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Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Embarrassingly Reaching 100 Episodes Somehow, Special Edition: "Back Then I Painted That"

September has arrived. Only four months left this year. Don't you feel like time accelerates once summer passes? ...Wait, just me?

Apparently this "Color Design Notes" is the 100th installment.

How did we get here without me noticing... With Yoshimatsu-san's "1000 episodes" and the editor-in-chief's "200 episodes" - such spectacular numbers dancing around Anime Style lately - my series' "100 episodes" represents 100 episodes of constantly dropping manuscripts, so it's just embarrassing. That they've published the rambling writings of a mere color staff member for 100 episodes - I'm newly grateful to the editorial staff.

Still, apparently some people are reading this series, occasionally getting comments like "I'm reading your series!" which makes me quite sheepish. Particularly some quite young industry colleagues are reading it, making me wonder how these "old stories" feel to such people.

Honestly, there's nothing particularly educational - I'm just trying to record what I've done before my memory becomes unreliable with age. So I hope to continue rambling... sometimes dropping manuscripts (...oops), as long as I'm allowed to write.

Now then.

People started saying "What will you write for the 100th episode?" I wasn't particularly conscious of "100 episodes," but thinking maybe there's something for the occasion... hmm, honestly no timely topics, or stories that are interesting but can't be written due to my position (laughs).

So I'm digging up old stories again. Titled "Back Then I Painted That."

Before I started color direction work at Toei Animation (■■■■■■■■■■, formerly Toei Doga), I did coloring work at a finishing production company in Ikebukuro called Kozue Anime Co., Ltd. I wrote about this long ago. I painted cuts from many different works there. While that production company's main work centered on Toei works, we also received lots of jobs from other production companies, including coloring jobs secretly taken without company knowledge. Today I'll share some stories from those coloring days.

First, the theatrical

Dr. Slump: Arale-chan - Hoyoyo! The Secret Treasure of Nanaba Castle

.

Released in 1984, this was a Toei Doga work. A

Dr. Slump

work for Toei Manga Festival during the series' big hit period. Among several

Arale-chan

movies made then, this was the masterpiece for story, direction, animation, and color. Color direction was by Fujioka Masako-san. I'd later become her colleague, and she did remarkably detailed, excellent work. I was quite envious. This work might have been what triggered my departure from Kozue Anime. Such a work.

I was post-serious illness then, no longer able to do intensive coloring like before, mainly doing finishing management at Kozue Anime. Getting involved in this

Nanaba Castle

finishing, I could feel my body heating up - such a work. So I didn't do much coloring myself, but it's a very important title.

Earth Story: Telepasii 2500

.

Summer 1984 theatrical release. Recently touched upon in "Anime-sama 365 Days." Ah, what a nostalgic title (laughs).

I remember this being produced with quite a relaxed schedule. So with a long schedule, I took on quite a few cuts.

This was a Tatsunoko (■■■■) work, yet color direction and paints were STAC. According to what Kozue Anime's president told me then, the finishing person in charge (?) said "STAC has more stable colors and easier retake processing!" and pushed through with STAC for this work. Well, I don't know how much was true, but since it used STAC paints that we were accustomed to, it was very easy for us.

There were

Earth Story

exclusive L-number and T-number paints - quite a range of subdued colors. Especially skin tone variations.

Around then, Sanrio works also used unique exclusive paints (three letters + three numbers like AKB-003!). As a paint-loving person, I was simply delighted facing lots of different numbered paint bottles (laughs).

Inspired by "Anime-sama 365 Days," I actually bought a used video on Amazon and watched the main episode for the first time. ...Ah, so that's what kind of story it was. Somewhat subtle (laughs). But I could feel the "mood" of anime from that era.

Giant Gorg

.

Broadcast in 1984, but production was well underway by 1983.

I was secretly doing personal part-time coloring for this without company knowledge (burst). How did that happen? I think a "doesn't anyone personally help with coloring?" type request reached me. Sunrise works that Kozue rarely took, plus a robot show. And most importantly, Yasuhiko Yoshikazu's new anime! This I absolutely had to do. So I secretly took it (laughs).

Even so, personal coloring jobs are limited in volume and cuts, but it was incredibly fresh. Content and schedule were tough, but I worked quite hard at it. How I painted "secretly": coming to the studio on days off "secretly," or late nights, all-nighters "secretly" (laughs).

Color direction instructions had human characters mostly shadowless coloring. Only close-ups got shadow coloring. Shadows were properly drawn in the in-betweens. But shadows were ignored for shadowless coloring. Somewhat ambiguous for my "coloring heart" but unavoidable. In return, mechanical elements were solid: normal/shadow 1/shadow 2/BL shadow plus highlights.

Most difficult was coloring Gorg itself. While it didn't have many colors, almost any size got normal/shadow 1/shadow 2/BL shadow plus highlights. And this guy walks. Doesn't run. Many, many sheets of slow walking in-betweens meant high frame counts (laughs). Super finishing-killer.

What impressed me then was the "night color conversion chart." "For night scenes, replace normal-specified paint numbers using this 'conversion chart.'" Converting with this, amazingly everyone became bluish night colors! It was incredibly fresh. Toei works never had such things. ...But this was incredibly troublesome (laughs).

Oh yes, the unit price was incredibly low for the content (laughs).

Then

Miyuki

.

Around 1983. The TV series of that

Miyuki

by Adachi Mitsuru. The ending theme "Omoide ga Ippai" became a hit, making the work famous.

There was Kitty Film Mitaka Studio near Mitakadai Station on the Keio Inokashira Line, handling what I think was their only TV series. I remember Kozue Anime and Suzuki Doga Kikaku (a giant finishing company in Chiba, Ichihara(?)) took on most of this series' finishing. I think we did most finishing except gross production episodes.

I loved this

Miyuki

's color direction - within limited colors, it was well-assembled in pastels with clothing coordination that made me excited whenever new color direction arrived each episode. Ah, maybe I'm influenced by

Miyuki

's colors? I feel that way somehow.

Watching the work now, it's quite subtle overall (laughs), but then I really loved it and worked with deep attachment.

Writing this reminds me - among the production managers then was a young, beautiful manager K-san, and I, a secret fan, looked forward nightly to her bringing cuts to the studio. Memories from when I was 20 (laughs).

Later, through

Miyuki

connections, I helped with Kitty Film Mitaka Studio's video work

Karuizawa Syndrome

(original by Tagami Yoshihisa). ...Though just helping with finishing retake processing. I was locked up about two full days at their Mure studio, helping with considerable finishing corrections.

Googling my name "Tsujita Kunio" always brings up this

Karuizawa Syndrome

. Yes, it was unpaid work with the condition of appearing in ending credits (burst).

Was I already at Toei Doga then? (laughs)

These works are all important to me - I actually still have their color direction sheets preserved at my parents' house (laughs). Including experiences, these color direction sheets are all my little treasures.

■ Continued in Episode 101

(09.09.01)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 101: Autumn New Program Introduction! Special Edition - Please Support

Ghost Stories Restaurant

!

Last Sunday I returned to my parents' house in Sayama City and did quite a bit of searching through my room's storage. And wow, various things came out.

First, cel artwork. Lots of

Dragon Ball Z

,

Fist of the North Star

,

Saint Seiya

and other cel artwork I got from staff during my Toei days. Particularly

Saint Seiya

- cel artwork from the theatrical

The Heated Battle of the Gods

appeared. Including Midgard cel artwork. All with backgrounds of course.

These are quite precious. ...Well, all the others are precious too (sweat). These

Heated Battle of the Gods

cels are ones I quite liked and got as mementos.

Oh yes, the TV series

Miyuki

I spoke passionately about last time - miraculously one cel from this also appeared. Ah, I had this! I was surprised (laughs).

Various works' color direction sheets also appeared. Starting with TV series

Miyuki

, then

Twin Hawks

,

Genma Wars

,

Space Battleship Yamato Final

,

Dairugger XV

and others. Plus

Urusei Yatsura: Beautiful Dreamer

.

This

Beautiful Dreamer

had "Remember Dream" on the color direction cover, making me remember "ah right, the title changed when it was released."

Just digging a bit yielded quite good results (laughs). Still,

Earth Story

and

Giant Gorg

color direction sheets didn't appear, so they're probably buried somewhere else in other shelves. So I'm thinking of returning for more "excavation" soon.

Now then.

For the 101st installment, let's go with a new development! ...Actually, let me take another beat here. Yes, a bit of promotion for programs I'm participating in (laughs).

The notable new TV anime from Toei Animation this fall would be

Mononoke

director Nakamura Kenji's work

Kuchu Buranko

, but somewhat hidden behind that (laughs), another TV series begins.

Ghost Stories Restaurant

(■■■■■■■■■) airing on TV Asahi network from October.

The original is the children's literature book series of the same name

Ghost Stories Restaurant

(supervising editor: Matsutani Miyoko / illustrations: Takai Kazuyoshi, Kato Kumiko). An omnibus ghost story series for elementary and middle school students collecting Japanese folk tales, legends, and world ghost stories - this series has an amazing 50 volumes of popular novels.

Now Toei Animation is adapting this into anime. Series director Ikeda Yoko and series composer Yonemura Shoji - the

Negibouzu no Asataro

team. Character design by Studio Dub's Takahashi Akira, art design by Watanabe Yoshito. I'm handling main character color design and main visual coordination. Following the

Hataraki Kids Maiham-gumi

pattern. The effective color design called "color direction" is handled by Toyonaga-san. Other staff also have basically the entire

Negibouzu

crew handling it.

The story develops in omnibus format centered on three elementary students: Ako, Sho, and Reiko. Each week in restaurant format, we deliver three stories: "appetizer," "main course," and "dessert."

Ghost Stories Restaurant

has 24-station nationwide network, and moreover, every Tuesday night at 7:30 PM - a so-called "golden time" slot!

Recently we properly did "purification" prayers for the program's hit and, since it has "ghost stories" in the title, staff safety. Now we're all set, except for the schedule... (laughs).

So please favor

Ghost Stories Restaurant

among this fall's anime.

■ Continued in Episode 102

(09.09.08)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 102: Once Upon a Time... (62) - About Gyopi-chan and Cow-san in Goldfish Warning!

Recently, the book I ordered by Kamimura Sachiko-san, "Encyclopedia of Animation Basics," arrived. I've been flipping through and reading (or rather, looking at) it during work breaks, and even familiar terms and various systems I use daily feel somehow fresh when compiled in a book like this. Moreover, facts like "huh? That's how it was? (sweat)" are revealed (laughs). Anyway, it's really well compiled and wonderful. Highly recommended.

Lately, except for magazines, I order almost all books through Amazon. I ordered this book on Amazon too and had it delivered to my home by courier. However, Amazon's courier packaging is mysterious. For example, this book is quite substantial so I wouldn't be surprised if it came in a "box," but they'll send even one DVD (not a DVD-BOX) in a "box," yet sometimes the same single DVD comes in simple cardboard envelope packaging delivered by mail service to the mailbox. What are the packaging & shipping criteria here? > Amazon

Personally, for single DVDs or books, I'm fine with simple packaging using mail service. Receiving courier deliveries is quite troublesome. You have to be home at the designated time. Previously when I was at Toei Animation, I had things sent to the studio, but now that's not possible...

Well, besides mail service handling, the accumulating "boxes" are quite stressful these days.

Now then.

Around 1992-93 when I was making

Coo: Far From Home

, I was approaching the milestone of turning 30. Looking at my work chronology, in 1992 while working on gradually starting

COO

, I was handling multiple parallel works including theatrical works for Toei Manga Festival (

Dragon Ball Z

etc.) and Toei Video OVAs (

Crying Freeman

etc.). But in 1993 when

COO

production reached its climax, I seem to have focused on

COO

.

Previously, while holding theatrical and OVA works, I also maintained one TV series line, creating main character colors and color direction sheets, deciding finishing conventions throughout the work, plus opening and ending color direction, episode 1 color direction.

But this became increasingly difficult due to theatrical work scheduling, and my involvement with TV series from

Saint Seiya

,

Akuma-kun

,

Moretsu Ataro

ended with

Goldfish Warning!

(■■■■■■■■■■) starting January 1991.

Huh? I haven't written about

Goldfish Warning!

have I? (sweat) Well, briefly...

Goldfish Warning!

was an anime adaptation of Nekobe Neko's manga of the same name, broadcast on ANB network from January 1991. In Kanto it aired Saturday nights at 7 PM. Main staff included character designer Iriyoshi Satoru, art designer Mukuo Takashi, and series director Sato Jun'ichi.

Incidentally, this staff room included Ikuhara Kunihiro who made his directorial debut on the previous work

Moretsu Ataro

, plus assistant directors Igarashi Takuya and Uda Konosuke. Looking back, it was an incredibly luxurious lineup (laughs).

I probably wrote this before, but even when assigned TV series then, I was only allowed "startup" participation. So I handled main character color design, several screen processing and screen effects foundations, opening and ending, plus episode 1 main story color direction.

This system was honestly quite stressful from around then. I wanted to be involved in main story work. While creating solid foundations through "startup" was important and I felt entrusted with that, TV series develop and grow interesting through accumulated episodes. So I couldn't participate at all once it became truly interesting. That was definitely stressful (grumble... well, similar treatment participation continues recently, causing super stress... grumble).

Goldfish Warning!

was particularly stressful because it was interesting from the very beginning!

But my feelings didn't reach anyone, and as usual it was only "startup" participation.

For

Goldfish Warning!

, I created character colors referencing the original work's covers and color pages, making everything generally light and bright. Above all,

Goldfish Warning!

was about the flying mysterious goldfish "Gyopi-chan" and the overwhelmingly present "Cow-san" (laughs).

In busy screens with lots of characters gathered, I aimed for balance where Cow-san's black would stand out distinctly. So Wapiko's sailor uniform and Shuichi's school uniform were made pale blue-purple tones.

There was much trial and error with Gyopi-chan's body pink color, finally using paint called PB-1a. But this paint was technically a special color forbidden for TV. Even so, I really wanted this color and pushed it through saying "he's the star after all!" (laughs).

This work did quite innovative things for gag expressions then. For example, the so-called "tornado run." When characters ran in gag mode, instead of properly drawing feet, we made spiral-shaped abbreviated animation. Hence "tornado." Though we didn't call it that on set - we called it "spinning run" or something like that.

Also, something we definitely did in the previous work

Moretsu Ataro

too - drawing main lines extremely thick as if boldly drawn with magic markers for "wave splash!" expressions.

Initially we created thick lines by drawing outlines from thick lines drawn during key animation, making animation during in-betweens so the inside could be painted, then painting the inside black during finishing. But I think it was Sato-san who brought the thick pen from Print Gocco (popular then for drawing New Year's cards) saying "couldn't this be used with finishing trace machines?" Since the principle is the same - transferring animation to cels via trace machines and creating Print Gocco design masters - we tried it and it worked perfectly (laughs). So afterward this animation processing became drawing with Print Gocco thick pens during in-betweens (laughs).

Furthermore, we prepared dot pattern (polka dot) book materials for backgrounds, placing them over characters for so-called "sweat drip" expression cuts. Come to think of it, drawing big "sweat" behind characters' heads and sliding it might have started with

Goldfish Warning!

...

Anyway,

Goldfish Warning!

was made while trying various things. That

Goldfish Warning!

also ended after one year. The program afterward was

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon

.

As written earlier, I didn't participate in

Sailor Moon

's "startup" either. Incidentally,

Sailor Moon

's startup was handled by Itasaka-san, then still at outsourced finishing production VAP. I felt somewhat frustrated (laughs), but was still curious so I went to peek at episode 1's staff preview. Got quite shocked (laughs).

A year and a half later, such

Sailor Moon

awaited me after

COO

ended. Ikuhara Kunihiro's directorial work

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R The Movie

.

■ Continued in Episode 103

(09.09.29)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 103: Once Upon a Time... (63) - Release Date Crisis!

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R The Movie

This week brought typhoons, but were everyone's towns and lives okay?

While I feel sorry for areas that suffered damage, I strangely get excited when typhoons approach.

When we were kids... ah, about 40 years ago... when we heard "typhoon," we'd check flashlight batteries preparing for power outages, and during long nights with shutters closed tight, we'd listen to typhoon information on TV and radio, getting excited by phrases like "it made landfall at XX!" as if describing monsters, our tension rising strangely at the sound of wind and rain raging outside, staying up late full of excitement.

How are today's children? Are they relatively cool about it?

I didn't stay up all night chasing typhoon information this time, but if I'd been up all night for work, I probably would have been glued to typhoon reports the whole time without getting bored (laughs).

Now then.

"The release date got moved up a week. So we have even less schedule. Please help!" This was production manager Higuchi-san's opening line to me.

Plus "Tsujita-kun, sorry, please help!" This was Ikuhara-san's opening line. September 1993.

Sudden developments (laughs).

The release date moved up one week was December 5th. Normally there's always a publisher-hosted preview one week before, meaning we had to deliver the complete package by late November 20th at the latest. Hahaha (laughs), exactly two months (laughs). We'd spent nearly two years on

COO

until then, so wow (laughs). Immediately hellish schedule progression.

Now, such theatrical

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R The Movie

, directed by Ikuhara Kunihiro who was also TV series chief director, animation director Tadano Kazuko, art director Taniguchi Jun'ichi. December 1993 release,

simultaneously screening with

Make Up! Sailor Senshi

(director: Kosaka Haruna) and

Tsuyoshi Shikkari Shinasai: Tsuyoshi no Time Machine de Shikkari Shinasai

(director: Misawa Shin, production: Studio Comet) - a three-film program. The "pillar" work was this

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R The Movie

.

As written before, I wasn't involved at all with TV series

Sailor Moon

or

Sailor Moon R

. So I was in exactly the same position as with

Dragon Ball Z

theatrical series, where I also wasn't involved with the TV version. "TV is TV, theatrical is theatrical."

I peeked at episode 1's staff preview, but afterward never watched broadcasts, so I was shaky on detailed story conventions, character relationships... or rather, even the main characters' names (laughs). But there was no time to rewatch TV versions now. So I participated in what you might call a "completely blank state."

First, as usual, I worked on adjusting main character color tones. Those "Sailor Senshi" costumes.

While "TV is TV, theatrical is theatrical," not changing character impressions from the TV version was essential, so I aimed not to mess with basic "normal colors." I changed "shadow colors" and "highlight" color tones for skin, hair, and clothing parts slightly to create overall contrast. I adjusted everything just a bit stronger than TV version color direction.

Around then, many works in the streets gave characters fairly deep shadow colors emphasizing contrast, but setting shadow colors too deep would break these characters' "dignified yet soft" impression, so the contrast was balanced to just appear clearly on theater screens.

Actually, looking at TV version color direction, shadow colors were set relatively shallow. Furthermore, many main episode cuts in the TV version were colored and

photographed "shadowless."

People who regularly watch TV come to see theatrical versions. So when TV viewers see this screen in theaters, if shadow animation appears somewhat clearly tightened, looking slightly upgraded - that would be OK! I thought of it that way. Same impression as TV, but a bit "theatrical-like" was the target.

Oh yes, these "Sailor Senshi" costumes are design-wise more like figure skating leotards than "sailor uniforms." Figure skating costumes with sailor collars and skirts added. So unlike real sailor uniforms, they're functional, easy to move in, and not sleazy.

"Takeuchi-san's (original creator) concept is really good," I remember Ikuhara-kun admiring.

■ Continued in Episode 104

(09.10.09)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 104: Captured by Pirates!!

Autumn has fully arrived, with mornings and evenings getting quite chilly. Simultaneously, extreme dryness... My nose and throat wake up parched and dry, and while I'm not catching a cold, I'm troubled by nasally wake-up voice...

That "new type" seems to be going around lately.

Fortunately, no one around me has been hit by the "new type," but it feels like something to be cautious about.

...As I write this, I'm still wearing just a T-shirt, but I need to be careful about health management.

Now then.

Today's Tokyo was blessed with wonderful clear weather after the typhoon, but I'm caught in a situation completely unrelated to such things.

Yes, I've been captured by pirates!

I'm imprisoned under a legendary pirate called "Golden Lion Shiki." The reason this series has been delayed these past 2-3 weeks is because I've actually been kidnapped and confined by pirates.

I can't say much in detail, but the Navy suffered tremendous damage before "Golden Lion Shiki's" "powers."

I can only wait for Luffy and the "Straw Hat Pirates" to come rescue me and defeat Shiki as soon as possible.

So I'll probably remain captured by pirates a while longer, please forgive me (tears).

Such theatrical

ONE PIECE FILM STRONG WORLD

opens December 12th! Please look forward to it!

■ Continued in Episode 105

(09.10.27)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 105: Escaping from the Pirates!!

Lately I've been eating "Cup Noodle" for late-night meals. Actually I don't really like cup noodles and rarely eat them unless it's really necessary, but "Cup Noodle" is different. I've been with it for 30 years now. Since middle school, late-night snacks meant "Cup Noodle." Still taking care of me now.

Particularly the standard "soy sauce" and "curry" are divine! I had curry last night too.

I suddenly remembered a boom way of eating from middle and high school: "dropping in a raw egg."

First, open the lid halfway and pour hot water slightly less, just covering the noodles. Drop one raw egg on top - plop! Then cover and steam. Instead of the usual 3 minutes, about 4 minutes. Then you have perfectly steamed "egg-topped Cup Noodle." This is exquisite not only with "soy sauce" but also "curry."

Ah, I haven't eaten it that way recently.

Does anyone else enjoy "Cup Noodle" like this? (laughs)

Now then.

As I wrote two weeks ago, I'm still "captured by pirates." Struggling to escape. Almost there.

In such "pirate movie" - theatrical

ONE PIECE FILM STRONG WORLD

- a fellow captive is assistant director K-san.

This time there's a character (the enemy boss) called "Golden Lion Pirate Shiki." K-san is assistant director so she often writes character names on cut bags and retake instruction sheets, but her writing of "Shiki" (■■■) always looks like "Tsuki" (■■■) (laughs).

It's her handwriting habit. "Shi" (■) and "Tsu" (■) - a common story, but as the crunch progresses, fatigue shows even in this young woman, and her handwriting reflects that exhaustion. "Shiki" that was "Tsuki" became even more disheveled and finally became "Shi-kan (sweat)" (laughs).

Fighting such battles, the theatrical

ONE PIECE FILM STRONG WORLD

we're working hard on opens next month, December 12th. Please look forward to it!

■ Continued in Episode 106

(09.11.10)

Color Design Notes [Tsuji Kunitada]

Episode 106: Somehow Escaped from the "Pirate Movie"!!

Last week, I went to Kyoto for a bit. I walked endlessly along the Kamogawa riverbank, going upstream from Shijo all the way to Shimogamo Shrine. It was still a little too early for the autumn leaves, but I thoroughly enjoyed weekday Kyoto and the Kamogawa River. More than anything, it was just the right kind of stimulation for my heart and body, which were completely exhausted from the "pirate movie," and made for a good change of pace.

Kyoto is really close, though.

It's only a little over two hours from Tokyo Station on the Nozomi! You leave Tokyo Station after 10 AM and arrive by noon—that's how close it is. You crack open a beer, feel good, doze off a bit, and before you know it, you're in Kyoto (laugh).

Come to think of it, the very first time I went to Kyoto was on a middle school field trip. I don't remember where we went or what we did anymore (oh wait, I do remember Nijo Castle and Kiyomizu Temple), but it was my first big trip, and I remember having this desperate feeling like I was heading out to some incredibly distant frontier.

Thirty years have passed since then. I often think I'd like to take my time and visit each of those various places I went to back then, one by one.

Unrelated to that, I'll probably be going to Kyoto again around next week (laugh). Oh, this time it's for location scouting.

Now then.

The "pirate movie"—

Strong World ONE PIECE FILM

—which had me trapped for so long, was finally completed last Wednesday. Preview screenings have already been held in various locations nationwide, and there are less than three weeks left until the nationwide release.

Today we finally have our staff preview screening. It's being held in the screening room at the Oizumi projection studio. Normally you'd hold the staff preview before the other screenings start, but well, sometimes these things happen (laugh).

And after the preview, naturally there's the celebration banquet. Actually, we've already had several small parties here and there, but the banquet after the staff preview is something different. It's the last banquet where all the people who worked on this film will gather together for this project.

So I'll probably get dragged away and end up drowning somewhere in Oizumi until morning.

So sorry! That's all for today again! I'll properly get back into the swing of things starting next week. Once the movie is released, I'd like to write about the "pirate movie" again.

And so,

Strong World ONE PIECE FILM

opens nationwide on December 12th. Please look forward to it!

■Continues to Episode 107

(09.11.24)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 107: Once Upon a Time... (64) Incredible Population Density! The Staff Room for

Sailor Moon R

Movie

Now that production on the "pirate movie" has ended, I thought peaceful days had finally arrived... but thanks to the schedule getting severely delayed, my work on other projects I'm involved with is completely backed up. Last week I actually had to pull all-nighters for three days straight. Ah, maybe being captured by pirates was easier (wry laugh).

To add insult to injury, one of my home computer's HDDs died, and I lost work-related data (sob). Most of the data was backed up so it was okay, but the work data for a certain new project that I'd been preparing for a meeting was completely wiped out! This happened on the morning of the meeting day. I was so shocked I couldn't even speak. Naturally that day's meeting was postponed. I'm really sorry for the trouble! > All concerned parties

Everyone, back up your data early and often! (cry)

I somehow managed to recreate that tragic color chart data from scratch, and had the rescheduled meeting the other day. Overall, I got the director's OK. This project starts broadcasting next year—I still can't write about it in detail, but please look forward to it as well.

Now then.

It might vary by production company and studio, but at Toei Animation (formerly Toei Doga), when a new project starts up, first a "staff room" gets set up.

The "staff room" is literally a room for staff. The director is at the center, along with key animation directors, assistant directors, production managers and other main staff who are gathered in one room, and the project revolves around that room. Whether it's a TV series or theatrical work, the scale varies, but anyway, first there's the staff room.

Incidentally at Toei Animation (■■■■■■■■■■), except for special cases, we color designers and color direction (■■■■) staff don't have desks in the staff room. Since it's basically company employees who handle this work, we participate in projects from our own departmental desks within the company. Art staff work from within the company or outsourced production houses. This system remains the same today.

Ideally, all the main staff should be gathered in the same room, and in today's digitized environment that's relatively easy to do, but back when we used cel paints, you couldn't exactly bring paints and such along with you, so it became somewhat customary to work separately.

So, the staff room for

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R

movie was set up on the second floor of Oizumi Studio's so-called "new building."

Actually, this staff room had a slightly different atmosphere from other projects' staff rooms.

This room constantly housed Director Ikuhara, Assistant Director Igarashi Takuya, and production managers (the key animation directors worked at their own affiliated studios), plus one more person: Production Manager Higuchi.

"Production manager" is a uniquely Toei credit, a position that combines the roles of production producer and production desk. Higuchi, who was probably the most capable production manager at Toei Animation at the time, was in charge of "steering" the production of this project that was sure to become quite challenging.

Since this project had virtually no schedule, Higuchi employed a certain strategy to ensure the key animation would be completed. That strategy was to gather key animators in the staff room.

Writing it like that, you might think "isn't that normal?" Well, it's a typical measure production takes when pushing to finish key animation, but actually, the room we were using as the staff room this time was a bit—or rather extremely—small.

A concrete building with not particularly high ceilings, only one door, a sealed space of about ten-some tatami mats. Normally, just putting in desks for the director, assistant director, and two production staff would fill it up completely, but they kept bringing in as many animation desks as they could fit.

Higuchi placed one office desk right in the middle of the room so he could survey the entire staff room at once, then arranged animation desks around it one after another. Not just along the walls—they filled every gap, and when there were no more gaps, they'd angle desks to create gaps and fit in as many animation desks as possible. The animation desks were naturally all the smallest in-between animation size.

And then, the key animators who kept getting gathered.

Once you sat down, you were packed so tightly you couldn't easily get up. At peak capacity, there were probably about 10 people including the director. This was probably the highest population density in Oizumi Studio history, hands down.

And they'd keep people at their desks until they finished what they had on hand. Higuchi glared from the middle of the room (laugh), creating this somewhat tense atmosphere. And the door was always firmly shut (laugh).

Every time I had questions or consultations for the director and showed up at the staff room, the density of people made it somewhat difficult to talk (laugh). Key animation tends toward night work now and then. It was truly a fortress that never sleeps like this. During the production period, the lights in this room never went out.

Then, one by one, people would leave the staff room as they finished their assigned portions. The key animators dragging their tired bodies but cheerfully saying "Good work!" as they departed were quite memorable (laugh).

That was the tension under which the key animation progressed. And that key animation would next make its way to me.

■Continues to Episode 108

(09.12.01)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 108: Once Upon a Time... (65) I Love Thinking About Girls' Clothing Colors!

Sailor Moon R

Movie

Monday through Tuesday this week, I went to Kyoto again (which is why I missed my Tuesday deadline (sweat)). Self-funded location scouting to mentally prepare for a certain new project. Well, the previous trip was similar (laugh). This time the director also asked me to shoot video materials for the main production, so I went and struggled with an unfamiliar movie camera.

Since this was an overnight trip, I was able to enjoy various delicious Kyoto foods. My goodness, Kyoto is delicious (laugh).

As I mentioned before, even though I went to Kyoto twice on school trips, when I think about it, I didn't really eat anything decent. Basically we'd return to the inn for meals and the whole grade would eat the inn's food all together. I'm sure Kyoto specialties were on the table too, but we were a group of kids starving for meat, so rather than savoring anything, it was all about quantity first!

Two nights with two dinners, one of which was sukiyaki. Back then, I think all I could think about was meat. On the high school trip, we'd collect meat that the girls didn't eat because they said "it'll make me fat" and eat it in our own hot pot. Some groups even stopped by butcher shops during free time and bought extra beef on their own (laugh).

Now, over thirty years later, I've finally reached an age where I can enjoy Kyoto cuisine in a proper adult manner.

And that "new project" has finally had its information released.

The Tatami Galaxy

(■■■■■■■■), please look forward to it!

And the "pirate movie,"

Strong World ONE PIECE FILM

, finally opens nationwide tomorrow! Everyone, thank you for waiting! ...Though I hear it's become quite a situation with the first and second days completely sold out for all showings (sweat). Everyone, do your best to go see it!

Now then.

Continuing the story of

Sailor Moon R

movie.

Around the time the key animation was making its way to me, we finalized the color schemes for the character cast. As with usual projects, I created color sample cels for the characters I was assigned, and all the main staff checked them together, exchanging opinions to make the final decisions.

This time, we had Director Ikuhara, Assistant Director Igarashi, Art Director Taniguchi Junichi, and myself—a group of relatively similar ages. Oh, Producer Azuma was also the same age as me. This group gathered to check the color samples. I believe Key Animation Director Tadano wasn't present at this time? I remember that we made certain decisions among ourselves and then showed them to him later for approval... but wait? Was that different? (←My memory is quite vague here (sweat))

Though I'd just finished

Coo: Far From Home

, a major theatrical work, it had been quite a while since I'd done a movie adaptation of a TV series, especially a hit one. Not since

Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth

(■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■■), I think? So I was putting in extra effort (laugh).

Since it was based on a hit TV series, naturally the audience coming to see it would be people who watched the TV show. Plus since this was the first movie adaptation, there were "first movie constraints," so we basically didn't make major color changes from the TV version. Oh, I've written about this before.

At the time, quite a lot of high-contrast works were popular and trending. In fact, stronger shadows do make the screen more impressive when projected in theaters. But honestly, I wasn't really fond of things getting too harsh.

Sure, battle scenes should be sharp and cool, and scenes with clear light sources or scenes where you want to leave a strong, impressive image should use fairly strong contrast to build the screen, but for other scenes, I thought a softer feel would be better. I believe I discussed this various ways with the director and convinced (?) him (laugh).

So I tweaked the shadow colors of the main costumes (Sailor Warriors) just a little, just a tiny bit. In exchange, I kept the casual clothes scenes—the normal, gentle scenes—at basically the same balance as the TV version.

And these casual clothes—thinking about their colors is so much fun! After all, in Saint Seiya

I created various Saint colors, but the only girl was Saori-san in her same outfit all the time, and the theatrical work I'd been doing right before this had characters running on the beach in shorts and T-shirts (laugh). Working on the color coordination for fashionable, slightly realistic girls' clothing that seemed trendy at the time was such enjoyable, delightful work (laugh).

For each character's casual outfit designs, I thought about their individual personalities and created about two different combination sets—one harder, one softer—to show them. With just minor adjustments, they got approval quite smoothly.

For the enemy character Fiore, Director Ikuhara had a solid image in mind, so I remember creating the initial color scheme fairly in line with the director's vision. Wait? Was there a TV story this was based on first? Or did the TV episode come from this? (←My memory is quite vague here too (sweat))

Incidentally, the "first movie constraints" were unwritten Toei rules when adapting TV series into movies—things like using the TV series opening as-is for the first movie adaptation, among several such unwritten "rules." They don't say such things much anymore recently. Actually, since the "manga festival" format disappeared in recent years, TV series movie adaptations themselves have decreased.

But

Sailor Moon R

movie didn't use the TV opening. They used the opening theme song, but the background was footage from the theatrical version. I think Director Ikuhara wouldn't compromise on this point (←this memory is also vague).

■Continues to Episode 109

(09.12.11)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 109: Once Upon a Time... (66)

Sailor Moon R

Movie

...Oh, and About

Space Battleship Yamato: Resurrection

Last weekend saw the nationwide release of

Strong World ONE PIECE FILM

, which turned into a situation far beyond our wildest imagination. From the first showings in the morning to the late-night screenings on opening day and the second day, theaters across the country were completely sold out. Seeing footage of the long lines of customers surrounding theaters who came to watch—wow, what a surprise. I knew advance ticket sales were incredible, so I personally expected "there'll probably be some lines," but I honestly hadn't imagined it would reach this scale.

From what I hear, the box office revenue for the three days from opening exceeded 1.3 billion yen. Hmm... such an incredible amount that I don't know how to react (sweat).

By the way, this day was also the opening day for

Space Battleship Yamato: Resurrection

.

I was once a middle schooler who camped out overnight in front of a Shinjuku theater for the opening day of

Farewell Space Battleship Yamato—Warriors of Love

. And today, a project I was involved with has long lines at theaters. Moreover, this huge success competing with

Yamato

on its opening day. There's something I can't quite put into words about how that feels.

Well, we on the

Strong World

staff are fully aware that so many people flocked to see it because of the comic "Volume 0" admission gift. Even so, having this many people watch the work we worked so hard to create is truly a happy thing. Thank you so much, everyone!

The release is just getting started. For those who haven't seen it yet, and for those who'll come to see it a second and third time, please take your time and enjoy the main feature.

Now then, yesterday during a work break I slipped out and went to see

Space Battleship Yamato: Resurrection

.

You see, for me, my anime roots are

Space Battleship Yamato

(■■■■■■■■■■), which I was obsessed with in elementary school. So I was extremely curious about this

Resurrection

. Plus it opened on the same day as the theatrical

ONE PIECE

I was involved with! So I wanted to see it as soon as possible.

Wow, it was fantastic! Honestly, it gave me goosebumps!

Resurrection

was completely and utterly

Yamato

itself! This is incredibly amazing.

There are many anime in the world where sequels are made after a long time has passed since the previous work. It's common to bring contemporary "modern" elements and tastes into sequels. Some works succeed by skillfully digesting and fusing these elements, but more often than not, things tend to go wrong, and they get criticized as failures or questionable. That's not uncommon.

But this

Resurrection

stayed completely true without wavering—it was

Yamato

itself through and through! The Yamato ship itself and all the mechs and battles became CG, the characters aged, and quite a few "new faces" were added, but the world and goals there were completely and utterly

Yamato

itself! This is amazing. It showed us "the Yamato we know" itself.

Throughout the entire film, the mechanics and battle scenes centered around the CG-rendered Yamato—I was a bit wary of potential awkwardness before watching, but once the story began, I felt a reassuring familiarity as if I'd known it forever, a natural, settled texture on screen.

What I personally call "Yamato methodology"—how characters are presented, how battle screens and cuts are built up, getting the exact shot you want at the moment you want it, music sliding in at just the right time. Ah, this sensation is Yamato, I thought. They properly followed that flow in creating this. Watching this made me truly happy.

In

Resurrection

, what's truly eye-catching is the visual upgrade and its overwhelming power. The beautifully reborn CG Yamato. It probably shows us the form we'd been expanding in our heads all those years ago when we took the hand-drawn Yamato and imagined it freely, making me think "Yes, yes, this is it!" rather than feeling any awkwardness. It's that kind of upgrade.

The texture in close-up shots is impressive, but the presence in wide shots is incredible. While the hand-drawn original works had some disappointing animation in wide shots, this CG version doesn't suffer from character model collapse.

And the characters! Kodai has aged and become more dashing, and most of the characters are new. Each one has great individual flavor. Those characters were all Kogawa-san! throughout. They were charming characters that felt nostalgic while being properly new.

The art was amazing too! And the color work was wonderful!

When mechanics and art become more realistic and the acting gets deeper, the character colors naturally tend to get pulled along and become overly realistic. You see this in various anime where they do scene-by-scene color changes too deeply and end up leaving the viewers behind.

But in this

Resurrection

, the balance—that sense of proportion to avoid "going too far"—was excellent. The scene-by-scene crafting, the psychological expression through cut-by-cut color building, including the photography processing, all had this exquisite "properly done but not overdone" feeling. They pushed forward and expanded new visuals from the previous

Yamato

works here too, which was admirable. As a fellow professional, I was actually envious.

Also, the story beginning and progressing without explaining anything from before felt refreshing (laugh). People who've followed

Yamato

will appreciate this approach. After all, there's the feeling that "we don't need every little thing we already know explained to us."

So it's honestly unfriendly to people encountering

Yamato

for the first time through this movie (wry laugh), but I'd rather tell such people: "Please rent and watch the theatrical

Yamato

and

Final Yamato

on DVD first!"

That's how I'd like people to enjoy and get hooked on

Space Battleship Yamato: Resurrection

. I want people to see

ONE PIECE

, but I want everyone to see this too!

Now then.

...Oh.

I wrote too much "introduction" (sweat). You've all noticed, right? (laugh) ...Which means,

Sailor Moon R

movie continues next time...

■Continues to Episode 110

(09.12.15)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 10: Special Episode... I'm in Seoul

Since yesterday (Monday), I've been in Seoul, Korea.

For meetings regarding the work I'm currently participating in,

Taichi Senjimon (■■■■■)

.

This work is a TV series for Korean broadcast, where the Japanese side (Toei Animation) handles everything from scenarios to storyboards and character/art designs, while Korean production companies handle the actual animation production work.

Yes, it's "collaborative work."

Based on the setting materials we Japanese staff created, the Korean side cooks and expands everything to complete it for broadcast.

First, broadcast in Korea is scheduled to start in April, and production is already well underway.

This meeting is for various confirmations and considerations of questions and requests from each part - direction, animation, etc.

The group includes producer, director, character designer, mecha designer, and others - 8 people total.

Until tomorrow (Wednesday), it'll be quite a dense Seoul stay.

Our group that arrived in Seoul at noon immediately went to the production site after lunch with the production company people who came to meet us.

The location is in a newly developed district in one corner of Seoul city.

Many glass-walled high-rise office buildings stand in rows. Many Korean animation production companies have gathered in this district, all located in these high-rise office buildings. Man, it's completely different from Japan (laughs).

But once you step into the studio, it's still an anime production site.

Mountains of piled cut bags, posters on walls, staff working at desks and monitors, and staff napping on folding beds nearby. Ah, it's the same (laughs).

After a general tour, Korean and Japanese staff gathered in a meeting room to start discussions.

We had passionate meetings for nearly 5 hours, far exceeding the originally planned time. After all, communication between staff is fundamental to anime production. It's fun meeting and talking with site staff. I was considering giving up this business trip because of all the difficult work I'm carrying, but man, I'm glad I came!

Today, the second day, after observing the dubbing site, we returned to the studio for more meetings.

This *Taichi Senjimon* broadcast in Japan is still undecided, but I hope broadcast in Japan gets decided soon.

So sorry, this time was such a Seoul business trip diary (sweat).

##

■Continues to Episode 11

(07.03.13)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 110: Once Upon a Time... (66)

Sailor Moon R

Movie: The Secret of Moon Revenge

Today (December 22nd) is this year's winter solstice. Even Tokyo, which they say gets warmer each year due to global warming and other factors, has felt properly "winter-like!" these past few days. The nighttime and early morning chill has become quite formidable.

With less than 10 days left in this year, how is everyone spending their time?

Last weekend, I finally managed to make it to the theater myself—for

Strong World ONE PIECE FILM

. I've already watched the main feature more times than I care to count during production, but I couldn't very well send my wife to the movie theater alone when she wanted to go, plus I wanted to confirm how the color corrections I'd requested from the lab during the final preview screening turned out in the print. But more than anything, I wanted to watch it surrounded by lots of customers and feel their reactions.

So Saturday night, I went to Marunouchi Toei in Tokyo's Ginza. Right below Toei's head office. By the way, I always wonder why this theater is called "Marunouchi Toei" when it's in Ginza.

While it wasn't quite the frenzy of opening day last week, thanks to everyone, it was still bustling even a week later. As of last weekend, Marunouchi Toei was still distributing actual copies of the "Volume Zero" comic, and the pamphlets that were selling out everywhere were properly on sale. As expected from being right under the head office! So I impulsively bought one myself (laugh).

That theater pamphlet uses quite a lot of color samples and is quite luxurious, and most of those are color samples that I colored myself during the color decision process.

Well, when stuff you painted yourself is obviously featured like that, it's happy on one hand, but somehow makes you break out in a weird sweat (laugh). Is it embarrassing? Ah, that's not quite it either. Well, actually some incorrectly painted color sample data made it in there too, so that part is embarrassing (wry laugh).

Having done this kind of work for many years, I should be used to such things, but this time the "exposure" across various fronts is exceptionally high, and

encountering it in so many different places might be making it feel extra strange.

Strong World ONE PIECE FILM

will still be playing into the new year, so those who couldn't make it by year's end, GO during New Year's!

Now then.

I apologize for the extremely scattered pace, but continuing the

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R

movie story. I think you've all probably noticed by now that my pen isn't making much progress (explosion). To be honest, my memories of producing

Sailor Moon R

movie are quite vague.

It's probably because we rushed through such a short schedule at the time? Like the memories passed by before they could solidify. Hmm. There just wasn't any schedule. The things I mentioned earlier, like the staff room story—I remember the early period quite clearly, but the roughly one month from when work started coming to me until completion was truly a torrential state of affairs. So it's super vague.

At the time we were still in the analog era, of course. We painted on cels with paints, finished them, and shot on film. Key animation reaches me → color direction on key animation → in-between animation & painting work → cels painted in about 5 days → cel inspection & photography → rushes check. Every day was this repetition. That kind of month. In that flow, that it turned out reasonably well was probably because, even with no time, we properly did the decision-making work and got director approval—I think that's the process we followed, but I don't really remember!

Well, most scenes could go with so-called "normal" colors... oh right, come to think of it, there were only a few key scenes where we properly did color checks—like the rooftop evening scene, the hospital room in the flashback image, stuff like that (sweat).

In today's digital painting era, for example, even if cuts don't have properly finalized color direction, you can send them to key animation and finishing (■■■■) anyway, have the painting proceed with "normal" or "dummy colors," then after they're painted, place them on backgrounds to decide colors and repaint the digital painting data before sending to photography (actually, we make things quite routinely in that manner). But in the cel finishing era, naturally such repainting was impossible.

And so, "color direction is reflexes" became increasingly the case. We'd do some degree of scene-by-scene decisions, then "instinctively" apply color direction to key animation on the spot. And truly, "color direction is reflexes"—this is one of my theories.

Whether it's key animation or in-between animation, when cuts come around for color direction, you face them for serious combat. When amazing key animation comes around, you get goosebumps and think "Alright!" and fight it, and when bad animation comes around, you curse at that key animation (not the key animator, but the key animation itself) thoroughly, then decide whether to send it back to the assistant director for animation retake, or proceed as-is and fix it somehow after colors are applied—this too is decided through color direction. Handling such things quickly while fully visualizing the final painted result for color direction.

That's why I can't quit color direction. Design alone isn't satisfying (laugh). ...Ah, I'm getting a bit off track (wry laugh).

Anyway, it was definitely a month of fighting with wonderful key animation.

The color story for the story's climax, the Silver Crystal scene. Those who've seen it might remember—the scene where the famous song "Moon Revenge" plays, Sailor Moon appears in a white dress, everyone's flashback images overlap, everyone's power combines, and the Silver Crystal reaches maximum power. For this scene, Director Ikuhara and I actually had a difference of opinion.

For Sailor Moon and the others in the light, I finished them with a stronger high-contrast "normal-style" color scheme—a step up from previous scenes—but the director's image was different. He wanted that scene to have the characters overall bathed more in pink light, a so-called "pink tone" strong high contrast. So after the rushes came up—or was it during the shoot preparation (the work of combining backgrounds and cels before sending to photography to add photography instructions)—we had a disagreement. Well, Director Ikuhara said, "This is a bit different from what I was thinking."

Actually, I wasn't entirely unaware of Director Ikuhara's intent, but I was concerned that if I made the cel colors pink-toned in pink light, the characters would blend too much with the light color and I wouldn't be able to effectively utilize their expressions. So I deliberately finished them with "normal-style" strong contrast colors without shifting toward pink.

Director Ikuhara pondered and groaned for a while, but we decided to shoot with the cel colors I'd created for now. "If we watch it and still think 'this is wrong,' then we'll retake, okay?" Director Ikuhara said. There certainly wasn't much time left, and honestly, it was a photography-intensive scene. Actually, retake reshoots are something you don't want to do unless absolutely necessary. Even while saying that, perhaps the director had already decided at that moment to go with the colors

I'd produced no matter what.

When we watched the rushes later, we ultimately didn't retake and let me push through the climax with my approach.

And so,

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R

movie was somehow completed two weeks before its public release. However, the "price" of the torrential schedule remained as "rough spots" scattered throughout the screen. So Director Ikuhara, at the wrap party after the staff preview, directly appealed to President Tomari (current advisor): "This movie will definitely be a hit, so please let us do additional retakes for the laserdisc & video version!" The theatrical release couldn't be helped, but he wanted to do something about the LD & video version that would remain for posterity. And well, amazingly, he got President Tomari's "OK!" (wry laugh).

And, well, naturally there was some friction with the production department (wry laugh), but thus several of the really disappointing cuts from the theatrical release version were corrected and became the DVD version we can watch today.

Oh right, writing this reminded me—there was an old single-seat sofa in the staff room back then. I secretly called that sofa the "king's chair," and that imitation leather sofa was wonderfully soft and was the perfect item for sleeping.

And it was always a competition between me and Assistant Director Igarashi for that sofa. If the sofa was free, we'd nap there. If it was occupied, we'd go home to sleep (explosion). It seems somewhat backwards, but that's how much we wanted to stay at the studio working—I think our focus was that concentrated on the project.

This

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R

movie, thanks to everyone, became a big hit. And receiving this big hit,

Sailor Moon

theatrical versions would continue to be made the following year and the year after that.

■Continues to Episode 111

(09.12.22)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 111: New Year Special Edition -

Strong World ONE PIECE FILM

Notes (Part 1)

Happy New Year!

How did everyone spend their New Year's?

As for me, I wrapped up work quickly on the 26th and enjoyed my first completely work-free New Year's in years.

Actually, the editorial department asked me to participate in the usual "New Year's cards from familiar faces" again this year, but sorry! I completely blew it off (sweat). Actually, this year I completely gave up on New Year's cards altogether.

Having abandoned even New Year's cards for a relaxing New Year's, well, thanks to that, I became a bigger person! (Mass-wise, that is... (sob))

Now then.

Strong World ONE PIECE FILM

, which was released last month, became a big hit thanks to everyone. I don't know the detailed numbers, but anyway, lots of customers came to theaters and watched it.

As I wrote before, we staff are well aware that the initial momentum of this big hit was due to the effect of the comic "Volume 0" admission gift, but even if that was the trigger, having so many people watch the work we created and sent out is above all a joyful thing.

So this time, these are my "

Strong World

notes." I really need to write this down somewhere before I forget.

*

At the end of March last year (I wrote April in the theater pamphlet, but it seems it was actually late March), when the cherry blossoms were in full bloom, the main theatrical staff including the director visited Oda Eiichiro-sensei's workplace somewhere in Tokyo. Of course, this was my first time meeting sensei. I was quite nervous (wry laugh).

The thing is, I joined the theatrical

ONE PIECE

at Director Sakai's request, but actually, I had never read

ONE PIECE

before!!

I'd only caught a glimpse of the TV anime on a restaurant TV while eating
sometime, and when my wife and I went to see

CLANNAD

movie, I saw a One Piece movie trailer and was super shocked to learn for the first time that Chopper was a reindeer! Despite being in this industry and having worked at Toei Animation (■■■■■■■■■■) until last year, I was an extremely rare person who knew absolutely nothing about

ONE PIECE

at this stage. So naturally I was nervous facing the original creator himself (wry laugh).

Oda-san quietly spoke to us staff about various aspects of this project. From the situation surrounding

ONE PIECE

, particularly the theatrical versions, to his own feelings about theatrical adaptations. After that, we staff and Oda-san exchanged opinions about content questions and concerns. During this, the director introduced me and I spoke a bit about "color."

"Actually, I've never encountered the work

ONE PIECE

before..." I started honestly (laugh). "Are there any points about 'color' you'd like me to pay attention to, or any requests?" I asked.

"No, please feel completely free. Just 'excitement.' I want a feeling that's exciting above all," Oda-san said. That became one of my starting points.

By the time I joined the project, character concept sketches from Oda-san were mostly complete, and Character Designer & Chief Animation Director Sato was organizing and cleaning them up for animation. We scanned those, and then—colors. First, the base colors for main and regular characters' skin, hair, eyes, etc.

For

GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!

movie that I'd worked on the previous year, the basic direction was "don't stray too far from the TV series" and "upgrade for theatrical work while maintaining the TV impression," so I modified the TV series color base to look good on screen. But in addition to what Oda-san had told us, Director Sakai also said "Please do it the way you think best, Tsujita-san!" So I decided to think about it from a completely clean slate. In this situation, not knowing

ONE PIECE

was actually a strength (laugh).

So I deliberately didn't use the existing TV series or previous theatrical versions' color direction (■■■■) as reference or foundation. That said, since it was an "original work adaptation," I couldn't completely ignore the original and do whatever I wanted, so I bought the three available color illustration collections by Oda-san (←out of my own pocket (laugh)) and decided to try my hand at it using those colors as reference.

The color illustration collection "COLOR WALK"—this was great! The exciting three-dimensionality and dynamism that manga characters gain by having "color."

While flipping through that color illustration collection, I remembered Director Sakai's words: "I think it would be good if it came together with colors that feel 'transparent.'" Ah, I see. So this is what the director wants. Watercolor-touch colors that feel clear, but with solid presence. Could we somehow achieve this unique atmosphere on screen? That's what I thought about.

While thinking about such things, I built up the main characters' base colors. I lined up faces of all nine people (yes, nine people!) on screen, adjusting balance by making this one darker or that one lighter, repeating fine adjustments to aim for that color illustration collection's atmosphere. First I balanced Luffy and Nami, then placed the other members' colors. As a result of being conscious of the color illustrations' transparency, first Luffy's skin became brighter than previous anime versions. With that balance, Zoro and Robin also ended up with considerably brighter skin tones. Oh, Brook and Chopper didn't change much as a result (laugh).

I showed the completed main characters to Director Sakai and the assistant directors for now. How would these color balance look to people who had become familiar with these characters through the TV series? I was primarily curious about their impressions.

"Hmm!" said Director Sakai. "Could you make Nami's hair color a bit darker?" Plus some other small requests about everyone's eye colors. "Well, let's go with this for

now," and so the base colors were tentatively decided.

With base colors decided, next was creating colors for Luffy and the others' costumes this time, plus the other main character—the enemy characters like Golden Lion Shiki. I made them in sets like "adventure outfit set," "shipboard outfit set," "raid suit set," and "Shiki set." With all of Luffy's group being nine people, it was quite challenging.

First, I created "adventure outfits" and "shipboard outfits" with colors I'd conceived myself. Plus Shiki and the others. Similarly, I showed these to the directors and exchanged opinions. Then it was time to show them to Oda-san.

Oda-san is extremely busy. Ideally we'd have had him come to the studio to see them directly and exchange various feedback, but "that's absolutely impossible! Impossible! Impossible!" So we decided to arrange the finalized character color samples by set in comparison charts on single sheets, print them out, send them to Oda-san, and get his response.

Computer monitors and printed paper naturally have completely different color reproduction. So I corrected the image colors for printing to print in colors close to how they looked on the monitor screen, and used slightly better paper to create an "Oda-san check print set" to send to him. Now, how would Oda-sensei's feedback turn out?

After waiting several days, the long-awaited response from Oda-sensei came back. But...

■Continues to Episode 112

(10.01.05)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 112: New Year Special Edition -

STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM

Notes (Middle Part... Actually Part 1 Part 2)

Yesterday in Tokyo, we had the first snow of winter dancing down. First snow. In Oizumi it started snowing around noon and was coming down nicely for a while, but unfortunately it quickly turned to rain.

In the distant past when I was a student, there was the "Joint First-Stage University Examination" for national and public universities every January 15th (ah, that's what's now called the "Center Test"), and mysteriously it would always snow on that day without fail. January 15th was "Coming of Age Day" anyway. Every year without fail, footage of people heading to exam venues in the snow and footage of 20-year-olds in ceremonial dress walking to coming-of-age ceremonies while minding their kimono hems in the snow would flow from the news—that was the standard.

When was the last time we had "heavy snow"?

Tokyo rarely gets snow in recent years. There are definitely quite a few Tokyo residents thinking "I wish we'd get enough snow to stop the trains once or twice a winter" (laugh). I wonder how it'll be? Will this winter bring that kind of heavy snow to Tokyo?

Now then.

Continuing "

STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM

notes."

I sent the first batch of character color samples to original creator Oda-san and waited several days. The long-awaited response came back. However, it wasn't a particularly favorable response.

There weren't any particular comments about the base colors I'd created—Robin with bright skin and Nami with light hair color seemed "OK"—but the costume colors were apparently lacking somehow. "The excitement doesn't come through"—I believe that was the comment.

The colors I'd conceived and built up had shifted somewhat toward a realistic direction in their coordination, and in addition to aiming too much for the original color illustrations' atmosphere, from the director's word "transparency," I'd made

the colors overall too light. That seemed to be the problem. The colors themselves probably lacked a bit of "powerful projection" or "volume." Looking back, there are several things that make me think "Yeah, that's right..."

And then, that unique "Oda World."

Everyone has their own color worldview—especially creators, the original authors of popular manga. The person who created the characters and story naturally has strong visual images in their head. Frustrating as it is, it can't be surpassed. I was the one who couldn't show Oda-san something that would make him "grin."

And then...

"This might be very rude to Tsujita-san, but..." Oda-sensei said, "This time, I'd like to have input on every part I can possibly have input on..."

We ended up having to ask Oda-sensei to do the costume color coordination concepts. Additional work amid his incredibly busy weekly serialization schedule—I was full of apologetic feelings.

After waiting about three more weeks, it arrived from Oda-san—the raw manuscript of color concepts. Character line art arranged in rows, with colors carefully placed using color ink (I think?). Oda-san must have pondered various options too, because on top of the once-colored versions, 2-3 alternative options per character were overlaid and pasted, neatly organized so the first choice was on top.

Facing those color concepts, Director Sakai and I groaned. Wow, it was truly Oda World!

"Well, this is really a color world that only the original creator could produce," Director Sakai and I said. Oda-san's color proposals were bolder than any combination we'd thought of, and they fit the characters perfectly. It was frustratingly good (laugh). These were truly color coordinations and combinations that only the original creator could produce.

Thus character color creation resumed. Based on this first proposal from Oda-san, I repainted the color samples. Golden Lion Shiki and Luffy's group costumes were mostly Oda-san's proposals, but still, for several characters including Golden Lion's subordinates Dr. Indigo and Captain Scarlett, Oda-san had colored them exactly as I'd proposed. So these remained basically as-is.

I lined up the newly painted characters on the monitor again and adjusted the color volume balance between characters. Once everything was roughly in order, after director approval, I sent them back to Oda-san for checking again.

However, at this point, we were right up against the "preview trailer" production deadline... The character designs themselves weren't changing, so animation work could proceed, but without finalized colors, color direction (■■■■) couldn't be done.

Without colors, naturally the trailer couldn't be made. But the deadline was also tight. This was something that absolutely couldn't be helped. We couldn't wait for Oda-san's OK before applying colors...

But even for a trailer, fans are waiting to see it, and this would be their first moving visual, so we absolutely couldn't put out something half-hearted. "While movement and poses are important in footage, first impressions are overwhelmingly determined by 'color'"—this is one of my theories, but color's impact on impressions is very significant.

So we proceeded with trailer production and work while waiting for Oda-san's response. I created trailer color direction based on the colors I'd sent to Oda-san for checking and proceeded with cut-by-cut color direction. We'd push the work forward anyway, and if Oda-san gave his OK, we'd continue as-is. If retakes or changes came back, we'd respond to make the deadline somehow—that was the strategy.

Eventually, painted trailer cuts came back to me one after another. Naturally all cuts selected from the main feature storyboard. Since they'd basically be used in the main feature as is, the animation volume and impact looked good. These could be projected on screen with confidence.

And finally, Oda-san's response arrived. An "OK"!

Thus that trailer was completed. "Ah, finally we can stand at the starting point for STRONG WORLD

"—that was my feeling.

■Continues to Episode 112

(10.01.05)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 113: New Year Special Edition -

STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM

Notes (Probably Middle Part)

While last time we had "first snow fell!" in cold Tokyo, this week Tokyo is warm enough to make you think "Is this spring?" But well, another cold wave will probably return soon, so it's just a momentary "spring-like?" weather.

Tempted by such weather, I rode my bicycle from my Nakano home to Toei's Oizumi studio for the first time in a while. About 10 kilometers in about an hour at a leisurely pace. Probably the first time in about three months. Along the way, the new Shakujikoen station building, which had been under serious construction, was now quite completed.

What I realized keenly after riding my bike for the first time in a while was that hybrid cars are scary! They don't make sound, you see—hybrid cars. The running sound is too quiet. When we're riding bicycles on the road, we can usually tell when cars are approaching from behind by engine noise, right? But these hybrid cars are incredibly quiet when running on motor power. They're quiet like "Are you a ninja?" and you really don't notice even when they're right behind you. I had several close calls because of this (sweat).

At night, there are headlight beams so even hybrid cars' approach is easy to detect, but what's especially scary is wide roads in residential areas during the day. If you're riding without noticing they're approaching and accidentally drift toward the center line... you know? Really scary. That's why iPods while cycling are absolutely out of the question.

This seems to be becoming a problem. With both hybrid cars and cyclist populations increasing these days, I hope the automotive industry, Ministry of Land Infrastructure and Transport, and police will implement countermeasures soon.

Now then.

This week continues the

STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM

notes.

We somehow cleared the trailer hurdle. Using almost all cuts that would be used in the theatrical main feature, it became a pretty good trailer. But that trailer couldn't actually be used as-is in the main feature. Everything was still "temporary."

While the animation and art needed considerable corrections, the "colors" in particular were still temporary color direction. "Temporary color direction." We certainly got Oda-sensei's "OK" on the basic character color coordination in time, and the trailer was painted based on that coordination, but that was just the basic basics. It was "trailer colors."

As with any work, characters (cels) and art (backgrounds) require balance adjustment work.

I think probably all color designers do this, but when we start creating character colors initially, we first build character colors according to some kind of "basic brightness value for characters" that each designer holds within themselves. Once we've created them all, we place those completed characters on basic backgrounds (art boards) to see (adjust) the balance between backgrounds and cels.

I also build based on the standards within myself.

For human characters, generally the whites of eyes or teeth are the whitest and brightest parts of the body, right? So in my case, I first create a balance between eye white brightness and skin brightness, and using that as a standard, I arrange colors overall while assuming volume under sunlight in normal daytime colors.

This thinking was basic both for the colors I first showed Oda-san that got rejected and for the colors I reorganized based on Oda-san's color concepts and showed him again.

So, the trailer. When I saw the art boards and actual backgrounds that came from the art staff, I groaned involuntarily.

"Hmm, amazing! It looks really good, but..." I said.

Actually, it was quite a bit—or rather considerably—more clearly defined, with denser colors and tones than what I'd anticipated for background art.

"Ah, at this rate, the characters will be overwhelmed (sweat)"

That's right. When placing characters on backgrounds as-is, the characters' color volume would be overwhelmed by the background volume, making the characters completely inconspicuous. This was especially true since Chief Animation Director Sato's character drawings had thin, delicate lines, making them even more prone to getting buried in the backgrounds.

For example, if this had been a TV work, characters are central, so we might apologetically ask the art staff to tone down the backgrounds a bit based on character requirements, but this was a theatrical work after all. This background art was for screen density that would look good projected on that big screen, so while there might be director retakes regarding color tone, scaling down the volume from

here was impossible. That meant we had to raise the volume on the cel data colors to a level where they wouldn't be overwhelmed.

So I hastily applied uniform level corrections to all completed trailer painting cuts before they went to photography. Thanks to this, we achieved some degree of balance, but it was emergency treatment under time pressure. For me, it was still quite insufficient. While still images might look okay at first glance, this is animation after all—when characters move, they looked somewhat weak. While that balance was acceptable for the trailer, I wanted to work on it more for the main feature.

So I readjusted the character balance against backgrounds for the main feature and recreated the standard "normal" color direction.

I adjusted the strength of colors themselves so that the character color balance created when lined up on pure white backgrounds would look the same when placed on high-density backgrounds. I adjusted colors darker and raised saturation levels without breaking the balance between characters.

The key here is that doing this too much makes characters overly assertive on screen, while too little makes their presence fade. Characters must have a solid presence against backgrounds. But without proper harmony, it doesn't work as movie imagery.

Additionally, based on verification from creating the trailer, I fine-tuned the color separation for several costume parts. While I'd initially tried detailed color coding and separation, parts that didn't look good on screen or seemed likely to become retake sources later were organized and corrected without significantly changing the original impression.

And one more thing. The theatrical promotional poster was drawn and colored by Oda-san based on the finalized color sample set, but this had subtly different part separations. So I made minor corrections to match the poster too (wry laugh).

At this point, there was one more major correction: Robin's eye color.

The director and assistant directors pointed out "It's blue in the TV version," so I once modified Robin to have blue eyes, but this always felt wrong to me somehow. But in this poster, Oda-san had finished her with brown eyes after all! So I passionately convinced Director Sakai in front of the color proof of the poster displayed at the staff room entrance. Thus Robin returned to the light brown eyes matching the color illustrations.

Based on this completed "basic"—so-called "normal"—color direction, we then moved into each scene's colors, scene-by-scene color design.

■Continues to Episode 114

(10.01.13)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 114: New Year Special Edition -

STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM

Notes (Indeed Middle Part 2)

"Hey there! Good work! Kobiki here!"

Kobiki-san, who appeared energetically, is a color direction specialist mainly active on Toei works. She also participated in color direction for

Casshern Sins

. This time, not as color direction but as "assistant color designer," I asked her to help me. I made an unreasonable request (really, quite an unreasonable request) for her to participate. From this day until the movie's completion, she'd be stationed in my room at Oizumi Studio.

For theatrical works over 90 minutes long, the general standard approach seems to be that color design handles the design work in principle, with color direction handled by someone else. Even for the theatrical

Legend of the True Savior: Fist of the North Star

trilogy where I participated as color designer under a "different name" at Tokyo Movie, we had 3-4 color direction specialists participate in each.

However, for Toei Animation theatrical works, the color design person handles both design and all color direction alone as a rule. That's been Toei's traditional method since ancient times. I used to fight using that approach too.

GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!

movie from two years ago also used this method.

But while that might have worked in the old days with sufficient schedules, in today's situation with such tight deadlines, it's quite difficult. If you try to look at everything thoroughly and work out details, this method becomes impossible. I learned this anew from

GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!

(though things like

PreCure

are still done this way even now...).

But at the same time, I personally have the desire to "do both color design and color direction completely myself."

I think any color designer feels this way, but once you create characters and design scenes, you naturally want to do color direction on the raw animation yourself and readjust the painted colors against backgrounds.

And this was also the director's wish. He wanted careful attention to details and a thoroughly substantial screen finish. So he wanted me to do all the color direction and completion checking too. But to do everything properly alone, there simply wasn't enough time.

So this time, I absolutely needed someone to assist me. Enter Kobiki-san. Kobiki-san and I have weathered many battlefields together. We're comrades who understand each other's methods well. She's one of the color direction specialists I trust most.

Work-wise, I would first do the overall color design for the main feature, and I'd do all the color direction alone. On top of that, I'd ask Kobiki-san to handle various somewhat time-consuming tasks that would take me too long if I started them myself.

One of these was organizing mob scenes.

This work has an incredible number of pirates appearing. Kobiki-san handled creating colors for these pirates overall. First, creating color direction data for pirates appearing across multiple cuts. Based on reference designs Sato-san provided for the pirates, she created colors for the pirate captains seated in the great hall during the "raid" scene, and used that data as color direction reference for the finishing (■■■■) staff to paint.

Then color matching in actual painted cuts. Only a handful of pirate characters were roughly decided as designs, and the pirates actually appearing in cuts were mostly drawn by the key animators who handled those scenes & cuts as a series. She corrected and unified these painted results to avoid inconsistencies. Plus drinks and food in taverns, swarms of pirate ships, and so on. She handled "difficult cut" after "difficult cut." That big pirate brawl mob scene during the "raid" sequence—that's all Kobiki-san's work.

Incidentally, what about painted completion inspection? Cuts painted overseas would first get a rough inspection from the team at Toei Animation mainly handling retake processing, checking for animation mistakes and missing masks. Then Kobiki-san and I would inspect all cuts once more together—that was our method.

So at that point, through "sorting," I'd ask Kobiki-san to handle cuts needing cross-cut matching, cuts needing color corrections, cuts where I wanted to add processing later during color direction, and she'd handle detailed processing work

along with inspection. When I'd ask Kobiki-san "Make this 'on fire!'" she'd make it nicely 'on fire'—that kind of combination.

"Because you're touching actual key animation and in-between animation for color direction, you can pay attention to detailed acting and nuances"—this is my theory about color direction work. So my usual style is to inspect painted results of cuts I did color direction for myself and add "one more spoonful." But in situations with tight schedules like this, it often becomes difficult to do such detailed "seasoning."

But thanks to Kobiki-san participating this time, she thoroughly covered parts I couldn't have handled alone and created several cuts beyond that.

Now then.

We got through September with its palpable sense of crisis and plunged into October. The month from here probably became the biggest "festival" in recent years. A dialogue between Oda-san and Mr. Children's Sakurai-san was scheduled for the first week of November. That meant we absolutely had to show them completed footage before that dialogue. Which meant completion by then...!

Aaagh! (waterfall sweat)

From here on, there are too many things that would cause problems for various parties to write about properly (wry laugh). Actually, during this one month, nearly 70% of the main feature's cuts flew around East Asia, and we somehow managed to reach completion.

Literally kicking young staff in the rear, sometimes raising our voices, somehow keeping the director motivated while running to the finish! Those days continued. A month that passed in a flash. I spent half of it sleeping in a sleeping bag in my studio room. Before I knew it, I'd become almost the oldest person on site, so there was also a month of fighting pressure, thinking that old guy had to work hard and set an example.

And so, we utterly exhausted staff faced November...

■Continues to Episode 116

(10.01.27)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 115: It's February Already But... New Year Special Edition -

Strong World ONE PIECE FILM

Notes (Final Part 1)

Somehow, it's become February already!

February.

The cold suddenly got severe, and Tokyo suddenly had snow falling...

Plus I hear talk about the winter Olympics coming up soon, but this February, as someone handling programs starting in April, every day is nothing but pressure.

Because February is short! Two whole days shorter than regular months!

If I can skillfully conquer this February, I'm sure I can greet March and then April with a smile. Believing that, I'm working hard every day.

Yeah, do your best > Japan. And, do your best > Me

Please look forward to that new program

The Tatami Galaxy

!

Now then.

Strong World

's original deadline was actually mid-September. The plan from the publicity department and production committee was to deliver three months before the nationwide December 12th release, then spend three months on promotion, but delays starting with the storyboard completion delay gradually widened that wound, and particularly the delays in animation—layout animation completion and its checking work—became the biggest cause of delays for all subsequent departments.

(Oh right, one big numerical error in the previous installment. The total cut count wasn't "over 1400" but about 2200 cuts. Hahaha! (laugh) I'd noticed I wrote it wrong but missed it in final checking and sent it to the editorial department as-is. Incidentally, this cut count equals about seven TV episodes. It was the largest cut count in my career!)

Without layout approval, neither key animation work nor art background work can proceed. We assigned multiple assistant animation directors and tackled correction

work on the massive number of cuts, but progress was frustratingly slow. "First and foremost, properly establish animation and screen layouts to build the screen"—that was the primary important point for the director and animation team on this movie. So they ended up spending slightly more time than necessary.

So the crucial art boards were also scheduled to be drawn scene by scene waiting for actual layouts, which led to an emergency situation where even boards weren't coming up. That was the September situation.

However, you can't just sit idle saying "cuts aren't coming" or "key animation isn't coming." Even doing nothing, remaining time keeps disappearing day by day. So anyway, we start with whatever we can work on, and whatever form it takes, cuts should eventually rush in like a tsunami at the end, so we prepare to handle such situations—that's what we could do.

The rough color design plan was mostly complete by mid-August, and after that we'd wait for art boards to be completed in sequence to create actual "colors." Between places we'd decided for the trailer, scenes where boards came up relatively early, or scenes where we'd requested boards for CG-related advance work, little by little we had a fair number of scenes with completed decisions.

While animation was certainly delayed, regarding animation work after key animation completion—in-between animation and finishing work—thanks to the "short-term overseas in-between and finishing system" built up over many years, considerable acceleration was possible. Once key animation was completed, passed the animation director, had color direction applied, and was ordered for in-between and finishing work, cuts would be painted through in-between animation + painting work in just 2-3 days (even "12-hour in-between and finishing" as a final measure).

But backgrounds apparently couldn't work like this. While background work also often relies on overseas for actual work, opposite to key animation where animation directors work on it before ordering, the workflow for backgrounds has art directors thoroughly work and check with their brushes after ordering and initial completion. So time reduction is difficult and it does take time.

Due to such factors and others, many scenes ended up waiting for art boards and backgrounds. With a total volume of over 2000 cuts, even with animation delays, a decent number of key animation cuts came to color direction daily. Ideally we'd finish properly deciding each scene's "colors" before applying correct color direction and ordering in-between and finishing work, but since moving cuts were absolutely necessary for sound work, we couldn't wait for art boards and color decisions.

So we temporarily applied "normal" color direction and ordered in-between and finishing work, had them painted in temporary colors, shot them as-is for now to

create moving material for sound work. Behind that, we'd decide the "correct colors" for those scenes and ask retake processing painting staff to replace colors with "correct colors," then reshoot—that workflow was established. This happened for quite a lot of scenes. Especially the latter half had considerable numbers of cuts processed this way. Ah, at times like this I really think "Thank goodness for digital painting!" In the old cel era, such methods would have been absolutely impossible.

My and Kobiki-san's "color team" was steadily building up work even in such circumstances.

As I wrote last time, work-wise, I'd first do overall color design for the main feature, and I'd do all color direction alone. I asked Kobiki-san to mainly handle somewhat time-consuming detailed tasks.

"Somewhat time-consuming detailed tasks"—one of these was organizing mob scenes.

This work has an incredible number of pirates. Kobiki-san generally created colors for these pirates. First was creating color direction data for pirates appearing across multiple cuts. Based on pirate reference designs from Sato-san, she created colors for the pirate captains seated in the great hall during the "raid" scene, and used that data as color direction reference for finishing staff painting.

Then color matching in actual painted cuts. Only a tiny handful of pirate characters were roughly established as designs, and pirates actually appearing in cuts were mostly things drawn by key animators handling those scenes & cuts as a series. She corrected and unified these painted results without inconsistencies. Plus drinks and food in taverns, swarms of pirate ships, and so on. She handled "difficult cut" after "difficult cut." That big pirate brawl during the "raid" scene—all those mob scenes—that's all Kobiki-san's work.

Incidentally, painted completion inspection involved cuts painted overseas first getting rough inspection from teams at Toei Animation mainly handling retake processing, checking for animation mistakes and missing masks. Then Kobiki-san and I would inspect all cuts once more together.

So through "sorting" at that point, I'd ask Kobiki-san to handle cuts needing cross-cut matching, cuts needing color corrections, cuts where I'd been thinking about adding processing during color direction, and she'd handle detailed processing work along with inspection. When I'd say "Make this 'on fire!'" to Kobiki-san, she'd make it nicely 'on fire'—that kind of combination.

"Because you're touching actual key animation and in-between animation for color direction, you can pay attention to detailed acting and nuances"—this is my theory about color direction work. So my usual style is to inspect painted results of cuts I did color direction for myself and add "one more spoonful." But in tight schedule

situations like this, it often becomes difficult to do such detailed "seasoning."

But thanks to Kobiki-san participating this time, she thoroughly covered parts I couldn't have handled alone and created several cuts beyond that.

Now then now then.

We weathered crisis-filled September and plunged into October. The month from here probably became the biggest "festival" in recent years. A dialogue between Oda-san and Mr. Children's Sakurai-san was scheduled for the first week of November. That meant we absolutely had to show them completed footage before that dialogue. Which meant completion by then...!

Aaagh! (waterfall sweat)

From here on there are too many things that would cause problems for various parties to write about properly (wry laugh). Actually, during this one month, nearly 70% of the main feature's cuts flew around East Asia, and we somehow managed to reach completion.

Literally whipping young staff into shape, sometimes raising our voices, somehow keeping the director motivated while running to the finish! Those days continued. A month that passed in a flash. I spent half of it sleeping in a sleeping bag in my studio room. Before I knew it, I'd become almost the oldest person on site, so there was also a month of fighting pressure, thinking that old guy had better work hard and set an example.

And so, we utterly exhausted staff welcomed November...

■Continues to Episode 116

(10.02.08)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 116: It's March Already But... New Year Special Edition -

STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM

Notes (Final Part 2) "SW" Main Feature Complete Scene Color Design Notes! Part 1

Aaaaaah! March (sob). I was so busy I kept missing deadlines, and February ended before I knew it. Sorry! > All concerned parties

The cause of that busyness is various projects colliding, truly leaving no time to sleep. I'd love to promote everything here, but unfortunately some things still can't be discussed... Among those, what's been opened to the public in a big way is

The Tatami Galaxy

.

Official site

The PV has started being released. The broadcast date was finally decided. Please look forward to this too!

■Scene 1: Navy Headquarters

"Hey, who's Garp?" I asked. "Apparently he's Luffy's grandfather," said Kobiki-san. "Why is a pirate's grandpa in the Navy?" "Who knows?"... Well, design work for one scene started with that kind of conversation (laugh). This scene was used in the trailer too, but the trailer colors were strictly "temporary." For the main feature I recreated them from scratch.

The goal was an impressive "bright red" as the hook, unified in red that felt pink rather than orange. The CG island ship was made heavily black for weight and presence. For this scene I handed Kobiki-san colors I'd adjusted from the trailer cuts with a "Well then, please handle it!" feeling (laugh).

■Scene 2: Summer Island Jungle

Luffy's entrance. This scene of jungle monster battles was designed with strong summer-like contrast.

The dust clouds in the jungle were deliberately made somewhat bright. Thinking realistically, since it's jungle it would be more humid, and the dust clouds themselves would be more ground-colored. I tried that approach initially, but it blended too much with the monsters and somehow felt off—the atmosphere didn't match the animation. Since the photography policy was also not to double-expose

(not make transparent), maybe dry ground dust cloud colors would be better? So the dust cloud colors became the same dry colors as the dust clouds in the later plaza battle against Teroguma.

I actually like these three scenes best in the main feature. They overflow with that "What? What? What? What's starting?" feeling.

■Scenes 3-5: Autumn Island Ruins

When I saw the art boards from Waki-san, the autumn leaves were so vivid and bright that I went "Ugh! (sweat)" and thought maybe we'd have to tone down the color saturation somewhat. But when actually shot, it settled really well, had great contrast, and became a good point in the main feature's introduction. Ah, as expected, amazing, well calculated.

This scene is basically painted with so-called "normal" color direction. Based on the balance with the previous scene and the art around here, I decided the basic normal color balance for the main feature.

Incidentally, the army ants swarming out—those are almost entirely CG. Only a few animation cuts. I added colors to 2D designs and handed them over, and modeling and coloring were based on those.

■Scene 6: Opening

"Make it look like a color chart screen"—that was the director's order. The meeting was just that, and I was allowed to freely create the rest—that opening. One-cut processing. I applied color direction to an incredibly thick bundle of key animation with "here goes!" reflexes. After it was painted, while watching the screen flow, I repainted and corrected with another "here goes!" feeling. About an hour for color direction. About five hours for painted correction and final repainting work. Photography was handled by the CG department. A one-shot gamble that got an OK!

Actually, this opening was so close to the deadline with no time that there wasn't leisure to work carefully—that was the reality. In result, I think that worked out well. This kind of screen, this kind of work, this kind of result—I quite like it personally.

■Scene 7: Shiki's Palace Greenhouse Pool

From the opening the screen moves directly to the indoor pool. Also "normal" color direction here. It's the proper introduction scene for Shiki's group. For the entrance dance, based on the storyboard, movement was first created with 3D dummy models and frame printouts were made for the duration. Using those as foundation, character animation (key animation) was placed on top, proceeding through in-between animation to finishing in 2D workflow. This was quite troublesome—the movement animation itself was fine, but the facial in-betweens were catastrophic

(wry laugh). Some cuts had animation corrected twice (but the ones that couldn't be fixed are a secret).

■Scenes 8-15: Sunny Deck to Island Ship Bridge, Storm Arrival

The flashback scene about why Nami was brought to the palace.

The 3D Sunny was created for TV series, but I modified colors and textures for theatrical use. I provided modification proposals for colors, Special Effects' Ota-kun added texture retouch samples to that data, and based on those, CG department staff reflected them in the main feature. Incidentally, the island ship had CG models created based on designs by Art Setting's Sato Masahiro, and CG models were completed using textures prepared by the art department combined with island ships drawn by Waki-san as art design.

For Sunny deck characters, I initially thought about strengthening shadow density for more contrast, but when I made color samples, they looked somewhat dirty so I stopped. Nami's white tank top chest shadows just wouldn't look clean. Chopper's expression also became harsh (laugh), and Nami's the lead (laugh). So this too was basically "normal" color direction. Storm scenes and the closed island ship bridge had overall saturation and brightness lowered.

The island ship bridge crew (pirates) were also created by Kobiki-san. Among them was one character set as "Shiki's Subordinate A," but he looked like talent Wacky and was quite eye-catching—ah, maybe I should have made his colors more similar too.

■Scene 16: Shiki's Palace Greenhouse Pool

Billy's entrance. Billy's colors are actually TV series color designer Horita-kun's colors. Before I joined this project, colors apparently had to be released first for games or something, so Horita-kun had provided colors for Shiki and Billy. I remade Shiki and others my way, but since Oda-san said Billy was good as-is, I used it unchanged.

For pool scene Nami's hair, while animation expressed wetness, wondering if we could add another touch, Special Effects added glossy processing to highlight areas. Plus I asked for highlight brush processing on Nami's eyes as much as possible. This was also Special Effects' Ota-kun's handiwork. Considering whether Nami's inner strength could be expressed through her eyes, though the volume was large, I requested it. Nami's the lead after all (laugh).

■Scenes 17-23: Spring Island to Resident Island, Xiao's House

The monsters—ah, they're fun! My favorites are Cowball (the ones that shoot out from cherry tree branches) and Toramata. I briefly thought about secretly using Toramata for New Year's cards, but that would obviously be problematic so I didn't

(laugh).

Around the winter zone monster battles, the snow in the backgrounds that came up was unexpectedly light brown. Since it was supposed to be a desaturated scene, that was OK, but there was a slight problem. While the background looked properly like snow even in light brown, if I matched that color to create animated (cel) snow, the cel version just looked like dirt (wry laugh). So I deliberately didn't match cel-drawn snow and snow clouds to the background and made them white snow.

Xiao's grandmother's illness "spots" and Nami's spots later were all Special Effects handiwork. Base parts were created on separate cels and processed.

■Scenes 25-26, 30: Pirates Gathered at Port to Palace Command Room

Matching pirate captain colors, command room pirates and navigators—this area was all Kobiki-san work.

Inside the command room, character brightness was suppressed to match background brightness. Even in dim places, it's brightness that looks natural through balance.

Den Den Mushi wandering the village, plus Den Den Mushi appearing in island ship bridge and command room—also Kobiki-san work. When I make them they tend toward realistic, so I asked her to aim for a manga-like feel. The unbalanced feeling creates good atmosphere.

■Scene 24, 27: Palace Pool to Merveille Sea to Caldera Lake Island

Nami and Billy's escape and reunion with Luffy. Nami's swimsuit—I actually made a slight mistake. This swimsuit has black and white vertical stripes, but when I created the painting settings, the bra straps were mixed between white and black ones in full-body and close-up images. So the painted results were inconsistent (cry). I sent them to photography without noticing and created lots of retakes. Incidentally, it's a secret that some cuts weren't completely fixed (wry laugh).

The scorpion meat Luffy grills and eats used grilled crab as reference (laugh). Incidentally, I don't really like crab.

■Scenes 28, 29: Wasteland, Xiao's Village

This area is also basically all "normal" color direction.

■Scenes 31, 33: Wasteland Tavern

Inside the tavern, overall brightness was suppressed to match backgrounds with lighting redness (or rather yellow-orange) added. Pirates and food were Kobiki-san work, plus Special Effects added appetizing textures.

Pirate Kitajima appears. Ah, Kitajima! For promotional reasons, Kitajima's participation was suddenly decided. I was suddenly handed the character and created it with "here goes!" momentum, but thinking back, various things were awkward. He was supposedly a fishman tribally, but actually no other fishmen appeared in the main feature besides Kitajima—I should have put more fishman-type pirates among the mob.

Also Saito Aiko-chan's Xiao's sister Ever. This was also suddenly communicated as "that's how it became!" (sweat). Since that wasn't my intention, if I'd known earlier, I had more ideas to make her cuter (oops).

■Scene 32: Xiao's House

The scene where Nami overhears Xiao's family conversation and becomes upset. Originally I planned to make characters in the room darker for evening atmosphere, but since the outdoor scene just before wasn't particularly westering sun, and the animation had large shadow areas, I unified it normally. Photography added various atmosphere.

■Scene 34: Xiao's Village, Sunset Battle

First half climax. This scene divides into two color groupings: the orange sunset "Sunset Color B" during the big battle with Shiki, and "Afterglow Color" for when Nami submits.

The battle scene "Sunset Color B" appeared briefly in the trailer, but I remade it for the main feature. In the trailer version, character color volume was overwhelmed by the cool backgrounds, so in short, fast action sequences, characters were hard to see—or rather their impression would be weakened. So I remade it with stronger projection. Result: good balance! Self-praise (laugh).

Shiki's big technique "Lion's Threat Earth Roll" (←is that how it's written?) is all CG. The actual CG footage took a while to come up, making me a bit anxious (laugh), but it had impressive volume! A bit "The Mummy" (laugh).

Then the latter half "Afterglow Color." Visual imagery of that helpless feeling after sunset—from my real experiences tent-packing and mountain climbing in the past, I had this "like this!" feeling inside me. So it became that way. This is also one of my favorite scenes.

Now, what will become of Nami who submitted to Shiki!? And what about Luffy and the others!?

This continues one more time.

■Continues to Episode 117

(10.03.02)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 117: It's March Already But... New Year Special Edition -

STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM

Notes (Final Part 3) "SW" Main Feature Complete Scene Color Design Notes! Part 2

Yesterday marked exactly one year since I became freelance. Wow, that was fast (laugh). Still, it was quite a thrilling year. While I'd secretly (!) worked on various projects before, this was definitely a big difference.

One year ago today was also the day I said farewell to my other secret name "Kunioto Kunio" (■■■■) when I went freelance. For me, this name was both a brand and an emotional anchor. It was a day of resolve, saying goodbye to that name.

One way or another, it was quite an emotionally intense year.

Even so, being able to continue receiving work without interruption like this is truly something to be grateful for—I'm endlessly thankful.

Now then.

Continuing "

STRONG WORLD

Main Feature Complete Scene Color Design Notes!" for this major theatrical work that was my first big job after going freelance.

■Scene 34: Supplement

There's work called "Special Effects," mainly adding brush textures to characters and props, blending wind and smoke with backgrounds and cel-drawn parts—well, it's like a magician profession that does various things, and for this work we asked Ota Nao-kun. I've been working with him continuously since

Magical DoReMi Movie: Secret of the Frog Stone

.

In traditional Toei work style, Special Effects teams would handle brush work like smoke with "Here goes!" but this time we asked photography to handle all work they could, and had them focus on areas where handiwork could really show its power.

Particularly in Scene 34, we asked for texture processing on the Tone Dial. When I requested "When Nami finishes recording her message and places it on the ground, make it shine as if there are emotions there," it was crafted with atmosphere as if precious life dwelt there. Much gratitude!

■Scene 35: Palace Command Room

Like the first half, character brightness is somewhat suppressed to match the dimness.

■Scenes 36-38: Outside Palace, Various

From around here time becomes night. From then on, it's endless night scenes until the battle ends.

For monsters responding to Captain Scarlett's roar and enhanced soldiers, I deliberately made night scene colors bright. Thinking realistically, you'd darken them more to match background colors for atmosphere, but doing that raises the screen's age appeal. What we aimed for was screens for boys and girls, "manga movie" screens, so we thought about showing characters and monsters as clearly as possible.

However, cuts where story development called for "this cut should be really dark!" were properly crafted.

The Daft Green felling scene (Scene 38) was actually a scene where both animation and backgrounds finally came up when the production schedule was quite pressed. I think the white trunk feeling of Daft Green was a bit insufficient.

■Scenes 25-26, 30: Pirates Gathered at Port to Palace Command Room

Matching pirate captain colors and command room pirates and navigators—this area was all Kobiki-san work.

Inside the command room, character brightness was suppressed to match background brightness. Even in dim places, it's brightness that looks natural through balance.

Den Den Mushi wandering the village, plus those appearing in island ship bridge and command room—also Kobiki-san work. When I make them they tend toward realistic, so I aimed for a manga-like feel. The unbalanced feeling creates good atmosphere.

■Scene 40, 42: Palace Command Room

Nami's formal wear debut scene. ...Rather, for us the key was the "kotatsu" (laugh). I asked Kobiki-san to handle this too, but we had the discussion "What's piled on top of the kotatsu?" "Fruit? But this looks like big carrots, right? (sweat)" "If what they're eating is oranges, I'll forgive the rest (laugh)," I said. But this too

became quite convincing with Special Effects magic (laugh).

■Scene 41: Xiao's Village Fire

This scene also matched colors created in advance for the trailer—Kobiki work. This scene also took work until quite late, didn't it?

■Scene 43: Xiao's Village Burned Ruins

Franky and others arrive at the burned ruins. The scene where the Straw Hat crew assembles.

Initially, the art board for this scene that came up had the same series of night colors as other night scenes around the palace. But I thought this should be a bit different. The dejected feeling of being thoroughly beaten by Shiki, plus losing Nami—that despair. And the scene where spirits rise toward "raid" after hearing Nami's message. So I proposed "How about somewhat cold, strongly blue moonlight?" and they modified it in that direction.

Transparent night colors that make characters feel moonlight. It finished with good balance.

However, one failure in this scene: the smoke wafting around. I tried creating various detailed colors to match backgrounds for depth perception. But the colors I made apparently had too low saturation, and when photography applied blur processing, oh my, the smoke lost too much color and became mere gray. Gray on the blue-finished background felt somewhat reddish. Hmm. I was aiming for somewhat harder colors, so disappointing.

Ah, this type of adjustment needs close collaboration with photography doing actual compositing—a lesson scene. But even subtracting that, the scene finished with good feeling.

■Scene 44: Palace Island

The scene where island ships carrying pirate captains arrive at palace island's sea. 3DCG island ships landing in equally CG seas, but waves kicked up by island ships are 2D animation—a hybrid. Probably making everything CG would be easier, but that would feel different. It would surely have become a "different thing" feeling. Having animated waves there creates balance with other scenes.

■Scene 45: Palace Command Room

Which gesture represented which content, I wonder? (laugh)

■Scene 46: Outside Palace, Daft Green Plantings

And what Indigo conveyed was that they'd captured Nami (laugh).

For outdoor night scenes around the palace, in my initial design plan I intended to create about four subtly different "night colors." One for moonlit night colors when Sunny crashes in, one for night colors near palace building lights, one for night colors on palace rooftops, and night colors around this Daft Green area.

But ultimately, I made them all the same "night color." There are various reasons, but one was snow. Snow constantly danced on screen, and later became blizzards. In that case, doing subtle things wouldn't be very effective. Rather, organizing everything the same would reduce work hassles and let us properly spend effort where we wanted to add touches—that was also a consideration.

Considering balance with work volume while properly establishing screens under time pressure—I consider that part of my job too.

Oh, the scene where Nami gets caught by iron spears—I secretly remembered Anthy from "Utena" just a bit (laugh).

■Scene 47- Palace Interior Assembly Hall

Anyway, a spaciouly broad, gorgeous, bright great hall. Pirate captains lined up there. And a Kobiki-san work scene (laugh). Reference copies were distributed for animation matching, but many cuts inevitably didn't come up as intended, so detailed corrections beyond just colors were done bit by bit on cel data.

■Scene 52: Caldera Lakeside Sunny

This time, Sunny was made with 3DCG in principle. And 3D scene colors are naturally my job too. For this Sunny too, I provided color samples matched to backgrounds scene by scene, and they worked based on those.

They'd output single images from models assembled for specific scenes and cuts, then I'd layer color corrections using adjustment layers. Plus detailed nuances were conveyed verbally to staff like "more like this feeling" (laugh).

■Scene 54: Palace Front Garden

The scene where Sunny crashes in with full moon backdrop. Also a 2D/3D hybrid. This was a scene where I thought about making overall contrast stronger but stopped. Instead, I could properly craft impressions in key cuts.

■Scene 60- Assembly Hall Raid

In the earlier teaser, there was a cut with Luffy and others lined up in formal wear against backlight—that visual was so cool that we absolutely had to do it in the main feature too!

So for the raid scene, darkening just before Luffy's group bursts through the sliding doors was to recreate that cut. Around here, it wasn't about physical logic but atmosphere and impression priority!

Smoke from Luffy's group's firearms. The blast smoke from firing barrels is black powder-type black smoke, but the first shot is darkest, then gradually becomes grayer. Landing smoke is also black-type initially, but smoke rising from floors in subsequent cuts gradually becomes lighter gray as cuts progress.

The reason is both Luffy's group and pirates wear "black." If smoke is also black, screens become busy and important character acting becomes hard to understand.

■Scene 61- Around Palace Various

From here it's pure volume! Basically, inside the great hall is "normal," elsewhere like corridors have brightness adjusted to backgrounds. Once on rooftops, night colors. From Scene 65, monsters storm into the palace, but those follow the same basics.

Really, around here it's pure volume (laugh).

■Scene 67: Outside Palace

While consulting about rescuing Nami and getting medicine, Shiki attacks. Here's the big technique "Lion's Threat Earth Roll" snow version. This time not CG but animation. Then Luffy appears. Gear Second mode.

Actually, I didn't understand what Gear Second or Third meant. So I asked the assistant director. They said "Power stored in his body emits light from inside, pink." "I see," I said. So I conceived that processing.

The body glowing itself—if you use high-contrast processing it looks bright. For that light being pink, make the steam clinging around his body pink reflection. If you also unify the body's shadow areas in high-saturation pink tones, overall it should look like pink glowing? And then photography skillfully put it together.

This was actually an application of

Dragon Ball

's Super Saiyan and Kamehameha wave. Techniques I'd used myself over ten years ago proved useful here (laugh).

...And writing this far, ah, time's up!

Ah, sorry, continuing one more time.

What will become of Nami afflicted by Daft!?

How will the Shiki VS Luffy battle go!?

With sweaty palms, please look forward to it!

■Continues to Episode 118

(10.03.12)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 118: It's March Already But... New Year Special Edition -

STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM

Notes (Final Part 4) "SW" Main Feature Complete Scene Color Design Notes! Part 3

It's completely spring now. Tokyo apparently had its cherry blossom bloom declaration, and the buds on the cherry tree-lined street near my home are swollen to bursting. We'll soon see this year's magnificent cherry blossom tunnel.

Speaking of cherry blossoms, it's hanami time!

Near my home there's Araiyakushi Park, and during hanami season it becomes incredibly bustling regardless of day or time. How incredible? The park and surrounding roads smell like nothing but beer (laugh). If you carelessly try to cross the park unguarded, that alone will get you drunk (laugh).

By the way, recently I told the

Tatami Galaxy

staff, "Don't you think the words 'four-and-a-half tatami' and 'hanami' have very high affinity?" The director replied, "Hanami sounds good. We absolutely must do it. Let's definitely do it."

However,

Tatami Galaxy

is also quite busy heading toward April broadcast start. So will we actually manage it? Hanami. Come on, for hanami's sake, let's work hard! (laugh)

Now then.

Final installment of "

SW

Main Feature Complete Scene Color Design Notes!" that I've been writing at length.

■Scene 68: Palace Research Lab Cultivation Facility

Usopp and Chopper carrying Nami and searching for "medicine" enter the research facility. The skylit glasshouse is an "IQ" cultivation facility. A somewhat fantastical screen bathed in moonlight.

This was actually another failure retake story because I didn't understand well (laugh).

During the "raid," everyone wore formal clothes, and Chopper also wore formal shoes then, but when Chopper becomes gigantic (that's the right term, right?), he's not wearing shoes? Rather, he can't wear them with hooves (laugh).

Since I didn't really understand during color direction, I had them paint it with shoe-wearing colors, but during rushes check everyone pointed it out. "Eh? Really? (sweat)" I said. While this scene was dark overall, in cuts where moonlight hit his feet, the mistake was clearly exposed... So retake repainting (wry laugh). Including the next scene, quite a number ended up as retakes. Ah, sorry.

...But there were also cuts wrong in animation, so it's a draw (ah).

■Scene 69: Palace Research Lab Chemical Factory

First, the research room interior in the scene's first half. Background art is fairly dark brown-black, with dim equipment lights in that space. Characters are also made dark to match backgrounds, but aiming for a feeling "somehow lit by equipment lights," I added faint green taste to normal parts.

The Daft chemicals being made here are yellow-green, so. Incidentally, the treatment medicine is pink. The "IQ" that's the source for making treatment medicine is also pink.

In my color imagery, yellow-green has a fairly poisonous image. And pink has an image of illness being cured. I don't know why, but perhaps it's the image of syrup medicine prescribed at pediatrics when I caught colds as a child?

The latter half, Zoro's appearance and confrontation with Indigo. I made this a complete color battle. Indigo with yellow-green reflection from his own techniques. Since Indigo was initially dominant, in the bridge confrontation's first half, Sanji receiving attacks also got Indigo's technique yellow-green reflection to create a "being pushed" feeling. After being enveloped in green flames and smoke, the tide turns. Now Zoro's technique gets red-type reflection. "High-contrast reflection should be the attacking side's color, the dominant side's color"—that's my personal rule. "Being dyed in opponent's colors" somehow has a "losing" feeling, right?

Incidentally, the first three cuts of this scene—chemicals and various things on tables. Special Effects team worked so hard it became quite like the secret underground room from "Nausicaa" (wry laugh).

■Scene 70: Palace Exterior Rooftop

Next, Sanji VS Captain Scarlett. This is fairly hand-to-hand combat. I avoided flashy color use, normally used night color base with some cuts slightly high-contrast. I briefly considered whether to color smoke from Sanji's leg

techniques, but since the legs themselves looked like they'd glow nicely with transmitted light, I made the smoke whitish so that would be easily visible.

■Scene 71: Palace Exterior

The scene where Nami regains consciousness on Chopper's back. From around here, Nami's face "spots" start fading. Special Effects created nice transparency in Nami's eyes as she notices weather changes and looks around.

■Scenes 72-75: Merveille Everywhere

Shiki VS Luffy + Billy aerial battle. Around here, my initial plan considered changing colors by location, but since the animation and cut buildup speed felt good, I deliberately pushed through with basic night colors.

However, since Luffy stayed in Gear Second, I wish I could have created better reflection effects for Billy. Regarding that, there were actually circumstances where this series of cuts had key animation that didn't come up until the very end.

The scene where Shiki cuts the sea to drown Luffy and others. The seawater here combines animation-created material with CG overlay. I actually wasn't very confident about cel water colors, but the CG team put it together well.

■Scene 76, 78: Palace Exterior

From around here where storms approach and snowfall becomes intense, I made character colors "storm colors." Saturation is lowered and made slightly heavier than previous "night colors."

■Scene 77: Palace Interior Armory etc.

Chopper and others busily setting bombs. I used colors from the earlier research room here.

■Scene 79: Some Small Island

Luffy regaining consciousness and standing up. Also "storm colors." Initially Luffy wasn't bleeding, but Oda-san proposed "Shouldn't we add blood?" so forehead blood animation was added.

■Scene 80: Above Palace

Shiki VS Luffy. The decisive battle. Blizzard action throughout. And Gear Third.

In this

SW

, starting with Animation Director Sato, we had a stellar animation team, but among them, the key animation for this scene was particularly incredible. Wow, I got goosebumps doing color direction!

Within this scene, the Luffy vs Shiki battle portion's key animation was handled by Umakoshi. While

SW

's overall art style was unified with thin, sharp line animation, this scene unleashed Umakoshi's thick-lined, truly robust animation at full strength. This power! The climactic battle heat became even hotter through that robust line strength.

This scene was also used in the trailer and animation was completed relatively early. So including colors, it could be carefully crafted.

From midway through the battle, I used overall lightning-type blue-white high-contrast color direction, but Luffy's giant leg just looked like a daikon radish no matter what (laugh). After the trailer, I changed colors and processing several times for reshooting, but couldn't shake that initial impression (wry laugh). But overall screen "momentum" created through cut accumulation was sufficient, so "OK!"

After Luffy's giant radish heel drop explodes, Sunny flies through gradually brightening dawn that shakes off the battle's lightning high-contrast. As expected, safely surviving Luffy appears in sun-bathed colors. Everyone on Sunny's deck also changes colors in two stages during this time—from anxious monotone tones to relieved brightness upon learning Luffy's safe.

■Scene 81: Navy Warship

Captured pirate captains and Navy cuts. I deliberately shifted this toward purple. Looking back later, maybe it could have been more restrained. But maybe the somewhat unstable feeling is good too. Islands are falling from the sky after all.

■Scenes 84-86: Sunny Epilogue

An epilogue hoping to achieve refreshing feeling. Basically "normal" color direction. Only ship interior brightness is slightly suppressed to match backgrounds. After big incidents end, this returns to daily life—hoping that atmosphere would come through. So I finished it unchanged without doing anything special.

Chopper holds the medicine box by hand, but "Hey, how is he holding this?" I asked. "Same as Doraemon, probably," said Kobiki-san (laugh).

In this scene, everyone changed costumes. Luffy and several others wear TV series main setting clothes, but balanced for theatrical use. Nami's dress shirt look was strong director intent, but this was also every male staff member's wish. Making it color trace finishing was my intent (laugh). For me, Robin was more striking than Nami! A see-through blouse. I was excited while creating colors (laugh). But disappointingly it didn't show much on screen.

■Ending

This was also created under incredibly tight time constraints. Several cuts came up as quite disappointing in-between animation, but naturally we couldn't cry about it—re-animation. We barely managed to remake them at the last minute.

Starting from illustration-like images like the opening, ending with the usual Luffy and others. In between, separate from East Blue scenes, several characters not appearing in the main story appear—I thought maybe this bridges to stories developing on TV.

...Thus

STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM

was completed.

November■■■, Preview 0 at Tokyo Chofu's Toei Lab Tech (←there were quite a lot of replacements and retakes after the Odaiba completion preview—that's just between us). After watching, meeting with lab technicians in the conference room to discuss "print" adjustments. Scene 43's colors felt somewhat brownish, so I requested adjustment to sharp blue tones with good clarity, and with that all my

SW

work was complete.

When finished watching, I casually asked Kobiki-san, "How was it?" She replied, "Throughout it really felt like Tsujita-san's screen." Well, it's probably quite different

ONE PIECE

from previous movies and TV, I thought, but that's that. What Director Sakai and we created as

STRONG WORLD

is like this.

Schedules and schedules and schedules (wry laugh)—it was tough in various ways, but I think I did all the work I possibly could, left good work.

About the post-release big hit, I was surprised to the point of "it didn't need to be that big a hit (sweat)."

ONE PIECE

popularity is really incredible. I was reminded anew.

While fully aware of big hit catalyst "Volume 0" effects, having so many people watch it was still the happiest thing for production staff. And hearing that many

repeat viewers came to theaters three or four times made me even more grateful.

At the wrap party, Director Sakai said, "Someday I'd like to do another theatrical work with this staff!" All of us staff feel the same way.

■Continues to Episode 119

(10.03.23)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 119: Once Upon a Time... (67) 1994, Between TV Series and Theatrical Versions

Cherry blossoms! ...That's what I was saying last week, but Tokyo has gotten thoroughly cold again. While the bloom declaration came out, subsequent cold snaps mean even this final weekend of March still has cherry blossoms at only 20-30% bloom. The real hanami day will probably be around this weekend.

In such mood, I had a slight bicycle accident and injured my left foot, so I'm living while dragging one leg (cry). Ah, if the swelling doesn't go down soon, I won't be able to sit properly at hanami banquet seats! Heal quickly, my foot!

And come quickly, full cherry blossoms!

Now then.

1993 ended with

Sailor Moon R

movie. After completion and the wrap party, I remember taking time off and traveling to Hokkaido. I think I was around Kushiro on opening day. Wait? Which opening was that?

Sailor Moon R

?

Coo

?

That year ultimately became a theatrical work year with completing

Coo

and

Sailor Moon R

movie. Having been removed from TV series lines, I was becoming even more specialized for theatrical works.

Into 1994. My first job was again a theatrical work:

Dragon Ball Z Movie: The Galaxy at the Brink! The Super Incredible Guy

.

Script: Koyama Takao, Animation Director: Yamamuro Tadayoshi, Art Setting: Kubota Tadao, Art Director: Tokushige Masaru, and Director: Yamauchi Shigeyasu. Strictly speaking, when

Sailor Moon R

movie ended I'd already received the scenario and rough characters, but actual work began in January after New Year's.

My first

Dragon Ball Z

movie in two years. Good grief, without my knowing, the kids had multiplied!

I hadn't been involved with TV series

Dragon Ball Z

at all, so I actually hadn't watched the TV show or even properly read the original comics. That's precisely why theatrical work was always fresh for me.

But characters who'd already appeared on TV had established consensus among viewers about their colors, so naturally the theatrical version had to match TV. So I'd obtain TV color direction and begin work.

As before, TV color direction was naturally made for TV and couldn't be used as-is for theatrical works created with movie theater screens in mind. So as before, including during

Sailor Moon R

, I always did correction work on shadow balance and such when producing theatrical versions of TV series works.

It was similar this time, but I suddenly thought:

Dragon Ball Z

theatrical versions would probably continue being made at twice-yearly pace, and that work would probably come to me. In that case, wouldn't it be fine to develop theatrical-specific color approaches and development?

"That work would probably come to me"—thinking such things was arrogant, and I think "I was young" (wry laugh), but somehow I was thinking such things then. I actually was young (laugh).

That didn't mean character colors and visuals would change drastically between TV and theatrical versions—such things would be impossible while actually handling the work (laugh).

However, regarding taking on just theatrical versions of TV works where others handled basic design, there were various pressures and considerations I had to be mindful of, and regarding such personal internal problems, I strongly held such thinking to push through and clear my head.

So from around this time I openly declared—or rather proclaimed—"TV and theatrical are separate things!"

Even so, neither then nor recently have TV staff ever complained about this or that, and I put good pressure on myself thinking "I have to work solidly so they won't have complaints!"

Honestly, some TV colors had color direction that made me think "Eh? These colors are a bit..." but even including that, they were TV colors built up over long periods, and that "color" became the base for expanding worlds that became popular enough for theatrical versions. So I've always deeply respected TV series "colors" and "worlds."

And on top of that, "Let's build theatrical versions as theatrical worlds!"—that feeling remains unchanged in me even after over ten years.

■Continues to Episode 120

(10.03.30)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 11: Once Upon a Time... (8) The Treacherous Small Bottles

After returning from Seoul, Tokyo has gotten cold somehow.

What surprised me during last week's Seoul business trip was mobile phones.

I didn't know! Recent Japanese mobile phones can be used overseas!

The production staff K-san who went to Seoul with me received calls from Tokyo on his mobile phone as if nothing had happened, and emails too.

Ah, it's somehow frustrating, or rather, enviable. My mobile phone was only useful as an alarm clock in Seoul.

So I've decided to change my phone model next time I go overseas! (laughs)

...But when exactly is "next time I go overseas"? (bitter laugh)

Well then.

About paints. Did you know? Paints are "perishable goods."

I have no idea what raw materials are actually used, but cel paints would grow mold and rot.

Stack paints especially were thoroughly "perishable goods."

When you go to art supply stores in town, sometimes they sell animation cels and cel paints.

The cel paints sold there come in tiny small bottles, but for our work painting purposes, those are definitely too small (laughs). We use bigger small bottles. Glass bottles about the size of small coffee cans, or slightly shorter poly bottles with thicker circumferences, filled with paints and arranged around each person's painting desk for easy use.

These small bottles of paint sometimes set various traps waiting for us (laughs).

First, the fragrance - or rather, smell.

Cel paints had a somewhat sweet fragrance, and I loved that smell.

What was it like? You know how new vinyl products have that faintly sweet smell? It was like that. Every time we painted colors, every time we opened paint lids and stirred, the paint's fragrant smell would rise (laughs). It was a moment where I felt

just a little bit happy.

However.

Sometimes, betrayals awaited that would trample that moment of ecstasy.

"Ugh (sweat)"

That sweet fragrance would suddenly change.

The paint itself was emitting a foul odor. That smell was exactly like rotten eggs! When you come back from lunch and open paint that smells like this with a "Here we go!", honestly, it makes you cry.

Not all colors would become like this - it was more likely to happen with indigo-type NR series paints and beautiful pink PB series paints, specifically the darker colors in those ranges.

Next troublesome thing was mold.

Paints have different usage frequencies depending on color.

Depending on the works coming in at the time, colors divide into frequently used and not-so-frequently used. For some colors, it wasn't uncommon to not even open the lid for a month or so.

Then one day, when you open the lid of a color you haven't used in a while...

Fluffy.

Dense white mold covering the paint surface (laughs).

Long-haired white mold had grown. You wanted to touch that fluffiness (laughs). Since it only grew on the surface touching air, you'd press the glass rod used for stirring between the jar's inner surface and the mold, then turn it around once. Then "plop" - the mold covering the paint surface like an inner lid would come off cleanly. Since only the surface was moldy, you could just throw away that part and use the paint normally.

Incidentally, this glass rod used for stirring was a drafting tool called a "groove ruler."

Many people think it's a rod for stirring paint, but when drawing straight lines with drafting pens using rulers, you use this rod like chopsticks to draw lines.

But well, mold was still cute.

Similarly opening paint lids and trying to stir with glass rods, sometimes there would be squishy lumps on the surface.

Jellyfish-like gelatinous substances floating on the paint surface. Sometimes, like with mold, they'd cover the entire surface like an inner lid.

The cause was probably decay.

This was the troublemaker! If it had grown to cover the entire surface, you could throw away that part with a "plop" like with mold, but if you stirred the paint without noticing when it was still small and just beginning, that substance would be nicely stirred throughout the entire paint, making all the paint rot.

What happens then?

The entire paint becomes slimy to the touch, paint on brush tips starts stringing, and on cel surfaces the paint won't spread properly, making it hard to paint.

Some colors would even darken. Once it reached this state, it was over. That paint went to the trash.

Cel paints varied in condition according to each user's preferences.

Some people found it easier to paint with more moisture in a looser state, while others preferred it harder for vigorous painting. So depending on that water balance, moldiness and rotting tendencies probably varied too.

##

■Continues to Episode 12

(07.03.20)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 120: Once Upon a Time... (68) Continued: 1994

It's April, and numerous new anime programs are starting one after another, and among them are three lines of programs I'm participating in.

First is

Mary & Galy Ver. 2.0

on NHK Educational TV that started March 30th.

This is the second season of

Mary & Galy

, which had been broadcasting to great acclaim since last spring.

In the first season I could only participate in main character color design, but this season I'm deeply involved and handled color direction for most episodes. I made it with considerable enthusiasm. Yes, actually this season's broadcast content is mostly completed. That's the strength of 5-minute anime (laugh).

It broadcasts within "Science Ranger" every Tuesday at 6:55 PM. Plus reruns every Saturday at 10 AM. Both on NHK Educational TV. And even on General TV every Thursday at 4:05 PM! Wow, nationwide broadcast!

Next is

Ultra!! Mecha-Mote Chairman Second Collection

. This is also the second season of "Ultra!! Mecha-Mote Chairman" which had been broadcasting to great acclaim since last spring. Continuing from the first season, I'm participating in color design and various other roles. This second season starting April 3rd became a full 3DCG work, with background art completely renewed in style! New rival characters also appear for even more fashionable upgrade!

Broadcasting Saturdays at 9 AM on TV Tokyo network to great acclaim.

And

The Tatami Galaxy

, beginning broadcast April 22nd late night on Fuji TV's "NoitaminA"! Director Yuasa Masaaki's work—known to those who know (I think?). I handled color design and color direction for the first episode. I've participated in quite various anime over the years, but wow, this is a first of its type. Every episode during

all-rushes, I forget to check the screen and get completely absorbed watching (laugh).

Please support all three of these series!

Now then.

Dragon Ball Z Movie: The Galaxy at the Brink! The Super Incredible Guy

. Working with Director Yamauchi for the first time in two years since

Crying Freeman 5: The Battlefield Demon

. This was my first

Dragon Ball

with Yamauchi-san.

My first

Dragon Ball Z

theatrical in two years myself. Goten, Trunks, Videl—starting by grasping characters who'd multiplied while I wasn't looking. Hm? And Broly too? Apparently he'd appeared as a theatrical original character around the previous year. I heard this was a character who appeared in Yamauchi-san's directed work.

For now, I obtained color direction from TV series team and materials room to create color samples for this theatrical version. As I wrote last time, since I was plotting to develop colors as theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

, I built up Goku, Vegeta, Piccolo and others based on theatrical color direction from when I'd handled them before, and also organized and corrected regular characters like Goten and Trunks appearing from this time in my approach as "theatrical basic color direction" while considering future prospects.

Goten is basically the same as Goku, so mostly the same color direction. For Trunks, TV color direction had almost no difference between normal and shadow hair, so I made normal colors somewhat brighter and adjusted shadow colors so hair color could be felt. Then I strengthened overall shadow color density (brightness) for better contrast.

And then these guys also become Super Saiyans and such (wry laugh).

Super Saiyan apparently means energy built up inside the body wells up and overflows from inside to outside. So I imagined something like those human-shaped mannequins in department store women's underwear sections with lightbulbs inside, where the whole body glows from within. I brightened character

colors overall and didn't drop shadow colors deeply—rather set them bright with almost no difference feeling. On top of that, I set the slightly animated secondary shadows slightly darker to aim for character muscle three-dimensionality.

And Broly. This was senior Sakamoto Yoko-san's work from his previous appearance. She handled colors for works like

Magical Taruruuto-kun

, so pastel color usage was her characteristic. I remade this toward my approach—or rather my style—for this work, but since this character had already been released once, I couldn't go completely 180 degrees opposite colors. While glaring at the original and seeking more powerful volume, I tried creating a new Broly.

Yamauchi director's works are first and foremost "light acting." Between the director and me, theatrical

Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth

serves as one standard, and this

The Galaxy at the Brink! The Super Incredible Guy

is no different. So when light is emitted, recipients always receive it—characters and spaces surrounding characters change in color and shadow under that light's influence.

This time too was packed with "technique" light acting that Broly manipulates, plus "Kamehameha waves" surpassing that. Anyway, preparing 2-3 types of materials and overlapping, doubling, making them glow with supers and transmitted light—using every possible technique.

What materials should be prepared to achieve such footage? Each time working with Yamauchi director, I became more knowledgeable about photography techniques. Eventually I ended up adding quite a lot of photography instructions from my end, and photography staff's work gradually becoming quite demanding became fairly normal.

The cel and film full analog era. Moreover, complex photography takes that much more time, and you can't reshoot many times. Even preparing materials meticulously for shooting often didn't achieve intended screens. Each time requesting retakes, or having to give "OK" even with slightly different nuances.

In today's digital era, you can simulate on your own computer monitor, so screens can generally be built to strike zone feeling, but 1994 was still an era with no hint of such a convenient world's arrival.

■Continues to Episode 121

(10.04.06)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 121: Once Upon a Time... 69 - 1994 Part 3 - Celebration! Overseas! The First Step

Tokyo is cold! It's April! What's with this cold weather!

Like most people, we've already washed and put away our winter down coats at home. But with this winter-wave coldness, should we respond with winter clothes? I thought about it, but no no, let's endure with spring layering! I'm being somewhat stubborn (laugh). I wonder how long this cold will continue?

Meanwhile, due to Iceland's volcanic eruption effects, European air travel seems to be in chaos. With flights getting canceled across the board, my heart goes out to everyone whose travel plans got blown away.

Speaking of which, when my wife and I went to Greece for our honeymoon, our Athens flight from Santorini Island in the Aegean Sea was canceled due to strong winds. Since we'd arranged the trip without going through agencies, we had to handle everything ourselves, and I remember struggling with airport counter staff in unfamiliar English. We hastily got ferry tickets and somehow made it to Athens.

Santorini Island's wharf battered by big waves, with waiting areas like refugee camps. It was packed with dejected tourists. Next to us a French couple was making phone calls frantically on their mobile. Apparently they couldn't make their Athens to Paris flight so were trying to change it, but that didn't work out either, and I vividly remember them getting into a subtle argument.

Both this Tokyo low temperature and Iceland's volcanic eruption are natural phenomena we can do nothing about. At times like this, ah, humans really are tiny, I think. But if humanity could control such nature, that would feel wrong somehow too.

Now then.

Dragon Ball Z Movie: The Galaxy at the Brink! The Super Incredible Guy

was completed by forcing through with strength at the end as usual. The latter half was indeed built through in-between animation and finishing orders to Korean and Chinese companies. So about half the total was painted with Taiyo Shikisai (■■■■) paints. I'd become quite skilled at Taiyo color direction and retake handling.

However, Taiyo paints' weak color reproduction remained problematic, and for colors too difficult to convert from STAC to Taiyo, rather than forcing conversion, I sent STAC paints to those companies and had them paint in STAC colors.

This considerably improved both screen quality and work efficiency, making me think "If needed, this whole approach could work for all Korean and Chinese orders."

During production of

The Galaxy at the Brink! The Super Incredible Guy

in February, I received a certain directive from the company. It was a business trip to "EEI-TOEI" in Manila, Philippines.

EEI-TOEI ANIMATION CORPORATION—this was a joint venture between Toei Animation and Manila's local EEI Group, established to handle in-between animation and finishing work for Toei Animation productions. The remaining half of this

The Galaxy at the Brink! The Super Incredible Guy

was worked on here.

Incidentally, as of 2010, EEI-TOEI has become a subsidiary of Toei Animation and is now "TOEI ANIMATION PHILIPPINES."

Senior staff had made several long-term business trips to this EEI-TOEI for technical guidance on actual work, but at this point when things had stabilized somewhat, the painting retake rate just wouldn't go down. So the trip's purpose was "inspection" and "actual work guidance" to investigate causes.

"Eh? Tsujita-kun, Manila is your first overseas?" laughed a certain interpreter from the overseas production team, somewhat amazed (wry laugh). Yes, this Manila trip was indeed my first overseas experience. Actually, I'd somehow obtained a passport when

Coo

ended, but this was truly the first time using that passport. While there were Japanese staff stationed locally, the trip there and back was basically solo travel.

As soon as

The Galaxy at the Brink! The Super Incredible Guy

was completed, preparation for the business trip began. Since the stay was several days, no particular visa was needed. The interpreter gave me detailed lectures on airport procedures and such. I received an envelope with local living expenses and business trip allowances.

Furthermore, "Don't exchange money at the hotel! The rates are bad. Definitely do some at the airport, then you can do it at 'Shoe Mart' near the studio." Hm? "Shoe Mart"? What's that? There were many things I didn't understand, but "ask

Soya-kun and Tachisen-kun when you get there."

Going and returning, luggage included not just personal items but aluminum trunks packed full with work cuts. Multiple ones. Besides work luggage, there were also large quantities of souvenirs for local and stationed staff. Carrying that massive luggage, at Manila airport I'd have to handle customs procedures and such. In English too. This was a bit nerve-wracking.

English from middle school through university—reading and writing were reasonably okay, but conversation was almost unknown territory. This was completely away territory, different from using broken English with foreigners in Japan. And the local accommodation was also a local hotel. Naturally Japanese seemed impossible there too. Ah, English. I should have studied more seriously.

Departure was March 14th. 5 AM from Oizumi Studio. With heavy luggage by taxi to Hakozaki's TCAT. Transfer there to limousine bus to Narita Airport. JAL flight from Terminal 2.

Ah, first Narita Airport (laugh). Scenery I'd seen in TV dramas was there. And me getting flustered (laugh). I somehow managed safe check-in. Passed immigration and became an airborne person. Then takeoff.

After a flight of just under five hours, I arrived in Manila. Getting off the plane, completing various procedures, collecting checked luggage and loading it on a cart to move. Passing between security guards equipped with automatic rifles, proceeding through long underground passages. Then outside to the lobby.

Whoosh! Tropical heat, crowds of Manila people with different skin colors, mysterious languages flying about. "Ah, foreign country!" I was overwhelmed and held my breath at that scene.

■Continues to Episode 122

(10.04.16)

Color Design Notes [Tsuji Kunitada]

Episode 122: Once Upon a Time... 70 - 1994 Part 4 - What! A Bus to "Higashikurume Station"!

At last,

The Tatami Galaxy

began last week (Tokyo area). Did everyone get a chance to watch? For me personally, this is my first NoitaminA slot since

Graveyard Kitaro

two years ago, and I'm hoping for the kind of excitement we had with

Graveyard Kitaro

.

Probably readers of this WEB Anime Style who regularly watch anime will watch it, but I especially want people who don't usually watch much anime to see it.

The Tatami Galaxy

is a work I especially want such people to watch. I'd love for office ladies and such to watch it too.

So everyone reading this, please spread word-of-mouth promotion to "general" audiences! Rather than ratings concerns, our feeling focuses on one point: having as many people as possible watch what we're creating.

So this week is Episode 2, "Film Club 'Misogi'." This week too, please support us! Please look forward to it!!

Now then.

March 14, 1994, Manila. Stepping outside the freezingly air-conditioned airport lobby, there was a tremendous number of people's unfamiliar language clamor, deafening car horn floods, and joke-like muggy heat.

"Hmm, foreign country!"

I stood dazed for a while pushing a cart loaded with luggage. Local people gathered around me like that. They seemed to be taxi drivers. Among "Taxi" words mercilessly showered on me was mixed "Shacho-san, Taxi wa?" "!" Mixed with local Tagalog and English was incredibly suspicious Japanese (laugh). I mean, who's the company president? (laugh)

Then, "Ah, Tsujita-san! Over here!" came a properly solid Japanese voice. It was Soya-san, a locally stationed Japanese staff member who'd come to meet me at the airport, and Palabrica-san from EEI-TOEI staff who'd been in Japan for extended training. After brief reunion greetings, we got in a car and left the heavily congested airport arrival area. "How is it? The Philippines (laugh)" said Soya-san. "How, or rather, what can I say..." I replied. I heard the airport arrival exit is generally always that crowded. In the heavily air-conditioned car interior, my sweat finally subsided.

The car ran through Manila's center to Quezon City adjacent to Manila City. The EEI-TOEI studio was along West Avenue there. West Avenue felt somewhat removed from downtown bustle, fairly residential. Ah, in Tokyo terms, it's like running through Ginza or Shinjuku and ending up in Nerima's Oizumi (laugh). Even in Manila, anime studios are built in similar places—I was strangely convinced.

The studio was an old single-story building. How to put it—somewhat different from a factory, and not modern either. Like a warehouse attached to a larger private house that had been expanded and remodeled onto that house—if I had to say, it gave a "town factory" impression. Right inside the gate was an entrance with one guard uncle carrying a pistol at his waist. When we pulled out the heavy aluminum cases from Tokyo from the car, local staff who came out to meet us carried them in. And I was reunited with Tachisen-san, another Japanese staff member. After handing over souvenirs for both, Palabrica appeared again. "Tsujita-san (←this was in Japanese), Now, we'll go to the hotel."

Hastily into the car again. I was taken to the hotel where I'd stay. The hotel I was taken to was reasonably nice, but ah, Japanese probably won't work here, I thought. Anyway, even the front desk had no Japanese-speaking staff, making me nervous again. I'll probably be at the studio most of the time and just come back to sleep, so it'll be fine! I half-convinced myself. After being shown to a twin room and putting down luggage, another car ride back to the studio.

On the way to the studio, I kept watching roadside scenes and traffic flow. Shop and building signs everywhere displayed Japanese and American company names and Japanese product advertisements. I'd sort of heard about this, but seeing it firsthand felt strange. If this were Japanese text, wouldn't you momentarily think it was Japan?

Passing cars were mostly Japanese, with occasional Korean or American makes. Jeepneys—shared mini-buses that are the local people's "legs," or rather like covered small trucks—were running around quite a bit. And what really surprised me were the route buses. Japanese route buses were actually running! Not Japanese-made buses—actual Japanese buses. Seibu buses with displays like "To Higashikurume Station" were running as-is.

Perhaps as part of Japan's Southeast Asian aid, used buses that had gotten old in Japan were transported to this country and running actively in current service. Since Japan and the Philippines naturally have opposite traffic lanes, what they'd done was suddenly switch doors and driver seats left-right. Glass on doors that became fixed and couldn't open still had "automatic door" text remaining... This was quite a culture shock for me. Such things weren't much reported or discussed in Japan.

Watching such Manila scenes made me feel strange. The

Dragon Ball

and

Sailor Moon

I'd brought today—Japanese anime gets painted in places like this, created in places like this.

While I was lost in such thoughts, the car arrived at the studio. Now, finally a full studio tour. It would be my first meeting with local staff.

■Continues to Episode 123

(10.04.27)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 123: Once Upon a Time... 71 - 1994 Part 5 - Zun Zun Jaka Jaka!

Tokyo is early summer. Day after day of clear skies with refreshing air continues, and beer tastes good (laugh).

Every year from this season through summer, I'm active from around 5 AM. Oh, not staying up all night—living by waking up at 4 or 5 AM. Yes, I've become a proper "morning person."

This early morning time period is quiet, the air feels good, and my head is clear, so thinking and work—whatever I do progresses efficiently and smoothly. It's a magic time period. This is wonderful. Waking up around this time, days can be used incredibly long without staying up late.

TV series-centered life progresses in weekly cycles with fixed schedules—like Wednesday for editing, Monday for dubbing and recording, Thursday for video editing to delivery. So this combination of "day-of-week based" daily life and being a "morning person" is strongest. They match very well.

But when it's the night before delivering episodes that are absolutely down to the wire, you can't say such things, and "morning person" becomes "until morning" work—that's troublesome.

Well, working hard like that for

The Tatami Galaxy

—last week was Episode 4 "Seeking Disciples" broadcast. And this week is Episode 5 "Softball Club 'Honwaka'" broadcast.

The production is already in the thick of the second half. Running toward the finale and DVD extras.

Thanks to everyone, ratings are gradually rising! This week too, please support us! Please look forward to it!!

Now then.

"Zun zun ja! Zun zun jaka jan! Zun zun jaka jaka!" Loudly lively music overflows from the radio. This is EEI-TOEI Studio's Second Studio, the trace room.

EEI-TOEI Studio was along a street called West Avenue in Quezon City. This area had a fairly leisurely residential feeling, and while West Avenue itself had reasonable traffic, along the street were scattered shops, restaurants, gas stations and such. This vicinity also had former US military residential areas.

Incidentally, at the north end of this West Avenue was a huge shopping market. This was "Shoe Mart." Huge building with huge parking lot. Complete with cinema complex and huge food court underground—a huge commercial facility.

The studio was divided into First and Second. About 100 meters apart along the same street, and while my memory is quite unreliable, I believe the Second Studio was larger and mainly for finishing work. Animation (in-between) and backgrounds were at the First Studio, I think. Hm? Which had the resident Japanese staff room? I think this was also at the Second. Guided by resident staff Soya-san and Tachisen-san, I toured the studio.

The work flow at EEI-TOEI Studio then was that luggage (key animation and in-between animation) collected at Tokyo Nerima's Oizumi Studio the previous day would arrive at Manila studio every evening. EEI-TOEI production staff would sort it. Key animation to in-between animation staff, completed in-between animation to finishing. Since background work was already being done in Manila, background-bound luggage was also carried to the background team. These were cross-referenced with invoices faxed from Tokyo in advance, with priority controlled according to schedule situations.

Since regular shipping would result in next-day arrival, business travelers from Tokyo like me arrive in Manila in half a day, so they happily load us up with massive hand-carried luggage.

So, completed in-between animation first gets packed into cut bags. These cut bags were Toei Animation specification, but the products themselves were Manila-made. Made by local companies here. Everything except special professional tools and dedicated equipment was locally Philippine-made. I think there were such laws? Cost-wise that was definitely better anyway.

After once confirming color direction was applied through "inspection," they go to "machine trace."

Equipment was trace machines from Josai Duplo brought from Japan. These transferred in-between animation to cels via carbon transfer. Actually these trace machines often malfunctioned. Even with normal use in Tokyo, regular maintenance like glass tube cleaning and lamp replacement was necessary. Using them intensively in hot, humid Manila naturally led to frequent malfunctions and breakdowns, so manufacturer staff regularly traveled to Manila studio for maintenance. Incidentally, "raw cels" were Japanese-made. Sent from Tokyo by ship along with painting supplies and such.

After "machine trace" came "trace." Color trace work for machine line corrections and shadow highlights. And this "Zun zun ja! Zun zun jaka jan! Zun zun jaka jaka!" room was the trace team's room.

About 10 staff were working in this noisy room. Most were male. Working so enjoyably while this radio blared was impressive. People chatting energetically while tracing, people quietly tracing in their own world. Japanese studios play radio during work too, but not at this incredible volume. Quite a light culture shock.

Next was "painting." The sight of painting desks with supply shelves lined up was the same here in Manila. Desks were naturally Manila-made. Not as much as trace, but here too everyone worked with reasonably loud radio music flowing. Many male staff here too. In Japanese domestic studios, finishing tends to center on female staff, but here males were vigorously painting.

"Painting" operated 24 hours with day and night shifts in two rotations. How many people were there? Even just the day shift had over 20 people, I think. Day and night shifts weren't fixed members but rotational shifts. Anyway, operating 24 hours meant continuous painting completion. Incidentally, trace and inspection had someone on night duty daily, but not full two-shift systems.

In principle, cuts worked on by day shift were finished by day shift and sent to inspection. So for work efficiency, cuts often involved multiple staff divisions. Few-frame cuts were painted by one person, but 40-50+ frame cuts were systematically approached by multiple people to ensure quick completion.

Painting's biggest bottleneck is "drying wait." It inevitably takes time for painted colors to properly dry. To ensure quick completion, everyone painting at once is the better method.

After painting came "inspection."

Oh, before that, cuts with brush or touch instructions went to "Special Effects" for work.

"Inspection" checked painted results, and checked cuts were packed daily after noon for Tokyo shipment. Since night shift painting completions were loaded first thing in the morning, mornings were quite busy.

About 10 "inspection" staff. Members carefully selected and promoted from painting staff. Naturally mostly women here. Each member handled assigned works, and they handled Tokyo inquiries about unclear color direction areas, local trace and painting questions, and coordination across multiple cuts and painting methods.

You can't do finishing inspection without properly understanding trace and painting. So it's promotion of excellent staff from painting. When establishing the Manila studio, those technical and systematic aspects were first properly considered and structured. While theatrical works get reinspected in Tokyo, for Toei Animation handling multiple TV production lines, cels from Manila studio had to reach levels where they could go directly to photography.

Thus shipped luggage would be delivered to Oizumi the next afternoon.

"Hi, Tsujita-san, ■■▼×■●■!"

Filipino staff were all impossibly cheerful, speaking to me with smiles. But I don't understand! (wry laugh) English would be manageable somehow, but local Tagalog was completely hopeless, so I could only respond with my best strained smile (wry laugh).

Rooms naturally had air conditioning, but unlike Tokyo's crisp air conditioning air, it was cold enough to be chilly yet somehow had lingering humidity. Outside was suddenly over 30 degrees, but indoors was cooled maximally by air conditioning. This was quite hard on me, but everyone here seemed fine. Their body construction is different after all.

Strangely, trace and painting teams wore fairly casual clothing. T-shirts and shorts, tank tops and jeans, some even shirtless in shorts. All of them wore white gloves while working. Those white gloves on somewhat dark Filipino skin were quite striking.

While individual, everyone seemed uniformly happy. I'd never seen people so happily doing trace, painting, and inspection in Japan.

Well, having toured the finishing department overall, various problems requiring improvement were visible everywhere. So now I had to talk to all staff about those problems.

■■Continues to Episode 124

(10.05.18)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 124: Early Summer Special Edition -

The Tatami Galaxy

Notes for Color Direction Staff

Eh? Rain that seems like early rainy season continues in Tokyo. Still, once it clears, refreshing May winds. My, beer tastes good. ←That again? (laugh)

Now then.

The Tatami Galaxy

currently broadcasting on Fuji TV's Thursday late-night "Noitamina" and other slots since April. I'm participating as color designer, and to great acclaim, this week's broadcast is already Episode 6 (Kanto area). We've reached exactly the halfway point of all 11 episodes.

So this time I'll write a bit about

The Tatami Galaxy

. Title: "

The Tatami Galaxy

Notes for Color Direction Staff."

Since work overview for

The Tatami Galaxy

has been specially featured and introduced on "WEB Anime Style," I'll omit that here and direct you there (laugh).

I first received this job offer during the thick of

STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM

last autumn. I met Director Yuasa for the first time in November, and at that meeting we had rough discussions about character "colors."

"Simple. I want to keep it simple without using too many colors. Same with backgrounds—like putting one pop of color in black and white. And basically, no shadows."

That was Director Yuasa's first order. As character concepts, there were colored illustrations by Nakamura Yusuke, and based on those, Character Designer Ito Nobuyoshi rewrote them for animation. I received those character line art, and ah,

they were truly simple!

Actually, I'd never done works with art styles this simple. I'd done a similarly simple character work called

Neighborhood Story

on TV quite a while back, but while those were simple line art, they had outfit changes every episode and were colorful—a work pursuing "fashion" above all. The complete opposite of this

Tatami Galaxy

.

Anyway, limiting colors, reducing color separation as much as possible, while picking up the original illustration atmosphere—those became those characters. Particularly protagonist "I" really came together with a "black and white" feeling.

Then Episode 1 began. I also handled color direction for Episode 1. "Ah, I see!" While working, various things gradually became visible. We tend to increase color count inevitably. By suppressing that, you can instead create various "colors" across entire scenes—or rather entire screens. Hmm, a bit abstract?

Based on Episode 1 impressions, I convey that "atmosphere" to color direction staff from Episode 2 onward.

For

The Tatami Galaxy

, once storyboards are complete, each episode's director centers meetings with the overall director, Art Director Uehara Shinichi, and me as color designer for "art board meetings." Once boards get general OK, art staff and color direction staff for each episode join "art board meeting" members for "art meetings." This art meeting also serves as color direction meeting, but after each scene's color design is complete, I have separate "color direction meetings" with color direction staff.

Various "notes" I conveyed to color direction staff during meetings. First, "simple." Props colors should all lean toward backgrounds. When animation shadows appear by scene, all borders should be wide gradation blend processing. And so on.

And among these, the most important note was "mob character silhouette processing." Oh, "mob characters" means passersby, shop customers—well, "everyone else" characters.

Those who've watched this work probably noticed we boldly use silhouette processing extensively. Like Episode 1's tennis scene, things "simplified" from

animation stage are naturally designed with such screen intent, but other so-called "properly thoroughly animated" mob characters—we're doing quite bold things with "color." In most cases we do "single color flat painting" and such. Truly "simple." And this becomes quite important visual processing.

This work centers on "I," and we're basically watching that "I's" muttering from relatively close to "I"—that's the basic stance I consider. This "I" isn't very interested in things (people) not directly related to him currently. So we make them "silhouettes." By doing so, acting related to "I" becomes clear with "colors." Well, thinking such things, I ended up with that kind of "silhouette processing."

Color direction staff were apparently quite bewildered initially. We color direction staff have habits like "wanting to separate colors for things animated to be properly color-separated." With fairly realistic works common recently, having such animation before you naturally makes you want to add detailed colors. Then I'd say "one color is fine," and color direction staff naturally react "Eh? But... is that okay? Really just one color?" (laugh).

But when we actually tried single-color painting on animation cuts and showed them placed on backgrounds, everyone understood with "Ah, I see!" Incidentally, "what color to use for single-color painting" involves roughly explaining the target screen, then leaving it to color direction staff.

As always, my scene-by-scene color design is strictly framework, strictly blueprints. Color direction staff face actual cuts and handle actual key animation and director instructions. Moreover, this work has many cuts with non-designed key animation matching and special animation cuts coming up quite different from designs, plus various individual director instructions. I provide direction like "please unify in this feeling," and consider various things together with color direction staff, but how to cook that up depends on color direction staff's sense.

So please enjoy

The Tatami Galaxy

with that "color" aspect as one highlight too.

■Continues to Episode 125

(10.05.25)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 125: Once Upon a Time... 72 - 1994 Part 6 - Meeting! What Were the Results?

The asteroid probe "Hayabusa" is coming home! Ever since hearing that news, I'd been sending encouragement to Hayabusa flying alone through the solar system toward Earth.

And last Sunday late night, it finally returned to Earth. I watched that on Ustream broadcast. Hayabusa, returning after completing its long, long journey of about 6 billion kilometers. Having overcome countless hardships and returned battered all over, I don't think I was alone in seeing

Space Battleship Yamato

in that figure. Ah, well, I'm that generation (laugh).

I saw several movies that amateurs (?) had created visualizing Hayabusa's difficult journey, and several used

Yamato

as BGM. They all matched magnificently! Wonderful!

Space Battleship Yamato

music seems to connect stories with our feelings like this.

Hayabusa returned to Earth but sadly burned up in the atmosphere. At the very end, it photographed Earth and scattered away. Ah, what a story that shook Japanese hearts.

I think about this stuff. While our job is creating various "stories" for people to watch, we really can't beat real stories like Hayabusa's.

Hayabusa's fireball burning up during atmospheric reentry was more magnificent and beautiful than any CG imagery.

Now, changing topics,

The Tatami Galaxy

currently broadcasting to great acclaim. In the Kanto area, this week is Episode 9 "Secret Organization 'Lucky Cat Chinese Restaurant'" broadcast. Including this week, only three episodes remain. Everyone, please support us! Please look forward to it!

Now then.

March 1994. EEI-TOEI Studio in Manila, Philippines.

With general inspection complete, now for our approach. Regarding several observed problems, to solve them, we decided to gather all staff for meetings. This was the biggest mission assigned to me for this business trip.

The biggest problem with painted results from EEI-TOEI Studio was "dirt." Much dirt was observed on transparent cel parts. Most common among that dirt was paint spattering. Plus fingerprint or palm print attachment.

Technical precision of painting itself—mistakes, overruns and such—has some variation anywhere, domestically or abroad. Particularly for TV works, some degree of problems can be overlooked, but transparent parts coming up dirty was quite problematic.

These fingerprints and palm prints really stood out on dark backgrounds. The production lineup then centered on

Dragon Ball Z

and

Sailor Moon

. Battle scenes and image scenes increased dark background scenes, and fingerprints and palm prints would appear white on screen during battles.

For theatrical or video works, we reinspect cels before photography, so we cleanly wipe fingerprints at that point, but for TV series, Manila painted results basically went straight to photography, so after shooting when rushes came up and we watched previews it was like "Oh no!"...

Naturally this problem was conveyed to Manila studio repeatedly with requests for attention, and while attention would improve things momentarily, after a bit they'd return to the original state. So investigating why this happened and implementing improvement measures was my mission.

Observing their actual work, I understood—they do wear painting gloves during work, but watching them, they'd carelessly press cels with their arms without thinking. Naturally short sleeves meant direct skin contact. Or the hand holding brushes wore gloves, but the opposite hand holding paint bottles was bare skin. When warned they'd properly wear gloves then, but look away briefly and they're working bare-handed again (wry laugh).

So it was ultimately a consciousness problem. Why must you wear gloves? They'd comply when told, but didn't properly understand reasons. Some staff didn't necessarily equate "job of painting cels" with "job of creating anime screens." For example, if this were domestic Japan, they could watch their work's final form on

TV broadcasts, which might naturally raise consciousness, but unfortunately what they're currently making can't be watched in Manila. Ah, this is difficult.

Still, somehow including such aspects had to be understood. So, meetings.

The biggest problem here was "language barriers." While I'd talk endlessly in Japanese, English was absolutely hopeless. Reading and writing sentences were generally okay, and I mostly understood what others said, but speaking from my end was weak. I'd try composing English in my head and get mini-panicked. Ah, pitiful child of exam English (wry laugh). I never took English conversation classes or such.

But no problem! Soya-san and Tachisen-san stationed at this studio were already solid with English, so I asked them to interpret meetings. Having my speech somehow skillfully translated. Three meetings were set up between studio delivery schedules. First, one with inspection staff. Based on content exchanged there, one with trace team + painting team, then one with painting team night shift.

I first met with inspection staff because they actually manage cel quality, and I thought they probably had various thoughts too. Points I noticed while touring and trying some work together were probably understood by everyone, and they might have problem points they were more concerned about than me, who could only stay briefly. Exchanging opinions from that perspective and organizing points might make various things penetrate even better to everyone.

So, opinion exchange.

Everyone seemed to understand what I wanted to say, and various opinions emerged during discussion—it was interesting. Conversely, I got various opinions about Tokyo studio color direction methods and inquiry responses, which revealed many things we needed to improve too.

Next, meetings with trace and painting staff. Honestly, initially they probably just thought "What's this guy?" or "Annoying guy from Tokyo" (laugh), but talking gradually got through to them with individual differences. Various opinions and requests emerged here too—interesting.

Three meetings like that, talking extensively for about 4+ hours total. Quite an intense experience.

Then I departed for home. Return luggage was two aluminum cases so packed full the lids wouldn't properly close. Over 60 kilograms. At the airport counter I persistently negotiated overcharge fees in Japanese-mixed English conversation (wry laugh), still paid considerable amounts, and somehow boarded the Tokyo-bound JAL flight.

After that, how much did the business trip results achieve? Not dramatically, but still some improvement occurred. But three months later, during my next theatrical work's crunch, similar situations would repeat (laugh).

■Continues to Episode 126

(10.06.15)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 126: About

NOX

The rainy season has arrived, and I'm suffering from the daily mugginess. The most challenging season of the year has come.

My new weapon for this year's rainy season is long pants. Translated into Japanese, that's "suteteko." My wife bought me several for my birthday present this year. Various print patterns, somewhat fashionable and cute ones. I wear these in my home work room. Oh, I definitely don't wear them outside (laugh).

Made from smooth materials and reaching just below the knees, they properly cover sweat-prone areas like behind the knees. They absorb sweat quite well. These "fashionable suteteko" really work!

I'm writing this manuscript today in such "fashionable suteteko" attire (laugh). I wonder if these will become trendy this summer? I'd be happy if they did.

Now then.

"Tsujita-san, here! Sorry to keep you waiting," the director personally handed me a white box DVD the other day. Oh right, completed version samples distributed to production staff are called "white boxes." These used to be distributed as unmarked white case home video tapes, hence "white box." These days they're usually DVDs.

Do you know the anime

Wakfu

? It's an animation currently broadcasting to great acclaim on French TV. The story is otherworld adventure? A children's work. Production is ANKAMA ANIMATION. A French company. Made based on Flash. Actually last year, I participated in what was essentially a "side story" of this

Wakfu

. That was

NOX

(original title "Special Episode NOXIMILIEN").

The director is Choi Eun-Young. Storyboard, direction, and partial key animation are also by Eun-Young. Oh right, Eun-Young is this kind of person.

I first worked with Eun-Young on

Casshern Sins

#20, and we somehow hit it off (laugh). So I was invited to this

NOX

.

Character design is by Yuasa Masaaki, animation director is Mihara Michio, art is by Santiago-san who is French. And I'm in charge of color design. Incidentally, color direction is by Akimoto Yuki-san, who's also working hard on

Tatami Galaxy

. The original

Wakfu

is Flash animation, but this

NOX

is full hand-drawn 2D animation.

I joined last summer. Right during

STRONG WORLD

production, working in parallel. I was handed character designs and told "It's Yuasa-san's design," and I remember thinking "Heh, that Yuasa-san." Two months later I'd meet him for the first time on

Tatami Galaxy

(laugh). That was also my first time meeting Animation Director Mihara-san. Since I'd been reading Mihara-san's Anime Style columns, I was actually quite nervous when first meeting him (laugh).

The production studio is Arai Yakushi. Actually ANKAMA's Japanese studio is located here. It's incredibly close to my home, and every time I passed by I'd think "What's this stylish office?" This lovely building has Japanese and French staff working together. Plus Eun-Young is Korean, making it an incredibly global studio.

French animators also participated in this

NOX

, including Art's Santiago-san and composite staff (ah, sorry, I forgot the name (sweat))—also French. When everyone gathered in the conference room for meetings, English became the common language. The director personally

interpreted (laugh).

My work started as usual with character color design, first creating a "how about this?" proposal with me, Eun-Young, and Mihara-san. Then we'd show it to French staff for their opinions. Since it's a work broadcasting in France, their opinions were important. And this was quite interesting.

We "Far East Asia group" and the French people had quite different color sensibilities. Plus their sense of ethnic things was very different from ours. Ah, I see, very European. Various races and ethnicities are routinely everywhere, and not about discrimination—there are various historical concerns.

Opinions erupted particularly about clothing colors. Since they're "family," I'd coordinated colors so parents and children looked like the same colors, but "a clan wearing same-colored clothes becomes too much of a chosen people ideological visual." I see—when cultures differ, feelings about such things are so different too.

Listening well to such opinions, I reconstructed. Finally the director decided "We'll go with this!" and based on those basic colors, I proceeded with each scene's color design.

This work's obsession on the animation side was "line expression." With ordinary 2D works we make, everything starts by digitally binarizing line art, but doing that inevitably makes lines hard and thin, losing the swell, thickness—essentially "line expression"—that pencil drawings possess.

How to create screens that utilize that "line expression" while being digital painted, so-called 2D anime screens? Trying various methods, we arrived at laying raw line art that wasn't binarized over painted material with binarized lines during photography. Main line colors were also calculated and decided to match this technique. It demonstrated wonderful effects on beautiful backgrounds.

Production continued until the very end of last year, and Eun-Young took completed footage to France. After dubbing and sound work, it was completed early this spring. There was a completion preview at ANKAMA-JAPAN's Araiakushi studio, but both Yuasa-san and I couldn't attend due to

Tatami Galaxy

meetings. So with this white box I received, I could watch the sound-complete version for the first time.

Wow, good feeling. It became better screens than we aimed for. While

Wakfu

is for children, this

NOX

seems aimed at slightly older demographics. It's a somewhat scary story. The screen is also heavy and frightening. I'm slightly worried whether small children watching

Wakfu

might get traumatized (laugh).

I think the main feature movie will officially appear on ANKAMA's site eventually, but currently only trailer movies can be watched. The main feature might also be on YouTube? Those curious might try searching. Oh, incidentally, it's in French (laugh).

Now, that Eun-Young participates in

Tatami Galaxy

Episode 10 "Four-and-a-Half Tatami Idealist" for storyboard and direction. It broadcasts this week in Kanto. Everyone please support it. Please look forward to it!

■Continues to Episode 127

(10.06.22)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 127: All 11 Episodes Were Battle Episodes!

The Tatami Galaxy

Complete!

Writing this manuscript in the evening of June's final day, ah, half of this year has already ended today. Tomorrow begins this year's second half.

Ah, so fast (sweat).

Getting older, the flow of days really becomes too fast. It's becoming a standard complaint, but "it was just New Year's..."

The Tatami Galaxy

, which started in April, already has its final episode broadcasting this week (Kanto area)!

Hmm, too fast (sweat). There's definitely an accelerating trend year by year. Ah, will next year be even faster...?

Now then.

After about three nights of all-night work,

The Tatami Galaxy

final Episode 11 was completed the other morning. A Director Yuasa storyboard & direction episode. Truly an "all-out battle!" episode.

The Tatami Galaxy

is hereby complete.

Unfortunately it hasn't aired yet so I'll refrain from detailed content discussion, but watching the full-length sound all-rushes before video editing, I got a bit emotional. Having stayed close to "I" throughout and created colors for "I's" story, I probably ended up feeling like "I." With final rushes completed, giving OK to the old book fair "I" and Akashi-san cuts and completing the master. Going home, I cried a little.

One-cour TV series (especially this

Tatami Galaxy

with all 11 episodes) really is over in a flash—short. During my Toei days I mostly participated in long TV works lasting a year or more, so that short feeling is especially pronounced.

But being short with few episodes, everything was unquestionably a "battle episode." Long works continuing 3-4 cours have weaker episodes due to series composition pacing. But this

Tatami Galaxy

had all 11 battle episodes. While various things happened, all 11 episodes felt like everyone gave their all.

Having fought through such 11 battle episodes, I'm quite spaced out now. Ah, I can't get my hands on other work (sweat). I want to rest just two more days, at least until the final episode broadcast ends... Ah, eh? That's not allowed? Hmm.

Well, feeling somewhat "spaced out" like that, this week is extremely short.

Oh, Thursday late night "Noitamina" this week apparently has broadcast time moved back 10 minutes, so be careful. There are final episode-specific devices, so please look forward to it. Everyone, please support us until the end.

■Continues to Episode 128

(10.06.30)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 128: Once Upon a Time... 73 - 1994 Part 7 -

Dragon Ball Z

Blues

The other day, I actually bought reading glasses! When I went shopping at Muji in Ikebukuro Seibu, they were selling lightweight, affordable, somewhat fashionable ones, and I couldn't help picking them up.

Yes, actually I'm developing presbyopia. Well, not just me—quite a lot of anime industry colleagues in their 40s are getting presbyopia at considerable pace. Man, presbyopia comes on suddenly!

I noticed it about three years ago on a certain day. Somehow I couldn't instantly shift eye focus well anymore, and it became difficult to focus on close things. Initially, I didn't realize that was presbyopia. When I happened to discuss "my eyes lately..." with work colleagues of the same generation, they said "Ah, that's presbyopia." Shock!

Well, that's why I finally bought them, but man, frustrating as it is, these are great. I can see incredibly well. At that moment, it felt like one era quietly ended within me (cry).

Now then.

Continuing the 1994 story.

Returning from the Manila business trip, my next job was waiting. My second theatrical work of the year:

Dragon Ball Z Movie: Super Warriors Defeated!! I'm the One Who'll Win

. Director was Ueda Yoshihiro. Animation Director was Yamamuro-san continuing from the previous work, and Art Director was also Tokushige-san, same as before.

My fourth

Dragon Ball Z

. Writing this might get me in trouble, but I was actually getting slightly tired of

Dragon Ball Z

.

Sure, it's theatrical work after all, so under the director I was working hard on the project to have people watch something even slightly more enjoyable, to leave

something even slightly better—that didn't change. But honestly, the stories just weren't interesting (wry laugh). The inevitable flow of repetitive developments each time, common to long-running works, was unavoidable, and while I tried various approaches, stories that didn't change much became inescapable.

This story had Broly from the previous theatrical version appearing before Goten and Gohan in a new way... I think... probably... (sweat) ...That's about all I can remember—it's already faded in memory.

For better or worse, one installment of the so-called "Toei Manga Festival." When I think about it, receiving theatrical work is a luxurious, inexcusable complaint, but for me it was work while holding some dilemma of not being able to fully get into it.

Still, I remember the staff room being quite fun, centered on Director Ueda and Animation Director Yamamuro. I remember it as a staff room where laughter never ceased. The schedule itself didn't fall terribly behind either—it felt like we created it with a "reasonably tough" atmosphere. Everyone including me had gotten used to making

Dragon Ball Z

of this volume.

I joined around Golden Week, and completion was late June.

Then summer. After resting somewhat leisurely, two projects came to me from late August. First, one theatrical work:

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon S

. And one mysterious video work titled

Warriors of Erosion

.

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon S

was a side story to the TV series that began that year following

Sailor Moon R

. A theatrical version visualizing a story written specifically by original creator Takeuchi Naoko.

And

Warriors of Erosion

was apparently a video work commissioned by some religious organization. This seemed potentially quite interesting.

■Continues to Episode 129

(10.07.09)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 129: Sorry, Another Special Edition -

The Tatami Galaxy

Kyoto Local Post-Production Location Tour

The Tatami Galaxy

, which received great acclaim, has completed not only broadcast work but also all work on unreleased episodes for BD & DVD release. With a little time available, I'm taking a brief vacation. Ah, travel for the first time in a while. I'm in Kyoto bustling with the Gion Festival, camera in hand.

But, rain. Western Japan generally seems to have heavy rain tendencies since the week's start, and Kyoto too feels properly like the end of rainy season, getting hit by daily evening showers. Plus it's muggily hot during the day without clearing up completely. And humidity. Good grief.

Still, I'm enjoying my first vacation in a while.

Now then.

Right after receiving the

Tatami Galaxy

job offer last autumn, before my actual work started, I went to Kyoto twice for self-funded location scouting. At that time I toured important

Tatami Galaxy

locations like Kamogawa Delta, Kamo Bridge, Shimogamo Shrine and Tadasu Forest, plus the Kiyamachi area, grasping the atmosphere in my own way before diving into main production work.

Then main production work started. As Episodes 2, 3, 4... progressed, various locations kept appearing. All fascinating places. Plus locations I hadn't covered in self-funded scouting came one after another. I became irresistibly curious about the source material for the spatial worlds created for animation.

So this time, though belated, I've toured several locations I felt deeply about among places that served as story stage references. Title: "

Tatami Galaxy

Kyoto Local Post-Production Location Tour" (laugh). Ah, just like an anime fan (laugh).

First, naturally revisiting Kamogawa Delta and Kamo Bridge.

With big rain effects, the Kamogawa River was in major flood. The stepping stone turtles you can walk across the Kamogawa were magnificently submerged. More water than during Gozan no Okuribi night fires? If you fell in here you wouldn't survive, Ozu (sweat).

I bought "bean mochi" that appeared in the main feature from famous Futaba shop in Demachiyanagi shopping district and ate them sitting on Delta benches. Delicious!

Crossing Kamo Bridge eastward and walking straight leads to Hyakumanben intersection. Beyond that on the right spreads Kyoto University campus. Walking through that campus toward the main gate. Walking through university grounds where young people pass as such an old guy is a bit nerve-wracking (laugh).

The clock tower that appeared almost every episode, used as visual reference for the university "I" attends. It was surprisingly small. I thought it towered more magnificently. In the main feature screen it's shown quite majestically large. Incidentally, the tree in front is camphor. In Episode 1 we showed it cherry blossom-like for entrance ceremony imagery.

Exiting Kyoto University's main gate and turning left, just ahead is Yoshida Mountain. Yoshida Shrine.

This is the spot used for filming by film club "Misogi" led by Jogasaki. It was so close to university campus!

Beyond Yoshida Shrine's main hall is a small mountain. In this mountain, just over the summit on the side opposite the shrine, is Cafe "Moan."

This was used as reference for the spot where "I" and Hanuki-san had their tea date after Conversation Club. Actually, I'd been curious about this place since main production work and had wanted to visit forever! This atmosphere is wonderful! I had delicious lunch.

Leaving Yoshida Mountain, going down Shirakawa Street, the final spot I reached was here: Lake Biwa Canal, Keage Incline.

I had no idea such a thing existed in Kyoto until working on this project. I didn't understand Lake Biwa Canal well in the first place. Actually gazing from the bridge where "I" stood in Episode 3, I was moved with "Ooooh!" Further moved seeing the boat pool wall that "I" crashed into with his human-powered aircraft (laugh).

Still, Akashi-san ran alongside here by bicycle, right? Even with a mountain bike, that's incredible.

Incidentally, this canal connected to Nanzenji's aqueduct, that mecca of suspense drama filming locations.

Well, touring places I felt deeply about like that. I really understood the feelings of fans doing "local pilgrimages"! This kind of thing is fun!

I got so emotionally invested in

The Tatami Galaxy

, but this finally gave me emotional closure. This "post-production location tour" was also for such "closure." Work and feelings are hereby finished. My feelings will now enter new works.

■Continues to Episode 130

(10.07.16)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 12: Special Episode... Adventures Around Windows and Family Registers

It's been a while.

Actually, my father passed away early this month, and with all the related matters, plus the work piling up as a result - whoosh! - I've been taking a break for a while.

Well, the work situation is still very much whoosh! continuing, but somehow... (distant stare).

So I'm starting again.

Well then.

Suddenly, but actually I'm still not quite back to normal, so this time is a special episode (bitter laugh).

Moreover, it's not about anime at all... (sweat).

In anime, people actually die quite often, but when a person - just one person - dies, it's actually an incredibly difficult thing (bitter laugh).

The dying itself is certainly difficult, but what comes after death is also very troublesome in various ways.

My father died in the hospital, and first they do "death determination" there.

The doctor confirms no vital signs (pulse, heartbeat, breathing, pupil reflexes), and only then is "death" confirmed. The "died at what hour, what minute" thing. Based on that determination, the hospital issues a "death certificate." When you submit that to the city office and it's accepted, my father, who was a Japanese citizen, becomes "deceased" in Japanese society and is "removed from the family register."

With the funeral company arranged by the hospital, we returned home to discuss arrangements, leading to the wake and funeral.

Since my mother had already passed away, I, as the eldest son, became the "chief mourner."

It had been 15 years since the last funeral, and since my father had handled everything as chief mourner last time, I honestly didn't remember much.

Moreover, that time was right in the middle of production crunch for

Dragon Ball Z Movie: Extreme Battle! The Three Great Super Saiyans

, so except for the wake and funeral, I was at work the whole time... ah, that part was exactly the same this time (bitter laugh).

The funeral arrangements were left to the funeral company so that was OK, but what I had to arrange and contact myself were temple-related matters.

Having the head priest from our family temple come, posthumous Buddhist names, offerings - man, I was nervous. I wanted to wake up my dead father and consult with him (laughs).

Still, somehow clearing the difficult challenges, we proceeded with the wake and funeral.

After the funeral, for cremation, you need permission for that too.

You must get a "cremation permit" from the city office. And once he became bones, then you need burial permission. "Burial permit." Without this, no matter how much grave preparation you have, temples cannot perform burials.

Such permit harassment (bitter laugh).

But these were all handled by the funeral company applying and receiving on our behalf, so there were no problems. What was difficult came after that.

I had to stop, change, or inherit various procedures from my father's social life.

Just government office-related: National Pension, Health Insurance, Elderly Health Insurance, Long-term Care Insurance...

Then stopping bank accounts, stopping and changing names for various utility automatic withdrawals, etc. Oh, and receiving insurance money. Moreover, several had conditions like "within 14 days of death"...

So I had to make rounds to various windows.

The thing is, every single window is different (bitter laugh). Moreover, to apply and handle procedures at each one, you need family register copies, resident certificates, etc.

First, National Pension.

This is the Social Insurance Office. For benefit suspension procedures, besides the pension certificate, you need a "death notification certificate" and the family register copy of the deceased person. Pensions are apparently paid through the month of death, which is fine, but since I'd stop my father's account, I as the representative heir would receive it. For that review - or rather, identity verification - I needed family register copies and resident certificates showing the relationship between my father and me.

National Health Insurance, Elderly Health Insurance, and Long-term Care Insurance are under city hall jurisdiction.

However, Health Insurance is the Health Insurance Division, Elderly Health Insurance is the Welfare Division, Long-term Care Insurance is the Elderly Care Division - different departments and windows requiring separate procedures for each.

For stopping bank accounts, first they need the person's family register copy "complete from birth to death and removal from registry."

Then since this becomes "inheriting" those deposits, they need family register copies, resident certificates, seal certificates, etc. for us inheriting siblings.

For utilities, I called everyone to arrange mailing of name change and account change procedure documents.

For life insurance (simple insurance), like banks they needed family register copies and such, plus since there was medical insurance, I had to go to the hospital where he was admitted to get "hospitalization certificates" issued.

Incidentally, my family home is in Sayama City, Saitama Prefecture.

I'm in Nakano Ward, Tokyo. And both my father and I had our family registers in Nakano Ward. So basic procedures were in Sayama City, and basic documents needed were in Nakano Ward - back and forth like that.

...What a hassle (bitter laugh).

Such things are never depicted in anime, right?

There was the movie "The Funeral," but it didn't cover these procedural matters...

By the way, my father was a Sayama City resident in his later years, but originally had his family register in Tokyo's Nakano.

So I went to Nakano Ward Office to get "complete from birth to death and removal from registry" family register copies. "Complete from birth to death and removal from registry" means copies are needed for every update of the family register due to marriage, children being born, etc. The copies they provided had various history of my father - marriage with my mother, mother's death, my birth, etc.

However, things didn't end at Nakano Ward Office.

Actually, my father moved his family register to Nakano Ward after World War II, but originally, my father was born in "Tokyo City Ushigome Ward." "Tokyo City Ushigome Ward" is now Tokyo's Shinjuku Ward. So next, to Shinjuku Ward Office.

Waiting over an hour at Shinjuku Ward Office.

The copy they provided clearly recorded my father's birth registration. Furthermore, this family register move to Ushigome Ward was two years after my father's birth, and in the true sense, my father's first appearance in family registers would trace back to Toyama City, Toyama Prefecture, where my father's father - my grandfather's - family register was.

Man, a bit moving.

By following family register copies, I felt my father's 80-year life anew and firmly.

And various procedures are still incomplete and continuing (sweat).

I wonder when they'll end...

##

■Continues to Episode 13

(07.04.24)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 130: Once Upon a Time... 74 - 1994 Part 8 -

Sailor Moon S

Movie Blues

I've returned to morning-person lifestyle recently.

Sleep early at night, start around 4 AM. I currently have work where I handle everything from color design to color direction and finishing inspection, so I wake up and immediately enter my work room to begin cel inspection. Production managers collect animation director completions around 7 AM every morning, and stop by my home around 9 AM. There I hand over completed finishing inspections and receive in-between animation completions for immediate color direction. They take those straight back, hand them to finishing staff at 10 AM for painting work. Then those completions get brought again the next morning—that's my current lifestyle flow.

Generally morning home work like that. Afternoons I go out for meetings or take little naps. Quite a healthy lifestyle.

Speaking of which, elementary, middle, and high school students just entered summer vacation. I was a child quite bad at early rising, but thinking now, if I'd managed proper early rising, I could have done much more. Not saying 4 AM, but acting from around 5 AM really lets you use the day incredibly long. It's normally bright before 5 AM anyway.

I won't advocate "daylight saving time" introduction like Europe and America, but summer especially recommends early rising.

Now then.

The first of my two jobs in 1994's second half was

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon S

movie. Director: Shibata Hiroki, Animation Director: Kagawa Hisashi, Art Director: Kubota Tadao. My second

Sailor Moon

theatrical work.

The cat Luna falls in love with a human man who helped her. Then Princess Snow Kaguya, queen of snow and ice who appeared with a comet approaching Earth for the first time in 4.5 billion years, attacks for Earth invasion. The man Luna loved

was first to spot that comet... such a story.

This story was actually written specifically by original creator Takeuchi Naoko. An episode "written for the movie!" with the plan to serialize the same story in magazines timed with movie release.

As I wrote before, almost exactly the same time the previous year I'd participated in Director Ikuhara's

Sailor Moon R

movie. With absolutely no time, having to make it work no matter what, it was still a theatrical version we could create with great concentration and enjoyment.

Then one year later. During this time I hadn't been openly involved with

Sailor Moon

, but I'll reveal this now—I was secretly participating in "new character" color design. Colors for Uranus and Neptune, especially their checkered uniform looks, were colors I provided. Then-CD Ikuhara-kun, Character Designer Ito Ikuko-san, and I would secretly paint cels in Oizumi Studio's painting room at night, making color samples for decisions.

Oh, incidentally, regarding upgraded Sailor Moon—that wasn't me. I think it was predetermined. From Kodansha editorial or Bandai maybe? The design came as "Use this!"

So, this work. Hmm, compared to the previous work, the schedule and work start were certainly earlier, but there were various troublesome situations and it didn't seem to progress much.

I can't remember what I disliked anymore, but at the time I really didn't like this story somehow. What was it? Probably typically "shoujo manga-like" settings that I didn't like. "It's weird for an individual to live in such a huge observatory as a home" or "They wouldn't build an observatory in such an urban area." Starting from such things (laugh). Luna's tragic love was clear from the beginning, but even so, couldn't something have been done? (laugh).

Since it was a story the original creator put out as "Use this!" we animation folks couldn't arbitrarily change various settings either. And naturally various original creator checks would come in, so the director and animation director seemed to have various difficulties too.

Release was first week of December. To achieve that, completion was necessary by mid-November. Work on this midwinter story of dancing snow and ice getting serious would begin in the thick of late summer heat, late August.

■Continues to Episode 131

(10.07.21)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 131: Once Upon a Time... 75 - 1994 Part 9 -

Sailor Moon S

Movie Bank Cut Blues

Yes yes, it's summer vacation for elementary, middle, and high school students. Well, aside from exam students, I hope children who aren't can spend a summer playing around like little pigs and having various experiences. Oh, but no bad behavior! (laugh)

By the way, I didn't know this, but recently even Tokyo elementary schools apparently have summer vacation only until around August 25th. Apparently because they made Saturdays holidays, there aren't enough class hours.

Hmm, how is that?

We don't have children so I can't speak carelessly, but where exactly were the benefits of making Saturday a holiday? Ah, but thanks to that, Saturday morning anime programs are viable, right? If it weren't a holiday, nobody would watch anime on Saturday mornings. ...As one of the staff for Saturday morning broadcast

Ultra!! Mecha-Mote Chairman

, I'm asking myself such questions.

Anyway, summer vacation should really be a holiday until August 31st for proper closure. Don't you feel that way? Right?

Now then.

TV series theatrical adaptations inevitably involve bank cut modifications for theatrical compatibility.

Sailor Moon

always uses transformation bank cuts and special attack bank cuts from the TV series in theatrical versions too. This was actually quite troublesome.

TV then was still fully analog broadcast, so aspect ratio was 3:4. Meanwhile theatrical works were basically Vista frame at 9:16. This difference was troublesome.

If we could set theatrical photography frames by trimming to match TV's 3:4 frame width, basic cel materials could use TV ones as-is. But this didn't work well. Width-matched trimming would often cut off cel tops and bottoms, so animation that fit full-size nicely in frame top-bottom would have character heads or feet cut

off when top-bottom trimmed, sometimes even missing everything above the neck. This obviously couldn't be used. So basic frame modification mainly meant expanding horizontally to match top-bottom.

At that time, when there were reasons like completely redoing colors or modifying movement itself, we could say "can't help it!" and create new cels from scratch with large cels (Vista cels), but the most troublesome was when directors helpfully reset modification frames right to the margins of current TV cel blanks and gave instructions for additions and painting additions to current cels. Accordingly, cel modifications would paint as far as cel blanks allowed horizontally.

This was the worst kind of troublesome!

I wanted to say don't do unnecessary things! (laugh)

Since these were cels already used many times for photography, they had scratches and some deterioration. Adding new lines and painting there, and as I wrote before, even paints with the same color numbers had slight color and brightness differences depending on production periods. So careless painting additions could result in subtly different colors in added parts.

Well, honestly since it's frame edges, it didn't matter much in cuts moving energetically. But that modification work itself was troublesome and annoying (wry laugh). Checking cel modification completions was also annoying. Thinking it was probably fine and checking only lightly before sending to photography, assistant directors would say "Um, the painted cel and mask don't match..." for retakes (wry laugh). That's right. Bank cuts had incredibly complex photography masks, and naturally these all needed painting additions for frame modifications too. Since it's additions to painted cels, naturally hand trace, which would shift. Good grief (wry laugh).

Moreover!

There were many bank cuts. Rather, increasing numbers. When new Sailor Warriors appeared, transformation banks and special attack banks increased by that headcount...

Since theatrical versions were definitely being made, when creating new bank cuts, couldn't they create animation + finishing from the start to handle large 9:16 frames! ...I resented TV staff for each incident.

In today's digitized era, painting data (cels) are digital, so such painting additions are relatively easier. Masks are also created accurately by computers through batch processing without mistakes or shifting. HD-compatible programs definitely have the same 9:16 aspect ratio as theatrical versions, so frame modifications themselves often don't exist.

So current

PreCure

series are probably still easier (laugh). Well, they probably have their own difficulties now (wry laugh).

■Continues to Episode 132

(10.07.27)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 132: Once Upon a Time... 76 - 1994 Part 10 -

Sailor Moon S

Movie Color Carbon Blues

August arrived. Daily scorching heat in Tokyo. Aren't there fewer cicadas this year?

Our house is next to a park, and while cicadas sing reasonably during the day, their voices stop completely in the evening. Last year and the year before, cicada choruses that started with sunrise continued all day, sometimes until night. This year is remarkably quiet.

I don't know about other areas, but Nakano definitely has fewer cicadas this year.

Cicadas spend about seven years underground. Seven years ago, perhaps that year also had few cicadas like this year. Seven years ago? What kind of year was it? What work was I doing?

And seven years from now, will it be another summer with few cicadas?

Now then.

Sailor Moon S

movie—this time's enemy was snow and ice queen Princess Snow Kaguya and her minions. Since it was an original creator's written story, naturally enemy character image illustrations from the original creator were sent.

Hmm, pure white (wry laugh).

That's right. Since it's "snow and ice" imagery, that's understandable, but both queen and minions were completely white from top to bottom. Sure, drawn as manga illustration style, it probably looked good, but in this anime version that couldn't just be OK. We had to somehow create queen-like dignity and hierarchy differences from minions. That said, we didn't want to increase color count much, and it should still feel like "snow" and "ice."

So I tried making "how about this?" color samples first. For minions "Snow Dancers," almost matching original illustration imagery—skin, hair, clothes all completely white with no color separation. Shadow colors unified in CB-system light blue.

Queen Princess Snow Kaguya also based on original illustrations with white for skin and clothes, N-system light blue for hair and accessories. Upper body had thin veil-like gown drawn in. Plus head-to-foot veils layered with semi-transparent

double brush processing. I tried unifying in white to blue (light blue) or white to light purple feeling.

But somehow it didn't feel quite right. The impression was somehow hard. While colors were unified in white base, the transparency—or "coldness"—was pointing in a slightly wrong direction.

"Ah, the main lines (outlines) are too hard."

Normal animation machine trace uses black carbon, making outlines black. This doesn't matter for regular characters like Usagi who use voluminous colors for skin, hair, and clothes, but this time's queen and minions were basically white. So white with black outlines inevitably looked hard—or rather dirty.

So I thought of colored carbon.

As I may have written somewhere before, besides black carbon there are brown, pink, green, white and other colored carbons. Among these, I thought about trying blue first.

I tried putting blue carbon lines on the previous color samples. Snow Dancers flying around energetically looked great! Making main lines blue added transparency and speed to characters for good balance. But Queen Snow Kaguya was still lacking somehow. She resembled the minions too much. Perhaps we should fundamentally reconsider by departing from original illustrations?

So I boldly remade painting colors departing from white. And for main line colors, I used white carbon. I stopped using white for skin and hair painting colors, and to make white outlines stand out, I changed painting colors to light blue-system colors respectively. Honestly, they looked completely different from original illustrations (sweat). Actually in the main feature screen, snow, wind, or beam technique effects would layer on top, so considering that, maybe this much color would be fine?

Color samples organized with such thinking were shown to main staff including producer, director, animation director, and art director, with slight adjustments to complete decisions. Sent to original creator side. "Maybe they'll say 'this is different from what I drew!' and send it back..." I was somewhat apprehensive. Incidentally, other guests Sora Kakeru and Nayotake Himeko were created in colors almost exactly matching original illustrations.

But such worries proved groundless—while there were some correction notes, basically everything got OK!

Now main feature work could start... but this color carbon proved more troublesome than imagined.

■Continues to Episode 133

(10.08.03)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 133: Once Upon a Time... 77 - 1994 Part 11 -

Sailor Moon S

Movie: More Color Carbon Blues

I wrote "Aren't there fewer cicadas this year?" last time. The manuscript stating "I don't know about other areas, but Nakano definitely has fewer cicadas this year" was published worldwide, and starting the next day: this year's cicadas are in full frenzy again.

Cicadas start singing before 4 AM when the eastern sky begins whitening, continue shrilly singing, take a break during the day's hottest (heated) 1-3 PM, then sing continuously from evening until midnight.

Simply wonderful (wry laugh).

At this pace, surely lots of cicadas will sing seven years from now too.

Currently in top form are minmin cicadas. Gradually aburazemi voices increase, eventually shifting to tsukutsukuboshi. When that happens, "autumn" approaches.

Now then.

Sailor Moon S

movie, having decided on blue carbon for enemy characters and white carbon introduction—after deciding, I was actually called by a production executive.

"Is colored carbon absolutely necessary for this?"

Actually, colored carbon is somewhat expensive. At the time, regular black carbon cost about 17-18 yen per sheet, while colored carbon cost over 20 yen. Plus prices varied somewhat by color.

Furthermore, a problem. Actually, colored carbon had absolutely limited distribution quantities. For brown carbon, which is sometimes used project-wide, there's reasonable distribution, but white and blue are used only in extremely special cases, so while Toei had some in-house stock, outsourced production houses—much less Philippine and Korean studios handling in-between and finishing work—essentially had zero inventory. So when ordering, we'd need to provide necessary quantities to production houses along with cuts.

The biggest problem wasn't money but usage volume. Though it's presumptuous for me to say, money could work out somehow. It's a theatrical work. But if we faced a "not enough carbon!" situation at crucial points during production, that

would be serious.

From what I heard, increasing colored carbon production is quite difficult, and requesting increased production today wouldn't be ready tomorrow or the day after. Plus operationally, machines must make large batches at once—you can't make just what you need when you need it. "Instead using all color trace..." was no longer possible.

"Yes. Nothing but white carbon and blue carbon will work!" I said.

We roughly counted from storyboards how many cuts "Snow Kaguya" and "Snow Dancers" would appear in to estimate usage, but anyway, it's a theatrical version. They'd probably move energetically throughout, so we decided to prepare lots! I think manufacturer Josai Duplo had reasonable inventory too.

Thus we plunged into main feature work, but first various problems emerged from advance trailer cut work.

First, one animation problem. Cuts where regular black carbon characters and colored carbon characters appear simultaneously must have animation on separate cels. Actually colored carbon and black carbon have different heat requirements during transfer, so simultaneous carbon transfer to one cel is impossible.

Well, strictly speaking, they can be "composited" on one cel, but that requires some knowledge and care, and considering mass production systems centered on overseas work with tight schedules and somewhat uncertain communication, separating in-between animation in advance was safer. So in-between animation that originally would finish in one cel increased to two or three cels per character.

And yet another problem! Seeing painted Snow Kaguya cels, I was dumbfounded. Snow Kaguya using white carbon became—putting it nicely—color trace painting, putting it badly—blurry painting that looked like front-back confusion, momentarily incomprehensible.

Here's what this means: animation cel paint painting applies paint from the back side, but naturally paint goes over main lines—carbon lines. With regular "black carbon" this isn't a problem at all, but with "white carbon," carbon lines themselves are semi-transparently thin, so they're overwhelmed by painted colors and look like there are no lines.

This was careless of me.

Actually when making color samples for checking, I'd shown color sample cels painted with black carbon with white carbon line-only cels overlaid to get "OK!" So they didn't get overwhelmed by cel paints like this—white lines properly emerged over painted colors for good feeling. Incidentally, blue carbon Snow Dancers were

fine since painting colors themselves were white, so they didn't get overwhelmed much and rather finished nicely. The problem was definitely the queen.

Now what? (sweat) Main feature work had already started. Changes weren't possible now.

■Continues to Episode 134

(10.08.10)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 134: Once Upon a Time... 78 - 1994 Part 12 -

Sailor Moon S

Movie: Even More Color Carbon Blues

I went to Kyoto again.

The final installment of my "

Tatami Galaxy

Kyoto Local Post-Production Location Tour"

—the Gozan fires.

On the night of August 16th, I watched the real Daimonji bonfire from Kamogawa Delta. Wow, moving! Thrilling! And unbelievably crowded (laugh). Apparently even this was fewer people than usual years. What!

Running like "I" in the final episode would be absolutely impossible under these conditions. Delta's pine groves and Kamogawa embankments were completely buried by bonfire-viewing crowds. Deai Bridge had one-way traffic control (laugh).

Still, I'll never forget that "■" character floating in the night sky.

This concludes my journey around

The Tatami Galaxy

. Now just waiting for DVD & Blu-ray release. Everyone, please support us.

Now then.

Sailor Moon S

movie where serious problems emerged from preview painted cels. Main feature work had already started. Changes weren't possible now. So what to do?

Then I suddenly realized. "Ah! Then like with color samples, just overlay one more white carbon line cel on top!"

So hastily one more machine trace each with white carbon. For all Snow Kaguya cels, creating one more cel each with just white carbon lines. Then overlaying during photography.

This became quite serious.

Finishing work-wise, doing two machine traces each to prepare painting and overlay versions would work, but the problem was photography. Digital photography could theoretically handle any number of cel layers without problems, but this was cel + film photography era. While cels are transparent, layering many inevitably reduces light reaching lower elements, making them darker.

For example, cuts completed with one in-between animation would need painted cel + line-only cel, so two layers would suffice, but when this became body + eye blink + mouth movement, that alone became six layers! Furthermore, when characters with different carbon types entered, their acting would be separate cels too, quickly becoming seven or eight layers.

So while normally mouth movement and eye blinks would be easier as separate cels, this time we requested "drawn-in" or "composite" wherever possible. That would reduce cel layers accordingly, but placed considerable burden on finishing work. And in-between animation frame counts too.

Then (well, now too), animation frame counts were major issues. Not just Toei—every company thoroughly managed animation frame counts, but this time (I forget exact numbers) we significantly exceeded limits. Considering various circumstances, it was unavoidable, but the hellishly exceeded finishing frame counts weren't actually much of an issue (sweat).

Anyway, before we knew it,

Sailor Moon S

movie was in final stages. The story climax was Luna transforming to human form for image scenes with Kakeru. At the time, in my

Sailor Moon

color design approach, I had this idea that "good scenes should look normal-ish," so this scene also basically used "normal" color direction as foundation, with only a few "Earth sunrise" cuts arranged in reflection high-contrast tones. However, seeing the completed screen later, I thought "maybe that was a mistake..."

This was again overshadowed by "Taiyo Shikisai paint problems." These cuts, especially close-up cuts, were worked on in Korea, so paints were also converted to Taiyo Shikisai paints for ordering and work. This conversion didn't go well subtly. Colors became muddy somehow. Color "clarity" wasn't good.

Converting normal color paint numbers and shadow color paint numbers to nearest Taiyo Shikisai paints respectively, normals became subtly dark and muddy, shadows became subtly bright, so combined contrast became blurred. This particularly affected skin and clothes. Scenes that should have been crisp with original STAC colors became somewhat faded and hazy finishes.

Maybe making them more image-like from the start as special painting scenes would have been better. But that scene was one where I hoped to get some realism on screen for Luna's feelings.

Plus the same thing with Snow Kaguya. Blue-system paints used for skin became subtly dark and muddy when converted to Taiyo colors. Ah, transparency was important here too... On the other hand, Snow Dancers actually looked better on film in Taiyo color cuts. Hmm, frustrating. If I'd had more mental and time allowance, there might have been various ways to handle this...

Other staff and viewers probably didn't see these scenes as particularly strange, but for me as the person responsible for colors, they became disappointingly regrettable screens.

For works like

Dragon Ball Z

with solid, tough animation, it wouldn't matter much, but as with previous

Sailor Moon R

, works that use many transparent colors are difficult to convert to Taiyo Shikisai paints. If I could have made everything with Taiyo Shikisai paints from the start, I could design within Taiyo paint color space, which might have been better. But then it probably would have become completely different atmosphere

Sailor Moon

.

Watching the preview screening while brooding over such things was

Sailor Moon S

movie.

■Continues to Episode 135

(10.08.18)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 135: Once Upon a Time... 79 - 1994 Part 13 - What! A Religious Organization's OVA

Warriors of Erosion

I went to Hong Kong at summer's end. I go to Hong Kong for fun fairly regularly, but this was my first time during such obviously hot midsummer season. I went quite prepared, but huh? Totally fine somehow. Rather, cool?

Apparently this year's Japan, particularly Tokyo's intense heat and extreme heat, secretly gave us heat tolerance? (wry laugh)

Ah, but checking temperatures, ah, Hong Kong was indeed somewhat cooler (wry laugh). At least mornings and evenings, temperatures properly dropped. Really, Japan being hotter than tropical Hong Kong...

Now then.

Sailor Moon S

movie, fighting various blues. That autumn-winter of 1994, I was also participating in another work in parallel. An OVA called

Warriors of Erosion

.

Staff included Director: Kasai Osamu, Setting: Tsunoda Koichi, Character Design & Animation Director: Nashizawa Takashi, Art Directors: Uchikawa Fumihiko & Tokushige Masaru. And color design by me (credited as "color direction").

This was actually a commissioned work from a certain religious organization in Hiroshima Prefecture. One of the so-called "religious anime," perhaps? When first told about this job by my supervisor, I thought "Huh?" "What kind of thing will we make?"

But I thought it seemed somewhat interesting. I heard it wasn't something containing that religious organization's doctrine, but rather "human history is religious history," and "easy-to-understand world religious history digest" with "ultimately religion saves humanity's future!" to teach their believers in an understandable way. Basically a video work just for distribution within that organization. For me, this "easy-to-understand world religious history digest" aspect seemed interesting. So I decided to participate.

Anyway, since it's anime never commercially released, explanation and description are difficult... but somewhere in the vast universe beyond there's a place called

Nakoku Tsunedokoro where the head god resides, and a novice god boy who caused some mischief there gets dropped to a star called "Punishment Country" (Earth) as punishment. That novice boy, together with two little demons turned into snakes by god, follows human and religious history on Earth throughout.

My work was the same as usual. First deciding main character colors. "Novice boy" and his pet that understands human language, plus snake versions and original versions of the two little demons—these were main characters. Everything else had just scattered character designs, with almost everything being key animation matching!

Actually, as the story progressed, scenes kept changing constantly, and Moses, Christ, Buddha, Nichiren appeared for maybe 10 cuts each at most. I created colors for these named religious figures from main feature cuts for checking, then proceeded mostly with reference matching. Not photographs as reference, but paintings and religious paintings from those periods, or imagination-type materials as basis for both animation and painting.

For example, Moses work matched good-atmosphere paintings drawn by later generations. Opposing Egyptian soldiers used materials selected from other reference collections matching the period. Right, as much as possible, historical research—or period clothing and such—we gathered references and researched for matching.

But this was quite fun. Since animation drew fairly solidly according to references, adding colors with reference matching naturally fit well! Doing such things feels quite good. Plus I personally like history, so I could work with enjoyment creating such ancient period things on screen.

Plus proper drama was created, so night scenes, bonfire scenes, early morning atmosphere scenes—quite a lot of special painting too. Actually the parallel

Sailor Moon S

movie was designed with as many "normal" color scenes as possible, so partly in reaction, I enjoyed changing colors scene by scene, cut by cut, doing whatever I wanted (laugh).

The story moves significantly from when Nostradamus prophesies humanity's future disasters. From the "three cart fire house" parable, it advances to parables like "socialism," "free prosperity ideology," "science technology faith ideology," and religion extends salvation to humanity facing destruction reality (wry laugh).

This climax "three carts pulled by sheep, deer, and cattle" scene resembled theatrical

Utena

's climax, and the salvation ship descending from the sky at the end was quite Matsumoto Reiji-like sci-fi, with dynamics that quite hit my sweet spot (laugh).

Such was

Warriors of Erosion

(laugh).

Fortunately I received a sample VHS of the completed product. Not a so-called "white box" but proper packaged product. How many were actually manufactured? Being an extremely small-scale work from 15-16 years ago, I have the impression that probably nobody has this footage anymore.

Actually anime isn't just TV and theatrical—quite a lot of such works are made. Things commissioned by various organizations like this, school education-related works like those placed in libraries nationwide.

So while "anime halls" and such "buildings" are inexcusable, creating archives of anime that don't appear much before general audiences would be quite meaningful, I think.

■Continues to Episode 136

(10.09.08)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 136: Once Upon a Time... 80 - Into the Turbulent Year 1995: Again From
Dragon Ball Z

Movie

As a child, I loved doing fireworks with my family in our yard on summer evenings. When I was a child, fireworks were sold individually at nearby shopping districts. Now various types of fireworks are bundled into packages sold at supermarkets and toy stores, but back then—what kind of shops were they? In summer, shops would display fireworks out front for sale. Ones that made flames go whoosh, ones that crackled and sparked with light. Since we did fireworks in a garden small as a cat's forehead, we didn't choose big elaborate ones like those you launch, but I'd still excitedly select extremely modest handheld fireworks and have mother buy them.

Sometimes I'd get ones you hang under eaves and light. Those waterfalls of light were beautiful. Morning glories and pond surfaces illuminated by that light remain in my memories even now.

Even at this age, I think every year about wanting to do fireworks like those days, but it doesn't quite work out. First, the sight of a middle-aged man doing fireworks alone is, from others' perspectives, a bit... you know (laugh).

Still, I think maybe sparklers would be okay, but when I tried sparklers a few years back on some occasion, they were incomparably shabby compared to old ones, leaving me disappointed.

Somewhere, aren't there proper sparklers like we used to do, with gunpowder right up close to where you hold them? If you search properly, are they still sold? Such old-fashioned sparklers.

Thinking such things, I noticed cicada voices growing distant, and cricket autumn voices became audible at night. While still quite hot during the day, mornings and evenings have become much more bearable recently.

Ah, this year's summer is ending too. Thinking that makes me feel lonely.

Now then.

1994 ended with

Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon S

movie and OVA

Warriors of Erosion

. In the usual flow, after completing one theatrical work I'd have a break from work and get some extended rest, but

Sailor Moon S

movie completed in mid-November, then

Warriors of Erosion

work continued for year-end delivery, so 1994 was unusually work until year's very end.

With

Warriors of Erosion

in full production swing in early December, my next job also started. One installment of next year's March "Spring Break Toei Anime Fair"—

Dragon Ball Z Movie: Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta

. Director: Yamauchi Shigeyasu, Script: Koyama Takao, Animation Director: Yamamuro Tadayoshi, Art Setting: Kubota Tadao, Art Director: Tokushige Masaru.

This was my fifth

Dragon Ball Z

theatrical work. While the previous work had me getting tired of

Dragon Ball Z

making motivation difficult to maintain (wry laugh), maybe having

Sailor Moon S

and such in between was good? I was a forward-thinking, motivated me thinking "Alright! Let's work hard!" (I think having Yamauchi-san as director was actually most significant (laugh)).

This story was set in the demon world. A mass of people's soul evil thoughts combines with young red demon to become monster Janemba, reviving the dead one after another and throwing the world into chaos. Goku and Vegeta, revived by Janemba, join forces to fight Janemba.

Director Yamauchi's storyboard work continued until after New Year's I think, but setting-related work was progressing rapidly from early December. First, confirming TV series

Dragon Ball Z

story progress and settings.

Theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

episodes fit between ongoing TV series timeline. So characters who appeared and were active on TV also appear in theatrical versions following that flow. For example, Gohan's Great Saiyaman, Mr. Satan, No. 18, Videl and such. Since I mostly hadn't watched TV series broadcasts (wry laugh), everyone had appeared without my knowledge, and before starting theatrical work I always had "who's this?" exchanges with TV staff.

Plus one more important TV series coordination aspect: child character growth. Gohan had grown up quite a while ago, but his brother Goten and Vegeta's son Trunks were actually subtly growing in height by design. Krillin with changed hairstyle too (laugh). Like that, checking TV series settings was essential. Oh, and dead characters! Since Goku and Piccolo are dead, they get "halos" on their heads (laugh).

Characters appearing in TV series naturally have character designs drawn for TV, but they're actually redrawn anew for each theatrical version. TV designs were drawn by Nakatsuru-san I believe, but theatrical versions have been handled by Yamamuro-san as animation director for several works now. Yamamuro-san's animation was quite different from TV, especially "shadow" animation volume feeling differed from TV.

Character colors change impression considerably based on shadow volume. Even painted with same color direction, they can look completely different depending on shadow and highlight area ratios and application. Or depending on shadow application methods, changing significantly from color direction often looked better. Especially for special animation like Super Saiyans.

So at my request, TV series characters also had designs rewritten by Yamamuro-san wherever possible. For this

Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta

: Goku, Piccolo, King Yemma, King Kai and others. Gohan, Videl, Goten, Trunks used Yamamuro-san rewrites from previous works. And naturally, colors also had theatrical volume added.

Then, theatrical original characters.

Theatrical enemy characters would have rough (!) sketches arrive from original creator Toriyama, organized for anime according to story, but this time I remember Toriyama gave OK to designs exactly as Yamamuro-san designed based on Director Yamauchi's ideas. I created colors for those designs.

Janemba had two designs. First was the early innocent child-like, fluffy round Janemba. A seemingly comical atmosphere design that actually didn't look very strong, so I aimed for that feeling and unified it in overall cream-colored soft tones.

The second Janemba was pure evil, incredibly strong imagery appearing in the latter half. Sharp eyes, sharp form—clearly a powerful enemy! design. So definitely strong red and purple. Trying various options, I settled on red and purple after all.

After passing Shueisha checks and progressing through poster and trailer work, 1994 ended. And finally 1995, Heisei 7.

At that year's start, something tremendous literally shook the Japanese archipelago.

■Continues to Episode 137

(10.09.14)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 137: Once Upon a Time... 81 - 1995 Part 1 - Rubble and Collapse in January

I've been maintaining early sleep, early rise as much as possible all summer. Wake up around 4-5 AM and start work. Eat breakfast around 7, then home work again all morning. External meetings from afternoon. Sleep around 11 PM—this lifestyle has settled wonderfully.

This morning time is truly pleasant. Quiet, head is clear, work seems twice as efficient (←by our company standards).

Plus amazingly, excess weight has started decreasing bit by bit. Apparently early rising and activity, then proper breakfast when hunger begins, works well. Everyone should try it.

What I experience through such early rising is sunrise time progression. July-August skies were bright after 4 AM, but this September it's around 5 AM before getting bright. Ah, already "autumn equinox." After "autumn equinox," sunrise gets considerably later, and evening sunset gradually earlier too.

Weather will finally cool down, truly feeling like autumn. Heading toward a somewhat lonely season.

Now then.

January 1995.

Dragon Ball Z Movie: Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta

had all storyboards completed and work progressing reasonably smoothly.

Theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

gives us makers an image of "harder battles" compared to TV series. Actually, stronger enemies appeared each time with increasingly hard battles. Intense combat, crumbling mountains and buildings, explosions, and fires. While certainly one of theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

's attractions, this tended to make screen atmosphere heavy and dark each time.

"Bright, pastel-like color tones," said Director Yamauchi. This

Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta

differed from previous theatrical versions, becoming a work with brighter, more comical tastes pushed more forward.

The demon world where innocent Janemba created barriers became a bright pastel space with countless mysterious colorful spheres floating in the air. At its center sat cream-colored fluffy Janemba, easily handling Goku's persistent attacks.

Meanwhile, the earthly realm where the dead revived causing chaos was also never drawn realistically—character outlines were bounded by thick outer lines, with animation and colors all made comical. While previous theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

had realistic explosions and smoke, in this earthly realm these were all manga-like too. Unified in bright pastels.

For several recent works, theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

"protagonists" were Goten and Trunks little kid combo. While little kids were certainly active this time too, I think they visually clearly separated realistic battle demon world from comical-touch earthly realm to clarify that story axis and main battles were Goku and Vegeta.

Work progressing toward editing and dubbing like that, at dawn on January 17th, a massive earthquake struck Osaka, Kobe, and Awaji. The Great Hanshin Earthquake.

Those tremors reached distant Tokyo, and though only intensity 1, I woke from that shaking and learned from TV news upon waking that "something terrible seems to be happening." From then I was glued to TV. Streets on fire, collapsed buildings, highways, houses, shopping districts. I was shocked by footage delivered one after another. Well past departure time and beyond, I continued staring at news screens.

Man, real rubble footage. We regularly do rubble, building collapse, and disaster screens in anime including

Dragon Ball

, but seeing such things actually happening in reality creates quite complex feelings. I was made to realize reality's weight.

Witnessing that earthquake footage, honestly I thought "I don't want to create realistic rubble and collapse imagery." And if children who experienced the earthquake watched and there were realistic such scenes, even in anime, wouldn't they feel bad?

Thinking that way, "Ah, this theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

was good to make with bright screens and many comical parts!" That's what I thought in January 1995.

■Continues to Episode 138

(10.09.21)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 138: Once Upon a Time... 82 - 1995 Part 2 - Pseudo-Digital? February

"Heat and cold until the equinox"

...How well the ancients said that! The Japanese archipelago truly became "autumn" all at once with this equinox as the border. Typhoons came properly too. I finally put on long sleeves! Ah, I'd planned to stay in short sleeves until October this year (wry laugh).

Ultra!! Mecha-Mote Chairman

that I'm participating in has background art entering "autumn mode" from around what we're making now. Inwardly I was thinking "What if it stays hot forever? (sweat)" but wow, quite relieved. Mood-wise for us makers, we can finally enter "autumn mode."

Now then.

Dragon Ball Z Movie: Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta

for March release got through editing and dubbing mostly with original photography, finally entering full-scale crunch mode in February.

"I want to show Janemba's instant transmission digital-like," said Director Yamauchi. "Eh? Digital-like? (sweat)" said Animation Director Yamamuro and me.

Actually from around this time, personal computers were starting to enter the graphics world. While not yet concretely entering anime production, at individual levels PCs were gradually becoming objects of interest.

"Apple Computer's Macintosh..." said Director Yamauchi. Within Oizumi Studio, Director Yamauchi was actually at the center of that PC mood, Mac mood. People around the director gradually got "brainwashed" and "influenced" by PC and Mac moods. Including me (laugh).

So, about Janemba.

Naturally not using CG, but strictly an order to make it "digital-like" with animation. What this meant was basically making Janemba's instant transmission "disappearance" and "appearance" afterimages in mosaic-style animation for "pseudo-digital-ish" imagery. I see, the mood is digital-ish (laugh). Plus we were asked to devise colors so mosaic part cross-sections would deliberately look flickery.

This was quite difficult. Painting each mosaic piece's cross-section differently, painting each cel so they wouldn't be continuous. This was hard to achieve.

Painting work normally requires attention to proper continuous color application—avoiding so-called "color flicker"—but even noting on key animation and in-between animation to "make it look flickery," it rarely painted up as intended. Everyone still painted properly after all.

Ultimately, most "instant transmission cuts" got retake processing during finishing inspection. We repainted cel fronts one by one to look flickery.

Checking those cuts on rushes film: "...Hmm (wry laugh)" from everyone (laugh). But it probably became interesting screens anyway.

Always giving somewhat surprising orders like that, Director Yamauchi's screen creation added various techniques during shoot preparation. This time too we shot adding various materials during shoot preparation.

For example, high-contrast screens. Photocopying background art in black and white. Making high-contrast black-white inverted copies with various adjustments. Using those copies as master plates for lithograph mask machines to create transmitted light masks. Laying those masks on backgrounds for photography to add light effects for even stranger high-contrast screens.

Using copy machines like that could be considered digital in a way? Hm? Not really? (laugh)

Getting through fun, difficult crunch like that, somehow reaching completion by late February. Then nationwide release first week of March. Incidentally, simultaneous screenings were

SLAM DUNK

and

Marmalade Boy

.

The story climax has "Gogeta," who appears through Goku and Vegeta's fusion technique, magnificently defeating Janemba and restoring order between this world and the next. As a result, Vegeta, who was revived by Janemba, becomes soul-only again. I quite liked this part—Vegeta's cool departure got me a bit emotional.

■Continues to Episode 139

(10.09.28)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 139:

The Tatami Galaxy

Color Design Notes Volume 0

Last week, for preparation of a certain work, several of us including a certain director went to a remote island in Kyushu. Plane → car → ferry connections for a little over 4 hours. Writing it like this makes it seem relatively close, but this was quite something...

Island life was completely different—eye-opening for us who've lived in Tokyo constantly. Then again, some aspects were much more advanced than Tokyo. Truly "don't underestimate remote islands!" Wonderful!

Still, what I felt most on the island was its quietness. Incredibly quiet. Not a single artificial sound. With so little traffic there's just one signal on the entire island—no car sounds at all. Only bird voices could be heard.

I was made to realize how much noise we live in daily. Crowd sounds we're accustomed to are actually considerable noise too.

Unfortunately this research trip was just one night, but occasionally staying in such places to relax body and mind in quietness would be good.

Now then.

Everyone, thank you for waiting! (←though whether that's true is unclear w) "

The Tatami Galaxy

Color Design Notes." DVD & Blu-ray Volume 3 will be released at month's end too. So about time to do this? Starting with that feeling!

I discussed

The Tatami Galaxy

colors once in early summer (Episode 124: Early Summer Special Edition -

The Tatami Galaxy

Notes for Color Direction Staff), so see that for overall general discussion. This time I'll start with "individual episode notes."

This time's individual episode "color" work flow involved "art board meetings" once storyboards came up. Director, individual episode directors, art director, and color designer (me) would gather to hear each scene's imagery from director and

episode directors, exchanging opinions while solidifying atmosphere. There we'd decide which cut layouts to prioritize for drawing actual backgrounds for art boards (so-called "actual boards"). Based on those layouts, the art director would begin art board work.

Completed art boards were checked by director and episode directors. Art direction was mostly solidified there. Next, based on those boards, art meetings included assigned art staff and color direction staff. Detailed scene flow and imagery meetings here.

Receiving that meeting, I'd enter each scene's color design. Placing characters appearing in scenes on art boards, fiddling around while building basic color design for each scene. Then director and episode director checks when completed.

Meanwhile in parallel, I'd write that episode's "color chart." Though called a chart, it was memos hastily written in pencil on storyboard backs, but this was quite important. Based on this "color chart" and OK'd "scene design" psd data, separate meetings with color direction staff.

Since color direction staff attended art meetings too, they properly understood content including directorial points. There I'd explain three-dimensionally with "actual visuals will be like this."

Animation artwork is living, so even with detailed meetings like this, actual animation cuts that came up often had different tastes, so we'd also decide approaches for color direction staff to consider colors responding to those, plus arrangements for circulating cut data I wanted to check.

Plus on-site "naming" meetings for color direction data for each scene.

Basic color direction for each scene decided by placing characters on art boards got individual names. For example, in Episode 1: color direction for "I" and Akashi-san's evening flashback scene was "Evening Color A," scene color direction in Gozan night crowds on Kamo Bridge was "Gozan Color," red scene color direction where fortune-teller granny is always encountered in Kiyamachi was "Kiyamachi Color." Those names get reflected in painting data like "EVA011_Akashi&Watashi;_kaisou.tga."

Deciding this makes color direction input work convenient. Though actually, having color direction staff further process painted completions wasn't uncommon.

Well, generally proceeding with decisions and meetings in such flow each time.

Since the introduction got long, that's all for this time. Next time diving into individual episode notes.

■Continues to Episode 140

(10.10.05)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 13: Once Upon a Time... (9) Strip Color Charts and Paint Maniacs

It's supposedly Golden Week (GW) in society.

If you take the right days off, this year's GW could be 9 consecutive days - how are you all spending it? (laughs)

This year I'm basically working.

Well, I'm always working regardless of the calendar anyway. But when the weather's nice, I naturally want to go somewhere. So if it would rain, I could give up easily... (← troubling for others).

While saying that, with the attitude of "I'm not going anywhere this GW, so I'll splurge instead!" I actually got a new digital camera.

A compact model for "always carrying with me." Incidentally, this makes my digital camera collection the 9th one! Including film cameras, it's my 16th camera (explosion).

Once you get a new digital camera, it's natural to want to try it out (bitter laugh).

...I wonder if I'll go somewhere camera in hand during the latter half of the holidays?

Well then.

When it comes to essential items for color direction in the paint era, it was definitely the strip color chart.

In industries dealing with color - publishing, printing, and others - they almost always use "color samples," right?

For example, when choosing wallpaper at home centers or even for paint, there are strip-shaped sample bundles at sales floors so you can compare color differences up close. Similarly, cel paints had strip-shaped color sample charts.

Had... or rather, in our case, we made them ourselves as needed.

STAC did sell strip charts for their 120 basic colors (I think it was made-to-order), but it was about 5,000 yen per set. I don't know about

Taiyo Shikisai

, but since it cost 5,000 yen, naturally we made our own (laughs).

We'd paint cels and cut them to strips about 7cm tall by 2.5cm wide.

This size was about the best. Bigger became unwieldy and hard to handle. Since there would be 200-300 pieces total, if each piece was large, the volume when bundled would be tremendous. Carrying them would be tough too.

First, painting cels, but if mass-producing several sets for multiple people, painting entire blank cels was an option, but cel costs add up, so usually we used "blank spaces" on cels rejected for some reason.

Mouth cels and eye cels were all blank spaces, so they were GOOD.

Once dry, to prevent strips from sticking when stacked, we'd paste thin white paper on the backs of painted strips.

We'd also write paint numbers on that paper. Then use office hole punchers to "bash!" one hole and thread them on rings - complete.

As a precaution, when painting strips, if you don't properly note what paint number you painted near the painted color, similar colors are numerous and you'll lose track later (laughs).

I loved making these strip charts, and every time rush jobs came in with new paints available, I'd steadily make strip charts.

It was like a collection. Maybe I was a kind of maniac (laughs). And besides the main STAC colors I used daily, I worked especially hard making strip charts of

Taiyo Shikisai

paints.

There was a proper reason for this - it was absolutely necessary for the "STAC-Taiyo Shikisai paint conversion" I mentioned before.

Without paint color samples, dealing just with paint numbers was often incomprehensible. Moreover, Taiyo Shikisai paints had complex numbering systems with fine detail and many numbers. So for better, closer color conversion, these were essential.

This would prove very helpful later when I did color direction for many theatrical works at Toei Doga.

So, using the strip charts made this way, we color directors from the cel paint era would wear them out.

When thinking about and specifying some color - like the color of props a character holds - first you envision what kind of color to use, then use the strip chart at hand

to combine colors and materialize the image in your head.

If the normal surface color is this, then what balance of density should the shadow be?

Or what color tone should the shadow be? - combining colors with strip charts while considering combinations.

When deciding character colors, we'd trace character designs or in-between animation and actually place colors to decide, but even then we'd first layer skin color with colors we planned to use for clothes using strip charts, check the balance, then start painting.

Also, during meetings, when discussing color images held by directors and us, we could share images with strip charts like "with combinations like this..."

This was an era when we couldn't manipulate nearly infinite colors with digital coloring or create subtle colors and hues exactly as imagined.

How to express with limited colors? For this, everyone used their heads to think, imagine, and devise, and strip charts were indispensable important tools.

Color design and color direction... or rather, the foundation of finishing begins with "learning colors, learning paints."

Especially in "color specification" work, you can't do the job without properly understanding paint numbers and their color characteristics and differences. So by painting ourselves this way, we learned paints and colors.

This remains true in the current digital coloring era.

Though tangible things like strip charts no longer exist, whether for character samples or anything else, imagining colors yourself and actually painting them to think things through is a fundamental principle for us in color design and color direction.

##

■Continues to Episode 14

(07.05.01)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 140:

The Tatami Galaxy

Color Design Notes Volume 1

Sports Day long weekend—some schools probably had athletic festivals around this time. In elementary school, I absolutely hated those "rehearsals" done the day before athletic festivals—I just couldn't stand them. Why practice everything? Is doing things properly that important? One-shot showdowns would be fine! And such.

Well, looking back at this age, that's right—there's no way things would go well in one shot (laugh). Not just running, but ball toss, tug-of-war, plus various dances—there were quite procedurally demanding competitive events. If I were an elementary school teacher, I'd be so nervous I might make them rehearse two or three times (laugh).

"Come to think of it, why were boys so reluctant to hold hands during folk dancing at middle school sports festivals?" came up at a drinking party with female colleagues sometime. "Right right, just barely touching fingertip to fingertip (laugh)." Man, we were embarrassed—what adolescence!

"Now we'd totally hold hands firmly!" The female colleagues' strong words made perfect sense (laugh).

Now then.

Continuing from last time, "

The Tatami Galaxy

Color Design Notes." Finally individual episode notes.

■Episode 1: Tennis Club "Cupid"

Storyboard & Direction: Yuasa Masaaki, Animation Director: Ito Nobuyoshi, Color Direction: Tsujita Kunio

As usual, I request to handle color direction for TV series first episodes myself, and this time too I did everything for Episode 1 myself.

Episode 1 work featured many locations appearing throughout the series, so rather than Episode 1-specific, it was work while solidifying visual policies and foundations for the entire series. For example, opening cat ramen cart scene and Kiyamachi fortune-teller granny scene were decided as fixed imagery throughout

the entire series. Cat ramen cart added yellow tones to normal characters matching background-painted yellow lighting, and Kiyamachi granny was built from the start on red backgrounds.

The four-and-a-half tatami room that would become stage center was decided through director and art consultation as "dim during day, brightest when lights are on at night." So characters in lit nighttime four-and-a-half tatami were set in basic "normal" colors. Therefore, the latter B-part castella-eating scene became the only "normal" color direction scene in Episode 1.

Other scenes were designed matching scene-specific art boards. Consecutive Kamogawa Delta fireworks scenes and "Gozan" bridge scenes were decided based on night brightness-darkness balance, yakiniku restaurant scenes added yellow-green matching background colors. Since only "I" is drunk, above the neck is pink, but completion-wise it was somewhat weak? So for similar scenes from Episode 2 onward, I decided to adjust redness much stronger.

"It's a promise, right?" flashback scene evening—including art, making outlines (main lines) orange was the director's decision, so I first set main lines in colors matching art board main lines, then adjusted colors to match art boards. Initially starting from fairly normal-like colors, "How about boldly making hair orange too?" suggested the director. So boldly trying it, it became that orange.

However, Akashi-san's bag, which was black like hair—following rules it would also become orange, but there's a cut explaining the five-colored "mochiguma" hanging from the bag (actually four colors since one is missing), and so viewers would have "mochiguma" clearly impressed upon them, I deliberately kept the bag behind those "mochiguma" blackish.

Final "Gozan" crowd scene. All characters except main ones got bold single-color silhouette processing, but those color tones and brightness were indeed subtle—they combined nicely on computer monitors, but watching actually shot cuts on checking monitors showed poor balance. Main lines dissolved into painting colors or dissolved against backgrounds. So I requested several retakes (reshoots) for subtle cut-by-cut adjustments.

■Episode 2: Film Club "Misogi"

Storyboard & Direction: Yokoyama Akitoshi, Animation Director: Nishigaki Shoko,
Color Direction: Akimoto Yuki

As with

Casshern Sins

, I was entrusted with color direction staff selection and rotation control this time too, so I contacted acquaintance color direction staff for participation. This time

basically three color direction staff rotation. I handled Episodes 1 and final 11, with remaining nine episodes split three each among three people.

Weekly delivery TV series schedules have biweekly crunches for dubbing coordination and master coordination. Handling this with two people often creates situations where crunch periods for consecutive episodes overlap. With three people, at least one non-crunch week occurs. Since everyone carries other project work too, creating some leeway somewhere is essential—when exhausted during crucial times, it's hard to produce strength.

Top batter was Akimoto-san. I kept showing her Episode 1 footage approaching completion to grasp atmosphere while watching. From then, Episodes 3 and 4 similarly kept showing advanced episode footage for reference.

The big point from Episode 2 onward was "flashback" and "present." Episode 2+ stories had "I" standing at certain points, first half "flashbacking" to events leading there, second half being developments from "present" where "I" stands. "A look that makes you think 'ah, this is flashback'" said the director. So I conceived making both art and cels use sepia-tone brown main line colors, with color tones also consciously brown-sepia to match. Character clothing also changes between present and past. So main locations also had two normal color direction types: regular "normal color" and "flashback normal color." Skin colors stayed the same, but parts that were data "black (BL)" like hair in regular "normal color" were all replaced with "gray-system dark brown" matching backgrounds' darkest colors in "flashback normal color."

Like that, basically all special painting scene by scene. It seemed quite complex and confusing, so from this episode I started writing "color charts" mentioned briefly last time. This made color direction meetings, explanations, and actual work much smoother.

Oh right, Yoshida Mountain flashback scene. "Where exactly is my skin white? There are lots of other people with white skin..." Akashi-san's line. While wanting to retort "No no Akashi-san, you're plenty white," actually Akashi-san's skin color had faint redness, and RGB data-wise "I" had whiter skin. I couldn't help grinning alone (laugh).

■ Bonus: Opening

Storyboard & Direction: Yuasa Masaaki, Video Design & Photography & Editing: Kato Michiya, Color Direction: Tsujita Kunio

For this opening's colors, I handled everything myself. Not just appearing character colors, but background color tone conversion, text colors, live-action movie color tone balance—everything. Being entrusted with everything like this was my first experience—very enjoyable and educational.

Based on imagery conveyed in meetings, I prepared data in advance, then matching it to provisional movies sent by Kato-san, while somewhat restraining the director who was tired from daily storyboard checks and meetings, I decided everything one by one—not just colors but timing of color changes and how many times to change.

Characters spinning at opening's end—when we started making the opening many characters still had unconfirmed colors, so it took until delivery deadline with 2-3 replacements to reach final version colors.

■Continues to Episode 141

(10.10.12)

Color Design Notes [Tsuji Kunitada]

Episode 141:

The Tatami Galaxy

Color Design Notes Volume 2

I've started going to a new studio this month for the first time to prepare for a certain TV series. The equipment is already set up and we're waiting for work to begin in earnest.

As always, what bothers me every time is the height of the desk and chair. I don't have very good posture, and I tend to become quite hunched over when sitting and working. This isn't good, you know, especially for the back. So I consciously set the desk surface quite high and the chair seat low, creating a balance that forces my back to straighten whether I like it or not.

However, the chairs at this studio aren't very good (bitter laugh). They're all quite worn out, so the director and animation director bought their own chairs and brought them in. And honestly, I'm considering it too. Until that's decided, I can't determine the desk height either. I've prepared wooden blocks to place under the desk legs for height adjustment just in case.

So what should I do? For now, I'll try out the studio chairs and see how it goes. So today, I decided to buy a cushion when I go to the studio (laugh).

Anyway.

This week's "

The Tatami Galaxy

Color Design Notes" continues. Episodes 3-5 from DVD & Blu-ray Volume 2.

Episode 3: Cycling Club "Soleil"

Storyboard/Direction/Animation Director: Makihara Ryotaro, Animation Director: Asano Naoyuki, Color Direction (■■■■): Otsuka Natsuko

Schedule-wise, Episode 3 felt like it was being worked on almost parallel with Episode 2. Episode 4 was actual work after Episode 1 was mostly formed, but when we were making Episodes 2 and 3, Episode 1 was still in production. We progressed with quite a bit of exploration about how the visuals would develop.

Episode 3 has more of "I's" delusions than Episode 2. Past recollections, present, and delusions. Broadly divided, the first half part where his bicycle is stolen and he tells the story up to that point is past recollection, and the latter half, where he

returns home dejected, and then from the "Shimanami Cup" is the current timeline. And then delusions.

As I wrote in Episode 2, we make the past recollections recognizable by making the main line colors sepia-toned brown, but we also tried changing the main line colors in various ways for the delusion scenes. And furthermore, we differentiated by making characters other than "I" colorful monotones. The exploratory feeling actually remains in such places, and you can see an atmosphere where we're still holding back a bit. This becomes much clearer in the latter half of the series, but in Episode 3, we still lacked a bit of boldness, I think.

What worked quite well though was the silhouette processing of background characters (■■■). The other players in the bicycle race, spectators, bicycles and parts at the bicycle shop. In this episode, we were able to establish the rules for background character silhouette processing almost completely. "Background characters" refers to passersby, shop customers, and all those other masses of characters.

As I wrote before, I consider the basic stance to be that we're watching from relatively close to the protagonist "I" as he mutters to himself. So people (or things) that "I" isn't directly involved with right now are given thorough silhouette processing since "I" himself isn't interested in them, while people (or things) that "I" is talking to or handling are given color. By doing this, the things related to "I" become colored and clear. This became the major principle going forward.

For example, in the bicycle shop scene. The bicycles and parts placed around or hung on walls are single-color silhouettes. But the parts "I" is holding are colored. Also, for instance, in the recollection scene of Akashi-san's victory press conference. "I" and Akashi-san are colored, while the press corps and surrounding spectators are single-color silhouettes. That's how it works.

The color direction (■■■■) for Episode 3 was done by Otsuka Natsuko-san. She participated while working on a certain theatrical film scheduled for spring release. She gave quite bold color direction, and I left the silhouette color tones almost entirely to Otsuka-san. This sensibility would be fully demonstrated again later in Episode 6.

In Episode 3, there's one scene - well, it's not a failure, but I have some regrets about it - the scene with "I" and Akashi-san during the race at Keage. It's the scene at the magnificent Incline with cherry blossoms. Director Yuasa apparently wanted this to be like the evening scenes in Tadasu Forest used in Episodes 1 and 2, but that would have been problematic timing-wise, so it ended up being a daytime scene. However, to make it a "special scene," we made the main lines pink and finished it in colors that felt pink-purple. But looking back now, ah, I should have gone more boldly with the coloring. From that reflection, or lesson, came the

pink-tinted coloring for "I" and Akashi-san that appeared several times from Episode 4 onward - hair also made pink, becoming the pink version of Episode 1's evening colors.

Episode 4: Seeking Disciples

Storyboard/Direction: Yokoyama Akitoshi, Animation Director: Ito Nobutaka, Color Direction: Suzuki Hisako

Episode 4's direction was by Yokoyama-san. Following Episode 2 with Episode 4, and moreover, quite a heavy episode in terms of volume. Time was quite tight and it was tough (laugh). Color direction was by Suzuki Hisako-san. She was the color designer (■■■■■) for "Stray Cat Overrun!" which was airing at the same time, but I really forced her to take this on despite her busy schedule.

This episode basically follows the current timeline, with past recollections interspersed throughout.

There are so many scenes, hence many detailed color changes, plus props and one-off items, and incomprehensible delusional depictions (laugh) appearing all over the screen. Even the same four-and-a-half-mat room - Master Higuchi's room is extremely cluttered, making the art department's job difficult enough, but then it's night, day, evening, or even imaginary, with every possible color variation existing. Moreover, it's a storm of combined layout and animation cuts. Combined cuts spanning multiple color changes made it a nightmare for the color direction staff (←actually, later episodes would become even more difficult...).

I prepare the color tones for broadly divided scenes, but there were many things that depended on the animation on a cut-by-cut basis rather than scene basis. For now, we had the color direction staff color things based on our meetings, then I'd check and make necessary corrections - this back-and-forth was probably the most frequent in the series. This episode also featured many famous Kyoto specialties. The cockroach cubes also appeared in this episode, and Episode 10, where cockroaches appeared again, also ended up assigned to Suzuki-san. Pure coincidence (laugh).

The evening scene at Kamogawa Delta. The image scene where the delta rises up as Master Higuchi sings and becomes the Nautilus - after the animation came up and we had it colored temporarily, Yokoyama-san and I worked it out together, then sent it back to the color direction staff for refinement.

The climactic "confrontation" scene was tough again, with the cut showing historical representatives appearing on both shoulders. This was difficult in terms of finishing (■■■■■), and Suzuki-san literally had to work on the cel data sheet by sheet to complete it somehow.

Incidentally, the master's hammock was actually animation, and we pasted in chiyogami paper material used for backgrounds for the net parts, which the photography team processed nicely. I did all this pasting myself. For some reason, the workflow developed that way, and I painstakingly transformed materials to match the animation. This was surprisingly fun (laugh). So ultimately, all this work became my responsibility (laugh).

Oh yes, the pink coloring for "I" and Akashi-san I wrote about in the Episode 3 section appears in the scene where "I" and Akashi-san, who were wandering in search of the phantom scrub brush, meet at Nishiki Market.

Episode 5: Softball Circle "Honwaka"

Storyboard: Hamasaki Hirofumi, Direction: Takahashi Tomoya, Animation Director: Ishihama Masashi, Color Direction: Akimoto Yuki

The end of the first half is this suspicious "Honwaka." From escaping the Honwaka headquarters onward is the present; everything before that is past recollection.

This Episode 5 was also quite a troublesome episode, and like Episode 4, involved considerable back-and-forth where the color direction staff would color things and I'd check them. Color direction was by Akimoto-san, her second time.

Episode 5 features many "Honwaka" members, but aside from image scenes and some depth effects, basically we didn't silhouette the "Honwaka" members. They were all tied together with yellow "Honwaka" T-shirts and patches, so I thought it might be better for each individual to have some color variation. And since both the animation and coloring were designed to lack much individuality, I thought not silhouetting them might better bring out that "creepy feeling of a mass without personality." Instead, we thoroughly silhouetted ordinary people.

Kohinata-san was supposed to wear yellow according to the director, so her dress is yellow. Since she's a "black-haired maiden," she has black hair. To differentiate her from other people, her skin and face have no outline colors - everything is the same white. Since the setting was to not draw eyes or nose, this created a nice sense of presence.

Including this Kohinata-san, the past recollection in the first half has both art and coloring arranged in an overall bright, soft, gentle screen, but from when "I" arrives at the "Honwaka" headquarters, following "I's" suspicion and danger signals, it gradually flows into darker color usage. The primary colors of black, green, and blue coming from nozzles in the pure white factory look great. I had Akimoto-san handle this area more and more.

The "brainwashing scene" with drifting pink smoke. The colors of people "popping!" and bursting had already formed in my mind during the art board meeting, and after creating samples with actual cuts and getting approval from director

Takahashi-san, I had Akimoto-san compile them with "please make it like this."

A little before completion, we all watched it through with dialogue and sound, and wow, the Honwaka chairman's speech was magnificent - gave me goosebumps watching it.

At the end, "the 'I' from Episode 10" appears from the window. Like the "100,000 yen" from Episode 4, we creators had a "grin" feeling of "how will viewers react to this?" (laugh).

I'm writing this while rewatching the DVD footage, and the completely dark forest scenes at the beginning and latter half were beautifully dark even on the video check monitor, making me worry "Is this okay? Won't it be invisible on TV?" I think this was ultimately just barely acceptable? Did we adjust it slightly brighter during V-editing? I'm not sure.

The schedule was already getting quite tight from around Episode 5. But thinking back, maybe this area still had plenty of room...

To be continued in Episode 142

(10.10.19)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 142:

The Tatami Galaxy

Color Design Notes Volume 3

There's a cat that has semi-permanently settled in a park near our house. Nicknamed "Char Cat." It's neither red nor three times faster than normal. It's called "Char Cat" because whenever you try to pet it, it always threatens with "Char~" (laugh). But then it'll meow "nya~n" in a cute voice.

This cat seems to be still a kitten or young cat, but apparently was abandoned by someone. So it's interested in people but seems wary somewhere, hence the "Char~." My wife and I had been concerned about this cat for a long time, but recently a neighborhood cat lady took it under her care and apparently made a nice sleeping spot in her yard(?).

But this Char Cat still sometimes sleeps in the park. It roams around freely, sometimes getting food from strangers, and when satisfied, returns to its sleeping spot.

My wife and I have long wanted to keep a cat, but if we were to have one, due to various circumstances, it would probably become what's called an "apartment cat" that never goes outside. But is that really a good thing?

Living without knowing the outside world, without any worries, always together with owners - that's probably happiness in its own way, but living like Char Cat, freely walking around outside and touching various things, is probably also happiness.

I personally think cats should ideally be allowed to go outside freely, and that this is their natural way of being. Both cats and humans should be like that, I think.

What exactly is happiness for a cat? Watching Char Cat makes me think about various things like that.

Anyway.

This week's "

The Tatami Galaxy

Color Design Notes" continues. Episodes 6-8 from DVD & Blu-ray Volume 3, finally entering the second half.

Episode 6: English Conversation Circle "Joy English"

Storyboard/Direction: Natsume Shingo, Animation Directors: Nishigaki Shoji & Asano Naoyuki, Color Direction: Otsuka Natsuko

Episodes 6 through 8 are what I'm arbitrarily calling "'I's Romance Fantasy Trilogy.'" They revolve around "I's" romantic(?) situations with three women: Hanuki-san, Kaori-san, and Keiko-san. Three stories coexist and intertwine on a single timeline, then branch off toward their respective conclusions partway through.

The beginning of these three stories commonly starts from the toilet in Hanuki-san's apartment. "It would be good to visually tie them together, and with strongly impressive screens (colors)," I thought. So during the Episode 7 art board meeting, I made a proposal. "How about an emergency situation feeling, with a bright red toilet like emergency lighting?" Thus, the common image for the opening scenes of Episodes 6-8 became "a bright red toilet like emergency lighting."

Why was it during Episode 7's art board meeting instead of Episode 6's? Because at that point, Episode 7's work far exceeded Episode 6's, so we prioritized Episode 7's meeting (laugh).

So Episode 6, "Hanuki-san." For this episode, I aimed for somewhat flashy colors. As the first of the three episodes, I consciously wanted to add flashiness for impact. The following Episode 7 would be a deliberate, focused presentation centered on "I's" four-and-a-half-mat room revolving around Kaori-san, so I wanted to create contrast in that sense too. Incidentally, Episode 8 would raise the tension again and reach a conclusion.

With that thinking behind Episode 6's color design (■■■■■), the first half progresses relatively quietly, but after drinking one glass of wine, a switch flips and it suddenly becomes high-tension.

This "drinking contest with Jogasaki-senpai" scene. Director Natsume also ordered "make it gradually become strange colors," so I tried to create the feeling of gradually getting drunk and then breaking down(!) with colors. Like Episode 5's "brainwashing scene," I first created character color samples and explained them to the color direction staff, then had them create everything according to the tension of the incoming rough animation. I'm only creating the design blueprint for the screen's coloring - it's each episode's color direction staff who follow it and further expand on it.

The "brain conference" - I was already laughing when I first received the character designs (laugh). Since it could become too raw if done wrong, we made this colorfully pop-colored too. Hanuki-san's runaway pink mode literally made both the art and characters pink (laugh). This area was really fun to work on (laugh).

And "Johnny." First there was the animation character design, then we decided colors like other characters, then had it made into Flash.

Episode 7: Circle "Hero Show Enthusiasts"

Storyboard/Direction/Animation Director: Mihara Michio, Color Direction: Suzuki Hisae

Episode 7 proceeded on an incredibly proper schedule, and we completed meetings around the same time as Episode 4, which had started quite late. So color direction staff Suzuki-san was putting color direction into Episode 7 cuts even before Episode 4, which was delivered first.

"Kaori-san's" Episode 7 takes a deliberate approach. About Kaori-san herself: "This person isn't 'human,' so please change the main line color from human characters so it's recognizable," said Director Yuasa. She first appeared in Episode 2, but we tried various things with Episode 2's director Yokoyama-san included and decided on it.

Character color decisions involved me first creating colors, then showing them to Director Yuasa, character designer Ito-san, and the director in charge of the episode where that character first appears. Various ideas came up during decisions, sometimes resulting in 180-degree direction changes from the initial meeting.

This story is also told through past recollections and present, but in the latter half, after shaking off temptation from Hanuki-san's apartment toilet and returning to the four-and-a-half-mat room, it rides the current timeline. Everything before that is past recollection. And then elopement. Here's the first appearance of Real Otsu. It's a bit hard to tell in the night color-changed scene, but Real Otsu has the same skin color as "I." You can understand this area by watching the final episode's last scene - not only the facial features but also the skin color of the Otsu that "I" saw was such an evil existence (laugh).

Kaori-san comes to "I's" four-and-a-half-mat room. Based on past recollections, there are art distinctions for different times of day - day, night, night without lighting, morning - and we change cel colors accordingly. However, since these are combined cuts (so-called same position) with the same layout depicting multiple time periods, color direction and coloring were quite difficult. During rushes check, there were several "wait, what?(sweat)" moments. And such things would increase even more in subsequent episodes.

From when he embraces Kaori-san and flees under the Kamogawa bridge, we actually change Kaori-san's main line color to the same human character color as "I." Around here, for "I," Kaori-san is no longer a doll but already human. Then when Jogasaki comes and delivers a kick, he literally wakes from the dream, and simultaneously we return Kaori-san to doll status.

Incidentally, the Mochiguman show at the opening scene, with children's "Reform yourself!" chants. This might be scarier than "Honwaka" depending on how you think about it (laugh). Oh yes, about the Mochiguman in the Mochiguman show - originally there are five colors and five bodies, but actually only four appear in this scene. But there are five colors. Why did this happen? There was some reason for it, but...

Episode 8: Reading Circle "SEA"

Storyboard: Shimizu Hiroshi, Direction: Fujise Jun'ichi, Animation Director: Ito Nobutaka, Color Direction: Akimoto Yuki

The last of "'I's Romance Fantasy Trilogy" is the correspondence story with Keiko-san. "How about if 'I's' delusions in the letters gradually become more realistic?" was the conversation during the art board meeting. I think during the meeting we talked about "how can we differentiate reality from delusion?" and the discussion progressed toward making the delusion scenes look unlike the

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style we'd had up to that point.

The animation also has sparkling eyes! in a realistic(?) "I," so we aimed for a nice feel by placing it over backgrounds. The decisions for those cuts also followed the flow of having the color direction staff create colors from the animation's atmosphere, with me checking. So basically it was super-short decisive battle work after backgrounds came up. Well, not just for this scene - in

The Tatami Galaxy

, almost all scenes were in that situation. Moreover, schedules were getting quite tight, and from Episode 8 onward, it was quite a fragrant situation (bitter laugh).

Also, from around Episode 8, using processed scenes and cuts from previous episodes increased dramatically. Until then, there were scenes used repeatedly throughout the series as-is (sometimes with additions) like the castella-gorging scene in the four-and-a-half-mat room or the conversation scene with Otsu at the Okinawan restaurant, but from Episode 8 onward, the usage became somewhat different.

As I wrote earlier, these three episodes from Episode 6 tell three stories progressing in parallel on a single timeline, so structurally, screens from previous episodes would be used repeatedly. However, they're not used as-is - we change the color of the entire screen including backgrounds to give meaning to those scenes. Since familiar scenes and cuts appear repeatedly, the purpose is to visually organize the increasingly complex timeline intersections. For example, the series of "Mochiguman Show" scenes that appeared in Episode 7. These appear

twice in Episode 8, but we change colors each time, and change the color-changing method differently both times.

The first time is used as fictitious "Actually..." that "I" wrote in a letter. Only "I" including Mochiguman is normal color, while everything else (including newly added conversations of children in the bus for Episode 8) is gloomy blue-tinted monotone. With somewhat negative implications, arranged in heavy colors. The second time appears as Akashi-san's recollection. Since it's from Akashi-san's viewpoint, Akashi-san and "I (Mochiguman)" are colored. Others are bright monotone. Since it's Akashi-san's good memory, it's arranged brightly and softly.

All such processing was actually left entirely to me. I was allowed to work on everything including backgrounds. I'd create processed screens thinking about directional meaning, then have the director and direction staff check them. I'd try changing color direction for cels and backgrounds, or make only specific characters different colors, preparing photography materials with such processing, then having them re-shot with basically the same time sheet.

Generally, it's common to add color processing by applying filters to the entire screen during photography or editing, but actually, we "color people" aren't very happy about that. However, in

The Tatami Galaxy

, there was almost none of that. Even when processing during photography, we were consulted by the photography staff.

This work increased more and more in subsequent episodes, and I actually handled everything single-handedly until the final episode. But you know, it was enjoyable work! As a designer (■■■), you delegate each episode to the assigned color direction staff, so you can't really directly touch the main footage to participate in each episode yourself. Being able to touch the screen like this without infringing on the color direction staff's work divisions made me very happy.

To be continued in Episode 143

(10.10.26)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 143:

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Color Design Notes Volume 4 (Final Volume)

The other day, the professional baseball draft was held, and promising young people were each selected by various teams. Previously, I used to think the draft "violates freedom of career choice," but recently my thinking has changed somewhat - actually, isn't it like hoping to join a big company called "Professional Baseball" and being assigned to one of 12 branch offices called "teams"? After all, these days students submit "job applications" saying "I'm going pro!"

But then how about making the "starting salary" uniform? Then from the second year onward, raises would be based on ability. What do you think?

People who don't want to go to the company called "Japanese Professional Baseball" and want to go to America, which is a "foreign company," can submit "job applications" there. Some people who have worked long-term for "Japanese Professional Baseball" might want to "change jobs" to America. Well, whether they're hired or can get the job varies.

I'm thinking about various things like this on autumn nights. ...Eh? Japan Series? What are you talking about? Incidentally, I'm a Giants fan (laugh).

Anyway.

First, let me start with the "bonus" notes.

The Tatami Galaxy

was decided from the beginning to have 11 episodes for the main story, but additionally, production of a "side story" for DVD & Blu-ray bonus content equivalent to one TV-length episode was decided. It ultimately became three short films, but we in production called it "Episode 12" as work progressed.

Schedule-wise, we made it immediately after working on the main story's final episode without a break. "Since it's just a 'bonus,' keep it light," said Director Yuasa. It has quite a different feel from the main story. Incidentally, I did the color direction myself. Three different styles, like independent films shown at school festivals - it was very interesting!

Bonus Episode 1 (Episode 12-2): Underground Submarine to Antarctica

Storyboard/Direction/Animation: Mihara Michio, Color Direction: Tsujita Kunio

This is director Mihara-san's "solo animation" episode. All the realistic line touches for backgrounds were also drawn by Mihara-san (during the art meeting, Mihara-san had already drawn on drawing paper for backgrounds and brought them).

In the main TV series, character skin was basically colorless "white," but in this "bonus," we departed from that principle and worked freely. However, "if we stray too far, how would that be?" so we decided to minimize basic color count and color divisions. That's how this visual came about.

These three "bonus" episodes had color restrictions: Natsume-san's second one was "pink" or rather "red," Miyazawa-san's third one was "black and white," and this first one by Mihara-san was "blue." Otsu appears as an octopus monster, and initially Mihara-san ordered "pinkish." A pink octopus in a blue-white world. However, when we actually placed the color, it didn't settle well. So ultimately, the Otsu octopus also became blue. I quite like this blue Otsu octopus.

Bonus Episode 2 (Episode 12-3): Underground Submarine to Women's Bath
~Boudoir Investigation Team Pink Exploration~

Storyboard/Direction/Animation: Natsume Shingo, Color Direction: Tsujita Kunio

This is also director Natsume-san's "solo animation." Natsume-san has completely become the "pink person" (laugh). In this episode, it's all about Akashi-san in a school swimsuit! The way Hanuki-san's shoulder strap slips, her naked towel appearance - Natsume-san is definitely aiming for the "pink" position (laugh).

Actually, pink is quite difficult to create on PC monitors and doesn't display the way we think it should. No matter how much you raise the saturation, you can't really see the change. But when this gets shot and converted to video signal, it unexpectedly displays flashily, or the color shifts to red or purple. But this time it was "red" rather than "pink." It worked quite well.

Like Mihara-san's, this subtly incorporates the atmosphere of "The Night Is Short, Walk on Girl." Both feature a character called "Rihaku." Plus "God of the Used Book Market" also appears.

Bonus Episode 3 (Episode 12-1): Love and Fishing Underground Submarine

Storyboard/Direction/Animation: Miyazawa Yasunori, Color Direction: Tsujita Kunio

"Miyazawa-san is a bit of an unusual person," several people whispered to me before the meeting, but no no, he was completely normal. He was perhaps a bit single-mindedly passionate to excess (laugh), but very wonderful. This Miyazawa-san episode was actually "bonus" Episode 1, and resetting the principles we'd cultivated over 11 episodes for this meeting left me and the art staff a bit confused.

This episode is also Miyazawa-san's "solo animation." Characters are colored, or rather colorless(?), with "white I," "black I," "white Otsu," "black Otsu"... well, something like that - a somewhat complex visual story, but since animation came up steadily in cut number order, I could do color direction following the storyboard sequence, which was very clear and helpful.

However, one evening when we were fairly close to completion, after rushes check and retake assignments were finished and Miyazawa-san had left for home, I suddenly got a phone call from Miyazawa-san.

"Um, the color of the harpoon, well, I'm really sorry, but I want to change it. I'm on the train right now, and I just thought of something, and then I really wanted to change it..."

"I" holds a vividly colored harpoon in the main story, and he wanted to change the blade tip color from light blue to reddish-black.

So from there, we spent several hours repainting all the finished cels (laugh). Actually, at that point, almost all cuts had finished coloring work. Miyazawa-san felt bad about this for a long time afterward, but no no, I was completely fine with it. Because the color after this change fit the screen much better. Ah, amazing - Miyazawa-san's intuitive power! Another director I definitely want to work with again! (laugh)

...And that ends the "bonus" talk. Now, let's go straight to the main story until the end!

Episode 9: Secret Organization "Lucky Cat Restaurant"

Storyboard/Direction: Yokoyama Akitoshi, Animation Director: Makihara Ryotaro, Color Direction: Saito Mayu

According to the original rotation, Episode 9's color direction should have been Otsuka-san from Episodes 3 and 6, but she couldn't participate due to another project's crunch, so Saito-san joined instead. And that one episode turned out to be quite difficult (laugh).

Episode 9 is the summary story of everything up to this point. The Lucky Cat Restaurant and Otsu had been pulling strings behind all the organizations "I" had been involved with. And "I" is... The bicycle cleanup army scene where Akashi-san slaps him at the night Incline is the present (the pre-OP too), everything before that is past recollection.

"Let's change colors by 'I's' affiliation to make it easy to understand," said Director Yuasa at the art board meeting. We'd color-code scenes by the organization "I" belongs to at Lucky Cat Restaurant. "Library Police" is blue-tinted, "Print Shop" is green-tinted, and "Bicycle Cleanup Army" is yellow-tinted.

When art boards came up, I created color tones by placing characters on boards as usual and had the director & direction staff check them. Initially I thought "backgrounds in respective colors" with characters staying relatively normal throughout might work, but "ah, no, let's change everything," said the director. "Let's make characters completely monotone-ish too." I immediately remade colors on the spot and got approval from Director Yuasa and Yokoyama-san. Accordingly, we color-changed not only new material but also bank cuts from past episodes as usual.

Since it's a summary episode, many past scenes and cuts appear dizzingly. However, there was a pleasant feeling of various fragments connecting, and while I felt sorry for Saito-san about the difficult work, I was actually quite enjoying it (laugh).

"You must not use the word 'possibility' indefinitely." "Being captivated by things that don't exist leads nowhere. Placing hope in unreliable things like your other possibilities is the root of all evil." "You must acknowledge yourself as unable to become anything other than who you are here and now." These are Master Higuchi's words at early morning Kamogawa Delta, in response to "I's" wandering and troubled questioning. I think this scene is a major pillar of this work. The gentle Kamogawa background with a slight blue tint in the black and white monotone foundation, and the blue tint of Master Higuchi's scarf created a truly transparent and beautiful screen. It's my favorite scene.

Episode 10: Four-and-a-Half-Mat-ist

Storyboard/Direction: CHOI EUNYOUNG, Animation Directors: Ito Nobutaka & Ishihama Masashi, Color Direction: Suzuki Hisae

Episode 10 is the story of not leaving, or rather not being able to leave, the four-and-a-half-mat room. Finally the second-to-last, finally the climax.

For Episode 10, our color team had it much easier than the art team by far. What made it so difficult? Because the enclosed four-and-a-half-mat world was to be made almost entirely with photographic backgrounds. People unfamiliar with this might think "you don't have to draw, so it's easy!" but no no, absolutely not! I may not be the one to say this, but drawing everything from scratch would be so much easier!

Actually, during production, we rented an actual four-and-a-half-mat room somewhere in Tokyo. We brought in various items (mostly Director Yuasa's personal belongings (laugh)) to construct a photography model of "I's" room. The live-action four-and-a-half-mat room that appeared in the main story, including the opening, was mostly shot here. Now, if we could have photographed that four-and-a-half-mat room exactly according to the completed storyboards and layouts, that certainly would have been easy. But in reality, that wasn't possible.

We certainly had a real four-and-a-half-mat room as a model. But no matter how we tried to shoot with the camera, we could never capture exactly the angles from the storyboards. Because the layouts intentionally distorted perspective. That unique "Yuasa perspective." It's not perspective that can be created with formulas. So how did we actually create those photographic backgrounds? By cutting and pasting and combining massive amounts of reference photos.

Using the massive photo materials shot in that room, every cut was a collage storm. There were almost no cuts where a single photo could be used as-is - at most, close-ups of tatami mats. Most backgrounds used this photo as the base for this cut, this bookshelf from that photo, that wall and window from this other photo - cutting and pasting and gathering them together, transforming them in Photoshop while fitting them to the layout's distorted perspective. And drawing(!) the missing parts - truly mind-numbing work.

Meanwhile, for colors, we decided basically not to change them after being confined. However, there was a slight communication miss, or rather confirmation miss, between me and Unyoung-san. I intended to go normal, but Unyoung-san was thinking monochrome tone. Normal is very monochrome tone-ish, but actually has proper colors in it. When cels started coming up and several rushes came up, this problem was discovered. We hurriedly corrected the cels. Really, I was truly sorry > everyone involved

Episode 11 (Final Episode): The End of the Four-and-a-Half-Mat Era

Storyboard/Direction: Yuasa Masaaki, Animation Director: Ito Nobutaka, Color Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Finally the final episode. At the series start, I first handled color direction for Episode 1 and somehow wanted to do the final episode too, but the schedule was truly pressed, and from Episode 8 onward, episodes had almost one week from color direction start to master delivery. Furthermore, the final episode's storyboard took until the very last minute, making it the episode with the least available time in the series. "This is impossible at my speed (cry)." I certainly wanted to do it myself, but judging from a production standpoint, it was better to have someone faster handle it. So I had Akimoto-san, who had the greatest speed among our color direction team, handle it.

Actually, for the final episode, processing Episode 1's bank material and the massive amount of other bank material processing would all become my work, so I couldn't realistically handle it together with the main story's new cuts. Ultimately, over 1/3 of the total cuts were material cuts I processed, so well, I did 1/3 together! (laugh).

Such was final Episode 11.

"It doesn't need to connect at all, so we're changing animation for each frame, so please colorfully color each cel," said Director Yuasa. The world seen after being released from the "four-and-a-half-mat-ist" curse was truly a world filled with colorful brilliance. We were trying to create visuals exactly like that. At this point, it was really "color direction staff, please handle it!" and I had Akimoto-san work hard, but when I saw the results, the colorfulness was still a bit reserved. So I applied tone correction to those cels and raised the saturation dramatically with "here we go!" The correction was applied so hard that each individual color looked like primary colors - that's how we got that screen.

Episode 11's climax was the night at Gozan that appeared in Episode 1. Actually, the script I received only went to Episode 3, and after that I only had a plot for about 9-10 episodes, so I didn't know how Episode 11 would turn out. Well, I thought "the very end will probably be in the hospital room with that line" (laugh), but I didn't know until Director's storyboard actually came up. But when I was making Episode 1, I had a vague feeling that "the final episode will probably return to this night at Gozan." And well, it was right on target!

What I was vaguely thinking during Episode 1 was "I want to properly color these background character silhouettes in the final episode." So I put color into each of those bank material background character silhouettes one by one. This was quite a difficult job in a good way (bitter laugh). Originally when making Episode 1, most of these background scenes were instructed as "free coloring," left to the coloring staff to paint with individual color divisions. In Episode 1, we ultimately repainted them as single colors, but this time we recreated the color divisions from scratch. If we had kept the very first colored data, we could have made it somewhat easier based on that, but well, that's that. Despite having little time and being difficult, I was working quite enjoyably (laugh). And thanks to that effort, the flow from the colorful world "I" looked around at Hyakumanben intersection to the subsequent screens came together really nicely.

For Episode 11's scene color changes, what the director and I refined until the very end was that summer recollection scene of the used book festival at Shimogamo Shrine grounds. The major axis of

The Tatami Galaxy

is "I" and Otsu, but another axis is definitely "I" and Akashi-san.

"Green" for this scene was decided from the art board meeting, so how should we build it accordingly? In this recollection, for the first time in the series, "I" confesses that he "fell for Akashi-san." So I wanted to make this scene the best scene in Episode 11.

The best scene for "I" and Akashi-san is that Episode 1 evening recollection scene in Tadasu Forest. So naturally, both the director and I headed in that direction. Built

like when we created the colors for that evening recollection scene, that's how we arrived at those colors for that scene.

...And with that, we've finished all episodes including "bonus" (applause).

This is self-praise, but this isn't just my work - it's very good work that we all in the color team accomplished together with all the color direction staff who worked hard with me. This color team was truly a dream team for me. And I'm truly grateful to everyone for being able to work with the wonderful, or rather amazing staff including Director Yuasa. They were truly enjoyable days. A wonderful experience from late autumn 2009 to early summer 2010. And I hope that someday, somehow, all of us can meet again somewhere.

To be continued in Episode 144

(10.11.02)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 144: Long Ago... 83 1995 Part 3 Shocking March (First Half) Return to Manila

This autumn, we've had a succession of obituaries for people who captivated us during our boyhood and youth and had no small influence on us, and recently even news of the accidental death of

Space Battleship Yamato's

Producer Nishizaki... What is this? I'm filled with such lonely feelings.

Looking at Mr. Nishizaki's career again, I was surprised - when that TV series

Space Battleship Yamato

that we were so enthusiastic about was being produced, he was still only in his early 40s. I see, when I lined up all night at that Shinjuku movie theater on opening day for

Farewell Space Battleship Yamato

, the man himself I glimpsed that day was younger than I am now! Realizing that gave me goosebumps.

I can't become like Mr. Nishizaki, but I want to participate with good work and dedication in as many productions as possible that all the boys and girls of today will watch. That's what I think.

Anyway.

In early March 1995, after finishing work on the theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta

, I was once again heading from the pre-dawn Oizumi Studio to Narita Airport with my aluminum trunk. Another business trip to EEI-TOEI in Manila, Philippines. This time for two weeks. Last time had strong meaning as inspection & reporting, but this time I would actually work together with them and then provide various guidance.

The big difference from last time was accommodation. This time, instead of a hotel, I'd stay at a house rented for Japanese staff on long-term assignment. Near EEI-TOEI's studio, there was a section where housing for former US military personnel in the Philippines once existed, and they were renting one house in that area. The roads accessing the residential area had gates with 24-hour armed guards carrying automatic rifles, so security inside was definitely good. The

residents all had a wealthy atmosphere.

Daily life in Manila: wake up in the morning, take a not-very-hot shower to wake up, walk to the studio by 10 AM. Breakfast was bought on the way to the studio - cheeseburger and cola from a hamburger stand operating on the roadside, eaten at the studio. Lunch and dinner were with studio staff at nearby restaurants. Work until around 8-9 PM then return to lodging. Such days continued. Unlike last time where someone came to pick me up at the hotel, being able to move at my own pace was very comfortable.

Actually, this time there was another person accompanying me besides myself. M-kun, an in-betweener from a certain subcontracting production company. He was to be stationed for three months as an in-between checker, and I was to take him along. M-kun and I stayed together at the Staff House (that's what we called the rented house). There was already one person staying at that Staff House: senior animation director Kino Tatsuo-san. M-kun and I were completely taken care of by Kino-san.

At that time, Toei Animation (■■■■■) was putting effort into training in-betweeners at EEI-TOEI. In addition to the smoothly running finishing (■■■■) department, they wanted to grow the in-between department to a large scale and have integrated in-between and finishing work done. In other words, the plan was to strengthen a system where rough animation sent to the Manila studio would properly return to Tokyo as cels. While coloring work could stably handle quite a volume, in-betweening hadn't reached that level yet, and there were often temporary breaks in coloring while waiting for in-betweening to finish. So training in-betweeners and stabilizing quality and quantity was urgent. Furthermore, they were also training background staff at the Manila studio. And even further, they were preparing one camera stand. They aimed to construct a system where even photography would be done in Manila - send rough animation and get film back.

So Kino-san was there for that in-betweener training. Actually, Kino-san was fluent in English, so communication with local staff had absolutely no barriers. Particularly for teaching in-betweening nuances, language is important after all. It was just wonderful! And at the same time, I was envious. The "students" trying to learn in-betweening seemed lively, full of desire to study! to learn! Among those students, some had difficulty progressing due to natural "aptitude" differences, but their earnest attitude was admirable.

On the other hand, what about our finishing? Looking around, many people were certainly working seriously, but there were still several staff with a "this kind of thing, you know, just do it roughly like this" attitude. Being there longer and watching, unlike last time, such points gradually became visible. But those types had strange confidence and pride, and no matter how much I warned them and tried to get them to improve, it was completely useless. Tracing and coloring

should be special skills, but conversely, they're also skills "anyone can do to some extent." Those doing it understand this, and the motivation vectors underlying "drawing" and "painting" seem quite different.

Even so, what bound together such finishing in a sense was the "inspection" team. They (overwhelmingly female) were members pulled up from tracing and coloring, and not only did finishing inspection after coloring, but also provided technical guidance to tracing and coloring staff through completion checks, took care of consistency for inadequate parts of color direction we put in from Tokyo, or directly inquired with Tokyo. Moreover, inspection and retake processing was a race against time until flights to Tokyo departed. Their work ethic was truly admirable.

Having received lots of courage and lots of harsh opinions about color direction improvements from those women, I headed home (bitter laugh).

And then, several days later. I was in Narita Airport's departure lobby again. This time, heading to Seoul, Korea!

To be continued in Episode 145

(10.11.09)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 145: Long Ago... 84 1995 Part 4 Shocking March (Middle) What Awaited Us in Seoul...

In about two more weeks, the live-action "Space Battleship Yamato" - that is, "SPACE BATTLESHIP Yamato" - will be released. Man, I'm getting excited about it!

Actually, when this film's production was announced, honestly I was thinking "Bah!" You know, manga and animation adaptations almost never succeed! (←declaration! lol) And it's "Yamato"! That immortal masterpiece "Yamato" from our boyhood, made into live-action! Such a thing, you know, "Bah!" - that kind of thing.

But you know, being shown the gradually released preview footage, I did a 180-degree turn! "This might actually work," I thought. Now I'm at 120% anticipation! Man, I'm already done for before even watching (laugh). I want to see it so badly that I was scheming to get preview screening tickets through acquaintances, but struck out completely. All the general preview applications were also misses. Covering my ears to preview group spoiler talk, I'm helplessly waiting for general release (cry). Incidentally, I bought two advance tickets targeting the bonus items (laugh).

Like

Yamato Resurrection

released last winter, I really do love

Space Battleship Yamato

. The other day I was talking about the

Yamato Resurrection

movie at a certain gathering, and Director Yuasa told me "Tsujita-san is too kind to movies lol," but you know, it's fine.

Yamato

is in a different league (laugh). But really, I hope it's a hit.

My friends since high school are also quietly but quite passionately excited about "let's all go see it!" The audience will definitely have an extremely high "middle-aged man ratio"!

Anyway.

After returning from the two-week Manila business trip, a few days later I was departing for Seoul, Korea.

Actually, this Seoul trip was a private vacation. Four of us friends who share hardships at Toei Animation somehow thought of a Seoul trip and went on a 2-night, 3-day package tour. Just a completely ordinary package tour with a tour guide, so we'd tour normally, eat normally, and normally spend money at duty-free shops before returning. Since we at Toei are always indebted to Korean production companies for theatrical works, we're naturally curious about Korea. What kind of city is it, what kind of culture, what does everyone eat to keep going (laugh). The trigger was that kind of light feeling.

The plane carrying us arrived on schedule at Seoul's Gimpo Airport. Through immigration, through customs, to the arrival lobby. Since it wasn't work, no big aluminum case. Everyone traveled light with just one piece of hand luggage. Going through the automatic doors to the wide arrival lobby, as expected, a Korean female tour guide holding a big card with our names was waiting for us. "Ooh! Having your name written like this feels pretty good!" At 33 years and 11 months, having my first package tour experience, I was quite excited.

However! The tour guide wasn't the only one waiting for us. Several somewhat tough-looking, solidly built Korean men were waiting for our arrival!

"■■-San, right?" The leader-like man among the group approached ■■-san, the central figure of our group of four. Behind his lightly tinted sunglasses, his sharp eyes gleamed. "We've come to meet you! Come, please!" "...Huh? (sweat)" went us and the tour guide. "Eh? What? Who are you people exactly..."

Actually, they were people from D Company, a Seoul animation production company with deep ties to Toei Animation - ah no, the president, production manager, and production staff. Having secretly obtained information that we were starting a Seoul trip today, they declared they would take over our group of four instead of the tour guide. Of course, this was completely unexpected for us. However, leaving us bewildered, the president was saying something forcefully to the tour guide. We watched this situation in amazement. Other tour customers looked on anxiously. The conversation between the tour guide and president was of course in Korean, so we had no idea what was being discussed, but with the condition "please definitely bring them to the hotel for check-in by ■ o'clock!" the tour guide somehow gave in... (bitter laugh).

Thus began D Company's grand Seoul hospitality tour (laugh). Depending on how you look at it, this was kidnapping (laugh). We no longer had any means to resist (laugh). "But, well, it's okay (bitter laugh)" - things had become quite interesting.

To be continued in Episode 146

(10.11.16)

Color Design Notes [Tsuji Kunitada]

Episode 146: Long Ago... 85 1995 Part 5 Shocking March (Final) What Awaited Us in Tokyo...

For several years now, I've been using a razor-type shaver to shave my beard. Until then, I used an electric shaver, but that thing surprisingly scatters the shaved whiskers. Well, maybe the more expensive models don't do this, but anyway, the several-thousand-yen class one I was using splendidly scattered shaved whiskers everywhere. Once I noticed this one day, it bothered me so much that I ultimately converted to using a razor-type shaver.

When shaving with that razor-type shaver, I use something called shaving cream. Lotions, gels - various types have come out recently, but I'm definitely a shaving cream devotee. However, the thing is, I don't know the proper amount.

How much should I smear on my face each time before starting to shave? I've been unable to find the answer to this day. Shaving cream has that nice fluffy texture that makes you want to use lots and put it on your face, but does that actually help with the original act of shaving whiskers? If you put too much on, maybe you can't actually shave whiskers properly? But if it's too little, that's lonely in its own way.

Every time I shave, I think about such things and try various approaches. But I still tend to use too much cream. It's also fun to see myself like that at 47.

Anyway.

After being "kidnapped" at Seoul's Gimpo Airport, we were split between two cars and first taken to D Company's headquarters.

Where exactly we drove - well, it was my first time in Seoul. No matter where we went, I had no idea (laugh), but the company was in what seemed like a somewhat downtown-ish(?) area. We were shown to the chairman's office. There was the chairman who was the mastermind behind our "kidnapping."

"Thank you for this time" - it's strange for us to say that, isn't it?" I thought while giving greetings anyway. Come to think of it, I remembered gradually that I had met this person in Tokyo before. Then, one after another, familiar faces were invited into the room. Korean animators and art staff. They were all people who had come to work at Toei Animation (■■■■■) for a period, so we knew each other loosely. We chatted for a while. Oh yes, everyone spoke Japanese fluently. This always amazes me. We can only say things like "Kamsahamnida" or "Maekchu juseyo" or "Jeongmal masisseoyo!" - quite mysterious and somewhat frustrating moments.

Lunch with other company employees at a restaurant near headquarters. After eating and returning, the chairman asked, "So, where would you like to go?" "We'd like to see production company studios here," we said. Somehow, we were really serious about these kinds of things. Or rather, Seoul animation production sites were definitely spots we couldn't easily see otherwise. What we most wanted to see in Seoul was actually animation studios (laugh).

"Well, Kim-san will come soon, so it would be good to see Kim-san's company." At that time, D Company was already shifting from animation production to rights management and publishing business, and the production site had become quite small. Kim-san, who arrived shortly after, was president of E Company, a production company that had participated as a main force during the crunch for the recent theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

. So we could actually observe a hot, current production site.

"Well, welcome!" said Kim-san. Come to think of it, I had met her in Tokyo a month earlier. Felt a bit strange (laugh). Leaving D Company, we headed to E Company. Again, I didn't really know the location, but apparently several production companies were gathered in this area. We were invited inside and immediately began touring. Staff had mostly gone home right after a busy project ended, but we were super lucky to see an actual working site.

What interested me was naturally the finishing (■■■■) department. The studio's second floor was the finishing room, and wow, you could feel the fighting spirit! There were ingenious touches everywhere for efficiently progressing work in short time - very educational.

For example, paint bottles. Normally you line up paints in thin glass bottles, but honestly, there's limited space around desks so you can't line up very many. At this studio, they were amazingly using 35mm negative film - you know, regular camera film containers. They put paint in those cases! Of course, colors used in large quantities were in glass bottles, but for colors used only a little at a time but with quite a variety of colors, this method worked well. Since they're low height, you can line them up in desk drawers.

Come to think of it, domestically (within Toei Animation?) there were small glass bottles called "tracing bottles," and tracers did color tracing with paint in those. Thinking about it, we also used paint in tracing bottles for minor corrections during inspection.

A further innovation was drying shelf usage. To dry paint applied to cels, you put painted cels one by one on shelves, but here they rolled them tightly and stuck them in shelves to save space. They'd roll them into horizontal U-shapes and push

them into 3-4 centimeter gaps between upper and lower shelf boards. Since cels have resilient force trying to return to their original shape, being held down by upper and lower shelf boards prevents cels from sticking together. We often used such methods for long cels, but here they used this method even for standard cels. It's impossible for large painted areas, but for small painted areas or things painted only on the right or left half of cels, unpainted parts can be rolled and turned upside down safely. Moreover, since they were using high-viscosity Taiyo Shisai paint, such feats might be possible. Well, maybe I just didn't know and the same thing was being done at domestic finishing production companies using Taiyo colors, but in any case, for us using low-viscosity STAC paint, it was eye-opening to see methods we'd never thought of!

Other areas - animation and art - all seemed to have their own unique innovations, making for quite good learning!

Now. After the tour ended, it was already evening. That night, Kim-san took us to an extremely expensive-looking Korean court cuisine restaurant. A banquet hosted by D Company's chairman from earlier. We enjoyed delicious food here. And afterward, amazingly, a casino. Seoul has public casinos. Actually, the president of a certain K Production from Japan happened to be in D Company's chairman's office earlier, and he took us for a casino experience. Everyone except me was experiencing casinos for the first time. Actually, I had already experienced it in Manila. The result? Amazingly, only I made quite a profit! So I paid for the taxi fare back to the hotel and tips. The next day I bought a pretty nice bag with that money (laugh).

The next day was a full day of sightseeing. Again cared for by E Company's Kim-san. Touring around Seoul in her car. And that night, another banquet by D Company's chairman (laugh). It had become such an embarrassingly grand hospitality tour. Come to think of it, what happened to the package tour we were supposed to participate in? (bitter laugh)

And the day after that, we were already returning home. Reunited with the tour guide at the airport (bitter laugh). We had her handle procedures quietly without much conversation and became passengers.

On that flight, I encountered tremendously sad news. Voice actor Yamada Yasuo-san, famous for

Lupin III

, had passed away. I learned this from Japanese newspapers on the plane. This was shocking. We spoke little, and the plane headed to Narita.

And at Narita Airport, we would encounter even more surprising news. That morning, someone had spread sarin gas in Tokyo's subway, resulting in many

deaths! It had become a major confusion, a major incident! We were stunned. It was March 20, 1995.

To be continued in Episode 147

(10.11.30)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 147: Long Ago... 86 1995 Part 6 Somewhat Heavy April and May

Every year, my biggest concern in December, or rather agony, is actually New Year's cards.

Honestly, New Year's cards - please, no more! I think. Because I have to think about design right in the middle of year-end rush and such, and that's extremely difficult. "Then just stop! Quit doing them!" people say, and actually I think "should I quit?" too, but still, since I'm the eldest son, I need to send them to relatives, and there are old acquaintances and friends connected only through New Year's card exchanges. Plus, every year Web Anime Style here sends me that annual New Year's card project proposal (laugh).

"Then just buy ready-made designs and send those," people say, but that also seems somehow bland. Well, it's not like I can write or draw anything particularly impressive. I'm just stubborn about wanting to make my own design no matter how terrible it is.

That's why it's quite difficult (bitter laugh).

Actually, next year I discovered I'm a zodiac year man! Wow, the zodiac has finally cycled four times (sweat). My goodness. "Then let's work hard and make something amazing!" ...But you see, again, this is impossible.

Such is me caught in the New Year's card spiral this December.

Anyway.

After returning from the mysterious "2-night, 3-day Seoul kidnapping & hospitality tour," we immediately faced the sarin incident, followed by the shooting incident targeting National Police Agency Commissioner-General Kunimatsu, and society was wrapped in heavy atmosphere during spring 1995. I entered April feeling quite unsettled by these two major incidents.

"Maybe it'll be quiet for a while?" I thought, but the script for the next theatrical work was properly waiting for me. Script: Koyama Takao, Art Setting: Kubota Tadao, Art Director: Higashi Jun'ichi, Animation Director: Yamamuro Tadayoshi, Supervisor: Yamauchi Shigeyasu, Director: Hashimoto Mitsuo. Theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Dragon Fist Explosion!! If Goku Won't Do It, Who Will?

This was my 6th theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

.

One day, a mysterious old man appears before Great Saiyaman (Gohan and Videl), pleading to release a hero sealed in a music box. The hero Tapion appears when the seal is broken by calling the Dragon. Trunks adores Tapion like a brother, but Tapion's expression hardens and he pushes Trunks away. Actually, the monster Hirudegarn is sealed within Tapion's body, and with Tapion's revival, Hirudegarn's seal is also broken and he revives. Then the death battle between Hirudegarn and Goku's group begins... Such was the story.

In theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

films, series creator Toriyama Akira-san usually wasn't involved much in the stories themselves, but he would draw original concepts for guest characters appearing in the films if requested. This time, seeing the rough drawing of hero Tapion's character concept sent by Toriyama-san, we staff all said the same thing in unison: "Is this going to be okay? (sweat)" The rough drawing sent looked exactly like Chrono, a key character from the Super Famicom game "Chrono Trigger" that had been released just about a month earlier.

This "Chrono Trigger" was a game where Toriyama-san handled character design, and it had quite a reputation even before release. "Probably when Toriyama-san draws now, everyone ends up looking similar in this direction," we thought. Still, we couldn't exactly reject Toriyama-san's work, so Yamamuro-san and director Hashimoto-kun consulted and gradually tweaked details to make the character. Then it came to me. Time to decide colors.

Now, what to do?

How much can you change something that already looks similar at the line art level through color? If it were me now, I might have thought about it more and established some strategy, but at that time, I was completely influenced by "Chrono." The colors of this "Chrono" were really good. They perfectly hit my sweet spot at the time. And above all, this Tapion's positioning in the story and that color balance strangely matched. If I wanted to change the impression through color, I should have done the exact opposite of "Chrono's" coloring scheme and adjusted from there, but story-wise, a bright-colored Tapion was impossible, and most importantly, myself, Hashimoto-kun, and Yamamuro-san were all somehow imagining red hair. So with red hair and subdued blue-tinted clothes... no matter how we changed small parts, it would inevitably become "Chrono."

"This is definitely problematic!" said producer Morishita-san. Well, yes. Exactly right. We understood that. What should we do? But well, it can't be helped - that's the direction it went, and I think we ultimately removed the bandana he originally had to show the shaved head part, modified hair from red to orange-tinted vermillion, further adjusted clothing shape, moved the color used for clothes to a

long scarf, and changed the clothes themselves to lighter brown. This gave us somewhat of a "different thing" feeling.

Now, we somehow found a compromise for Tapion, but actually Hirudegarn too. Hirudegarn first appears as upper and lower body, which was still okay, but when combined into complete form, it started looking like Cell. But well, this was similar-or-not within the same

Dragon Ball Z

, so "it's not on screen very long anyway (laugh)" and we somehow cleared it.

But honestly, as a

Dragon Ball Z

work, it was already at its limit. Character design and story - we were simply out of material. The TV and theatrical series that had continued endlessly up to this point - their former charm had become quite questionable.

And in such circumstances, that day finally came. The end of

Dragon Ball's

serialization in Weekly Shonen Jump was decided.

To be continued in Episode 148

(10.12.07)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 148: Long Ago... 87 1995 Part 7

Dragon Ball Z's

End in June

Have you all seen it yet? The movie "SPACE BATTLESHIP Yamato." I couldn't stand it anymore and eagerly went to see it on the second day of release.

As for my impression, I was quite satisfied... If I write that, everyone will probably tell me I'm "too soft!" again (laugh).

Honestly, it's impossible to remake that TV series' massive 26-episode story exactly as-is in a slightly over 2-hour movie. Live-action adaptation is, I think, an act of extracting essence, cutting away various things, and "generalizing." In that regard, I honestly thought they worked quite hard. The bold setting changes, the "repositioning" of Kodai Susumu and Mori Yuki's characters including their personalities - that was skillful. Other characters too, especially Sanada-san and Saito, were magnificent.

However, what I regret is that I wanted to see more of Yamato itself - more footage of Yamato as a space battleship. Not just Yamato's gallant heroic figure, but I wanted to see much more footage of Yamato getting damaged yet still trying to advance forward while enduring attacks. Since I'm on the periphery of commercial video production, I can imagine various production circumstances, but we old fans already love the ship called Yamato itself, so that treatment was disappointing.

Well, it's a work where old fans like me who watched religiously from the first episode's original broadcast in October 1974 are everywhere, so it must be difficult in many ways (laugh). And we, for better or worse, watch while supplementing various omitted details, so how did it look to young people experiencing "Yamato" for the first time with this movie? I think about such things. And I want those young people to definitely watch the original

Space Battleship Yamato

TV series - all 26 episodes!

Anyway.

The end of "Dragon Ball's" serialization in Weekly Shonen Jump was finally decided. Somehow, the feeling of "ah, finally..." was big within me too. Toriyama Akira-san's manga - "Dr. Slump" and then "Dragon Ball" - had always been there for over ten years. And they became anime including TV, and I'll never forget - the first professional cel I ever painted as a part-timer was

Dr. Slump

TV, and while

Dragon Ball

had little TV involvement, regarding theatrical versions, especially after becoming Z

, I'd been working with considerable attachment up to this point.

A bit of a digression, but TV series

Dragon Ball Z

inevitably caught up with Jump's serialization, so waiting for magazine release before starting scenario composition was too late. But future stories existed only in Toriyama-san's head. So manuscript pages with name (panel layouts and dialogue in rough form) were sent from the editorial department to Toei Animation as they were completed. We could secretly read ahead. Well, there were no pictures, so just story development.

"Since the original serialization is ending, TV and theatrical versions will end before long too" - such feelings were there in an unexpectedly large way. And the theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

we were making now would probably be the last theatrical version.

Now, that theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Dragon Fist Explosion!! If Goku Won't Do It, Who Will?

- as usual, we started by confirming roughly where in the original this episode was supposed to occur. This determines "who's currently dead, who hasn't appeared yet" or "who's revived and what techniques they can use" - we have to balance with the original and TV series progress. As always, we're careful not to do anything strange.

Particularly around this time, the fusion technique "Fusion" that appeared in the previous work was popular, and Goten and Trunks desperately wanted to fuse (bitter laugh). "Don't tell me new fusion techniques will appear this time too? (sweat)" I thought, but that didn't happen. Ah, good (laugh). Actually, I hate that "Fusion." They don't need to combine - if each could individually increase their power, that would be fine! ...Or rather, wasn't that competition the original form of

Dragon Ball

? I'd been thinking that all along.

This time's point was that it was all night scenes. Actually, by setting, the Hirudegarn sealed within hero Tapion would break the seal and appear when Tapion fell asleep. So battle scenes were almost all "night" backgrounds. Throughout the entire film, night scenes were abnormally long.

And it was endless urban warfare. Actually, theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

had tried to avoid urban warfare until then. Because fighting in the city means destroying various buildings, and rubble from collapsing buildings and people in the city make animation extremely difficult. And no matter how difficult, that difficulty doesn't really relate to the story's core. Until then, they'd say "if we fight here, everyone will be in danger!" and move to fight in places far from human habitation, but this time they fought right in the city.

Why the scenario became like that is unclear. Was it trying to change the story by making such developments? Certainly the visuals looked different from previous theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

, but hmm, how was it? For me, I had the feeling "I don't like making realistic rubble and collapse footage" from the previous theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta

, so... even if not that realistic, I was resistant to waging battles explosively in the city. So honestly, I wasn't in a very good mood.

And that subtly reflected in the colors too (bitter laugh). Smoke colors in urban warfare became the most subtle colors in my history, competing for 1st or 2nd place. Honestly, they weren't beautiful. Certainly there were many night battle scenes, naturally with night city backgrounds. I was specifying colors balancing with background art, but used only gradually darker & lower saturation colors. Even though it was dark, couldn't I have used colors that looked more beautiful?

Actually, I was full of regret watching the screen afterward. With today's digital coloring, you can quickly convert finished paintings to different colors, but back then, fixing finished work meant repainting from scratch. Moreover, massive color-matching cuts were specified all at once and came back painted all at once - no time leeway. Needless to say, I approached completion inspection and rushes check with truly dark feelings.

And the climax was the yellow dragon's descent! Hmm, truly, story material was exhausted - I keenly felt that. The TV and theatrical series that had continued endlessly - their former charm had become quite questionable.

And in such circumstances, that day finally came. The end of

Dragon Ball's

serialization in Weekly Shonen Jump magazine was decided.

To be continued in Episode 149

(10.12.14)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 149: Long Ago... 88 1995 Part 8 Birth of First TV "Color Design" at Toei in April

Breaking news! There are only 10 days left this year! (big sweat)

Several happy things in such a busy December.

First. In this year's Agency for Cultural Affairs Media Arts Festival Animation Division,

The Tatami Galaxy

, which I participated in, amazingly won the Grand Prize! Grand Prize! I hear it's the first time a TV series work has won the Grand Prize. Director Yuasa's second win since winning the Grand Prize for

Mind Game

. Amazing!

Second.

Strong World One Piece Film

was selected for the 34th Japan Academy Prize Excellence in Animation Award. The recent terrestrial TV premiere also recorded high ratings, so we're aiming for "Best Picture Award" next February!

It makes me genuinely happy when work we've all worked hard on gets recognized like this!

Anyway.

The last

Dragon Ball Z

, theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Dragon Fist Explosion!! If Goku Won't Do It, Who Will?

In parallel with that production, another job was actually moving. Time returns to April. Around the time of "Golden Week next week!" That day I was called to the meeting room next to the planning and sales department room on the 3rd floor of Oizumi Studio.

"We're doing a series called

Neighborhood Story

for one year as the program following

Marmalade Boy

, which is currently airing Sunday mornings. So, we'd like to ask Tsujita-kun to handle the 'color' part!" With a voice that carries well like a voice actor's - Producer Seki Hiromi.

A TV series offer! In front of me were Producer Seki Hiromi-san, Series Director Umezawa Atsutoshi-san, and Production Manager Kazama Atsunori-san. On the table were the

Neighborhood Story

manga main story - pages torn from comic magazines and bound together - and the TV animation

Neighborhood Story

proposal.

Following Seki-san's words, Series Director Umezawa Atsutoshi-san continued. "This work has fashion occupying a very important position. We want to show the protagonists changing clothes every single episode. So instead of leaving it to color direction staff like previous TV shows, we want you to properly consider the entire program and coordinate the 'color.'"

Previous Toei TV series each had different approaches for each series. For example, in

Goldfish Warning!

that I previously participated in, after I compiled all main character colors during program startup, guest character colors appearing in each episode were decided and used by that episode's director and assigned color direction (■■■■) staff. Actually, that tends to make "color" directions somewhat scattered. That episode might be OK, but when this character appears in other episodes, it sometimes lacks balance.

What I was offered this time was essentially not just main character colors, but comprehensive color design for everything - all main character costume changes and guest characters and items appearing in each episode, and all comprehensive color design for parts relating to the main story content - unified and compiled by me. And that was exactly the job called "color design" (■■■■■).

"Yes! Please let me do it!" I said.

However, there was also a big problem. Ideally, doing color direction for all episodes throughout the series would be least problematic, but actually, as a

company, I was somewhat "theatrical work personnel," and several theatrical works were already scheduled through the next year.

"So, since Tsujita-kun has to handle other theatrical works, we'll have someone else handle color direction, and create a job type? or position for handling color settings - 'color design' - so please handle it in that capacity."

What!? I never imagined what I was thinking would come from Seki-san's mouth! Umezawa-san and Kazama-san seemed to have the same thinking. The discussion was already properly established.

At this moment, the first "color design" in Toei Animation's long TV series history was born.

For a long time, I'd been particular about credits representing our job content and somehow got "color direction" created in the work's ending credits. That was finally taking hold, and the next stage I'd been aiming for was naturally "color design." And above all, this new "color" position - the way "color design" should be - would become an indicator for "color" work in future Toei works.

Even so, ah, a TV series! I like working on theatrical works projected on big screens, but still, TV series! And getting such a chance! My feelings, my heart, inevitably raced.

"So... Eh?"

Neighborhood Story

... you said?"

Of course I'd never read it. "What kind of work is it..." I was wondering when Seki-san said:

"So, this weekend we're going to Shueisha to meet the original creator Yazawa-sensei, so keep your schedule open!"

Neighborhood Story

had already started moving considerably toward September broadcast.

To be continued in Episode 150

(10.12.21)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 14: GW Memorial... Japanese Anime Protagonists Speaking Foreign Languages

Golden Week (GW) - how did everyone spend it?

In the end, I spent half my GW working.

Well, this is fine too (bitter laugh). The only place I went out was the National Art Center in Nogizaka. I went to see the "Monet Exhibition," but faced with the massive crowds and long lines at the ticket booth, I gave up on the "Monet Exhibition" 6 seconds after arrival. I just got swept along by the human wave and drifted through the equally crowded Tokyo Midtown.

Maybe because of that fatigue (← wrong), I completely mixed up the day of the week and totally missed yesterday's update deadline! (cries)

So sorry (sweat).

Well then.

I think many people spent GW overseas, but did any of you watch anime during your travels?

Japanese-made anime, specifically.

I once watched extensively from early morning in Rome, Italy.

That day happened to be Saturday, and early morning seemed to be that kind of time slot. The works shown that day were

Future Boy Conan

,

Haikara-san ga T^{ru} (■■■■■■■■■■)

,

Lupin III

, and

Maison Ikkoku

. There were also 2-3 other older Japanese robot shows and classics on different channels, but I've forgotten the titles.

Japanese anime characters speaking Italian from a cheap Rome hotel TV!

Somehow strange (laughs). Still, with

Lupin

and

Conan

, there was no sense of incongruity. Especially

Lupin

almost seemed to fit.

Conan

was around Episode 3, I think? By this point, I had most of the dialogue memorized, so it was probably being converted in my brain naturally.

But *Haikara-san ga T■ru* and *Maison Ikkoku*...

Content-wise, they're universal topics in a sense, so if Italians watched properly they'd naturally empathize, but the

Maison Ikkoku

episode that day had the Tohoku (?) Shinkansen stopped due to an accident or something, and the Ikkoku-kan residents started having a drinking party on the station platform... something like that (probably).

Ichinose-san with a sake bottle arguing with station staff in Italian

... hmm, surreal (laughs).

Though Italy is also a major railway country, and above all a cheerful country, so maybe such situations really exist there (bitter laugh).

Not anime, but I also watched old Japanese movies on TV.

None other than "

Matango

." In Florence on Sunday at 10 AM! (laughs) I was just stunned. They were speaking proper Italian. Why "Matango" at such a time on Sunday? Too mysterious - my head was spinning (bitter laugh).

Not just Italy - in Switzerland, Germany, Greece, and Southeast Asian countries, I've repeatedly encountered Japanese anime being broadcast during travels.

Japanese anime protagonists speaking each country's language. Unfortunately, I never got to watch works I was involved in, but it's purely happy that anime from our country, anime we know well, is being watched by so many people and children in various countries.

Oh yes, about 10 years ago now, when I first went to New York.

I spent all night in the hotel watching cable TV anime channels. Japanese-made anime there were just scattered here and there. Most were American-made anime. However, one show surprised and made me very happy.

That work was *Muppet Babies*.

One of the "collaborative works" once produced at Toei Doga. And amazingly, the episode airing on TV was one I had done color direction for! Man, I was moved! I never expected to reunite here! I was so happy I watched intently (laughs).

Something I was somewhat involved in remains like this, properly broadcasts somewhere in the world, and various people watch it.

It's really happy. That's why I can't quit this job (laughs).

##

■Continues to Episode 15

(07.05.09)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 150: Long Ago... 89 1995 Part 9 Meeting the Original Creator in April

Everyone, Happy New Year!

I missed the deadline for last year's final manuscript (ah~uh~) and had to make a slide appearance over the New Year!

Ah, and it was the commemorative 150th episode too...

Such as I am, please treat me favorably this year too.

Like the manuscript, New Year's cards also went over the New Year. These past few years, year-end has been extremely busy, so ultimately writing and sending them on January 2nd or 3rd after the new year begins, like "after-the-fact rock-paper-scissors," has become routine. Ah, I'm sorry. I'm sorry (sweat).

Even so, New Year's cards. The number sent and received decreases yearly. Somehow, cases of greeting by email or sending New Year's card images as email attachments are increasing. And what was quite common this time was not knowing the recipient's address even if I wanted to send one!

Many people know cell phone numbers and email addresses but don't know postal addresses. Certainly nowadays, cell phones and email addresses handle most communication needs. Well, that's our modern lifestyle.

Despite finding New Year's card preparation and sending troublesome, I feel somewhat lonely about New Year's card culture gradually retreating.

Anyway.

April 27th, several days after talking with Seki-san and Umezawa-san, we were in a relatively large meeting room at Shueisha. A very large meeting room divided in half by ceiling-high movable partitions. Truly befitting a major publisher! We were shown to such a meeting room, quietly took our seats, and waited for the teacher's arrival. The so-called "face-to-face meeting" with original creator Yazawa Ai-sensei.

Production staff from Toei Animation included Producer Seki, Series Director Umezawa-san, Series Composition/Script writer Matsui Aya-san, Character Designer Umakoshi Yoshihiko-san, Costume Designer Kawamura Toshie-san, Art Director Yuki Yukie-san, Gyoshin Mitsu-san, Production Manager Kazama-san, and myself. From the TV station, Producer Kotake-san from Osaka Asahi Broadcasting. From main sponsor Bandai Corporation, people from the department making tie-in toys. A representative from advertising agency Asatsu. And the original creator Yazawa Ai-sensei with a representative from "Ribon"

editorial department. Such members all gathering face-to-face for a meeting.

Production staff members also properly greeted each other again at this meeting. I often saw Art Directors Yuki-san and Gyo-san at the studio, but this was probably the first opportunity to actually work together. With Character Designer Umakoshi-san, I think this was probably our first meeting. I'd vaguely heard rumors of "a very skilled animator," and maybe we'd passed each other many times before, but this was the first proper introduction. And at this time, we had no idea we'd become a team continuing this Sunday morning broadcast slot for years to come.

And meeting Yazawa Ai-sensei for the first time. I naturally knew she was female, but I thought she'd be older and more veteran-like! But the actual Yazawa-san was a bit younger than us, bright, and in a strange way to put it, seemed like a normal person - that was my first impression. "Ah, this person draws these" - there was fresh emotion!

Oh! Come to think of it, actually meeting a manga artist in person was almost my first time! I'd participated in anime adaptations of manga-based works many times, but with original manga artists, I'd only glimpsed them at wrap parties and such. Even when creating colors, I'd just work referencing passed-along original color materials. Meeting and having discussions before a program starts like this had never happened before.

Everything made me nervous. My throat kept getting dry and I was drinking tons of the provided tea.

Now, the meeting. First, business card exchanges(!) and self-introductions all around. The meeting began with Producer Seki's facilitation.

Seki-san and Kotake-san first explained the program overview. About the broadcast slot, roughly the target age demographic and program points for appealing to that demographic - explanations following the proposal format. Then Bandai explained how some items appearing in the show would be commercialized as toys for program tie-ins. Materials listing several specific commercialization candidates were distributed.

This was my first experience with such meetings. The very scene of "this is how animation programs are made!" The realization that "making programs is definitely business!" "We create animation footage within such large frameworks." When absorbed in actual work, there's often a self that enjoys it like a hobby despite it being work, but "this is work, part of business." Though I naturally understood this mentally, being in such meetings, such settings, made me feel it keenly for the first time.

Now, Yazawa-sensei's talk. The teacher discussed points she pays attention to when drawing

Neighborhood Story

, including fashion and animation technique topics. Regarding fashion, we production staff also asked the teacher questions. What should we reference for clothes worn by each character? This was quite an important theme for us. Another concern was digital-ish animation processing. Actually, in

Neighborhood Story

and previously drawn

Tenshi Nanka ja Nai

, there are pages throughout where images were processed using computers - Macintosh. We asked various questions about that too.

Regarding fashion, Yazawa-sensei would create fashion reference materials by character for us. She'd send them later. About Macintosh: "Ah, I don't really understand that very well (laugh)." Apparently she worked with someone else who handled that part. Then Art Director Yuki-san asked, "Um, there are depictions of manga artists' workplaces..." What kind of atmosphere are manga artists' workplaces? What art supplies are used or placed around? How do they actually draw? These were quite hard to imagine.

"Would you like to come see once?" said Yazawa-sensei. "It would be better for you to actually come see, right?"

That's right. Amazingly, visiting Yazawa-sensei's home for research was suddenly decided!

To be continued in Episode 151

(11.01.07)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 151: Long Ago... 90 1995 Part 10 Visiting the Original Creator's Workplace in May

Yesterday, January 10th, was "Coming of Age Day." Due to the legal revision called "Happy Monday" in 1999, Coming of Age Day, which had been January 15th every year, became the second Monday of January - it's been quite a while now. Originally, why was January 15th Coming of Age Day? Because traditionally this January 15th was called "Koshogatsu" (Little New Year), and it was customary to perform coming-of-age ceremonies on this day - rituals where society recognizes boys as adults. Why do they carelessly change holidays with such origins? Here's a middle-aged man who feels great resentment toward holiday laws and legal systems that disregard such ancient cultural customs.

Well, anyway, Coming of Age Day. In Tokyo's Nakano Ward where I live, and many municipalities nationwide, ceremonies and events called coming-of-age ceremonies are held on this Coming of Age Day. Recently, there are many idiots who cause trouble during these ceremonies. How long are you going to remain children! this old man wants to say. I think all such people should be arrested!

And some municipalities hold such coming-of-age ceremonies at places like "Toshimaen" or "Disneyland." This is completely incomprehensible to me. Because isn't a coming-of-age ceremony supposed to be "from today you join the ranks of adults"? So why "return to being children and enjoy the day"? Just because such places happen to exist locally? That's thoughtless. They're not thinking about anything at all.

So every year when this "Coming of Age Day" comes around, I get inexplicably irritated.

Anyway.

One Sunday afternoon in May after Golden Week ended, we gathered in front of a certain station a bit past where the Odakyu Line crosses the Tamagawa River. "We" being Series Director Umezawa-san, Art Directors Yuki Yukie-san and Gyoshin Mitsu-san, and myself. Hmm? Oh, Producer Seki-san arrived quite late to the meeting time (laugh). And our destination was the workplace/home of

Neighborhood Story

original creator Yazawa Ai-sensei. Under calm, beautiful weather, about a 10-minute walk from the station? An emotional manga artist workplace visit.

The purpose of this workplace visit was "what are manga artists' workplaces like?" The protagonist Mikako's mother in

Neighborhood Story

is a successful manga artist with a workplace at home where she's always chased by deadlines. Naturally, this visual is drawn in the original manga, but to make it into animation, we need to grasp the overall picture and turn it into settings. What kind of atmosphere is it? What art supplies and pens are placed how? How do they actually draw? So if we could see the real thing, nothing could be better.

And the reason I joined along with the art staff was that since I was entrusted with the overall work colors, "let's see anything that might be relevant." Anyway, I probably didn't understand

Neighborhood Story's

world very well myself - where exactly does that taste lurk? Maybe that taste exists in original creator Yazawa-sensei's workplace too. That's what I was thinking.

First, tea in the reception room? and some chat. Then "shall we look? (laugh)" and to the next room. A work room tour.

"Ooh! This is where she draws!" That was my biggest impression above all (laugh). Really, my first manga artist's work room ever. Not just manga artists - seeing the desks and desk areas of working people is enjoyable, right? Yazawa-sensei's desk area also had various art supplies and materials scattered about, but somehow had a "production site aura" that was sparkingly beautiful. And "ah, it's just like in the manga (laugh)."

Nowadays we probably would have taken digital camera photos, but that was still the film camera era. And there was definitely an atmosphere of "you shouldn't ask to photograph a manga teacher's work room" (laugh). Well, maybe Gyo-san and others took photos? Anyway, we thoroughly observed the room and asked questions about various things that caught our attention.

And we were also shown another room of interest next door. That's right, the digital room. Here too, Macintosh computers shone brilliantly. I think there were about two. The soft white cases unique to Macintosh computers of that era, and matching white-cased monitors, scanners, printers, etc. The transparent digital image processing used in Yazawa-sensei's work title pages and decisive pages and panels - it was born in this room. I was moved by the teacher's hand-drawn (analog) workplace, but personally, this side gave me more of a "I've been had!" feeling.

Now my home work room has become like a digital fortress secret base with computers and multiple monitors, but back then, I'd never seen a scene with so many computers and peripheral devices lined up throughout an ordinary house room. This was quite a culture shock - ah, from now on, such digital environments will increasingly enter the worlds of manga and our anime, I felt strongly.

And through promotional still work for
Neighborhood Story
, I would start using computers extensively.
To be continued in Episode 152
(11.01.11)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 152: Long Ago... 91 1995 Part 11 The Original Creator's "Rules" in June

My work room at home has become quite an electronic digital room with several computers and peripherals, broadband internet, home server, etc., but that server suddenly died. Rest in peace.

This server machine was actually a 1TB server machine bought during

Casshern Sins

production for handling settings exchanges and image data management within the staff room, separate from the main production server. After production ended, I, who had paid for it, took it home for use.

And it died without any warning. Apparently one of the four built-in HDDs broke. Fortunately, since I was in the middle of organizing and migrating data, not much data remained, and most had copies on CD/DVD discs or separate hard drives, so no major problems. Phew.

Unlike the old "paper" era, digital is scary. Being digital data enables coordination with various things and unlimited possibilities, but conversely, you can lose the data itself over small things. So really, backup is essential.

Well, people often say "I have backup on hard drive," but hard drives aren't reliable! Dynamic disks can break anytime. Data should definitely be backed up on static discs like DVDs and CDs!

Anyway.

Having also visited Yazawa-sensei's workplace,

Neighborhood Story

was gradually gaining momentum, but time passed in a flash. Broadcast start was early September - only about three and a half months left. There wasn't as much leeway as expected.

I was in the middle of producing theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Dragon Fist Explosion!! If Goku Won't Do It, Who Will?

in parallel at this time - I had to pin down this theatrical work first. But I couldn't stop

Neighborhood Story

preparations either. Promotional images and footage had to be created and delivered to magazines and TV stations well before the September broadcast main story. First, promotional stills and poster creation. No, before that, basic character color work for the main story had to be done.

Work to decide basic character colors - skin, hair, eyes - was determined using both color samples made from main story character settings and artwork for stills that had to be released first. Fortunately, since this work had manga source material, we could reference original color pages for rough bases. But there were various problems. Yes, character clothing colors.

For stills, we could reference original title pages and such to some extent, so depending on art style and clothing, we could directly reference colored originals, but the problem was anime version original layout stills. Naturally these didn't exist in the original, and when clothing without color reference appeared, I'd squeeze my limited knowledge and think it through, but was this really okay?

In the midst of this, the promised item arrived from Yazawa-sensei. What she sent was color materials compiled in an A4 clear file. "

Neighborhood

Fashion Catalog" - yes, commonly called "The Book of Rules."

This was what Yazawa-sensei had promised during our first face-to-face meeting - she'd send compiled materials about fashion directions for each character.

Neighborhood Story

features seven people: protagonist Mikako and her friends attending the same design school - Tsutomu, Risa, P-chan, Yusuke, Jiro, and Mariko. Being fashion design school students, everyone has different fashion tendencies. Honestly, this was beyond our expertise. Still, to make it into a program, we had to study hard and gain sufficient understanding, but our efforts alone couldn't catch up. Hence this "Book of Rules."

For example, Mikako uses vivid candy colors as base, coordinating with Mikako's favorite color "yellow," wearing body-hugging clothes like mini T-shirts and mini skirts. Tsutomu uses subdued colors - brown, gray, black as base with flashy accent colors like red or yellow-green, wearing fitted rather than baggy clothes. Mariko basically uses flashy colors tied together with black, gold accessories, and high-end brand suit feelings, etc.

Like this, she had carefully compiled character "rules" combining teacher's handwritten notes with fashion magazine clippings. This was immediately clear! Truly a "divine" volume!

And upon deciphering this "Book of Rules," the colors I'd conceived apparently didn't deviate from these "rules." Ah, thank goodness! Following these "rules" and then studying trends myself, I should be able to manage somehow. I was confident of that.

To be continued in Episode 153

(11.01.18)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 153: Side Story: A Cold Sufferer's Delusions

Today is Monday, January 24, 2011. I finally caught my first cold of this winter (cry).

I've lived as regularly as possible and diligently practiced hand-washing without fail, but hmm, I've fallen. Currently: headache, fever, sore throat. And I can't speak (cry). Until just now I was taking medicine properly and lying in bed in a bedroom that felt misty despite two humidifiers running, but I sluggishly got up and am now facing the computer.

Was I tired from traveling overnight for a relative's funeral last week? No, it was probably because I had wine surrounded by young beautiful women over the weekend.

Good grief.

Anyway.

This morning, lying in bed and suffering from cold symptoms while discussing on Twitter: "Wait, how old is Nobita's mom exactly?" Furthermore: "How old is Bakabon's mom exactly?"

Both have elementary school children, so they'd be in their 30s. I think Nobita-kun was in 4th grade, so 10 years old. Thinking normally, Nobita-kun's mom would be about 35 or 36? Meanwhile, Bakabon's mom is a mother of two. I don't know what grade (age) Bakabon is, but probably around the same age too.

Thinking about this, there apparently were proper settings as expected. Nobita-kun's mom is 36, Bakabon's mom is 32. Ah, Bakabon's mom is indeed a bit younger.

Getting carried away, I investigated various mother characters' ages.

First, Doremi-chan's mom from

Ojamajo Doremi

. When the series started, Doremi-chan was in 3rd grade, so 9 years old. So about the same age as Nobita-kun's mom, around 35-36?

Mizuki-san, Hanasaki Tsubomi-chan's mother from

Heartcatch PreCure!

, is also 36. Kurumi Erika-chan's mother Sakura-san is officially unknown, but since Erika-chan has an older sister Momoka-san who's a high school sophomore,

maybe a bit older, around early 40s?

Nadja's mother Colette from

Tomorrow's Nadja

- considering the era, probably around 36 too? Maybe a bit younger. Hiroshi's mother from

Gutsy Frog

is 34. That's young! Kamaria-san, Amuro's mother from

Mobile Suit Gundam

- since Amuro is 15, roughly estimating maybe around 40?

Kitakami Mikai-chan's mother from

■■■! Mecha Mote Committee Chairman

- Mikai-chan is a high school sophomore but has twin brothers above her (I'd forgotten such a setting until now (laugh)), so probably early to mid-40s?

Magical Angel Creamy Mami's

Morisawa Yu-chan is 10, but her mom is amazingly 28. She was a young mom!

From here, not mothers but

Lupin III's

Mine Fujiko. Officially age unknown, but somehow feels around 30? (←this is preference) Nearby(?),

Evangelion's

Misato-san is 29 and Akagi Ritsuko-san is 30 according to official settings. Well, this range is reasonable.

Sazae-san's

Sazae-san. She's surprisingly young at 24. I somehow thought she looked around 30 including appearance, but surprise. Incidentally, her mother Fune-san is 52. Ooh! This is also unexpected.

Somehow, 30s moms are strongest? (Why? (laugh))

Incidentally, if I were to receive nursing care for a cold, would it be Bakabon's mom or Doremi-chan's mom?

Such were my cold-induced delusions.

To be continued in Episode 154

(11.01.25)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 154: Long Ago... 92 1995 Part 12 My First Mac Experience in July

Last week I magnificently caught a cold, and the morning after writing my manuscript, my wife and I went to the neighborhood doctor. Eh? Together? That's right! Actually, my wife suddenly developed a fever at night too, so we ended up going together as a couple.

Result: My wife magnificently hit influenza! I unfortunately (←eh?) missed. So well, we both ended up convalescing at home for about two days.

It's somehow subtle (laugh). A couple both resting with colds simultaneously (laugh). Quite restless feeling (laugh). First experience in 10 years of marriage. Thanks to that, we both recovered magnificently before the weekend.

...But wait? I've had a fever and cold symptoms again since yesterday. Huh? Hmm...

Anyway.

The September TV series

Neighborhood Story

, which progressed parallel to theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Dragon Fist Explosion!! If Goku Won't Do It, Who Will?

production - after visiting original creator Yazawa Ai-sensei's workplace in May, we continued meetings with the teacher about twice weekly at Shueisha.

"Do you really meet with the original creator this much?" I was honestly surprised this time. Because in "manga-based" works I'd been involved with before, I'd never met with teachers this many times. Usually, original color references were passed along with "use this as reference."

Maybe I just wasn't allowed to attend such meetings, and other works also had meetings with original creators at this frequency. But this time, both Seki-san and Umezawa-san made me keenly feel they valued my "color design" (■■■■) position. And I thought Yazawa-sensei had that much expectation for the animation adaptation. Couldn't help feeling good pressure.

Regarding character colors, there were teacher's "rules" as I introduced last time (Episode 152), but we also received quite detailed, careful notes from Yazawa-sensei about other aspects. These were answers to questions from us animation production staff - points to note when drawing each character (like line uniformity and each character's proportional balance, clothing precautions, etc.),

distance feelings in character relationships, motifs of the town serving as setting, floor plans of Mikako's apartment and layout diagrams of Yazagaku (Yazawa Arts Academy) where Mikako and others attend, plus sketches of important people scheduled to appear in future serialization, and even overall story concepts about how she wanted to end the serialization. Well, serialization matters were naturally secret from outside.

After somehow finishing theatrical

Dragon Ball Z~

by the end of June, I had no time to relax even for a moment and plunged into

Neighborhood Story

work like a raging torrent. While working on slightly delayed character color sample creation and coloring setting (■■■■■) production, preparing color direction (■■■■) for each episode. And some kind of meeting almost daily. By July 10th, we'd finished art meetings for Episodes 1 and 2.

Why it had become so hectic was because from July 12th, another week-long business trip to EEI-TOEI studio in Manila, Philippines was waiting. However, this trip was for

Neighborhood Story

. Most in-betweening and finishing (■■■■) and some backgrounds, plus some photography for

Neighborhood Story

were decided to be handled at this Manila studio. If it were just normal in-betweening and finishing, probably no special meetings would be needed, but this time art and even photography work would be done at the Manila studio, so we should definitely have various discussions with local staff.

So this Manila trip was a large group. Series Director Umezawa-san, Art Directors Yuki-san and Gyo-san, and myself - the

Neighborhood~

crew. "If this plane crashes,

Neighborhood Story

crashes too," was among the jokes (laugh).

The week-long business trip passed in a flash, and waiting for me upon return was poster work along with promotional stills. For posters, I'd finished color direction (■■■■) before the Manila trip, and I checked completed coloring the day after

returning and delivered it. The problem was promotional stills - 2-3 points were finished in June, but the latter half additions were just starting meetings now. And among these was an order from the producer to "mix in things with computer image processing added."

"Hmm? Computer image processing? What should I do?" As mentioned earlier, one characteristic of Yazawa-sensei's works is slightly digital cuts and panels processed with computers, and the scheme was to show this a bit in

Neighborhood Story

animation too.

Now, finally computers. Macintosh.

By this time, several sets of Apple Computer's PowerMacintosh 8100AV computers were already installed in Toei Animation's Oizumi Studio production department, arranged so anyone could basically use them. I've forgotten the detailed specs, but hard disk drives were still around 800MB, memory was maybe 32MB or 64MB? Compared to today's latest machines, they couldn't even enter the same arena, but they were still among the latest models then. At the end of May or beginning of June, something slightly beyond a "this is how you use it" workshop was held, and I'd been taught roughly the "basics" of usage, but actually was still far from ready. Even so, they definitely conveyed the atmosphere that "eventually everyone will become computerized."

The era was definitely heading digital, and actually, even home game consoles are digital computers, so work like painting cels with paint - while it wouldn't be just pushing buttons - would undoubtedly become computer work before long. So I needed to always prepare not to be left behind by such technology. This would definitely be a major turning point. Above all, since I'd been completely influenced by Director Yamauchi's Mac enthusiasm, "I really need to have my own Mac" was a natural progression. I thought I needed my own equipment to use freely. And I had a premonition I'd probably love computers.

And just before departing for Manila business trip, I made a big decision. Actually around this time, I left my parents' home, rented an apartment room calling it my "work room," and amazingly bought this PowerMacintosh 8100AV for that room.

To be continued in Episode 155

(11.02.01)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 155: Long Ago... 93 1995 Part 13 Learning Macintosh Through Part-Time Work July-August

Setsubun, then Risshun - spring has arrived on the calendar. These past few days in Tokyo, the air feels somewhat spring-like, and the cold has lost its temporary severity. The plum blossoms bloomed too. Ah, winter is ending.

Somehow, I feel lonely about seasons changing. Summer has summer's enjoyments, winter has winter's flavors. Did I properly enjoy winter this winter? I think such things. Every season, nearing its end, I always ask myself this.

I didn't think like this when young, but now that the big 50 is coming into view, I'm gradually becoming concerned about remaining time. Too early? No no, really, how many more years can my body stay healthy and push itself? I think seriously about this. And how many more times can I welcome and enjoy winter? Life is short when you notice.

Our memories are built on the changing seasons that repeat yearly. Did I make good memories this winter? Am I leaving proper work behind? And when spring comes, I'll probably ponder the same way when it ends.

Anyway, spring is really coming soon. Ah, but before that, couldn't it snow and accumulate properly just once? thinks this Tokyo person (laugh).

Anyway.

The PowerMacintosh 8100AV I'd bought anyway. I had to fiddle with it thoroughly to somehow learn to use it. Despite having almost no knowledge about digital or computers, I'd bought it. So I had equipment but only partially knew how to use it.

For example, suppose I scan line art and try to color it. Scan the image with a scanner, binarize it, then connect broken lines in Photoshop while carefully painting... I vaguely understood the procedure because Toei Animation had workshop-like things for such areas, so I could somehow understand by watching and learning, but I didn't know guidelines for basic image resolution and size for working with imported images. Naturally, required size changes depending on image purpose - what resolution should I work at? I didn't understand even that. Furthermore, what type of image should it be? .pct, .tga, .psd, .jpg... How exactly do these differ? Particularly .pct and .tga look the same, don't they?

I had to start by understanding such basic knowledge experientially or by researching in books. Fortunately, I had very basic video signal and imaging knowledge studied briefly in college, which helped somewhat, but almost everything was new.

Just then, I received a phone call.

"Hey hey Tsujita-kun, you bought a Mac? Immediately, want to do part-time work? (laugh)"

It was a call from Okubo-san, who had been helping me in various ways. He was a senior who had been a producer at Toei Animation, became independent and ran a small production company, and I'd been doing part-time work for him here and there. What kind of part-time work had I done? Still image work like color direction (■■■■) and coloring for game guidebook and magazine cover illustration cel paintings, to animation footage work for TV commercials. I also participated in several NHK

Minna no Uta

videos. All were cel animation.

Incidentally, among

Minna no Uta

pieces I participated in was a masterpiece (←I think (laugh)) called "Jagaimo Jagar," where I handled both cel work colors and art. Direction and animation were also handled by acquaintances who were at Toei Animation then. Like that, daily life was extremely busy, but since it offered different experiences from working at Toei, I did part-time work here and there.

Now, this Okubo-san had already equipped his company with several Macs by then and was increasingly entering digital video work like game software opening footage. Since individuals buying Macs for work were still rare, Okubo-san wouldn't miss such opportunities (laugh).

"First, I'd like to ask you to do the painting for this," he said, offering what I believe was still image material for PlayStation game "Tokyo Dungeon" opening. Immediate meetings with Okubo-san and animator Umetsu Yasuomi-san. And soon afterward, actual work began.

"But you know, Okubo-san, I still don't understand Mac at all."

"Yeah. I'll teach you, so it's fine! (laugh)"

Thus began part-time work with Okubo-san's "Mac Course" included. About twice weekly, Okubo-san would come to my room for exchanges that I found endlessly enjoyable. This was truly grateful. He taught me from the very basics and answered my ridiculous questions carefully. Resolution problems I mentioned earlier, video material points and resolution guidelines for print materials, Photoshop tips, clever scanner usage, etc. Furthermore, everything from ISDN line details to video editing software like Director and Premiere, usage of Mac basic

software like Quicktime and Hypercard. Without this part-time work offer, without Okubo-san, would I have come to love computer work and Mac this much? I'm truly grateful to Okubo-san.

So my first digital work was actually this part-time "Tokyo Dungeon" before

Neighborhood Story

work. And I continued doing part-time work many times afterward. In the later flow of TV animation shifting to digital, I was taught various things at key points through part-time work, staying somewhat ahead of the curve.

Now, finally

Neighborhood Story

work proper. This would become unexpectedly quite difficult.

To be continued in Episode 156

(11.02.08)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 156: Long Ago... 94 1995 Part 14 Persistence by the Color Copier in August

Today as I write this manuscript is February 11th, National Foundation Day, and amazingly, Tokyo is getting heavy snow! Last week I wrote "couldn't it snow and accumulate properly just once?" and amazingly, it's actually snowing! Oh, the weather god must have read my previous writing (laugh).

Though some people may be inconvenienced by the snow, please forgive me everyone. This is Tokyo's first real snow of winter. It's cold but I'm enjoying it.

Anyway.

Days of part-time work and Okubo-san's practical Mac course in the "work room" I made by renting an apartment room in front of Nakano Station proceeded in parallel with

Neighborhood Story

steadily progressing toward September broadcast at Oizumi Studio. Main story work was various, but my current big problem was remaining promotional still work. The "stills with computer image processing added" ordered by Producer Seki.

Setting aside the "computer image processing? What should I do?" problem for a moment, I had to create digital materials for it anyway.

First, scan animation with a scanner. I had to think about resolution. What values should I capture at? Now I could immediately answer "ah, for stills used that way, about 288dpi is fine," but lacking experience, I didn't understand those guidelines well.

"Basically, just use resolution where lines don't look jagged" - well, that's right (bitter laugh). I actually consulted Okubo-sensei(!) about this too. Okubo-san taught me the principles and guidelines. Unless it's vector images, in principle, the higher the resolution, the less jagged lines appear. But if you honestly go too high-resolution and data becomes large, you hit computer processing limits and it stops working, or takes deadly amounts of time. I'd done such experiments myself. So I understood to some degree that working with unreasonably large data was impossible. So I shouldn't make data too large.

Moreover, digital data submission was still nonexistent then, so digital still data had to be printed out once, then amazingly photographed with still cameras like other cel + background stills, and those positives delivered and submitted. So if printed lines didn't look jagged, and print size was roughly the same as cel + background

stills, A4 to at most B4 was OK. So I think the first still was made from roughly A4-size animation master at about 300dpi resolution. But even that size would later plunge us into hellish waiting times...

Now for work. Binarize imported animation line art data. Color the binarized line art data with coloring tools. I used Adobe's Photoshop for both animation import and coloring work. Now, line art import and binarization use Traceman, coloring uses Paintman - digital coloring specialized software has differentiated, but such convenient things didn't exist then. Working bit by bit in Photoshop with a mouse, finished data was temporarily saved on MO discs that could store large capacity. Work up to here was done on a Mac installed in a corner of the finishing color direction room, but work from combining with backgrounds through processing to printing was done on another Mac installed in a corner of the 2nd floor copy room in the same studio. This Mac was connected to a color copier, perfect for checking while printing.

That evening, gathered in front of the copy room Mac were Producer Seki, Umezawa-san, Gyo-san, Yukie-san, Production Manager Kazama-san, and me. Starting work from combining my prepared coloring data with background data Gyo-san had worked on and brought as layers.

"So, what should we do?" I asked.

"First, you know this color illustration processed on Yazawa-sensei's Mac? Can't we do this kind of atmosphere?" said Seki-san.

Ah, I see. That illustration was processed into night-like coloring and finished with an overall rough texture. Naturally, what was done how to create such images was unknown (laugh). Anyway, I started by watching and learning. I thought if I tried and fiddled around, somehow it would work! I began thinking like that. First try adjusting tone from above to create somewhat similar coloring, then to fiddle with image texture, try adding noise, blurring, testing various filters. But this became quite difficult.

This work also involved Photoshop processing, but it took enormous time. Trying one filter effect took several minutes of calculation processing for that single processing. As I wrote before, this PowerMacintosh 8100AV of the time, despite saying "Power~," had specs incomparable to today's machines. Moreover, image weight exceeded expectations. That's right. When background data was added, it became surprisingly large and heavy data, and that weight further hindered calculation processing. Furthermore, Photoshop then had no undo function - if something failed, you had to start over from the beginning. So we saved repeatedly at work stages. Each save, disc writing, also took several minutes...

Work progressed like that, but when we gave tentative OK on monitor and actually printed, it was somehow unsatisfactory. So which parts to reprocess how... back to

data temporarily saved at earlier stages for correction work. Each operation took enormous time again. Print, correct, repeat. Getting tired led to more silly mistakes, retreating to saved points and rebuilding work and waiting.

Everyone waited by that narrow color copier watching the work screen through such repeated work. The clock hands reached midnight. Ultimately, giving OK to two stills took until near dawn.

To be continued in Episode 157

(11.02.15)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 157: Long Ago... 95 1995 Part 15 Production Going Smoothly?
September and October

The TV series

Hakaba Kitaro

Blu-ray Box that I participated in will be released February 23rd. Last winter we created jacket artwork for this Box with Director Chioka's design concept, Animation Director Yamamuro's animation, and my color work, which the jacket designer worked hard to compile. This turned out quite well! Once you get your hands on it, you'll definitely want it! Such a jacket. So everyone, even those who already have the DVD-BOX, please consider it! ...Promotion, promotion (laugh).

During that

Hakaba Kitaro

jacket work, I heard that Blu-ray conversion of old works, especially TV series, is quite difficult. Recent TV works produced with HD standards and Blu-ray release in mind from the start are one thing, but to convert footage produced in old TV standards to Blu-ray requires remastering processing to convert the footage itself to Blu-ray standards - that effort is quite demanding and costs considerably. This becomes a bottleneck preventing old works from becoming Blu-ray. Since costs must be added to the price, sales prices inevitably become somewhat high, and even when made and released that way, they don't sell much - massive losses. So unless you know a work was popular enough to guarantee certain sales numbers, you can't easily release Blu-ray Boxes.

My amateur thinking is, for example, keeping image quality exactly as when released on DVD - then lots would fit on one Blu-ray, so you could put entire series on 2-3 discs! But apparently that's not such a simple matter either (bitter laugh).
Hmm, difficult.

Old works aside, I record quite a bit of recent terrestrial digital TV anime on home Blu-ray, but honestly, once you record and save to Blu-ray yourself, you don't need to buy released commercial Blu-ray Boxes.

Hmm, difficult...

Even so, even so, please purchase

Hakaba Kitaro

Blu-ray Box!

Anyway.

Season progresses from autumn to late autumn.

Neighborhood Story

production proceeded almost smoothly. Around early autumn 1995. Weekly broadcasting means completing one episode weekly - weekly editing and dubbing, and art meetings at roughly the same weekly pace.

When director's storyboard is completed and gets OK from producer and series director, and animation meetings are almost finished, art meetings immediately follow. Art meetings (■■■■) are attended by that episode's director, assistant director, art director, that episode's art staff, color design (me), and color direction staff. Toei's production system has no setting production. Setting-related management and handling is done by assistant directors. Also, I don't know from when, but in Toei Animation's system, production staff (production progress) rarely attend TV series art meetings. I think it's questionable that production doesn't attend, but since assistant directors are present, it's considered acceptable. Quite a system not found at other studios.

So, such art meetings.

Often art meetings are scheduled when a certain number of background layouts are ready, but in

Neighborhood Story

, since art meetings also served as art board meetings, meetings were scheduled at early points. As I wrote before,

Neighborhood Story

has a large production volume done at the Manila, Philippines studio, so early episode startup was required for that reason too. Particularly since photography would also be done at Manila studio, retake response needed proper time allocation, requiring stricter schedule management than other domestic photography series (...but reality was that it didn't go so smoothly (bitter laugh)).

Background work procedure: each episode's art staff first organizes and corrects background layouts from animation according to actual art settings. Background work begins with corrected layouts, most of which were sent to Manila studio for Filipino staff to draw. Depending on content, some scenes and cuts were better handled by designers or domestic staff, so those were domestic work, but almost everything else was Manila work. Actually, since Manila studio also handled photography portions, that was sometimes more convenient.

Meanwhile, us color direction folks. I didn't handle main story color direction work - we asked someone else. Kinugasa-san, a senior company color direction staff member. A division system where I did color design (■■■■■) and Kinugasa-san did color direction (■■■■■). This pattern would continue for all episodes. Color design me would create character colors and get approval, making coloring settings (■■■■■) up to that point. Color direction Kinugasa-san would put color direction into each episode's main story animation based on these materials and art meeting content. For cuts that differed from art meeting content or changed, we'd consult and decide processing and direction each time. This style would continue in this slot for years to come.

Until now, for any work I handled, I'd do color design myself and then do all color direction myself too, but "dividing this work" didn't suit me in various ways. But since this was also a new approach, I thought methods would gradually suit me through working in this system, and even if some things didn't work well, there must be good solutions. That's how I began. Everything is experience.

Neighborhood Story

would go with "no shadows" visually - this was a "rule" from the beginning, but directional points weren't limited to that, and scenes or cuts wanting impression could have shadows added in animation. However, the method was somewhat unusual - shadow parts were created as separate cels painted BL (black) (positive mask), then half-exposure photographed during shooting.

Why use such methods? First, you get more matte feel than shadows normally painted with cel paint. Shadow brightness and saturation balance for skin shadows, paper shadows, clothing shadows becomes uniform. And shadow strength (brightness) can be adjusted and controlled according to scene and cut meaning. For example, if normal double-brush density is 50%, scenes wanting more shocking impression could use 60% or 70% stronger density for darker shadows, expressing that character's mental state and shock feeling.

Also,

Neighborhood Story

didn't set so-called "night color" special coloring tones. This was also processed during photography. Scenes wanting night coloring like outdoor night scenes were shot with blue filters applied to the entire screen.

Night scene backgrounds were drawn with somewhat reduced coloring and brightness, but

Neighborhood Story's

art style was graphical like original visuals - utilizing black-painted parts and firmly drawing outline lines, so light blue filters didn't change background impressions much, rather preserving good moist coloring. And cel paintings finished in overall bright tones with basically no shadows appeared slightly darker with blue tint added, matching night backgrounds at just the right balance. Evening scenes were probably roughly the same.

However, as the series entered the latter half, irregular methods were gradually incorporated responding to story excitement. Sometimes shadows were normally painted with cel paint, or night color and evening tones were set and painted as special coloring. "Rules" existed as "rules," but new attempts and conversely orthodox methods would also be used. Since presentation "rules" had taken hold among viewers in the latter half, various things could be tried as expressive range.

Digital processing-like screen creation using computers was also incorporated into main episodes. But using digital composite processing like the opening in TV series main episodes lacked budget and especially time. Still, for cuts wanting particularly impressive presentation at scene endings and episode endings, we shot using materials processed by computer like "harmony processing." Methods like overlapping computer-processed printouts onto normal cel + background combinations. Incidentally, such processing was usually done by me or art staff Gyo-san, but in the latter half, directors and assistant directors increasingly did such work too.

But these were all still early series stages. Still just starting to run. First was the stage of establishing these "rules."

To be continued in Episode 158

(11.03.01)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 158: Long Ago... 96 1995 Part 16 Weekly Art Meetings! September and October

Everyone! Have you finished your tax returns? This year's tax return deadline is March 14th! Last year I thought "ah, next year I'll ask a tax accountant!" but ultimately this year was also self-calculated & document preparation. "Ah, next year for sure..." Well, but I'll probably do it myself next year too... (distant look).

...Actually, at the time I'm writing this manuscript, I haven't finished this year's tax return yet (explosion). The plan was for it to be properly finished by the time this manuscript appears - should be, should be, should be? (sweat)

Now, will it happen!?

Anyway.

Neighborhood Story

finally began broadcasting. Production proceeded almost smoothly. Art & color direction meetings were set roughly weekly, and character color checking progressed at roughly the same pace.

Character setting work procedure: for main character settings, we'd make costume change bases from basic design character settings drawn by Umakoshi-san, then Costume Designer Kawamura-san would draw costume changes on top of those base settings like "dress-up dolls."

Main appearing characters were seven people: Mikako, Tsutomu, Jiro, Yusuke, Risa, P-chan, and Mariko. Characters would increase further in the latter half, but these costume changes happened every episode. About 7 outfits appeared each episode at one per person. Well, after accumulating episodes, clothing would accumulate and some reuse became possible, but this series also followed seasons somewhat, so summer clothes, winter clothes... Since it was a year-long story, each character had considerable clothing.

For main characters, guest character and prop settings appearing in each episode were principally drawn by each episode's animation director. Combined with earlier main settings, we created quite a number of color settings each episode.

Making color samples from those character settings - all color samples were cel paintings. Cel paint coloring. Even starting to use Mac, we were still far from current digital coloring levels of painting settings on screen and making color samples. Having all those color samples painted with cel paint and finished into cels myself would be quite time-consuming, so we had company finishing staff

paint them. But first, I myself needed proper color images.

In previous works, I'd carefully paint setting copies with multiple colored pencils to create my own images, but that was forced mental conversion. When thinking mentally, quite specific cel paint number color images already exist in my head, but naturally, cel paint and colored pencils are completely different. No matter how much I convinced myself with paint numbers, it only became division instruction samples when making cel color samples. Moreover, that itself took considerable time - couldn't I create images closer to finished painting? That had been a long-standing concern.

Then I noticed certain color marker pens at an art supply store. A series called "Copic." Trying them out (trial coloring), these were very good. Being alcohol markers, they could be painted quickly and uniformly, and above all, had good color development. So I bought almost all available colors at light speed (laugh). Boom! Set them up at both work room and studio. Come to think of it, these Copics were also at Yazawa-sensei's workplace.

Using color copy paper, I'd place coloring conceived mentally onto black and white copied character line art using these Copics. Why use color copy paper? Because color copy paper had much better ink adherence and finished color development than ordinary copy paper. Painting with Copics that developed colors close to cel paint numbers I was thinking of meant finished Copic settings had quite similar atmosphere to cel images. Then I'd specify colors again with paint numbers and have finishing staff paint color sample cels.

Using Copics, I gradually wanted colors "between this color and that color, like paint number ■■" - colors other than manufactured ones. So I'd blend and mix supplementary inks myself, creating and using new original color Copics (laugh). Gradually becoming a maniac (laugh).

That much - this method of thinking character colors using Copics was revolutionary for me. Mac was also new weaponry, but this was immediate combat power! Anyway, since I could reproduce color images conceived with coloring quite close to cel finishing, not just character color samples, but for complex pattern still color direction, I could paint divisions and place colors myself using this, confirming my own images while making finished images and detailed divisions easier to convey when requesting cel trial painting.

While handling

Neighborhood Story

character setting color work daily like this, another work was actually operating in parallel behind the scenes. Such was autumn 1995.

To be continued in Episode 159

(11.03.08)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 159: Long Ago... 97 1995 Part 17 Storm of Color Samples and Copic is Divine! November and December

Everyone! Have you finished your tax returns? This year's tax return is due March 14th! Last year I thought "ah, next year I'll ask a tax accountant!" but ultimately this year was also self-calculated & document preparation. "Ah, next year for sure..." Well, but I'll probably do it myself next year too... (distant look).

...Actually, at the time I'm writing this manuscript, I haven't finished this year's tax return yet (explosion). The plan was for it to be properly finished by the time this manuscript appears - should be, should be, should be? (sweat)

Now, will it happen!?

Anyway.

Season progresses from autumn to late autumn.

Neighborhood Story

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While handling

Neighborhood Story

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To be continued in Episode 160
(11.03.08)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 15: Once Upon a Time... (10) Still More Collaborative Works, Then Suddenly

It's early summer.

The weather's decent and the sunshine feels pleasant and refreshing. The air is crisp, and even when you sweat a bit, it dries right up - GOOD.

So I'm already in short-sleeve T-shirt mode this season.

When it gets even hotter, I won't have any more clothes to wear... I think this every year, but when next month brings the rainy season, it gets relatively cool. Well, before that, I need to be careful not to collapse from the humidity.

I want to play outside lots before that rainy season comes... (distant stare).

Well then.

Let me set aside the paint talk for now.

Having become able to do color direction for collaborative works, I first got the mini-series *Robotex* and somehow managed to finish it.

Of the total 5 episodes, I was able to do color direction and check deliveries for 2 or 3 episodes... Even now I can't remember the story details (bitter laugh), but this became my first color direction work.

Around the same time as *Robotex* production, I handled several collaborative works as per-episode color director.

First was

Transformers

. You know, trucks and trains that transform into robots. That work feels very Japanese-made now, but this was also American collaboration. Specifically, which series and which episodes I did - I can't tell anymore, but I handled several episodes.

"Can't tell anymore..." because we were making so many, year after year.

Not just

Transformers

but series like

G.I. Joe

and

Muppet Babies

, starting production around summer each year to match American broadcast schedules, making about 50 episodes per series annually.

So, *Transformers*.

Man, it was robot stuff (bitter laugh). Robot stuff, but somehow very human-like - well, the robots talked and acted (laughs). I've forgotten the stories too, but my impression was some cube or other, a pink or purple cube glowing with transmitted light, with flashy beam battles over it.

Honestly, the animation was quite loose, so the moving images weren't particularly cool, and I remember not enjoying it that much... (bitter laugh).

Though last year I got hooked on robot stuff with

Gaiking: Legend of Daiku-Maryu (■■■■■ LEGEND OF DAIKU-MARYU)

(laughs).

Oh yes, speaking of *Transformers*, Toei Doga was making a theatrical version around then.

Directed by

Morishita Kozo (■■■■■)

. I think it was about a 2-hour epic. This one had perfectly cool animation - shadows with secondary shadows plus BL shadows, of course highlights galore - incredibly dense.

For this theatrical version, I helped with checking finishing deliveries, and man, I remember it being incredibly difficult.

But I thought, if this gets done properly, it'll be amazing, while somewhat detachedly checking for color mismatches.

Later, when I saw the completed footage (I think I saw it on video, not the first print...), it was spectacular.

Honestly, I've forgotten the plot of this too (explosion), but I was simply overwhelmed by the density that was completely different from the TV series

Transformers

I'd worked on. Ah, I want to see it again.

Besides per-episode *Transformers* color direction, there were lots of small collaborative work commercials and such short projects, and I was handling those one after another.

Like this, day after day I was struggling with collaborative works that couldn't be seen in Japan, but suddenly things took a sharp turn - I ended up handling a domestic work.

Moreover, it was a theatrical work!

The title was *GeGeGe no Kitaro: Yokai Daisenso (■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■)*.

##

■Continues to Episode 16

(07.05.15)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 160: Long Ago... 99 1995 Part 18 Sailor Moon SuperS Movie (sweat) in September

The March 11th earthquake and accompanying tsunami have devastated eastern Japan, particularly the Tohoku region.

Thinking of all those affected makes my heart ache. I offer heartfelt sympathy. And I pray sincerely for those who lost their lives.

Fortunately, I'm healthy in Tokyo without major damage, but colleagues and friends I work with had family homes in affected areas, and everyone had difficult times until safety confirmation. Fortunately, all acquaintances' families seem safe. Relief for now.

Now, about us.

Those of us who didn't suffer major damage should continue doing what we can do, what we always do. I think it's important to maintain activities as normally as possible. Spending money shopping, eating out when needed is important too. But no hoarding! Living normally while conserving electricity.

And we'll make anime! We'll continue making anime normally. That's what we can do first. I believe what we create will surely reach affected people in the near future and help heal their hearts.

Anyway.

In autumn 1995 when TV series

Neighborhood Story

launched fairly smoothly, rewinding the clock again. Just when

Neighborhood Story

broadcasting began, I was creating colors for characters in yet another theatrical work. My third theatrical title this year was

Sailor Moon SuperS: The 9 Sailor Soldiers Unite! Miracle of the Black Dream Hole

.

Sailor Moon

theatrical version, third consecutive year. A New Year anime released in December.

Director: Shibata Hiroki, Script: Enokido Yoji, Character Design & Animation
Director: Kagawa Hisashi, Art Supervisor: Kubota Tadao, Art Director: Tajiri
Ken'ichi. Starting with Director Shibata-san, mostly the same staff from previous
theatrical

Sailor Moon S

, plus Enokido-san joining for script. Incidentally, this was a triple feature with

Special Present: Ami-chan's First Love - Sailor Moon SuperS Side Story

and

Azuki-chan

.

Ami-chan's First Love

was a Toei Animation short directed by Igarashi Takuya with Animation Director
Shimogasa Miho.

Azuki-chan

was Madhouse production.

One day, Chibiusa meets a mysterious boy Peruru looking into a confectionery
shop window. The two become friends. Meanwhile, incidents occur where children
are taken away nightly. Peruru's brothers Pupuran and others were kidnapping
children with flute sounds. Using them to gather children, Badiyanu was trying to
create black holes by absorbing children's dream power. To save Chibiusa taken
with the children, Peruru and the Sailor Soldiers storm Badiyanu's castle... such a
story.

Like the theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

series, theatrical works develop a certain "knack" within oneself through repetition,
and being the third theatrical work, I approached it with slightly more composure.
Guest characters are built from scratch each time, but regular characters basically
don't change, so that provided some ease too. Color direction (■■■■) could use
previous work as-is... wait?

Ah, Sailor Moon's design changed again (sweat). Now even Chibiusa became a
Sailor Soldier and even cats increased (sweat sweat), plus three other soldiers
appeared (big sweat)... amazingly 9 Sailor Soldiers! Too many characters. Plus the
title's too long! My goodness. "But this large group probably appears normally on
TV."

Like

Dragon Ball Z

, I wasn't involved with TV series

Sailor Moon

, so each theatrical work brought newly encountered new settings and characters, particularly Sailor Moon designs with upgraded decorations - quite troublesome actually (bitter laugh).

Even so, 9 soldiers in one screen is many. But thinking about it,

PreCure All Stars

must be incredibly difficult... (sweat).

For guest characters, we again received colored concepts from original creator Takeuchi Naoko-sensei. But as-is had too many lines for animation, so Character Designer Kagawa-san organized lines and rewrote them. We applied Takeuchi-sensei's colors to those character settings. Ultimately Badiyanu became almost exactly as the teacher's concept, but we made modifications to Peruru and other characters.

Sensei's Peruru and Pupuran character designs wore thin veil-like material clothes with good fairy-like feeling, but faithfully reproducing semi-transparent effects was difficult. We considered methods like shooting transparent parts at half exposure, but once started, that would become tremendous work volume, no time leeway, and retakes would definitely increase... so rejected (bitter laugh). Ultimately we settled on normal solid painting in bright colors, with animation drawn to look transparent. Instead, I think we added mesh-like paint divisions to hair. I don't think this was in Takeuchi-sensei's design. I remember us anime staff adding it.

So this work would also become quite difficult... (laugh). Still, the story held together well - actually my favorite plot structure of the three works. I'd worked very hard on the "previous work," but just between us, I was somehow unsatisfied or didn't like it much, so I think I had my own "expectations" for this work.

After all, emotional aspects are big in animation production.

To be continued in Episode 161

(11.03.22)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 161: Long Ago... 100 1995 Part 19 Theatrical

Sailor Moon SuperS

and Various Thoughts October and November

I hate nuclear power plants. I hate them, but it's fact that nuclear power plants are one of the major pillars supporting the massive electrical situation for us Tokyo residents and the metropolitan area. And due to earthquake accidents, Fukushima's nuclear power plants are now in terrible situations, with radiation danger approaching Fukushima Prefecture residents and us metropolitan area residents. The government keeps repeating "it's safe," but online "danger!" is being shouted, and everyone lives with anxiety.

I'm not an expert so I'm not in a position to say "which is correct," but it's inescapable fact that unpleasant situations are approaching. For now, staying in Tokyo seems OK, but quite a number of people want to leave Tokyo and the metropolitan area. Some among my acquaintances and industry colleagues too.

Rather than "effects on human body," I think it's first about "peace of mind." Particularly for those with small children, infants, pregnant women - there are only anxiety factors. Once you become concerned and anxiety sprouts, those sprouts only grow and won't easily disappear. So for peace of mind too, I think evacuation to other regions is one strategy for those in situations where it's possible.

But the majority, including myself, aren't in such situations. We must continue doing what we can do now, our roles. Various things happen and progress isn't immediate, but steadily advancing step by step is essential. Staying composed without wavering. But never becoming stubborn, constantly recognizing new information and surrounding situations. Always preparing and waiting for opportunities.

With such feelings, I'm currently participating in a new TV series at a certain Mitaka studio. I believe society will be somewhat calmer by the time this work can be viewed.

Anyway.

Theatrical

Sailor Moon SuperS: The 9 Sailor Soldiers Unite! Miracle of the Black Dream Hole

(←title too long (laugh)), the 1996 New Year movie - nationwide release December 23rd, Emperor's Birthday. With always tight Toei Animation production and Toei distribution theatrical work schedules, general previews are held the weekend

before release. These principally use prints for general screenings at the venue theaters. So one week before those previews, we complete it tentatively, do a zero preview, and begin printing films for screening.

Print work procedure starts with prints for theaters far from Tokyo that take time to transport. Theatrical screenings use 35mm film, but small rural theaters were still using 16mm film screening then, and I think they started with those 16mm films.

About 1-2 weeks before master completion (negative editing) and zero preview, there's sound work. Music and sound effects. Impact sounds, explosion sounds, effects sounds for special moves, character clothing rustle sounds, etc.

Furthermore, whether sounds come from right, left, front, back, or while moving - sound positioning matches screen movement. So naturally, screens must be completed to add those sound effects.

Editing to adjust acting timing and determine overall movie length was November 11th this time, with voice actors dubbing the next 12th. But screens weren't completed yet. About 1/5 was almost finished at this point - cuts made in advance for trailers and transformation bank cuts also used in TV series. The remaining 4/5 were still rough photography and timing shots (when cels are finished but backgrounds aren't ready or photography effects take time, we temporarily shoot with just cels to understand voice and sound timing).

Anyway, editing and dubbing require minimum rough animation completion for acting, so rough animation gathers for this editing. Animation directors then do intensive animation director work. Next, I add color direction (■■■■) and order in-betweening and finishing. Parallel to color direction work, inspect finished cels, process retakes, pass to photography, rushes check photographed cuts, and process retakes in parallel if any. So the approximately 2 weeks from editing and dubbing to sound work are the real crunch. The actual battle.

Theatrical works of this era were all cel production. Moreover, needing creation in short periods, domestic productions usually handling Toei works and Manila studio alone weren't sufficient, so we requested work from Korean and Chinese productions. As I write every time, paint problems arise. Toei works' basic STAC paint versus Korean and Chinese productions' Taiyo Shisai paint. This color development difference is quite difficult. Particularly

Sailor Moon

requires clear color development finishing. We want to avoid muddy colors on screen as much as possible. But production-wise, we must also request Taiyo Shisai paint productions. Moreover, volume-wise, during crunch periods, the ratio requested from Korean and Chinese productions inevitably becomes much higher.

Still, this theatrical

Sailor Moon SuperS

was my third Sailor Moon. Based on past two works' reflections, I allocated "normal" color cuts and Sailor Soldier cuts to productions that could use STAC paint as much as possible. Instead, enemy boss character "Badiyanu" and "Bonbon Babies" cuts that seemed OK painted with Taiyo Shisai paint, and background scenes of kidnapped children were prioritionally ordered to Taiyo Shisai productions. Even Sailor Soldiers' special coloring scene cuts were designed from the color design stage using Taiyo Shisai paint from the start.

This was actually more convenient for me. Character clarity in normal scenes was definitely better with STAC colors, and since TV series used STAC colors, including compatibility with bank scenes also used in TV series, it appeared in familiar balance to audiences coming to theaters. Conversely, night colors, reddish special coloring in Badiyanu's castle battle scenes, and reflection highlights and high contrast colors worked better with subtle color creation based on Taiyo Shisai paint's rich color variety. What always concerned me was retake processing after cels were painted with Taiyo Shisai colors, but by this time, considerable Taiyo Shisai paint stock existed in-house, covering most retakes.

Like this, in December. December 13th, exactly 10 days before release, theatrical

Sailor Moon SuperS

safely had its zero preview. Somehow completed.

Everything works out somehow if you're properly prepared, no matter how difficult. This theatrical

Sailor Moon SuperS

was probably quite difficult including work volume during crunch, but somehow felt like we persevered without much confusion. Well, maybe various things were difficult, but ah, I don't remember...

Like the previous two works,

Sailor Moon

theatrical works involved color creation and screen creation thinking about first firmly reproducing TV series visual impressions, then how much "theatrical work-ness" could be added on top. I think I managed to work hard well in my own way for this third theatrical version.

But still, detailed areas show roughness throughout the screen. Myself feeling limits and rebelling against this theatrical work creation method of making everything at once in short periods, and myself having experience and familiarity from experiencing such creation methods multiple times yearly. Feeling dilemma

about myself lacking clear satisfaction in that gap was also fact. "Not remembering very well" the difficult aspects might also represent becoming accustomed to such theatrical work creation methods. I want to make theatrical works taking more time carefully. But I also understand that's definitely impossible while working at Toei Animation.

"So how should I be within such creation methods?" I began pondering such thoughts around this period.

Though I was like that, there was another reason for "not remembering very well" the difficult aspects... While handling TV series

Neighborhood Story

color design in parallel, currently in enthusiastic crunch for theatrical

Sailor Moon SuperS

. And amazingly, preparation for two more theatrical works plus another different job had started. That was November 1995.

To be continued in Episode 162

(11.03.29)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 162: Long Ago... 101 1995 Part 20 Unexpected Additional Theatrical Works and "Dragon Quest VI" Descent in September

Actually, we currently have a cat at home. Due to various circumstances, we're having my wife's family cat homestay with us. Her name is "Mao." About 10 years old. Male. In human terms, maybe over 60? An old man.

If asked "dogs? cats?" I'm definitely team cat, but I'd never owned a cat before. Moreover, this "Mao" and I had been in a rival relationship for years - whenever I visited my wife's family home, I was completely unwelcome, always glared at with triangular eyes, plus threatened with "fuu~~, shah~~!"

So initially I wondered what would happen, but thanks to diligently preparing food and continuing to handle poop disposal, we're now super close. Bound by strong trust.

This "Mao" will return to my wife's family home soon - about one more week until farewell. Ah, what is this? This sadness... Somehow I can't imagine life without "Mao." Like lovers torn apart by fate.

Ah, what should I do... (cry). (continued)

Anyway.

"Tsujita-kun, do you have a moment?"

One day at the end of August, the section chief called me to a small room. This pattern usually means being scolded or assigned new work. "Work-wise,

Neighborhood Story

TV broadcast is about to start and that's going fairly smoothly, and the new winter theatrical

Sailor Moon

just started when similarly called recently. So is this some scolding? Things I can think of... ah, there are some" - thinking such things while following the section chief to the small room.

"Well, it's about theatrical (works)"

"Yes? I'm already on the

Sailor Moon

theatrical, and poster work has started..."

"The next one. Next spring. Apparently they're doing

Dragon Ball

."

That's right. The story was making a theatrical

Dragon Ball

work for next year (1996) spring release. Moreover, not

Dragon Ball Z

that we'd been making for years, but new theatrical

Dragon Ball

without the "Z." With original manga serialization ending in "Weekly Shonen Jump" and no more new original developments, apparently they'd return to origins and make a theatrical version following the original from the very beginning, around Goku's appearance. Title:

Dragon Ball: The Path to Power

.

"Well, Tsujita-kun, you're handling a lot, so I was thinking of putting someone else on it..."

"No, I'll do it, I'll do it, please let me do it!"

Actually, I'd been vaguely hearing about this theatrical version since early summer. And while the flow should have naturally settled on me as usual, somehow things were getting strange - production was floating ideas like having someone else do color direction since I was overloaded. And since there was nobody suitable in-house, they'd call external color direction staff.

I wasn't amused by that talk.

Certainly I was handling TV series

Neighborhood Story

color design (■■■■■), and currently working enthusiastically on theatrical

Sailor Moon SuperS: The 9 Sailor Soldiers Unite! Miracle of the Black Dream Hole

(←title still too long (cry)). But originally, for

Neighborhood Story

, I was removed from individual episode color direction so I could handle other theatrical works, and honestly, for spring release works, the real busy period should be after

Sailor Moon SuperS

finishes in December. Certainly preparation periods overlap, but I was prepared to handle that somehow. And above all, I've supported theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

up to this point! - there was self-respect and pride, so I thought I'd do it whatever the situation!

"Ah? Really? You'll take it? Well, since the director is Yamauchi-kun, even saying 'someone else' would be difficult, so I was wondering what to do. I'm sure Yamauchi-kun will ask for Tsujita-kun anyway. I see, you'll do it. Ah, good!"

"Yes, I'll work hard!"

"And there's still more."

"Yes?"

"

Neighborhood Story

will also be made as a double feature."

"Whaat!?"

What the heck! Nobody told me! Theatrical

Neighborhood Story

- I didn't actually know this was moving.

"If Tsujita-kun takes

Dragon Ball

, this would be impossible, so just create character colors, just characters. Someone else will do the movie's main story color direction."

Ah, I was had! Toei Animation's convention was that TV work theatrical versions are basically handled by the TV staff member for color direction. So naturally that would be me, and the section chief knew this and brought up topics in this order. He knew I'd naturally want to do

Dragon Ball

, so I was completely had by the section chief (bitter laugh). Hmm? Was it the section chief? Maybe someone higher up in production created such a scenario?

Anyway, 1995 thus became a super-packed year: 5 theatrical titles (1 title characters only), 1 TV series color design, plus part-time work with 2 magazine cover color directions, 1 laser disc jacket still color direction, 1 PlayStation game opening color direction and inspection...

"Oh, and one more thing. Do this too."

"Eh?"

The section chief handed me several rough drawings. These drawings, don't tell me...

"You know the game

Dragon Quest VI

coming out? Calendar for that. Since it's Toriyama Akira and Nakatsuru-kun is drawing it, do color direction for this. And..."

"Eh? And?"

"And there's also color direction for strategy guide art for the upcoming

Dragon Quest VI

, so please handle that too."

"...!"

Somehow the section chief piled various things on me in the confusion and left. After all that talk about theatrical works being difficult and

Neighborhood Story

being tough, eh? What? This work is...

So amazingly, even "Dragon Quest" work came my way!

To be continued in Episode 163

(11.04.12)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 163: Long Ago... 102 1995 Part 21 "Dragon Quest VI" Emergency Calendar in September

The cat "Mao" homestayng at our house due to various circumstances from my wife's family home had loose stool, even somewhat diarrhea. The return date was already decided, but "we can't send him back with loose stool like this," so we took him to a neighborhood doctor for examination. Amazingly, undesirable bacteria were found in his stomach. Medicine was prescribed and we began giving it to him.

However, this medicine was apparently too strong - instead of diarrhea clearing up, vomiting became frequent, and he visibly lost strength and weakened. Ah, what should we do (sweat).

We took "Mao" to the doctor again for IV treatment. Indeed, medicine side effects. Too strong apparently. Since it was too strong, bacteria were magnificently eliminated. Subsequent medicine was changed to gentle stomach medicine.

I didn't know, but there are almost no cat-specific medicines. Both the medicine that caused side effects and the stomach medicine given afterward are actually all human medicines. They adjust quantities for cats. That's right - cat-exclusive medicines would probably sell in small numbers compared to development costs.

Such "Mao" is still lying on my wife's bed. (continued)

Anyway.

"Dragon Quest VI: Realms of Revelation." An extremely popular Super Famicom game software. Honestly, its popularity is somewhat declining now(?), but 1995 was still peak boom. I'm actually a big "Dragon Quest" fan myself. From the very first Famicom game, I'd get it on release day and play thoroughly. I think for II or III, I was such a bad working adult that I barely went to the company for 3-4 days from release, playing thoroughly (bitter laugh). So during this busy period, even if handed such troublesome-looking work in half-chaos, there's no way I'd refuse! (laugh)

This "Dragon Quest" - I think VI's release was also delayed repeatedly until December this year? Various items are released to coincide with that release. Among those, Toei Animation was actually working on the artwork portions of several items. Because Toei Animation had made

Dr. Slump Arale-chan

and

Dragon Ball

- Toriyama Akira original animation works, and above all, Nakatsuru-san, an animator essential to Toriyama works, belongs here. So Toei Animation had been handling Toriyama-sensei related non-animation work for a while. Incidentally, work like "V Jump" covers and character stills for other games where Toriyama-sensei did character design were also handled in various small ways.

Now, this "Dragon Quest VI." First was emergency calendar work. Normally calendars are completed by summer of the previous year for trade shows, appearing in stores by November. I was assigned this calendar work and worked on it in September. So you can see how delayed it was. Well, I remember it wasn't for normal calendar distribution, so it was special in that sense.

Calendar artwork: cover plus 6 interior pieces, total 7. Basically artwork feeling like famous scenes from the game main story. Work was basically same as stills and posters - first rough layouts "like this" came from calendar producers, then the rough artist (Nakatsuru-san) created layouts. After those checks got OK, the rest followed animation artwork flow. Nakatsuru-san drew rough animation for character parts, it came to me for color direction, then to coloring. Rough animation in this case wasn't rough lines but so-called clean copy state rough animation ready for finishing tracing and coloring work as-is. Meanwhile, art staff drew backgrounds in parallel. When both were finished, they were combined, position and frame confirmed for completion. Delivered and sent to photography in that state. Photography was probably handled by still artwork specialist photographers.

Character colors naturally had to match the game. Toriyama-sensei's color illustrations (used on game software packages) were provided as references, and main characters were color directed to match those. Also, monsters and items appearing in games had existing "Dragon Quest" related visuals to match. But the problem was other characters - like unnamed characters, masses of other people, small items. For these, I had to decide somehow to match the atmosphere. This was perfect! Having played through previous "Dragon Quest" games thoroughly, I could grasp images without hesitation and place colors confidently. Ah, maybe the section chief who assigned this work knew I'd played through "Dragon Quest."

Like that, calendar was delivered before autumn equinox in a rush. Afterward, "V Jump" stills (and covers?) came occasionally. And December, the awaited game was released. Naturally I also purchased it. But this time was a delicious deal - amazingly, I received the game (laugh). Hehe, nice! Sometimes such delicious things must happen.

But that was brief. Strategy guide work finally began. December was already enthusiastically working on both parallel

Neighborhood Story

and the next theatrical work. The "Dragon Quest VI" that finally reached me had no time to play (cry).

To be continued in Episode 164

(11.04.19)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 164: Long Ago... 103 1995 Part 22

Dragon Quest VI

Item Color Direction Into the New Year!? December

The cat "Mao" homestayng at our house due to various circumstances from my wife's family home - thanks to that, his stomach condition improved and he's in perfect form. He eats even more than before.

Actually, this cat had obesity tendencies previously, so he'd been eating somewhat expensive diet food as regular food. High-fiber crunchy diet food. However, when his stomach condition was worst, the doctor advised restraint, so we switched to soft normal food - you know, those cat-delight canned foods advertised on TV. Well, there was also the practical reason that mixing medicine into food was easier.

But this cat wouldn't jump at this cat-favorite food. Initially he ate reluctantly, but soon wouldn't look at it and completely refused.

Somehow, he apparently dislikes the texture. Seems to dislike non-crunchy food (bitter laugh). "I'm still young. I hate such toothless mushy food. Men stick to crunchy food" - exactly that feeling.

So we quickly returned to crunchy diet food, but he really eats a lot (sweat). Even if it's diet food, overeating is... (continued)

Anyway.

Super Famicom game software

Dragon Quest VI: Realms of Revelation

- strategy guide work following the calendar. The book's official title was "Dragon Quest VI: Realms of Revelation Official Guidebook." It was divided into two volumes: "World Volume" as upper volume, "Knowledge Volume" as lower volume. "World Volume" centered on game world maps and story development, while "Knowledge Volume" consisted of character job abilities, spells, weapons and armor items, and monster encyclopedias.

Both "World Volume" and "Knowledge Volume" basically centered on game screen images. What we at Toei Animation handled was cool game character images and reproduction(?) scene images, plus item introduction images, etc.

Main characters - protagonist, Hassan (martial artist), Mireyu (dancer), Barbara (mage), Chamoro (priest), Terry (swordsman) - who form parties with the

protagonist for travel were test-painted and decided according to Toriyama-sensei's illustrations during calendar production. First, their standing poses. Several pose images each of them using techniques or casting spells. Several images each equipped with items obtainable during travel.

Next, supporting characters. Warriors and monsters who act as protagonist's companions during travel. Then characters met in villages, towns, castles who have various information - standing poses decided. Merchants, tavern girls, fortune teller grandmas. Oh, kings too. Since there weren't particularly Toriyama-sensei's original color illustrations for these, Toei Animation would create Toriyama Akira-style artwork, get it checked, and if OK, proceed to coloring. For colors, I'd pick general colors from actual game screen captures and color direct appropriately to create them.

Next, we made scenes of their activities as still artwork. These became still images with backgrounds. Like animation cuts, layouts were created, checked, and if OK, animated into in-betweens, color directed, colored, then those cels were combined with backgrounds for still photography. There were actually quite a lot of these. Just like normal animation production, everyone used cut folders for each cut. Since they were stills, cut folders themselves were thin, but accumulated, they created quite an intimidating pressure.

Moreover, what was difficult was spell and technique effect expression. Games had some animation attached, but we had to create stills. No movement. So naturally they'd have special effects like brushes and touches, but this was honestly subtle (bitter laugh). They inevitably became shabby. As I wrote earlier, I'm a fairly passionate fan who's played

Dragon Quest

throughout, so by those standards, I didn't want to include disappointing cuts. So I personally had many unsatisfactory cuts, but I closed my eyes and resigned myself to "if they're OK with it, it's OK."

These character and scene cut groups were completed in November. November was anyway the crunch for theatrical

Sailor Moon SuperS

, TV

Neighborhood Story

, and two spring theatrical works I haven't mentioned yet - a wonderful situation. Whether they considered my situation is unknown (←probably not), but latter half item-related artwork was extremely delayed.

Then boom, December. Storm-like item attack (sweat). Items were suddenly piled up for color direction. Weapons, armor, equipment, tools... From "medicinal herbs" to "mysterious armor" - how many points were there exactly? Anyway, all items appearing in "Dragon Quest VI" would become artwork (cel paintings). Color references for these were various - items that appeared in previous works matched the same forms and colors. Previous strategy guides were handed as references (laugh). For newly appearing items, game screen captures were references again. But some had no reference images, just notes saying "please arrange ■■-like." Those became somewhat my original feeling.

Well, basically it was enjoyable "Dragon Quest VI" work I couldn't help loving, but there were simply too many and color direction couldn't keep up. Particularly, work picking colors from capture images and creating them wasn't just making the same colors - they naturally had to look cool, and required considerable time for work like color coordination considering balance to avoid resembling existing items. Moreover, I still had to handle theatrical work centrally, so this tended to be pushed back. Result: this item-related color direction work couldn't be finished by New Year's Eve, so I completed it giving up New Year's holidays.

And naturally, the actual game

Dragon Quest VI

was postponed until those were finished.

To be continued in Episode 165

(11.04.26)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 165: Side Story: About Names

My goodness. Sorry for taking such a long break from publication.

Currently participating in a new program starting broadcast in July. First TV series in almost a year since

The Tatami Galaxy

. Just over a month until broadcast. Entering the climax of program startup - quite difficult in various ways. With all this, I couldn't move freely and kept missing manuscript deadlines. Everyone, I'm sorry.

Now, this new TV series - I'm handling Episode 1 color direction as usual, but I'm scheduled to participate in color direction for quite a number of episodes this series. This 2-cour, planned 24-episode series - this is my focus this year. Please look forward to it.

Eh? The title? Official staff announcements haven't been made yet... (sweat). The workplace is dizzyingly busy, but working with this director for the first time in quite a while is quite enjoyable with continuous surprises and laughter.

...So I've returned after 3 weeks?

Anyway.

The Anime Style talk event "Yamauchi Shigeyasu's World Part 1" was recently held with great success. I also appeared as someone who knows Director Yamauchi, talking about old stories (already a quarter century ago (laugh)) and various things.

Well, I didn't talk about this at the event, but about Director Yamauchi's and my names.

Many of you probably know, but I actually worked under names other than my real name. The credit "Kokuon Kunio" - some of you have probably seen it somewhere. Starting with

Revolutionary Girl Utena

, through

Strange Dawn

,

Kaleido Star

, theatrical

Fist of the North Star

trilogy, etc.

Well, since the statute of limitations has passed (has it?), I'll talk about it - these works were so-called "other company work" during my time at Toei. So they were credited with concealed characters, or pen names, or false names, aliases. That was Kokuon Kunio.

Working on other company productions while doing Toei Animation work, but being involved with productions meant not being half-hearted, not causing trouble for other staff - I resolved this and approached productions with the stance of giving 100% to Toei work and equally 100% to other company productions. However, it couldn't be like Toei work where I'd handle everything (color design & color direction inspection), so participation was like character color design only, or color design only - such forms of full participation.

Those in the industry understand well that Toei Animation and other productions have greatly different production methods and workplace systems. Toei is somewhat of a black box. Since almost all parts are made with basically in-house staff (including TAP), Toei's style has formed in production. That has good aspects, but I was interested in other productions' styles, and there were many good aspects not found at Toei. So I wanted to experience that and make it mine, and reflect that experience even slightly into Toei's system. With such personal convictions, I participated whenever asked.

Initially when first using this name for

Utena

, I hadn't thought much about the future, but thankfully I received various work offers afterward. Among those, from around participating in

Kaleido Star

, I began thinking "ah, I'd like to make this 'Kokuon Kunio' into a brand." "Tsujita Kunio" at Toei, and "Kokuon Kunio" elsewhere. Having encountered works with different tastes from Toei works, I arbitrarily thought "I'd like to develop this into a brand."

And then

Casshern Sins

. This work was also initially discussed with the production producer as Kokuon Kunio credit, but when the opening was finally completed and credit discussions began, Director Yamauchi said this:

"When putting names in the opening, if it's not a real name, it seems not serious and is disrespectful to all other staff."

This single statement was tremendously shocking to me. Director Yamauchi always sharply strikes the essence of matters directly with few words like this. I thought I was working on productions with sincerity and full effort, working hard without causing much trouble, but people seeing this credit might not think so... Honestly, I hadn't considered such things at all.

Having names credited in productions means, for better or worse, "I'm responsible for this part." Moreover, when it's opening credits, this becomes a responsibility issue for the entire production. Not crediting with real names there certainly could seem like escaping that responsibility.

For

Casshern Sins

, I decided to be credited with my real name. And simultaneously, I decided to work with only my own name going forward and quit Toei Animation, where I'd been long cared for, to become freelance.

It's been three years now, but I think that decision was correct. Being able to continue without wavering like this is thanks to what Yamauchi-san said that time - I'm grateful. Works marking turning points for me are always Director Yamauchi's works.

To be continued in Episode 166

(11.05.31)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 166: About Apple-Branded Equipment

I missed my manuscript deadline again (sweat). I'm sorry.

As I mentioned briefly last time, I'm participating in Director Ikuhara's new TV series

Mawaru Penguindrum

. With July broadcast start imminent, the workplace has become quite tense in various ways (bitter laugh). Lots to do! But TV series workplaces are fun.

With Director Ikuhara since

Revolutionary Girl Utena

(for

Utena

I was credited as "Kokuon Kunio"). How many years since theatrical

Revolutionary Girl Utena: Adolescence Apocalypse

? 12 years? 13 years? Anyway, it's been quite a while working with Director Ikuhara again.

As always when participating in TV series, when broadcast approaches, feelings naturally get excited. I want to see everyone's reactions soon (laugh).

Besides terrestrial broadcast, it apparently airs on CS and BS too, so it seems viewable nationwide. So everyone, please treat us favorably. Please look forward to it!

Anyway.

This time, about equipment I use.

Currently I'm stationed daily at

Mawaru Penguindrum's

workplace, Brain's Base studio in Tokyo's Mitaka, bringing my own equipment for work as usual.

Recently keyboard problems worsened, so I bought and replaced it with a new one. Keyboards are consumables. This old keyboard came with (or rather, was bought with) the desktop main unit. It was a keyboard that traveled through quite various works. Because this machine I'm using here at Mitaka studio was first

purchased midway through the first work when I participated in the theatrical
Fist of the North Star

trilogy at Tokyo Movie in Shin-Yakushi. I think it was 2006? The original MacPro
type. Yes, I'm a hardcore Mac user (laugh).

Initially I borrowed Tokyo Movie's machines (miraculously, they had Macs!), but
they were somewhat underpowered. Particularly for large copyright still work like
posters, or continuous Photoshop batch processing of main story cut coloring data
- quite overwhelmed and time-consuming. At that time I was juggling with Toei
Animation work at Oizumi - daytime → Oizumi, evening ~ morning → Shin-Yakushi
lifestyle. So if machine power could reduce work time even slightly, some personal
expense and investment was unavoidable. So I bought the new model (at the time)
out of pocket(!).

For about 3 years after that, I participated in theatrical

Fist of the North Star

trilogy and pachinko/pachislot

Fist of the North Star

work in between at Shin-Yakushi studio. When somehow finished, I cleared out of
Shin-Yakushi studio and brought this equipment to Oizumi. Used it at Toei
Animation studio.

Our color design equipment at Toei Animation was basically hand-me-down
machines from photography staff. Though I expected photography machines to be
extremely high-powered, these were honestly underpowered too. So "Fine! I'll use
my own equipment!"

At Toei, I completed theatrical

Gegege no Kitaro

,

Strong World One Piece Film

,

Marie & Galie

, and various other works with this machine, then last year brought it here to
Brain's Base.

My basic equipment set: desktop MacPro with keyboard, WACOM pen tablet
Intuos, two monitors (EIZO 24-inch ColorEdge and 19-inch sub-monitor). Plus A4
scanner, external HDD, and oh yes, uninterruptible power supply (laugh) as

needed. Roughly like that. What the heck, tremendous baggage. Writing it out myself, I'm surprised! (laugh)

Conversely, when participating in

Casshern Sins

, I actually equipped the same basic equipment set at Madhouse. After production ended, I temporarily brought it to Shogakukan Music & Digital Entertainment in Jinbocho for

Gokujo! Mecha Mote Committee Chairman

. Then moved it again to Madhouse (Shin-Nakano this time) to complete

The Tatami Galaxy

. And this is also now at Brain's Base. Active for various checks. Incidentally, there's the same set at my home work room, so amazingly 3 sets total. So I'm doing depreciation on tax returns every year (laugh).

Most production companies mainly use Windows equipment, so borrowing equipment at their studios inevitably means Win machines. Moreover, OS and equipment specs vary considerably by model. And what's concerning is monitors. These vary completely by equipment - is the color I'm seeing now correct? This is actually the biggest stress.

So from the perspective of being able to concentrate on work without stress by unifying the environment I use daily, I necessarily bring my own equipment sets.

Why Mac originally was, as I wrote here before, Director Yamauchi's "missionary work" and Toei's digital environment being Mac, but I can use Windows to some extent. But compatibility is definitely best with Mac. Windows feels rugged and masculine? Mac feels intuitively gentle? Feminine? I'm drawn to Mac (laugh).

However, depending on what direction my work heads, things will probably change in various ways. If heading toward 3DCG, depending on applications used, it would probably be Windows. How is it?

Even so, I think I probably can't separate from this apple-marked equipment.

To be continued in Episode 167

(11.06.28)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 167: Long Ago... 104 1995 Part 24 Finally "The Path to Power,"
However...

Well,

Mawaru Penguin Drum

has finally begun broadcasting - have you all been watching? (grin)

Mawaru Penguin Drum's

production site has more female staff than any I've ever experienced. So I'm paying more attention than usual to my appearance and grooming. One aspect is my beard. I make sure to shave every day.

Speaking of shaving, as I wrote here before, the shaving cream problem. Recently, after using up what I'd been using, I went to buy new supplies and my eyes met something called "Shaving Gel." The color and texture looked very refreshing, so I bought it for immediate trial.

Literally gel - putting bouncy gel in my palm and spreading it slickly on my face. Cool and refreshing up to this point. However, when I actually started shaving, huh? It doesn't shave as refreshingly as expected. Catching here and there, causing bloodshed (cry). Good grief. But I'll probably get used to it eventually...

Anyway.

There's been quite a gap, but the story returns to 1995.

The Great Hanshin-Awaji Earthquake, plus the subway sarin incident - I think it was a year with somehow restless, tense atmosphere.

Not that I was driven by such atmosphere, but work titles were extremely packed in 1995. Capping that year were naturally theatrical works. Theatrical

Dragon Ball: The Path to Power

. And double feature, theatrical

Neighborhood Story

. These two became the final work of turbulent 1995 ~ early 1996.

As mentioned earlier, for theatrical

Neighborhood Story

(Script: Kageyama Yumi, Animation Director: Umakoshi Yoshihiko, Art Director: Gyoshin Mitsu, Director: Shimizu Junji), I only did character color design and special coloring design for several scenes - color direction (■■■■) work was handled by someone else.

Now, the problematic theatrical

Dragon Ball: The Path to Power

. Script: Matsui Aya, Character Design & Animation Director: Yamamuro Tadayoshi, Art Directors: Tsuji Tadanao & Higashi Jun'ichi, Director: Yamauchi Shigeyasu. Incidentally, assistant directors were Sakai Munehisa and Nagamine Tatsuya - the young days of new and old

PreCure

series directors for

Suite PreCure■■

and

Heartcatch PreCure!

(laugh).

When my participation was officially decided at summer's end, storyboard work wasn't even half finished, with just occasional promotional stills coming around. I myself was extremely busy with TV

Neighborhood Story

, theatrical

Sailor Moon SS

, plus

Dragon Quest VI

work, so I was half-neglecting

The Path to Power

work. Somehow, having completely figured out Toei's theatrical work schedules over recent years, I felt "well, still far off~."

However, unbeknownst to me,

The Path to Power

had fallen into various problematic situations. Not simply storyboard delays, but apparently fundamental content issues. And then...

"We're having an overall review meeting for

The Path to Power

!"

Producer Morishita-san issued the order. All main staff, production people, and planning people were summoned to a large room at Hotel Hikarigaoka near Oizumi Studio. October 19th evening.

To be continued in Episode 168

(11.07.12)

Color Design Notes [Tsuji Kunitada]

Episode 168: Long Ago... 105 1995 Part 25 Hotel Sequester Meeting Camp - Where Will It Lead!?

This weekend, I took just two days off and went to Sanuki in Kagawa Prefecture, Shikoku for a Oda Kazumasa live concert. A passionate 3.5-hour outdoor live performance at the tip of Okushi Peninsula against the backdrop of the Seto Inland Sea - it was magnificent! What a great summer vacation.

And Sunday, there was a major nationwide event in Japan. Yes, analog TV broadcast cessation. Cessation at noon on the 24th - at that moment I was on Kotohira Shrine's long stone steps. It was unfortunate not to experience that moment in front of a TV. A turning point for TV broadcasting that had cared for me for over 40 years since becoming aware. Thanks to this TV I was captivated by animation and am here now - grateful for TV broadcasting history.

I returned to Tokyo at night, but my work room TV receiver is analog (digitized through BD deck connection), and I'd actually been watching analog waves until just before leaving for travel. So I was half-looking forward to turning on the TV when I got home to confirm static!

But when I turned on the TV... huh? Wait? I can watch broadcasts normally (sweat).

"Ah, that's right!"

Actually, our apartment building uses cable TV entirely, so the cable company apparently provides analog conversion of digital broadcasts - nothing special, just normal viewing. Somewhat disappointing (laugh).

Anyway.

Under Producer Morishita's orders, we theatrical

Dragon Ball: The Path to Power

staff were gathered at Daiichi Hotel Hikarigaoka (at that time). Gathered in a large guest room with an unusually spacious meeting room, the conference began.

First, various current situation discussions. Schedule talks, already decided CG processing orders, sponsor and magazine announcement talks, various framework discussions. After such brief preliminaries, straight into the main topic.

I don't think it started with "We've gathered you for nothing other than..." (laugh), but quite urgent and serious talk. Actually, changing scenario composition at this point was this meeting's main topic.

Storyboard work had been progressing since summer until today, but the situation was quite slow progress. Animation had already started based on partially completed storyboards, but "wait a moment!"

The Path to Power's

plot structure basically covers Bulma and Goku's meeting through defeating the Red Ribbon Army. Naturally there wasn't time to show everything according to the original, so the script selected and connected episodes, but apparently this lacked excitement somehow. So going back to script stage, dividing completed script episodes into blocks and rearranging them, adding writing if necessary - such discussion. Who brought up this topic is unclear. Such discussions would normally be settled privately among planning, scriptwriter, and director, but having camp-like situations seeking "some breakthrough" was somewhat abnormal. So the meeting atmosphere felt extraordinary.

Starting the meeting like that. Initially everyone didn't speak much, but eventually it became heated discussion. I think there was a whiteboard or something in the room, with the assistant producer writing down various opinions while creating episode reordering plans.

And in the midst of that, I was... sorry, mostly dozing (explosion).

Because at this time I was in crunch mode for theatrical

Sailor Moon SS

, working until morning almost daily. Sleep deprivation was reaching its peak. So though summoned to such meetings, I couldn't beat extreme sleepiness and involuntarily nodded off... When I noticed, somehow the meeting was heading toward conclusion (sweat). Discussion was thoroughly exhausted, with conclusions to make several rearrangements.

Then "we'll take today's discussion results and reconsider"... Eh? It's not decided here after discussing?? ...Well, like that (bitter laugh). Somehow extremely tiring. The clock hands had already overrun to the next day.

I returned to the studio afterward and stayed overnight for theatrical

Sailor Moon SS

work. Really, whatever anyone said, theatrical

Sailor Moon SS

in front of me was more important then, so honestly I mostly felt "being called to such meetings and restrained..." And ultimately, the crucial scenario composition problem didn't result in very major changes... Such was that mysterious one-night camp.

Oh yes, that guest room was rented until morning, so "since we have it, someone stay overnight!" said Morishita-san. So Nagamine-kun and Sakai-kun stayed to clean up. Wait? I remember that bedroom having a double bed... How was it?
←What?

To be continued in Episode 169

(11.07.26)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 169: Summer Greetings and Current Status

Summer greetings to you all. How are you spending these hot summer days?

Recently, I've been dropping manuscripts sporadically - no, completely - and I'm sorry (sweat).

I'm currently in the midst of production for Director Ikuhara Kunihiko's long-awaited new work, TV animation

Mawaru Penguindrum

currently airing to great acclaim on MBS network, spending enjoyable passionate days every day and night. Broadcasting has already finished through Episode 5. After a break for golf broadcast(!), from this weekend's Episode 6, turbulent broadcasting continues. All 24 episodes, broadcast until year-end.

My recent daily routine involves commuting from my home in Nakano to Mitaka via Chuo Line. Amazingly, a commuter pass! I haven't had a commuter pass for about 10 years? But this is cheapest and most convenient. I can stop at Kichijoji freely along the way (laugh).

Such Chuo Line commuting - after arriving at Mitaka Station, I first stop at Starbucks in the station building for coffee. I carry around a 16-ounce, exactly "Grande" size thermal bottle, buying coffee for it before heading to the studio as daily routine. Usually hot coffee, but this summer, naturally iced coffee. This thermal bottle is quite good - stays properly cold for about half a day. Ice remains unmelted, which makes me happy.

Going daily, shop staff gradually remember my face, which feels nice too.

About a 5-minute walk from the south exit to Brain's Base, the production company with staff rooms. Stopping at convenience stores along the way is also routine. Here I buy mineral water. Brand: Wilkinson. Carbonated mineral water.

When traveling in Europe, mineral water sold in cities is usually carbonated, and being somewhat uncomfortable with carbonation, I avoided gas-filled ones completely, but apparently this carbonation somewhat helps relax muscles and shoulder stiffness, so hearing that rumor, I thought "well then..." and started drinking it. As rumored, it might be somewhat good. So I continue drinking it. The sharp taste feels good too. Well, regarding shoulder stiffness, I'm simultaneously taking Vitamin B12 supplements, so that might be helping, but I think it's good to try anything possible.

Though the biggest enemy is undeniably lack of exercise...

I buy two 500ml bottles of that Wilkinson. Depending on timing, I also buy rice balls, sandwiches, lunch boxes. Oh yes, I often buy Calorie Mate too. Fruit and Maple are recent favorites. Perfect for eating when slightly hungry during studio work.

"This isn't very delicious, so it's just right!" says Chief Director Nakamura Akiko-san. She apparently often buys Calorie Mate too. "Because if it were delicious, you'd eat too much!" Ah, certainly (bitter laugh).

Brain's Base building is located slightly into a residential area from the commercial district. Since staff rooms are on upper floors, I unhesitatingly take the elevator (laugh). Eh? Stairs? Lack of exercise? ...No no (bitter laugh).

This building's stairs are outside stairs, and previously when I went up by stairs, the floor entrance was locked and I couldn't enter, waiting 1.5 hours for staff to arrive, so since then it's basically elevator.

Mawaru Penguin's

staff room isn't that spacious. Desks are arranged everywhere with shoulder-width narrow passages like a maze (laugh). During the recent big earthquake, color boxes stacked on animation desks fell simultaneously! During continued aftershocks, everyone couldn't restack color boxes in original locations for a while, making narrow passages even narrower with color boxes.

My seat is the northwest corner of the staff room. I work with color direction staff in an area half-covered by black light-blocking material. Since I use my monitor as the reference monitor, various checks like art boards, backgrounds, character color checks are usually done at my seat. When there's lots to check, it's tough and I often can't do my own work. Well, either way, I need to attend those checks, so time consumption is unavoidable (laugh).

Furthermore, I attend many meetings. Regarding each episode's meetings: starting with "direction meetings" held immediately after storyboard completion, "art board meetings" for art board orders, "art meetings" following that episode's overall art flow, "color direction meetings" between assigned color direction staff and myself based on color direction charts I write, and "photography meetings" with photography staff about screen processing. These happen once weekly without fail.

And furthermore, all-rushes & retake assignments happen weekly without fail. To complete and deliver one episode weekly, you must clear things one by one weekly. If this starts stalling for any reason, the ripple effects are quite large and returning to track becomes difficult.

With so much to do plus handling individual episode color direction beyond color design duties, my own work inevitably becomes late-night work. Since meetings

and various checks often happen late at night, it becomes late-night work tendency anyway, making dawn returns routine.

Originally a morning person, once entering TV work rhythm, I can't maintain morning routines. Forcing it eliminates sleep time. So recently I've completely given up - first train home → morning sleep. Well, when I can go home at night, I properly go home. Then get up again and commute to Mitaka via Chuo Line (laugh).

This is roughly my recent daily routine and current status. Such days will continue until year-end. Gradually settling as life rhythm. Around 4:30 AM when Mitaka Station's first up-train departs, it was completely bright with risen sun around summer solstice, but recently it's still dimly dark before sunrise. Definitely the latter half of this year. Just one more month until autumn equinox.

Making

Mawaru Penguin drum

like this - everyone please treat us favorably (laugh).

To be continued in Episode 170

(11.08.16)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 16: Once Upon a Time... (11) *GeGeGe no Kitaro: Yokai Daisenso

*

The other day, Ms. O from the records department (Toei Animation has this kind of position - like a script supervisor in live-action. Without these people, matching sound and image from editing onward becomes impossible - very important work) came to me saying:

"Hey, hey, look at this!"

What she handed me was a snapshot photo taken somewhere in the studio long ago. A snapshot from over ten years ago. And what was in it was me from when my hair was still short, before I started tying it back.

Man, ha ha ha ha (laughs).

The young folks who don't know how I looked back then couldn't tell it was me, and that transformation is quite amusing even to myself (laughs).

By the way, I actually applied for a passport at the Tokyo Metropolitan Government's passport office today. My current one expires in July. The photo in my current passport is from exactly 10 years ago, already with my hair tied back. But somehow you can tell from the somewhat unsettled hair that I hadn't been tying it back for very long. Over 10 years but less than 15? Well, something like that.

10 years from now, when my new passport expires and I apply again, I'll probably think "Ah, so this is how I looked 10 years ago..." (laughs).

Well then.

A theatrical work! *GeGeGe no Kitaro: Yokai Daisenso*.

The

GeGeGe no Kitaro

that began broadcasting in the fall of this year (1985). This was the third TV anime adaptation, with

Toda Keiko

voicing Kitaro,

Ikuzo Yoshi

singing the opening song, and the series where "

Yumeko-chan

" appears. This theatrical work was produced and released as one film in the "

Spring Toei Manga Festival

."

The TV series *Kitaro* had color direction handled by a great senior,

Sakamoto Yoko

, who worked on *Tongari Boshi no Memoru* and *Magical Taruruuto-kun*.

Usually the TV series person would also handle the theatrical version, but I think she was also handling another big work? So it came around to me - that's how I remember it...

The theatrical version had an impressive lineup: Director

Kasai Osamu

, Animation Director

Kanemori Yoshinori

, Art Director

Tsuchida Isamu

.

Hmm, I was thrown into such staff as a complete rookie (sweat). I remember being very nervous when I went to greet

Kasai-san

and

Tsuchida-san

. At that time, I think Kasai-san said "Let's make it a bit different from TV. We want to change the atmosphere from TV." Then I was given the storyboard to read, and indeed, it had a density quite different from TV. The running time was about 40 minutes.

The story involves Western yokai led by

Baird

arriving at the southern sea's isolated

Houkiboshi Island

with the appearance of

Halley's Comet

(!), and when a boy from that island asks for help, Kitaro and friends land on the island to wage a great yokai war.

Yes, "Yumeko-chan" doesn't appear (laughs).

At that time, Toei Doga had art directors decide almost everything color-related.

Not just art boards and background paintings, but character colors were also specified by art directors in principle. We'd paint color sample cels with specifications from art, then have character color meetings. There, directors, animation directors, art directors, producers, and others would finalize colors.

Starting with

Baird-sama

,

Dracula

,

Frankenstein

,

werewolf and wolves

, and the village boy

Akio

- basically all were

Tsuchida-san

's color designs.

We fine-tuned them with everyone's input. Ah, since I was just a complete rookie, I mostly just modified color samples according to instructions from Kasai-san and Tsuchida-san (bitter laugh).

However, while main character colors already existed from TV, given the director's earlier comment, I made color samples slightly more subdued than TV with stronger shadows based on my thinking.

And that was adopted as-is.

Based on this theatrical version's basic "colors," we had main episode meetings.

Art meetings had already finished, so this was just color direction meetings. "This beach has strong sunlight with fewer shadows, so high contrast" or "Kitaro here is near death, so make his skin color earth-toned please" - I desperately noted the director's instructions in the storyboard. Making colors meaningful for characters, having characters act through colors. Happy moments during meetings.

Now we routinely do "night colors for night scenes" - changing colors to match background time periods - but back then character colors were normally normal-based regardless of time, maybe just varying shadow color intensity.

The "collaborative works" I'd done were all basically normal characters too.

Now, main episode cuts finally came to me.

Theatrical works back then basically all came to us after being properly made into in-between animation domestically.

Man, that animation was good! The characters themselves were good, but the sharpness of movement was great! Just bundling in-between animation and going "para-la-la-la..." made me happy (laughs). The degree of character shadow amounts in each scene, properly calculated matching light sources (well, that's natural though (bitter laugh)) - I was excited about cel painting results.

Rocks, dirt clumps, construction site logs, breaking mansion roofs, water spouts rising to the sky, etc. - all background color matching was also color-directed by the art director in the style of that time.

Properly deciding cel details like that was truly art director work.

And that art was wonderful.

That's Tsuchida-san's artistic ability, that's theatrical work quality. My color-directed and painted cels would go on those backgrounds, be photographed, become rush film for viewing. Well, it's the same work as "collaborative" projects, but thinking "it's a movie!" made it even more exciting (laughs).

In the main episode, there's a scene where Kitaro and Akio fight Dracula and the werewolf in darkness.

I don't know whose animation (key animation) scene it was, but animation came up with normal + shadow having solid

BL (black)

shadows, plus lots of reflection light. At the time I still didn't understand animation well, and no matter how much I worried, I couldn't figure out what kind of screen it would be or what colors to use, so I took a whole bunch of those cuts to consult

with Tsuchida-san.

When shown them, Tsuchida-san also found it a bit hard to understand, and what remains strongly in my memory is him directly calling the responsible key animator for meetings.

Now I think it would have been easier to understand by looking at key animation rather than in-between animation. But back then, what came to finishing were cut bags containing only timesheets and in-between animation.

Thus, my first theatrical work *GeGeGe no Kitaro: Yokai Daisenso* was completed.

To write this, I brought this movie's video (I bought the commercial version as a memento back then) from my parents' house to watch.

Amazingly, the tape was beta - what a surprise (laughs). But since I have a working beta VCR at home too (explosion), I could watch it properly, and man, it's pretty well done. Interesting!

In the ending staff credits, my name appears with the job title "inspection."

This was because back then Toei Doga didn't have "color direction" notation - it was strictly cel delivery "inspection," that kind of era. As I mentioned earlier, this stemmed from the style where all "color"-related things were decided and specified by art (actually, our room is still noted as "inspection" in internal company notation even now (bitter laugh)).

Incidentally, among the finishing staff names is

Itasaka-san

, who handles color design for the 4th series and currently broadcasting *Kitaro*.

Ah, it's fate, right? >Itasaka-san (laughs)

##

■Continues to Episode 17

(07.05.29)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 170: Emergency Investigation! Are Directors Popular?

The days called intense heat and extreme heat have become distant, settling into quite bearable temperature days. Our house neighbors a park, and the cicadas' voices that had been noisily crying from sunrise to midnight have gradually decreased, replaced by gentle cricket and autumn insect voices.

Ah, summer is leaving.

Before summer came, my plans were to resume mountain hiking after several years, camp and eat barbecue at Kiso-Komagatake in midsummer, climb Mount Fuji this year! - such thoughts, but when summer actually came, intensely busy

Mawaru Penguin drum

days. Summer is ending without much opportunity for summer-like activities.

Mountain barbecue didn't happen, but I was fulfilled this summer. Being able to concentrate on beloved work so seamlessly, having

Mawaru Penguin drum

- a work I worked hard on with many colleagues - get off to a highly acclaimed start became this summer's greatest memory above all. 2011's 48-year-old summer is leaving, but when I look back someday, I have a feeling it will be an unforgettable summer.

Now, production is finally entering the latter half's second cour. Three more months - let's run!

Anyway.

Recently, young actor Nakao Akiyoshi appeared on a Sunday afternoon Fuji TV program, and I happened to watch, thinking "huh? This person resembles someone?" "Ah! That's right!

PreCure's

Otsuka-kun!" That's right. Director Otsuka Takashi closely resembles this Nakao Akiyoshi-kun. Well, a handsome man.

Tweeting about such things, the person himself got hooked - ah, Otsuka-kun's side (laugh). From "is Otsuka-kun popular?" the topic somehow became "are directors popular?"

"Eh? Directors are popular, right?" I said. "Eh? That's not true," said Otsuka-kun. "Look at me and Nagamine-san" (laugh). Well, setting aside Nagamine-kun

(explosion), I have an image that people with "director" titles are popular... Then Director Sato Jun'ichi said:

"My 30 years of physical surveys confirm no relationship between job type and popularity!"

Ugh! 30 years is heavy! (laugh) But Sato-san seems plenty popular to me?

The word "director" has an image of someone who judges various things, leads everyone, and bears responsibility as a solid existence. Some aura feeling, such special feeling. Well naturally, individual qualities are questioned, but people in "director" positions seem to have that human weight, that "ah, right!" quality that convinces everyone around them.

Well, don't you think the word "director" is cool? (laugh)

Looking around, our animation industry has truly many "directors" even within making one work.

Starting with "director" at the top (oh, there's also "general director"), animation director, art director, photography director, CG director or VFX director, sound director, music director, etc. Each section has respective "directors." Among those, wait? Our finishing department has no position called director. "Color design" (■■■■), "color direction" (■■■■), "inspection" - but not "director." ...Ah, I think I remember seeing "finishing director" credit somewhere before, but generally current production systems don't have "finishing director" credits.

Hmm, why is that?

For example, if it's art staff, finished backgrounds are final-checked by "art director" before passing to photography, right? Same with animation - rough animation only goes to in-betweening after "animation director" checks and approves. Photography staff also have finished rushes approved by "photography director" before editing. In other words, respective "directors" are positioned to manage and supervise the qualitative aspects of their section's products.

Our finishing section is composed of color design → color direction → coloring → finishing inspection flow, and usually coloring data passed to photography is ultimately checked by finishing inspection staff before being passed to photography.

Are "director" positions those who bundle everything together to become "director"? Thinking about it, does "finishing" not have "directors" because it's an assembly line system that asks final staff for checks? Or changing perspective, are finishing inspection staff closer to "directors"? Maybe, but that also feels somewhat different.

So what is our finishing section's "quality"? The absolutely important thing is properly fulfilling requirements as photography materials. Not just coloring data precision like size and color mistakes, but whether mask materials are properly complete - naturally important points. Regarding this, it's "coloring" and "finishing inspection," and also "color" problems. I think this part is "color design" and "color direction." Finishing "quality" consists of both.

Certainly "color design" is positioned at the beginning of finishing work flow and somewhat oversees the finishing section generally, but still feels different from "director" positions somehow. Even so, for works where I handle color design, I try to control from the front as much as possible.

I'm entrusted with selecting main color direction staff, and request color direction staff handle finishing inspection themselves. Rushes checks, retake assignments, and final retake processing are handled together with color direction staff. Working together as a small group like this makes communication smooth and enables sharing series-wide work recognition. Then "quality" can naturally be maintained.

If such creation methods are possible, I think "finishing director" is unnecessary for works I'm involved with (laugh).

Now, the "are directors popular?" problem. An important statement emerges here.

"Character designers seem popular!"

"Character design" is more popular than directors! Ah, I somehow understand... So are "directors who also do character design" strongest? There are quite a few such people, right? Among my acquaintances, maybe Oizaki Fumitoshi-san? How is it really? How about it, Oizaki-san!

...The truth of that matter is for another time (laugh).

To be continued in Episode 171

(11.08.31)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 171: Long Ago... 106 1995 Part 26

The Path to Power's

Overthought(?) Colors

Now September.

Typhoon troubles have settled, and Tokyo suddenly feels autumn-like. Outdoor sunshine looks like summer at first glance, but the passing wind is somehow autumn wind. Particularly morning return temperatures have dropped surprisingly. This requires careful health management. When it gets cool, fatigue hits all at once.

Mawaru Penguin Drum

, which started broadcasting in July, has finished 1/3 overall on air, the production site has rounded the third corner, and storyboard work has only a few remaining - we've come that far. Once broadcasting starts, time flows quickly! Though I've experienced this painfully every time I'm involved with TV works and understand it, I'm reminded again this time.

Hey Doraemon, don't you have a tool that secretly makes days 30 hours long?

If not that, how about a tool that secretly shifts all deadlines back by two days?

Well, such is my state of mind (bitter laugh).

Anyway.

Things from 1995 have become somewhat sporadic - theatrical

Dragon Ball: The Path to Power

story. After October's sudden hotel sequester meeting, work somehow progressed... though storyboards were nicely delayed, various setting work and first half animation proceeded. Incidentally, release was March next year. Essentially 3 months. Ah, dangerous, dangerous. Thinking such things, I'd experienced battlefields with Director Yamauchi many times, and main staff were familiar usual faces. So there was somehow a "it'll be fine" mood.

I finished theatrical

Sailor Moon SS

somehow and could enter full work at the end of November. Or rather, essentially after entering December. First, organizing setting-related matters.

As I wrote before, this

The Path to Power

was 90 minutes - a remake of

Dragon Ball's

very beginning plus original parts. Since TV series had already covered these stories years ago, various settings existed, but Animation Director Yamamuro-san naturally had greatly different artwork taste from old Maeda-san's characters, so everything from Goku and Bulma settings onward was newly drawn. So naturally all "colors" were new too. Work started with color settings for such story core parts.

Color construction for main characters like Goku, Bulma, Master Roshi, Oolong, Yamcha referenced original TV series and original manga colors, but overall balance came together with a solid, heavier atmosphere feeling. While creating colors, I thought about people who had continued going to theaters to watch theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

- hoping they could view this as an extension of that. I remember discussing this with Director Yamauchi and having similar thinking. So I built respective colors following the color flow from theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

series. Certainly the story had "return to origins" elements, but screen taste didn't need to return that far, I thought.

Or rather, artwork styles from years ago felt uncomfortable to our sensibilities then.

So while not forcing it, I gradually made minor adjustments to original colors. For example, normal section colors followed original colors, but I twisted shadow colors, deliberately setting different-toned shadow colors and trying to construct a color worldview where that would work. Like mixing purple into white object shadows instead of gray, or adding slightly mint-green to normal section whites. Adding something somewhere, struggling to bring it closer to theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

series atmosphere.

The Path to Power's

character and prop color design was completed like this.

Well, watching it again now after over ten years, it has a subtle atmosphere (bitter laugh). What is it? Somehow feels like old-fashioned struggling, making me

involuntarily bitter-laugh. Rather, the original colors look newer and more innovative. The original and original designs were truly amazing - I'm newly impressed.

To be continued in Episode 172

(11.09.07)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 172: "This Got Me Into the Industry!" Stories

Somehow, I'm sorry (sweat). What was supposed to be weekly serialization has become monthly serialization. I apologize. Moreover, this is another somewhat standalone column breaking the flow.

Mawaru Penguin Drum

, the culprit driving me to miss serialized manuscripts repeatedly, has finally entered the second cour, latter half. Production has only about two months remaining. Actually, I'm writing this while attending a certain episode's photography crunch - writing this on October 17th, so really just a few weeks left! Whoa! (sweat)

Even so, I'm having somewhat rare experiences these past months. Constantly incoming magazine copyright still work and feature article interview requests. I've never had works I was involved with covered this much in magazines or have stills and pin-ups featured so prominently. This is what it means for works to draw attention! I was newly surprised.

Anyway, Blu-ray and DVD sales finally begin at month's end. While progressing jacket work, main story broadcast also has turbulent developments and workplace work is hot. Two more months - I think I'll cause more trouble here, but please bear with me a bit longer. And I'll work hard!

Anyway.

In such busy but extremely enjoyable

Mawaru Penguin Drum

days, during a certain episode's crunch, I was chatting with a production staff member during a brief rushes waiting period. Amazingly about

Revolutionary Girl Utena

. Actually, she watched

Revolutionary Girl Utena

broadcasts during college and got hooked, which apparently motivated her to pursue animation work.

Come to think of it, I heard my junior color design colleague also got into this industry after watching

Utena

during junior college and getting hooked, and a certain director who worked with me on

The Tatami Galaxy

recently confessed that watching

Utena

motivated pursuing this industry. My, what a sinful work

Revolutionary Girl Utena

was! (laugh)

Working like this for a long time, occasionally... or recently quite frequently such stories (laugh). Chatting with young staff often develops into such stories.

"Tsujita-san, you participated in '■■■■'! I was watching! That's what made me want to pursue this industry!" - such developments.

I've long worked on many nationally broadcast works at Toei Animation, so quite nationwide, many people watched programs and works I was involved with. Moreover, many were child~teen targeted works, so maybe some people encountered them as children and thought "I want to do animation!" and pledged it in their hearts.

Even if not such personal critical hits from childhood, there are cases of encounters after growing up, like her

Utena

case earlier. Actually, such encounters after becoming somewhat adult probably have real influence.

Well, reflecting on myself, ah, I think

Space Battleship Yamato

is my biggest root.

TV animation we've been making is basically entertainment. Not art works or lofty educational programs. But still, hearing that someone was somehow influenced by works created with dedication and determined their path forward makes me think it was good to work hard.

Somehow, such things are emotional.

This

Mawaru Penguindrum

I'm working hard on now might also influence someone's future? Maybe years later, someone will say "I watched

Mawaru Penguindrum

, got hooked, and entered this industry..." (laugh).

To be continued in Episode 173

(11.10.18)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 173:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Complete! Watching the Final Episode in Theaters

Amazingly, just a few more days until this year ends! Everyone, it's been a while - Tsujita here. Due to main work being extremely busy, I ended up taking over a month break from serialization. Sorry.

That main work, TV series

Mawaru Penguindrum

, recently reached its final episode and concluded. Thanks to your favorable reception, I'm extremely happy. Well, including "I don't understand!" various reactions seem diverse, and it's quite fun looking around at impressions and analyses posted on the web.

Well, honestly when work started last autumn, I couldn't imagine such a final episode at all (probably the director couldn't either (laugh)). My goodness.

Anyway.

That

Mawaru Penguindrum

final episode, Episode 24, had an all-night event where we watched it on a Ikebukuro movie theater screen timed to the Kanto TV broadcast. Watching the final episode with about 400 lucky fans who won the fierce ticket battle. Connecting time with screenings of several previous episodes plus cast and director talk (laugh), screening the final episode in the theater perfectly timed to broadcast.

Watching

Mawaru Penguindrum

on theater's big screen was quite amazing. I was internally worried whether footage originally made for TV could withstand a theater's large screen, but it was completely unfounded worry. Magnificent. Just like a theatrical version! (laugh) I newly recognized how dense the screens we'd been creating were. Particularly the art. Hand-drawn backgrounds viewed on theater's big screen are wonderful. And photography's magnificence. Screens that carefully captured spatial depth and breadth while restraining excessive filter work were magnificently spectacular even on this theater screen.

Somehow, we could probably make a theatrical version with this feeling! I thought... Well, no such plans exist (laugh). But if I get chances to work on theatrical works somewhere again, I feel like this

Mawaru Penguindrum

experience could be fully utilized.

So my year was entirely

Mawaru Penguindrum

-colored. Last year was

The Tatami Galaxy's

year, and before that was

Strong World One Piece Film's

year. What works will I be involved with next year? I can't wait to find out!

To be continued in Episode 174

(11.12.27)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 174:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes Part 1

Happy New Year. I dropped manuscripts terribly last year - I apologize. That was all for

Mawaru Penguindrum

. Yes,

Mawaru Penguindrum

! Were you all watching?

Main broadcasting has ended, but Blu-ray and DVD are still coming! So...

Anyway.

Finally starting today!

Mawaru Penguindrum

color design notes. There must be people secretly waiting for this! ...I'd like to think so. Starting anyway.

Episode 1: The Bell of Fate Rings

Storyboard: Ikuhara Kunihiro, Direction: Nakamura Akiko, Color Direction (■■■■): Tsujita Kunio

First, Episode 1. Episode 1 is important anyway. We have to properly present "this is what we're doing!" first. Story, direction, animation too, but altogether showing "screen basics." This becomes Episode 1's most important point. For

Mawaru Penguindrum

, we considered the Takakura house living room and kitchen scenes as "screen basics."

The first art boards submitted were Episode 1's opening bed, Takakura house living room, and kitchen. The bed is also an important key scene, but more of a place to show imaginatively. The center of acting is naturally Takakura house daily acting. Firmly deciding and creating this, burning this visual balance into viewers' minds is important.

So

Mawaru Penguindrum's

main character colors were decided on this living room background board.

Director Ikuhara's order was "clear feeling." My image was the same direction - being careful not to become ambiguous by over-aiming or look dirty by lowering saturation. And the delivered art board's vividness and wonderful hand-drawn density feeling. "Good!" I began creating colors with good motivation.

Kanba and Shoma's hair colors - red and blue directions - were from the director. Since they were supposedly "twins," I tried creating "twin-ness" by matching and unifying eye colors. But actually at this point, though they were "brothers" and "siblings," there was "actually..." so I hoped for good misleading visuals and colors.

For Himari, I initially considered darker black-ish or dark brown hair with sickly pale skin, but the director said "more fragile feeling..." so hair became light, and we modified hair main lines to bright, light brown. Bright, fragile-feeling skin and hair, white-based blouse with vivid light blue skirt. This light blue - I thought slightly more subdued might be good, but the director demanded vividness "to the limit" for that balance. Light blue tends to develop intensely on HD screens, so quite nerve-wracking colors. And boots.

These boots were another struggle. Sheepskin-like boot image was immovable from the start, but basic main line colors made outline lines too strong for boot colors, creating "unbeautiful" balance. So ultimately, I decided to brighten boot main line colors too. Color tracing for hair (eyebrows) plus boot main lines. This is quite troublesome in coloring work. Certainly becomes difficult, but this good balance was non-negotiable. So I decided to go with this color tracing.

When general color balance was decided, "Tsujita-kun, a little consultation..." said Director Ikuhara. "Could we make the eye feeling more Hoshino-san-like?" This time, character concepts were requested from Hoshino Lily-san, and the consultation was whether we could put Hoshino-san's color illustration atmosphere into main story visuals. Hoshino-san's drawn eyes have dark pupils with deep, beautiful, sexy bleeding. I was conscious of that, but Nishii-san's animation character artwork details alone didn't work well. But adding more complex details and highlights to artwork itself might cause painful results if character animation wavered.

So what to do? Slightly tighter and darker than initially decided, plus one more processing. Using eye pupil colors, adding gradation brushes to eyes that gradually darken upward. We asked photography staff to add this. This was how I compiled it as a compromise. Uniformly adding this processing to main characters. Naturally, some cuts have additional ingenuity.

Characters were roughly decided like this.

Oh yes, penguins (laugh). Penguins are naturally that color (laugh). I tried making blackish-colored ones too, but they were lackluster. Long ago there was a Suntory commercial campaign called "Penguin's Bar" with penguins this blue. That color image seems imprinted on both me and Director Ikuhara (laugh). Incidentally, the blackish penguin color I tried making was later inherited by Esmeralda.

Like that, Episode 1 main story.

As written earlier, the episode presents "screen basics" of "this is what we're doing!" I thought it important to impress important visuals for stories developing over 2 cours (all 24 episodes) in the first episode. So Episode 1 basically allocated more "normal" colored scenes. Also, firmly showing important scenes (special coloring scenes) appearing throughout at key points. These two points were first important.

So basic "Takakura house living room," subway interiors, aquarium, souvenir shops were firmly shown in "normal colors." Conversely, hospital examination room's bluish scenes, scenes where Himari stops breathing, and morgue's strong evening scenes were also created with colors to remain strongly impressive. Anyway, screen tempo and contrast. I intended to avoid brightness changes and shadows by time of day in Episode 1 as much as possible, but naturally rain scenes had brightness adjustments matching backgrounds.

My series-wide design plan was to build relatively natural-looking color design for the first half cour, then deploy various tricky color usage from when the story begins moving significantly in the middle. It's 2 cours after all. First, creating screen balance that lets stories smoothly enter viewers was essential.

Well, Episode 1 was exciting anyway. Just enjoyable. How will we proceed? And ah, so this is how the animation becomes! Color direction input and coloring completion inspection work were endlessly fun. Oh yes, as Episode 1's small detail, the commuter pass holder delivered to #2 - that color is my actually used commuter pass holder (laugh). I was commuting to Mitaka's Brain's Base with that pass holder and Suica commuter pass (laugh). When you do color direction yourself, such fun is possible - enjoyable. Self-satisfaction though (laugh).

Even so, those two boys... (bitter laugh). Those were colors decided in the moment - if I'd known from the start, I would have decided more carefully (bitter laugh).

According to records, this Episode 1's art meeting was held at the end of November the year before last (2010). Broadcast start was next summer, so about half a year before. But actually at this point, storyboards weren't completed. Well, were they tentatively done? Either way, we couldn't discuss some parts. Yes, that bank scene where Princess of Crystal appears.

To be continued in Episode 175
(12.01.10)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 175:

Mawaru Penguin Drum

Color Design Notes Part 2

I'm in Kyushu. Research and location hunting for a certain new work. Nagasaki, Kumamoto, and today Kagoshima. So this manuscript is being finished at a certain location in front of Kagoshima Station while getting coffee refills.

For us Tokyo people, Kyushu has a somewhat tropical image, but unlike Okinawa, Kyushu's latitude isn't actually that different from Tokyo. So well, it's normally cold. We were suddenly hit by snow at Aso! (laugh)

A complete silver world! The scenery was already Hokkaido (laugh).

Yesterday's weather was somewhat disappointing like that, but this morning in Kagoshima is clear with good weather forecast. Today's another full day of hard research work.

Anyway.

Bank scene "Crystal World" actually started work after the new year.

What took time first was Himari's queen outfit, commonly called "Princess of Crystal" costume. Character concepts themselves were received from Hoshino Lily-san, and the famous "penguin hat" was approved early with animation progressing, but the problem was this "queen" outfit's colors.

Standing pose wearing that "penguin hat." The image of black base with clear red was common to Director Ikuhara and me, but when actually coloring along those lines, wait? It resembles something (sweat).

"Ah, Doronjo-sama! (explosion)"

From there, endless worry spiral (laugh). Adding highlight animation to suits and skirts, devising muffler colors and paint divisions. But with black and red as base, that image inevitably remains. So ultimately "well, fine" (laugh).

We added fluffy volume feeling by making all frilly designs from sleeves and skirts front to back into color tracing finishing (■■■■■■■■), somehow pulling it together.

Bank scenes are hybrids of normal animation cuts and 3D. Parts where characters like "Princess" appear and act are animation, but "baskets" containing teddy bears and teddy bears (white ones) in several cuts are 3DCG. Teddy bears were handled by Nakamura Akiko-san, "rocket," "pencil sharpener," and "basket" designs by

Shibata Katsunori-kun. I considered colors for designs created in animation (basic color concepts for both black and white teddy bears from Akiko-san) for coloring. Based on that, Machida Masaya-san handled 3D modeling and movement. I added further color corrections to those demos.

From the director, there was only an image meeting of "dark space, then after teddy bears and Princess appear, space becomes whitish space" - so I'd create specific color samples first.

Passing ticket gates, rushing through space(?) to see the workplace nickname "Himari's star." Rockets launching from this, racing through dark space, I thought should be whitish. Somewhat Apollo spacecraft image.

"Himari's star" - rotating frame is animation, central light rays are materials from art staff. Stars flying toward the front have only movement created in animation.

"Pencil sharpeners" and "baskets" after breaking through dark space into pure white space, I thought should go with clear pink. Pink + metallic gimmick parts are gold, with emerald green allocated to glass accordingly. Then white teddy bears burst out boom! bang! from within.

First, 3D for these "pencil sharpeners" and "baskets" took shape. Then other cuts, overall work.

After teddy bear appearances, I wanted to firmly show colors for Princess and "dialogue" partner characters (#1: Kanba & Shoma). So I thought we could go with basic "normal" color direction as-is, but background space decisions were delayed, so I was uncertain about final approaches until the end.

Background space would use "gear"-shaped things and "monogram icons" and "route maps" created by Osakabe-san to make infinite image space, but assembly was to be requested from photography staff. Since I would ultimately do color adjustment and decisions for completed space, we were waiting for photography staff.

Bank scenes and Episode 1 excluding opening and ending were almost completed in early May. Bank scenes had delayed animation, with full work becoming May and June. Bank scene photography was requested from Graphinica, and the first photography meeting was held amazingly one month before broadcast - quite a tightrope walk. Director, Akiko-san, Yamasaki-san, and I visited Graphinica for meetings. Trying to convey images somehow, the director stood up with gestures for quite a long meeting.

Several days after meetings, additional 3D-related parts began coming up from Graphinica's 3D team. "Stairs" from teddy bear crotch to crotch, etc. I colored rough materials and returned them to the 3D team. These were also pink-based naturally. Rockets worked on in animation also finished coloring, passing

everything to photography staff. Putting materials into photography like this, we waited for photography completion.

Two weeks after the first meeting, bank scene rushes came up and we returned to Graphinica. The completed rushes shown completely amazed the director and all of us! Magnificent! Bank scenes were assembled and created at scales many times what we'd envisioned, finished into glittering beautiful footage.

Movement dummy materials had seven-colored starlight and afterimages applied, rocket-rushing space had art material snow and ice crystals. And crystal space had Osakabe-san's icons and route maps moving beautifully. Magnificent screens with no room for me to adjust color tone. An explosion of Graphinica's team power and Photography Director Ogiwara Takeo's sensibility.

We requested additional instructions and corrections for just a few points, with recheck several days later. On the way back in the elevator, Director Ikuhara's momentarily happy smile saying "well, this might work. It might be a hit (laugh)" was impressive.

However, we still had big challenges remaining. Yes, the opening and ending problems remained.

To be continued in Episode 176

(12.01.17)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 176:

Mawaru Penguindrum

(■■■■■■■■■■) Color Design Notes - Part 3

Last week, I was caught in unexpected snow in Kyushu's Mount Aso, and this week it snowed in Tokyo! Man, snow! For a Tokyo native like me, this snow just makes me unreservedly happy. Sure, there are concerns about frozen roads the next morning and impacts on transportation, but well, that's that. I mean, it's an event that happens maybe once or twice a winter! (laugh) Let's just enjoy it with a big heart!

But January is already ending. Next week is the start of spring. Will Tokyo get more snow this winter? I'm having such irresponsible fantasies about maybe getting another snowfall that continues all day long - and I'm a 49-year-old guy thinking this! (laugh)

Now then.

Opening: Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiko (■■■■■) & Furukawa Tomohiro (■■■■■),
Direction/Ikuhara Kunihiko

Ending: Storyboard & Direction/Nakamura Akiko (■■■■■)

According to my records, Episode 1 reached temporary completion (excluding the BANK scene "Crystal World") right after Golden Week in May. Then "Crystal World" was completed and Episode 1 was finished at the end of June. ...However, at this point, the opening and ending weren't completed yet. So the advance screening held in Yokohama on July 3rd, just before broadcast began, didn't have the opening and ending attached - that was the situation.

Truth be told, the opening and ending music reached us production staff in early June. Temporary versions had been delivered earlier, but with temporary tracks the arrangements differ from the actual ones, and even the song lengths themselves are different. Since openings and endings switch cuts based on the timing of the instruments used, we can't make storyboard decisions without the actual songs. Also, depending on the arrangement, the mood of the song can be greatly affected, so we simply couldn't move forward with work until the actual songs arrived.

In any case, it was super rushed work with one month until broadcast. And in parallel, "Crystal World" was also super rushed. Naturally, work on other episodes was also proceeding steadily at a pace of one episode per week. Oh, and

promotional work like posters and licensing deals were coming in too... It was such a hellish, stomach-churning June.

Now, the opening and ending. About three weeks from storyboard completion to video completion.

First, the ending. Storyboard, direction, and even all the animation were handled by Nakamura Akiko. It was just wonderful! From the planning meeting through the work process, I was grinning the whole time (laugh). Actually, I'm a huge fan of Akiko's artwork! I love her delicate yet somewhat realistic bone structure and the subtly erotic lines that somehow drift through her work. I also love watching Akiko quickly and vigorously drawing, and I often found myself staring at her working... Well, since it was artwork that Akiko had finished all the way to animation, naturally I was in charge of all the coloring (laugh).

Sanzigen handled the photography for the opening and ending. For the ending's red background, the photography team created it in advance, and we designed the character colors - or rather, the screen's aesthetic - to match it. Basically, we wanted it to look normal, but decided to bring everything together within the range of "red~pink~brown." So we made the main lines of the appearing character "Triple H" brown to blend with the background, aiming for a slightly sepia-like color tone. This was also aimed at matching the somewhat languid feel of the ending song.

Additionally, I thought about adding "bleeding" to the main lines. Besides creating harmony with the background, I wanted to add the aesthetic of the color illustrations drawn by character designer Hoshino Lily (■■■■■■). Technically, we made two copies of the main line parts, changed the blur levels on each, and overlaid them using hard light layer blending mode. When I showed the image assembled this way to Akiko for checking, it was approved in one shot (laugh). The photography team skillfully utilized this.

The opening direction was by Director Ikuhara. Actually, I don't remember having a proper meeting about this opening (laugh). The only comprehensive meeting we had was maybe the photography meeting? In terms of color direction, it was probably just a "right!" kind of feeling with the director, and we just had casual standing conversations, talking about each cut. I went ahead and did color direction on the incoming rough animation without hesitation.

Anyway, the opening was like a preface saying "This is the kind of story that's about to begin!" - a microcosm of the entire story, or highlight scenes, so to speak - meaningful cuts piled up like that. The composition was to show this against a basically pure white background. So the characters were basically "normal" coloring. That part was a bit easier (laugh).

Though it was a basically pure white background, this wasn't just plain white - Osakabe's designed icons were used wallpaper-style. And the director's plan was

to move those icons around in various ways. The director and photography team worked together ahead of the animation to create lively icon performances. Then the animation followed after that.

The storyboard showed a certain degree of planning, but when we actually tried to do it exactly as planned, the cut length was too short for the icon movements we wanted, or when we forced everything in it became too fast to understand - we had test movies shot many times, changing direction as needed each time, and prepared each piece step by step.

On the night of July 3rd, the day of the advance screening, we first finalized the ending. Akiko, myself, and the Sanzigen team worked intensively, watching video previews of the assembled cuts while making final adjustments. Screen color balance, overlap duration length, depth of screen processing, and so on - everyone brainstormed ideas together to finalize everything. With this, the ending was complete.

And the next night, it was time for the opening's final decision-making, with Director Ikuhara and myself visiting Sanzigen again. We had already finished rush checks on most cuts by the previous day and given them the OK, but there were a few cuts we absolutely wanted to work on - final decisions and re-shooting.

Sanzigen's 2D photography section had just been established. Actually, this Mawaru Penguin drum

opening and ending was their first job. Yamada and Uezono were veterans who had survived countless battlefields. But with consecutive days and nights of intensive work, they were clearly showing fatigue. Even so, they raised their energy as if this was the crucial moment and were waiting for us.

The director and the two photography staff members checked previews one by one.

The opening's biggest concern was the main title cut. In After Effects, we changed the size, trajectory, and timing of the materials (character coloring data) and added various processes on top. First the director would propose changes, then Yamada from photography would add modifications. Looking at that, the director would ask "How's this?" seeking opinions from myself and Yamada, then add modifications based on those opinions. Then the director would have further ideas: "Could we do something like this?" and we'd look at that again and add everyone's opinions. Right up to this point when we had to complete and deliver everything by the morning of that day - such a session (laugh). Since every cut became more refined each time we watched the preview, participating in that serious battle was incredibly enjoyable.

Then, "Argh!" Director Ikuhara suddenly cried out. One of the monogram icons used in the background had an error. Or rather, something that was supposed to be treated as a dummy had been used for the actual version due to a communication mistake. We hurriedly called the studio to find the correct one, but apparently the materials usable for this opening had been missed. Oh no! What should we do? But without hesitation or delay, the director and I tried to contact designer Osakabe. It was late at night... or rather, dawn. Normally he'd be sleeping at that hour, but since Osakabe had just tweeted on Twitter, we thought maybe, just maybe...

So we successfully contacted Osakabe, and he quickly finished and sent us the icon. That icon was the subway "TSM (Tokyo Sky Metro)" icon. This was actually a pretty important icon representing a certain fact that would be revealed in Episode 13. In this way, the opening was scattered with all sorts of "hidden information."

Oh yes, after the broadcast started, there was talk on the internet about the multiple "hands" appearing in the opening - someone captured RGB values from broadcast screen captures and compared them to determine "this is so-and-so's hand," which surprised me and made me laugh. Wow, that's really today's digital terrestrial and current viewers, I was impressed. Well, it is correct (laugh), but you can only do that because it's digital terrestrial - with analog it wouldn't have been so clear, and I thought, so people care about these details! It gave me new recognition of fan psychology. Well, this wasn't exactly hidden.

So we managed to complete the TSM icon replacement. After taking breaks, work continued further, and all cuts received OK at past 5 AM. The director moved directly to the video editing studio. After adding telops to the opening and ending,

Mawaru Penguin drum

Episode 1 was truly complete.

And two days later, late at night, starting with the Kansai region, the actual broadcast of

Mawaru Penguin drum

began. Thus we stood at the new starting point of the intense, harsh battle that would continue for the next six months.

Continued in Episode 177

(12.01.24)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 177:

Mawaru Penguinindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 4

Various productions are moving toward spring at each company, and even someone like me has been invited to work on several April-start projects. One of them was announced the other day:

Saint Seiya Omega

(■■■■■Ω). It's a completely new original TV series.

Actually, when rumors of "doing Saint Seiya" were floating around last year, it felt like someone else's business, but surprisingly the offer came to me, and honestly I was shocked. Even so, if it had been a remake I was thinking of declining, but since it's a new story - and original at that - I decided I wanted to help out.

Even so, everyone's new staff! Incredibly, I'm the only staff member remaining from the original series! (laugh)

And it's tough (laugh). After all, it airs in April! Ah, there's no time...

But anyway, I'll do my best! Please support us!

Now then.

Episode 2: Dangerous Survival Strategy

Storyboard & Direction/Yamazaki Mitsue (■■■■■), Color Direction/Otsuka Natsuko (■■■■■)

Episode 3: And Then Eat Me Magnificently...

Storyboard & Direction/Shibata Katsunori (■■■■■), Color Direction/Akimoto Yuki (■■■■■)

With Princess of the Crystal's descent providing the "Penguinindrum" clue, the Takakura siblings begin pursuing Oginome Ringo (■■■■■). Remotely controlling the penguins, they proceed with tailing Ringo and investigating her personal life, but Ringo actually makes contact with the Takakura siblings' homeroom teacher, Tabuki (■■). Moreover, she goes under the floor of the apartment room where Tabuki lives. It's revealed that Ringo is Tabuki's stalker. Such was Episode 2.

The Takakura brothers infiltrate the Oginome house while Ringo is away. But Ringo returns home unexpectedly early. Every 20th of the month is curry day, so

Ringo makes curry and visits Tabuki's room, but there's a beautiful woman there making curry and waiting for Tabuki to return. Ringo switches her curry for the pot, but on the way home, through an unfortunate accident, she gets covered head-to-toe with a pot full of curry. And when the Takakura brothers return home, there's Ringo sitting at the dinner table, having been helped by Himari (■■■). Such was Episode 3.

Rewinding time to February 2011. Work on Episode 2 began, considerably behind the original schedule. According to records, the art meeting for Episode 2 was in early February. Originally we planned to create a "reserve" of 8 episodes by broadcast start... but in reality it was half that, 4 episodes.

Episodes 2 and 3 were still in the period when we were building up the initial story settings in parallel.

First, the school uniforms. In the main story, Kanba (■■■) and Shoma (■■■) are often in school uniforms, but the design of those uniforms went through quite a winding path to decision.

The chest emblem and such were in Hoshino's character designs from the beginning, but in the initial design there was no red line division on the collar, and it was a blazer with a relatively ordinary silhouette. We were also exploring the animation shading for the blazer itself - whether to do normal/shadow animation or highlight/normal. Since the blazer color itself would be blackish, we concluded that adding shadows in animation wouldn't be very effective, so we decided on highlight animation with no shadows. Then further changes during main production work. Initially we added highlight color divisions to the red lines too, but it became "kind of noisy," so during Episode 2's main production work it was changed.

What was quite troublesome when deciding the blazer color was the problem of the character main line (outline) colors. In

Mawaru Penguin Drum

, we worked with basic main line colors of RGB: 33.33.36. Roughly black, or rather dark gray. Incidentally, the black (BL) during coloring was set to RGB: 8.8.8. Conversely, the eye white color was RGB: 240.240.240. Actually, long ago during my Toei era, I was the one who set Toei productions' main line color to RGB: 33.24.32 charcoal gray (it's still used now).

Pretty Cure

and such should be using it too), and initially I was thinking of using that main line color for

Mawaru Penguin Drum

too. However, while it had good compatibility with Kanba's hair, it was somewhat off with Shoma's blue hair, or was too strong for the balance against Himari and Ringo's skin tones - various things started bothering me, so after consideration I set it to 33.33.36.

This main line color is actually in the somewhat bright category for this type of anime's main line colors. Looking at other works, there are some with 3.3.3 which is surprising... So in terms of area ratio it tends to appear whitish and float. But I deliberately went through with this density for the sake of compatibility with skin tones. And compatibility with the blazer paint colors. Not too buried, not too assertive - I think it achieved a good balance. Of course, matching with background art is also important. I think this problem also settled into a very good balance.

Oh yes, about the uniforms. Making the pants red was an idea Director Ikuhara had proposed from quite early on, and that direction was fine, but Director Ikuhara wanted to make the red saturation of those pants extremely high, and ultimately I put a stop to it saying "That's going too far!" and we settled on the current balance.

Speaking of pants, about the color design of Kanba and Shoma's casual clothes - Kanba's casual pants somehow had a colored jeans image. And on the day I was creating that color, what Director Ikuhara wore to the studio was exactly that color of Kanba's casual pants. "I'll take it!" so we used it as is (laugh). When I revealed this during color checking, the director didn't seem to mind (laugh). So Kanba's pants = the director's casual wear.

I remember Ringo's sailor uniform being difficult. Honestly, no matter what color you bring, someone somewhere has definitely done it. There's a destiny that sailor uniforms will inevitably resemble something. So Ringo's green - when we were stuck on the decision, either Director Ikuhara or Nishii gave the hint "How about green?" and it came together like that. Initially we were trying light blue and such. But that bright green was a big hit. It had such a green apple feel and became a good color that defined her impression.

When Ringo's sailor uniform was decided, I immediately had an image for her two classmates in Episode 2. I had decided from the start that Yukina (■■■) would be the gross face type, and when I actually showed everyone, it was highly praised. It's just regrettable that she had few appearance scenes (laugh).

Now Episode 2. And Episode 3.

For both episodes, without doing anything particularly special, we strived to be ordinary, carefully doing scene-by-scene color design matching the dramatic time progression and backgrounds. As I wrote during Episode 1, the series-wide design plan was to build up color design that would make the screen look as natural as possible until the middle part when the story would move significantly, so I have the

impression we made it quite matter-of-factly. Particularly for Episode 2, following that impactful Episode 1, you want to do something, but I considered it important to deliberately take time to create and compile it "normally." Of course, the story itself was interesting from the start with that energy. So basically, we carefully built up special coloring matched to the art for each scene. Not just scene by scene, but in some cases we subtly changed things cut by cut. I didn't think I was being that detailed myself...

Episode 3's climax was definitely that evening scene and curry (laugh). That thick orange evening scene had an order to "make it feel like

Fist of the North Star

!" so both the art and coloring aimed exactly for that feel. However, that energy would be impossible for Himari's side (laugh), so the point was how we could make that transition.

Episode 2's color direction was handled by Otsuka Natsuko. Following my previous work

The Tatami Galaxy

(■■■■■■■■■■), she participated in this work too as color director. Episode 3 was Akimoto Yuki. She also participated following

The Tatami Galaxy

. For me, it's the best lineup. With me added, we planned to proceed with

Mawaru Penguindrum

in a basic three-person color direction system. This was this work's "color team." Due to two gross production episodes coming in, we ultimately added two more color directors, but we operated with this small elite team throughout.

"Operating with as few staff as possible while maintaining precision" is actually an important point for TV series, especially continuous ones.

The advantage of few members is first that content explanation is easy (laugh). With new color directors every time, you have to explain the work content each time, plus processing and prohibition explanations - it's quite troublesome, and there are often omissions. Next, your assigned episode count increases, allowing you to concentrate on content. This time too, everyone looked at storyboards for episodes other than their assigned ones, becoming thoroughly familiar with the content flow. If this becomes every other episode continuously, it becomes exhausting in today's TV production short-term battle schedules. Having them participate with such concentration means they can hold challenges for the next episodes in their minds, thinking about various things beyond what I'm considering

to create colors, which I think is a good method in that respect too.

And above all, they thoroughly understand my methods (laugh). This is important, and especially for works with such quirks, having members who understand my tendencies is extremely grateful.

Now, during such Episodes 2 and 3. The art meeting for Episode 3 that began in the morning had ended, and we were having a late lunch when it happened. The Great East Japan Earthquake. March 11th. From that day, our production site would also be greatly affected.

Continued in Episode 178

(12.02.08)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 178:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 5: 3.11 At That Moment...

Drift ice seems to be coming to the northern sea, the Sea of Okhotsk coast, again this year.

Drift ice - this is amazing! I've been to Abashiri around this time three times so far to see the drift ice. The beautiful whiteness that completely fills the sea, the overwhelming mass beauty of ice that crashes against the shore and locks everything away. I really want everyone to see it at least once. Writing this, ah, I want to manage to go this year somehow. How many years has it been since last time? I keep narrowly missing the chance to go every year.

And the busier I get, the more I want to go! (←apparently escapist behavior)

Now, how is it really? Where's the schedule gap where I could actually go? (sweat)

Now then.

March 11th, 2:46 PM. Episode 3's art meeting had ended and I was having a late lunch at a French restaurant near the studio. Just as I finished eating and was chatting with the owner, it happened. A slow, long tremor began and gradually the amplitude grew larger. Wine glasses sliding off and shattering, wine bottles falling from shelves and breaking. Following the owner's instructions, I went out to the street and saw telephone poles swaying back and forth in an unbelievable way. The large amplitude that wasn't a direct hit made me immediately predict an epicenter off Chiba or Ibaraki. Or perhaps Tohoku? While the shaking continued, I checked information from Twitter on my iPhone. Tohoku offshore epicenter, Tokyo seismic intensity 5-strong (later corrected to 5-weak). Born and raised in Tokyo for nearly 48 years, it was the first earthquake of this scale I'd ever experienced.

When the major shaking subsided, I hurried back to the studio. What I was most worried about was my equipment. Would my EIZO 24-inch monitor COLOREDGE, my business tool, have fallen over? That was my primary concern. The staff room was on the 4th floor of the building. Since this floor had unpleasantly swayed greatly even during relatively small earthquakes before, I was especially worried about damage. Obviously the elevator was impossible right after the earthquake. I used the stairs to the 4th floor. As expected, the staff room was in quite a state. While calming down a northeastern production staff girl who was panicking because "I can't reach my family by phone," I looked around the staff room and what clearly remains in my memory is how the color boxes stacked on the

animation desks had fallen to the floor so cleanly and beautifully that visibility had greatly improved. Staff members picking up and organizing rough animation, timesheets, and setting copies scattered on the floor. Since it swayed roughly north-south, desks positioned facing north or south had their shelves catastrophically fallen. Director Ikuhara's, Assistant Director Yamazaki's, and Director Kaneko's desks were all positioned facing north and were in complete chaos. Incidentally, at that time Director Ikuhara was in the middle of a "script reading" with scriptwriter Igami and Assistant Director Yamazaki at a restaurant called "Bashamichi" in front of the station.

Fortunately, my desk area and equipment had no problems at all. I immediately gathered information on the internet, played NHK broadcast from the computer's external radio, and emailed my family to confirm safety. Then another big aftershock hit. I evacuated from the room with the production producer and others, and when it subsided we returned to the room. Then I couldn't believe the words I heard from the radio: "A 10-meter high tsunami..." What? And on the TV screen at Goto Keiji's desk were images of a town being swept away by muddy torrents...

For several days after that, production work continued sporadically at the site, but there was also an order from the production producer to "please work from home as much as possible for the time being," so main staff members worked primarily from home, only coming to the studio for meetings. I similarly worked primarily from home. But honestly, work was impossible to focus on, and I was completely affected deep in my heart by the disastrous images that were truly flooding us every day. I thought that was seriously dangerous. The images unknowingly penetrated deep into the heart and eroded one's feelings. As someone positioned at the edge of the video industry, I deeply impressed upon myself that I must be careful about such situations in various ways.

In any case, I was completely affected. The truth is that my desire to work or create anime was completely taken away. Somehow, when confronted with such real images, I even came to doubt creating fictional stories and videos, and for quite a while after I completely stopped wanting to watch movies. But this is dangerous! Anyway, back to daily life. If asked what I can do, it's only making anime. Anyway, continuing to work day by day as usual, one thing at a time. That's all I can do, and I convinced myself that doing so would surely be the most helpful thing for the world.

After things settled down somewhat, I thought about various things, and realized that if this had been the old days with paint work, it would have been a terrible situation. Paint bottles would probably have broken and scattered, with paint flowing out everywhere... Just thinking about it gives me chills. And I remembered something from about 20 years ago. There was a finishing company called Suzuki Animation Planning in Chiba that handled many Toei Animation (■■■■) works like

the TV series

Fist of the North Star

, and they were hit by a somewhat large earthquake, the storage shelves for large paint bottles collapsed, and large quantities of cel paint bottles broke causing major damage. But nowadays everything requires electricity. Without electricity you can't use computers, without electricity you can't view a single image. This power problem would deal us another blow.

So while I went to the Mitaka studio pinpoint-style when there were meetings or checks to attend, then came the further trial of "planned blackouts." My home area of Nakano was in a blackout-exempt district, but the studio was firmly designated as a planned blackout target area. So inevitably daytime operating hours were restricted, and we generally shifted to nighttime work. But actually, despite being in a planned blackout area, the studio apparently never actually had a blackout, and we were irritated by the poor response from TEPCO and the government during those days.

Even so, I was glad we weren't involved in a work that was broadcasting. I heard that due to news programming, some broadcasts were postponed or suspended, and some works even needed content revisions, plus these planned blackouts. Some staff apparently had trouble even commuting, and whether revising or creating anew, it was quite a difficult period. While

Mawaru Penguindrum

was said to have no schedule, broadcast was still 4 months away, so by then things would probably be settled in various ways, we thought. However, our

Mawaru Penguindrum

was scheduled to debut at major March anime events, but ultimately all of those were canceled, and I honestly felt a bit anxious about the future.

In the end, throughout March after March 11th, there were 2-3 art board checks, 1 character color check, 1 CG meeting, and direction meetings for 2 episodes. That was everything.

Such was March 2011.

Continued in Episode 179

(12.02.14)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 179:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 6

This month I've been interviewed in various places about

Mawaru Penguindrum

and

Saint Seiya

, doing interviews several times. Well, I apparently have a basically talkative disposition, so I end up speaking enthusiastically with abundant service spirit. Good grief (laugh).

When I was younger I was trying to be cool and reserved, wanting to show my character and such, but lately I don't think about such things (laugh). Now it's like a stance of "if everyone's happy, I'll do whatever I can" (laugh).

Well, this column has become like that too (laugh).

Though I'm often delayed due to being pressed by busyness, I'm thinking of working hard to write vigorously.

Now then.

Episode 4: The Falling Princess

Storyboard & Direction/Kaneko Shingo (■■■■■), Color Direction/Tsujita Kunio

Ringo continues stalking, and today she's invited by Tabuki to go bird watching in the park. Shoma follows along. But with the appearance of a skunk and crows devouring their lunch, Ringo becomes frustrated that she can't create the developments written in her diary. Is this the Penguindrum? Shoma steals a look at such a diary. Then Tokikago Yuri (■■■■■) appears. Learning that Yuri is Tabuki's fiancée, heartbroken Ringo takes the final measure and goes into the pond. It was Shoma who saved the drowning Ringo, but Ringo thinks she was able to kiss Tabuki as desired. Meanwhile, at Akasaka-mitsuke Station, Kuho Asami (■■■■■■■) was pushed down an escalator by someone. Such was Episode 4.

The general flow of production meetings for

Mawaru Penguindrum

was like this: First the script would come up and storyboard work would begin. Through one-on-one "storyboard camps" between the storyboard person and Director Ikuhara, the storyboard would be completed. After storyboard completion, immediately following would be the "direction meeting." Here, centered on Director Ikuhara with that episode's directing staff, Chief Director Nakamura Akiko, Assistant Director Yamazaki Mitsue, and myself (with animation director and photography director participating as needed), we would confirm scene by scene what kind of screen to make, or whether the storyboard showed this kind of performance but was this really okay? - confirming methods and such. There was always active opinion exchange here, and each episode's policy was decided almost entirely in this meeting. In this meeting we'd decide which scenes needed art board orders, determine cuts to prioritize for layout submission, and sometimes additional character settings would be ordered.

After this "direction meeting," individual animation meetings with the key animators. Then when priority layouts came up, "art board meetings." Art directors Akiyama and Nakamura Chieko, the episode's directing staff, Yamazaki, Akiko, and myself. Here we'd order art boards. We'd also meet about art settings for future episodes. Then about a week later, "art meetings." Meetings about the actual art for individual scenes and cuts of the story. The episode's directing staff, Yamazaki, Akiko, the two art directors and assigned art staff, and myself and that episode's assigned color director.

When art boards came up, everyone including the director would check them. When boards got OK, I'd place characters on them to design scene-by-scene coloring, get OK from the directing staff, Yamazaki, and Akiko, then I'd write the color direction schedule, and based on that have "color direction meetings" with the color director. And after that, "photography meetings." Photography director (from Episode 7 onward, 3D and special effects staff also participated), episode directing staff, Yamazaki, Akiko, and myself participated.

Having completed all these meetings, rushes would come up, then editing, voice recording... and so on.

I participated in meetings across the broad range from storyboard completion to photography meetings like this. I was allowed to participate quite actively in screen creation by expressing opinions. I don't actually know very well how other color designers work, but generally my area of responsibility this time was "overall screen." By participating from the earliest processes as much as possible, I could see the whole picture even more, and many of my ideas were reflected.

So, Episode 4.

"That fluttering thing they did in that

Patlabor

short

Mini-Pat

- something like that," said Director Kaneko. This was during the direction meeting. Those fluttering puppet shows where you draw front and back pictures on paper, attach them to chopsticks, and move them by hand under the stage. We were going to do something like that in the main story during Ringo's fantasy scene. The storyboard was already drawn that way. Of course, without the chopsticks, but the animation would be like so-called "gen-satsu" (shooting only rough animation), putting white borders around characters to create a "drawn on paper feel," and having photography move it fluttering and spinning without using in-betweens. We decided to add drop shadows on the background to create a cheap stage-like feel. This would be easy for animation and coloring, but photography would definitely be tough. So I think we had photography director Oyama for Episode 4 participate in this direction meeting to get his opinion. Oyama hesitated for a moment but said "Well, I'll try!"

This seemed like it would create quite an atmosphere, but the problem was the background. What to do with the art? We thought it would be better if it had a different atmosphere from normal background space. To make it look puppet show-like and stage-like, we consulted with the art team. We had the background drawn with a stage backdrop-style feel in mind, and additionally had paper-like texture added to the backgrounds. This differentiated it from normal background space. But we still wanted one more something, so we decided to add a "frame" to the entire fantasy scene. Akiko designed and drew this, and I colored it for the final decision.

Thus, the world of "Ringo's fantasy scene" was completed with white-bordered fluttering animation + backdrop-style background art + drop shadow photography processing and movement + frame. There was just one problem. This fantasy scene starts from inside a subway car. This subway was entirely assembled in 3D, so it didn't seem like we'd have much freedom. But if we made all the subway backgrounds for the fantasy scene hand-drawn, it would be a bit too different. The subway should maintain that precise 3D feel, said Director Ikuhara. So then, for now, shall we change the car interior color - including the outlines of the 3DBG (we conveniently call 3D modeled backgrounds this) - and change the color completely? I tried changing it to pink outlines and an overall pink tone, but hmm, it was somehow unsatisfactory. It didn't look very changed. So I consulted with the art team, and they created a sample with floral pattern texture applied to the car's walls and floor. "Oh! That might work!" and everyone immediately gave it the OK. When I checked with photography they said "We can probably manage it somehow," and that "floral fantasy subway" was born.

However, this caused trouble later. Actually, that floral subway took an incredible amount of rendering time during photography. We had imagined this to some extent, but it took far longer than we'd imagined, so we had to extend the master schedule. But fortunately it was still May before broadcast began, so we managed, and among us it secretly became "subways require caution!" Looking back now, I'm really glad this wasn't during the difficult later period (laugh). Well, subway aside, I hadn't even imagined at this time that this fluttering direction would power up even further and appear again (laugh).

Even so, that skunk with the "KIGA" pattern. Why the "KIGA" pattern? Even I don't know the reason (laugh). It was quite a mysterious existence, but the name "Kiyoshi-kun" apparently comes from the name of animator Hasegawa Shinya's pet cat (laugh).

Continued in Episode 180

(12.02.23)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 17: Once Upon a Time... (12) "Atatatatata..." "Bushu! Hidebu!"

A CD I ordered online recently arrived - *Future Boy Conan Complete Music Collection*.

When I told A-san, who helps with work, "The *Conan* music collection is great!" she gave me a puzzled look...

"Eh? Tsujita-san listens to *Conan*? I mean, do you watch *Conan*?"

"Eh? Not 'watching' but 'watched'..."

"Hm? Hm?"

The *Conan* she was referring to was *Detective Conan*!

Incidentally, she was born in 1982. Ah,

Future Boy Conan

was anime from before you were born (laughs). A slight generation gap over "

Conan

" (bitter laugh).

Well then.

1986 opened with the theatrical work *GeGeGe no Kitaro: Yokai Daisenso

(actually, Toei Animation's website "Work Lineup" lists the release date as March 15, 1985, but this is a mistake for 1986),

but around the same production period, Toei Doga was working on another major theatrical work. The title was

Hokuto no Ken: Seikimatsu Kyuseishu Densetsu

.

* A new theatrical work for the same series that was serialized in "Weekly Shonen Jump" and had begun TV animation broadcast the previous fall, gaining considerable popularity.

Director:

Ashida Toyoo

, Direction:

Umezawa Atsutoshi

, Character Design/Animation Director:

Suda Masami

, Art Director:

Tanaka Sukeyuki

.

Color direction had

Fujise-san

, who handled TV series colors, with

Tsukada-san

(

Slam Dunk

,

One Piece

) helping. Not just me but all Toei Doga inspection members at the time were drafted to help inspect this TP delivery.

As I wrote before, the system then was that people with free time from their own works and jobs would help with theatrical work cel delivery finishing inspection.

Furthermore, during pre-editing or pre-dubbing photography crunches, under department manager instructions, we'd stop our own work to prioritize helping with cel delivery inspection.

I, who had the theatrical *Kitaro*, inevitably participated in helping.

Or rather,

Kitaro

proceeded very precisely on schedule and was actually almost completed by the end of the previous year.

This *Hokuto no Ken* had various problems with TV series production finishing work.

As I wrote long ago, Toei Doga works back then were mainly "shadowless" works, but this

Hokuto no Ken

, due to the work's nature, absolutely had "No.1 shadow," "No.2 shadow," "BL shadow," and even "highlights." Work volume increased while finishing unit costs remained the same, plus no schedule - finishing production companies were avoiding it.

So for the theatrical version, animation density naturally exceeded TV.

"Challenging depictions of scattered internal organs and brain matter that couldn't be drawn on TV" was one of this theatrical version's "selling points."

So animation drew each intestinal fold more finely and boldly, color direction used reference books to specify colors in detail, and painting this required even more finishing work. Moreover, finishing was much more overseas than domestic production companies. Roughness inevitably stood out. Hence cel delivery inspection and retake processing took incredibly long.

Day after day, battling blood splatters (laughs).

No matter how strictly we checked, retakes appeared. And unlike now with digital, it took time to photograph, develop at labs, watch rush film with all staff in screening rooms - then discovering "color mismatch" retakes. An indescribably unpleasant atmosphere would flow through screening rooms (bitter laugh).

With retakes not decreasing, at one point production staff K-san stood up in the screening room and declared:

"Listen! 'Paka-paka' is retake, but 'paka' is OK! Listen! One 'paka' is OK!"

More pressure for us finishing inspectors (bitter laugh).

But anyway, for places that went "paka," we painted them black all over with black markers (finishing favorite "Pentel Name Pen") (laughs). This technique worked because

Hokuto no Ken

had many "BL shadows."

Somehow completing it this way.

At the time, barely 2 weeks before release, staff first screening was held at Toei Studios screening room. However, watching the first screening, we inspection folks were disappointed. Apparently for "self-regulation" for film ratings, all splatter scenes were crushed from above with what was called "video processing." Even cuts with realistic pink intestines scattering that had been so difficult, cuts with brain matter scattered with blood splashes - all beautifully turned silhouette-style... Hmm.

Incidentally, now if you show "hidebu!" cuts directly like this, with [PG-12] or [PG-15], regulations are much stricter than back then, so children couldn't come see them in theaters, making it even worse box office-wise.

I recently discovered *Theatrical Hokuto no Ken Film Book* (volumes 1 & 2) from my parents' bookshelf!

Looking at it intently after so long, seeing it anew like this, the limitations of Toei paints back then are quite obvious (bitter laugh).

Come to think of it, when the video was released, I think I bought it through internal company sales...

I lent it to someone and that was it... Anyone who remembers, please contact me! (laughs)

What I can't forget from that time was during pre-editing *Hokuto no Ken* crunch when help was called and we were all working at night, listening to "Tunnels All Night Nippon" when a news bulletin came on.

It was news that Space Shuttle

Challenger

had exploded. Late night January 28th.

##

■Continues to Episode 18

(07.06.05)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 180:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 7

Currently at Namco Namjatown in Tokyo Ikebukuro's Sunshine City, a collaboration project with

Mawaru Penguindrum

called "Survival Strategy at Namjatown!!" is being held. Several Penguin Drum staff members went there the other day. Going together were scriptwriter Igami, Assistant Director Yamazaki, Character Designer Nishii, Director Kaneko, and myself. We all drew in the visitor message notebook, took commemorative photos, ate all the collaboration sweets together - the five of us went completely field trip mode with all the chatter and excitement (laugh). Man, it was fun.

Even so, I used to be a bit cynical about these tie-up and collaboration events and avoided them, but strangely I find myself wanting to go to

Penguindrum

events. But naturally there are regular

Penguindrum

fans there. Seeing such people seriously absorbed in the exhibits or happily eating the collaboration sweets, well, there are moments when I get strangely nervous (sweat).

There seem to be more project events coming up, so I want to go with everyone again (laugh).

Now then.

Episode 5: So I Will Do That

Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiko, Direction/Sotome Koichiro (■■■■■■■■■■), Color
Direction/Saito Asami (■■■■■)

Masako (■■■■) visits hospitalized Kuho Asami, who was injured in the Akasaka-mitsuke Station incident, aiming at her forehead with a red ball pachinko gun. Ringo's date with her divorced and separated father was lackluster, and furthermore she witnessed Tabuki happily dating with Yuri, so heartbroken in the pouring rain, she was invited by Himari for dinner at the Takakura house. But she fought with Shoma over the fate diary, and after causing a ruckus in Crystal World,

chasing a penguin hat caught on a truck door speeding through the rain, Kanba and #1 have a bicycle chase! ...such was Episode 5.

Episode 5 was an Artland gross production episode. Storyboard was by Director Ikuhara, with direction onward through animation and coloring handled by Artland. The color director was also from Artland. Oh, I think we arranged the core animation staff members from our side? And it was unexpectedly the "panty shot episode" (laugh).

In

Mawaru Penguindrum

, "panty shots basically prohibited" was an unspoken understanding. Showing under skirts or underwear and such - those elements typical of so-called "late-night anime," those kind of fan service elements - didn't seem to suit this suspense & mystery work. Well, in Episode 2 the penguins wore panties & bras. Or rather, more than that, Princess had been stripping magnificently since Episode 1 (laugh).

However, there was room for things that naturally showed in the flow of performance, but in Episode 5 not only Ringo but even Kanba's underwear was visible. My personal feeling was "Eh? We don't need to show it!" but well, if the director says OK then it can't be helped (laugh).

So, well, Ringo's panties being white is natural if you think about it (cough cough), but what about Kanba's pink? (laugh) This shouldn't have been my instruction. Did color director Saito decide it, or was it Director Sotome's taste? Hmm, I don't think I said pink, probably... (memory is vague).

Actually, I didn't see Kanba's pink underwear during the rush check. I was surprised when I watched the white box DVD right before broadcast. So I was thinking of correcting the color for Blu-ray & DVD, but it seemed to be getting a subtle reception on various places online, including the USTREAM broadcast "Secret Penguindrum" hosted by Koizumi Yutaka and Iwasaki Ai, so it became hard to fix, and in the end it remained pink (laugh). Well, I guess the result is fine. I think this is also an interesting aspect of anime made by everyone together. Eh? What color was I going to correct it to? That's a secret.

In Episode 5, the scene chasing the truck is on a rainy night, and for the character and truck colors against the background art color tone, we intentionally brought out blue strongly. By doing this, the characters and truck would look tighter in terms of screen balance, and I thought we could feel the speed and tension of the chase more. Also, considering that photography processing rain would be layered on top, it was calculated that making the characters with strong blue tones and a harder tone would be better. Director Sotome pointed out "Isn't the blue too strong?" but I requested "I want to go with this!" and carried it through. I think the result was a

screen as calculated.

Incidentally, the truck appearing in this scene used a 3D model. I believe we bought a license-free 3DCG model from some website. Osakabe's designed "GOOD-BYE Transport" sticker materials were applied to that model. The color tone of this truck was naturally also adjusted by me. Just like with characters, I placed a psd format sample image on the BG board, layered various adjustment layers on top ("level correction" + "hue saturation" + "lens filter" this time) to create the rough balance, then adjusted details individually for the final decision. On the model, the driver's seat had a bare front windshield, but if the inside was visible there would be driver problems and such complications, so to make it invisible I painted it completely dark. In

Mawaru Penguindrum

, various 3DCG materials appear in later episodes too, but in most cases we created color tones this way.

Anyway, since I hadn't had work requesting gross production including direction for years, there were various things that didn't go smoothly, and for me it was an episode with not a few points of reflection.

Continued in Episode 181

(12.03.01)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 181:

Mawaru Penguin Drum

Color Design Notes - Part 8

The other day I completely moved out all the remaining equipment and luggage from the Mitaka studio. There's still some

Mawaru Penguin Drum

leftover business to handle here and there, but the staff room where I was is already in the thick of work on a different title (apparently an April new series). So I withdrew to avoid being in the way.

The seat after cleaning up your own equipment is somehow lonely. Exactly one year since the Great East Japan Earthquake. As I wrote here before, exactly one year ago I encountered that major earthquake in Mitaka. Various memories from that time, memories of working hard for a year after that, and the final rush days - all sorts of things pass through my heart.

Will there come a day when I can work here again? Producer Tokiwa said this to me at the end:

"Next time I do a 'stylish' work, I'll definitely have Tsujita-san come!"

Thank you, Tokiwa-san, I'm happy. But somehow it seems that in Tokiwa-san's mind I've become the person who does "stylish" works and "celebrity" works... Hmm? Huh? Was this

Mawaru Penguin Drum

a stylish work? That part is a mystery (laugh).

Episode 6: You and I Connected by M

Storyboard & Direction/Yamazaki Mitsue, Color Direction/Akimoto Yuki

The three members of the "Takakura Kanba Victims Association" - hospitalized Kuho Asami doesn't remember Kanba at all, and the remaining two also have their memories erased after being shot by someone with mysterious red balls. Meanwhile, Ringo has Shoma help her create a love nest under the floor of Tabuki's apartment, scheming for a "first night" with Tabuki. In this episode, the relationship between Ringo's sister Momoka (■■■) and the "fate diary," and between Tabuki and Ringo, begins to be revealed, and the reason why Ringo's family collapsed is also clarified. Mysteries are gradually revealed, and even more

mysteries increase. Such was Episode 6.

"Before going to see a play with Tabuki, isn't there some good place near Higashi-Koenji Station?" I was consulted by Director Yamazaki before starting storyboard work. For me, born and raised in Nakano, this Higashi-Koenji area at the border between Nakano and Suginami was an area where I had some familiarity, since friends lived there during high school. So I went location hunting with a camera to find places. This was in December 2010. Oh, Higashi-Koenji is where Ringo's apartment is located. So after visiting Ringo's house, if Tabuki and Ringo were to talk, it would be near this station, we decided. Incidentally, the entrance to Wadazuka Park that appeared in Episode 4 was modeled on "Sanshi no Mori Park" located along Ome Kaido, very close to Higashi-Koenji Station.

So I went location hunting alone by bicycle. I took photos of various things - small shrines, promising-looking back alleys, and such - but among them, what struck Director Yamazaki's heartstrings was that "frog park." She seemed to like those mysterious frog ornaments lined up on the benches (laugh). Several cuts in the main story use layouts exactly matching the reference photos I took. Also, while black cats appeared in the main story, there were actually cats when I went too (laugh). Also, the road where Ringo and Tabuki walk with numerous drainage pipes protruding from the wall is an actual road beside an elementary school playground or such.

Also, the department store rooftop where the two girls called by Kanba are sniped with "red balls" is based on the rooftop of Town Seven at Ogikubo Station's north exit. Even that yellow object of indeterminate shape (actually children's playground equipment) is exactly as it was. Like Sunshine Aquarium in Ikebukuro,

Mawaru Penguin Drum

secretly and casually uses real places as source material in this way throughout.

So, the "red balls" used in this rooftop sniping and in Asami's hospital room - they're red from being fired until impact, gray after impact when they "shubabaabababa" and suck something out, and finally become pure white ash. The KIGA mark on the red balls is material pasted in during photography (in later episodes the balls become 3DCG entirely), but from the ash stage it's pencil drawing with a burnt touch. Initially when the animation came up, I rejected it, and Yamazaki redrew the animation to match the setting. This felt quite good. So we used this completed main story "burnt material" as paste-in material for later episodes.

Even so, this gun has laser sighting but what it fires is a manual pachinko (wry laugh).

Episode 6, while appearing comedic on the surface, actually contains quite serious scenes and suspenseful scenes, with conversations that are keys to future stories woven throughout. In terms of color design, I deliberately used the most realistic color usage up to this point in the series. For the evening scene at Ringo's apartment, I carefully built up the subtlety of evening sunlight interfering with shadows. Also, in hospital room scenes and rooftop scenes, I created deep shadows to match the tense direction, and applied gradations to shadow boundary lines to explore suspicious atmospheres. I wanted to properly create a gap and contrast with the comedic touch direction.

Also, in the flashback scene between Ringo and Tabuki at the frog park, while the background was made into an evening scene with pink~purple imagery, I made the characters with slightly stronger purple tones than the background. Since this was the scene where Ringo and Tabuki first spoke about Momoka, it was reality but with Ringo's memory images coming through strongly - I thought such a meaningful screen would be good.

Oh yes, just before this frog park scene there's a scene with Ringo, Tabuki, and Ringo's mother at the dinner table, but this is a scene that also appeared in Episode 3. However, in the actual broadcast, Ringo's clothes are different in Episodes 3 and 6. Actually, this scene was originally supposed to have all three wearing black formal wear. But I think during Episode 3's production, the story's temporal setting was changed, and high school student Tabuki would wear his uniform instead of formal wear. Ringo also wore a black dress with black stockings. Her mother also wore black.

Actually, I should have corrected Ringo during Episode 3, but I thought, well, maybe it's okay? The Episode 6 script was already up during Episode 3, so I should have noticed, but when Episode 6's storyboard came up and I faced that scene, "Ah! (sweat)." So I secretly corrected it in Episode 6. I corrected Ringo's clothes to match what she wore in the subsequent frog park scene. Incidentally, after that I was planning to secretly replace Episode 3 for Blu-ray & DVD... ah, sorry, I forgot! (apologetic (sweat))

Making screens like the frog park while simultaneously making screens more gag-like for scenes with important, serious content is actually one of this work's patterns. So in this episode, the scene of Ringo's flashback of her parents fighting (Kappa and Otter) is made extremely surreal and gag-like. The content being told is quite an important flashback explaining Ringo's situation. During the stage of creating setting colors for this scene, we talked about "if things escalated, they'd normally throw something, right?" "The father (Otter) could throw shells, but the mother (Kappa) has nothing... Ah! The plate! (explosion)" - so it became a performance where she removes the plate from her head and throws it (laugh).

The pink color tone of the final "first night in progress" scene under the floor of Tabuki's apartment was created imagining a somewhat seedy Showa-era love hotel (laugh). I requested this during the art board meeting. Ah, this might be why

Mawaru Penguindrum

gets called a "Showa anime" in some quarters (laugh).

Continued in Episode 182

(12.03.07)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 182:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 9

The new TV series

Saint Seiya Omega

that started broadcasting April 1st. Between that work, an unannounced short work, and another short-length TV series, I'm getting completely swamped, which is partly why I'm falling behind on manuscripts again. Really sorry.

So that

Saint Seiya Omega

- at the end of this month, right before broadcast starts, we're doing an all-night event at a movie theater. It's become such a big thing with a world premiere and all (sweat).

Saint Seiya

is popular not just domestically in Japan but overseas too. Even so, I'm surprised! For a Toei production to do such an event before broadcast begins - hasn't that never happened before? ...A bit nervous.

Even so, ah, there's really so little time left this month! We've come to the point where everyone will be able to see it soon (sweat). Everyone, please support

Saint Seiya Omega

!

Now then.

Episode 7: The Woman Who Does Tamahomare

Storyboard/Matsumoto Jun (■■■■), Direction/Ichimura Tetsuo (■■■■■), Color Direction/Tsujita Kunio

At the center of the stage of the theater performance Tabuki invited her to was that woman - Yuri. And an unexpected engagement announcement. Though crushed, Ringo thinks of forceful strategies to make Tabuki hers. Shoma gets dragged into her schemes. On Shoma's back is the Tamahomare Frog. Such was Episode 7.

Episode 7 was also one where I handled color direction. Episode 7 was produced around the time of the series broadcast start. As I wrote earlier, for

Mawaru Penguindrum

we had a three-person color direction system. During this period when there was still some schedule leeway, I was also in the rotation doing color direction for each episode. But after Episode 9, I was removed from color direction until the series finale. The reason being that when broadcast started and we had the tight schedule of delivering one episode per week, if I participated in color direction too, it would delay the original design work. Moreover, for this work I was properly attending from direction meetings to final checks of retakes just before delivery, so I really couldn't handle individual episode color direction anymore. But actually handling the animation and confronting it for each episode's color direction is fun, so I enjoyed working on Episode 7 too.

From Episode 7, photography for the main story was handled by Graphinica.

For main story photography, they created screens matching the overall texture and smoothing of animation material main lines so the screen atmosphere wouldn't change significantly from Episodes 1-6. However, while there was much matching, they simultaneously evolved into newer, more advanced screens.

First, the Sunshine Opera Company stage scene. In this scene, Yuri's costume on stage has sparkling photography processing applied. This was Photography Director Ogihara's idea. While the animation costume was certainly beautifully finished, color alone wasn't quite enough. The director and I were both thinking we needed one more "sparkle." So we decided to use this for Yuri's cut in the opening that was being worked on in parallel at Sanzigen, and among the opening cuts, that Yuri full-sparkle dress cut was a collaboration cut where Ogihara applied processing to the animation (coloring) and output sequential materials, which Sanzigen then photographed.

Pictogram handling began evolving from Episode 7. Fan pictograms swarming Yuri, customer pictograms in the luxury restaurant, invitation guests and waiter pictograms at the garden party - various pictogram variations began appearing in Episode 7. During direction meetings we'd continuously discuss "Do we need to create new pictograms here?" and "Should the pictograms here have gorgeous clothing?" Assistant Director Yamazaki would order these from designer Osakabe, keeping them as simple as possible.

So these pictograms - we'd hand Illustrator data to photography, and photography would arrange them on screen according to direction photography instructions. Since pictograms themselves are individual fixed designs, they don't walk around like animation in-betweens, so photography creates all their movement. Horizontal and vertical movement is just sliding on screen so it's not too difficult, but depth

movement from front to back seems quite challenging - in Episode 7 the movement of fan pictograms swarming toward Yuri and Yuki was apparently quite difficult. The balance between that speed feeling and animation size was delicate, and particularly the cut where Ringo gets shoved by pictograms swarming from behind required many retake re-shoots. Even so, the bouncing fan pictograms were cute. They're in my top five favorite pictograms (laugh).

Pictograms were quite difficult to handle in terms of "color" too. Especially this time with the garden party scene. Originally pictograms are in a sense "visual abbreviation" - icons placed for that abbreviation. So in a sense they're not real entities. Therefore, in that meaning, it might be okay for them to stand out quite a bit.

However, this scene is outdoors at night, and spatially it's not very bright except for parts where lights hit. We're placing pictograms in such an environment, but if you just plop those pure white pictograms into darkness, only the pictograms would shine and gleam in the screen, making unwanted assertions and breaking the screen and direction. So naturally we'd change (lower) the pictogram colors to match the screen darkness, but when you adjust colors to blend with spatial light and dark, they gradually become entities - actual "human-shaped boards" placed there. If that happens, wouldn't that be wrong? Photography suggested "For example, how about adding gradient shadows from the ground direction upward?" but that would create even more "board-like substance feeling," so I rejected it.

In Episode 7, knowing this risk, I deliberately dropped the pictogram brightness quite realistically to match the background. I aimed for the borderline, but how was it? Whether this was acceptable for

Mawaru Penguinindrum

's screen style. Every time I rewatch Episode 7, this part bothers me (laugh). Incidentally, later in the finale's "Children's Broiler" and such, we placed pictograms somewhat brighter. While there were differences in direction intent, it was the color (brightness) of pictograms where I continuously questioned "Is this okay?"

Now, one thing not to forget about

Mawaru Penguinindrum

is "food." "Make food properly delicious-looking!" was

Penguinindrum

's... or rather my theme (laugh), so we had animation drawn with spirit from the rough animation stage. This time it was restaurant cuisine above all! This was a finish that could only be called magnificent. Special effects like texture from Episode 7 onward were handled by Graphinica's Yamada. That soft-looking meat

and sauce shine feeling was supreme. And from this episode onward, various special effects magic would be displayed. Oh, all the monitor screen content of Ringo's laptop in the science room was also created by Yamada.

That frog story in the science room (laugh). That frog's design source was one item from a "Gachapon" series called "Primary Colors Japanese Frogs" or something that I happened to have. Some day after

One Piece Film: Strong World

ended, I casually tried the gachapon machines lined up in front of the toilet on the 4th floor of Yodobashi Camera in Kichijoji or somewhere, and out came that frog. It had been sitting in front of my computer since

The Tatami Galaxy

days and was carried along to Brain's Base. So when we needed some frog reference material, that frog sitting on my desk happened to be in the spotlight (laugh). Director Shibata put it together as a character while looking at that tiny figure (is that what you call it?) (laugh).

The color had an order from Director Ikuhara to "make it flashy anyway!" We created something and checked it with everyone while tweaking it, putting together flashy coloring. But wait, I feel like I've seen this somewhere... It ended up looking extremely similar to Eva Unit-01's colors. Hmm. What to do? It got an OK at the scene with a "well, I guess it's fine" feeling, but late that night the director called my cell phone. "About that, I want to do something about it after all... I mean, if it were a parody of our own work that might be okay, but if it looks like a parody of other people's work, I think that wouldn't be good for those people" - so we readjusted. The result was that Tamahomare Frog.

Continued in Episode 183

(12.03.21)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 183:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 10

Sorry for the wait! Resuming!

Now then.

Episode 8: Even If Your Love Is a Lie, I Am

Storyboard/Nakamura Akiko, Direction/Fukushima Toshinori (■■■■■), Color Direction/Otsuka Natsuko

Ringo's night raid on Tabuki's apartment ends in failure, and she sits stunned in the empty room after he moved out. Furthermore, she witnesses her father's remarriage proposal. Her crushed feelings turn toward Tabuki, and she heads to Tabuki and Yuri's new home carrying a housewarming cake. Having put sleeping pills in the cake to make Tabuki sleep, Ringo instead tries to assault Tabuki. Such was Episode 8.

Episode 8 featured that fluttering animation (is that what you call it? (laugh)) again. This time it was Western-style. Since the photography staff had changed from Episode 4, I wondered how it would go, but wow, as expected! This time we made the screen Western movie-style and set a cinemascope-style frame within the screen. Since the original screen aspect ratio is 16:9, the screen layout cutting the top and bottom slightly more than that felt quite good. And the logo elements within the movie screen were Osakabe's work.

Tabuki and Yuri's new home, a luxury apartment in Akasaka-mitsuke - we talked about "what kind of place would an actress live?" and expanded our fantasies in various ways, ending up with that kind of high-ceilinged, spacious area (laugh). When we used red and black for the interior and furniture (sofa), it became "like Don Juan (the sound studio we're indebted to for 'Penguindrum') (laugh)." I'd never been there so I thought "hmm," but right after that I was invited to the USTREAM program "Secret Penguindrum" (the recording location was a room inside that Don Juan), and I went "Ah, I see!" It was red and black interior coloring so much to Director Ikuhara's taste that it raised the suspicion "Ah! Could it be that the sound studio was chosen for that reason?" (laugh).

Since "we want Shoma to slide smoothly across the shiny floor," initially we were going to have no slippers indoors, but we discussed in direction meetings "In this kind of household you'd normally wear slippers, right?" and "Since they just moved,

maybe it's okay not to wear them?" In the end we decided "slippers exist," so Tabuki and Ringo have slippers. Only Shoma has no slippers (laugh).

One challenge of Episode 8 was "not showing." Starting with naked Ringo at the beginning, to the scene in the latter half where she assaults Tabuki, we didn't want to show nudity too explicitly. Certainly it's a late-night anime, and we understood that showing things to some degree wouldn't get complaints from the TV station, but even so I somehow had resistance to showing nakedness directly. So we avoided showing as much as possible. We had the animation drawn as normally as possible, and since they were night scenes anyway, we made them night-colored~silhouette-like with color.

However, watching the completed broadcast screen, it became darker than we had anticipated, and well, brightness-wise it's barely visible? Hmm, did I make it too dark... It ended up as a screen with somewhat disappointing balance. If I had designed the characters themselves a bit brighter, couldn't we have achieved a "not showing" feeling screen-wise? Various reflections.

Now, my personal highlight of Episode 8 was the conversation scene between Ringo and Shoma on the emergency stairs, and the subsequent ending sequence until the diary is stolen and Shoma gets hit by a car.

Here the animation (shading, expressions), art (damp rain atmosphere), photography (rain and slightly smoky feeling), and color matched well to successfully express the uneasy feeling of the conversation content, the tension, and the "shadows" of Ringo and Shoma's backgrounds. And the color tone of the close-up of Ringo and Shoma illuminated by approaching headlights was color director Otsuka's work. She created magnificent colors for Episode 8's shocking ending.

Incidentally, since "We forgot about #2! What should we do?", we decided he was blown away by the car too (laugh).

Continued in Episode 184

(12.06.12)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 184:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 11

Before I knew it, it's already June, and the new programs that started in April have mostly passed 10 episodes, with one-cour shows already at their climax.

Saint Seiya Omega

that I'm participating in is planned as a one-year series. We've finally passed the first major climax of the early part. The story will steadily progress toward the next climax from here.

Among those who have been watching since the original series, I think some might be puzzled by how different it is from the original

Saint Seiya

, but this is the new

Saint Seiya

. I hope you'll enjoy the new characters and their stories created by new staff at a new tempo. I'm also going "Ah, I see! (laugh)" with daily admiration while contributing lots of ideas and enjoying making it together. It's quite tough though (laugh).

Such

Saint Seiya Omega

- please support us, everyone!

Now then.

Episode 9: The Ice World

Storyboard, Direction & Animation Director/Takeuchi Nobuyuki (■■■■), Color Direction/Tsujita Kunio

Just when Ringo and Shoma were lamenting each other's heart shadows on the rain-soaked emergency stairs at Tabuki's apartment, at the Takakura house Himari was vaguely experiencing a mysterious space. The Sky Hole Branch of the library. In those deep layers of heart and memory underground, Himari meets Mario (■■). Confronting "that time" within memories of her own origins, Himari. And the faint memory she reached was a place with an ominous atmosphere called "Children's

Broiler." Such was Episode 9.

Episode 9 was truly Takeuchi Nobuyuki in full force! Storyboard, almost all rough animation, animation director, and direction. This Episode 9, which took time carefully and deliberately, required about 3 months of actual work. Completion slightly overran one week before broadcast.

The main stage, the "Sky Hole Branch," was entirely constructed in 3D from layout onward. Takeuchi went to art director Akiyama's Studio Pablo, learning to use 3D tools while building it together with Akiyama. Bookshelves extending endlessly couldn't be drawn by hand, and rather, by assembling them with 3D layout, they injected clear "discomfort" compared to the screen atmosphere up to Episode 8, creating screens that were orderly yet somehow anxious.

With various devices applied in background art, I didn't do anything tricky in color design, dedicating myself entirely to creating color tones to match the brightness of the art space. However, Himari's flashback scenes interspersed between the matter-of-fact cold library scenes were sometimes afternoon sunlight, sometimes incandescent lighting - I tried to bracket them with color tones that felt yellow somewhere. While this was also aimed as contrast with the library scenes' color tone, I wonder if I successfully expressed the languidness of memories that aren't necessarily pleasant?

Photography for Episode 9 was by Sanzigen. Yamada and Uezono from Sanzigen's photography department, which had just been established. We had planned from the beginning to irregularly request the OP and this Episode 9, well, with schedule considerations. But when we opened the lid it was quite difficult (wry laugh). The total cut count was nearly 400 (normal 30-minute shows are around 300 cuts), with not a few special processes and things that had to be assembled in 3D. And the book spine paste-ins for that library were all pasted in by photography.

This paste-in work became incredibly difficult, and actually those book titles are all different! The "Frog-kun" series in particular was moving (laugh).

So those library book paste-ins, the 3D floor rotating and disappearing - they would reappear in different forms in Episode 13 and the final episode.

Now, Episode 9 was Mario's debut episode.

Right around the time we were producing Episode 9, we were making the OP, and actually Mario's character wasn't completed yet. We had Hoshino's character rough draft and Nishii's rough character setting, and layout work proceeded based on those, but Mario's final character setting, including coloring, was decided to meet the OP work deadline (we proceeded with color decisions using rough settings), resulting in simultaneous work.

For Mario's color image, I initially had a "pure white" image and thought "how about a character that's pure white from top to bottom?" Hair and even eyelashes white. And red pupils. That kind of image. But when I secretly tried it, white eyelashes felt like too much of an overdo (laugh), so I adjusted to a more human-like color tone and showed it to the director.

"Hmm..." the director said, but seemed to have a somewhat lukewarm impression. Somehow the response felt unclear. While my Mario had come together atmospherically, it certainly felt lacking in the impact and assertiveness that the character "Mario" should have. But I made this the "provisional final version" and began preparing for temporary coloring work. That was June 13th. While proceeding with work, I reconsidered the colors. What was lacking in this model? And what emerged was that pink-haired Mario.

"Well, I guess it would end up like this after all..." said the director. Thus Mario was solidified. It was the night of June 23rd (laugh). With less than a month until Episode 1 broadcast, it was truly the last minute for opening work.

So the opening was fine, but the problem was Episode 9 - actually, for Mario's first appearance, his costume was library staff costume (laugh). So this also required urgent correction.

Mario was decided through all these various processes. While we knew he was an important key in the story, at the time we were producing Episode 9, how the story would end and what exactly Mario's true identity was remained far in the fog, in the director's mind.

Now, this Episode 9 has differences between the broadcast version and Blu-ray/DVD version. It's the deepest part of the Sky Hole Branch, the scene with Mario and Princess of the Crystal.

When first made, we had colored Himari's pupils in Princess costume with the usual pink, but that really bothered me. The reason being that we had established the symbol pupil→pink when controlled by the hat, but in this scene, while Himari is wearing Princess costume, she's not actually being controlled, is she? So I consulted with Director Ikuhara.

"Hmm, that might be so. But well, either way..."

The decision was left to me, so in the Blu-ray/DVD version, I corrected the pink pupils to Himari's normal colored pupils (though there are cuts intentionally left pink). So for those doing detailed analysis, I planted further "seeds" (laugh).

Continued in Episode 185

(12.06.19)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 185:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 12

Recently, I've finally (finally!) started paying attention to my weight, and I'm properly getting on the scale every morning. This morning as I write this it's 81.2 kilograms. I've gained a bit lately. Plus 1 kilogram, perhaps due to that Chinese food banquet the other day. Come to think of it, last month when I had yakiniku three days in one week, I was surprised when I suddenly gained 2-3 kilograms (laugh). But somehow I'm keeping it under 80 kilograms.

Incidentally, based on the standard weight calculation for my height, I need to lose another 10 kilograms (laugh).

Our work involves sitting for long periods, so if you're a bit careless your weight increases immediately. Frequent eating out is also one cause. Recently I've shifted the center of studio meals to bread + milk. I'm controlling to avoid greasy things as much as possible. This has settled things down considerably. Aim for the dream 70-kilogram range!

But you know, when stress builds up, I desperately want to eat greasy things (wry laugh).

Now then.

Episode 10: "Because I Like You"

Storyboard, Direction & Animation Director/Goto Keiji (■■■■■), Color Direction/Akimoto Yuki

Shoma, carried to the hospital after a car accident, is kidnapped by someone, and in exchange for his person, they demand the half of the diary remaining in Ringo's hands. Kanba confronts the criminal with a fake diary and chases the criminal into a mysterious space within the hospital. Meanwhile, Ringo is demanded to give the real diary to the criminal and ends up handing it over. Such was Episode 10.

Episode 10 was an episode where Goto Keiji handled storyboard, direction, rough animation, and animation director by himself. It was an episode he steadily drew alone at the seat furthest back in the staff room.

"Togou General Hospital," which would become one of the important stages for the story from here on, debuts in this episode, but Episode 9's Takeuchi Nobuyuki was in charge of design. All the visuals of the mysterious internal space that Kanba

wanders into were Takeuchi's responsibility. The exterior motif is an actual building called the Pompidou Centre in Paris. Using that as reference, he skillfully arranged it into a uniquely distinctive atmosphere.

Actually, throughout

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, we've referenced real building designs in many places. During art setting meetings, thick photo books of world architectural design and Art Deco photo books were pulled out countless times, flipping through their pages or looking at images searched online. Unexpected architectural structures were referenced in unexpected scenes. So every episode, I looked forward to backgrounds coming up from the art team.

Incidentally, background completion checks were done for almost every episode by the assigned director, Chief Director Nakamura, and myself. Of course, for checks of important points that had been discussed in direction meetings, Director Ikuhara and Assistant Director Yamazaki also attended. Within the studio, my work monitor became the standard for screen brightness and color tone, and checks were done around my desk and monitor late at night. Of course, art board checks were the same. At those times, with art staff included, we'd have meetings around my desk while looking at the screen, discussing this and that.

When background completion timing was around midnight, we often couldn't catch the last train. Particularly in the latter half of the series, we quite frequently missed the last train and worked until morning (laugh).

So, about that Togou General Hospital - in Episode 10 we decided to "not show the overall exterior yet," so we devised the storyboard to show only partial views like the upper part of the building, patient room exteriors, and parking lot.

And one character who appeared while we "didn't show the full picture yet" - the figure in the parking lot who picks up the diary and leaves, yes, Renjaku (■■■) also made her first appearance in this episode. But still just a silhouette. Actually, this figure was a male "Natsume family's old butler" until the middle of producing this episode. Then suddenly in Episode 16 "Renjaku's" appearance was decided, and we urgently had to create her design. Then it became "this person at this time is probably Renjaku," so we redrew two cuts to be Renjaku. However, Renjaku's colors weren't decided yet at this time, and the close-up cut of the hand picking up the diary was, well, an evening scene, so somewhat atmospheric (laugh).

Now, for Episode 10's color design, the basics were still matching art space and temporal settings. We patiently held back various things until the coming "story turning point" of Episodes 11 and 12. ...However, the mysterious hospital interior space that switches in the rooftop scene - in a sense real but somehow unreal

imagery. In that mysterious space, we really needed to consider something visual or it wouldn't settle properly. So after trying various things, I personally used the technique of "changing main line colors imagistically" that I'd been saving for after the "story turning point." This time I picked up the blue atmosphere used in that scene's background and made the main lines blue-toned. I used it from where Kanba wakes up on the rooftop, going down the stairs to the front of the underground operating room (?).

The night vision goggle view of the operating room's darkness - well, the standard reference for this kind of scene is the movie

The Silence of the Lambs

. I myself have done this in various works - how many times is this? (laugh). For this scene, the green color change is not photography filter work but properly creating it green with art + coloring. The reason being that if you apply a green filter over a normally created screen, characters get buried in the background and become hard to see. Real night vision goggles might make screens look that way, but in this scene the character's (Kanba's) expression and performance must be properly visible, so against the background's green color tone, I shifted the character coloring's hue slightly and added somewhat yellow color tones. Then photography added noise and such over that to create that screen.

Another subtle failure in such dark performance. The Kanba×Masako kiss scene was fine in the close-up cut, but in the subsequent wide shot, Kanba×Masako in the background blended too much with the dark BG, and only the Esmeralda×#1 kiss scene in the foreground stood out on screen (laugh). Hmm, dark scenes are indeed difficult to balance.

Continued in Episode 186

(12.06.26)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 186:

Mawaru Penguin Drum

Color Design Notes - Part 13

This year I'm working at Toei Animation for the first time in several years. I commute to the Oizumi studio almost daily, and my desk is on the 3rd floor. I take the stairs up to the 3rd floor. But something's strange. That climb is incredibly tiring. Why?

So I checked various things, and ah! There are many steps on the stairs!

The reason being this studio has extremely high ceilings on each floor. How high? High enough that you could easily build lofts on each floor if you wanted. So while it's a 3-story building, it's actually equivalent in height to a 4-story building!

Normally, stairs between floors in apartments and such have about 13 steps. So for a 3-story building, that's 26 steps. But at Oizumi Studio it's 22 steps per floor. Climbing to the 3rd floor exceeds 40 steps, which is equivalent to the 4th floor of a normal building.

Ah, so that's it! In other words, while climbing stairs thinking it's the 3rd floor, I'm actually forced to consume energy equivalent to moving up a 4-story building. Ugh, fearsome Toei Animation Oizumi Studio!

Now then.

Episode 11: "Finally You Have Noticed"

Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiko, Kaneko Shingo & Yamazaki Mitsue,
Direction/Yamazaki Mitsue, Color Direction/Otsuka Natsuko

Starting with the diary being stolen, the relationship between Shoma and Ringo gradually becomes strained. And Ringo, who decided to restart "Project M," again borrows the power of the mysterious frog to bewitch Tabuki. But Tabuki goes berserk! And failure. Yuri, who returns home, also shows her class difference. Returning home defeated, waiting for her are Himari and Shoma. Those feelings of helplessness are directed at Shoma, but... Such was Episode 11.

It's the unexpected frog episode again (laugh). This time's frog, as you can tell from the visuals, is female (laugh). Himehmare Frog. The color design was completed by adding a ribbon and lipstick to Episode 7's Tamahomare Frog character, with some color divisions and color changes. Quite labor-saving. For the main story too, the science room's cut divisions - or rather the cuts themselves - we used several

cuts from the previous use as-is, so people who had been watching would understand "Ah, it's the frog again! (laugh)" and we could show it simply without adding extra cuts. Skillfully reusing cuts from past episodes like this was done quite intentionally in

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, connecting to labor savings and being very effective.

Speaking of frogs, the frog website screen on Ringo's laptop in the science room - all of that is the work of special effects and graphic design staff Yamada Kanako. The animation materials we prepared were just the frog image and laptop animation. Based on that and the storyboard performance, she created that PC screen. Man, I was surprised when I saw the completed screen! I've asked Yamada for design work around ICU monitor screens appearing in later episodes and #1's erotic magazine creation. Oh, special effects for cooking cuts are mostly Yamada's work too.

And again this time, the nighttime bedroom (laugh). Learning from Episode 7's failure, I designed it slightly brighter. However, scene design created in advance on art boards actually changes considerably in appearance due to differences in actual cut layouts and animation shadow angles and areas. But it's the color directors who skillfully adjust that. Right after that, when they close the bedroom door from outside and trap frog-Tabuki inside, the color director skillfully created the color handling for tension and comical expression.

Actually, Episode 11 is quite a favorite of mine.

I think "color design" is the job of writing the "color blueprint" for a story, and "color direction" is what creates screens by facing actual animation with that blueprint in hand. So if it follows the blueprint, that's even enough, but whether the screen becomes even better depends entirely on the color director's ability. It's an episode where that was put together in a settled, good feeling.

Color directors who approach their assigned episodes with their own plans create wonderful work.

Understanding the "blueprint" I provide, then adjusting the balance with actual animation, sometimes suggesting "How about something like this?" - since it's the color director who actually faces the animation, having them think about various things like this is both pleasing and helpful. The two main color directors we're asking for this time, Otsuka and Akimoto, are such color directors. The goal is ultimately the same: "How to make it even a little better."

Now, up to the nighttime scene in front of the apartment where returning Ringo meets Himari and Shoma, it was the usual

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color usage, but just before the end, boom! Yes, our nickname "95 Train." That subway visual was by art director Akiyama. When we all gathered to check on my monitor, starting with the director, we all went "Ohhhhhh!" (laugh). We got somewhat excited with a visual that felt like "It's coming!" (laugh). Only the director came back to his senses saying "Is this okay? This (sweat)" (laugh).

Anyway, since the shocking visual exceeded our imagination, creating colors to go with it was fun. Here I finally lifted the ban on the method of changing main line colors. In Episode 11, inside the 95 train, I made Princess's main lines red-toned. Meanwhile, Ringo, Shoma, and the penguins remained the usual black-toned. Here, since I wanted to differentiate the positions of Princess versus Ringo and the others, I only changed Princess. Also, the base for overall color change was created to link with the redness of the "95" number. When considering special color tones in such enclosed spaces, incorporating the most eye-catching color used in that space is a technique I always use. This tends to settle well when finished.

Anyway, Episode 11 ends with a tension-filled cliffhanger of "What on earth is about to begin!?"

Continued in Episode 187

(12.07.03)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 187:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 14

When this manuscript is updated, I'll actually be in China. For location hunting for a certain new TV series, the director, art staff, and I are heading to somewhere in China. Ah, China after a long time. It's been several years since I've been to China outside of Hong Kong, and this time it's somewhat rural.

However, both the director and I are super busy. What we managed to squeeze out was a 3-night, 4-day forced schedule. Departing Narita early morning and arriving locally firmly at night. Plus time difference feelings. Plus domestic flight connections and such - some heart-pounding moments!

In such a situation, will we actually be able to return properly? (No, we're not going that deep into the wilderness (laugh))

That work is still before information release, but maybe we can announce it in autumn? Please look forward to that too!

Now then.

Episode 12: "The Circle Around Us"

Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiro & Shibata Katsunori, Direction/Shibata Katsunori, Color Direction/Akimoto Yuki

Shoma begins telling how losing Momoka was his fault. The "incident" from 16 years ago as told by Shoma. The memories of that day, that incident are revealed. Surprised and confused Ringo. Himari collapses and is carried to the hospital. Kanba rushes there, but Himari dies. And Mario appears. Such was Episode 12.

Finally the major turning point from first half to second half.

The outline of the "incident" told on the "95 Train" continuing from Episode 11. Processing inside the car continues from Episode 11. In Episode 12, the penguins also stop their movement - are they intently listening to Shoma's story, or are they literally turning their backs? Such a first half with heavy, oppressive air dominating the car interior.

The "incident" flashback beginning with Shoma's narration is drawn from young Tabuki's perspective midway through, and how to handle this flashback scene's screen was Episode 12's first challenge.

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builds up its story using many flashback scenes, but by inserting "out of service boards" modeled after subways at the beginning of flashback scenes, we basically eliminated special processing for flashback scenes (like frames within screens common to flashback scenes). In previous episodes, for flashback scenes we basically didn't do anything particularly special besides color changes matching time periods and locations.

Now this time, since the incident being treated as a motif is what it is, while some degree of realism was necessary, the theme wasn't exactly identifying and recreating that incident or place - so how far exactly should we draw it? For the few early morning cuts just before the incident, I believe the art boards that first came up had Tokyo landmarks drawn in quite realistically, but the director gave correction instructions to "show it more with silhouettes only." Since it's fine if being Tokyo is somehow conveyed, we went with more silhouette-like drawing. We also dramatically lowered the overall screen saturation, making Ping Force members in orange windbreakers stand out strangely in grayish screens.

From midway through the flashback, it's told from young Tabuki's perspective at that time. Since that morning began as the same daily routine as always, while somewhat suppressing saturation, this side was finished as a relatively normal screen. Then we created a sharp drop to heavy screens at the boundary of helicopter silhouettes flying about.

In this series of flashback scenes, the number one contributor was definitely the "Picto-sans" - various pictograms by Osakabe. Orange jacket Ping Force Picto-sans, confused customers and subway staff Picto-sans in front of Higashi-Koenji Station. Moreover, variations with movement like carrying boxes and shouting through megaphones - we ordered these from our site... while being somewhat reserved, we went all out (laugh). Since we ordered so many, we decided to do what we could ourselves, so for the funeral scene's mourning dress Picto-sans, I created them by processing previously appeared Picto-sans.

Now, what finally appeared in this funeral scene was Momoka. Her first appearance was as a portrait photo, but the story of Momoka's colors will be revisited in later episodes.

After Himari was carried to the hospital, I created overall heavy screens. ICU inside and outside - the corridor where Shoma and Ringo keep watch with lighting reduced and darkened, while ICU interior was in pale whitish light like Himari's life growing thin. Both aimed for screens with lowered saturation but properly showing color tone.

Crystal World space also matched Himari's life state, creating a dark, nearly stopped space. For this scene's color tone image, I had them output normal Crystal

World space 3D images as PSD format with layers intact, and processed that image data myself to create samples. I also decided character color tones accordingly. Honestly there were parts where I was making quite unreasonable processing orders to photography, but photography put it together into even better atmosphere.

And Episode 12's second half highlight was "Mary's Lamb." This was the scene that took the longest to finalize in Episode 12.

The sheep design was by Shibata. They were simply cute, too cute individually, so how to balance this with the art became quite high-hurdle work. This series of art was by Nakamura Chieko. During this episode's production crunch, Nakamura came to the staff room repeatedly right up to the last train at midnight, bringing gradually completed work for checking. I layered characters over those backgrounds and created sample images built up considering cut-to-cut connections and cut buildup, having photography reproduce and compile them. The cuter they are, the more beautiful they are, the more cruel an impression is born. While there wasn't much time, gradually. Matching such art, we gradually decided the depth of image processing and the goddess's colors and processing.

And the dark rabbit had returned.

Such an Episode 12 that can't be fully described (laugh).

Incidentally, as a digression, about the elementary school Momoka and Tabuki attended - what should we do about its school emblem? For that, the elementary school's name had to be decided first. So, Kagaya Elementary School. We borrowed production staff member Kagaya's surname (laugh).

Continued in Episode 188

(12.07.10)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 188:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 15

As I briefly wrote last week, I went location hunting for a certain new TV series all the way to Lijiang in China's Yunnan Province. It was quite a forced march, but haha, we got an unexpected bonus at the end. Actually, our return flight from Beijing was canceled due to bad weather! We stayed one night at an airline-arranged hotel and returned on the next morning's replacement flight.

The art director who accompanied me seemed quite damaged by this, but I gradually found it more and more enjoyable and was excitedly savoring the situation (laugh). I mean, this kind of thing rarely happens! Well, it's not like anyone died. A rare experience, priceless.

That said, I had to cancel meetings scheduled for the day after return and caused various troubles for projects waiting on me, but I'll work hard to catch up!

Now then.

Episode 13: Our Crime and Punishment

Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiro & Furukawa Tomohiro, Direction/Ichimura Tetsuo, Color Direction/Otsuka Natsuko

The flashback from three years ago continues. Memories of that day when public security visited the Takakura house and peaceful days met their end. The truth about their parents revealed by TV. The shocked brothers. In the ICU, Himari, whose life flame once went out, is revived by Mario's mysterious ampule medicine. And Mario's encounter. Momoka and Mario. Various facts connecting past and present are revealed anew. Such was Episode 13.

Episode 13 is directly connected to Episode 12. The ICU surroundings and flashback scene handling were finished with basic scene design continuing from Episode 12. While

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is overall a continuous story, these Episodes 12 and 13 feel like one episode made as two consecutive episodes.

These Episodes 12 and 13 became the major turning point between the story's first and second halves. Particularly in Episode 13, the penguin hat = Momoka was actually revealed, but judging from various people's reactions online, surprisingly

many hadn't noticed, which was more shocking to us (wry laugh). Eh? Was it really that unclear? Despite such easy-to-understand direction and cut buildup (laugh).

So while Momoka was secretly revealed, Episode 13 was the first time Momoka's actual form appeared.

When Momoka's design came to me, what I was thinking was that Ringo and Momoka have different details, but maybe the basic color tones should be the same? Or rather, maybe they should be the same? With that thought, I once showed the director a color design for Momoka that was almost the same color as Ringo.

But that was wrong (laugh).

The moment I called the director to show him and displayed Ringo-colored Momoka on my monitor, before the director could speak, I was convinced "This is wrong!" (laugh). Originally Ringo is not Momoka - she's a separate personality, so for that we needed to properly prepare different colors to construct Momoka. Once that was clear, the discussion was quick. If I switched my thinking, the visual goal naturally became clear. So the director and I quickly decided on the spot, and that became that Momoka.

Incidentally, while I personally thought "I wonder?" I asked the director just to be sure.

"Momoka, what about her hair?"

"Peach color!"

Ah, as expected (laugh).

Speaking of reveals, the fact that the subway was actually a monorail was also a reveal in Episode 13. At the very beginning, when preparation for

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started, that subway was planned to be drawn much, much more. We had Shibata create lots and lots of idea sketches for station platforms and ticket gate areas, planning to properly create such scenes... but one day the director's single word "Let's stop!" flipped everything (laugh). Shibata was stunned, but indeed, drawing that subway surroundings in an SF-like way ultimately wasn't needed for

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.

There are various things in flashback scenes too.

About those KIGA apples conspicuously (laugh) piled on top of the entryway shoe cabinet - I probed the director during direction meetings saying "Is this okay? Is this

alright?" but I couldn't get a particularly clear answer and it was passed through (laugh).

Also, the public security detective visiting the Takakura house - the woman is wearing red nail polish, which I believe was Director Ichimura's instruction. Ichimura wanted it to be more flashy red, but I said "If it's too flashy, wouldn't she look like a fake detective?" so we settled on that more subdued feeling.

The hotel where the brothers were taken - the exterior is the Keio Plaza Hotel in West Shinjuku, but for that cut showing the exterior, they used reference photos I had taken. The clouds flowing in the sky behind the hotel are exactly the atmosphere from the photos (laugh). Obviously I couldn't photograph inside the hotel, so I had one beer in the lounge and left. Then from there I went to the sound studio in Shin-Okubo. It was the day of my first appearance on "Secret Penguindrum."

Now, Episode 13's biggest worry was actually the fried chicken that appeared at the dinner table in the flashback scene. Fried chicken... no matter what we did, it didn't look like fried chicken (laugh). Why? This is an unfortunate story for the animator, but it was an animation problem. If the animation doesn't properly create that form, no matter how much you fiddle with the colors, it still won't look like that (wry laugh). Fried chicken can only achieve fried chicken texture through distinguishing between chicken skin parts and other soft parts in the drawing, and as someone who loves fried chicken, I tried processing it as much as possible, but it went to broadcast with mortifying feelings. Incidentally, for Blu-ray & DVD we corrected that part first. From the animation stage, of course (laugh).

And from Episode 13 the ending changed. That story will be next time.

Continued in Episode 189

(12.07.17)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 189:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 16

Congratulations! Magazine "Anime Style 001."

I actually received it from the editorial department. Last year's "Anime Style" issues 1-6 were dense, but wow, this new inaugural issue is dense too. And packed with

The Wolf Children Ame and Yuki

(■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■) (laugh). Ah, I can't read this without seeing it in theaters first!

So (laugh), I snuck out of work and immediately went to see the movie

The Wolf Children Ame and Yuki

in theaters.

Man, it was really a "movie." Wonderful! Amazing! Ah, precisely because it's such a difficult theme, this is something that can only be achieved through animation! Such a work. Magnificent! I want Director Hosoda to keep making movies vigorously like this!

Everyone please definitely go to the theaters! I want to see it again somewhere myself!

Now then.

From Episode 13 the ending became new. The songs are ARB masterpiece covers sung by Triple H. Of course, arranged by Hashimoto Yukari! The new ending wouldn't be fixed to one song, but would decide which song to use based on each episode's main story content and tension. So the first Episode 13 used "Gray Wednesday." This song was ultimately used three times.

This time's ending was created under photography direction. First the director explained the concept to Graphinica's Horiuchi, and had him create a template video. We created each episode by modifying that template according to the songs used and content. The floating stars, apples, and red threads were all created with 3D and photography.

My work was color direction for Nakamura Akiko's animation (Princess Himari + Double H) and supervision of the overall ending color tone. Content checks each time were the director, Akiko, and myself. While watching each episode's ending video from Horiuchi, we'd give correction orders about timing and color tone, and

have them reflected.

In the previous ending I handled coloring too, painting colors myself while continuously modifying to create the image, but this time since I had no time due to main story design work and retake processing management, I urgently asked color director Otsuka to handle Princess Himari + Double H coloring.

"Actually, I really wanted to paint Nakamura's Double H!" said Otsuka. Ah, that's right! We finishing people really want to paint good animation artwork, favorite art styles! Despite making an impossible request with so little time, Otsuka carefully and magnificently painted it.

Then we applied line processing and texture brushes to that coloring data for photography. Inserting that completed the ending almost entirely. The initially completed movie had a red background version as the master. For Episode 13, since we were using "Gray Wednesday," we had them make the background gray. Furthermore, in Episode 16 we made the background blue and really went wild with various additions to match the song (laugh).

The boy's hand that appears at the ending's end - "make one side a silhouette" was the director's instruction. It's not about which hand belongs to whom, but for visual balance we made the right side silhouette-like.

So, if the ending became new, maybe the opening too? (sweat) But with delays in main story work, the production site was quite at capacity, and honestly the situation was "Well, it'd be impossible for the site, right?" The director himself said "The opening is the 'face,' so I don't want to change it."

...However, one day suddenly, "Sorry! We're making a new opening after all!" said the director (laugh). What a sudden about-face!

Continued in Episode 190

(12.07.24)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 18: Once Upon a Time... (13) *Jem* and "Brown Carbon"

I took 10 days vacation. Not traveling anywhere, just living normal daily life in Tokyo, cleaning up the house and surroundings, repairing broken appliances.

Yesterday was disposing of videotapes from home. VHS tapes and - 8mm video!

When 8mm video first appeared, the picture quality was decent, and above all I was charmed by the small size of 8mm video tapes that took up so little space, so I suddenly became an "8mm video enthusiast" and recorded like crazy.

So there are tremendous amounts of videotapes at both home and my parents' house. But eventually 8mm video became a distant past thing too... Ah, it followed the same fate as

beta

,

Sony

(bitter laugh).

So I disposed of the home batch together, but most of it was movies, dramas, and anime broadcast on TV.

Now with movies and anime, when you want to watch them,

TSUTAYA

and other DVD rentals are well-stocked, so there's no need to keep old stuff. ...Or rather, the 8mm video VCR itself at home is already at the end of its life (cries).

Still, I excavated various treasures.

Special programs from "

Denpa Shonen

," the late-night broadcast

Whychoy Production

drama "

Johin Driver

" (laughs). These will also be gradually dubbed to HDD-DVD recorder (laughs).

Well then.

After the domestic theatrical works *GeGeGe no Kitaro: Yokai Daisenso* and *Hokuto no Ken: Seikimatsu Kyuseishu Densetsu* continued, my 1986 work was still mainly collaborative work.

That year I handled *Transformers*, *Muppet Babies*, *Glo Friends* (per-episode color direction and inspection for all), numerous collaborative work commercials, pilot films, and *Jem*.

This work features a

BAND

of four girls named "

Jem

, " "

Shana

, " "

Kimber

, " and "

Aja

" (though they're about 20?) as protagonists.

They tour worldwide performing, getting into predicaments through various interference from rival band led by "

Pizzazz

, " but somehow get through it every time (laughs).

I was assigned to handle this work.

Well, ultimately, from Episode 4 onward, all color-related work would be handed over completely to subcontracting production companies, but those initial 3 episodes were tough again.

Being a girls' band story, naturally there were 2-3 costume changes per episode. Naturally around the eyes were sharp eyeliner and eyeshadow. All naturally color trace. And what was most difficult - this work was a "

brown carbon

" work.

Back then, we used "trace machines" to transfer in-between animation to cels.

The mechanism was almost the same as "

Print Gocco

." Line drawings (in-between animation) drawn on paper were heat-transferred to cels from the back side using special carbon paper. This carbon was actually troublesome.

Regular anime works were produced using "black" carbon.

But depending on work content and nature, sometimes non-black colored carbon paper was used. Mechanically, different carbon colors meant different transferred main line colors. There were several so-called "

color carbons

" - "red," "white," "blue," "green," etc., and one of those colors was "brown." For soft-toned works or to make female character outline main lines look softer, this "brown carbon" was very effective. So it was perfect for

Jem

. But this "brown carbon" had a big problem.

When transferring with trace machines, only main lines transfer, but naturally untransferred areas are also heated while covered by carbon paper.

As a result, oil from the carbon paper faintly sticks to areas without lines. This was a major problem. Water-based cel paints are water-based, so literally water and oil. The paint would be beautifully repelled.

This was what I heard from sales staff at

Josai Duplo

, which handled trace machines and dedicated carbon paper exclusively back then - compared to regular "black carbon," "color carbons" had lighter colors, making them technically difficult to manufacture. They couldn't achieve the clean sharpness of "black carbon" when transferred, plus oil adhesion increased.

Incidentally, due to that "manufacturing technical difficulty," unit costs were several yen higher than black carbon, about 25-26 yen per sheet I think.

Despite higher unit costs, there were many product precision inconsistencies - when good, oil adhesion was almost as little as "black carbon," but that was actually rare. When bad, it was thoroughly terrible (explosion).

And this

Jem

launch period was directly hit by that "bad period" (bitter laugh).

So finishing work was difficult.

"Brown carbon" itself had already been used for

Muppet Babies

and

Glo Friends

, but those had rounded characters without much shadowing, so we could somehow manage. But this

Jem

was a shadowed work with lots of detailed color divisions - facial makeup, costumes, instruments, etc. Plus color trace. With solid line color divisions, you could somehow place paint hooking onto those carbon lines, but with color trace, painted surfaces had no grip - just pure paint repelling.

Furthermore, compared to "black carbon," in-between animation didn't transfer cleanly, so transferred lines were thin or broken, often requiring careful trace correction before painting.

Therefore, to transfer more solidly, trace machine heating time was set slightly longer, but if slightly too strong, "burning" would occur in areas without lines, creating faint carbon stains. Painting without noticing these stains would paint over the dirt, resulting in NG. With moderate dirt and darker colored paints, it wasn't very noticeable and helped, but this

Jem

had lots of bright, light colors, causing unplanned brown gradations on hair and costumes, leading to retakes.

The countermeasure was wiping each piece with alcohol or some weak chemical before painting (bitter laugh).

Hmm.

Speaking of which, in the theatrical *Transformers* I mentioned earlier, there was a female robot character, and only this character was processed with "brown carbon" while regular robots (using "black carbon") had different trace machine settings for each carbon type in the same in-between animation, so they couldn't be transferred at once - quite difficult.

As a further aside, later when I did *Sailor Moon S Movie*, the appearing Snow Queen and snow fairy (?) used "blue" and "white" carbons.

But these colors had transparent main lines that were overpowered by painted paints, making lines invisible. So we actually layered another cel with just color carbon traced lines over the actually painted cel for photography.

Due to such circumstances, changing main line colors was quite risky back then.

With current digital painting, changing main line colors to create works is normal (laughs). This

Jem

would probably become something interesting if remade with today's technology.

Now, amid such "collaborative work" days, I was assigned a new work. A domestic work - and a TV series!

Saturday night 7 PM golden time broadcast! The character sheets and storyboard cover handed to me had the large title

Saint Seiya

* written on it.

##

■Continues to Episode 19

(07.06.12)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 190:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 17

"■London, London, your London~" Huh? There used to be a commercial like that, right? It somehow stuck in my ear so I ended up writing it, but what commercial was that exactly? (sweat) National? Tokyo local? Hmm...

Well, anyway, it's the London Olympics (laugh).

Whether summer or winter, what I look forward to every Olympics is the opening ceremony. Man, that's amazing. It's a grand show created by requesting famous artists and directors to direct it, staking the nation's prestige. For us making anime, it's must-see. Especially for us color-related people, it's must-see. The various spatial and color direction performances unfolding three-dimensionally in that vast space - man, it's very educational every time!

Even for individual competitions, the arrangement and color schemes of various things in the venues, the art design is worth watching too. The unified design sense maintained throughout the entire event. Not just "Go Japan!" but I try to watch the Olympics with such a perspective.

Oh yes, compared to the previous Beijing Olympics, this London event feels like the overall coloring design is put together more chic. Ah, that's national character, or regional differences - hmm, interesting.

Oh, and go for it! Japan!

Now then.

So we

Penguindrum

site staff ended up making a new opening after all, but schedule-wise starting from Episode 13 was definitely impossible! So when content-wise would it be okay to make it new? After all, the opening is the program's face. To change that face, there really needs to be appropriate timing. Originally Episode 13, switching from first to second half, would be one timing, but well, we couldn't make that deadline, so when would the next timing be?

So, we ultimately decided to make the new opening from Episode 15! That timing was probably the last timing. So we rushed into work toward that goal.

But before that, Episode 14.

Episode 14: "Lying Princess"

Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiro & Yamazaki Mitsue, Direction/Yamazaki Mitsue,
Color Direction/Akimoto Yuki

Ringo, whose relationship with Shoma has become strained, thinks about somehow recovering their relationship, but Shoma's reaction is cold, and she sinks to the bottom of despair. Tokikago Yuri approaches her. Taking Ringo into her private car, she plans a hot spring trip for just the two of them. Yuri and Ringo, and when their feelings have quite opened up that night, Yuri mysteriously approaches Ringo to make her hers. Such was Episode 14.

Anyway, I think Episode 14 was shocking in various ways for everyone watching weekly (grin).

This Episode 14 - what was difficult in various ways first was Yuri's car. Of course a foreign car, a Jaguar. This used 3DCG entirely. I think we purchased a ready-made 3D model and used that as the base. Since "there's no one among current rough animation forces who can draw mecha, it'd be impossible," we had no plans to draw automobiles with animation from the beginning. The truck speeding through rain in Episode 5 was also 3DCG, based on the same thinking. Not only is it difficult to do with animation, but there are actually many failures, so when you think about it, this kind of thing should be 3DCG!

For that car, what first concerned us was its texture. If you place it on screen with a look that's too realistically 3D, the worldview breaks at that moment. So "how much 3D-ness would be okay?" was an important point to explore. How much 3D-ness would be acceptable was really a matter of our sensory balance. So rather than super-smooth glossy 3D, we requested adjustment from the start toward cel-shading that brought the atmosphere closer to animation. Then it was a matter of how much to adjust that degree.

So, for that exterior car body color tone, this decision was quite difficult. Actually, I wanted to make this car "champagne gold." In my mind, Tokikago Yuri's image was somehow "champagne gold," so I really wanted to make this car champagne gold. "Champagne gold" is quite difficult to do with regular animation, and I felt like we couldn't create or show the subtle color reflections beautifully, so ah, with 3DCG we could probably do it properly and beautifully.

However, this didn't go as smoothly as I thought.

When we focused on properly expressing the "champagne gold" feeling and built up the surface texture, it inevitably became a floating presence on screen. Also, the stronger we made the shading for balance with animation, the more it just looked like a cream-colored painted body. In this way, I asked 3D staff Kaneko to

work hard on adjustments many, many times, but we couldn't get that decisive "this is it!" and only time passed. So we decided on the red body that had been prepared as a backup plan. It was honestly a last-minute decision due to insufficient work time. Ugh, disappointing!

So, the red car.

For the scene of that car driving at night on the Metropolitan Expressway, we leaned the 3D expression somewhat excessively toward realism, with reflections of Metropolitan Expressway lighting and such. As I wrote earlier, considering compatibility with animation, we had 3D as cel-shading, but for this scene rather, the realistic direction would better match Yuri's emotional state, so we deliberately did that.

Incidentally, while the exterior is completely a 3D model, for the car interior we had 3D provide layout and had rough animation drawn according to that guide. In other words, hybrid animation. Additionally, we had it nicely built up with special effects.

Like that Metropolitan Expressway scene, this episode basically created each scene matching the spatial brightness and color tone. Hotel guest rooms, open-air baths, hot spring ping-pong, dining scenes in guest rooms - I built up color tone and brightness for each to match the background lighting conditions.

The theater scene before the opening was based on Episode 7's cuts and processing, adding even more. By this point in the episode count, there were many scenes in the same places used previously, and for such scenes we aimed for labor savings by using layouts from previously appearing cuts as much as possible at the storyboard stage, and using the same backgrounds when possible. With background art of such content volume, the work burden every episode was considerable, and moreover the art team's available time was being gradually shaved due to animation schedule delays. But this labor-saving was simultaneously a very useful technique for "imprinting" scenes and places.

Now, the problem nudity (laugh).

This time's director was Assistant Director Yamazaki Mitsue, who calls herself "Penguindrum's ero person in charge" (true story (laugh)). A-part's Yuri, B-part's hot springs and rooms. Man, what can I say (laugh). Especially the B-part hot spring inn was Animation Director Ishii Kumi's part if I remember correctly, and it was really good - I was quite excited while creating the screen (laugh).

Create the atmosphere to the limit but don't show. Under such tacit understanding, this episode also didn't show to the limit (laugh). That's also why there was the towel wrap in the open-air bath. Certainly, in actual hot springs you shouldn't enter the bath with a towel wrapped, but well, that's how it is.

For the final bedroom passage after the mysterious atmosphere began, I created colors with two things in mind: first, make the skin look beautiful, and second, create mysterious tension on screen as a "hook" to the next episode. Initially thinking "make skin beautiful," I created and shot color tones that showed skin color fairly directly, but it became too raw and I couldn't create the scene well. So after all rushes I had it retaken, creating shadow colors with purple mixed in. I searched for just the right purple feeling for the bedroom's blue space, actually painted it in the cut, and finally completed the decision. Those are that scene's color tones.

"Rather than blending with the screen, make it clearly red, bright red with a sharp impact!" These were words I said to color director Akimoto during the color direction meeting. "This will decide this episode (laugh)." It was explaining the cut where naked Yuri mysteriously goes "sharp!" with the red cord (laugh).

Continued in Episode 191

(12.07.31)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 191:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 18

The newly redesigned Web Anime Style. One day Oguro-san said "We'd like to add a cover illustration to this column." "Hmm, should I draw pictures like other writers? Ah, but that's somehow different for me (laugh)." So I thought about it a bit and submitted a rough idea saying "How about something like this?" The designer skillfully put it together into that cover illustration.

The color chart-style design used in the background is actually a real color chart (laugh). Since we can't make color models for all coloring specifications (like dust cloud color specifications or minor prop color specifications), we use color charts like this for color direction input. This chart is one I made myself, and I use it for almost all works where I'm in charge of design. I add modifications each time to match the work's content and color tone tendencies.

Making color charts is quite fun, but once you start, it takes an incredible amount of time. It's fun and you forget time passing and get absorbed, to the point where it interferes with other work (laugh). So it's troublesome because I sometimes want to play with color charts as a form of escapism (laugh).

Now then.

Episode 15: The One Who Saves the World

Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiro & Shibata Katsunori, Direction/Shibata Katsunori, Color Direction/Mizuno Taeko (■■■■■)

Ringo, caught in Yuri's trap, about to have this and that and even such things done to her. But then, unexpectedly Shoma appears! Not exactly dashing - he trips, hits his head, and faints. Yuri is somewhat exasperated, but her thoughts turn to her young days, meeting Momoka, and the days they spent together. And aiming for the other half of the diary that such a Yuri possesses, Masako had infiltrated the inn. Such was Episode 15.

Actually, Episode 15 was the important episode that tells the core of Momoka's mystery. Momoka appearing in Yuri's childhood dominated by her father's twisted affection. And Yuri's flashback story of being liberated by Momoka's "ability." The first surprise of such Episode 15 was the "David Statue Tower" (laugh).

This David Statue Tower was originally made with 3DCG. We also bought a ready-made David statue 3D model, output it to background rough drawings

according to layout, and since using the 3D model as-is would float too much on screen, we had art add retouching and photography blend it in. But initially this didn't go well and was quite difficult. What was difficult was expressing that size and building-like feeling. This "David Statue Tower" is about Tokyo Tower height in the story, but just normally placing it on background and blending it didn't quite convey the sense of a gigantic building.

Well, it's a David statue after all. If this moved around like in robot shows, size expression would be easy, but this is a tower and building so it doesn't move, and it shouldn't move (laugh). If that building-like quality doesn't come out naturally, the screen lacks persuasiveness. We tried flying helicopters from the tower's back to front, but somehow it didn't work well.

For example, using many cuts to finely depict the statue's surface details in close-up, looking up from the feet with upward angle layouts, properly showing comparisons with something - if we piled up several such cuts we could certainly express height, size, and building-like texture, but there's no need to single out this tower and deliberately show it by layering cuts like that. We just wanted it to be there naturally in the landscape, casually without discomfort (laugh).

So at some meeting attempt, I suddenly thought "How about adding 'windows' like observation decks?" Buildings are indeed about windows. This conveyed the size of space where people exist inside the tower, so both size and building feeling were perfect. The texture as an artificial structure tower was established.

Incidentally, the new tower (Tokyo Tower) brought by "fate transfer" also uses a 3D model.

So from that opening with the David Statue Tower surprise in the past flashback, another surprise was, well, that father (laugh). For all atelier scenes I thought to create a slight sense of unreality, having photography apply strong diffusion to characters and strongly create a color bleeding feeling. Particularly in the opening evening atelier scene, against the yellow-toned western sunlight background, I applied pink~purple shadow colors to characters to create a mad atmosphere. I wanted to properly make an impression of this father's madness here, and I think we successfully created it.

On the other hand, scenes with Momoka rather built up quiet color usage matter-of-factly matching spatial brightness. Particularly the scene telling of the diary and "fate transfer" under the afterglow after sunset, combined with that quiet, repetitive, shuddering music, is personally a quietly favorite scene of mine.

Oh yes, in the world with the David Statue Tower, in flashback scenes there are no Ping marks throughout the city. Not limited to this episode's flashback, in characters' distant past flashbacks it's like that. Did you notice?

Now, in the actual timeline it's the hospital and hot spring inn.

For the hot spring inn, the dark room tones of Yuri and Ringo's room - I created three types divided by scene content. The first half aimed for that mysterious atmosphere with purple-like color tones, and after Shoma bursts in I created more normal-like color tones to strengthen reality feeling. In the scene with Masako dressed as an inn attendant, I created atmosphere with blue-toned colors to match the expression of quietly listening to Masako's story in the sliding door shadows, and in the scene where Shoma wakes up after everything ends, I deliberately made it brighter with normal color tone balance to create a relieved feeling of conclusion. Except for the initial mysterious atmosphere scene, the background art brightness and color tone are basically the same, but I created these impressions through differences in character color tones. Creating colors, this kind of thing is fun (laugh).

I forgot to write this last time, but there's a convenience store bag casually placed in front of the safe in the inn guest room. When I asked Director Yamazaki "What's this?" she said "Ah, that's an 'overnight set.' Ringo bought it!" Ah, I see! This is truly the perspective of a female director, I thought!

Now clearly revealed this time are Momoka's diary secrets, but here's another secret revelation! The pages where Momoka's diary is written were actually production assistant Kagaya's responsibility. Following text content created by Director Ikuhara and Assistant Director Yamazaki, Kagaya handwrote it. All the illustrations are also Kagaya's hand-drawn work (laugh). We had him quickly write things during busy intervals, then had photography paste them in as-is.

So for this diary, we thought up content for only the pages needed for main story scenes each time and had Kagaya write them each time. Occasionally when other pages were unexpectedly needed on screen, we'd frantically think up text and order from Kagaya - this happened many times (laugh). Since we were making the diary in such an ad-hoc way (!), we didn't have text & illustrations for a full diary volume. Ah, thinking about it now, if we had properly made a full volume, we could have sold it as merchandise (laugh). There were surely many people who would have wanted it!

Even so, Yamashita-kun is mysterious. Why did he invite Shoma to the hot springs? Mysterious, right? Suspicious, right.

Continued in Episode 192

(12.08.07)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 192: Summer Vacation 1970

When this manuscript is updated, it'll probably be around the Obon period. By then the London Olympics will be over, and while gently soaking in that afterglow, everyone will be doing hometown visits or summer vacation trips, perhaps? Summer vacation like that. This week is a summer vacation special, so "

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes" is taking a break (laugh).

Now then.

Since both my wife and I were born and raised in Tokyo, our household doesn't have major events like "hometown visits." Furthermore, I had no "countryside experience" as a boy, and in elementary school I was somewhat envious when classmates would go play in the "countryside." Oh, come to think of it, I asked my mother "Why don't we have a countryside?" - this was when I was in lower elementary school.

During elementary school, my summer vacation in Tokyo's Nakano was morning glories, radio calisthenics, school pool, and morning anime.

First, waking up at 6 AM. "Which ones bloomed this morning?" Our house grew many varieties of morning glories in pots every year, and seeing different colored flowers bloom each morning was incredibly enjoyable. Our house's morning glories were mainly large-flowered varieties. For many long years, we properly collected seeds every year, organized them in small bags with notes (like "Purple large-flowered variegated"), and the following year we'd plant seeds at the right time for summer morning enjoyment.

After making the rounds of the veranda morning glories, I'd go to the nearby middle school grounds. NHK radio calisthenics started at 6:30. There was a "radio calisthenics card" that hung from your neck on a string, and you'd get stamps after doing calisthenics each day. It was somehow mandated by the neighborhood association until July 31st - about 10 days from the start of summer vacation - and if you had perfect attendance you'd get something commemorative. A pencil or notebook or something. The reason it was just July from the beginning of summer vacation was probably a measure to make children maintain regular lives during vacation. Radio calisthenics continued in the middle school grounds throughout summer vacation after August 1st too, but I never went (laugh). I was probably getting up fairly early, but why? I never went (laugh).

Then I'd return for breakfast. And help with cleaning as my mother instructed. When finished it was usually 9 o'clock.

I don't know how elementary schools are now, but in our era, school pools were open to students during summer vacation. Ah, "open" is misleading. There were schedules like "pool classes" roughly 1-2 hours each, morning and afternoon, I think organized by every two grades - not exactly classes but loosely like that. I'd go to school flip-flopping in beach sandals with swim trunks, bath towel, and swimming cap (!) in a vinyl bag.

Honestly I didn't really like pools (laugh). Sure it'd be cool if you could swim, but I thought it was fine if you couldn't swim (laugh), but somehow on pool days going to the pool became top priority, so I'd flip-flop my way there.

There was another reason I somehow didn't want to go to that school pool. Actually, when there was pool in the morning, I couldn't watch morning anime.

Back then in Tokyo during summer vacation weekday mornings, from about 10 o'clock for an hour or hour and a half, they'd show anime reruns. Current TV Asahi was broadcasting them quite actively. "Summer Vacation Children's Theater" or something like that. Dubbed American anime like

Wacky Races

,

Tom Thumb

,

King Kong

,

Dora Dora Kitten and Chaka Chaka Girl

,

Super Three

. And Japanese ones like

Sally the Witch

,

Secret Akko-chan

,

Flower's Pyun Pyun Maru

. They kept showing such things.

This was really my enjoyment. Not just summer vacation, but winter and spring breaks had anime programming too, but winter and spring breaks are unfortunately short. So depending on the work, broadcasts would naturally end partway through. Well, programming-wise they were broadcasting as "masterpiece selections," but we wanted to watch everything! So summer vacation with its long broadcast period was quite high points!

Regardless of summer vacation, each broadcasting station had anime rerun slots in evening hours too, but since you could watch anime from morning (AM), that was really happy!

So to watch anime during that time without getting complaints from parents, I'd properly finish daily studies and summer vacation workbooks beforehand, then settle in front of the TV fully prepared (laugh). Thanks more to morning anime than early morning radio calisthenics, I was able to live regularly during summer vacation - such were my elementary school days (laugh).

Incidentally, what was I doing in the afternoons? I was chasing cicadas with a bug-catching net (laugh). Since store-bought bug nets don't reach very high places, I'd extend the pole myself and catch cicadas crying high up on tree trunks. In the evenings I'd water the garden plants while getting mosquito bites, and about once a week we'd do fireworks at night (laugh). Our household didn't go to beaches, had no "countryside" visits, no summer vacation trips, but I still got quite tanned.

Ah, it's an old man's past flashback (laugh). Happy memories, good recollections.

What kind of summer vacation lives do today's elementary students have? Since my wife and I don't have children, I don't really understand that part. Ah, now there are probably active extracurricular activities like soccer? Or cram school attendance? Compared to my childhood there are probably many more fun things, but still, I think summer vacation should broadcast anime for elementary students every morning!

Continued in Episode 193

(12.08.14)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 194:

Mawaru Penguindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 19

The so-called Obon vacation is over, the earth was subtly saved again this year by "24-Hour TV," and ah, the feeling that summer is finally ending is becoming palpable. The days have gotten shorter too... At night you can hear autumn insect sounds here and there... but ah no no, cicadas are still energetic in Tokyo's Nakano (laugh). During this last weekend of August as I write this, around my house they're still having grand choruses day after day - or rather night after night.

Those guys seem to conserve energy by staying quiet in tree shade during the intensely hot daytime hours, start crying around evening when the sun sets, and it's "showtime!" after midnight when temperatures drop (laugh). Such is this still swelteringly hot end of summer. But you know, even these cicadas' summer is almost over. In less than a month we'll reach the autumn equinox - such is summer's end.

Oh! Are students doing summer homework assignments around now? (laugh)

Now then.

Episode 16: The Immortal Man

Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiro, Kaneko Shingo & Furukawa Tomohiro,
Direction/Kaneko Shingo, Color Direction/Otsuka Natsuko

The half of the diary that Masako finally obtained is a bright red fake planted by Yuri. And Masako begins telling her own past story. Memories? Conflict? with her fearsome grandfather Sahei. The curse of that grandfather's ghost. Such was Episode 16.

In the middle of the story, right in the thick of this serious development, it was an unexpected "gag episode." I received the storyboard, read it, and burst out laughing! But you can't have "embarrassment" in this kind of gag episode. You have to properly commit fully to the gag parts as gags, or it tends to become a half-hearted disappointing result. So we made the content even denser in the direction meeting (laugh). Oh yes, direction was by Kaneko. For performing weird things, this is definitely the person!

But actually, Episode 16 was a very important episode content-wise. While diverting attention with gags, young Kanba appears wearing a KIGA-marked trainer, part of Masako and Kanba's past relationship is revealed, Masako's father

actually went "somewhere," and various truths and new mysteries were scattered throughout. Yes.

Now, Episode 16's protagonist, Masako's grandfather Old Man Sahei. From the beginning we decided "it's better not to show his face," and like the "authority figure" who appeared in Episode 7's "Ringo's fantasy about Yuri," we decided to paste paper in front of his face. I think this came up when we were vaguely discussing settings with the director and Kaneko. So for the text on the paper pasted to his face, since there were many cuts this time, we decided to prepare proper materials and ask photography to paste them in.

Proper materials... Right, we decided to paste something properly written with calligraphy brush! We wanted a gorgeous feeling of truly having power. So I believe we asked a calligrapher through someone on staff's connections. Hmm? Was it someone's mother? Well, while "Grandfather" for Sahei was one thing, I wonder what the person who wrote "Mango" for the Asian hostesses at the cabaret was imagining about how it would be used? (laugh)

Sahei's paste-ins weren't just the "Grandfather" text, but also all the Natsume family crests on his haori were pasted in by photography. Furthermore, the family crest birthmark that appeared on his left shoulder skin was the same. The family crest birthmark was another mystery - I noticed it had been drawn in the setting, and when I asked "Eh? Is this okay?" Kaneko and the director said "Yeah, it's okay!" Hmm, I thought it might not be necessary (the work is difficult, and actually quite a few photography retakes resulted), but now I can't imagine Sahei without the family crest birthmark.

There was always a somewhat bothersome white foreigner next to Sahei speaking English excessively, but who exactly he was was never explained in the main story (laugh). Actually he was set as "Sahei's overseas friend," and was quite an important (?) existence that Sahei kept close (probably living together in the mansion). Incidentally, my initial character image was Carlos Rivera's manager from

Tomorrow's Joe 2

. I finished him with Central/South American skin and hair color, but gahaha (laugh), he looked way too similar and we had a big laugh, but since "it's conversely hard to tell (laugh)" he became a normal blonde white person (laugh).

Character-wise, oh yes, Renjaku! I attacked with a cobalt blue bra like this was my moment. Yes. This is my taste (laugh). From when I first met this Renjaku, she must be wearing a cobalt blue bra! (laugh) Man, that was exactly right, wasn't it? There must be quite a few people whose hearts were grabbed by this Renjaku in this episode!

Now, color-wise, I asked color director Otsuka for lots this time too. Things without proper settings, like Sahei's costume changes - golf wear, fishing old man look, sushi chef look, etc. Also young Masako's various disguises. For such scenes that matched the rough animation, I had Otsuka create almost all the colors.

And, after all, what can I say - the fugu sashimi!

I've only eaten fugu sashimi about 4 times in my life, but I remember it being "translucent" (laugh). Looking at reference photos it seemed like that too, so "we have to make it translucent." Anticipating that translucent feeling, I first had Otsuka create colors, then threw that to special effects' Yamada for processing. But story-wise, with quite a few cuts of fugu sashimi appearing, processing each one individually would be quite difficult. So we processed one cut of fugu sashimi from a nearly overhead angle and reused that for multiple cuts. We had photography paste it in at different angles, or I forcibly drew additional parts. We couldn't fully process the cut where chopsticks sweep it up, but the animation momentum made it feel OK!

Such was the "fugu sashimi" we all worked hard on (laugh).

But you know, if you're going to put "fugu sashimi" and such in the main story, well, you need realism, so research is necessary! Experience is key in anime making! You really have to actually eat it! Even just that "translucency" - real experience is necessary!! So when I work on anime featuring "fugu sashimi" next time, I must convince the higher-ups and definitely go "research" it with related staff! I thought this very, very strongly (laugh).

Continued in Episode 195

(12.08.28)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 195:

Mawaru Penguinindrum

Color Design Notes - Part 20

There used to be a TV commercial that went "Baldness begins to show, hair is a long friend," and I'm actually facing such feelings myself. Good grief (sweat). While my hairline has been gradually receding over recent years, these past few months - or rather, this summer - my hair has suddenly thinned considerably. Crisis of capitulation before 50! Good grief, good grief (major sweat).

Actually, I seem to have several spots of alopecia areata, but the thinning of my front hair is probably age-related hair loss and balding. Hmm, to think the day would come when I'd think about various things over such matters (wry laugh). Well, considering the baldness of my father's side brothers, I could have predicted this to some degree. Truly hereditary, blood will tell (laugh). Even so, father held out until the end.

Now, when it comes to this, what suddenly becomes concerning are words like "hair thickening" and "hair transplants." And TV commercials (laugh). Man, when you pay attention, there are really all kinds! I'm newly surprised by such technology! Particularly that adhesive-like thing that can attach hair anywhere. When it gets to that point it's like special makeup (laugh).

Well, whether I'll take some measures in the future is still unclear (laugh), but it's getting quite noteworthy!

Now then.

Episode 17: The Unforgiven

Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiro, Nakamura Akiko & Aizawa Masahiro (■■■■■),
Direction/Nakamura Akiko & Aizawa Masahiro, Color Direction/Akimoto Yuki

The Takakura brothers have a takoyaki party, bringing complete equipment and ingredients to the hospital room to feed hospitalized Himari takoyaki. Meanwhile, Tabuki and Yuri each confirm their respective feelings for Momoka. Himari and Ringo sneak out of the hospital room to search for yarn for a secret present. In the underground, a death match unfolds between Masako VS Yuri. And Himari and Ringo are kidnapped by Tabuki. Such was Episode 17.

Finally Episode 17 filled with such premonitions that the story would begin moving significantly. Episode 17 had two directors. Nakamura handled the first half, Aizawa the second half. Episode 17 became packed with various meanings.

First, the first half opening takoyaki part.

Sudden splatter scene (laugh). The wonderful realistic feeling is excellent! That animation of the penguins' struggles, pressing the knife firmly against the cutting board to cut the elastic octopus legs - incredible! (laugh) Furthermore, #3 (Penguin #3) throws those... ah, what do you call them? Those pick-like things for flipping takoyaki, at the octopus going "Bish! Bish!" like "Deadly! Executioner." That series was animation by Nishigaki if I remember correctly, and for me it was among the top 5 good animation scenes in

Mawaru Penguindrum

! Since I quite like that kind of realism, I was happy watching the rushes!

This work's "life" is "making food look delicious," so we put considerable effort into the takoyaki. The only regret is that we couldn't create a cut of bonito flakes dancing on hot takoyaki (laugh). I wanted to make thin-shaved bonito flakes flutter around in 3D, but schedule-wise and otherwise it was definitely impossible (laugh).

The Crystal World scene continuing from the hospital room scene showed serious, anxiety-filled screens, completely different from the bright, even somewhat comical depictions we'd shown before. To express the "shadow" beginning to fall on the relationship between Himari (Princess) and Kanba, both characters and space are put together with special color usage. Hearing the changed space image from Nakamura, I took Crystal space PSD data output by layers from photography, changed colors myself, and assembled it. While first solidifying the space image, I adjusted by adding character color tones that had formed in my head in parallel, then sent it to photography. Adding bleeding and such to create spatial depth completed it.

I may have written this before, but in

Mawaru Penguindrum

, for the second half, I was thinking of clearly changing character main line (outline) colors from the usual black ones for scenes depicting characters' inner worlds. So this Crystal World Princess = Kanba scene also changes main lines to blue tones. While such story developments were suppressed in the first cour, the ratio increases dramatically in the second half.

Another highlight of Episode 17's first half was the scene between Tabuki and Yuri unfolding while viewing the night scene.

A quiet scene in the light of the night scene outside the window with room lighting turned off. In this scene I synchronized the yellow color tone of Tokyo Tower's night scene lighting with the slightly sparkling white wine color. Tabuki and Yuri drinking with a glass prepared for Momoka. The composition of Tabuki, Yuri, and

Tokyo Tower (Momoka) between them. As the brightest, most eye-catching "color" in this room space, and as something connecting the three, I matched the white wine color they're drinking with the night scene Tokyo Tower. For cuts where Tokyo Tower reflects in the wine bottle and cuts where Tokyo Tower is visible beyond the bottle, I went into the photography studio and worked with Photography Director Ogihara to create them. I wanted to create a feeling of the bottle softly embracing Tokyo Tower.

Now, the second half, B-part. "Yozawaya" - "Yozawaya." Of course the source is Yuzawaya (laugh). We had Osakabe create Yozawaya-related logo designs and pasted them all over paper bags and yarn ball labels. This became an important part creating that good realistic feeling.

In the story, the scene where Kanba talks by phone with Shoma on the street in front of Ikebukuro Station's Seibu exit. Here Kanba says "I'll try going to Yozawaya," but this was the director's misunderstanding. The director mistakenly thought there was a Yuzawaya in Ikebukuro too (incidentally, what was in Ikebukuro was Kinkado. But that Kinkado is already gone). This was discovered during the direction meeting, but "Well, it's fine. There's a Yozawaya in Ikebukuro too!" (laugh) There's no reason to trace things that precisely (laugh).

I took photos of Ikebukuro Seibu exit and a certain electronics retailer near Shinjuku Ogado for animation reference. Like Episode 13's hotel exterior, since directors and production were too busy to take photos, I went and took them! Actually, Ikebukuro Seibu exit would appear prominently in later episodes too, so I wanted to check location relationships and such.

So, the major battle unfolding in that Yozawaya underground parking garage! (laugh) Yuri's weapon is a Sunshine Opera Company logo crossbow, Masako has a red ball Gatling gun. I think Yuri's crossbow was set as "opera company props" (laugh). The red ball Gatling gun... is this KIGA-made? Natsume Foundation weapons division-made? (sweat)

Yuri's LOUIS VUITTON-style brand bag in this scene and the preceding store scene used Osakabe-made Yuri monograms pasted in. I think I did most of this series of paste-ins myself. I transformed and pasted them in Photoshop to match each movement frame. If done properly, this bag would require building a 3D model, and we didn't have that extra capacity, and having photography paste it in would be difficult, so it became my work.

In this way, by this time I wasn't just doing color design but everything I could do, all possible things. Participating in direction meetings to give opinions, ordering art boards, art meetings, doing color design, meeting with color directors, checking background completion with directors, processing completed coloring data, giving comprehensive retakes at all rushes, then immediately camping at photography

studios to manage retake photography traffic control until delivery. I was handling such situations every week.

Incidentally for Episode 17, editing was August 24th. Voice recording was the following week I believe. The storyboard came up right before editing, and editing and voice recording proceeded with storyboard photography. The direction meeting was the night of editing day. Then we immediately organized animation meetings, with art setting meetings three days after the direction meeting. Art meetings were September 16th. Photography meetings October 1st. All rushes on the 21st. Video editing delivery on the 25th, with retake rush command camping at photography from the 24th. Such was Episode 17.

From here on, such situations and rushes would continue every week until the final episode.

Continued in Episode 196

(12.09.11)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 19: Once Upon a Time... (14) *Saint Seiya* Part 1 - Conversation with Kubota-san

Last weekend was such intense summer sunshine that I wondered "Huh? Did the rainy season end?" So I went stargazing in the Okuchichibu mountains with friends from my high school astronomy club.

We met at JR Mitaka Station in the evening and drove west on the Chuo Expressway, chasing the sunset.

Getting off at Nirasaki and driving through mountains for an hour.

The location we reached had a great open view. About 10 cars of "star people" like us who came to see stars were already there, setting up telescopes as they pleased. We also waited for 2 more families in 2 cars to arrive before starting observation.

Since it was past new moon, there was no worry about moonlight, but high-altitude clouds kept flowing overhead, so unfortunately it didn't become a completely clear sky!

Still, the starry sky glimpsed through clear patches was superb - man, I saw the Milky Way after so long! After all, humans are best under big skies! It was a good change of pace.

One friend brought a 20cm telescope and showed us various celestial objects through it - man, this was great!

I found myself wanting a telescope for the first time in over 20 years (laughs). So when I got home, I immediately looked around various telescope manufacturer websites online...

Ah, but in my case, I don't have a driver's license.

Maybe that should come first (bitter laugh).

Well then.

The work title I was assigned was *Saint Seiya*.

"Hm?"

Saint Seiya

" Actually, I didn't know this work (bitter laugh). Back then (well, even now...) I wasn't reading much "

Weekly Shonen Jump

" (laughs). So hearing the title didn't really ring a bell. Then I got copies of the original source material and read it, thinking "Ah, so I'm doing this kind of thing."

Original:

Kurumada Masami

, Series Director:

Morishita Kozo

, Series Composition:

Koyama Takao

, Character Design:

Araki Shingo

and

Himeno Michi

, Art Design:

Kubota Tadao

.

What an incredibly impressive lineup.

Honestly, the excitement of being given a TV work and the worry of whether I could do properly among such amazing people (laughs). Most of all, I was excited about working with

Kubota-san

for art design!

Actually, I'm a huge fan of the art in theatrical *Galaxy Express 999* and *Farewell Galaxy Express 999*.

When they were released, I was a middle/high school student, and I was very moved by the excellence of those background arts - that's when I first learned the names

Mukuo Takashi

and

Kubota Tadao

from

Mukuo Studio

. The

Galaxy Express 999

art book published back then is still one of my treasures (laughs). Working with Kubota-san, whom I'd admired since childhood! That alone made me nervous.

Jumping ahead in the story, later during production of theatrical *Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods*, we set many special coloring scenes, so I visited Mukuo Studio in Ogikubo for detailed color meetings with art.

The meeting location was right behind

Mukuo-san

and

Kubota-san

's work desks, and throughout the meeting, Mukuo-san was facing his work desk. When the meeting ended, he smoothly turned his chair toward me saying "Finished? I'm having dinner, so eat with us." We talked about various things then, but man, I was so excited (laughs). I can't remember what we talked about at all. Incidentally, what we had then was delivered curry rice from a soba shop with green peas on top.

So, *Saint Seiya*.

As I wrote before, back then all character color design was color-directed by art designers. We'd make test-painted color samples with colors specified by art, check them with producers, directors, character designers, etc., and repaint if there were modifications. Same with

Saint Seiya

- I first test-painted main characters with color specifications from Kubota-san. At that character color decision meeting, I first met

Araki-san

and

Kubota-san

.

I've forgotten which room it was, but we spread all main character color sample cels on the central table and everyone stood around that table for the meeting.

Producer

Hatano-san

, CD

Morishita-san

, character designer

Araki-san

, art

Kubota-san

, production staff

Takeda-san

, plus TV station producers and director

Yamauchi-san

were probably also present. And me.

Now I often speak the most in meetings, but back then I was mostly just nervously watching

Hatano-san

and

Morishita-san

talk from the corner of the room.

What was checked then was probably the 5 Saints in regular clothes and

Cloth

-equipped forms, the 5 individual

Cloths

,

Saori-san

,

Shaina-san

,

Marin-san

, and

Cassius

appearing in #1.

The

Pope

,

Jabu

,

Ichi

, and other Bronze Saints weren't ready yet, I think.

"Mm. Well, it's probably like this," said

Morishita-san

after looking through everything.

The most important check in this meeting was the "

Saint Cloths (■■■)

" worn by the characters, but these actually came first from

Bandai

's toy design drawings, and we followed those to create animation color specifications. So basic colors and color divisions were mostly decided at that point. After making them into cels, it was fine-tuning based on color compatibility and balance with the protagonists' skin, hair, eyes, etc.

In the end, I think just

Saori-san

's hair highlight color and

Hyoga

's skin or hair color needed modification, with the rest being "OK."

Araki-san

's careful, careful examination of each color sample cel was impressive.

After the meeting, I finally had proper conversation with
Kubota-san

.

Kubota-san spoke in quiet tones:

"Well, basically I'll leave details to you. If you don't understand something, send me copies or call."

"Yes! Please take care of me."

That's all I remember of our conversation (laughs).

Man, I was really excited.

Thus began my battle with *Saint Seiya*.

##

■Continues to Episode 20

(07.06.19)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 1: What are Color Design and Color Direction?

Nice to meet you.

My name is

Tsujita Kunio (■■■■■)

. I work in

color design

and

color direction

.

This time, I've been given the opportunity to write various things for

Anime Style

, and I hope you'll take care of me.

Articles and series about people involved in animation tend to focus on direction, scriptwriting, animation, and art backgrounds. The work of

color direction

and

finishing

rarely gets featured. So here, I thought I'd write about finishing and

color design/color direction

... Though I still have no idea which direction this will go (laughs).

Well then.

In my animation work, I do

[finishing]

, mainly

color design

and

color direction

. Color design? Color direction? It's quite hard to understand, isn't it? This time, let me start with a general explanation of this work.

In the animation screen production process, after progressing through

[storyboard]

→

[layout]

→

[key animation]

→

[in-between animation]

, the drawings are passed to

[finishing]

. Here, the completed line drawings are colored and materials are prepared for filming. But when told "paint it!", you can't know what colors to paint those drawings with. That's where the job of

[color direction]

becomes necessary.

[Color direction]

checks the content of all cuts (key animation and in-between animation) for that story and adds specifications. For example, "this character uses this color model" or "this rock's color is number XX from the color chart" - adding simple, easy-to-understand "specifications" one by one. And for this, you need the basic color models and rules as a foundation. Creating that is what

[color design]

does.

The work of

[color design]

is "creating and deciding the basic colors for characters" and "creating and deciding the color direction for that work." You color the character line drawings

drawn by the character designer, but you construct the image through discussions and meetings with the director (direction), character designer, art director, and producers, then translate it into actual colors. When there's an original manga or similar source, you first reference the colors in that original work.

Based on the character colors decided this way, you create the color worldview for that entire work. For this, coordination with

[art]

becomes important. "How dark should night scenes be?" "Is the western sun in evening scenes strong or weak?" - decisions are made while placing them on art boards (background paintings).

Then you meet with

[color direction]

and request actual color instructions. The teamwork between

[color design]

and

[color direction]

is important. While

[color design]

makes judgments about the entire work,

[color direction]

looks at individual actual drawings (key animation and in-between animation).

After having the colors specified this way,

[painting]

paints them, and then

[inspection]

checks whether the painted results are correct. This is roughly the

[finishing]

process. Then those OK cels are passed to

[photography]

for filming.

Well, I've explained it simply, but from next time I'll go into more depth.

##

■Continues to Episode 2

###

PROFILE

Tsujita Kunio (■■■■■)

Born April 19, 1963. Active as color designer and color director. Representative works include the

Saint Seiya (■■■■■)

series, theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

series,

Ojamajo Doremi (■■■■■■■■■)

series,

Gokinjo Monogatari (■■■■■)

,

Hana Yori Dango (■■■■■)

, etc. His personal website is "kunion's cafe" (<http://www.kunion.com/>).

(07.01.09)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 20: Once Upon a Time... (15) *Saint Seiya* Part 2 - Episode 1, and OP & ED Stories

Last Saturday night, I got an email on my cell phone from a female acquaintance (25, single). From Narita Airport no less!

"I thought the excitement before my first overseas trip departure could only be conveyed now, so I'm emailing." Ah, that's right. That day was her very first overseas trip ever.

The feeling when you've passed immigration and are waiting at the departure gate looking at your plane through the window - that indescribable strange heart flutter of anxiety and anticipation.

And it's her first time! Reading that email, this old man found himself getting gentle eyes (laughs).

Then Sunday late night, Tokyo region broadcast the latest *Suiyou Dou Deshou Ka* (Wednesday How About It).

I was watching while working at the studio, and ah, it's Europe! Rome, Vatican, Florence! Ah, I want to go after so long!

The new passport I picked up recently has no scheduled use yet.

Actually, I took a week off early this month. I wanted to go to Brussels and Antwerp. But I ended up just relaxing in Tokyo (bitter laugh).

I want to go out somewhere by maybe next month...

Ah, maybe impossible. Then, then at least in autumn... (distant stare).

Well then.

Saint Seiya* Episode 1. Script:

Koyama Takao

, Storyboard & Direction:

Morishita Kozo

, Animation Director:

Araki Shingo

, Art Director:

Kubota Tadao

.

Toei Doga's TV series finishing system at this time assigned one "inspection" member as the person in charge of each work, but usually they only handled program startup and later-appearing "main treatment" character coloring settings (so-called "color direction sheets"), with per-episode color direction requested from production companies handling that episode's finishing.

As I wrote earlier, basically character color direction was also handled by art, so guest character colors appearing in each episode were all specified by art director

Kubota-san

, with per-episode finishing production companies communicating with art through art department progress to decide.

For example, guest characters appearing in #3 who then appear in several subsequent episodes would get OK from the first episode's direction, then that OK color direction would be passed to the next episode's production company, and so on.

Usually colors from art were OK as-is, so art's specifications - copies with paint numbers noted on character design drawings - would circulate as-is as color direction sheets.

As an aside, due to such systems, most early *Saint Seiya* episode guest characters lack properly organized color direction sheets.

Toei Doga didn't place "setting production" then or now (assistant directors managed it), so color direction got quite scattered.

Also, because of such color direction sheets, there were many coloring mistakes.

Unlike now where color designers check all episodes, things other than properly organized main characters were OK if consistent within that episode and production company.

However, Episode 1 and opening/ending were handled by internal inspection, so Episode 1 was basic - the series standard.

But Episode 1 is the very first, so following direction instructions for color direction was all I could do. I had no capacity to think about later episodes back then (bitter laugh). Just adding color direction to in-between animation coming to me one after another.

Also back then, we weren't allowed to check TV series finishing deliveries.

Delivered cels went directly from finishing progress to

saridashi

(compositing), with assistant directors checking before

saridashi

if time allowed. So color mistakes and such would only become retakes after being photographed and becoming rush film, or when lined up and connected during editing (well, this system basically hasn't changed even now (bitter laugh)). We often weren't even invited to rushes.

So, Episode 1.

Actually, before writing this, I secretly rewatched Episode 1 on DVD.

Ah, I don't remember much detail about this Episode 1 main story, actually (bitter laugh). Since I was completely unaccustomed to "image-style screen direction," I just remember constantly taking cuts to ask

Morishita-san

about everything.

For example, "

Shaina-san

's '

Thunder Claw

' cobra image scene" and such.

Image backgrounds with this animation - what kind of screen would it be as cel, how would it look with transmitted light added in photography? I couldn't really imagine it, so I remember just groping through specifications.

Rewatching reminded me that pupil highlight processing wasn't finalized yet.

Also

Pegasus

Saint Cloth (■■■)

highlight processing. How to process highlights on white, like

Marin

's mask highlights - trial and error (laughs).

I remember opening and ending work better than Episode 1 main story.

Opening and ending broadcast every episode had to be made properly, so I was made to check all of this.

Incidentally, opening and ending were shot on 35mm film (main story used 16mm film).

This was because many prints had to be made, and staff and lyrics text had to be optically composited. So even using the same materials (cels, backgrounds), opening and ending had finer grain than main story images.

"Red, right, ground shadow. X-28, right."

These are

Morishita-san

's words. About ground shadows under the Saints running toward us in the opening's first cut. This was Morishita-san's first words at the opening color direction meeting. When paints were used for coloring, we'd communicate colors and color nuances using paint numbers as common vocabulary like this. So, "X-28, right." Incidentally, blood-like vivid red.

The

Seiya

Cloth

equipping cut shared with main story used main story cut animation, but

Araki-san

personally changed timesheet frame timing, removed some animation cels, and used it for opening with strong/weak tempo.

Opening and ending work came after Episode 1 work was finished, and we were pressed for time.

Cels painted at the last minute had color mistakes, and I have memories of repainting large cels alone at the large-format light table for late-night coloring (laughs).

Color mismatches appeared in rushes completed at the last minute, but there was no time to fix them, so they became "lifelong embarrassing retake #1" (bitter laugh).

In an ending cut where large cel hair flowing was on repeat, cel misalignment couldn't be fixed until the end, becoming "lifelong embarrassing retake #2" (bitter laugh).

Near the end of the opening, the

Athena

statue rising from below cut.

The Athena statue's shadow colors were painted differently in the cut's first and second halves, and I secretly OK'd it as-is - that's a secret (laughs).

Oh, I think Episode 1 also had quite a few

dousa

(in-between animation photography) cuts?

"

Dousa

came out (sweat)," we were all panicking.

Gensan

(original photography) and layout photography being commonplace now makes it somewhat cute (laughs).

Anyway, *Saint Seiya* Episode 1 was completed this way.

When the first screening ended and he stood up, Chief Director

Morishita-san

said one thing: "That's it. This will be cancelled after 2 cours."

That *Saint Seiya* would become a huge hit work.

##

■Continues to Episode 21

(07.06.26)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 21: Once Upon a Time... (16) *Saint Seiya* Part 3 - Steel Saints

Last weekend, my beloved laptop PowerBook G4 wouldn't start up.

The cause was hard disk failure. A year and a half after purchase. Considering usage frequency, ah, from experience it's about time for problems to occur (cries).

Now I'm in trouble.

I have several computers at home and work, but the center of it all is that broken PowerBook.

I manage various things on that PowerBook. Actually, I write this manuscript on the PowerBook too.

Well, I couldn't use that as an excuse to say "Sorry, I'll skip this week's series..." (bitter laugh), so I hurriedly replaced the hard disk myself and got it temporarily revived.

What a relief. I'm writing this properly now (laughs).

The problem is the dead hard disk.

Actually, it contained very important photo data. I usually back up regularly every 3 months, and I was planning to do it this weekend after June ended. Ah, regret doesn't help (wails). I'll do it more frequently from now on.

So everyone, please back up important data frequently (cries).

Well then.

Saint Seiya* that somehow got started.

I don't remember watching Episode 1 during the original broadcast.

Like Morishita-san's comment after that Episode 1 first screening, I honestly didn't think it would become such a hit either. Also, actually, due to staff error, my name wasn't included in Episode 1's end credits.

Toei Doga work credits back then didn't have "color direction" or "inspection."

They'd list about 4 names under "finishing," and color direction would be mixed in there (usually at the top). But somehow they forgot to include my name.

This was depressing.

Disappointed watching the first screening (bitter laugh). This kind of thing is actually very important. Being credited proves you were involved in the work, and with TV, parents, siblings, friends, and acquaintances can see and properly recognize it, plus it raises your own motivation.

So back then when I was still young, not having my name there probably dropped my "motivation" somewhat, and maybe that's why I didn't watch the original broadcast? (laughs)

Moreover, from Episode 2 onward, it basically left my hands.

Unlike the current system where "color design" oversees the entire series, per-episode color direction and inspection were all left to the finishing production company handling that episode.

As I wrote last time, guest character color direction was all handled directly from art designers and the art department to each finishing production company, and color continuity between episodes was mainly managed by assistant directors and production progress.

The finishing department managed cut flow but we had no involvement in color matters. Something like that.

Also, every few episodes, production company

Lifework

entered the production rotation.

Lifework's episodes for

Saint Seiya

were handled consistently by Lifework from direction through animation and finishing.

Ishizaki Susumu

's directed episodes were like this.

Lifework used

Taiyo Shikisai

cel paints for coloring.

As I wrote before, Toei Doga used STAC cel paints, but back then most other companies used Taiyo Shikisai cel paints. So Lifework's color director converted STAC→Taiyo Shikisai based on

Saint Seiya

color direction created at Toei Doga.

With today's digital coloring, such problems don't exist at all, but back then such effort was required.

STAC paints with good color development clarity versus Taiyo Shikisai with many subdued colors. You couldn't make them exactly the same. So in Lifework production episodes,

Seiya

and other characters' colors were somewhat different. But thanks to the color director's good sense in organizing them, you can't tell the difference unless you look very carefully.

So *Saint Seiya* TV series production proceeded without me (laughs).

The initially hectic production situation settled down, popularity gradually increased, and about half a year passed.

Whenever there were problems, they'd come to me.

And such a problem arose.

A new main-treatment character was to appear.

While I had no involvement with per-episode guest characters, for main-treatment characters appearing throughout the series, I was to create color direction sheets - that was the arrangement.

The new character.

Moreover, they wanted to create and feature new Saints not in the original work. Three Saints wearing

Saint Cloths

designed and created with the pinnacle of scientific technology. Their name: "

Steel Saints

."

As usual, designs came from the sponsor toy manufacturer.

Frankly speaking, very "toy-like" design, colors, and gimmicks. Hmm, this is...

I think I received specifications for character skin color and hair from

Kubota-san

.

Combining those to make color samples. Then checking.

The basic principle for this kind of thing is "the same shape and color as what appears on TV is lined up in toy store displays."

So since product (toy) colors and color divisions were already decided, the version appearing in the main story had to match the toys.

"Well, this is how it'll be," so color checking was also OK like that.

Thus "Steel Saints" appeared on TV, but...

They only appeared in a few episodes, then were somehow buried in darkness, with no one mentioning their existence anymore.

##

■Continues to Episode 22

(07.07.03)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 22: Once Upon a Time... (17) *Saint Seiya* Part 4 - The Story of Babel's Flame

I injured my back last weekend. The pain didn't recede but spread throughout my shoulder and worsened considerably (cries). So I went to a nearby orthopedic clinic.

After examination and looking at X-rays, the doctor's diagnosis...

"We can't rule out suspicion of 'cervical hernia,' but well, it's probably 'frozen shoulder.'"

Sigh...

After examination, I had various consultations with a physical therapist. Just from 2-3 body tilt and muscle tests, man, they perfectly diagnosed my work posture! Amazing insight.

In my case, I extend my right hand to operate the keyboard while working with a tablet in my left hand. Maintaining that posture for long periods causes excessive tension in right shoulder to back muscles, worsening with "frozen shoulder" around the shoulder joint area.

Infrared treatment to warm and loosen shoulder-to-back muscles, neck traction and stretching, lying on mats for stretching, electrode electrical therapy, and done.

So for a while, it's rehabilitation (cries).

Well then.

Saint Seiya

, which had left my hands after just Episode 1, returned to me after half a year.

This year, Toei Doga decided to order some TV production that had been done domestically to Taiwanese production companies. While "collaborative" works had long sent animation and finishing, plus some key animation, to overseas production companies, ordering domestic TV works overseas was the first time since I joined Toei Doga. So for overseas-ordered episodes only, I would handle color direction and inspection.

Saint Seiya

after half a year. Far from Morishita-san's "prophecy," it had become very popular with good ratings (bitter laugh). It was safely continuing beyond 2 cours.

Episode 26 at the end of that 2nd cour: "Friend or Foe Steel Saints." This episode became the first overseas order. The "Steel Saints" episode I wrote about last time.

Ordering to Taiwanese companies basically meant key animation and animation directors remained Japanese domestic staff, with animation and finishing requested from them. Rather than requesting all checks from them, Toei Doga sent assistant directors to their companies for animation delivery direction checks. Well, this was almost the same system as "collaborative" works. The difference was having that company handle 100% of the assigned episodes.

Moreover, since they weren't particularly experienced companies, animation was guided to some extent by assistant directors sent there, and finishing was guided by staff from certain finishing studios on long-term business trips.

So, Episode 26.

The story continued from the previous episode - the first half A-part was battles between

Babel

, the Silver Saint who manipulates flame, and Seiya's group. The second half B-part introduced Steel Saints and them heading somewhere by plane and being shot down (?), something like that I think.

The second half B-part wasn't much honestly, but

Seiya

's selling point was battle scenes. Using various photography processing to aim for things was one of this director's specialties. Moreover, since it was a Saint's technique manipulating flame, naturally we'd use lots of transmitted light masks to create "flame" effects.

During the story, Babel torments Seiya and friends with flame balls, and from one animation drawing of that flame ball, we decided to create 6 transmitted light masks for multiple photography of 3 types of flame light. Besides the painted cel of the flame ball itself, 6 masks (laughs). Finishing sheet count exploded! We ran out of BL (black) paint for painting transmitted light masks and had to urgently send additional supplies from Japan.

Furthermore, I proposed that when creating flame balls, naturally flame reflection would be needed, and we increasingly used overlaps from normal cels to reflection color-change cels within single cuts. Not just Babel who manipulates flame, but Seiya and friends receiving those techniques also had 2 color types of cels made for overlaps. Plus,

Cygnus

's "cooling technique" color-change overlaps to protect from that heat were naturally done. Furthermore, Steel Saints' techniques appearing to rescue Seiya and friends all similarly did various things.

With storyboards by this director who excels at battle direction, naturally animators put in effort. Animation sheet count naturally increased too (laughs). Thus, for one TV episode, it became work with terrifyingly excessive animation and finishing sheet counts.

I can say now - both I and the director were half deliberate criminals (laughs).

This overseas ordering system for producing domestic works is now done by every production company - so-called "normal thing" - but back then at Toei Doga, honestly we staff had mental resistance. Moreover, why order popular

Saint Seiya

overseas?

With such feelings, somehow we staff under direction felt a strange emotional uplift: "Let's make everyone say 'Wow!' anyway!"

Thus Episode 26 was completed with greatly excessive sheet counts and schedule. I don't know how it looked from outside (laughs), but for us it became a very well-made episode we could proudly say "How about that!"

Incidentally, we were properly scolded by production department higher-ups (laughs).

The storyboard and direction for this episode was by

Yamauchi Shigeyasu

. Thus began my days with Yamauchi-san.

##

■Continues to Episode 23

(07.07.10)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 23: Once Upon a Time... (18) *Saint Seiya* Part 5 - Things I Was Taught, Things I Learned Through Skin and Body

I'm moving. The apartment where I've lived with my wife for 7 years has become too cramped, so we're moving to a slightly larger place.

The problem is packing. My wife is someone with few belongings so she's super relaxed, but as you can imagine, I'm... (sweat). Still, I started little by little, boxing things up.

However, those packed boxes made it impossible to move around. Two or three cardboard boxes and my room's floor is invisible! Ah, it's certainly cramped...

So before the actual move, I decided to carry as much luggage as possible to the new place myself. Well, the new place is nearby. I'm being forced into steady effort in this heat (cries).

By the way, while I'm writing these old

Saint Seiya

stories, new work information was officially announced:

Saint Seiya: Hades Elysion Chapter

*

(<http://www.toei-anim.co.jp/sp/seiya/>). Actually,

Araki-san

and the

Hades Chapter

staff are currently in production for this winter's broadcast start (

SKY PerfecTV!

). Of course I'm participating too.

This series will go through to the end of

Kurumada-sensei

's original source material. After a long gap, about 20 years. Finally the

Saint Seiya

series reaches its end. Please look forward to it!

Well then.

From Episode 26 onward, comprehensive animation and finishing orders to Taiwanese companies started continuously at about 1 episode per 3-4 episodes, so I handled color direction and inspection for "Taiwan-sent episodes." The program's reputation and ratings were quite good, and broadcasting entered its second year, far from just 2 cours or half a year. The program entered the "

Twelve Temples arc

" and content was getting more and more exciting.

The fun part of TV series is that as you enter the rotation and participate in the work, you get more excited than TV viewers wondering "What will happen next?" Until then, I was only called when there were problems, but participating firmly in the work like this - though it's a bit cheesy to say (laughs) - love for that work grows steadily. You gradually become more of a fan of that work than anyone else (laughs).

Also, through consistent involvement, I was taught many different things by the directors. The

Seiya

direction team around this time centered on CD

Morishita-san

,

Katsumata-san

,

Akehi-san

,

Kikuchi-san

,

Yamauchi-san

, and

Ishizaki-san

- 6 people. Among Toei Doga's many directors, they were quite a "dense" bunch. Furthermore, young directors gradually joined them (since

Ishizaki-san

handled gross episodes for production company

Lifework

, unfortunately I couldn't participate in Ishizaki-san's directed episodes).

For example, the meaning of cut connections, the meaning of layouts and camera lenses capturing them (wide-angle or telephoto), things about key animation, timesheets, and timing, etc. I felt I acquired various things in more directorial fields beyond job categories.

Through working together, I'd ask questions at every opportunity, or learn by overhearing when someone else was asking. Anyway, through working closely with directors and many other staff on numerous works together, many things gradually became second nature.

In that process, I could think about various things myself - "I did it this way this time, but how about trying something like this next time" - actively speaking up and making suggestions in meetings, adding new processing attempts to the screen.

Even taking one special coloring for special image scenes, not just thinking about character colors but trying various things including photography processing was possible because of this "dense" direction team and this

Saint Seiya

work.

During this period, what was most educational was being scolded for my mistakes (laughs). Failures that made my face burn with shame are absolutely unforgettable, and you never make the same mistake twice. Learning through skin, learning through body, so to speak (laughs).

Not just being taught hand-by-hand, but accumulating many experiences like this is absolutely necessary when young. I think it was fortunate that for me it was

Saint Seiya

.

The popular

Saint Seiya

led to theatrical release. Production of the second theatrical work

Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods

was decided. Unfortunately I couldn't participate in the first theatrical version, but this time I could participate properly. And Director:

Yamauchi Shigeyasu

*.

Here comes Yamauchi-san!

##

■Continues to Episode 24

(07.07.24)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 24: Once Upon a Time... (19) *Saint Seiya* Part 6 - Theatrical *Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods*, and Stories with Yamauchi-san

It's high school baseball season. The other day, while browsing West Tokyo tournament match results on the internet, huh? I saw my alma mater - Tokyo Metropolitan Fuji High School - in the match results. I hurriedly checked their record and amazingly they'd won through the 2nd and 3rd rounds to reach the best 16. Winning further - surprise! Best 8!

Actually, during my time at Tokyo Metropolitan Fuji High, they only had a soft baseball club due to the small schoolyard and other reasons. It became a hard baseball club in 2000.

The quarterfinals were last Friday at Jingu Stadium. Win and it's best 4, win further and it's

Koshien

. I twisted my various schedules (laughs) to watch Tokyo local

MX Television

's broadcast from home in support.

It's a strange sensation. Cheering for my alma mater at this age. I'd never cheered for my alma mater during school or after graduation. Well, I certainly never thought my alma mater was that strong, but still thoughts of "maybe..." "possibly..." kept building excitement (laughs). Moreover, the opponent was

Kosei Gakuen

, Fuji High's neighbor. A

Marunouchi Line Honancho Branch

showdown! (Fuji High is at

Nakano-Fujimicho Station

, Kosei Gakuen at

Honancho Station

) Hmm, we can't lose this! (laughs)

The result: Unfortunately lost 2-7. But man, it was a really good game! I was moved by their never-giving-up attitude, scoring in the 8th and 9th innings. Really, they did well! Heartfelt applause for my alma mater's baseball club.

Well then.

Theatrical

Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods

. Director:

Yamauchi Shigeyasu

, Script:

Koyama Takao

, Animation Director:

Araki Shingo

, Art Director:

Kubota Tadao

. Long-awaited participation in theatrical

Seiya*.

This was

Seiya

's second theatrical work. As I wrote last time, I couldn't participate in the first one. Moreover, the long-awaited

Yamauchi

-directed

Seiya

. "I absolutely have to do this!" I went to directly petition the department manager with desperate resolve. Well, the manager apparently had already decided on me regardless of my petition (laughs).

Director

Yamauchi-san

. My encounter with Yamauchi-san was through a pilot film for some collaborative work. The title was

Space Raiders

*. Somewhere in space on a planet with incredibly strong winds, good guys and bad guys fight in fighter-like mechs... something like that. Several minutes long (?). Yamauchi-san was the director.

We decided to depict those raging winds - "constantly moving air currents" - through animation. We decided to animate "air currents" with cel drawings - about 2 types in the background depth, plus some in the foreground.

The screen, animated far beyond the storyboard sent from America, naturally made those "air currents" complex and intricate too. I thought single-color "air currents" lacked depth, screen variation, and interest, so I consulted with Yamauchi-san to separate the multiple "air currents" in the drawings into different colored separate cel specifications, then double them semi-transparently during photography.

Naturally, finishing became quite difficult work, but as intended, the screen turned out quite nicely. "Tsujita-kun, you do quite well." Getting those words gave me tremendous satisfaction.

Then that "Episode 26." Several subsequent TV

Seiya

episodes. Yamauchi-san and I tried creating various screens. Working with Yamauchi-san, who creates screens using solid layouts, animation, and photography techniques, always had unexpected elements - stimulating and enjoyable work. Now a theatrical work. I was excited about trying even more things.

Incidentally,

Space Raiders

* unfortunately remained just a pilot with no further development (bitter laugh).

So, theatrical

Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods

*,

The setting is

Asgard

, the Nordic gods' land. Learning of some strange events occurring,

Saori

,

Seiya

,

Shiryu

, and

Shun

head to Asgard. Asking about

Hyoga

's safety - he'd gone ahead and lost contact - Asgard's leader

Dolbar

and

God Warrior

Loki

deny knowledge. But Seiya and friends sense something plotting in their aggressive auras. That night,

Saori

, meeting

Dolbar

alone, falls into his evil hands and becomes captive. To save Saori, deadly battles between

Saints

and

God Warriors

begin... such a story.

The production schedule wasn't very good back then either, but this work was really well-made - it's in my personal all-time best ten. What didn't make it in time for color during editing and dubbing was... just a few cuts of final collapse scenes as

dousa

(in-between animation photography). And I remember it being almost entirely domestic animation.

The animation was good, but above all the art backgrounds. Each cut approaches you with "this is theatrical version" feeling. Especially

Valhalla Palace

backgrounds were amazing. The majesty of the palace on sheer cliffs rising before heavy Nordic skies in the background depths. Holding backgrounds lined up on

saridashi

room shelves, I secretly grinned while sighing (laughs).

In the main story, I tried various things color direction-wise. First, "shadows within shadows." Character acting where characters enter other characters' shadows (

Frey

and

Saori

in

Dolbar

's shadow cuts) - usually expressed by doubling BL shadows over characters, but I wondered if shadow colors could create crisis or anxiety feelings? Instead of BL shadow doubling, I had animation composite shadows and worked out those section colors, painting them in with coloring.

Also, this is direction territory not finishing, but in following scenes, as

Dolbar

's "technique," expressing drawing opponents into and absorbing them into different dimensions used photography to insert and replace multiple backgrounds. Making wave-pattern masks with animation, having 3-4 different color scheme backgrounds drawn from the same source drawing, then inserting them during photography. Such techniques are

Yamauchi-san

's specialty. Ground gouging depictions also used 2 background types for insertion.

Next I tried "night colors." Until then in

Seiya

, night scenes were colored with normal color direction without particularly changing colors, but I created "night colors" just for the scene where

Seiya

and

Shiryu

run across vast night plains. Not simply making colors one step darker, but adding background spatial colors to dull them down.

Actually then,

Lifework

, who'd been helping with TV series, could help somewhat with finishing, so I asked them to handle "night color" scenes together. Of course I created "night color" specifications using

Taiyo Shikisai

paints.

Taiyo Shikisai

was really suited for this directional color changing.

Additionally, a few cuts of

Seiya

running through

Valhalla Palace

before dawn also had twilight color changes created and painted by

Lifework

, I think.

Well, looking back now, the "night colors" weren't very successful (bitter laugh), but this color thinking approach would connect to later

Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth

*.

Besides these "night colors," each scene except image scenes was basically normal color direction coloring. This was based on considering "character standing" - the policy of "let's keep fighting characters in battle scenes basically normal as before."

But unlike recent digital coloring, even normal cels in dark nights, just photographing cels + backgrounds with cameras onto film strangely created good atmosphere.

With mostly normal coloring, battle scenes and "technique" scenes dealing with light always had detailed high-contrast and image coloring cels made for photography fade-in/fade-out. Slowly when creating intervals, quickly and briefly when increasing tempo. This "light" acting is still basic to

Seiya

today.

March 1988. This theatrical

Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods

was released as one film in the spring "

Toei Manga Festival

." At that staff first screening wrap party, what was handed to me was the final script for

Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth

*.

##

■Continues to Episode 25

(07.07.31)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 25: Once Upon a Time... (20) *Saint Seiya* Part 7 - Theatrical *Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods* A Bit More, and Stories about Special Effects Staff

I took about 2 weeks off from the series, and during this time I couldn't escape to cool highlands for summer retreat (cries) - I've been spending incredibly busy days. In this brutal heat too...

I successfully completed the move in this heat and now enjoy comfortable new home days, but perhaps due to age I got hit hard with fatigue and came down with summer cold for about 2 days. With fever exceeding the "temperature higher than body temperature brutal heat," I was delirious (bitter laugh).

Thankfully the summer cold cleared up and I'm in perfect condition now.

This summer I've been sweating abnormally, no matter how many T-shirts I change they're soaked immediately. I'm sweating more than ever in my personal history, but with all this sweating, why don't I lose weight? (wails)

Such is the middle of lingering summer heat in Tokyo (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Let me write a bit more about theatrical

Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods

*,

There's a process called "special effects" in finishing work processes.

Using airbrushes, brushes, sponges, dry brushes, spattering - utilizing every technique possible to apply expressions of natural phenomena like light and wind, plus various material textures to painted cels. Literally handwork. It requires various skills and sense.

Recently, since photography became digital, it's often worked on as part of photography processing, but in this cel era, it was all finishing work.

So for TV series there were often pressures or directives like "try not to use too much" (bitter laugh).

Seiya

is a work that can't exist without these special effects. Moreover, being theatrical work, we could really request it openly (laughs).

First, material texture expression. For example,

Saint Cloth

texture.

Seiya

and other

Bronze Saints

' cloths don't get much texture brush work, but

Gold Saints

' gold cloth textures and black lustrous cloth sheens are special effects brush work.

Drawn sword blade textures are also brush work. The silver goblet held by leader

Dolbar

in the opening also has texture brushing.

Also, rocks and debris crumbling and scattering during battles, bark textures of split and peeled tree trunks - these natural object textures are special effects. They draw additions over cels matching background touches. Raging blizzards and ice frost - such natural phenomena expressions are also special effects power.

Plus light and shadow expressions. Since it's a work with lots of fighting (laughs), there's glowing everywhere, so light expressions and shadow expressions receiving that light require special effects brushing. Sometimes direct so-called "light brushing" is applied, but for photography transmitted light processing, those transmitted light masks also get black brushing to blur light edges - that's special effects work too.

Oh yes, cel ground shadows were also mostly brush processing.

Expressing such effects requires first observational skills - "how do things appear?" - imaginative skills - "how to show it?" - plus technical skills and "artistic sense" to actually do the work.

Honestly, very time-consuming work. For example, airbrushes. First masking work to select brush areas. Using much thinner cels than coloring cels, starting by making masks cut from those sections. The more animation sheets, the more difficult, and demanding special effects or special techniques makes necessary masks more complex.

Also, since too many cel layers interfere with photography, sometimes effects must be added directly to colored cels, making it difficult to redo work.

And teamwork. Especially for big jobs like theatrical works, special effects staff divide up the work to finish piece by piece. True specialists.

In this theatrical

Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods

, the climax scene where

Frey

stabs his sword into the

Odin

* statue and massive collapse occurs in light was especially difficult. Flowing cut connections, beautiful powerful animation, colorful backgrounds, and photography that beautifully captured light and shadow. Cel colors and special effects that fit perfectly within that. It's my favorite scene.

However, here I made a big mistake.

In the series of cuts where

Frey

climbs the statue and stabs it with his sword, I made a color direction error in one cut. A cut needing light reflection from the

Odin

statue was finished in colors without reflection. I missed this during checking and had texture brushing applied with special effects in the wrong colors.

During

saridashi

(compositing),

Yamauchi

director noticed. Naturally I was called. Here the director thoroughly scolded me. Obviously we couldn't photograph it as-is, so cel colors, special effects - everything had to be redone.

"They did such careful brushing work - you understand how much effort that takes, don't you?" Those director's words I remember so clearly I can almost hear them now. Truly "face burning with shame" (bitter laugh).

Incidentally, it's properly retaken in the main story, so now only I know about this (laughs).

Every time I rewatch

Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods

, what I first remember is

Frey

's sword's magnificent special effects and

Yamauchi

* director's words.

##

■Continues to Episode 26

(07.08.21)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 26: Once Upon a Time... (21) *Saint Seiya* Part 8 - Getting Fired Up in the "Twelve Temples Arc"

The hot summer has finally started to show signs of waning, but man, it's still hot in this final week of August.

When I was a student, I absolutely hated this "final week of August" (laughs). This week marking the end of summer vacation, like the ending of "Sazae-san" or "Sunday Cinema Theatre," felt so melancholy and full of sadness that I couldn't stand it.

Even now as a proper (?) adult, when I hear phrases like "last Sunday of summer vacation" on the news, I get overwhelmed by this feeling that I've left something very important undone, and I get restless no matter what.

You all feel the same way... right? (sweat)

Incidentally, as a proper adult now I thankfully don't have "summer vacation homework," but we in the anime business are in "summer vacation homework" mode every week. We're always scrambling at the very last minute (cries).

Well then.

Let me set aside the theatrical version talk for a bit and discuss TV's

Saint Seiya

.

While making the theatrical version, naturally TV broadcasting continued. Just when we were making "The Heated Battle of the Gods," the TV version moved its setting to the Sanctuary (■■■■■■■■■■) and entered what's called the "Twelve Temples Arc (■■■■■)."

During theatrical production, I naturally wasn't handling per-episode color direction for TV, but I continued working on TV main story - creating coloring settings for Gold Saints (■■■■■■■/■■■■■■■■■■) appearing one after another, consulting with directors on special scenes like "techniques," and so on.

Even without specific business, I'd show up in the saridashi (■■■■) room to chat with directors, assistant directors, and progress staff, or help fix retakes that came up during saridashi. Everything was fun. The schedule was tough as always, but it felt like a really good period.

Over a year since broadcast started,

Saint Seiya

had stabilized in various ways. Plus the "Twelve Temples Arc" followed the "How much time is left?" rule (I'm naming it now) - a plot structure of saving Athena (■■■■) within limited time, and this was exciting.

Every episode's B-part would build up excitement, then at the perfect moment - "To be continued!" This "To be continued!" golden cliffhanger was why the story built to overwhelming excitement. And the following episode would try to top even that excitement.

What was depicted rather briefly in the original comics - confrontations and technique descriptions - animation succeeded in creating truly three-dimensional, fast-paced battles with skillful timing through animation-unique drawing, screen effects, and voice actors' deep performances.

Especially "technique" depictions were purely battles of sense. Taking various ideas created through animation and building them through finishing and photography. This was an era when you couldn't test or reshoot endlessly on computer screens like now. While some test painting and finalization was possible, TV series test shoots were rarely allowed for each episode.

"How do we want to show it, how will it look?" - everyone would think together. Taking ideas and expanding images, working out quite detailed and precise decisions in our heads, then turning them into actual materials. Well, this is still the same now, but in some ways I feel we thought more back then (bitter laugh). When what was shot and delivered matched our imagination or exceeded it, it was pure pleasure. We experienced this every week, every episode.

And then there were the "voices."

Around this time, I got to observe a dubbing session for the first time in my life. I think it was the episode where Shun (■) and Aphrodite (■■■■■■■■■) were fighting. Man, I just remember being continuously moved. Voice actors giving voices to the screens we'd created. Ah, goosebumps! (laughs) It really felt like breath was being breathed in, flat things becoming three-dimensional. I think the actors were also in their groove during this period.

I looked forward to weekly first screenings, and above all I'd become a huge

Saint Seiya

fan beyond just work. That's what it was.

Watching the "Twelve Temples Arc" again on DVD now - man, it still gets me fired up! (laughs)

And the theatrical

Legend of Crimson Youth (■■■■■■■■)

battle would unfold in this Sanctuary with its "Twelve Temples."

##

■Continues to Episode 27

(07.08.28)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 27: Special Episode - My Personal Best Theatrical Anime This Summer

This series has actually exceeded 26 episodes. In TV terms, that's 2 cours! Though I've taken breaks occasionally, man, this is wonderful. I'm amazed at myself (laughs).

So this week I'm setting aside the

Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth (■■■■■■■■■)

story for a "special episode" - before I forget, let me talk about the anime movies I saw this summer.

Lots of anime movies were released this summer. I saw three:

Ratatouille

,

Vexille

, and

Summer Days with Coo (■■■■■■■■■■■)

. Ah, I really wanted to see many more, but finding time to go...

Well then.

First,

Ratatouille

.

A Disney anime with a mouse protagonist who isn't Mickey (laughs). American animated movies now mean 3DCG. 3DCG means Pixar. Man, amazing. "They can do this much now!" - just pure amazement.

The mouse fur texture - if they made it too realistic it would probably be disgusting. But they pursued realism while properly creating anime-like texture. That balance was great.

And beyond the mouse fur, what really impressed me were the dishes on screen! They really looked delicious. Sure, with a restaurant setting the food should look tasty, but this was the first time I got so excited about both ingredients and finished dishes.

Pleasant layouts and lighting mastery, enjoyable pacing and movement with good editing. And above all, magnificent screenplay. Above all, movies start with screenplay! I really felt it was carefully crafted over time.

My previous American animated movie best #1 was tied between

Monsters, Inc.

and

Mr. Incredible

- but now this

Ratatouille

proudly joins them in a three-way tie.

Next,

Vexille

.

This was also hardcore 3DCG anime. However, unlike

Ratatouille

, this used cel shading for character processing, making it somewhat "anime-like" - you could feel the 2D anime taste we create.

This was also amazing. A movie with lots of mechanical depictions, and this too had that "they can do this much now!" feeling (laughs). A different direction of realism from

Ratatouille

.

The editing and camerawork were very live-action movie-like, which was interesting too. Quite thrilling! A pretty well-made movie.

However, what felt subtle was the matching between "story" and "technique."

This movie is about "humans" and "androids," but both androids and human characters are the same cel-shaded CG on screen. The more realistically gestures and movements were done, the less convincing it felt when those characters spoke about "humanity." Like wanting to yell at the screen "But you're CG!" If it had been regular 2D hand-drawn animation, there wouldn't have been such discomfort.

"Maybe this is the difficult part of CG movies?" - that's my impression.

Whether

Ratatouille

or

Vexille

, 3DCG work colors must be difficult. Lighting completely changes how things look. But it's probably fun too, though it looks tough (bitter laugh). If I get a chance someday, I'd definitely like to try it.

And

Summer Days with Coo

.

This is so-called "regular anime" movie like what we make.

"Wow, I got owned!" was my honest impression. Man, I was beautifully made to cry (bitter laugh). Haven't cried at a movie since Director Hosoda (■■)'s

The Girl Who Leapt Through Time (■■■■■■■■■)

. In summer vacation with an audience full of children, an old man crying is questionable... but man, I got owned.

Everything was made normally. Nothing particularly special was done. The animation wasn't spectacularly amazing. But it felt like work carefully, truly painstakingly and lovingly crafted. The elementary student protagonist Koichi (■■)'s feelings, those emotions, or the frustrating inadequacy of insufficient feelings - all made so gently. I somehow remembered making

Ojamajo Doremi (■■■■■■■■■■)

.

Truly a movie that leaves proper "good things" in everyone who watches - whether small children or old men like us. Anyway, this

Summer Days with Coo

is my top pick!

Those were my impressions of the three movies I saw this summer. Anime really is great!

By the way, though not anime, I also saw the movie "Transformers." Man, this was fun in its own way. Despite incredibly amazing visuals, the "extremely local feeling alien invasion" was GOOD (laughs).

Just having it transform, stand up, and say "I am Optimus Prime" (in English) was already the best! For us who made the anime version as collaborative work, it's

"Optimus Prime," not "Convoy (■■■■)" (laughs).

But man, magnificent transformation! Transformation scenes that should have been possible only through "anime lies" going "shaki-shaki-shakin!" so naturally - the world really is anything-goes now (laughs).

##

■Continues to Episode 28

(07.09.04)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 28: Special Episode - Theatrical *CLANNAD* Release Commemoration - Stories with Director Dezaki

Well then,

I first saw Director Dezaki (黒塚) live during the character color checking for theatrical

Air

. That day, he came into the color design room at Toei Animation Oizumi (■■■) Studio with directors, character designers, animation directors and others. The exceptionally tall director appeared casually. "Ah! Director Dezaki!" I thought. He passed in front of my seat near the entrance and went to the back. I wasn't participating in theatrical

Air

(Tsukada-san (■■) from

One Piece

handled it), and at that moment I was having character color meetings for

Saint Seiya: Hades Sanctuary Chapter (■■■■■■■■■■)

with Director Katsumata (■■■) at my desk.

I can be honest now - I was jealous of Tsukada-san (laughs). I mean, she was working on that Director Dezaki's project at Toei Animation. This kind of thing probably won't happen again (bitter laugh). I heard it was a difficult project with various troubles, but man, I wanted to do theatrical

Air

. I was carrying multiple projects including

Saint Seiya

so it was impossible from the start. As long as I work at Toei Animation, ah, I probably can't work with Director Dezaki, I thought.

Then came theatrical

CLANNAD

! Director Dezaki again!

Man, I was shocked. I almost immediately raised my hand saying "Yes!" But as usual I was overloaded with work and couldn't easily volunteer. I think this was around last year at this time. A feature-length theatrical work can't be easily handled alongside other projects. Actually around then

CLANNAD

storyboards were starting to come up and overall meetings had already been held twice. We couldn't continue meetings without a color designer any longer, so after various discussions, it was decided "Well, somehow with Tsujita..." and I gloriously joined the

CLANNAD

team.

I hadn't told staff much, but I'd actually been a longtime fan of Director Dezaki's works.

My first encounter was in high school. I was completely captivated by

Ashita no Joe 2 (■■■■■■■■2)

. This was an era without DVDs. When our house didn't even have a VCR yet. During the original broadcast and later reruns, I was a high schooler glued to the TV (laughs). Ever since, I'd been continuously captivated by Director Dezaki's works -

Ace wo Nerae! 2

,

Ace wo Nerae Final Stage

,

Black Jack

, and countless others.

So,

CLANNAD

overall meetings.

Based on storyboards Director Dezaki created, main staff including producer, directors, character designers, art designers, animation directors, art directors, color designers, etc. participated in meetings held roughly every 10 days to 2 weeks. About 100-150 cuts discussed per meeting. The director would explain storyboard content, and all main staff would confirm necessary setting orders and

content agreements.

I finally joined at the third meeting. According to my notes, it was October 7th. The director arrived about 15 minutes late as usual with a casual entrance. In the meeting room, all main staff sat around the director. I happened to be directly facing the director. Brief self-introduction. A bit nervous (laughs). "Oh, please take care of me," said the director. This became our first conversation (?).

The meeting began. Just reading through storyboards made my heart race. I knew nothing about

CLANNAD

as a work, read the given scenario, but naturally couldn't complete the game (bitter laugh). So actually,

CLANNAD

was built in my mind from given source materials, the scenario, and the director's storyboards.

Naturally, the storyboards were hand-drawn. Acting in storyboards was naturally Director Dezaki's drawings. While somewhat resembling characters, they had the director's distinctive style. But the original art style and Kadono-san's (■■■■) characters are like that. So there was a gap... (bitter laugh).

Girl characters I could mostly mentally convert, but the protagonist's friend Sunohara (■■) somehow... (bitter laugh). Our heads were completely imprinted with "Edo-dialect Sunohara (■■■■■■■■)" from Dezaki storyboards. "Hmm, this guy, you know..." Making character color samples while inadvertently bitter laughing. Bridging the gap between "Dezaki World" and the original was quite difficult.

But I was dying to see how these guys would develop.

To be continued (laughs).

##

■Continues to Episode 29

(07.09.18)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 29: Special Episode - Theatrical *CLANNAD* Release Commemoration - Stories with Director Dezaki Part 2

For certain reasons, I've been intensively watching

The File of Young Kindaichi (■■■■■■■■■■)

DVDs lately. The anime version (laughs). A work I previously did color design and color direction for. I helped with the recently released DVD-BOX packaging work, and through that connection I forcibly got the DVD-BOX! (Sorry)

The File of Young Kindaichi

initially started as cel-film work but switched to digital coloring mid-series, which involved considerable trial and error.

Oh yes, recently cable channels have been rerunning it too, and for a while before summer I got quite hooked watching it. It was quite fresh to carefully rewatch a work I'd designed so long after on TV. Man,

Kindaichi

was pretty well made (laughs).

Well, I plan to write about

The File of Young Kindaichi

here eventually, so please look forward to it (laughs).

Lately there have been increasing murder and assault cases that surpass anime and manga. Due to such influence, broadcasts of

School Days

final episode and

Higurashi no Naku Koro ni Kai (■■■■■■■■■■)

have been suspended in some regions. Well, these incidents probably aren't because anime had similar depictions. But it must be tough for broadcasters in various ways.

This reminded me - ah, when we were doing

Kindaichi

, several shocking real-world incidents occurred too. We never had broadcast suspensions, but some episodes were abandoned at script stage.

I mean, stories like "rolling severed heads" or "dismembering mummies for tricks" - impossible for terrestrial TV at 7 PM (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Continuing the

CLANNAD

theatrical release commemoration special episode.

About every 10 days to 2 weeks, overall storyboard meetings. Usually 15-20 minutes late, the director would arrive casually. When the tall director appeared casually at the meeting room doorway, everyone instantly switched to sharp meeting mode. The director's walking and speaking style were relatively "casual" and soft, but the eyes behind sunglasses, though gentle, gleamed sharply, making us tense up too (laughs).

Each meeting progressed checking settings for each department. Character designs, costume designs, art designs, art boards, etc. For character color checking, I'd have the director sit next to me, receiving instructions and giving opinions while making various adjustments. "That's it. Like this, light comes in whoosh, and shadow on this side properly..." said Director Dezaki.

However, since character visuals were decided to remain true to the original, I couldn't make shadow color contrast overly strong in basic design. The key became how to treat those characters within main story scenes.

The original visuals were "soft and soft, clean but fluffy," so I really wanted to make outline (main line) colors lighter and brighter, but actually trying it - while decent in still images, in moving pictures they either dissolved too much into backgrounds or floated too much. So I kept it to just slightly softer. Naturally, according to spatial brightness, character colors, main lines, color tones, and density were all adjusted accordingly.

As the director's storyboards progressed and overall meetings accumulated, storyboards gradually diverged from the scenario. "Somehow, that's what happened," said the director. Oh no, naturally he explained the reasons to us (laughs).

That change held major meaning within theatrical

CLANNAD

. And "Ah, this is Director Dezaki." Well, Producer K-san seemed nervous though (bitter laugh).

Then storyboards were complete. Overall meetings finished too.

"Ah, meetings are over..." I felt somewhat disappointed, wanting to have many more meetings, but naturally that wasn't possible (bitter laugh). After this, based on director meetings, we below the director would GO! with main story work. Well, as usual our time was limited (bitter laugh).

For theatrical

CLANNAD

I basically handled color design, color direction input, and final finishing delivery checks alone, but I'm not very fast and it was 1,400 cuts. We urgently got a young female color director named Akimoto-san (■■■) as assistant to handle various impossible demands for miscellaneous items.

Still, pushing the original schedule back as much as possible, editing and dubbing. After filling in images to take shape, all main staff including the director participated in full-length checking and retake assignments.

Overall director notes were given, then detailed processing checks for each cut. Numerous revision instructions. Honestly, quite a few cuts needed rework. Adding more photography processing, the screen gradually thickened.

We processed all retake cuts and delivered the tentative complete package. Our work went that far. Then the director added his "one more spoonful." Once all images were OK, video editing would be redone and the director would comprehensively add further processing.

Then the zero screening.

For movies, negatives are made and positive film printed for theater screening. "Zero screening" means screening the first print of the completed full movie to do final checks before mass print production. Here you can ask lab staff to adjust print exposure, color readjustment, and printing corrections as needed.

The producer, directors, and script supervisor who attended video editing knew the "complete version" where the director added his "one spoonful," but we were watching the "complete version" for the first time at this zero screening. The screening room darkened and screening began. Hmm, indescribable tension...

And 90 minutes. Screening ended. Great relief. "Hmm, I see!" I thought. The director's added "one spoonful" had greatly increased theatrical

CLANNAD

's sharpness and three-dimensionality as a movie.

In the waiting room after screening, I told the director who was smoking: "You added quite a bit, didn't you? (laughs)" "Well, something like that," the director grinned. Thus theatrical

CLANNAD

was completed.

Later, at the wrap party after the first screening at Toei Studios screening room. At the end of the excited after-party, I had a firm, gentle but strong handshake with Director Dezaki. "Man, thank you. You really helped a lot," said Director Dezaki. Man, I was moved. So happy! I don't know if I'll get to work with the director again, but I'll work hard dreaming of collaborating again someday!

##

■Continues to Episode 30

(07.09.25)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 2: Once Upon a Time... (1)

January is already half over.

During the year-end and New Year holidays, there were various movies I wanted to see, but I only managed to go see "The Inugami Family" (cries). I guess I'll have to work hard with DVD rentals (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Following Episode 1, I thought about "going deeper...", but before that, let me tell you a bit of an old story (?).

It's been over 20 years since I stepped into the animation world. I dropped out of university and got a job (?) at the small finishing production company in Ikebukuro where I'd been working part-time. There I did regular painting work. Since it was over 20 years ago, it was naturally the world of animation cels and paints. To be honest, my hands weren't very fast, but I was still painting about 1000 sheets per month. Since it was a small company, I didn't just do painting - I also operated the trace machine (a machine that transfers in-between animation lines to cels via carbon transfer), delivered cuts to outside staff, managed paint inventory, and did various other things.

That company was very small, but still worked hard with a commitment to quality. I learned everything - not just technical things about tracing and painting, but the mechanisms of various matters and how to be as a working adult. There were many difficult things, but it was an enjoyable workplace. Most of all, I was happy to feel that I too was making anime.

However, at the end of that year, I had a serious illness and became paralyzed on my right side. Later, through rehabilitation, I recovered almost normal function, but inevitably some disability remained in my right hand. So I became left-handed. But with my left hand, I definitely couldn't work like before. So I became centered on management and progress work and cel inspection. And I gradually began to start mimicking color direction work.

That company mainly did subcontracting for

Toei Doga (■■■■■)

(now Toei Animation), taking gross orders for TV series like

Dr. Slump

and

Ai Shite Knight (■■■■■■■)

by episode. At that time, Toei Doga's finishing subcontracting production companies included

Suzuki Doga Kikaku (■■■■■■■)

,

Takapro (■■■■■)

,

Shin'ei Pro (■■■■■)

,

Kyoei Pro (■■■■■)

,

Studio Crocus (■■■■■■■■■■)

,

Studio Peacock (■■■■■■■■■■)

, etc., each taking gross orders for 1 or 2 lines of TV series works on rotation.

Now when we talk about color direction, the mainstream is to do color direction on key animation checked by animation directors and order

doshi hatchu (■■■■■)

(integrated work from in-between animation through finishing), but back then we received and worked on all cuts that were completed up to in-between animation at finishing. So when we went to Toei Doga to pick up cuts, all 300 cuts for one episode would be completely ready and placed on shelves. Naturally, by the time of editing and dubbing, all cuts were already shot. If you sent out a

dousa (■■■)

(in-between animation photography)! it was a matter for written apologies - that was the era. Amazing, right? (laughs) It was completely different from the current situation where it's mostly layout photography during dubbing.

And basically, the color direction staff at Toei Doga (they were called

[inspection]

back then) would look through them and add specifications, but scene-specific props would come through as

[leave it to us]

without color direction. I began my color direction by doing the color direction for such items bit by bit.

Also, we couldn't make it on Toei Doga works alone. So we also took on various works from other companies.

Tatsunoko Pro (■■■■■■■)

,

Madhouse (■■■■■■■)

,

Ashi Pro (■■■)

,

Kaname Pro (■■■)

,

Studio Deen (■■■■■■■■■)

,

Kitty Film (■■■■■■■■■)

... Naturally, we also did Toei Doga theatrical works. Theatrical works were better in terms of pricing, and having the production company's name in the end credits of theatrical works was great publicity within the industry.

We'd take jobs based on our schedule situation, but I was nervous every time. With theatrical works, both the animation and colors were completely different grade from TV. Especially the color usage in character color direction, the detailed specifications. The beauty when painted (laughs). Eventually I began to yearn for it: "Color direction, huh. Ah, this kind of world might be good!"

And well, various things happened (bitter laugh), but in February 1984, I ended up joining Toei Doga. It was early spring when I was 22.

##

■Continues to Episode 3

(07.01.16)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 30: Once Upon a Time... (22) *Saint Seiya* Part 9 - Theatrical *Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth* - Storyboard Art and Meeting Legend

I recently bought a big TV. A 37-inch full-spec high-definition LCD. The "Kameyama Model (■■■■■)" they call it. Watching MLB broadcasts, binge-watching foreign dramas on cable TV, watching movies on DVD. Man, I'd been wanting something like this for so long (laughs).

Relaxing on a spacious sofa. This sofa is especially good for watching movies. It's like a "mini movie theater" feeling.

Ah, I haven't watched anime yet (bitter laugh).

Since anime production sites are transitioning to HD-compatible format screen creation, I'm thinking of carefully watching various programs, focusing on new fall shows, this October.

But well, my biggest favorite is definitely PS2's "Katamari Damacy (■■)" (laughs). My wife and I are both fighting the big screen while getting somewhat motion sick from all the spinning. The Xbox 360 version releases this month too. Looking forward to it! (laughs)

Well then.

Resuming long-neglected

Saint Seiya

stories (laughs).

After spring vacation 1988's theatrical

Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods

ended, until summer vacation August 1988's theatrical

Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth

* was about 4 months.

Even already starting storyboard work, making a 70-minute movie was a somewhat (quite?) tight schedule. But well, the director and we staff had firmly grasped something like confidence from

The Heated Battle of the Gods

, so mood-wise we were fully motivated.

Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth

was located on the 2nd floor of Oizumi Studio's new building. The newest wing at that time of Oizumi Studio, which consisted of patchwork additions, was the "new building" - the 1st floor had "collaborative work" staff rooms, and the 2nd floor had several staff rooms for video works like

Shonan Bakusozoku (■■■■■)

and

Crying Freeman

. Our

Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth

* was also tucked into one of those small spaces (incidentally, that area on the 2nd floor of the new building is now photography rooms and the color design room where I am).

In the staff room, Director Yamauchi (■■) sat firmly in the very back, with the assistant director's seat next to him. Back-to-back was production progress A-san's (female) seat. Plus about two spare seats. Just a small room like that. Animation Director Araki (■■) worked at Araki Pro (■■■■), so no seat in the staff room. Art and I each worked at our own seats within the studio, so no seats in the staff room.

Director Yamauchi did storyboard work at home on days off, but otherwise was always in the staff room doing storyboard work and various checks. So I remember spending quite a lot of time hanging around that staff room until things got busy. Somehow, being in that room was fun.

One day, after an animation meeting ended, the director and Araki-san came in, and Araki-san was looking at the half-written storyboard on the director's desk. One comment: "All the drawings look like Yamauchi-kun."

"Eh? That's not true. Look, it's properly Seiya (■■), right?" said the director. "No, no..." Pointing to the director's drawings, Araki-san said, "Look, the face humans see most is their own face in the mirror. So when drawing, it inevitably resembles yourself most." Come to think of it, the storyboard characters Director Yamauchi drew certainly had faces and body types like Director Yamauchi... "Oh, I see!" everyone nodded deeply. Only the director seemed unconvinced (laughs).

So, eventually the storyboards finished and total cuts were determined, leading to full-length art and color direction meetings. This time Kubota-san (■■) only handled art design and art boards, with Uchikawa-shi (■■) as art director. Since Uchikawa Fumihiko (■■■■) wasn't very familiar with

Saint Seiya

, thorough meetings were inevitable.

Meetings were held in the conference room called "Video Room" diagonally across from the staff room. Start time: 11 AM. Full of energy, let's start.

The main story's introduction was an important atmosphere-building scene for this work. The director drew explanation drawings on correction paper used as memo paper while giving detailed explanations for each cut. The clock hands easily passed noon, reaching lunch break. But the meeting was just getting into its groove. Everyone tacitly agreed to skip lunch and continue the meeting.

Eventually the content reached Seiya and friends charging into the Sanctuary, beginning battles with Abel (■■■■)'s subordinate Saints. The series of "technique" cuts combined animation, art, color direction, and photography techniques and ideas. First the director would explain images in his head, then art and I would propose "How about doing it like this?" with discussions of specific methods and necessary mask specifications, etc. As ideas came together and cut images expanded, meeting time naturally expanded too.

The clock hands advanced further, the 3 PM break chime rang, then evening work-end chimes... The scenery outside gradually shifted to night. The meeting continued endlessly with only 2-3 bathroom breaks and no meals. Moreover, content-wise we'd only reached the point where Seiya finally arrived at Abel's temple (laughs).

The full meeting finally ended just before 9 PM. A truly non-stop meeting lasting about 9 hours. Though I'd prepared somewhat for a theatrical work meeting, I never expected it to be this long. But everyone maintained concentration through to the end - amazing. Well, honestly, after finishing, both I and the two art people had fatigue pour out all at once (bitter laugh).

"Huh? We ended up skipping meals," said the director. "If you'd said something, we could have had dinner breaks - nobody spoke up."

From beginning to end, only Director Yamauchi remained consistently upbeat and energetic at his own pace.

##

■Continues to Episode 31

(07.10.02)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 31: Once Upon a Time... (23) *Saint Seiya* Part 10 - Theatrical *Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth* - Preview Cuts and "Light, Shadow, and Color"

Last weekend I mowed the lawn at my parents' house. Since my father passed away in spring, including his illness period, it was the first lawn mowing in about a year. Oh man, it had grown completely wild - more like "grass cutting" than "lawn mowing."

I tried using a rechargeable lawn mower I bought online, but the main machine's charging took over ten hours - heartbreaking (cries). I ended up using the handheld clipper-like device that came as a bonus (?) to buzz-cut everything.

Man, this was fun! It cut amazingly well! Plus since it was so overgrown, I could cut huge swaths and it visibly became clean - quite satisfying (laughs). Ah, barbers cutting long hair must feel this kind of enjoyment (laughs).

Well, the battery dying after cutting about half the lawn was predictable (laughs). The rest carries over to next time.

And getting muscle soreness the next day was also predictable (laughs).

Well then.

After successfully finishing color direction meetings for theatrical

Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth

*, main episode cuts finally came to me. First, the preview edition advance batch.

Toei Doga's theatrical work method doesn't wait for complete storyboards - as soon as storyboards finish, animation meetings proceed and orders go to key animators. So what comes up first are the initial cuts that finished animation meetings early. Well, for initial previews, there's no need to use climax cuts - rather, main story introduction "atmosphere" cuts are stacked for previews. This time too, we made previews centered on opening scenes of Abel (■■■■) and Gold Saints appearing. Incidentally, back then preview cut selection and direction were assistant director jobs. Now they often just hand materials to preview editing companies from the start.

Though preview cuts, they're basically main episode cuts. But with the "tacit understanding" that "since we're shooting once first anyway," previews become pre-main story tests for various processing.

Now you can do quick test shots on PC, but back then was the cel painting + film photography era. Preparing materials, shooting, sending to labs for development - quite an effort. Moreover, since movies use 35mm film rather than TV series' 16mm film, development costs were enormously high - even brief shooting cost tremendous money. So previews could, in a sense, be openly used for test photography.

Still, even with test photography positioning and "tacit understanding," these are films shown to theater audiences, so the finished product is naturally a complete screen. Made premised on main episode use with "retake if no good." If this turns out perfectly OK, there's no need to reshoot for main episodes.

But actually trying it, various departments come up with "want to do it a bit more like this" or "want to change this here." So ultimately, over half the preview cuts became "reshoot for main episode," mainly adding/changing light-related processing. And some color direction also changed.

"Saori-san, let's change the atmosphere a bit after all?" said Director Yamauchi (■■■). He apparently wanted to tinker with Saori-san's scenes wearing the same clothes used on TV. However, we couldn't significantly alter main characters' hair or eye colors, and costumes were already progressing with current main character settings for quite a few cuts. "Well then..." so we decided to keep the design as-is and tinker with clothing colors.

So Saori-san's skirt, which was the same pink as the TV series in previews, became blue in the theatrical main story. However, this would later remain as a major flaw...

So previews finished and we plunged into the main story. This story, after arriving at the Sanctuary (■■■■■■■■■■), covers the short time from day to night. So we decided to properly handle time passage through art and "color." The flow of day → early evening → sunset → night would be created with cels matching backgrounds precisely.

As I wrote before, TV series

Saint Seiya

usually used normal color direction for most scenes regardless of day/night. So we decided to do the color changes we'd tried in the previous theatrical

The Heated Battle of the Gods

much more finely throughout the entire work.

The basic thinking was "the light and shadow colors of that space naturally apply to characters too." Sunlight pours down universally on background buildings, ground, and space. That light's color tones determine the space's color tones. Whether

blazing summer light, soft light through clouds, western sun, or morning sun. Not just sun - starlight, moonlight, illumination, lightning are the same. Or spaces where sun has set and light no longer reaches, night darkness, even hard-to-reach underwater spaces have their basic light and shadow color tones. So characters standing there receive the same light, create the same shadows, and are influenced by that space's color tones.

So first we match character brightness to the necessary spatial brightness, then pick up spatial (background) color tones and add them to character colors. The degree here is crucial. If brightness and color tones exactly match the background, characters assimilate with backgrounds and necessary acting becomes invisible. If we thought truly realistically, especially on starlit nights, cels and backgrounds assimilating would look correct, but that wouldn't work as screen composition. Conversely, if characters are too strong, acting becomes hollow and disappointing.

How much to match, how much to show. The degree of "making character presence and acting stand out" depends on work tendencies, but this

Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth

* became my first work in a sense for determining that "degree."

This remains my theme today.

Now digital coloring helps as a weapon, so that "degree" can aim for almost satisfying balance, but back then was still the cel paint era. Moreover, the desperately intermediate-color and low-saturation-lacking STAC colors, Toei color chart world. Plus the color count itself was overwhelmingly small. I spent every day and night repeatedly test-painting to explore what combinations would show the targeted color tones.

Looking back now, I think I used imagination more richly to create colors back then.

##

■Continues to Episode 32

(07.10.09)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 32: Once Upon a Time... (24) *Saint Seiya* Part 11 - Theatrical *Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth* - Completion and Setback

Hatarakids: Maiham-gumi

* started October 7th at 6:30 AM on TV Asahi. Episode 1's viewership was 3.3%! Man, considering it's a 6:30 AM show, that's quite a number.

So for further viewership increases, I contacted and promoted to several friends with small children... but got sad reactions like "Let me sleep on Sunday mornings (cries)" and "Let me sleep at least until

PreCure

at 8:30 (angry)" (cries). Ah, everyone's having a tough time (bitter laugh).

Still, I want lots of families with small children to watch

Hatarakids: Maiham-gumi

*. Look, you don't have to get up - just record it! (laughs) From November 2nd, nationwide broadcast on BS Asahi starts too. That one's at 6 PM!

Everyone please support

Hatarakids: Maiham-gumi

*!

Well then.

Though it's now normal to add color direction to key animation for overseas animation/finishing orders, back then adding color direction to in-between animation was still more common. Especially for theatrical works. "Since it's theatrical, we must make it carefully and properly." The studio was still full of that spirit. I was happy that internal tracing and painting staff especially had such feelings.

Toei Doga's internal staff, especially tracing staff, were remarkable in their technique. Staff who had handled all hand-trace works continuously. Though I naturally could do hand tracing as someone on the finishing fringe, man, I was nowhere near their level (laughs).

For cuts we wanted to finish especially carefully, we still sent them to internal painting then, but when requesting trace machine line corrections, particularly

small detailed drawings would be redrawn by hand trace. Certainly trace machine lines weren't suited to small drawings and became thick, blurred, crushed lines overall.

But actually, I disliked this all-hand tracing (laughs). For copyright posters or large drawings needing color trace lines it was naturally OK, but for small drawings it inevitably didn't match the original in-between animation lines. Subtle nose bridges or jaw lines - the lines became clean and beautiful, but still didn't capture the in-between animation line nuance. Rather, even somewhat faded or crushed, trace machine lines picked up drawing nuances as-is. Especially for works like

Saint Seiya

, image sharpness was the deciding factor.

Saying this would anger the tracing staff back then, but somehow it just didn't work for me, so I ended up issuing lots of tracing retakes. Ah, sorry (bitter laugh).

However, such care was possible during preview creation, the initial schedule period. Time gradually ran short while animation progressed slowly. Well, originally trying to handle a 70-minute theatrical work in 3-4 months was questionable itself. So cuts gradually switched to overseas animation/finishing orders.

Still, main story color direction work was enjoyable. Especially the "rematches" between Seiya and other Bronze Saints and Gold Saints! Though each duration was short, I could handle battles I couldn't directly color-direct during the TV series with new theatrical animation. Every time I held key animation or in-between animation and flipped through them, I was constantly excited. Facing good animation, key animation, or in-between animation, your spine goes "sharp" and your mind tightens. Such enjoyable tense days.

Around the same time, another company was producing a major theatrical work in full swing.

AKIRA

. Since it was notable work industry-wide in various ways, various stories about

AKIRA

's production situation leaked into our staff room. Originally longer than

Saint Seiya*, it seemed quite difficult in various ways.

Hearing such stories, our situation was also getting quite tough. Well, only the director maintained his usual pace, sitting firmly.

However, I'd fallen into a bad situation myself. A summer cold I caught once at the end of June had cleared up and seemed to improve... but perhaps from

accumulated fatigue from consecutive late-night work, coughing and fever continued afterward. Then in mid-July when main story color direction work was almost finished, I crashed with fever exceeding 40°C. Diagnosis: "acute pneumonia." Yes, doctor's orders stopped me.

Ultimately I couldn't check final cel deliveries. Though I could attend final checking, the retake replacement work limit had already passed, leaving several disappointing retakes. The biggest failure cut among them was one made for previews. The cut where Saori-san's skirt color was changed to blue somehow wasn't replaced when the master was assembled.

Thus ended the days of theatrical

Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth

. After that, by company orders I had one month of forced rest. Perhaps due to my "criminal record" of crashing during theatrical production, I was removed from staff for the 4th theatrical

Saint Seiya

released the following spring, and TV series

Saint Seiya* also changed production systems, so for the 2nd season "Asgard Arc (■■■■■■)" and 3rd season "Poseidon Arc (■■■■■■)," my work returned to only main-related character color direction.

(Just between us, I'm not convinced about Athena (■■■■) in theatrical work #4. Athena would never cry like that, and you shouldn't make Athena cry like that. That's impossible (laughs))

Then TV series

Saint Seiya

ended. For the final episode, I think I watched the first screening with everyone in the screening room, but somehow I have no memory of the content. While watching this final episode of a work I'd had many personal feelings about, my mind probably went to memories of

Saint Seiya

so far. Years later, encountering that final episode in a CATV rerun, I remember being stunned thinking "Ah, so this is how it ended" (bitter laugh).

Then one day after over ten years had passed. A certain story reached me: "They're doing a sequel.

Hades Twelve Temples Arc (■■■■■■■■■■)

is decided."

##

■Continues to Episode 33

(07.10.16)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 33: Special Episode - *The File of Young Kindaichi SP* Broadcast
Commemoration - How to Make Hajime-chan's Colors

It's been a while (sweat).

I took two weeks off from the series due to busyness from

The File of Young Kindaichi

* and other work rushes, then last week I caught a terrible cold and was half-dead.
Oh man... (sweat).

Actually, I caught this cold at an exorcism for

Hakaba Kitaro (■■■■■)

. It's being called the "Hakaba cold" in some circles (cries). Plus it spread to several

Kindaichi* finishing staff around me, so it's being called the "Kindaichi cold" in
some circles (cries).

Anyway, this cold entering its third week, but thankfully I can see the end
approaching. Ah, when things settle down I want to go to a hot spring...

When will things settle down? How many days? For better or worse, I'm packed
with work until April next year (wails).

Well then.

The File of Young Kindaichi

* returned after about 7 years. We made two new titles: "Opera House: The Last
Murder" and "Vampire Legend Murder Case." Broadcast over two weeks this week
and next. First, "Opera House: The Last Murder" aired on the 12th. Did everyone
watch it?

"Opera House: The Last Murder": Script by Shimada Mitsuru (■■■■), Character
Design & Animation Direction by Takeda Yoshihiro (■■■■■), Art Direction by
Akiyama Kentaro (■■■■■■), Direction by Ito Naoyuki (■■■■■).

"Vampire Legend Murder Case": Script by Shimada Mitsuru, Character Design &
Animation Direction by Maniwa Hideaki (■■■■■), Art Direction by Watanabe
Yoshito (■■■■■), Direction by Uda Konosuke (■■■■■■).

Kindaichi

after 7 years.

Looking back, when

The File of Young Kindaichi

began, it was still analog production with cel + film. Then from Episode 45 "Black Death Butterfly Murder Case" File 2, it suddenly switched to digital production. From then on, we got through by gradually correcting basic color direction data for each episode. So for me,

Kindaichi

was precious training in digital coloring and digital color design. New works of such a

Kindaichi*. I couldn't help getting excited (laughs).

The producer's request to me was "Don't significantly change main character impressions from the previous

Kindaichi

."

Kindaichi

has been broadcast for a long time and reruns continue on various stations. The established image must be inherited as-is.

During the previous TV series production, Araki Shingo (■■■■■) & Himeno Michi (■■■■■) and Kubo Hidemi (■■■■) handled character design throughout, but this time each animation director would handle character design.

Different directors and animation directors for each is normal, but it's rare for continuously broadcast series to have different character designers. Moreover, they'd broadcast consecutively over 2 weeks, so we had to avoid significantly different impressions between those two works.

So I considered various things when doing color design for both works.

First, when I colored both Hajimes using

Kindaichi

color direction from the end of the old series, they predictably became something different. Well, naturally. Hair highlight placement, eye drawing methods, facial contour volume - since animation differed from the old series, the atmosphere naturally changed too. So various fine adjustments. Reconstructing balance matching each character designer's animation.

Hair highlight brightness against base hair color tones, adding/subtracting color tone intensity matching eye animation. Applied to each of the three - Hajime (■■■■), Miyuki (■■■), and Inspector Kenmochi (■■■). Naturally, we couldn't damage the "balance of three," so careful attention was needed. The result was this time's three characters. So "Opera House" and "Vampire Legend" have subtly different basic color direction for all three characters.

Next, clothing color tones.

For works with source material, we often base colors on those in the original, but static manga images and animation moving through space are quite different. Often they can't all be the same. Considering character overlap, presence, balance with art backgrounds, we think about color combinations and presentation methods for the animation version.

For me, Miyuki has been "yellow + pink basics" since the old series (laughs), so both works were completed first with roughly the usual balance and volume. For Kenmochi in "Opera House," I wanted tension of "charging into a place with two previous murders," so I dressed him in a sharp dark suit. This matched the original book cover's dark suit too. In "Vampire Legend," I wanted relatively private casualness, so I used the unfashionable light brown jacket used often in the old series. V-neck sweaters are also typical Kenmochi (laughs).

Hajime always troubles me. He's supposedly the protagonist (laughs), so protagonist-like "presence" and "character standing" are necessary, but he's not a hero show protagonist and supposedly a normal high school student (bitter laugh), so the basics are subdued with one accent color. So this time too, I considered him after somewhat settling other characters' colors.

Guest characters came up with costume designs close to the original, so I basically referenced the original to balance and place colors. "Opera House" owner Hibiki Shizuka (■■■■) and director Kageshima (■■■) were done quite stereotypically. Lake Moon Leona's slightly orange hair color was Director Ito-kun's preference (laughs). "Vampire Legend" had some characters with gender changed from the original, so those parts were original. Personally, I like Nekoma Junko (■■■■■) (laughs).

So, Hajime. Ultimately, "Opera House" settled on the original book cover's light green-based color. "Vampire Legend," set entirely in the dim ruined hotel, I considered colors that would show well under the mystery-solving guest room's standing lamp, settling on a red parka with yellow shirt combination.

The old series often had multi-day stories with lots of character costume changes, especially Hajime - when stuck for clothing color ideas, I'd directly use colors of shirts and jackets I often wore then (laughs), which was quite enjoyable. But this time both works were roughly one-night stories without costume changes -

disappointing (laughs).

Now, main story design discussion.

Both works this time are the standard "incidents in buildings isolated from outside." Moreover, both are "rainy" "nights" (laughs). So almost all cuts were indoors.

Kindaichi

's basics are dialogue drama, so I designed with scenes where characters gather and build conversations as brightness standards for main story. "Opera House" used the fireplace room, "Vampire Legend" used the lounge as color direction standards. However, these aren't finishing color direction "normals" but somewhat adjusted for brightness and color tone matching background spaces. In my case, color tones under natural light in bright places are basic "normal" colors, and when they enter various spaces, I adjust color tones considering how they look and what impressions they give.

For example, putting so-called "normal" colored characters directly against incandescent lighting room backgrounds makes them float white against the background and look unnatural. So this time too, I adjusted character color direction brightness and shadow strength for each scene's space, then added that space's light color tones. In the Opera House theater darkness, I added background darkness blue for blending.

This time, especially for "Vampire Legend," I aimed for overall dimmer colors than "Opera House" to create the oppressive feeling of never leaving the hotel and the scary atmosphere of vampire legends.

I set mystery-solving scenes relatively brightly too. After all, it's "mystery solving" - revealing and explaining trick secrets. So I considered making things easily visible. However, "Vampire Legend" followed the story and was kept slightly darker. But it created good atmosphere with tightly focused highlights.

Like this, both works are finished as almost entirely "color-changed" works (laughs). Looking back, places using "normal" color direction were just the final few cuts in both "Opera House" and "Vampire Legend."

Adding to scene color design designed this way, I apply arrangements cut by cut following directorial flow - intentionally exaggerating for impression or conversely burying to erase impression. First create atmosphere, then add meaning.

Especially important for works like

Kindaichi

, and very enjoyable work for color designers and color directors. Incidentally, this time Akimoto Yuki (■■■■■) handled "Opera House" color direction, while I handled "Vampire Legend" color direction myself.

Additionally, both works this time had Ota Sunao-kun's (■■■■) Toei Animation special effects team working hard. Character eye gradations and gradient brush shadows added to character shadows are mostly the special effects team's handwork. While Toei works normally can't add elaborate special effects to TV productions, they worked hard as if releasing daily frustrations (laughs).

Such slightly luxurious effort went into

The File of Young Kindaichi SP

* (laughs).

The other day, talking with Directors Ito-kun and Uda-kun, we laughed that Inspector Kenmochi is probably about our actual age now. Ito-kun, Uda-kun, and I are roughly the same age. So we thought, "Ah, we're 'old men' too now" (laughs). Though we're such "old men," we'd like to do

The File of Young Kindaichi

* again.

##

■Continues to Episode 34

(07.11.13)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 34: Once Upon a Time... (25) *Saint Seiya* Part 12 - And After 15 Years, "Saint Seiya Hades Twelve Temples Arc" Begins

Did you watch

The File of Young Kindaichi SP

that aired over two weeks? Behind that main broadcast, I attended the Anime Style Mononoke* event.

I'd only watched

Mononoke

on TV, but Director Nakamura-kun (■■■) is somewhat of a friend, several main staff are also

Hakaba

staff, and above all I heard Color Designer Nagai-san (■■■) would be dragged onto the stage, so "I must go cheer them on!" I went with Sakuma-san (■■■■) who handled

Mononoke

color direction. It's rare for color design or color direction to appear at such events. Hence the "cheering" (laughs).

Work delayed my leaving the studio, arriving at the venue around 8 PM. The venue was packed to capacity with great success, and on stage were host Oguro-san (■■■) and Director Nakamura plus main staff in a row! Nagai-san was properly on the far right.

At the event, Director Nakamura talked and talked (explosion). This person has always been excellent at speaking (laughs). Today too, he got things going with exquisite talk (laughs).

Still, the

Mononoke

staff had really good teamwork. The confidence and dignity of staff who survived hell and left good work - each staff member's talk was filled with depth and confidence, making it a very good event.

Now, let's work hard on

Hakaba

too! (laughs)

Well then.

Continuing the

Saint Seiya

story.

"We're doing

Saint Seiya

.

Hades Twelve Temples Arc

is decided," said a production department bigwig. "What? No way!" I said. Those were my immediate words.

Early summer 2002. There had been vague rumors since the previous year, but I never imagined it would actually happen. In a sense,

Saint Seiya

at this point seemed late.

While saying that, my mood was incredibly excited, and I loudly declared "I'll do it! I want to do it! Let me absolutely do it!" while wildly waving my hands to appeal for participation (laughs).

Honestly, I was initially somewhat hesitant. Though called a sequel, 15 years had passed since it ended. Too much time had passed. Who would direct? Would Araki-san (■■■) draw? If that era's spirit was missing, even with the

Saint Seiya

package, wouldn't it become something completely different? Such anxieties made me initially think about observing quietly. That's how important

Saint Seiya

was to me.

But such anxieties were easily resolved. Araki-san would draw, Yamauchi-san (■■■) would be Chief Director. Other staff from that era were gathering one after another too. The cast would also continue with the longtime members. "It's here!" I absolutely had to participate! (laughs)

For me, this was revenge for that theatrical

Legend of Crimson Youth

. That feeling was also fact.

New wind also came. "I watched the TV broadcast and imitated it playing!" were the words of Director Yamauchi's beloved disciple, Director Nagamine-kun (■■■). Ah, 15 years - I found myself staring into the distance (bitter laugh). For art, Iijima-san (■■■) from Studio MAO joined. And most new of all, Kawase-san's (■■■) Toei Animation CG department team participated.

15 years from the film & cel painting era, now coloring through photography is the digital processing era. This time's

Saint Seiya

would build most Twelve Temple backgrounds as CG backgrounds. By building CG models of the Twelve Temples and cutting them out according to scenes, we could use not just normal screens but also 3D-style camerawork previously impossible. Additionally, we thought the numerous techniques unleashed by Saints could be shown more three-dimensionally using CG.

So Araki-san's drawn settings finally came up. This time's enemies are Underworld Specters (■■■■/■■■■■■■) and Gold Saints revived wearing Surplices (■■■). First we had to consider their colors. This time without toy manufacturer sponsor constraints, "first try thinking freely," said the director. So referencing original colors while basically aiming for

Saint Seiya

animation-style volume with black-gray-purple combinations.

We had to distinguish between Surplices worn by revived Gold Saints and Surplices of original Specters like Rhadamanthys (■■■■■■■■■) through color differences, while creating unity for overall Surplices and Specters. So as a common element, I set one "must-use color" in color divisions to build colors, plus added slightly pale green to Specters' white eyes to differentiate from living Saints like Seiya.

Then Kurumada-sensei's (■■■) check. Since it differed somewhat from the original, I was secretly nervous, but got OK without particular complaints. Now main story could start.

Actually, when I first placed colors on characters, I deliberately lowered saturation significantly, making them quite subdued. I explored somewhat adult, so-called "un-Toei-like" color tone development. But it was different. It became "something Saint Seiya-ish" and somehow felt "fake" (bitter laugh). Plus this time, everything

was at night. When I placed the initially created subdued versions against backgrounds, they beautifully assimilated with backgrounds (laughs). Ah, this won't work.

So I decided to deliberately create color tones "Toei-like" or

Saint Seiya

-like for basic colors.

Well, just between us, looking back now, minor Specters could have had more subdued color tones (bitter laugh). That's what I think now, but back then I worried and decided quite a lot even then. That was the best at that time, if not better. So I think that was fine.

Instead, we did quite detailed "color changing" in the main story. From set "normal" color tones, we created "night colors" by slightly lowering brightness and saturation while adding blue tones - this became the basic coloring for the entire work. When emitting auras or unleashing techniques like "Pegasus Meteor Fist (■■■■■■■■)," we used "aura colors" with strengthened normal shadow parts. Then we stacked countless "special colorings" for each episode and scene.

Making each episode became educational every time. Skills gradually improved toward later episodes, and things I wanted to try increased. Consulting and trying these with each episode's directors. Like the initial TV series days, I couldn't help enjoying thinking about various things (laughs).

Saints' unleashed techniques mostly became CG effect-added processing. Creating screens through collaboration with the CG section. Though I'd worked on various productions, this was my first experience creating screens through such extensive back-and-forth collaboration. This was also very educational. I got to voice many opinions about CG, and we researched and created screens together.

However, what was difficult was fusing 3D into 2D cel + background screens.

Saint Seiya

is thoroughly 2D animation drawing world. 2D-drawn dimensionality and pure 3D dimensionality screens were often incompatible. Still, gradually understanding the key points episode by episode, direction and animation gradually improved at using and showing CG effects. Well, first it's how much acting can be worked into storyboards. Then how animators draw that up, and how directors control it further. That remains the foundation.

Among effects we worked on this way, one thing just wouldn't work well: "Pegasus Meteor Fist." The dynamic power accelerating from background to foreground inevitably became weak with CG alone. Despite multiple retakes and attempts, it still failed. So "Pegasus Meteor Fist" became traditional animation, TP + brush.

##

■Continues to Episode 35

(07.11.20)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 35: Once Upon a Time... (26) *Saint Seiya* Part 13 - About the Final Episode of "**Saint Seiya Hades Twelve Temples Arc**"

The other day my ordered

Ratatouille

* DVD arrived, so I immediately watched it with my wife on my home 37-inch "Kameyama Model."

3DCG animated movies really are great to watch in this environment too. Man, it was incredibly beautiful and amazing. Scenes with massive groups of mice swarming around - that was really something... (laughs).

This

Ratatouille

is my top anime of the year. The screen is wonderful, and above all, not one truly bad person appears. That's crucial. Nobody gets killed either. Even that critic Ego and the chef who was causing trouble ended up happy eating ratatouille at the end. I want to watch movies like this repeatedly.

In the final epilogue scene, my wife watching with me said: "That critic got a bit fatter, didn't he?"

During the story, protagonist Linguini tells Ego at their first meeting, "You like food but you're thin?" Receiving that, the epilogue probably made not just his personality but also his visuals slightly "plumper." Hmm, I see. I hadn't noticed that detail.

Movies and anime are definitely more interesting when watched with someone.

Oh, and delicious food too (laughs).

Well then.

The 13-episode

Saint Seiya: Hades Twelve Temples Arc

* raised our staff's tension with each episode. Since Sky Perfect TV advanced broadcast preceded DVD release, completion and delivery had to match that advanced broadcast, making quite tight schedules from series latter half, especially after Episode 9. Still, once things got exciting, there was no turning back. Every

episode continued with deliveries stubbornly holding out until the very limit.

For

Saint Seiya: Hades Twelve Temples Arc

, I handled all color design, color direction input, and finishing delivery final checking for Episode 1, but from Episode 2 onward Sakuma Yoshiko-san (■■■■■■■) took charge. For episodes with gross production requested from

Dangan Pictures

, Suzuki Rumiko-san (■■■■■■■), who handled color direction for

Lifework

* production episodes during the old TV series, participated in finishing inspection and special effects. She added another spoonful of essence to my color design to expand story volume.

Color design creates series or episode color blueprints, but for each episode, color direction and inspection are key.

For example, "The character color direction from color design for this scene is this brightness and color, but let's strengthen shadows a bit more for this cut to add impression."

Some color designers might say "Do everything exactly as I say!" but I think "As long as you maintain forms following basics, feel free to add where you can add." We design flow based on storyboards, but animation is living. Certainly storyboards show this kind of acting, but animation often changes things. Confirming actual animation each time is quite difficult.

Gradual addition/subtraction considering actual delivered animation flow, story/directorial intent, and screen brilliance is color directors' specialty. When actually facing individual cut animation (key animation, in-between animation) and specifying appropriate "colors" for those images, plus controlling painted results, sense and experience matter most.

Then Sakuma-san, whom I trusted absolutely for color direction, was taken away to color design another work (cries), so I handled color direction for the final 3 episodes again. Actually watching each completed episode, I honestly thought "I want to try color direction for the end myself" (laughs). The story was reaching climax! My feelings intensified. And the final episode. I approached this final episode thinking it might truly be the "last

Saint Seiya

." The direction was Director Yamauchi. I fought with the intention of making it my culmination.

My final episode battle had the shortest schedule among all 13 episodes, but it was my most enjoyable battle. Truly a revenge match for

Legend of Crimson Youth

(laughs).

Director Yamauchi's sense of "timing (ma)." The distance between characters, breathing "timing," "timing" when layering action probably suits

Saint Seiya

best. Particularly this final Episode 13 had all those beautifully condensed, I think.

Meetings themselves always ended quickly. Discussing points of concern and important points, then "Please take care of it." This time was the same. From there was my battle.

This final Episode 13 was almost entirely battles inside Hades Castle (■■■■■■), but every scene was special coloring through light and shadow, scene by scene. I designed color tones for each scene, but time was insufficient and backgrounds weren't coming up. Normally I should decide colors properly before sending to doshi

(animation + finishing work), but I couldn't hold key animation at my place. The schedule was already insufficient. I wanted animation work to advance even slightly.

So I created colors with hunches like "probably like this!" and sent

doshi

orders. After backgrounds came up, I'd try matching - if OK as-is, lucky; if not, work hard to repaint. I color-directed several scenes like this. Result: roughly perfect, but ah, I wanted to adjust various things anyway and ended up correcting most

TP

deliveries myself (bitter laugh).

Still, actually touching real animation is enjoyable. Checking key animation coming to me while getting excited. When wonderful key animation or in-between animation comes up, I get happy and tense simultaneously. "I must put good colors on this to make good screens!" Such feelings make me tense. As expected for the final episode, every cut had wonderful key animation, but what particularly made me tense and excited was the hand-to-hand combat action scene between

Rhadamanthys

and the four Saints including Seiya in

Pandora

's room. Flowing animation. True animation brilliance!

Touching such key animation, getting excited, working hard but enjoyably while tension rises, I think "I want to keep working on this episode forever" (laughs).

But well, that's impossible (bitter laugh).

I sent all cels to photography and repeated rush checking. Then, the last. I gave OK to Hades Castle collapse cuts and finished all cuts. Amazingly, it was the morning before broadcast.

Thus

Saint Seiya: Hades Twelve Temples Arc

ended. Thanks to this work becoming a big DVD sales hit, afterwards theatrical

Saint Seiya: Heaven Chapter Overture

then

Sanctuary Chapter

and

Elysion Chapter

* would be made, but well, those stories are for another time.

As an aside, Golden Week 2001, I went to Greece on my honeymoon. I spent time on Aegean Sea islands, and also visited a small island called Delos. This World Heritage island has temples, sculptures, and Roman-era ruins throughout. Just like the Sanctuary. Standing atop Mount Kinthos (■■■■■■) in the island's center, looking down at the ruins spread below, I thought ah, maybe the scenery the Saints saw was like this too. A bit moving. Somehow I felt like bronze-colored Saint Cloth boxes might be lying around there.

##

■Continues to Episode 36

(07.11.27)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 36: Once Upon a Time... (27) - The Long Battle Over "Color Direction" Credits, Part 1

The mornings and evenings have gotten quite cold, and even Tokyo's autumn leaves have finally settled down. The trees in the park in front of my house have completely shed their leaves over the past few days, taking on a distinctly winter appearance.

When it's not raining, I basically commute by bicycle the 10 kilometers from my home in Nakano to the studio in Oizumi. During this season, it gets cold, so I'm thoroughly equipped for winter. The morning commute isn't too bad, but since I come home late at night, sometimes in the early morning hours, it gets absolutely freezing cold.

My basic style is a new-material long-sleeve T-shirt and fleece on top. Over that, a Gore-Tex parka with a fleece neck warmer around my neck. On my hands, cycling gloves. Below, boxer shorts and more new-material "high-tech long underwear," plus mountaineering long pants.

These new-material underwear items are absolutely amazing. They convert sweat moisture into heat (?), so they're warm, and they let excess sweat escape, keeping the skin feeling smooth and dry. Pretty good! At the studio where it's warm, I work just in that underwear. Oh, of course I put on pants and such for the lower half (laugh).

There's just one drawback. This underwear is body-conscious wear that fits tightly to the body, so it naturally reveals all your body lines completely. Especially around the belly area, it's a bit... bulging.

Ah... I really need to work harder at cycling... (crying).

Well then.

Today's topic is about staff credits.

Most productions have staff credits in both the opening and ending.

First, the opening credits feature the people responsible for the overall production—the "core" staff, so to speak. Planning, production, original work, screenplay, music, character design, chief animation director, art director, color design (■■■■), photography director, sound director, and recently CG director, plus the director—in TV series, that's the series director—and so on. This varies between theatrical films, TV works, and OVAs, but that's roughly the format.

[illegible]

Now, I'm not certain about other companies, but at Toei Animation, especially for theatrical works, there's an established rule about credits. That is: "Names credited in the opening are, in principle, not credited in the ending."

So what happens is this: in recent theatrical works where I've handled both color design and color direction, when my name is credited in the opening, it doesn't appear in the ending. I argued, "But I'm also doing color direction, so put me in the ending under 'Color Direction,'" but it was still no good (bitter laugh). So for both

CLANNAD

and

Digimon Savers THE MOVIE: Ultimate Power Burst Mode Activated!!

, my name only appears in the opening.

But you know, animation directors get their names listed under key animation too.
Hmm... mysterious.

This "rule" is also partially applied to TV productions. In the recently aired

The Kindaichi Case Files SP

, the first episode "Opera House: The Final Murder" had someone else handling color direction, so her name appears in the ending under "Color Direction." But for "The Vampire Legend Murder Case," which I handled for color direction, there's no "Color Direction" credit in the ending.

Well, for this

Kindaichi SP

, since it follows the style of standalone theatrical productions, that's how it goes. But for the currently airing

GeGeGe no Kitaro

, in principle, color designer Itasaka-san has been handling all the color direction for each episode single-handedly, so there's also no "Color Direction" credit in the ending. Until now, that is.

However, there was a staff member who got caught up in this rule. From episode 35, one color director newly joined

GeGeGe no Kitaro

, but since they'd been going without "Color Direction" credits for so long, the person in charge didn't notice the change and forgot to include the credit. So the color direction for

GeGeGe no Kitaro

episode 35 was done by Kobioki-san.

Also, with a slightly different meaning, there's the currently airing

Hataraki Kids: My Ham-gumi

. This production also has my name listed as color designer. In this case, I'm handling the main color design, but the individual episode color design is handled by Toyonaga-san, who's credited under color direction. So this is another pattern that exists.

Now, regarding these "Color Direction" and "Color Design" credits—while Toei productions nowadays normally credit color design and color direction, when I started working over 20 years ago, neither "Color Design" nor "Color Direction" were credited.

As I've written before, at the time, Toei Doga (now Toei Animation) had a system where the art department had major decision-making authority over everything color-related, with the art staff determining both character color design and special coloring direction. So we were "inspectors," and while we were actually doing color direction and color design, we were positioned as a department that inspected the finished coloring.

So in the ending credits of productions, theatrical works were divided into "Tracing," "Coloring," and "Inspection," but TV productions lumped everyone together under "Finishing."

When I joined Toei Doga, I thought "Well, I guess that's how it is," but after experiencing several productions, I began to think "Is this really right?" Sure, we were doing "inspection," but the work of "color direction" had actually become the main job in terms of balance.

While the art department was still giving initial color instructions, all the work from that point on was handled by us. Most importantly, the job of putting color direction into each and every cut—this work was what controlled the overall cel output, and we had a kind of pride in that. It seemed wrong that this work wasn't credited with the proper terminology that described what it actually was.

And so, the long battle over "Color Direction" credits began...

■ Continued in Episode 37

(07.12.11)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 37: New Year Special - Pre-Broadcast Special!

Hakaba Kitaro

Starts This Week!

A new year has arrived. How did everyone spend New Year's?

This year, our household was in mourning, so it didn't really feel much like "New Year's." I worked until the 30th, went to Asakusa on New Year's Eve to eat year-end soba, then came home to drink wine and crash while watching the Red and White Song Battle. After the new year began, I didn't even do the "traditional New Year's Eve night card writing" (← So late!). On the 1st and 2nd, I just paid visits to my parents' house and my wife's parents' house respectively, and that was it. I spent just the 3rd relaxing for the day, then started regular work from the 4th. That's about it.

Thanks to that, I had no "New Year's stupor" and was able to jump into full-throttle work mode, which feels good. And at the start of work, I received various souvenirs from people who had gone home for the holidays. Since both my wife and I were born in Tokyo, we don't have the experience of what's called "going home" during New Year's and such. So while listening to stories about New Year's at their hometowns from people who went home, I munched on the sweets they brought back. I received all sorts of things again this year (laugh).

One item that's become a regular souvenir every year is "Mamadohru." Oh my, it's incredibly delicious! It's a souvenir from Sakuma-san, who shares my office—a Fukushima specialty. Ah, the blissful "Mamadohru" (joy). Please bring some again next time (laugh).

That's my new year.

However...

Something around my belly seems to have increased considerably... Huh? That's strange... even though we were in mourning (← meaningless).

Well then.

New Year calls for "specials," of course. So this week is brought to you as a special (laugh).

I've been involved in several projects since last year, including

Hataraki Kids: My Ham-gumi

and

Saint Seiya: Hades Elysion Chapter

(■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■), but the main focus right now is definitely

Hakaba Kitaro

(■■■■■■).

I didn't know this, but apparently this January marks the 40th anniversary of the TV version of

Kitaro

. Forty years ago means 1968 (Showa 43). I was still only 5 years old then (laugh). The first episode apparently aired on January 3rd of that year. January 3rd, no less! These days, it would be almost impossible to have a new anime series start on a nationwide network on January 3rd, right? It must have been a production they really put their heart into.

That first

GeGeGe no Kitaro

was a black-and-white anime. According to Toei Animation's website, it was "Toei Doga's final black-and-white production." Ah, that's right. I think our house already had a color TV by then, so it was a work from exactly that transition period.

In our house at the time, I wasn't really allowed to watch TV anime much, and I probably didn't know about

GeGeGe no Kitaro

. Well, I do have some vague memory of glimpsing it back then. But I wasn't watching it every week without fail or anything like that. The so-called second series of

Kitaro

that was made several years later—I remember watching that quite a bit.

I properly watched that black-and-white

Kitaro

when I was in middle school or high school, I think it was summer? Around that time, Fuji TV was rerunning it from about 6 AM on Sunday mornings. I think they might have been broadcasting it without commercials? I watched it every week without fail. In a room with the shutters still closed, staying dark, watching the black-and-white

Kitaro

. It had a really good atmosphere and was somehow scary.

"Jigoku Nagashi" (Hell Current), "Yasha," "Suiko" (Water Tiger), "Oritatami Nyudo" (Folding Monk), "Vampire Elite"—these were episodes I loved. I still remember them pretty well when I think back. "Daikaijuu" (Great Sea Monster) and "Obake Naita" (Ghost Night Game) were especially good. After watching "Obake Naita," I remember unconsciously groaning "Uuu~mu! (grin)" (laugh).

So, 40 years after that black-and-white

Kitaro

,

Hakaba Kitaro

begins this Thursday, January 10th.

Actually, in preparing for this production, I read the restored original manga for the first time. It had such a nostalgic scent, yet was very innovative, very rich but also refreshing. It was an original work overflowing with indescribable charm. Man, I was hooked! I wish I could have encountered and read it much earlier. Additionally, as visual reference material, we had them gather art books of Mizuki-sensei's work, and I got completely absorbed in those too. Amazing, the worldview and color sensibility of Mizuki Shigeru.

How to bring this unique atmosphere to the screen—director Chioka and all the staff worked on this together, feeling our way, and somehow managed to give it shape.

I'll write just a little about it (laugh), but usually screens are almost entirely determined by the combination of animation/finishing and backgrounds. This time, however, special screen processing in photography is added to that. This photographic processing creates the unique atmosphere in the final result.

However, that photographic processing dramatically changes how both the cels and backgrounds look. We create the cel colors using "reverse calculation" thinking: "To make the screen look like this in the final result, what colors should the cels be?"

So the colors of cels painted according to the color direction are very different from the cel colors in the actual completed screen. For this production, we created a color conversion filter specifically for color direction. When creating character colors, we place this filter over the cels to check the color tones. Honestly, it's incredibly time-consuming, but working while getting excited about how the screen will turn out is very enjoyable.

After a difficult production process, episode #1 was completed right at the end of last year. The night before delivery, late at night, I watched the completed version of #1 in the editing room at Oizumi Studio, and man, Nozawa Masako-san's voice as Kitaro gave me chills (laugh). Yeah, it's perfect—actually beyond my imagination, and I was moved. It's been a while since I was this happy hearing a voice performance. Somehow, it felt like something connected deep in my memory.

In that way, not just the story and direction, but also in terms of animation and screen texture, plus voice and music, I think it's turned out to be a production with considerable spirit put into it. Some unexpected people are involved in the OP and ED, but I'm apparently not supposed to reveal that yet, so it's a secret (laugh). Ah, there are many other things I'd like to write about, but first, please watch

Hakaba Kitaro

.

Unfortunately, it's basically broadcasting in the Kanto local slot, and the networked Kansai and Tokai regions will have broadcasts about a week delayed. Ah, I wish people nationwide could watch it. People in other regions will probably have to wait for the DVD?

In any case, please look forward to it!

■ Continued in Episode 38

(08.01.08)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 38: Once Upon a Time... (28) - The Long Battle Over "Color Direction" Credits, Part 2

Did you catch

Hakaba Kitaro

, which started broadcasting last week?

Right after the broadcast ended, I immediately went around looking at reactions on the web (including 2ch (laugh)). I think honest reactions are really those first impressions right after watching something. When time passes and you see other people's reactions, there's often a tendency for humans to correct and reorganize their own thoughts. So I kept clicking around doing searches until about 3 AM (laugh).

It was received with mixed reactions, pretty much as expected, which was reassuring in a way. I hope it becomes a topic of conversation in various ways and many people watch it. Thanks to this, we apparently got a good 4.8% viewership rating for the first episode, which makes me very happy. Even so, we just need to continue through the series without wavering from our center, keeping our focus steady.

By the way, there was actually content checking by the TV station at the storyboard stage, and we got feedback about expressions that would be problematic for broadcast.

For episode #1, things like the frog's eyeball stretching out with a squishy sound were NG (← the sound is there though), showing the hand that throws (shoves) baby Kitaro was NG, naturally hitting the gravestone with his eye was NG, showing the lesions under Kitaro's father's bandages was NG, naturally blood spattering was also NG, and so on. The blood bank storyline from the original, as well as the part from the original where Kitaro smokes cigarettes freely, were also removed from the setting in light of various contemporary circumstances.

Some feedback mentioned that the "expressions were mild," but there were those circumstances. After all, we're making

Hakaba Kitaro

as a TV broadcast production.

It's truly unfortunate that it's not a nationwide broadcast, but starting this week, people in Kansai and Tokai regions should be able to watch it too. Please give it a try (^_^).

Well then.

Continuing the story about "Color Direction" credits.

I wanted to somehow get a "Color Direction" credit created in the ending, but I didn't know how to go about it. I had no idea who I should ask at the time. So for starters, I went to my direct supervisor, the finishing department manager.

"Um, I'd like to have a 'Color Direction' credit created in the TV series ending..." I said.

"Hm? That sort of thing is decided policy, so no," said the manager.

"Huh? Why not? Who decides this policy?"

My switch flipped and I launched into a one-sided exposition of my theory to the manager. The folly of youth (bitter laugh).

"That sort of thing is..." The manager was momentarily taken aback, but still tried to calm me down while explaining how difficult it would be. I still wasn't convinced, but when the manager said "I'll consider it as a future matter for now," I couldn't do anything more and retreated.

This was during the time I was working on

Saint Seiya

(■■■■■). In the end, that discussion just faded away, and for the next 10 years, there was no "Color Direction" credit in TV series endings (bitter laugh).

Around that time, my work gradually shifted from TV to theatrical and video productions. So I thought, "Maybe weekly TV series are impossible, but standalone theatrical works might work somehow?" I was stubbornly persistent (bitter laugh).

Unlike TV series, theatrical version ending credits properly had a "Inspection" credit category from before, and I had my name listed under "Inspection" for

Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro: The Great Yokai War

(■■■■ ■■■■■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■■) and

Theatrical Saint Seiya: The Heated Battle of the Gods

(■■■■ ■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■■). So I thought, couldn't we attach "Color Direction" to that "Inspection" for the credit? Actually, the work content of "Inspection" was "Color Direction" and "Finishing Inspection," so if we could clarify that by having it read "Color Direction Inspection," maybe I could push for that and make it work somehow? That was my strategy (laugh).

So this time I used various means... well, it's not like I had political power, but whenever the opportunity arose, I'd explain the purpose to various people, building

understanding among related parties through what you might call networking, and I worked at it more persistently. As a result, I was able to get my name listed in the ending of

Theatrical Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth

(■■■■ ■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■■) under the "Color Direction Inspection" credit!

This was quite moving. Especially since

Theatrical Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth

was a work with strong obsession and emotional investment in color, when "Color Direction Inspection: Tsujita Kunio" appeared in the ending, I got all warm and fuzzy inside. I haven't investigated every single old production, but I think this was probably the first time a "Color Direction" credit appeared in a Toei production (sorry if I'm wrong).

Once a precedent or format is established, it gets carried forward. For a while after this, "Color Direction Inspection" became the established credit for theatrical production endings.

■ Continued in Episode 39

(08.01.15)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 39: Setting Aside "Color Direction" for a Bit to Talk About

Hakaba Kitaro

Man, Tokyo's been having cold days that really feel like the depths of winter.

Every year around this time, during the Center Test period (when I was a high school student, it was still called the "Common First-Stage Test"), Tokyo would always get snow, but it hasn't snowed for the past several years, has it? This year too, the Meteorological Agency forecast snow, but my expectations (laugh) were betrayed and it ended in disappointment. But cold days are still continuing, so I'd like to wait in anticipation.

Tokyo hasn't had much real snow lately. I'd like it to accumulate enough for snowball fights at least once a year. As a snow lover, it's quite lonely. Ah, I want to see snow. I want to go play somewhere snowy—an outdoor hot spring while snow is falling would be the ultimate... such are my fantasies and desperate wishes these days (laugh).

But if I took a break now, I'd probably get killed. I'm super busy being chased by

Hakaba Kitaro

work and coming home in the early morning almost every day. What surprised me about working on a TV series again after so long was the fact that "Why is one week so short?!" (bitter laugh). Ah, there's way too little time! But I'm in the middle of very enjoyable days.

Well then.

I really should be continuing the story about "Color Direction" credits... but I'm too busy with actual work to properly take time to write the manuscript (crying). Sorry about that.

So I'll write a little about

Hakaba Kitaro

instead. I'll talk a bit about the opening and ending that I couldn't write about two episodes ago.

Hakaba Kitaro

is currently airing to great acclaim in Fuji TV's late-night "NoitaminA" slot, and following the first episode's 4.8% rating, episode 2 was an amazing 4.9%! The producer and director are getting all excited saying "Let's aim for 10%!" (laugh),

and thanks to this good start, the broadcast area is steadily expanding. Man, I'm really happy!

For this opening and ending, director Nakamura Kenji from

Mononoke

handled the storyboard and direction. The key animation—or rather, all the animation—was done by Hashimoto Takafumi, also from

Mononoke

. The art was by Magic House, special effects by Hoshino-kun from Toei Animation, and photography by Tatsunoko Pro's photography department.

That opening uses panels from Mizuki-sensei's original manga as motifs, but everything was redrawn by Hashimoto-san, and moreover, it was essentially done in one take with marker pens. Amazing! We scanned those and had the finishing staff do the base colors, then I worked on determining the color tones while painting. Hashimoto-san's animation work took 4 days, overlapping with my work period of 3 days, then 2 days for photography. From completed storyboard to finished photography, it was an ultra-short decisive battle of just one week! (laugh) By the way, why it became such a short decisive battle is a secret! (bitter laugh)

As viewers can tell, the photography is essentially one-cut processing, including the live-action parts at the end. Same with the ending. When the rushes came up, there was a pleasant murmur in the screening room (laugh). Since so few people were involved in the work, nobody knew the content. Even those of us who were involved were surprised by how it turned out.

For the ending, we actually reshoot it every episode. The text flowing on screen is different each time (laugh). I also determine the colors and make replacements for each episode.

Director Nakamura and I had been saying "We'd like to do something together" whenever we met for a long time, and finally, that wish came true this time. Yeah, it was great. I'd like to do something interesting together again (laugh) > Director Nakamura

The opening and ending we made this way turned out to be quite interesting, I think.

So please watch this week too, everyone!

■ Continued in Episode 40

(08.01.22)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 3: Once Upon a Time... (2)

I recently bought a new computer for work.

A

MacPro

. I've finally become an intel-mac user. I increased the memory to 5GB and immediately put it to work. Whoa, it's fast!

Photoshop

,

TraceMan

, and

PaintMan

are all running smoothly at speeds I've never experienced in my personal history! Now if only my own hands could get faster... (distant stare).

Well then.

Immediate correction from last time (laughs).

It was 1985 when I joined Toei Doga. I just counted on my fingers again because the years didn't seem to match up (bitter laugh). So, the story from that 1985.

My first job at Toei Doga was

[finishing progress]

in the finishing department. Yes, not color direction, but starting with progress work first. I wanted to properly understand the production system first, so I deliberately asked to start with progress work, which I should have been relatively familiar with.

At Toei Doga, progress staff were assigned to both finishing and art backgrounds respectively, coordinating with production progress to manage finishing orders and cel deliveries for each work (background orders and deliveries for art backgrounds). This is still the same today. Usually, production progress manages everything by work, but Toei Doga's work production operates more like a "factory" system, creating multiple works in bulk and in parallel rather than by individual work, so this type of departmental management system becomes effective.

First I was assigned to

Dream Soldier Wingman (■■■■■■■■■■)

. I helped with the last few episodes of this work. Or rather, I was still like an apprentice at this point, learning the work know-how by following seniors. Soon after, I became in charge of the new program

Compora Kid (■■■■■■■■■■)

. After being involved from the launch of this program through about one cours, I finally transferred to

[inspection]

.

As I wrote last time, Toei Doga's internal color direction staff were called

[inspection]

back then (or rather, the internal department name is still

[inspection]

even now). Back then, for Toei works, not only background art but also the basic colors of characters were all decided by art designers. Character designers would pass character line drawings to art designers, who would add cel paint color specifications and make them into cels. Props and background color matching in scenes were all handled by passing line drawings to art for specification. So the job was "inspecting" whether finishing painted things correctly. Therefore, the jobs were

[color direction]

and

[inspection]

, and there wasn't yet the concept of

[color design]

as we know it today at Toei Doga.

Even though it was called

[inspection]

, by that time, checking painted TV series was already the job of each responsible production company, and actually checking cel deliveries was done for theatrical works, TV special works, and what were called "collaborative works" -

- what kind of work is this? First, you secure the cels and in-between animation with a tool called a "tap." While checking the cel movements and stacking order with the time sheet, you literally flip through them one by one repeatedly, doing everything from correcting trace lines to checking and fixing paint mistakes, paint overflow, and scratches on the cel surface - it's that kind of steady (laughs) work. It's quite a world of "technique" and "craftsmanship" (laughs) - bamboo scrapers for removing overflow, correction pens, solutions for fixing small paint mistakes from the front of the cel.

So every day, from afternoon to night, sometimes until dawn, that work.

Every late night, cel deliveries were carried by hand from Korea. One day, that hand luggage included what appeared to be a souvenir jar of

kimchi

. But apparently that kimchi's sealing was terrible, and the kimchi juice had soaked into the cel deliveries. Naturally, the cut bags, time sheets, and in-between animation paper had absorbed it well, and every cut we opened was kimchi-pickled. We had to dry them and inspect the cels, but every time we flipped through them one by one, there was that "take this!" kimchi smell... (laughs).

Despite such struggles, we somehow managed to complete

Odin

at the very last minute. In the end, there was no staff screening at the studio, and by coincidence, on the opening day when I was going home in the morning, I saw the very first screening at a Shinjuku movie theater.

##

■Continues to Episode 4

(07.01.23)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 40: Once Again Setting Aside "Color Direction" for a Bit to Talk About Hakaba Kitaro

Uh, it's been 2 weeks? 3 weeks? since my last update (sweat).

In my last manuscript I wrote "Ah, I want to see snow," and wouldn't you know it, the very next day it suddenly snowed (bitter laugh), and after that, we've had this lovely Tokyo weather with snow falling every week.

While I was going "Yay yay (joy)" over this snow, Akimoto-san, who's handling color direction for

Hakaba Kitaro

, gave me a look of complete disbelief saying "What?! Unbelievable!" (bitter laugh). She's from Aomori.

Those of us born and raised in Tokyo welcome snow falling as a "winter event" and even celebrate it somewhat. We think "It'll melt away soon anyway, so it's fine to have this 'event' 2-3 times a winter."

However, in Tokyo with its many building shadows, when we get half-hearted snowfall, the road surfaces freeze the next morning and "Demon King Ice Barn" descends, so you have to be careful (bitter laugh).

Well then.

I'm thinking about continuing the story of "Color Direction" credits... but I'm still too busy with actual work including

Hakaba

to properly take time to write the manuscript (crying). Sorry about that. So I'll talk a bit more about

Hakaba

.

In the middle of this cold winter,

Hakaba Kitaro

is going great. Thanks to everyone, the viewership ratings in the Kanto region have exceeded 5%! Man, thank you all so much. This is actually a pretty amazing number. Just looking at 5% might seem small, but in the first place, not many people watch TV during late night hours. According to occupation rate data, one

out of every five people who had their TV on during this time slot was watching Hakaba

.

Well, I don't want to just keep talking about ratings, but we staff are really happy that so many people are watching. When you make something with full confidence and effort, you naturally want lots of people to see it. So I keep hoping the broadcast area will expand even more.

By the way, this

Hakaba

apparently also has a high industry viewership rating (laugh), and people from other production companies I have relationships with often call out "I watched it. It's great!" when they see me.

Though, well, since I'm going around promoting it everywhere, there's probably some lip service involved (laugh).

This week's broadcast is episode 6. We're finally at the halfway point, heading into the second half.

This

Hakaba Kitaro

is basically structured as complete single episodes, and each episode introduces quite a few new characters. The setting work and color decision-making for these is pretty tough. For some characters, there are color prints in the original or colored versions in Mizuki-sensei's art books, but most references are from the black-and-white original. So first I put on colors, then series director Chioka, character designer Yamamuro, and the episode's director all groan "hmm, hmm" while we decide things.

And as I mentioned before, this production adds texture and filter effects during photography for screen effects, so the coloring-stage color tones and the actual screen color tones change dramatically. So we have to reverse-calculate while considering that when deciding colors.

How much do they change? Well, first, "blue" becomes almost "gray" (laugh). So in episode 1, I failed by doing a blue-tone night color at the beginning (explosion). Even in normal scene coloring, Nezumi Otoko's clothes (or rather, cloth) look yellowish on screen, but the actual painted color is quite flashy fluorescent yellow-green. The red jacket Trump Jui was wearing was painted in shocking pink!

Because of this, even when I try to make characters stand out by putting flashy colors on jackets and shirts, it doesn't achieve the balance I'm hoping for, which is frustrating.

Since the color saturation is so poor, for example, the yellow of Kitaro's vest and the red of Neko's skirt are actually shot twice—once with the filter, then overlaid again just for those parts.

Oh, incidentally, Kitaro and Medama Oyaji aren't really affected by the filter much. The colors we paint are generally the impression you get.

I hope you can enjoy

Hakaba Kitaro

while imagining such things (laugh).

■ Continued in Episode 41

(08.02.12)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 41: Sorry! Once Again Setting Aside "Color Direction" for a Bit to Talk About

Hakaba Kitaro

Once again, it's been two weeks since my last update.

The other day, Tokyo had its "first spring wind." Rather than "blew," "raged" would be the correct expression. The brown wind that stirred up dirt and sand was just like a sandstorm. The entire city was dyed in yellow-brown colors. The Shinjuku high-rise district hazy in the distance beyond the sandstorm felt like Middle Eastern footage or perhaps

Fist of the North Star

(laugh).

And with that "first spring wind" comes this year's "pollen season."

Fortunately, I myself don't have even a speck of hay fever, but my wife has terrible hay fever. Not just her eyes and nose—when pollen gets on her skin, those spots turn red and inflamed, and it's apparently itchy beyond belief.

Hmm...

So currently, our household is doing all laundry indoors (bitter laugh).

While being grateful to my parents for giving birth to me with a body free of allergies, I'm still a little scared this year that I might suddenly develop hay fever (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Hakaba Kitaro

, currently airing to great acclaim, has completed production through episode 8 "Kaiki Ichiban Shobu" (Strange Number One Match), which airs this week (in Kanto). We have 4 episodes left to broadcast and 3 episodes left to work on. We've already finished editing and dubbing through the final episode, and now we're rushing to catch up on the screen work, which is running behind as usual.

Essentially, my work as color designer is mostly finished, and now I'm just going through checks of the rushes as they come up. Plus work on additional cuts for the DVD release and corrections. Oh, and DVD packaging work too. Well, that's for later.

But it really is fast and short, isn't it—11 episodes total. I talked about this with Nagai-san, the color designer for

Mononoke

, and she said "It's short, 11 episodes. It's over in a flash (laugh)." It feels like just when you finally get used to it and think "Alright, now let's cause another ruckus..." it ends. Hmm, I'd like to do a bit more... such wistful thoughts (bitter laugh).

But well,

Hakaba Kitaro

doesn't have many original stories left, and with this type of work, carelessly creating original episodes can be counterproductive, so it's probably better not to (bitter laugh). So giving our all to these 11 episodes might be just right. With everything, it's good to leave a little regret at the point where you want "just a bit more..." (laugh). So I want to enjoyably finish the rest.

Now, changing topics. The ending that airs each week. The text that appears behind the staff credits—I mentioned before that it "changes every week," but actually, that text is excerpts from next week's episode script.

Hakaba Kitaro

is structured so that cuts from the "next episode preview" are inserted into the ending footage using split screen, but by showing not just those preview images but also excerpts from the script itself, the entire ending essentially becomes the "next episode preview."

I'm in charge of deciding the colors for that text (incidentally, the person choosing which phrases to change color for emphasis is assistant director Goto-kun), and I'm having fun playing with the color balance, deliberately making it easy to read for some episodes and hard to read for others (laugh). Not just the main story colors—"color" is interesting in places like this too.

Well,

Hakaba

has just a little left, but I wonder what will happen with the text in the final episode 11's ending? Actually, that hasn't been decided yet...

■ Continued in Episode 42

(08.02.26)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 42: Connected Through Mizuki Shigeru Originals - Remembering

Akuma-kun

I'm working hard not to miss my manuscript deadline this week! (explosion)

Man, March! Tokyo has gotten warm all at once. It still gets pretty cold from midnight through morning, but during the day it's nice and toasty. On my way to work, I find myself wanting to sit on a park bench and bask in the sun (laugh).

Starting today, I'm saying "farewell" to my down coat. I'll send it to the cleaners and store it away in the back of the closet until next season (laugh).

Such is March.

Hakaba Kitaro

, currently airing to great acclaim, finished creating all character colors last week, so my work is mostly done. What remains is checking the portions that color directors are handling for episodes #10 and #11, plus checking the main story rushes.

For broadcasts, we have 3 episodes left, with episode 9 "Johnny in the Fog" airing Thursday night this week in the Kanto region.

Well then.

Recently, when I look around at

Hakaba Kitaro

-related reactions online, I inevitably come across the opinion "Wouldn't this staff do

Akuma-kun

?" Unfortunately, there are no such plans at the moment (bitter laugh), but huh?

Akuma-kun

? I worked on that before.

So, the story of

Akuma-kun

.

Series composition by Koyama Takao, series director Sato Jun'ichi, character design by Suzuki Kin'ichiro, art design by Mukuo Takashi. It started broadcasting in April 1989, as the follow-up to

Saint Seiya

(■■■■■).

Ah yes, that's right—come to think of it, this was also based on original work by Mizuki Shigeru. Supernatural stories really feel like Mizuki-san originals, don't they? Well, those of us making it (at least me...!) weren't really conscious of the original work...

Speaking of

Akuma-kun

, when I was still a child, there was a live-action TV version. I think it was still black and white? That was incredibly scary (laugh), but I watched it every week without fail. When Akuma-kun blew his ocarina and smoke rose from Mephisto's head, it felt weirdly realistic in a way, and that was somehow terrifying. When I got to work on the anime version, I remember that scary TV show was still in my mind.

The anime

Akuma-kun

made Mephisto into "the Second," a round, child-like character, with overall cute character designs aimed at children. Hyakume was cute too (laugh). In exchange, the demons that appeared as guests in each episode were pretty solid characters, I think...

In this

Akuma-kun

series, I handled the coloring settings for the main characters and the main guest demons of each episode, plus the color direction and inspection for the opening and ending, and the color direction for the first few episodes after the series started. Oh, and I also participated in the first theatrical version.

In the series, there were Akuma-kun's companions called the "Twelve Apostles," and they would all appear together on screen quite often, which was pretty tough. Naturally, finishing was still analog back then. With animation cels and cel paint finishing, when you had detailed drawings on one animation frame, it was really hard. There were quite a lot of cuts like that. After all, it was Toei with their frame count restrictions (bitter laugh). To reduce the number of animation frames, they'd cram everything onto the same animation drawing. It was a real nuisance for the finishing department. Well, that still happens now (bitter laugh).

And then those characters would all get high contrast or evening color changes at once. One color change meant making all 12 versions, which was quite exasperating.

These Twelve Apostles were summoned by Akuma-kun blowing his ocarina from a magic circle, and at this time, there would be special coloring with footlight-style shadows from the glowing magic circle as a light source, and this was great. With pink to purple high-contrast tones, the backgrounds and cels finished in exactly my favorite color usage, and I was very happy—shameless self-praise (laugh).

Also, the tarot cards that appeared in the main story. I got to do the color direction for these too. I bought real tarot cards with my own money and studied them earnestly, which brings back memories (laugh).

Until then I had been working on

Saint Seiya

continuously. Actually,

Saint Seiya

was a story that developed in a very narrow scope, and the characters that appeared were actually limited and few. Most of the time, it was just one-on-one fighting (laugh). In that respect,

Akuma-kun

was basically a story that developed within the daily life of modern Japan, so many different things appeared, making it a very educational production for me.

It really made me realize that to do color direction, you have to know about all sorts of things! Not just things that actually exist in reality, but also the work of expanding your imagination to create something—first you need to firmly understand things that actually exist in the world and that you can touch, or you can't give persuasive power to the "colors" you create by building up imagination (bitter laugh).

That philosophy still flows at the foundation of my thinking today, and that was the production that taught me such things.

Oh, as an aside, the opening song for this

Akuma-kun

—when you sing it at karaoke, everyone gets excited! It turns into a big chorus! (laugh)

This

Akuma-kun

—wasn't it released on DVD? With

Hakaba Kitaro

as a catalyst, I'm hoping this

Akuma-kun

might also get the DVD treatment (laugh).

■ Continued in Episode 43

(08.03.04)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 43: Almost the End!

Hakaba Kitaro

- Stories of Tokyo from My Early Childhood

Spring in March. March means the annual JR schedule revision!

I'm not particularly a "train otaku," but when I see the thick timetable covers at bookstores with "Schedule Revision" written on them, I get inexplicably happy. Don't you all feel somewhat excited too? Don't you feel like taking a train trip somewhere? ...Huh? That's strange.

Actually, in conjunction with this weekend's schedule revision on the 15th, "Passnet Cards" will no longer be usable. Did you all know this?

"Passnet Cards" are prepaid cards that let you ride almost all the private railway lines in the Tokyo metropolitan area with just one card, without buying tickets. When they first appeared, I was overjoyed and used them daily, but with the arrival of SUICA and PASMO, which can be used for both private railways and JR East, I've become completely a SUICA person now.

So I'm currently desperately trying to use up the unused Passnet cards I have left. When I say "use up," there's really only my daily commute to use them for, so no matter how hard I try, I can't use them all up. Even if some are left over, I can still use them at vending machines to buy tickets for a while, or get refunds at ticket windows.

Still, Passnet cards have been very helpful to me. Out of respect, I thought I'd try to use them to the end.

So despite the warm weather being perfect for cycling, I'm faithfully taking the train to work (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Hakaba Kitaro

, currently airing to great acclaim, now has only 2 episodes left.

After watching last week's episode 9, my wife asked a simple question (sorry for the slight spoiler...): "Kitaro was dissolved for 3 years? So the next one is 3 years later?" Well, it's not strictly a story from 3 years later, but after episode 9, some time passes, and this week's episode 10 "Brigadoon" is set just before the Tokyo Olympics. So it's a story from around 1962-1963. Right around when I was born (laugh).

One thing I was happy about participating in

Hakaba Kitaro

was being able to visualize old Tokyo scenes and lifestyles. The setting for anime

Hakaba Kitaro

is Tokyo during roughly 10 years from the end of the 1940s, a little after the end of the Pacific War, through around 1964 when Tokyo was excited about the Olympics.

I was born in April 1963. I'm Tokyo-born and Tokyo-raised. A true Tokyo native, a Nakano native (laugh). The following autumn, the Tokaido Shinkansen began service, and on October 10th, the Tokyo Olympics opened. I heard that my mother took me, still one year old, to watch the Olympic torch relay run down Ome Kaido. I naturally have no memory of that or of the Tokyo Olympics themselves, but the atmosphere of that time remained vivid until I was about 4.

The alley in front of our house was an unpaved dirt road that got muddy after rain. Along the roadside were ditches covered only with boards—what we called "dobu" (laugh)—which still existed then. Naturally, toilets were also sewage collection types. Vacuum trucks would come regularly and suck things up with a "gogogogogo" sound, which I would watch from the edge of our yard from a safe distance.

In the neighborhood, there were exposed earth cliffs with horizontal holes that had been used as air raid shelters still remaining, sealed off so you couldn't enter.

In Shinjuku, where I often went with my parents and grandmother, the east exit had a food department store called "Niko" where Studio Alta is now, and streetcars still ran along Yasukuni-dori. Once, on the way back from visiting Yasukuni Shrine in Kudan with my parents, I have a memory of riding a streetcar from in front of Shinjuku Shochiku (which no longer exists—it was around the Shinjuku City Hall intersection) back to Shinjuku. Shinjuku's west exit didn't have super high-rise buildings yet and was still just the former site of Yodobashi Water Purification Plant. The Chuo Line trains were still running chocolate-colored cars with wooden floors.

For

Hakaba Kitaro

production preparation, they prepared massive amounts of books and photo data for us. There were so many things where I thought "Ah, I know this, I remember this"—it was really fun (laugh). I quite enjoyed reading, looking, and studying them. Home appliances, household goods—everything I looked at was nostalgic (laugh).

So how could we bring this atmosphere to the screen?

Actually, the

Hakaba

staff is quite young. Directors Ueda-san, Kakudo-san, Shibata-san, and Sato-san are older than me, but director Chioka, director Hatano-san, art director Kurahashi-san, assistant directors, and production staff are all young people still in their 30s and 20s. Among the color directors too, everyone except Sakuma-san, who's my age, are young people. So the "senior group" who experientially know the atmosphere and feel of that era naturally put extra effort into obsessing over the details (laugh).

Also, in art meetings for this week's episode 10, the art director in charge knew old Shinjuku well (he's considerably older than me), and in front of period photos prepared as reference materials, the art director and I got so excited that we ignored the meeting. Director Hatano-san couldn't follow the conversation and was sweating (laugh).

I hope you can feel the obsessions of us "senior group" members, including myself, in various places throughout

Hakaba Kitaro

(laugh).

■ Continued in Episode 44

(08.03.11)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 44: One More Time About

Hakaba Kitaro

- Image Resolution Talk

I somehow managed to get through the turbulent tax return process, and finally have some free time. This winter I was constantly busy with

Hakaba Kitaro

, so I kept putting off hot pot promises with friends and drinking party invitations, but now I'm going to do lots of that!

Though with it getting this warm, hot pot might be questionable? Borderline? (bitter laugh)

By the way, yesterday I went to a Genghis Khan restaurant that's supposedly delicious. And man, it was even more delicious than expected! The lamb had that famous Hokkaido restaurant taste—so good! I ate like crazy and went home in a great mood.

But you know, just like with yakiniku, Genghis Khan makes your clothes and hair smell. Even more than yakiniku because it's lamb. So today, before leaving, I thoroughly scrubbed myself all over in the shower, and of course changed all my clothes before coming to the studio. But wait? I could still faintly smell something delicious...

Ah! I messed up! (sweat)

The upper half was perfectly taken care of, but actually, I wore the same jeans (sweat). When I sat down in my chair at my desk, from around my thighs, there was a faint...

Hmm, I let my guard down! Genghis Khan is formidable. But I'll go eat it again!

Well then.

Hakaba Kitaro

, currently airing to great acclaim—last week's episode 10 apparently got a 5.8% rating in the Kanto region. Wow, 5.8%! And the peak instantaneous rating was 7.3%. Since I usually work on productions that don't really have anything to do with ratings, I get a little excited (laugh).

By the way, to put that amazing number in perspective—it's about as impressive as ratings that Kimutaku's dramas get (laugh).

Despite such a late time slot, we're truly happy that so many people are watching. As I've written before, what makes us production staff happiest is having people actually watch our work. Thank you all so much.

Production of

Hakaba Kitaro

is now completely finished for all episodes, with only DVD jacket work remaining.

So today, let's talk about screen image resolution.

Not just

Hakaba Kitaro

, but Toei Animation productions are basically made at 144dpi resolution. The basic key animation size (standard animation paper size) fits on A4 paper, and in terms of data size, for

Hakaba Kitaro

, the basic coloring data is "1596 pixels × 898 pixels," made a bit larger than the photography frame. Backgrounds are the same. They're also digitized at 144dpi. We combine these, apply filters, add textures, vary line weights, and do various other things in photography to create those screens.

144dpi seems to be a high setting industry-wise. Toei has used this resolution since digital coloring began, but other production companies' works vary quite a bit—120, 105, 95, and so on. Higher resolution naturally means larger data size, which affects work efficiency depending on the computer specs used for work. Especially for photography staff—the more screen effect specifications there are, the incredibly long it takes to shoot (composite) one cut.

But well, recently basic machine specs have improved dramatically, and with more productions being made in HD for terrestrial digital compatibility, 144dpi seems to be becoming the industry mainstream.

This 144dpi is sufficient resolution for standard frame cuts, but for camera work cuts that zoom way in on small frames, even 144dpi makes the image rough. In such cases, we need to work at even higher resolutions, but that makes coloring tough. When data gets too large, coloring software doesn't run smoothly. Photography staff face the same difficulties.

Sometimes directors and assistants give instructions for simple calculations based on frame reduction ratios—288 or 300. One or two frames might be manageable, but when 30 or 40 consecutive frames are made such high resolution, it basically becomes impossible to work with. Actually, you can get sufficiently beautiful screens without such high resolution (bitter laugh).

However, the story is different for posters and still images. There's a different way of thinking between data for moving screens and static images for print materials.

Unlike footage with movement, posters and jackets are static and can be examined closely by hand, so we finish them at high resolution and take care that lines don't show jaggedness.

Also, this type of copyright-related imagery can be used in unpredictable ways. For example, if it's truly limited to DVD jacket material, something just a bit larger than the main story—288dpi or so—would be totally fine, but sometimes it suddenly gets blown up large and used for promotional posters in stores, leading to "Oh no! (crying)" situations. So I make this type of copyright material on the large side (bitter laugh).

The first key visual for

Hakaba Kitaro

—that poster of baby Kitaro emerging from the earth—was created with screen work at 400dpi using A3-sized paper for the key animation. The two stills for "Shokotan's" CD jacket were also each done with B4-sized paper key animation, also at 400dpi. And the DVD jacket is likewise B4 size at 400dpi. All were colored, combined with backgrounds, and given the same photography processing as the main story images. Incidentally, all are original drawings by character designer Yamamuro-san.

Compared to main story cut data, these are incredibly large image data files, so when applying photography processing, the texture sizes were completely inadequate, making things quite difficult apparently.

Finally, you can see DVD volume 1 jacket images on the web and such. That flat, old print-like image is actually the outer jacket design, while the jacket for the soft vinyl package itself is made with that same artwork but using the exact coloring and photography processing from the main story. It's turned out quite suspicious (mysterious). Please look forward to it.

■ Continued in Episode 45

(08.03.18)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 45: Sorry! Currently in Rehabilitation...

The other day, I changed my mobile phone model. It's the 705i series! Finally—or rather, at last—I'm now a FOMA person (← so late).

"Mobile phones basically just need to be able to make calls!" has been my philosophy. So I stayed with mova for a long time, mostly OK with just phone functions, but it turns out that switching to FOMA would be much more economical no matter how much email I send or how much I connect to the internet! Plus it works overseas too, so I went with FOMA. Apparently, in my case, it'll be about half of what I was paying before (stunned).

The problem is the phone design. I hate big ones, and no matter how thin they are, flip phones don't suit me. Something small, solid but thin, and not flip-style. There was one that perfectly met those requirements. Its release kept getting delayed, but it went on sale last week, so I went straight to the docomo shop.

That model is from a certain European company. Orange-colored and so cool... But well, as expected, the usability is quite different from Japanese manufacturers. It's like somehow it doesn't quite scratch where it itches (bitter laugh). But including that, it's quite a cute device! (laugh) I'm quite satisfied.

Now, carrying this phone, I'll finally fulfill my ambition of overseas expansion! (mysterious)

Well then.

Hakaba Kitaro

finished all its broadcasts last week (in the Kanto region), and I'm currently in rehabilitation in various senses (laugh).

You know, after doing something that intense for the first time in a while, I need to switch mental gears, and when I work on colors for other productions, I can't shake the sense of that

Hakaba Kitaro

filter, which is troubling. Hence, rehabilitation (laugh).

At times like this, it's good to go out into the world around you—or rather, into the town where you live, your neighborhood—or to listen carefully and let your thoughts wander to those scenes.

Actually, since the beginning of this month, when I listen carefully in the morning, I can hear beautiful bird songs from a certain park adjacent to our house. Something

like "kekyo kyukyu kyokyo"—at first it was a very clumsy song, but as it's gotten warmer recently, it's become much better at singing properly, like "ho-hokekyo kyokyokyo." Yes, the voice belongs to a warbler (uguisu).

My home is in Tokyo's Nakano. While it's adjacent to Shinjuku and is part of the "big city," it's basically a residential area with quite a bit of greenery—not as much as Suginami or Nerima, but enough that you can hear voices of wild birds like this. Well, of course, the ones with the most influence are still the crows, but I feel like there are fewer crows than there used to be...

That warbler—while plum blossom season is almost over, I expect it will continue to entertain us with its voice for quite a while yet. Ah, this sounds like a "tea on the veranda" kind of story (bitter laugh).

Oh yes, the cherry blossoms have started blooming all at once. For the next two weeks or so, Tokyo will be flooded with cherry blossom pink wherever you go (laugh).

Speaking of "cherry blossoms" in recent work I've done, there's the theatrical

CLANNAD

. Cherry blossom petals dancing through layers upon layers of full-bloom cherry tree avenues. When doing color direction for things like conveying depth and atmosphere to people watching the screen, your own experiences—the sensations you know from actually seeing real scenery—really come in handy.

We tend to stay glued to our desks at work, but going outside to see various things and experience that atmosphere is really necessary. These days, you can find most reference materials on the internet, but you can't sense things like light, wind, and smells from just photos and such.

That's exactly why I think: seize the moment and play lots! Go lots of places, see lots of things, experience lots of things, and be impressed by lots of "wow"s. Starting from your neighborhood, then going on outings and trips. The more you play, the better work you can do—I believe that and play accordingly (laugh).

So, being "in rehabilitation," I'll keep it short this week (explosion).

■ Continued in Episode 46

(08.03.25)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 46: For Some Reason This Week Is About "Lip Sync" Instead of "Color"

Tokyo is in full cherry blossom bloom. Last week they reached full bloom all at once, and even in the park near my house, flower viewing parties continue from morning till morning (!) without pause (laugh). When I pass by the side of the park, the air smells of beer (bitter laugh).

At Toei Animation, staff room-level flower viewing parties have really decreased recently. Among this, I was invited to a "My Ham-gumi" flower viewing party just last week, but couldn't participate due to scheduling conflicts (crying). Hmm, too bad. I might end up finishing this year without any flower viewing parties...

I might have written this before, but back when

Saint Seiya

(■■■■■) was still airing on TV, the

Saint Seiya

staff had a flower viewing party. A gathering under night cherry blossoms at Shakuji Park. At that gathering, chief director Morishita-san, getting into a good mood with beer, said this: "Cherry blossoms only come once a year. So being able to have flower viewing like this—maybe a few dozen times in a lifetime. That's all it is."

Ah, I think that's quite a profound statement.

Twenty years have passed since then, and every year around this time, I remember Morishita-san's words and feel a bit wistful. Thinking such thoughts, I went night cherry blossom viewing along the neighborhood cherry tree avenue this year too.

Well then.

April is program revision season. The foreign drama slot on a certain commercial broadcaster's daytime programming is one of my pleasures, but when I turned on the TV to watch

CSI:NY2

... huh? It's

Winter Sonata

! (sweat)

Surprised, I checked and found that the broadcast slot had moved starting this week. Three episodes per week became just one episode on Wednesdays... (crying). Well, I ended up watching "Winter Sonata" for the first time in several years (laugh). Yesterday was episode 1. Mm, it's still a masterpiece.

By the way, Korean dramas seem quite interesting, but I actually haven't watched many.

The reason is dubbing.

Korean people's facial features are basically very similar to ours, right? When those similar-looking people speak Japanese through "dubbing," the lip sync doesn't match (laugh). Well of course, they were originally speaking Korean (laugh). That creates a tremendous sense of incongruity that bothers me. For the same reason, I can't handle Chinese dramas with Japanese dubbing either. But if it's dubbed versions of American or European dramas, it doesn't bother me at all. I wonder if this is conditioning from childhood? (bitter laugh)

So when I watch Korean productions, I try to watch them with "subtitles + original audio" whenever possible.

And you know, this "lip sync" really bothers me in my work too (bitter laugh).

In most Japanese TV anime, lip sync uses three types: "closed mouth," "medium mouth (slightly open mouth state)," and "open mouth," repeating these randomly to make characters "talk." Considering real human mouth movements, without horizontally opening mouths and vertically opening mouths, it's absolutely insufficient from the start, but mysteriously, it somehow looks reasonably matched.

However, when impressive speech or shouted endings don't match the pronunciation and image, it's completely unacceptable. For example, shouting "Ahh!" but the mouth isn't "open mouth," or the final lip sync image being "closed mouth."

Even in TV productions, necessary cuts properly animate according to dialogue pronunciation, but in many cases they're animated with "closed mouth," "medium mouth," "open mouth" patterns.

When dubbing is finished and sound is attached, there's always a process of watching the entire main story from beginning to end to check everything, and we check for audio-visual mismatches there too. At that time, we request retakes for any lip sync that's particularly bothersome and fix what can be fixed.

I'm there to check color-related things, but I end up pointing out those bothersome mismatches anyway. Some directors say "This is fine as is (laugh)," and maybe that's right, but... hmm, it bothers me! (bitter laugh)

There's something called "spotting" where the editor gives us timing like "open mouth starting at X seconds Y frames" to match sound/dialogue with images, and we reshoot according to that. Recently with digital editing, sometimes we can fix things by rearranging image order frame by frame on shot rush data, but usually it's a reshoot. Especially for something like

Hakaba Kitaro

(■■■■■■) with continuous screen processing, it definitely requires reshooting.

Incidentally, during the old "co-production" American subcontracted works, we used the "pre-scoring" method where dialogue was recorded first and images were created to match it, so all "lip sync" timing was already marked on time sheets before animation began. Moreover, about seven types of "lip sync" models were determined to match English vowels, with all those instructions written on the sheets. So the images and dialogue matched perfectly.

Oh, pre-scoring is also used in Japan. For scenes with singing, performances, and dancing, it's "sound first," so it often becomes pre-scoring.

So I'm bothered by "lip sync" daily.

Now Japanese anime works are speaking in various languages around the world, but how is that? With just the "closed mouth," "medium mouth," "open mouth" pattern, aren't there many languages that don't match? And cuts that we animation-matched because Japanese mismatches bothered us become completely mismatched when dubbed (bitter laugh).

(...Ah, there's no color discussion... (sweat))

■ Continued in Episode 47

(08.04.01)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 47: Once Upon a Time... (29) - OVA Days Begin!

Hana no Asuka-gumi! 2: Lonely Cats Battle Royal

Over the weekend, I went to Hong Kong for delicious seafood with friends who live in Beijing. ...Writing it like that sounds incredibly international and celebrity-like, doesn't it? (laugh) Well anyway, I went to Hong Kong in a rush.

This was my first overseas trip since my Seoul business trip last year, so it's been a year. For private travel, it's been two years, and that was also Hong Kong. This time, the couple I met up with are both fluent in Chinese, so the food ordering was absolutely perfect and wonderfully impressive!

Hong Kong after two years seemed even more overflowing with Japanese products. Street signs, supermarket shelves—everything that caught the eye was made in Japan. While this tendency existed before, it felt like it had accelerated even more in these two years (so souvenirs for staff were really difficult... (sweat)).

"This is China and yet not China" were the words of the couple from Beijing. Hong Kong people's public manners are better than Tokyo's. According to the couple living in Beijing, Beijing still has a long way to go in that regard.

Also, while Hong Kong used to be a paradise for pirated DVDs of Japanese anime, now all such items have completely disappeared from storefronts—or rather, entire stores have disappeared (laugh)—and only proper legitimate versions are being sold. Well, Beijing apparently still remains a pirated version paradise (bitter laugh).

"China doesn't change quickly in anything" are the words of Jackie Chan (■■). Not just manners, but the Chinese people's awareness regarding copyright and their low cultural standards still seem far from improvement.

Well then.

The story jumps way back to around 1989-1990.

The TV series

Saint Seiya

ended (the "Showa" era also ended and became "Heisei" around this time), followed by

Akuma-kun

,

Mo-rets A-Taro

, and then

Kingyo Chuiho

(■■■■■■■■■)—I continued to handle the main color settings for TV Asahi's Saturday 7 PM slot.

The flow was: deciding main character colors, creating coloring settings, determining processing rules for special characters (like the transparency level of "Yurei Oyaji" in

A-Taro

), and handling color direction for the opening, ending, and first episode. As I wrote earlier, there was still no concept, position, or credit for "color design" at this time, so my "traces" only barely remain as a name in the "Finishing" section of the first episode's ending credits (bitter laugh).

Oh, I also got to participate in the first theatrical version of

Akuma-kun

...

Around this time, from the late 1980s to early 1990s, anime works for sell-through and rental video were growing rapidly, and I gradually transitioned to working on those so-called OVA productions.

Toei at this time had two pillar OVA series:

BE-BOP HIGHSCHOOL

and

Shonan Bakusozoku

(■■■■■■■), plus expanding series like

Yankee Reppuu-tai

(■■■■■■■■■) and

Crying Freeman

. They were also producing many more detailed video works.

Actually, I was dying to work on OVA productions (laugh). TV works were fun in their own way, but the system was becoming one where I couldn't directly do color direction myself, and I was wanting to challenge denser animation work and content for slightly older age groups.

Also, there was the paint problem. As I wrote long ago, TV works had restrictions on the number of paint colors we could use. STAC paints already had few colors. But with OVAs, I could freely use paint colors other than TV-use paints (laugh).

The first production I got to participate in was

Hana no Asuka-gumi! 2: Lonely Cats Battle Royal

(■■■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■). Director Umezawa Yoshitoshi, animation director Motohashi Hideyuki, art director Nakamura Mitsuki. It was an OVA side story (?) of the manga "Hana no Asuka-gumi!" by Takaguchi Satosumi. "Asuka-gumi!" had been made into a popular live-action film by Kadokawa a few years earlier. This was the second OVA. October 1989.

So I went to greet director Umezawa saying "Please take care of me!" Director Umezawa's first words were "Tsujiita-kun, you can do whatever you want!" (sweat). Furthermore, "But you know, there's absolutely none—schedule!!" (explosion).

I was happy to be entrusted with an OVA work and wasn't thinking about scheduling at all, but this

Asuka-gumi!

was actually a production scheduled for delivery by year's end. "Huh? It's October now, right? (sweat)" I said. Ah, I realized then that a pattern of "difficult content and no-schedule projects go to Tsujita" had begun around that time, and this

Asuka-gumi!

OVA was the same! (bitter laugh)

That very week, we did character test coloring. This time too, I think art director Nakamura-san initially provided the character specifications. Along with that, I also presented various colors I'd thought up for comparison. The characters were based on original creator Takaguchi-san's drawings, refined by Motohashi-san, and while the line density was clean, they were sharp and keen with a wonderfully adult atmosphere that made me happy (laugh).

It's interesting how, while deciding the basic normal colors, plans for various scene color changes for the main story keep bubbling up in my mind. This is different from deciding main colors for TV series productions. I could control all these characters and colors myself.

"Yeah. Let's go with this feeling!" Umezawa-san gave the OK, and the base colors were decided. That was the beginning of turbulent days.

■ Continued in Episode 48

(08.04.15)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 48: Once Upon a Time... (30) - Things That Haven't Changed Since Then

Hana no Asuka-gumi! 2: Lonely Cats Battle Royal

Mid-April has passed, and the shadow of Golden Week is starting to appear. In the midst of the "Golden Week scheduling" where various departments will be properly closed during the holidays, this week is a delivery rush for magazine-related work, DVD jacket work, and various copyright materials.

But several key animation pieces haven't come up yet (bitter laugh).

For finishing, "you can't squeeze water from a stone," so we're coordinating delivery schedules with the relevant departments (bitter laugh). Such are these early summer weather days.

The other day, the

Saint Seiya: Elysion Chapter

(■■■■■■ ■■■■■■) staff had a slightly late flower viewing—or rather, a small gathering. We rented out a soba restaurant near Oizumi Studio that the director frequents, with about 20 people centered on field staff. Miura-san, who plays "Andromeda Shun," happened to be able to participate, making it a fun gathering.

Before that gathering, we finished the art finishing meeting for

Elysion Chapter

final episode 6. And the director check for the colors of the final character designs "Athena's Cloth" and "Hades in Surplice" was also completed. That's waiting for original creator Kurumada-sensei's check.

Ah, after about 20 years, the end is finally in sight for

Saint Seiya

.

Well then.

With all meetings finished,

Hana no Asuka-gumi! 2: Lonely Cats Battle Royal

finally got moving. The calendar was already mid-November. We had completed the normal-time colors for the main characters, but now—how to handle night scene colors and image scene colors?

The year was 1989. Finishing was still fully cel paint and cel animation coloring era. Unlike modern digital coloring where cel colors can be finely and subtly adjusted to match backgrounds, we had to create colors with just about 200 incomplete gradation paints.

We struggled with the limited color count to create the basic normal-time colors and were already at our limit. From those colors, we needed to think up special colors like "slightly darker" or "add a little blue," but at this point, we were overwhelmingly short of colors.

As I wrote before, the STAC paints used by Toei Doga (now Toei Animation) were paint groups with clear, crisp saturation matching Toei Doga's child-oriented production colors. However, what I wanted for

Hana no Asuka-gumi! 2

was desaturated, subdued intermediate colors. So while I could barely create colors for night entertainment districts with neon, I couldn't create the night colors of a snowy riverbank far from lights the way I imagined them in my head.

But I couldn't say "it's impossible." I had to manage somehow. I endlessly considered combinations with color chart strips, repeated test colorings many times, and finally half-forcibly convinced myself "This is OK!" (bitter laugh)—using this rough technique (!) to somehow squeeze out colors.

Toei Doga's finishing work at this time had a considerable percentage of overseas outsourcing. Especially standalone OVA and theatrical works even more so. While there was still schedule, we'd outsource to studios in Manila, Philippines, but when time became really pressed, it became "animation finishing outsourcing" where we'd send key animation to Korean productions to handle animation and finishing work and return it. And again, the paint problem. Further trials (bitter laugh).

Manila studios used STAC paints, but Korean productions used Taiyo Shikisai paints. Ah, here again was STAC → Taiyo Shikisai conversion. You know, Taiyo Shikisai paints were absolutely what I wanted to use for

Asuka-gumi! 2

. "Ah, I wish I could have created colors with these paints from the start." With complex feelings, I forced conversion of color directions I'd created with STAC colors to Taiyo colors (bitter laugh).

Anyway, cel finishing couldn't be easily changed once decided. Obviously, each color direction had to always be in finished form. Even taking one prop, nowadays we have it colored with "temporary colors" and change colors later, but back then it was precise color direction decisions.

And I added varying degrees of shadow color intensity cut by cut according to the story's excitement and tension. Scene color directions were decided, but seeing dialogue, animation expressions, and animation quality, I wanted to add color expressions and acting too. So it might have been self-satisfaction, but I tried various detailed directions. I was quite nervous while doing color direction, worried about failure, then even more nervous watching the rushes (bitter laugh). This was something I'd also done in

Saint Seiya

theatrical versions, but when drama, animation, and color combinations work together properly, good scenes feel great. Having gained confidence from this production, I've continued this style of color direction ever since (laugh).

Time flew by, and it was year-end in a flash. However, the animation work couldn't catch up at all, so year-end delivery collapsed and carried over into the new year. At the very end of the year, after work closing finished, key animation I'd done color direction for was sent to Korea, and Korean productions advanced the animation finishing work while Japan was on New Year holiday.

On New Year's Eve, I went to Oizumi Studio, which had only security guards and scattered people, to respond to color direction inquiry faxes. I sent replies to several inquiries that had come in and went home just before "Red and White" started. In the new year, we put the returned cels straight into photography, forcibly approved them, assembled the master, and delivered. I think we couldn't even properly make a first print.

Asuka-gumi! 2

was completed through all this. I was worried about the brightness matching between backgrounds and cels, but when I saw the photographed film, they blended together quite nicely, which was a relief (laugh).

But... there were still three or four "Yikes! (sweat)" failures... These were lessons for next time (bitter laugh).

That was my first OVA work.

And the OVA wave continued further. About half a year after

Asuka-gumi! 2

, at the end of summer, another OVA project came my way.

Vampire War

(■■■■■■■■■■). An anime adaptation of Kasai Kiyoshi's novel.

■ Continued in Episode 49

(08.04.22)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 49: Once Upon a Time... (31) -

Vampire War

Early summer. It's hot.

Golden Week—come to think of it, it was hot, wasn't it? I'm vaguely remembering such things. Ah, this season is perfect for beer. I'd love to go "puhaaa~" starting from daytime (laugh). ...Hmm, confirmed as a bad working adult (crying).

Yesterday, April 29th was "Showa Day" (until recently it was "Green Day"). Emperor Showa's birthday. The "Heisei" era has now lasted 20 years. Young people born in the "Heisei" era are steadily entering this industry too. Do they know? That this day used to be "Emperor's Birthday" (laugh).

Oh yes, two DVDs I ordered because they were recently re-released arrived.

Genma Wars

(■■■■) and

The Dagger of Kamui

(■■■■■). Works by director Rintaro. Kadokawa Shoten theatrical animation works from over 20 years ago now. Both had art by the late Mukuo Takashi-san. They're absolutely wonderful.

Such old anime, but I actually participated in

Genma Wars

as coloring staff (laugh). Of course my name isn't listed anywhere. I painted cuts like the protagonist crawling to help a fawn, and several cuts of the flame dragon at the climax. My, how nostalgic (laugh).

But when I carelessly tell such stories to young people, I get responses like "That's a movie from before I was born, right?" and find myself speechless (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Continuing the OVA story.

Vampire War

(■■■■■■■■■■). Original by Kasai Kiyoshi. An anime adaptation of a novel. Character design concept: Kitazume Hiroyuki, character design & animation director: Hamasu Hideki, art director: Nakamura Mitsuki, director: Takenouchi Kazuhisa. A thoroughly realistic lineup.

The story is contemporary. A battle involving French intelligence, American CIA, and vampires with the same blood over a girl named Kiki who has alien life form factors in her blood. Former terrorist Kuki Kozaburo fights to protect Kiki throughout this global conspiracy. That kind of story.

I was originally a fan of this work's source material. I had vaguely thought "I wonder if this kind of story could be animated," when this animation project came up. What a surprise!

Until then, Toei Video's OVA works were all manga adaptations, but this

Vampire War

was novel-based. With manga originals, there's already a character visual established as manga, so anime character design naturally follows that original art style. But with novel originals, if you don't worry about "illustration" artwork, you can start character visual design from scratch with the anime staff, giving high freedom.

And this

Vampire War

character design was just so good! It felt exactly like what I had imagined in my mind when reading the original. Hamasu-san's realistic line style made me so happy that participating became a very enjoyable work. Content-wise, it was also a slightly adult story with many mature depictions, so it was a perfect fit.

The protagonist is Japanese, but everyone else is foreign. The story setting is also Paris, and none of the staff had been to Europe (I still haven't been to Paris (bitter laugh)), but somehow couldn't we put a European atmosphere into the colors? I referenced various overseas photo books and kept layering my own images.

This time too, the initial character colors came from art designer Nakamura-san, but I also presented my image colors alongside them, and the director and everyone would gather to exchange opinions and make modifications while deciding.

Unlike the current era where you can modify color samples in monitors with a single click, we had to make decisions by placing paint strip color charts on painted color sample cels, then repaint them by the next color meeting. For me, I wanted to have the next meeting tomorrow and keep deciding, but everyone was busy and there were many external staff, so waiting a week for meetings was unbearable.

The paint problem that caused considerable suffering in the previous

Asuka-gumi! 2

—this time there was still some struggle, but it went relatively smoothly. When I thought about making the taste European atmosphere, relatively flashy colors were OK too. Naturally I toned things down where needed, but overall vivid color use created that "authentic feel." The protagonist in subdued colors, everything else using slightly flashy colors—that feeling.

Even props in the story were drawn referencing real existing things to create realism. Obviously we couldn't reference real firearms, but we collected tons of model gun magazines and military equipment introduction magazines for reference, and being guys, we enjoyed deciding bullet and camouflage paint details.

And alcohol. One day, the director came to my desk and said "This is reference," placing down a rum bottle with a thud! With contents, of course. In the story, the protagonist drinks this straight from the bottle. "Well, should we try it for real?" No no, we didn't actually try drinking straight, but we decided everything in detail like that.

But what was still difficult was the lack of skin tone intermediate color variations. Since many white people appeared, I developed skin tones with overall reddish hues. However, there were still insufficient colors for scenes with slightly lowered brightness like night colors, resulting in everyone settling on similar skin colors in darker areas.

Still, since there was much more time than with

Asuka-gumi! 2

, I could do color direction while continuously making samples myself bit by bit as much as possible, and almost every scene went perfectly well—shameless self-praise (laugh).

So it was completed in December 1990. Did this sell well? I'm not sure about that, but I feel like novel-based OVAs didn't continue for long after this. Hmm, too bad.

Oh yes, this

Vampire War

, being aimed at slightly older audiences, actually has some "adult scenes." My first "adult scene" color direction made me a bit nervous. And then an even more "adult scene" work was waiting for me.

OVA

Crying Freeman 4: Yugekit■goku

(Crying Freeman■ ■■■■■). That work by director Yamauchi Shigeyasu was waiting.

■ Continued in Episode 50

(08.04.30)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 4: Once Upon a Time... (3) My First Color Direction Was "Collaborative Work"

Last weekend, through an acquaintance's connections, I attended a seminar on "Color Space in Digital Cinema."

The content was quite specialized - how the expression range of "color" in digital video changes with the digitization of movie screenings and the high-definition improvement of video works accompanying TV HD conversion, etc. Having attended a video-related university (though I dropped out...), I do have basic knowledge, but being a cutting-edge technical course, I could barely grasp the general understanding (bitter laugh). But since it's a topic that relates to the core of our future work, it made me think about various things. We anime "color people" really need to have more digital knowledge. Ah, I need to study more (cries).

Well then.

Parallel to the *Odin: Photon Sailer Starlight* work, I was given another job.

Color direction for a 5-episode TV mini-series called

Robotex

.

Robotex

- it's a title you've probably never heard of, right? This was actually a work made for American domestic audiences that was never broadcast in Japan.

This was what was called "collaborative work" back then - subcontracting for American production companies. Toei Doga at this time was producing many "collaborative works." TV series like

G.I. Joe

,

Transformer

,

Muppet Babies

,

Jem

(before I joined, they had also made

Dungeon & Dragons

and

Spider-Man

), and theatrical works like

Roger Rabbit

. There were so many smaller ones that I can't even remember the titles.

Robotex

was one of those "smaller ones."

For "collaborative works," first "materials" like storyboards, character designs, art boards, and color models are sent from American production companies. The main parts of the work are already decided on the American side, and we Japanese do the animation work based on these materials. Therefore, direction, animation direction, and art direction become work of assembling according to those "materials."

The same goes for colors - naturally, color models for main characters are sent, but also guest characters for each episode and props, with color models sent for almost everything. Also, for episodes where very American things appear on screen - things where "ah, Japanese people probably wouldn't understand the nuance" - detailed color models were usually sent for those too.

Also, "collaborative works" differ from Japanese anime in using pre-scoring method - dubbing, or rather, dialogue recording is done first while there are no images yet. Then mouth movements are matched to those recorded actor dialogues.

In Japanese anime, it's usually three patterns of "open mouth," "middle mouth," and "closed mouth," but "collaborative works" had seven mouth shape patterns matching vowel pronunciations. Just that made me feel strangely moved like "ah, this is America" (laughs).

For this purpose, time sheets with frame-by-frame mouth movement matching instructions were sent along with storyboards and other materials. Since these were sent for all cuts of each episode, the volume was enormous. These had to be transferred to Japanese animation time sheets. So back then, there was a part-time job called "sheet pasting" where someone would spend all day fighting with copy machines doing nothing but time sheet transfers.

So,

Robotex

.

Anyway, I still hadn't properly done color direction.

As finishing work I wasn't a beginner, but color direction, let alone being in charge of an entire series however small - it was like "What? You're kidding, right?" (bitter laugh). The other

[inspection]

(color direction) seniors had an attitude like "You can do it, right?" and naturally (!) didn't teach me anything (laughs).

Hmmm... Well, I had no choice but to do it.

The small prefab's second floor hastily built in the studio's back parking lot was the

Robotex

staff room. A completely empty room with no animation desks or anything yet. "It's hot, so it's really tough," said

Sasaki Katsutoshi

, the Japanese chief director, when I met him on a hot summer day after the rainy season ended.

##

■Continues to Episode 5

(07.01.30)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 50: Once Upon a Time... (32) - Pentel Name Pens Going "Shuko Shuko!"

Crying Freeman

Appears!

How did everyone spend Golden Week? I was all about zoos! (laugh)

First to Ueno Zoo. Then to Asahiyama Zoo in Asahikawa, Hokkaido.

Actually, I had never seen a real panda in my entire life. Despite being born and raised in Tokyo, I had never been to Ueno Zoo. This time I went after hearing about Linlin's death, so I couldn't meet him in the end, but I joined my hands in prayer in front of the panda house where his portrait was displayed.

Asahiyama Zoo was also my first time. On the night of the 2nd, I suddenly had a flash of "I want to eat Genghis Khan!" so I arranged airline tickets on the web and went to Sapporo on the 3rd. Then I had another flash and extended my trip to Asahikawa on the 4th.

Man, zoos are great. You know, everyone's smiling—the visitors. Not just children, but adults are all smiling too, and no matter how crowded it gets, there's something mysteriously calming about it. It's real animal power. After all, having elephants, lions, giraffes, tigers—even with fences and cages, having the real thing right in front of you moving around is amazing. Pure amazement. It was incredibly fun (laugh).

But you know, the animals entertaining all of us—most of them are just one or two individuals. Especially with larger animals, the fewer the number kept. Well, it can't be helped, but living forever in a place without friends—or rather, without fellow species members—feels somehow poignant. Thinking about that deceased panda being alone for so long in his old age makes me think he must have been lonely.

Still, the penguins at Asahiyama Zoo—man, they're divine! So cute! Penguins have such different individual personalities, and they're so lively. There are even clingy ones (laugh).

Anyway, seeing so many animals up close like that might have been a first. It was good mood-changing and spiritual nutrition replenishment! (laugh)

Well then.

Finally it has come—OVA

Crying Freeman

. An OVA work based on the gekiga by original creators Koike Kazuo and Ikegami Ryoichi. I participated in two

Freeman

works over two years.

First was

Crying Freeman 4: Yugekitōgoku

(1995). Script by Ono Ryunosuke, animation director Urushihara Satoshi, art director Nakamura Mitsuki.

Then

Crying Freeman 5: Senjimon no Kishimojin

(1996). Script by Ono Ryunosuke, animation director Yamashita Takaaki, art directors Nakamura Mitsuki and Yoshida Noboru.

Both were directed by Yamauchi Shigeyasu. Participating in director Yamauchi's work again after a long time. And once again, thoroughly realistic direction. This

Freeman

had already had three productions made, all with other people handling color direction. So I did the fourth and fifth. I think director Yamauchi brought me in.

"Don't worry about the 'colors' from previous works—first try thinking freely in Tsujita-kun's way," said the director. Actually, for these two works, character design was entrusted to me from the beginning (perhaps because of that, the ending credits were actually "Color Design & Inspection").

Even so, since these were works with originals, basically the original color prints were the major premise, and it would be problematic if they changed too much from the existing three works. Worrying about this in my own way, I submitted several initial designs each. Then, as usual, the director and everyone gathered to check, but absolutely everything got corrections, almost total annihilation. Complete restart from the beginning.

The direction the director wanted was more realistic while having "flair." The colors I first submitted had probed too much for realism, all becoming similarly subdued and too biased. So we repeated correction, check, correction. The director himself seemed to think "hmm" when seeing my color samples, and through repeating these corrections, the director's image and everyone's basic worldview gradually solidified. Incidentally, this work process—or trial and error—was the same not just for "4: Yugekitōgoku" but also "5: Senjimon no Kishimojin."

Both

4: Yugekit■goku

and

5: Senj■ no Kishimojin

had art by Nakamura-san's Office Mec-Man. Sometimes delicate, sometimes rough, these Mec-Man backgrounds had a really good atmosphere that fit this work. Particularly in "5: Senj■ no Kishimojin," animation director Yamashita-san drew layouts for almost every single cut densely without a single gap, creating another masterpiece of completion (laugh). Art director Yoshida-san, confronted with this, responded with an equally detailed and dense frontal assault—a wonderful battle unfolded. Being pulled along by both, tension kept rising and it became a good work.

For color direction, while still having paint problems, I was gradually getting used to realistic works, and I gradually developed my own methodology for realistic, subdued color usage. Special coloring matched to scene backgrounds also became reasonably well-balanced screens when going in dark directions. But now special coloring that removed saturation while going in bright directions became a bottleneck (bitter laugh). While thinking there were still limits, special effects staff helped me out with various impossible requests.

Not just color direction but finishing-wise, the most difficult struggle was this "gekiga style" artistic style. Like the original art style, "realistic line touches" were drawn into every cut, every character, every animation frame in the animation. This was extremely difficult for finishing.

In animation cel finishing, pencil lines drawn on animation are carbon-transferred to animation cels using a machine called a trace machine, but this didn't transfer well. It often became uneven, and the uneven density of those realistic touch lines created flickering. Correcting this was incredibly difficult (bitter laugh). Using the oil-based marker "Pentel Name Pen" often used for cel line correction, we endlessly hand-corrected. We corrected in finishing, then at rushes the assistant director and even the animation director himself corrected like crazy with marker pens going "shuko shuko" (bitter laugh).

Furthermore, with detailed art styles and intricate shadows and highlights, it was a parade of coloring mistakes and color flickers (crying). In the end we couldn't fix everything, leaving many embarrassing retakes in the main story.

This

Freeman

, with gekiga-style realistic art featuring lots of weapons and firearms, realistic depictions, plus plenty of "adult scenes"—it's a work that boys would admire a bit

(laugh). Being a boy myself, weapons and firearms were endlessly interesting. And "adult scenes" were even more interesting (laugh).

But even with such scenes, it wasn't so-called "18+ anime," and since they were necessary scenes within the story, it was important to make them naturally beautiful scenes within the flow. We couldn't go too far into "erotic" realism. That area was very delicate. So especially visually, parts that shouldn't be shown all became silhouette coloring or black fills.

Actually, there was a small incident during production. There was a cut where a female character fought completely nude. This cut was outsourced to an overseas production for animation and finishing work, but amazingly, "pubic hair" not drawn in the key animation or animation director corrections was properly drawn and came back as cels. Three or four such cuts! My goodness, what a surprise (laugh). I don't know why this happened, but the animator probably "serviced" us by drawing it (laugh). Naturally this couldn't be used, so we had to redraw all those animation parts and re-finish (bitter laugh).

4: Yugekit■goku

and

5: Senj■ no Kishimojin

were completed through all this. 1991-autumn 1992.

I recently rewatched these two works after a long time. My, how nostalgic (laugh). At the same time, I thought "Ah, I want to remake this with today's digital technology." If possible, I want to redo at least all the cels from color direction up. That's how wonderful the animation and art are. Ah, wouldn't someone make this

Crying Freeman

again? (laugh).

■ Continued in Episode 51

(08.05.07)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 51: Special Edition - One More Time Only!

Hakaba Kitaro

Color Design Notes-Style Episode Commentary!

Yesterday there was an interview for the booklet to be included in

Hakaba Kitaro

DVD volume 4. Following director Chioka and animation supervisor Yamamuro, it was a group interview with art director Kurahashi, CG director Morita, and myself. The interviewer was Haraguchi-san from "List Production Committee." Oh! I met him for the first time.

The interview started pleasantly, but man, I was already starting to forget various things (bitter laugh). This wasn't just me—both Kurahashi-san and Morita-san were the same. I heard that director Chioka and Yamamuro-san were the same too. My goodness (bitter laugh). We tend to forget previous works so they don't interfere with the next ones, so we have that tendency.

But as we talked under Haraguchi-san's guidance, the three of us gradually remembered various things, and by the end of the roughly 2-hour interview, our memories of that time had become quite clear (laugh).

On the same day, we also finished checking the temporary assembly of the DVD volume 3 and 4 jacket images. Is this farewell to

Hakaba Kitaro

? So this interview felt like a good closure for us too.

Well then.

After Haraguchi-san's interview, I felt like I hadn't talked enough (laugh), and at the same time, I thought it might be good to write down somewhere all the various things that I'm forgetting. So suddenly, this time is a color design-style episode commentary for

Hakaba Kitaro

.

Episode 1: Kitaro's Birth - Storyboard/Chioka Hirotohi, Direction/Hatano Kohei, Color Direction/Tsujita

I also handled color direction for episode 1. For series works where I'm entrusted with design, I ask to handle episode 1 color direction myself unless there are production issues. That's because there are many things you can't understand without doing color direction yourself. Especially for newly starting works. Beyond what I anticipated at the design stage, various problems and points of attention emerge.

So, episode 1. What was most frustrating was the opening night scene with Mizuki in pajamas. The colors just wouldn't come out (bitter laugh). That scene was planned to go with blue-toned night colors and I designed and directed colors accordingly, but when photographed, the blue tones were beautifully suppressed and it became almost gray monotone. I had the photography team reshoot it two or three times, but it still didn't work. "So you're that kind of troublemaker, this filter!" I cursed the mysterious characteristics of the "Hakaba filter" (bitter laugh).

Episode 2: Yasha vs. Dracula IV - Storyboard & Direction/Kakudo Hiroyuki, Color Direction/Akimoto Yuki

This episode's production was quite last-minute, a difficult birth spanning the New Year. Dark clouds began gathering with talk that photography was incredibly difficult and taking too much time—this was episode 2. With the bonus that Yasha was all CG processing (bitter laugh). But the finished result was beautifully balanced.

For Yasha's colors, I had them output one CG model as Photoshop data, I colored it, and had the director and episode director check it.

For

Hakaba Kitaro

, we created a "simple conversion filter" for color direction from the photography filters & textures (let's call it the "Hakaba filter"), and advanced color direction while placing this on cels. This simple filter couldn't be used with old Photoshop versions. So we hurriedly had color director Akimoto-san's machine updated with the latest version. I heard they also got a new machine while they were at it. Thanks to

Hakaba Kitaro

(laugh).

Episode 3: Vampire Tree - Storyboard & Direction/Ueda Hidehito, Color Direction/Kojima Akihiro

For

Hakaba Kitaro

, we asked production company A-LINE to handle gross production for episodes 3 and 9. So episode 3 actually had very proper scheduling. However, previous episode photography was incredibly delayed, so we had them wait quite a bit.

In episodes 1 and 2, I had assembled detailed special coloring according to scene brightness, but while designing episode 3, I realized "Ah,

Hakaba Kitaro

actually shouldn't do too much detail," and suddenly increased scenes with so-called "normal" color direction. I did the same for subsequent episodes basically.

Instead, for scenes like Shigei's "transformation" in the theater, I told the color director "Up to you!" (laugh). But Kojima-san perfectly hit the mark and built it up. Thank you!

Episode 4: Neko - Storyboard & Direction/Nakamura Tetsuji, Color Direction/Sakuma Yoshiko

When you say "cats," it's color director Sakuma-san (laugh). At Toei, production tends to dislike having multiple color directors rotating through one series. But I pushed and had Sakuma-san participate. This created a three-team system: Akimoto = Sakuma = gross production episodes. Otherwise, one person handling such heavy weekly work would be impossible.

So, episode 4. It's all about "Meroron" (laugh). During production, that melody endlessly repeated in my head (laugh). No, I didn't dislike it at all. I quite liked it.

For Neko's skirt and stage costume, we had them shoot by overlaying the red parts again over the "Hakaba filter." Otherwise that impressive red wouldn't come out. Similar processing was done for Dracula's eyes in episode 2.

This episode had many theater interiors and crowds, plus special coloring. Sakuma-san helped us with everything.

The note about background characters in

Hakaba Kitaro

was "brown hair is NG." For period accuracy in the 1950s, ordinary people wouldn't have brown hair (laugh). Brown hair would only look like "foreigners," so we avoided that. Naturally, green or purple hair was also NG (laugh).

For the latter half bridge scene, I actually made a mistake with Neko's sunset color balance at the design stage. The broadcast version stayed subtle, but we've corrected it for the DVD.

Episode 5: False Kitaro - Storyboard/Chioka Hirotochi, Direction/Hatano Kohei, Color Direction/Akimoto Yuki

Neko who went to hell has white-outlined visuals in the original too, but wanting to make it slightly more alien—or having an atmosphere of going "over there"—I tried softening shadow boundary lines with Paintman coloring software brush processing. This was quite good, I think—shameless self-praise (laugh).

Incidentally, when False Kitaro meets Neko, there's a close-up of Neko's face where False Kitaro reflects in her eyes after blinking—the moment he reflects, Neko suddenly changes to bluish coloring. Actually, that was a photography mistake where only that spot doesn't have the "Hakaba filter" on the cel. But the accident created such a good effect that it became "OK!" So that white Neko was actually that blue Neko during coloring.

This episode was the end of the "Neko arc" and the first half of
Hakaba Kitaro

. A turning point where newborn Kitaro sheds his skin through various experiences. After this, Kitaro becomes greedy about "living" and increasingly adapts to the human world.

When I finished up to here, there was a strange sense of relief like "Ah, it's fine now." The worldview of

Hakaba Kitaro

that we'd advanced by trial and error somehow fit well with me.

Episode 6: Water God - Storyboard & Direction/Ishiguro Iku, Color Direction/Makabe Genta

Episode 6 was produced by Studio Doga Kobo. From this episode, it gradually becomes more omnibus-like. Kitaro with a somewhat "vacant" feeling. Visually, the screen filter was changed to white-based, changing the atmosphere from episodes 1-5.

However, was the color direction data changed? Not at all—we used the same data from episode 1. If it looks very bright, that might be episode 6's directorial mood.

The Water God sphere appearing over Ginza (?) had its color atmosphere provided by me, with the rest being photography director Iribe-san's technique. Tanks, fighter planes, great floods—

Hakaba Kitaro

's biggest spectacle episode. Work-wise, it was also a difficult episode. Anyway, it was an episode with tons of characters without character settings, and I'm endlessly grateful to the color director who handled all those background characters well.

Episode 7: Werewolf and Ghost Train - Storyboard & Direction/Shibata Hiroki, Color Direction/Sakuma Yoshiko

The famous episode "Ghost Train." I was mostly hands-off with this one too (laugh). I left it to Sakuma-san (laugh).

For the ghost train interior, since many cuts were animation, I created colors first and had the art staff match them.

But what was still difficult was reflection-type color direction. The flame reflection in the scene burning the Water God couldn't create good colors, clashing with the "Hakaba filter." That was a bit disappointing (bitter laugh). Like the sunset colors in episode 5, trying to shift colors toward orange didn't reflect well—that was one characteristic of the "Hakaba filter."

Episode 8: Strange Number One Match - Storyboard & Direction/Kakudo Hiroyuki, Color Direction/Akimoto Yuki

By this point, except for rough settings I provide, it's mostly "Please handle it, color directors!" (laugh). The "ha-hi-fu-he-ho" ghosts were all thought up by the color directors.

The fireball reflection at the opening went well—more shameless self-praise (laugh). For the similar scene in episode 7, since it was outdoors, I didn't add colors particularly for reflection parts, but here being an indoor narrow space, I tried shifting firmly toward blue-white-green.

The white coloring of Murata and Kanemaru in the pitch-black world with the "Guide" uses the same color construction as episode 5's white Neko. That "Guide" color came from director Chioka and Yamamuro-san's words "something raw-like" (laugh). Still, the "Guide"—both design and movement are supreme! (laugh).

Episode 9: Johnny in the Fog - Storyboard & Direction/Ueda Hidehito, Color Direction/Kojima Akihiro

The curry scene with the Prime Minister. Due to the "Hakaba filter," apparently delicious colors wouldn't come out easily, and the color director worried considerably. Finally, they had it shot with colors overlaid again during photography.

The dissolved Kitaro processing is basically the same as the body fluid processing when Kitaro's father (bandaged man) died in episode 1. Initially, I created colors thinking of Kitaro's skeleton as whitish normal bones, but from director Chioka's

request "Shouldn't it have an atmosphere of something not human?" I tried applying rainbow gradation brush to the entire skeleton, and "That's a good feeling." With the same thinking, the "Strange Olympics" ticket in the final episode also has rainbow gradation applied.

This episode also had many night scenes. In

Hakaba Kitaro

, we got through almost all episodes with just variations like outdoor night colors → night color 1, indoor night colors without light sources → night color 2. For episode 9 too, meetings were just like "This scene is 'night 1'" and beyond that, I mostly left everything to the color directors (laugh).

Episode 10: Brigadoon - Storyboard/Sato Jun'ichi, Direction/Hatano Kohei, Color Direction/Sakuma Yoshiko

The episode that recorded high ratings (laugh).

Initially, I was thinking of desaturating character colors too for the daydream-like space inside Brigadoon, but when I actually placed them on backgrounds, "Ah, normal is fine!" So in this episode, we only changed colors for the temple scene near the end.

The various monsters also had character designer Yamamuro-san and animation supervisor Hakamada-san carefully create character settings for almost everything, allowing proper decisions, which was very helpful. So actually, while the volume was large, it was relatively easy color direction-wise.

Episode 11: Foolish Man - Storyboard & Direction/Chioka Hirotochi, Color Direction/Akimoto Yuki

Actually, I initially planned to do color direction for this final episode myself. But I thought it might work better to ask Akimoto-san, who had handled several episodes already. Absolutely correct (laugh). Really, interesting screens were created.

In the first half, the surreal screens of tuna, beefsteak, and Chinese food that Rakuyō Rōjin devours are Akimoto-san's masterpieces (laugh). Beyond that, I left many detailed things to her.

The "Strange Olympics" "walking giant creatures," "island-like creatures," and "bird that walks one step per thousand years" were submitted with dummy coloring, and I created them while bouncing ideas with the director. Yes, those were all animation + coloring.

Beyond that, I was mostly just watching rushes (laugh). That was the feeling.

This is about it for episode commentary and notes.

Being a short decisive battle escape-type series of just 11 episodes, it became one of the few works where I could give full effort comprehensively. I don't think there will be many works like this, before or after. Being able to participate in such a work was very fortunate, and we achieved good results too—it was great.

And with that,

Hakaba Kitaro

ends (laugh).

■ Continued in Episode 52

(08.05.13)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 52: Once Upon a Time... (33) -

Tenj■-hen Uch■ K■ji

Starts

A typhoon is approaching!

The Tokyo area was stormed by howling winds all night long, and it's still rough this morning. When I was a child, I loved going outside in this kind of weather wearing a raincoat (or rather, rain cape) and rubber boots (laugh).

Recently, I often see women wearing rubber boots on the streets and trains on rainy days.

But these aren't just any rubber boots—they're the slightly cool outdoor-type ones from a certain company. The women cleverly match them boot-style with their clothes. It looks really stylish and good. So I wonder, "What would it be like if a man wore these?" Yes, naturally I'm wanting to try them myself (laugh) > outdoor-type rubber boots.

So I researched various options on the manufacturer's website. Oh! There they were—cool men's (or rather, unisex) ones. Hmm. I unconsciously entered fantasy mode with visions floating above my head (laugh). Imagining myself looking perfectly sharp... yes! Decision made!

But here's the thing! My feet are actually quite large. So when I checked sizes, as expected, I'd need the largest size. And...

Hmm, the web site's online shop was out of stock. I wonder about their direct shops? Do they even carry them? (sweat)

Will I be able to intercept this year's rainy season with cool outdoor rubber boots? (laugh)

By the way, today's manuscript is apparently episode 52. 52 episodes means exactly 4 cours for TV anime, exactly one year at 52 weeks. Well, for these "Color Design Notes," I've taken breaks sometimes—or rather, frequently—so it's been well over a year since serialization started, but somehow for "anime industry work," 52 feels like a good milestone, so I'm having a little solo celebration (laugh).

Well then.

Hana no Asuka-gumi! 2: Lonely Cats Battle Royal

,

Vampire War

, and

Crying Freeman 4: Yugekitōgoku

,

Crying Freeman 5: Senjō no Kishimojin

. I've been writing about the OVA cycle from 1990 onwards, but actually a big project was running in parallel. An OVA series no less! A full 13 episodes!

Tenjin-hen Uchi Kaji

(1989-1990).

Tenjin-hen Uchi Kaji

- Original by Fujikawa Keisuke, character design concept by Inomata Mutsumi, character design & chief animation director Yamazaki Nobuyoshi, art director Matsumoto Kenji, director Imazawa Tetsuo. Production by Kadokawa Shoten. An anime adaptation of Fujikawa Keisuke's SF (?) epic novel series "Uchi Kaji," which could be called his life's work.

The previous year (1989), also produced by Kadokawa Shoten, theatrical

Uchi Kaji

was released (animation production by Trans Arts), which was an adaptation of the "Earth Chapter." So this time was an adaptation of the sequel "Heaven Chapter."

Even though it was an OVA, unlike the Toei Video OVAs I was participating in simultaneously, it was basically TV format 30-minute episodes. With exactly 13 episodes = 1 cour series, it was sized to be broadcast on TV as-is.

The recognition around this was somewhat delicate (laugh). As a company (Toei Doga), the thinking was "Since it's the same length as TV, just make it quickly with TV-level quality," but we field creators thought "It's an OVA and the length is TV-short, so let's put in maximum effort!" (laugh). Well, it's a perfectly natural flow (laugh).

I think about 2 months of production time was allocated per episode, but maybe we worked too hard and took too much time, resulting in 2 months (bitter laugh). The flow was that staff for the next episode would see the rushes or first print of preceding episodes and think "Alright, let's work hard to make something even better!" (laugh). So each episode became progressively more substantial.

For this series, I handled character color design and color direction & inspection for each episode. During this period, I was doubling up with Toei Video OVAs, but

since those were mostly hard "realistic" works, doubling with

Tenji-hen Uchi Kaji

, which felt like a work with a somewhat different, softer atmosphere, was a good balance for me.

I already had a strong tendency to get emotionally involved and absorbed in work, but this production had attractive circumstances beyond content. This

Tenji-hen Uchi Kaji

series was going to be released on LaserDisc!

While LaserDisc (LD hereafter) is now a relic of the past, the feeling at the time was that it was a "digital" high-quality medium. While VHS or Beta videotape images deteriorated over time, images stored on LD could be reproduced beautifully semi-permanently. It was truly an attractive medium.

Around this time, a new recording/playback format for music, MD (MiniDisk), also appeared, and "digital" technology was gradually becoming mainstream. Well, MD is still alive, but we never imagined that LD would meet such an abrupt end with hardware and all through "the rise of DVD" (bitter laugh).

Now then.

I knew "Uchi Kaji" was a popular original work, but I had never read it myself, so before starting actual production work, I recklessly thought "First, let me try reading through the original?" and bought all the paperback volumes at once with a "ba-dump!" (By coincidence, I ran into Sato Jun'ichi at that bookstore! Seeing my bulk purchase of paperbacks, he laughed hard saying "I've never seen anyone buy books like this!" (laugh)).

So I eagerly started reading volume 1 of the "Earth Chapter"...

Ah, I failed spectacularly (explosion). In the end, I never reached the crucial "Heaven Chapter," and the days of OVA

Tenji-hen Uchi Kaji

began (laugh).

■ Continued in Episode 53

(08.05.20)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 53: Once Upon a Time... (34) - A Vivid World of Gods!

Tenj■-hen Uch■ K■ji

Part 2

Last week I went to three concerts. Man, this was definitely a first (laugh). When things pile up, they really pile up (laugh).

First was Oda Kazumasa's concert. As expected, a super major feel with a huge 10,000-person scale live show. Since it was at Yokohama Arena right by JR Shin-Yokohama Station, us adults naturally took the Tokaido Shinkansen from Tokyo Station (laugh). Round trip on the newest 700 series Nozomi trains (laugh).

Actually, I've been an Oda Kazumasa fan for 30 years since his Off Course days. I never imagined that he'd have such a breakthrough after turning 60 (bitter laugh). Oh no, I'm happy about it though (laugh).

Second was Matsuo Kazuhiko at a live house in Ebisu. He's one of the former Off Course members, and this was an intimate, homey 70-person limited live show. He's 9 years older than me with a quiet big-brother feel (laugh). For him, intimate live houses are better than big halls (laugh).

And third was Hitoto Yo. At Omiya Sonic City Main Hall in front of Omiya Station. This was a medium-scale 2,500-seat hall. This was my first time going to her concert, but man, she can sing! Much more solid delivery than the impression from CDs. Plus the live show was much more energetic (laugh)—a really fun concert.

Being in this business, what catches my attention at concerts are the visual direction of staging and lighting effects. Concert lighting is amazing! They combine various lights according to song order and style to create spaces. Not just the performing artist and stage, but they skillfully throw lighting into the audience seating too, creating unity throughout the entire hall. This is something that can't be fully conveyed just by watching live DVDs. Light and color. People doing anime should definitely make opportunities to go see concerts by their favorite artists!

Well then.

The OVA series

Tenj■-hen Uch■ K■ji

finally got moving.

The director was Imazawa Tetsuo. This was my first time working with Imazawa-san on this production.

Tenj■-hen Uch■ K■ji

led to me later participating in the theatrical work

COO: Come From a Distant Ocean

().

All 13 episodes had storyboard & direction rotating among three people:

Imazawa-san, Umezawa Yoshitoshi, and Yoshizawa Takao.

As I wrote before, I handled character color design and color direction for each episode. Though it was a 13-episode series, unlike TV it wasn't weekly delivery, so in principle I was entrusted with color direction and inspection for all episodes.

When you do character design, you naturally want to do color direction and inspection too. Like the concurrent Toei Video OVAs I was participating in, during this period my work flow increasingly became "doing everything myself."

Now, for Uchi Kaji character design.

The

Tenj■-hen Uch■ K■ji

original was a novel, but visuals like cover art were drawn by Inomata Mutsumi-san. So I remember referencing Inomata-san's art book (?) or something similar. I had also glimpsed the theatrical

Uch Kaji

, so that was somewhat referenced too...

But this

Uch Kaji

was the "Heaven Chapter." While episode 1 was set in the earthly realm of the capital (miyako) and Mount Kongō, from episode 2 onwards the setting becomes the heavenly realm, the world of gods. Yes, gods! "Asura King," "Four Heavenly Kings," "Fudo Myōō" and so on—the gods who successively appear before Uchiyama Kōji and others had no particular color references, and most were colors I created and decided on with everyone as usual.

The common recognition among the director and everyone was "The heavenly realm must be a colorful, flashy world, surely." So in contrast to the earth realm with its subdued, low-saturation colors that could be taken as almost monochrome, both the art and character colors made the heavenly realm bright and gorgeous. And I thought of the gods in vivid, extremely colorful tones.

The appearing gods were basically Buddhist guardian deities. Considering the visuals of original Buddhist art, they are indeed extremely colorful. So I used the characteristics of STAC paints—the vivid cel paints that had tormented me until then—to my advantage, creating brilliant gods (laugh).

Another important point was "gold color." First, a ship that flies through the sky called "Tensh■sen" appears in the story, and it was supposed to be "blindingly golden." For things crossing to the heavenly realm, and the heavenly realm itself, I felt "gold color" was quite a "key" in creating colors. So in the heavenly realm, I used "gold color" quite extensively at key points for characters and props.

"Gold color" comes out beautifully in photography. Especially since we were using film at the time, it was true transmitted light processing, and effects that captured light itself were dazzlingly beautiful. The brilliance of the golden clouds that welcome Princess Nayotake back to the heavenly realm in episode 1 is still entrancing when I watch it now (oh, but the color flickering... sorry even now (sobbing)).

(Actually, I dug up a LaserDisc player from my parents' house this time. I watched it for the first time in about 10 years. Man, I was trying all sorts of things here and there, and the screen overflows with the feeling that I was working enjoyably, which is quite heartwarming (bitter laugh))

Episode 1 ended like that.

My reaction after watching the first print was a "smirk" (laugh). I had a premonition while making it, but this was "quite an interesting job I've encountered!" for me (laugh). I had a "hooked!" feeling. First I enjoyed myself, then got excited thinking "I can do the next episode and the one after that—everything myself!"

But after this, an unexpected situation was waiting for me.

■ Continued in Episode 54

(08.05.27)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 54: Once Upon a Time... (35) - Hospitalization! Surgery! That Led to My First "Color Design"!

Tenji■-hen Uchi■ K■ji

Part 3

Last weekend there was the 17th memorial service for my mother, and I wore a suit for the first time in ages. Oh, formal wear (ceremonial clothes) could be called a suit too (bitter laugh). I wore formal wear in April, but a regular suit (← confusing) was really over a year ago. I was a bit anxious about my body type, but thankfully that was fine (laugh).

Speaking of suits, they always come with neckties. This necktie thing—for people who wear them daily it's nothing, but for "non-suit people" like us, it's surprisingly formidable.

I just can't get the lengths to match properly! (explosion)

The balance between the wide and narrow sides absolutely won't align (crying). Often the narrow side ends up hanging down "limply" from below, and when I redo it, now the wide side aims for my crotch and hangs "limply." And when I try once more, again... it's a standard routine (bitter laugh).

Well, somehow I managed to resolve the situation in three tries, but as always, I get a bit depressed thinking "How is this as a working adult?"

Ah, I really should wear suits sometimes. But in our industry, if you carelessly wear a suit to the studio, people ask with straight faces "Are you quitting the company, Tsujita-san?" which is awkward (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Tenji■-hen Uchi■ K■ji

somehow got off to a start. Episode 1 "Prince! Now Is the Time to Depart" (Direction/Imazawa Tetsuo), Episode 2 "Cruel! Asura King" (Direction/Umezawa Yoshitoshi), Episode 3 "Reunion! Woman of Geki Female Market" (Direction/Yoshizawa Takao)—with three episodes, the direction and animation staff had made one round. Starting from episode 4, we entered the second rotation round.

By episode 3, each staff member had roughly confirmed the atmosphere and feel of this work. Each director had different "flavors," and those differences mysteriously matched well with each story's taste, allowing all three to work

enjoyably.

Toei Doga's Oizumi Studio has a screening room where rushes checks and first print screenings for all works are held. Rushes checks are watched in principle by only the staff responsible for that episode, but other episode staff also come to watch first print screenings of completed works.

Unlike TV series works, without the tight schedule of weekly delivery, staff for the next episode after the one just watched were often still just starting work. So inspired or stimulated by that first print, they'd add a little seasoning to their current work, creating a bit of competition among staff that gradually raised the quality. Eventually, staff from other episodes started coming to rushes checks too.

In

Tenji■-hen Uchi■ K■ji

, while direction and animation rotated, art and color direction kept the same person throughout, so during meetings I could say things like "more ■■ feeling than ■■ from the previous episode..." and the directors' requirement levels gradually rose episode by episode, which was incredibly enjoyable (laugh). And the stories themselves progressed to bigger, deeper places.

Entering the rotation from episode 4 in this mood, I fell into a troublesome situation. A physical problem. My left elbow, which I'd been hurting for a while, got considerably worse. I was hit with pain and numbness so bad I could barely hold a pen.

Cubital tunnel syndrome. You know how when you hit your elbow it goes "biiing" with terrible numbness? The cause was inflammation of the nerve passing through exactly that area. I'd been attending a hospital and enduring with anti-inflammatories and painkillers, but finally reached my limit. So it became surgical treatment. About 2.5 weeks hospitalization.

Man, I was in trouble (sweat). The story was getting more interesting, with the prince and Taishakuten confronting each other over a woman named Kagami. Moreover, stories continued featuring the raging Taishakuten, the Four Heavenly Kings (Jikokuten, Z■ch■ten, K■mokuten, Tamonten), and literally dozens of gods called "Thirty-three Heavens." I had to create color settings for all of them...

However, I couldn't do satisfactory work in this condition, and naturally no one would stop work and wait for someone like me during my hospitalization, surgery, and recovery period of over a month, even with schedule allowances (laugh).

In the end, I managed to complete color designs for appearing characters including the "Thirty-three Heavens" before hospitalization, but had to ask senior colleagues Morita-san and Sakai-san to handle color direction for episodes 4 and 5

respectively.

Ah, I was supposed to do all episodes myself, but hmm, too bad!

But since it couldn't be helped, I thought things through. "Anyway, I'll decide special coloring and such color directions, then discuss details thoroughly before asking them to handle it."

Looking back, this became my first case of working with other color directors as "color designer."

While I had created character colors for TV series before, the basic approach was for directors and color directors to meet and proceed with work episode by episode, and I didn't take a stance of actively and deeply involving myself in each episode's content or the color director's work.

For these two

Tenji■-hen Uchi■ K■ji

episodes, after meetings with directors and art directors, I arranged separate detailed meetings with the assigned color directors. I think I also made and provided color direction schedules.

With surgery decided but waiting for bed availability until the hospitalization date was confirmed, I frantically rushed through work. But a bed opened earlier than expected, so I was hospitalized much earlier than planned. Some work didn't get finished in time, so I ended up bringing settings to the hospital room and completing unfinished work in the ward's rest room.

This was around the 1990 rainy season (laugh).

■ Continued in Episode 55

(08.06.04)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 55: Once Upon a Time... (36) - Do Rising Spirits Soar Through the Heavens?

Tenji■-hen Uchi■ K■ji

Part 4

The other day, I ended up making a "click" purchase. A pretty expensive purchase at that. Oh, not a computer. A camera. A digital camera. I bought another one.

It's a SIGMA DP-1 compact digital camera, and it's great! A high-performance lens without zoom and a large CCD for digital SLR cameras. Man, what a niche item.

I'm itching to take this somewhere for photography. Ah, I want to travel! Preferably overseas! Even if not overseas, I want to go on a trip somewhere regional! Tonight I'll jump on a late-night bus and tomorrow be in Tohoku? Shikoku? Kyushu?

But precisely when I feel like this, work gets busy. Or maybe I end up buying cameras as a reaction to being busy? (bitter laugh)

Either way, it's rainy season. The weather's been consistently bad... But rainy landscapes could be quite interesting as subjects...

...Well, I'm in the middle of the usual frantic mode (bitter laugh).

Well then.

After spending about 3 weeks during the humid rainy season in a clean, comfortable hospital room surrounded by young, beautiful nurses (!), I returned to the front lines with renewed energy starting from episode 6. However, I couldn't immediately go 100% full throttle, so I had someone else handle finishing inspection for episode 7, which was worked on parallel to episode 6. But from then until the final episode 13, I was able to handle everything myself solidly.

Starting with

Saint Seiya

, I had handled several TV series, but this was my first time being continuously assigned color direction for each episode like

Tenji■-hen Uchi■ K■ji

. My enthusiasm grew with each episode, and more and more ideas and things I wanted to try kept emerging. Color direction meetings became enjoyable around this time too.

Oh no, they were enjoyable before too (laugh), but instead of just receiving "please do this" from directors, I started actively proposing ideas and expressing opinions myself.

That's because, as I wrote before,

Tenji-hen Uchi Kaji

had relatively few members rotating solidly through direction, animation, art, photography, and color direction, so I unconsciously felt a "team" atmosphere or sense of trust and unity. That's why the more I actively engaged, the better it was received and became even better, creating that kind of flow.

Additionally, especially the animation staff, with competitive spirit against other episode "teams" beyond their own assignments, kept raising quality higher and higher. This kind of elevation is great (laugh).

As an aside, at that time Kadokawa Shoten was simultaneously producing an OVA of the novel "Record of Lodoss War" (production by Madhouse) similar to

Tenji-hen Uchi Kaji

. With similar schedules producing and releasing all 13 episodes, this

Record of Lodoss War

became a huge hit.

However, the production situation was apparently quite tight, with repeated "release date postponements." But when it was released, it sold incredibly well.

Meanwhile, ours never improved in sales and seemed quite in the red financially. The Kadokawa producer was holding his head. There was even bitter laughter about "making

Tenji-hen Uchi Kaji

with

Record of Lodoss War

profits" (bitter laugh).

I actually owned all those

Record of Lodoss War

LDs (laugh).

For writing about

Tenji-hen Uchi Kaji

this time, I actually dug up the LD deck from my parents' house and reviewed everything. Equipment that hadn't even been plugged in for years, just gathering dust under the TV (laugh). I carried it by hand on the train and set it up at home. Naturally I brought the software too, but since they're 30cm diameter discs, they were incredibly heavy (bitter laugh).

So I nervously tested it and played them back. The LD software's outer vinyl bags had deteriorated, crumbling into powder-like pieces every time I touched them (laugh). I captured that to computer and made movie data that I'm still watching while writing (laugh).

Watching continuously, I could clearly see how we really tried all sorts of things episode by episode. Special coloring patterns that felt somewhat exploratory in early episodes became increasingly elaborate toward the latter half, with more comfortable scenes that perfectly matched the animation tension. Also trying small techniques with various colored carbons like brown, white, and blue, and adding color changes within single cuts—we probably tried every conceivable idea at the time and enjoyed it.

Like with the previous Toei Video OVAs, reviewing my own old work has an embarrassingly ticklish quality, but

Tenj■-hen Uch■ K■ji

is rather enjoyable because I can see "working so happily (laugh)."

All 13 episodes made over about 2 years (come to think of it, there was also a theatrical re-edit compilation of about the first 7 episodes). It was a fun, satisfying period. After finishing the final episode, I secretly hoped for continuation series or more adaptations, but unfortunately that opportunity never came (bitter laugh).

While juggling multiple concurrent projects at the time, I feel this was a work where I could create very fulfillingly. At the same time, it was a work where I can now say "Ah, I grew quite a bit (laugh)."

■ Continued in Episode 56

(08.06.10)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 56: Once Upon a Time... (37) - The Story of 16mm and 35mm

Tenj■-hen Uch■ K■ji

Part 5

The other day, there was one voicemail on my home phone.

"This is ■■ from Nakano Tax Office. I'm calling about the content of your tax return."

Ugh, the tax office! Actually, this year I did three years' worth of tax returns all at once, and I'd been a bit worried because I hadn't received "OK notifications" from the tax office for the past two years.

Hmm, what could have been wrong? I didn't hide income or fraudulently inflate expenses... I don't think I did... I think I didn't, probably... hmm (sweat). Still a summons? (sweat) ...So I guess I'll get grilled? (heavy sweat)

Nervously, I called the tax office the next day. And then...

"Well, we found calculation errors in three places for fiscal year 2005..."

"Yes"

"Please file an amended return"

"That's all?"

"That's all"

That's all it was (laugh). Since they said "mail is OK," I'll clear it up by having them send documents and responding. Ah, what a relief (laugh). I'm really not good with tax offices (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Around 1990 when we were making

Tenj■-hen Uch■ K■ji

, it was naturally still "cel animation filmed on film," and at that time anime photography used both 16mm and 35mm film.

16mm and 35mm refer to the width of the film. Since film has continuous holes (perforations) on both sides for shooting and projection, the actual image area is even smaller, but back then TV works used 16mm film while theatrical works used 35mm. With larger image area, image density is higher, and 35mm film, being

about 4 times the area of 16mm, was naturally suited for large screens like movie theaters. Color reproduction was also better with 35mm.

Tenji-hen Uchi Kaji

was shot on this 35mm film. Not just

Tenji-hen Uchi Kaji

but all Toei Doga OVA works at the time should have been 35mm. Basically, TV works that aired once and were done, versus video works intended for repeated viewing, were treated like theatrical works.

However, even for TV works, opening and ending films were shot in 35mm, and frequently used bank cuts were often shot in 35mm too. Repeatedly used footage required creating dupe (duplicate) negatives from original film for processing, and 35mm was suited for such things. Nowadays you can just copy and insert on computer during editing (laugh).

So basically, TV work rushes checks were done with 16mm positive film, while theatrical and OVA works were checked with 35mm positive, but...

This 35mm film naturally cost considerably more for both negative film and processing compared to 16mm. So regular rushes checks used 16mm positive film. While shooting itself used 35mm negative film, during printing it was compressed and printed onto 16mm positive film. So what we watched for photography rushes checks was mostly 16mm film footage.

This was quite subtle.

Naturally 16mm used 16mm projectors, and with smaller film screens, the actual light projected onto screens was less, making screens feel darker compared to 35mm rushes. While 16mm was fine for checking animation and camera work itself, color reproduction and light effects like transmitted light in our domain inevitably looked inferior to 35mm rushes.

However, 16mm had various advantages, primarily being much easier to handle. Not just projection, but especially editing was easier. Editing was naturally done with positive film, and the difficulty between 16mm and 35mm editing was like heaven and earth (though "negative editing" done after all cuts were approved was naturally done with 35mm negative film as the master).

So after checking with 16mm and giving OK, the completed film had final checking with 35mm film.

This final check was called "Print 0 screening," meaning screening with the first positive film processed from the negative assembled through negative editing. Here we checked whether there were any fatal problems. Well, problems would be

bad (bitter laugh). I also attended these checks.

What I checked was screen color reproduction. Film impressions change considerably with printing. Naturally it starts with the negative, but color tones and transparency can look quite different depending on printing balance.

Also, there were individual differences in cameras and lenses used for shooting—even with the same 35mm cameras, lens individual differences could subtly affect footage color tones. If everything were shot with identical lenses there'd be no variation, but when shooting in parallel on multiple photography tables, there could often be slight color variations cut by cut.

Including adjustments for such things, technicians at processing labs would pre-adjust and print Print 0 to some degree (for this, we'd provide combinations of actual cels and backgrounds used in the main story as color references for each scene), but with animation, since light and color reproduction aren't shooting natural objects, some effects and color tones might be better emphasized depending on scenes. When intended effects didn't come out well, we'd have them adjust during printing.

"Make flame colors stronger in this scene" or "make blue sky reproduction clearer," sometimes specifying cuts for adjustments.

After screenings, we'd hold meetings with lab technicians and animation staff including the director to confirm and make requests. These adjustments were called "timing," and we always did this for film-screened works. Even with digital production today, this remains the final checkpoint for theatrical works screened on film.

These Print 0 screenings were held at Toei-affiliated processing lab Toei Chemical Industries (now Toei Lab Tech) in Chofu. For

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, roughly every two months per episode. Since other OVA works were also going to Print 0 in parallel, I was going to Toei Chemical quite frequently. On Print 0 days, we'd take 2-3 taxis from Oizumi Studio, and after several trips, I became more familiar with the route from Oizumi to Toei Chemical than the taxi drivers (laugh).

From 1990 through 1991, OVA-centered days continued like this.

■ Continued in Episode 57

(08.06.18)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 57: Once Upon a Time... (38) - Remembering and Thinking About

My Youth in Arcadia

Part-Time Job Story

Sorry for taking a two-week break from serialization. Various deadlines and other things in my main work kept me from having time to write manuscripts properly. Sorry to everyone who looks forward to this.

That's right! When I think about it, the other writers for this Anime Style—aside from me, they're all writers or artists, people whose job is writing (drawing)! Since I'm fundamentally a "color" person, I don't write or draw that much.

...Well, that's a bit of an excuse (laugh).

I might have to take breaks like this again in the future, but I'm back starting this week. Alright, let's work hard (distant look).

Well then.

A while ago I bought a DVD of a nostalgic work, and while I'd been carrying it around in my bag everywhere, I finally got to watch it recently.

The theatrical work

My Youth in Arcadia

(■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■). Original by Matsumoto Leiji, director Katsumata Tomoharu, character design & animation director Komatsubara Kazuo, art director Ito lwamitsu. A 1982 Toei Doga work.

This work was released during the summer vacation of the year I started part-time finishing work, so I had some memories of it. So this week, going back quite a bit in time, is the story of my part-time job days.

"Well, there's some work I'd like you to handle..."

One day in June or July of that year, I was called by the president of the finishing production company "Kozue Anime" where I worked part-time.

"I'd like you to handle this"

When I went to the studio (or rather, workshop) in West Ikebukuro, there were some thick, large-format cuts on the glass reception table. The cut bag had "

My Youth in Arcadia

" written on it. "Oh! Theatrical work!" I thought. Actually, since I'd only recently started part-time work, I hadn't been allowed to do coloring work on theatrical productions yet.

"I want you to paint these flame cels"

The president took animation drawings from the cut bag. The animation size was over 230 frames, large-format animation. About A2 size? What was drawn on that animation paper were thin flames running in wavy patterns. Basic two-color painting, with 1-2 flames running per animation drawing. With cel layers going up to about ABCDEF.

I heard these were cuts from prominence or something that appeared in the story's climax. There were several cuts like this, apparently divided among several Toei-affiliated finishing companies at the time.

So the "Kozue Anime" portion of flame cuts was to be painted by me and senior S-ta-san.

In today's digital coloring era, to put it roughly, there's honestly almost no difference in finished quality between TV and theatrical work based on the painter's skill level, but in the cel coloring era, whether tracing or coloring, technical skill differences showed up clearly in the finished results.

So at "Kozue Anime" at the time, only veteran in-house staff and some freelance staff could handle theatrical work coloring. There were several freelance staff who could finish tons of frames, but they were at "TV work quality" coloring level, so in principle such people couldn't be given theatrical work.

Writing this might make TV work seem low-level, but "Kozue Anime's" coloring level was actually quite high (I realized this even more after joining Toei Doga and seeing finished cels from other Toei-affiliated finishing companies).

"This is color tracing, right?" I asked.

In cel finishing, pencil-drawn animation is carbon-transferred to cels using trace machines, but so-called "color trace" artwork can't be transferred by trace machines, so you trace the animation artwork placed underneath directly onto cels with pens.

At the time, cel finishing workflows often separated "hand tracing" and "coloring" workers, but "Kozue Anime" deliberately didn't separate workers, with the policy that "the person painting does all the tracing too." So I thought we'd do all the color tracing for these "flame cuts" too.

But as I wrote earlier, I was still a newcomer who'd just started. Would a newcomer's tracing skill be adequate for theatrical work?

"You don't need to trace this"

"Huh?"

"Paint directly"

"What? (sweat)"

That's right. Normally you'd first color trace from the front, then flip the cel and paint, but this time we'd skip color tracing and paint directly from the back while tracing the animation.

"The finishing desks are occupied and it's large format, so paint here" - the president pointed to the reception table!

And the battle began that night.

We fixed a Z-light to the glass reception table, lit from below to create a "makeshift large-format light table," and on that we used animation pegs, paper clips, and scotch tape to fix animation and cels so they wouldn't shift, carefully painting with brushes. Two colors: B-3 (red) and OR-3 (orange). Brushes were industry-standard Sable long brushes. Fortunately they were relatively easy-to-paint colors, so we thinned the paint as much as possible and spread it evenly across the cels.

At first I was nervous and painted very slowly, but gradually getting the hang of it, I became more skilled and got into a good pace. Conversations with senior S-san and other staff were fun, almost like preparing for a school festival (laugh).

Time passed and the clock went past midnight. I was making mistakes left and right from familiarity and drowsiness (bitter laugh). Starting to paint without flipping the animation paper, or dozing off and painting strange places (bitter laugh). We worked until morning and withdrew once. The tiny company "Kozue Anime" had a narrow workspace, so work was difficult with many people coming and going during the day, plus I was a student so I went to classes during the day (laugh). So I returned to the company in the evening and resumed work.

How many frames were there total? I don't remember anymore, but since we worked two nights together, there were quite a few frames. I remember getting 500 yen per frame at the time.

Over 20 years have passed since then (laugh).

Looking back, this experience might have been one of the triggers for me ending up in this anime-making job (laugh). Incidentally, the S-senior who painted with me is now active in key animation and direction. Recently he was one of the character designers for

Itazura na Kiss

.

Now, for this

My Youth in Arcadia

, I think I went to see it when it was released, but I completely forgot the content, so rewatching on DVD I was a bit surprised like "Ah, so this was the story!" Hmm, it was a subtle work (bitter laugh), and long too (130 minutes runtime).

But I could watch it nostalgically thinking "This was the 'mood' of Toei theatrical works back then." I was satisfied watching the flame cel scenes we painted with a bit of happiness (laugh).

■ Continued in Episode 58

(08.07.08)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 58: Once Upon a Time... (39) - Summer Vacation, "School Pool," and "Television Manga"

The other day when I tried to buy tea from a vending machine, "Clank! Clink!" - the 100 yen coin I inserted came back to the change slot. "Maybe I didn't insert it properly?" I tried again. "Clank! Clink!" - it came back again.

"Ah, I see."

This 100 yen coin was genuine, but its surface had worn down considerably, and even the feel when pinched between fingers was like "thin? ...maybe?" So the vending machine rejected it. Looking closely, this 100 yen coin had "Showa 49" engraved on the surface. Showa 49 (1974) - a 100 yen coin minted when I was in 5th grade. Ah, it's been working for over 30 years since it was made.

Curious, I checked the other small change in my pocket. And found even older coins!

A 50 yen coin from Showa 42 (1967), one 100 yen coin each, and a 100 yen from Showa 47 (1972). There was also a 100 yen from Showa 50 (1975). Ah, coins are surprisingly aged.

Among all the small change in my pocket, that "Showa 49" 100 yen coin was the most worn and shabby. The older Showa 42 100 yen coin looked cleaner and more solid, appearing younger and newer.

It's kind of like humans.

I wondered what experiences that worn "Showa 49" 100 yen coin had been through.

I bought that vending machine tea with a still-young "Heisei 3" (1991) 100 yen coin (laugh).

Well then.

Next week, children and students will plunge into summer vacation.

When I was still in elementary school, some 30-plus years ago, one of summer vacation's pleasures was none other than "Television Manga." We didn't say "anime" yet, did we? Not "anime" but "Television Manga."

During summer vacation, from late July through August, Tokyo's Channel 10 - NET (now TV Asahi) - had "Television Manga" broadcast time during weekday mornings. "Summer Vacation Manga Festival" or something like that was the program title. About an hour-long slot starting around 10 AM.

Moreover, this summer vacation slot had a slightly different lineup tendency from the evening shows.

Wacky Races

and

Pyun Pyun Maru

were repeated every summer vacation and were consistently good as standards. Thinking about it, maybe there weren't that many domestic anime available for reruns back then? How was it?

Recently anime broadcast slots have completely changed, with unthinkable early morning weekend slots and late night becoming anime time. Plus there are basically no reruns anymore (oh, there's

Gundam 00

late night (laugh)).

But I'd really like to watch "Television Manga" again now. I want to show today's children

Wacky Races

and

Tom Thumb

. And I'd like to make such anime.

Recently, when I looked down from a Chuo Line train, I saw elementary school pool classes in session. Watching the frolicking children made me think such things.

Tokyo's rainy season is almost over.

■ Continued in Episode 59

(08.07.15)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 59: Summer Vacation Special - Saint Seiya: Hades Inferno Chapter & Elysion Chapter Completion & Broadcast Memorial Complete Episode Notes (Part 1)

Sorry, I took another two-week break, but I'm back starting this week.

Japan's summer high school baseball tournament at Koshien has begun. I listen to the daily heated battles throughout my work time. The "crack!" of the ball from the radio and the loud cheering from the stands beyond are my work companions during this season.

The brass band cheering from those stands still gets excited over

Space Battleship Yamato

(■■■■■■■■) and

Triton of the Sea

(■■■■■■■■) this year too. They're Koshien cheering brass standards now. Man, these two songs are anime theme songs from when I was in elementary school, so it's been about 35-36 years now. That's quite something.

And listening carefully, each school has slightly different arrangements. There must be brass sheet music collections available. Maybe veteran schools have traditional arrangement sheets unique to their schools, passed down continuously. Thinking about such things, I'm enjoying this brief "summer."

When Koshien begins, summer really feels like it's heading toward the halfway point.

Well then.

Last month,

Saint Seiya: Hades Elysion Chapter

(■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■) was completed. The first

Saint Seiya

TV broadcast was in 1986. While there was a long gap in between, it took a total of 22 years to complete all of Kurumada-sensei's original "Saint Seiya."

The final episodes 5 and 6 of

Elysion Chapter

are currently airing with great acclaim on SKY PerfecTV! To commemorate this on my own, here's a three-part "Saint Seiya: Hades Inferno Chapter & Elysion Chapter Completion & Broadcast Memorial Complete Episode Notes."

Oh, sorry to non-Saint Seiya fans (sweat).

Now then.

First,

Inferno Chapter: Prelude

. At the end of episode 13 of director Yamauchi Shigeyasu's

Hades Twelve Temples Chapter

series, Seiya heads to the underworld. The story begins where Shun and the others follow Seiya to the underworld.

From

Inferno Chapter

, the director changed to Katsumata Tomoharu. Katsumata-san directed from episode 2 of the first series too. Other main staff remained roughly the same, but naturally the taste changes when directors change. So what kind of feel would it change to?

Inferno Chapter: Prelude Episode 1 - Cross! River Acheron - Direction/Katsumata Tomoharu

As with any series, I try to handle color direction for episode 1 myself whenever possible. Only by actually touching the main story and key animation do detailed points requiring attention become visible. I handled color direction for this episode 1 too.

This series has almost the entire story set in the "underworld." So naturally it's a dark atmosphere. However, if we made the character colors themselves too dark, the entire production risked becoming gloomy, so that balance was one key point.

In the previous

Hades Twelve Temples Chapter

, the stage setting was "perpetual night in Sanctuary on Earth," so we realistically created "nighttime darkness" character colors. But this time the stage is the "underworld."

"Once we enter the 'underworld,' that becomes the baseline, so wouldn't brighter be better?" said director Katsumata. So I designed the underworld basics on the bright side. While suppressing brightness slightly from so-called "normal" coloring,

since backgrounds themselves are dark, they don't actually look that dark on screen - designed to look almost "normal."

So episode 1. It's just the story of endlessly traveling the River Acheron by boat. Hmm, quite plain (bitter laugh).

Inferno Chapter: Prelude Episode 2 - Silent Courtroom - Direction/Sasaki Noriyo

From episode 2 where the story gets moving, I passed the color direction baton to Kobioki-san. Kobioki-san handled color direction for all episodes through episode 6.

The color scheme system for Specters was already established in the previous series, so based on that, we referenced the original artwork coloring (for example, whether hair was solid black or white outline in the original) to create colors. So episode 2's guest character Lune became silver-haired.

Inferno Chapter: Prelude Episode 3 - Legendary Saint Orpheus - Direction/Katsumata Tomoharu

The opening scene with Pharaoh & Cerberus is designed slightly darker than the underworld's basic colors. Since Seiya's Pegasus Cloth base is white, he really stands out floating in dark spaces (bitter laugh).

So when deciding basic color tones for each scene, Pegasus Cloth always becomes the standard. How much to suppress the white became the key point.

Oh yes, Lyra Orpheus appearing in episode 3 was also almost white-based.

In

Saint Seiya

, there are several "technique" scenes during battles, and as a series principle, character colors became special coloring in those "technique spaces." Through about episode 3, both the technique user and target got special coloring, but from the latter half we organized it a bit: technique users emit auras while keeping character colors normal-ish for some contrast, while only targets get that space's special coloring.

Incidentally, when getting "WHAM!" blown away, we made it a rule to give the victim high-contrast processing, organizing this too.

Inferno Chapter: Prelude Episode 4 - Orpheus: Sad Requiem - Direction/Shinda Yu

In the consistently dark-backgrounded underworld, the place where Eurydice is captured in episodes 3-4 is a bright flower garden. So characters are also set brightly.

However, in bright spaces, the effects when Seiya and others fight don't stand out on screen well. This is quite difficult. So when battles begin, we'd make it an image space or somehow ensure light effects would show up. This homework carried over directly to Elysion Chapter.

Inferno Chapter: Prelude Episode 5 - Hades! Shocking Possession -
Direction/Katsumata Tomoharu

Hades' chamber. The basic character color balance here is actually my personal favorite. Suppressing brightness while still showing proper color tones. It feels good (laugh).

The transitions between the bright throne area and dark audience chamber worked well too.

And Hades with "Shun's face." On the production floor he was called "Hades-Shun" (laugh). When he's Andromeda Shun, he has slightly pink-tinted, relatively healthy skin color, but after Hades' possession, we made it a bloodless color tone.

Inferno Chapter: Prelude Episode 6 - Fierce Battle! Road to Judecca -
Direction/Katsumata Tomoharu

When one Gold Saint enters the screen, it tightens up perfectly. And when facing the purplish-gray Rhadamanthys and other three Inferno Judges, they stand out even more (laugh).

And finally the ace appears - Ikki! (laugh) While all five Bronze Saints' auras are photography processing, Phoenix Ikki's orange aura stands out most beautifully on screen among the five. Somehow he looks strongest and best (laugh).

*

The full 6 episodes that we should have approached with plenty of leeway - the final two were still somewhat, or rather considerably, tight scheduling. Even so,

Inferno Chapter

got started somehow. After finishing

Prelude

, there was much to consider, and I began preparing homework for what came next.

■ Continued in Episode 60

(08.08.05)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 5: Once Upon a Time... (4) All First Experiences! (laughs)

The other week, my wife and I happened to be watching TV when a commercial for Bandai's plastic model "1/350 Space Battleship Yamato" came on.

My wife looked at the happy-eyed middle-aged men on screen and said "I wonder if anyone actually buys this" while looking at me. There I was with the same eyes as the TV middle-aged men, grinning. "...You bought it, didn't you."

So now in our hallway sits a giant box with nowhere to put it (laughs).

Man, it was huge! My wife burst out laughing when she saw that box. So, when will I actually start building it (distant stare).

Well then.

Uh, another immediate correction (sweat).

The work title I mentioned last time,

Roger Rabbit

, was wrong - sorry, it was

American Rabbit

. I mistakenly wrote it in the heat of the moment. I humbly correct this. My apologies to everyone involved.

Now, the *Robotex* story.

What kind of story was it, you ask - well, they landed on a planet, and it turned out to be a planet where giant robot dinosaurs were fighting... something like that, probably... I've forgotten by now. I think it was humans and their robots cooperating to defeat bad humans and bad robots... or was it different?

Those robots had block-assembled-like forms with American comic-style black-filled shadow parts for visuals. This work was basically a promotion for selling toys - if kids watching the show wanted the robots (toys) appearing on screen, that was OK. Well, that's the same as Japanese anime. The actual toys were sent along with the "materials," but honestly they weren't very cool (bitter laugh).

So my work started with creating color direction sheets based on the sent color models.

Color direction sheets

- character line drawings with paint numbers written in. Which number for skin, which number for hair... drawing lines from each part of the character line drawing and writing numbers like mathematical fractions (!) The numerator is normal color, denominator is shadow color, something like that. For clothing color divisions, I'd draw diagonal lines in the division parts to make it clear, or paint divisions with blue pencil so they'd copy clearly (since the copy machines available then were naturally black and white, doing this would make it appear faintly gray like screen tone).

This way, I created color direction sheets for all necessary color models.

(Actually, I wondered if I could show you the actual *Robotex* color direction sheets? I searched for what I should have kept myself, but unfortunately couldn't find them. Still actively continuing the search)

Now, every work starts with meetings with the director.

This was naturally my first experience (laughs). I knew theoretically what meetings were like, but when I became the actual party involved... Man, what kind of meeting was it - my memory has scattered light-years away and I can't remember (sweat). I probably was just desperately listening to the director's explanations and taking notes on the storyboard. Very different from my current self who actively speaks up a lot (laughs). I have some vague memory of the director saying "I'm hungry" and all the staff eating delivered tempura bowls before the meeting, but maybe that's wrong? (mystery)

After meetings with the director, the work of adding color direction to cuts finally begins.

As I wrote in

Episode 1

of this series,

[color direction]

checks the content of all cuts (key animation and in-between animation) for that story and adds specifications. Originally, you add color direction to in-between animation and order

[finishing]

(painting), but quite often I was adding color direction to key animation.

These "collaborative works" were made beyond conventional domestic production capacity, so most of the actual work was ordered to Korean production companies.

So after checking key animation deliveries domestically, in-between animation work onward through painting was done in Korea (I remember

Robotex

Episode 1 had color direction added to key animation for about half the cuts. From Episode 2 onward, this ratio kept increasing). Because of this work flow, Japanese staff (assistant directors) were stationed in Korea to handle in-between animation checking.

Back then, assistant directors for collaborative works would fly to Korea after meetings for that work, see through to the final cut of that work, then return carrying cels as hand luggage. They'd immediately help with

saridashi

(compositing), ship the completed film to America, and finally get to rest - it was a harsh situation.

So, inputting color direction.

Nobody taught me anything (laughs). Since I had to figure it out myself, I learned by stealing looks at the work style of

F-san

, a senior color director about the same age as me, while breaking out in heavy sweat doing color direction.

Like everything, this is all about experience.

You do lots of it, make lots of face-burning mistakes, and learn it with your body (laughs).

Robotex

was made in 30-minute TV format (actually about 20-plus minutes after commercials were cut), with about 300 cuts and roughly 8,000-10,000 animation drawings per episode. The storyboards sent from America determined the action, plus the complexity of mouth movement cels I mentioned last time, and various other reasons. Incidentally, Toei Animation TV series average about 3,000-3,500 drawings per episode with roughly 300 total cuts, so this was over twice the animation volume.

Checking and adding color direction to this volume of cuts was naturally a first experience. And we were pressed for time.

Departing Oizumi Studio at 6 AM.

We carried them by hand to Korea almost daily. Sometimes with our assistant director's hand luggage, sometimes with Korean production company staff's return flights. Everyone headed to Narita Airport carrying several large duralumin trunks.

And we absolutely had to get them on those flights.

The mountain of cuts that never seemed to decrease no matter how much we worked. Every day barely finishing input by the deadline. Still, somehow we sent out all cuts, but naturally all this would come back painted.

A few days later, looking at those painted cels, I stood stunned.

##

■Continues to Episode 6

(07.02.06)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 60: Summer Vacation Special - Saint Seiya: Hades Inferno Chapter & Elysion Chapter Completion & Broadcast Memorial Complete Episode Notes (Part 2)

Lately, Tokyo has been hit by heat and thunderstorms.

Even though the morning had such beautiful weather, before I know it my head is covered by black clouds, and eventually the entire sky starts lighting up, with ominous rumbling approaching. In industry terminology, that's "battle sky" (laugh).

Then—WHAM! SPLASH!—a storm too fierce to even open an umbrella!

Right around evening when I could finally head home, the Oizumi area where the studio is located invariably enters "battle sky" mode (laugh).

Today too, I can already hear the rumbling approaching. Hahaha (laugh), we're being targeted (crying).

Well then.

Continuing from last time, "Saint Seiya: Hades Inferno Chapter & Elysion Chapter Completion & Broadcast Memorial Complete Episode Notes." Sorry again to those who aren't Saint Seiya fans (sweat).

Inferno Chapter: Finale Episode 1 - Divine Punishment! Greatest Eclipse -
Direction/Katsumata Tomoharu

After

Prelude

ended, we started production on

Finale

after a brief pause, but after finishing

Prelude

I had various thoughts and changed several "methods."

The biggest change was texture brushing for the Cloths. Texture brushing means manually adding highlight-like reflections and natural shadow drops to finished colored cels to give images material texture. The special effects team handles this work.

In previous

Saint Seiya

series, we only added texture brushing to key images and cuts, with the rest going to photography as colored cels. But cels without texture brushing inevitably looked flat and digital-coloring-like. Especially Seiya in white Cloth was fatal as the protagonist.

"Let's add texture brushing to all cuts and all characters!" This was my pushiness, convincing everyone around, and from

Finale

onwards we requested texture brushing processing for all cuts.

So after coloring completion checks, all cuts went to special effects team "

Saint Seiya

Chief" Katsuoka-san, and under Katsuoka-san's supervision, texture brushing processing was added.

Seeing the first rushes of episode 1, Araki-san said "It would be nice if all had brushing like this." "We're doing all of them! (laugh)" I said. "Then animation has to work hard too!" Araki-san's happy face at that moment made us happy too.

Inferno Chapter: Finale Episode 2 - Ikki! Fist of Anguish - Direction/Katsumata Tomoharu

Since Kobioki-san who handled color direction for

Prelude

escaped (laugh), I handled all color direction for

Finale

myself.

Episodes 1 and 2 progress centered on "Hades-Shun," Ikki, and Pandora. Honestly a somewhat plain development (laugh). So I used various small techniques for fun.

One was the scene where Ikki tells Pandora about Andromeda. When Shun's face overlaps with the chained Andromeda image from mythology, Andromeda's hair changes from olive to Shun's hair color green. Not through photography overlap specifications, just how this color looks when overlapped with that color, but it felt nice (laugh). There was no particular direction instruction, but I sometimes added color accents like this for fun. You can do this when handling color direction yourself (laugh).

Inferno Chapter: Finale Episode 3 - Goddess! Stake Your Life -
Direction/Nishizawa Nobutaka

Hades' soul expelled from Shun's body by Athena—in the original it was just a white mass like ectoplasm, so I first tried making it like white light, but the atmosphere somehow didn't work well. "Should we make it a color that suggests evil?" said Nishizawa-san. So it became blue-black with red Hades aura processing.

Inferno Chapter: Finale Episode 4 - Despair! The Wailing Wall - Direction/Sasaki Noriyo

Seiya finally escaping Cocytus reaches "The Wailing Wall." The basic character colors in front of "The Wailing Wall" are actually the same as "Hades' Chamber" colors. I liked this color balance myself, and when I happened to place that color sample on "The Wailing Wall" art board, it was a perfect match (laugh).

Oh, the Cocytus colors were also favorites of mine.

Inferno Chapter: Finale Episode 5 - Gathering! Gold Cloths - Direction/Katsumata Tomoharu

After all, it's Gold Cloths! (laugh). Above all else, Gold Cloths stand out on screen magnificently.

The

Finale

that had forced through "texture brushing for all cuts" was really pressed for production schedule by this point and in crisis. But we couldn't not add texture to Gold Cloths (bitter laugh). Especially the final two episodes had the special effects team really push through to the end. I'm so grateful.

Inferno Chapter: Finale Episode 6 - Farewell! Golden Saints - Direction/Nishizawa Nobutaka

Finale

reaches its end. Truly "Farewell! Golden Saints." ...Well, it's mostly standing around talking in front of "the wall" (bitter laugh). This bridges to

Elysion Chapter

.

And here too, ace Ikki appears at the very end (laugh). He's truly got the best timing (laugh).

*

Inferno Chapter

had various issues including "voice actor changes," but we managed to run through it somehow.

■ Continued in Episode 61

(08.08.06)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 61: Summer Vacation Special - Saint Seiya: Hades Inferno Chapter & Elysion Chapter Completion & Broadcast Memorial Complete Episode Notes (Final Part)

Summer means ghost stories and scary tales, doesn't it? (laugh)

In high school, I was in the astronomy club, and during summer camps or at nighttime observation sites, upperclassmen would start telling scary stories (laugh). In the fog, sitting in a circle on the ground with a candle flame from a lantern in the middle (laugh). We enjoyed doing such things.

My alma mater was Tokyo Metropolitan Fuji High School, and Fuji High had something called the "Seven Mysteries of Fuji High," passed down orally from upperclassmen to underclassmen through generations. "The story of feet being pulled at the pool in the evening," "The photo club darkroom used to be an X-ray room..." story, "The story of the toilet next to the duck pen," "The story of the warped mirror in front of the library," and so on (laugh).

I wonder how those "Seven Mysteries" are doing now? Are they still being passed down through generations? Since the old school buildings related to the "Seven Mysteries" were rebuilt, maybe the traditions have been lost?

I remember this every year around the time when Perseid meteor shower season approaches.

Well then.

Finally the final installment of "Saint Seiya: Hades Inferno Chapter & Elysion Chapter Completion & Broadcast Memorial Complete Episode Notes." At last, the final chapter "Hades Elysion Chapter."

Elysion Chapter Episode 1 - Death Battle to Elysion - Direction/Katsumata Tomoharu

For Elysion Chapter, I asked Akimoto-san, who loves "Ikki-niisan!" to handle color direction from episode 1. No, I was planning to handle episode 1 as usual, but due to a production communication error, Akimoto-san was called to the episode 1 meeting (bitter laugh). So I said "Then, do it!" (laugh). Thus, Akimoto-san handled color direction for all episodes.

Episode 1 was still the story of passing through "The Wailing Wall." So almost exactly the same color design created for "Inferno Chapter: Finale" could be reused.

Elysion Chapter Episode 2 - Gods of Death and Sleep - Direction/Katsumata Tomoharu

From episode 2, the stage finally moved to Elysion. Elysion Chapter became a bright world overflowing with light, in contrast to Inferno Chapter. Actually, this was quite difficult.

In

Saint Seiya

's case, they're constantly fighting, but rather than hand-to-hand combat martial arts, it had become mainly projectile-style fighting where they shoot light at each other. Such screen effects naturally look better in dark spaces.

At the episode 1 meeting, I proposed "Let's make battles image spaces whenever possible." In image spaces we could create dark spaces, and light photography processing would work better. That was my aim with the proposal.

From episode 2, Thanatos and Hypnos finally appeared.

Actually, these two had been appearing in the opening since

Inferno Chapter: Prelude

along with Hades in Surplice. Since we couldn't show them "until they appeared in the main story," they were silhouette processed throughout

Inferno Chapter

and even in

Elysion Chapter

until episode 2, but when we first made the opening for

Inferno Chapter: Prelude

, these two's colors were almost complete.

I absolutely love these two. They're my personal best among all the Cloths and Surplices we've done so far.

Incidentally, the opening had been steadily accumulating small fixes through

Prelude

,

Finale

, and

Elysion Chapter

(laugh). While openings tend to get skipped in DVDs (laugh), it might be interesting to watch them all in sequence for comparison (laugh).

Elysion Chapter Episode 3 - Golden Reinforcements - Direction/Nishizawa Nobutaka

Regarding Seiya's sister "Seika," we hadn't had proper character sheets until now, and while she appeared briefly in

Inferno Chapter

, we roughly decided colors based on the key animation that came up then. This time too, no character sheets came out in the end (bitter laugh), so we created coloring settings from key animation used in the main story.

Speaking of missing settings, I actually forgot that we hadn't created digital coloring color direction for Bear Geki and others (sweat), so I had Akimoto-san handle all of that through screen matching too.

For the Sanctuary where Seika and others are, character colors gradually darken in stages according to the eclipse's progress.

Elysion Chapter Episode 4 - Legendary God Cloths - Direction/Katsumata Tomoharu

Finally they appeared - the God Cloths (■■■■■■■).

These are anime original colorings. In the original color settings, all five were the same gold color, but that overlapped too much with Gold Saints. Actually, from the end of episode 3, Seiya and others are wearing Gold Cloths, so even changing them a bit would still be hard to differentiate on screen.

And I wanted to bring out each of the five's individual "colors" from the Cloths they'd fought in until then. The God Cloths' basic whitish color is common to all five, with their respective "colors" applied to the shadow colors.

These colored God Cloths had already appeared in

Saint Seiya: Heaven Chapter Overture

(director Yamauchi Shigeyasu). In mythological times, the Saint who uniquely wounded Hades wore these God Cloths. See? It connects properly, right? (laugh)

All underwear is white too. For the God Cloths' color balance and to express the sacred, elevated feeling of "God Cloths," I made everyone white.

In episode 4, Seiya first dons the God Cloth, and photography director Ogata-san worked hard on that donning scene. To somehow give form to my request for "aura

rising from the God Cloth itself," he repeated test photography many times and even did voluntary retakes himself.

Elysion Chapter Episode 5 - Hades! Awakening from Myth - Direction/Nishizawa Nobutaka

Even

Elysion Chapter

, which should have had sufficient schedule, still had quite tight scheduling for episode 5 and the final episode. Well, this is anime production's fate (bitter laugh).

Hades' soul rising from the mausoleum was also special effects team technique. Without using 3D, they manually created translucent effects based on normally drawn materials. Photography then added aura light on top.

Not just "Hades' soul" but also the "great jar" - everything was given texture brush processing by the special effects team. Naturally, the scattering rubble, Elysion garden flowers, Seiya and others' battle effects, and so on. The special effects team's hands touched absolutely everything. For

Saint Seiya

, the special effects team's power was indispensable.

As tension rises toward the end, work volume and content inevitably become extraordinary. Moreover, available time keeps decreasing. But they persevered and completed everything to the end.

"Let's add texture brushing to all cuts and all characters!" When entering

Inferno Chapter: Finale

, I proposed this and pushed it through - there might have been some resistance (laugh) - but huge thanks to Katsuoka-kun and the special effects team who worked hard together to complete it!

Elysion Chapter Episode 6 - To a World Overflowing with Light! -
Direction/Katsumata Tomoharu

The final Cloth I decided on was "Athena's Cloth."

I thought Seiya and others' God Cloths and "Athena's Cloth" should have common elements, so I based it on the gold coloring used for God Cloths, arranging whitish colors also used for God Cloths in the Cloth edge paint divisions. This "Athena's Cloth" was also a dazzling golden Cloth in the original color settings. I was able to arrange this well with coloring close to the original.

"Thanatos," "Hypnos," "God Cloths," and "Athena's Cloth." All the Surplices and Cloths appearing in Elysion Chapter are my absolute favorites (laugh).

*

Hades Elysion Chapter

ended after a year and a half from production start, and the long-running

Saint Seiya

anime adaptation concluded with this. The "Saint Seiya team" was disbanded.

Having defeated Hades and saved the earth's crisis, where will Athena and the Saints go next? What about Athena? What about the fallen Seiya? Ah, I want to make this continuation!

"I don't know when it will be..." After the final episode staff first screening ended, producer Obara-kun said in his greeting. "I want to do it again!"

Saint Seiya

!" I want to wait for that day.

■ Continued in Episode 62

(08.08.07)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 62: Once Upon a Time... (40) - The Beginning of Days with Theatrical Dragon Ball Z

The Beijing Olympics have begun.

As expected from the world's highest level sports competition all gathering at the Olympics, each match is incredible. So regardless of whether Japanese athletes are competing or not, I've been watching quite a variety.

With Beijing being just one hour time difference, it's difficult to watch live broadcasts during convenient times. So inevitably it's mainly late-night NHK-BS digests and reruns. Hence I'm somewhat sleep-deprived (bitter laugh).

There are competition events I'm seeing for the first time, which is refreshing. I watched archery and badminton matches for the first time. Hockey was incredibly speedy and quite appealing.

Among all this, what I'm watching with "professional eyes" is swimming.

The eternal theme for those doing color direction is, above all, expressing "water." Recently it's often processed with 3D CG, but expressing "water" through animation + coloring is still anime's foundation. So while enjoying the competitions, I'm just looking at water (laugh).

The texture of undulating pool water surfaces, the splashes athletes kick up, underwater bubbles, diving water columns, and the color tones of athletes underwater, and so on. The more I look, the more interesting it becomes (laugh).

The broadcast technology is amazing too. Between the camera work and CG-combined explanatory composite screens, I'm quite enjoying that side too!

Come to think of it, I remember the men's gymnastics team final from the previous Athens Olympics. At that time, I was watching while working at Oizumi Studio in the early morning. I watched that famous "Bridge to Glory" commentary on the master monitor at my desk (connected to a VCR, so you could watch TV through its tuner).

Hmm? What work was that? Saint Seiya? ...I mean, it feels like recent memory... (sweat).

Well then.

The clock goes back not just four years, but quite far. Continuing the old stories (laugh).

1990-91 centered on OVA work, but OVAs continued in 1992 too with

BE-BOP HIGHSCHOOL 3

(director Kakudo Hiroyuki, animation director Hayama Jun'ichi) and the previously mentioned

Crying Freeman 5: Senjū no Kishimojin

.

In between all this, I became involved in new work. Theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

productions.

Dragon Ball

TV series began in 1986, followed by

Dragon Ball Z

from 1989. Both were huge hits and extremely popular, and around that time, theatrical works were being made at a pace of two per year for the spring and summer "Toei Manga Festival." I was assigned to handle the March 1992 release

Dragon Ball Z: Clash! The 10 Billion Power Warriors

(100 minutes).

"Huh?

Dragon Ball

? Me? Why?" I remember responding like that when the department manager assigned it to me. Somehow it was suddenly decided I'd do it.

At the time, Toei had a principle that theatrical versions of TV series works would in principle have the TV's main person handle color direction. However, this

Dragon Ball Z

worked differently from other TV series.

For example, like me with

Saint Seiya

, normally one color director would be assigned to a series, creating main character colors and managing color direction sheets, but this

Dragon Ball

team didn't assign a dedicated color director. Staff room members - chief director, directors, and assistant directors - decided all color direction matters, with production coordinators and assistant directors managing color direction. They'd give color direction decided in the staff room directly to finishing production companies for work. That was roughly the system.

This team had used this method since the original

Dr. Slump

. Well, for TV series, especially works where characters don't increase much, this method worked somehow (← but later this method backfired when color directions got scattered (bitter laugh)).

However, for theatrical works, you can't do everything "in the staff room" like TV. So nominally, a female color director named Sakai-san had been handling

Dragon Ball

theatrical works as the basic person in charge, having worked on previous

Dragon Ball

and

Dragon Ball Z

theatrical versions.

So somehow this

Dragon Ball Z

work came to me. This was November 1991.

Honestly, I had hardly watched

Dragon Ball

original or TV until then. I had read the

Dr. Slump

original and watched quite a bit of TV since it was the first work I colored when I started anime work as a part-timer, but I knew almost nothing about

Dragon Ball

(bitter laugh).

So I first read the original comics in bulk to get "basic knowledge" in my head (laugh).

Most TV series theatrical versions become "side story" tales separate from the TV series. This

Dragon Ball Z: Clash! The 10 Billion Power Warriors

was like that too. So it seemed I didn't necessarily need to worry about matching TV.

Still, it was a popular work's theatrical version, and the director was the renowned Nishio Daisuke. The animation director was Maeda Minoru. Quite nervously, I went to greet the theatrical staff room... But no one was there (sweat). I went again on another day but still no one. I heard "they haven't been coming recently." Apparently they were holed up at home working on storyboards. Oh, come to think of it, I hadn't received the storyboard... it wasn't finished yet? (sweat)

The time was mid-November 1991. Theatrical release was March 7th the following year. Work time was already under three months. "Ah, I see. Because of these circumstances, things became difficult, so it came to me..."

My long relationship with the

Dragon Ball Z

theatrical series, which would continue from then on, began like this.

■ Continued in Episode 63

(08.08.12)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 63: Actually, I'm Currently Struggling with

Dragon Ball

(sweat)

The Beijing Olympics have ended (bitter laugh).

Despite everything, I watched quite a bit - broadcasts and recordings. Especially softball - I watched that with considerable excitement. Unfortunately, I couldn't watch the final live due to work (crying). But I'm glad they got the gold!

On the other hand, baseball was a disappointing result. But somehow I had a premonition about that. I have lots to say, but saying it won't change anything and would just be annoying, so I won't write it (bitter laugh).

But why does Japanese baseball use Japan-spec sized balls instead of international standard balls? I just can't understand that. I think they need to address that first or it won't work. While approaches and philosophies toward baseball can differ by country, having different balls is strange. The ball is the foundation of everything in baseball. I think it's odd to say "Japan is strong" when that basic premise is different.

Oh.

Come to think of it, I recorded the opening ceremony broadcast, but I still haven't watched it properly. I have a feeling it'll just get archived like this... And before I know it, it'll be the London Olympics (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Once again I've taken a two-week break from this series. I'm truly sorry to those looking forward to it (sweat).

In the series, I started writing about theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

from last time, but actually I'm currently working on a new

Dragon Ball

production in my main job. Due to that +α I'm being worked to death. One episode for Shueisha's autumn event. Since it's an episode written by original creator Toriyama Akira-sensei himself, we're making it with considerable spirit.

Director Ueda Yoshihiro, animation director Yamamuro Tadayoshi, art director Kurahashi Takashi. Ueda-san and Yamamuro-san are members who've been making

Dragon Ball

continuously. Kurahashi-san's art fits nicely there (laugh).

Whether it was last year or the year before, we made a short for the Fuji TV program "I.Q. Sapuri" for quiz purposes, but making

Dragon Ball

properly as a work like this is the first time since TV broadcasting ended.

So my work starts with pulling old color direction from Toei Animation's database and recreating it as digital coloring color direction data. Actually,

Dragon Ball

was made with cel finishing + film photography right to the end. So there were absolutely no materials for current digital coloring, and I had to start creating from there.

This is really tough (laugh). The sheer numbers... (bitter laugh). I'm recreating color direction just for characters appearing in this new work, but even so it's easily over 50. Naturally there are also new characters for the new work, so it suddenly became creating color direction for over 60 characters.

First I made the main characters like Goku, Vegeta, and Piccolo-san to establish balance, but when we had several cuts shot with the initial colors, it somehow became an overly mild

Dragon Ball

... (sweat). Apparently I'd made the color usage somewhat contemporary and familiar.

So "This isn't

Dragon Ball

!" - I apologized profusely and voluntarily redid it, remaking the colors to be more "sharp!" through trial and error.

I'm quite flustered by all this (sweat).

Since it's for an event, it probably can't be seen on TV, but if you're interested, please visit Shueisha's event.

So next time, I plan to resume "Once Upon a Time..." ...probably (sweat).

■ Continued in Episode 64

(08.09.02)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 64: Once Upon a Time... (41) - Theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Clash! The 10 Billion Power Warriors

Before I knew it, it's September.

Agh, it's September!

Cicadas are still barely chirping, but on cool nights I can hear autumn insects' voices. Before I knew it, evenings are getting dark earlier. Morning doesn't get bright until after 4:30 either.

Where did this year's August go?

As I get older, summer feels shorter every year. Naturally the length of months, days, and hours is the same now as always, but subjective speed seems to accelerate yearly, and this year's August passed at my personal record speed. Ah, farewell! My 45-year-old summer (sobbing)!

Will next year pass even faster?

So many things I want to do, places I want to go...

Next year I'm wanting to take the entire month of August as summer vacation. Would that be impossible?

Such is this melancholy September (crying).

Well then.

March 1992 release, theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Clash! The 10 Billion Power Warriors

. Director Nishio Daisuke, animation director Maeda Minoru, art director Taniguchi Jun'ichi.

While the TV series follows Toriyama Akira's original in animation form, theatrical works are basically side stories. This

10 Billion Power Warriors

was one such film. An enemy called Metal Cooler arrives and fights intensely with Goku. Oh well, that's roughly it.

I've forgotten various content details by now (bitter laugh). I don't have any completed video or anything myself. The storyboard I used back then might still be archived somewhere...

That storyboard. Director Nishio was struggling with the climactic final battle area, and that section's storyboard remained cut off abruptly. However, we naturally couldn't wait for its completion before starting work, so we proceeded with various tasks excluding that climax portion.

That storyboard was completed around early February. Since this work's editing was around the second weekend of February, it was about one week before. Then animator Ide-san apparently drew from layout to rough key animation for that section in one week, somehow getting through editing and dubbing.

Oh yes, March releases around that time were "spring vacation timing" around the 20th, so editing was in February. Now they've moved up to early March release, so editing and dubbing finish by late January accordingly.

Now, about colors.

Theatrical versions of TV works operate on the principle that "people watching TV will come see them," so if they become different from TV, that's problematic. Aside from animation, different-looking colors are bad. Things that were red on TV must be red in theatrical versions, blue things must be blue. That was the rule about not changing those.

However, theatrical versions naturally have different volume from TV versions. When TV version colors are just plopped into theatrical version screens, they inevitably feel light and float. So I started from designing main character color tones specifically for theatrical versions.

That said, unlike now with digital coloring where you can do subtle things infinitely, it was fine adjustments within cel paint color limitations. So normal colors stayed mostly the same as TV color direction, with balance reviews centered on shadow color depth. I reset shadow colors somewhat deeper than TV. And there was another big reason for this.

It was the Taiyo Shikisai paint problem again.

As I've written before, while most industry production company works used Taiyo Shikisai cel paints, almost only Toei Doga used STAC cel paints. With sufficient production schedule, naturally everything could be outsourced to Manila studios or domestic finishing productions handling Toei Doga work, having everything colored with STAC paints. But with such tight schedules, that wasn't possible. A considerable portion had to be requested from Korean productions, meaning naturally the paints would be Taiyo Shikisai cel paints.

Basic color direction is designed with STAC colors, then "converted" to Taiyo Shikisai colors. However, naturally STAC and Taiyo don't have identical colors. STAC color direction gets applied to "almost the same" color paints for "conversion." "Almost the same" can be "slightly different," and combinations of

those "slightly different" colors can sometimes become "quite different."

Common with normal colors and their shadow colors is when the normal color conversion is slightly darker than original STAC color, and shadow color conversion is slightly brighter than original STAC color - the finished cel's normal and shadow often end up with almost no difference.

So by designing shadow colors slightly deeper in the original STAC color design to create difference, even when converted to Taiyo colors, there shouldn't be major impression differences from the original - that's what I thought.

So in early 1992, I frantically prepared "conversions." And finally color direction with Taiyo Shikisai paint conversion began.

■ Continued in Episode 65

(08.09.10)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 65: Once Upon a Time... (42) - "R-2" Is Purple - The Trap (bitter laugh)

Before I knew it, it's October (sweat).

This past weekend, I went to meet my favorite paintings. The "Vermeer Exhibition" currently showing with great acclaim at Tokyo Metropolitan Art Museum in Ueno.

The genius painter Johannes Vermeer, who left only about thirty works in his lifetime. Seven of his works scattered around the world have been gathered and are on display. My beloved work "The Love Letter" unfortunately didn't come to Japan, but it was still a completely satisfying Vermeer exhibition.

Ah, seeing the real thing in person is truly amazing! While they're incredible in art books and catalogs too, when you photograph them and then print them, they inevitably become different. The delicate, soft light and the atmosphere and sense of depth expressed through it can truly be appreciated for their original splendor only by seeing the actual works with your own eyes.

I had goosebumps the entire time.

So, the Netherlands!

I've been thinking about this for the past few years - I really should go to Amsterdam to see paintings. Rembrandt is Dutch too! I must go! A trip to the Netherlands to see the real things is decided.

...Well, before that I need to subdue the work I'm currently struggling with. And when that's finished, I'll probably think "First, hot springs!" (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Color direction work for theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Clash! The 10 Billion Power Warriors

began in earnest in January 1992 after the new year.

First I'd do normal STAC color direction for the Philippines Manila studio under Toei Doga (at the time), but eventually production said "We'd like to send some to Korea soon." So Taiyo Shikisai color direction also started from there. Daily flights went out through contractors to Manila. Until evening flight departure, Manila studio STAC color direction. Then from evening until late night, Korean Taiyo Shikisai color direction. This continued daily.

Usually, we'd make a bound booklet "color direction book" for each work and give it to finishing contractors for work, but when requesting Korean work, since it was

completely animation finishing (adding color direction to key animation, then having animation→finishing work and sending back) contracting, we used the method of including copies of all necessary character color directions for each cut (inserting into time sheets). If everything needed for that cut was included with that cut, there would be less wasted searching or painting with wrong color directions, we thought.

Copies inserted into cuts were naturally color direction books created by converting to Taiyo Shikisai colors. Initially we considered giving them a "STAC→Taiyo Shikisai paint conversion table" and having them convert and paint STAC color directions themselves, but that would be tremendously troublesome work for them, and complexity would increase error likelihood. As I may have written before, STAC and Taiyo Shikisai colors have completely different color tones but the same numbers - extremely dangerous colors. So we thought it would be more reliable to specify in Taiyo Shikisai from the start.

But still, it's human work. There were inevitably some mistakes. Well, such mistakes were often color direction errors.

That's right. Sometimes I'd accidentally mix STAC and Taiyo Shikisai specifications. The copies inserted into cuts were error-free, but the problem was when I directly wrote paint numbers on key animation for color direction. Then I'd accidentally write the wrong numbers (bitter laugh).

For example, there's a color called "R-2" often used for skin shadow colors, which we converted to a Taiyo color called "R-70M." But I'd accidentally do it - write "R-2" on Taiyo Shikisai cuts.

So what happens? The skin shadow colors come back painted purple. And when I make mistakes, I tend to make them in batches, so multiple cuts come back with purple skin...

Each time I'd hold my head while apologetically taking retake work to the coloring team.

■ Continued in Episode 66

(08.10.01)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 66: Once Upon a Time... (43) - Racing Through the Studio at 5 AM!
Theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Clash! The 10 Billion Power Warriors

There are no bananas.

Apparently some variety show said they're good for dieting, and due to that influence, everyone and their dog is going "bananas, bananas," causing banana shortages throughout Japan. Geez, what unnecessary trouble!

I've been eating bananas regularly for a long time, regardless of dieting. They're just right for meals when busy. Good digestion too.

But now, during this incredibly busy period, they're not sold anywhere. It's very inconvenient.

Let me be clear: eating a few bananas won't make you lose weight! I'm saying this as someone who always eats them, so I'm not wrong. Before going "bananas for dieting," people should fundamentally review their daily eating habits!

Ah, bananas (sobbing)!

Well then.

Theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Clash! The 10 Billion Power Warriors

. Editing and dubbing were somehow finished, and while keeping an eye on sound mixing deadlines, the days continued with color direction & coloring completion inspections.

For about two and a half weeks from editing/dubbing to final mixing, the cycle continued: cel inspection of completed coloring cuts during the day, color direction on key animation at night. At that time, when key animation was sent out with color direction, it usually came back as finished cels after about one week of animation + finishing work.

I think Manila studios took a bit longer. Moreover, around that time the Philippines was politically unstable, with volcanic eruptions too, so jobs without much schedule leeway were somewhat precarious...

So partly due to such circumstances, the final push mainly involved asking Korean productions for help. Taiyo Shikisai cuts kept increasing.

The final cut's color direction was at 5 AM.

That day there was a hand-carry flight from Toei Doga's Oizumi Studio to Korea. Departure was 5 AM. Right up to that deadline, animation supervisor Maeda-san added corrections to key animation. Several cuts remained that day. Each time a correction was finished, the production coordinator brought it to me (in a slightly separate room), I'd add color direction, then the finishing coordinator would take it for packing - an assembly line process.

However, since these were cuts that remained until the end, they were considerably difficult in various ways, with heavy animation content and correction work. I believe that day's flight was taken by a department head from a Korean production company returning to Korea. The person was already prepared and waiting for departure time, but even as departure time approached, the cargo to be transported wasn't ready. We somehow managed to placate the person wanting to leave early, having them wait with their bag open.

The very final cut - the production coordinator brought it to me in a great rush right at 5 AM. With today's digital coloring, you can manage somehow even if color direction is rough or "free coloring," but with paint coloring, you must add proper color direction before sending it out. I quickly checked the key animation and added color direction, then ran through the studio with that cut and stuffed it into the waiting cargo...

What a morning past 5 AM that was. A strange sense of fulfillment that could become addictive (bitter laugh). The sleepiness had completely lifted in that still-dark, cold February morning.

This completed the color direction work. Now the battle with massive cel completions would begin.

■ Continued in Episode 67

(08.10.07)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 67: Once Upon a Time... (44) - There Were Actually Two Types! The Secret of Super Saiyans

The morning and evening air is completely autumn now. Days are increasing where it's cold enough to catch a cold if you're not careful. During these past few days when I've been coming home in the early morning due to work, the morning sky has been wonderful every day. The clouds are just great.

Every day, every morning, the sky's expression is completely different. The way light overflows, the colors of clouds. And they're wonderfully beautiful - I can't help but pray to the rising morning sun. Somehow, it feels so blessed (laugh).

This season when it gradually gets colder might be when morning feels most pleasant. Ah, I want to travel with my camera to capture wonderful mornings. Of course, hot springs would be a set deal.

Well then.

"The Namekians who migrated to New Namek were being attacked by someone and facing extinction. Dende, who became Earth's new 'God,' sensed this. He asked Goku and others to save New Namek. Goku, Gohan, Piccolo and the group headed to New Namek. What awaited the arriving group was a mysterious robot army and Cooler, who had been revived with a mechanical body - Metal Cooler..."

I rewatched theatrical

Dragon Ball Z: Clash! The 10 Billion Power Warriors

for probably the first time since the first print. This was because theatrical

Dragon Ball

DVDs were being released, and the one I ordered happened to arrive recently.

Man, hahaha (bitter laugh).

As always, reviewing old work I did is quite embarrassing or rather ticklish. I can't help but go "Ah~" (bitter laugh). I really remember things in detail. Watching the footage brings back even more detailed memories.

Reviewing it confirmed that there were more Taiyo Shikisai paint scenes and cuts than I thought - I was surprised. More than that - over half were Taiyo Shikisai color cuts. That means we asked Korean productions to handle that much work.

Speaking of Dragon Ball and Goku, it's Super Saiyans. When they raise their "ki" and go "uryaa!" their hair stands up and turns golden, becomes high-contrast

coloring, and they rampage stronger while wrapped in brush auras - that thing.

This Super Saiyan processing had two strength variations, but did you all know about this?

When Goku transforms from normal state to Super Saiyan, first he becomes the "strong" type processing with a "dowaa!" (the production name was probably 'B' type? "weak" was 'A'), and when conversations continued long in that state, he'd be dropped to "weak," then when battle resumed he'd go "doryaa!" back to "strong" type - that kind of usage.

Theatrical versions tended to jump straight into "uryaa!" battles, so we didn't use the "weak" type much, but TV series, which inevitably had long conversational scenes due to story development, used this "weak" type processing quite often.

How were they different? The "weak" compared to "strong" had: 1. Hair color was lighter (whitish) yellow, 2. Body high-contrast coloring was more restrained, 3. Special effects (brush & touch) aura worn was lighter.

Dramatically, standing around talking while constantly in a heightened state would be awkward, so naturally such strength variations were essential, but apparently there was also some desire to reduce work load.

This Saiyan aura special effects work was incredibly difficult. Since it was cel animation then, all these auras were hand-drawn by special effects staff. First they'd cut out masking cels for brushing according to animation drawings. Using those masks they'd spray brush, then hand-draw dynamic touches around those brush areas. Special effects staff worked on this frame by frame, cut by cut.

Dragon Ball

also had many character-specific special effects rules. Being a long-running series, the sheer volume was tremendous. Hirao-san, who was special effects team chief at the time, kept detailed notes on everything, and the entire effects team used it as a "

Dragon Ball

special effects encyclopedia" whenever needed.

Incidentally, during production of the recent new work for Shueisha JUMP Tours, that legacy was apparently utilized. Even with today's digital coloring, Saiyan auras were apparently still hand-drawn brush & touch (bitter laugh).

This "weak" type was used quite a bit in

Clash! The 10 Billion Power Warriors

. That was processing matched to TV series precedent. For customers who watch TV and come to theaters, showing them the same thing as TV would be somehow insufficient and regrettable. So we wanted to show speedier, more voluminous, thoroughly satisfying footage than TV. But if it strayed too far from TV, it would become "huh?" - being careful about that balance is the key point when making theatrical versions of TV works.

Come to think of it, later theatrical versions decided "Let's stop using 'weak'?" and I think I was the one who suggested it...

The hair color during "weak" times didn't have good saturation (color development) and didn't show up well on film, creating a kind of indigestion or frustration I remember. The "strong" hair also had poor saturation, but the "weak" with lighter aura processing looked more conspicuously dull. Hmm. In terms of color development, STAC paints were definitely superior, I deeply felt. As I wrote two episodes ago, those "slight errors" in STAC→Taiyo Shikisai conversion really bothered me on screen.

Anyway, we somehow managed to complete it and achieved nationwide March release. After somehow finishing and taking a breather, the script for summer Toei Manga Festival's

Dragon Ball Z

was at my desk.

■ Continued in Episode 68

(08.10.15)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 68: Once Upon a Time... (45) -

Dragon Ball Z: Extreme Battle! The Three Great Super Saiyans
and Final Days with My Mother

Recently my wife has been troubled by nightmares. When I asked, it's apparently dreams about me getting involved with some new religion and not coming home.

"So am I some kind of guru?"

"No, just a low-ranking member"

Oh, I see (bitter laugh).

"And you're wearing something like white clothes making something"

Hmm... (bitter laugh).

Could that be making anime? I have been coming home in the early morning lately (sweat).

It's a mystery.

Well then.

1992. Looking at my work chronology, this year I was involved in three theatrical works (two released that year), completed one video work (

Crying Freeman: Senjū no Kishimojin

), handled color direction for one TV series episode (

Dragon Quest: Dai no Daibōken

), and did some part-time work on several NHK

Minna no Uta

episodes... It was a year when I got to work on truly various projects.

I think from the previous year and around this year, the works I could participate in increased, work volume kept growing, and I've continued at roughly the same intensity to this day. It feels like the beginning year of that flow.

In 1992, the second theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

was the summer release

Dragon Ball Z: Extreme Battle! The Three Great Super Saiyans

(■■■■■■!!■■■■■■■■■■). Director Kikuchi Kazuhito, animation director Maeda Minoru, art director Nagasaki Hitoshi - a 60-minute work.

Around this time, "Toei Anime Fair" combined about three theatrical works for screening during spring and summer vacation seasons, and this

Dragon Ball Z

was one such film. Incidentally, the simultaneous screenings were

Dragon Quest: Dai no Daib■■ken - Buchiyabure!! Shinsei Rokudaish■■gun

and

Rokudenashi Blues

... I don't remember them (bitter laugh).

From spring theatrical release to summer was four months. Honestly the schedule wasn't very generous, but by this time staff were gradually getting used to making theatrical works on such short schedules. This time too, finishing work was outsourced to Manila studios while there was leeway, with the latter half asking Korean productions for animation + finishing work.

As usual, production schedules fell behind smoothly (bitter laugh), and the volume requested from Korean productions kept increasing. As I wrote previously, requesting Korean productions = Taiyo Shikisai paints. Learning from spring

Dragon Ball Z

reflections, I gradually prepared, but the more I thought and created conversion color directions by replacing paints, the wider the gap between Taiyo Shikisai colors and STAC paints became. "If only everything could be made with Taiyo Shikisai colors, how much easier it would be!" Such conflicts constantly swirled in my head.

Around that time, there was one major event in my family. My mother's death. My mother, who had been hospitalized with cancer in early spring, passed away in early June during this theatrical work's crucial production phase.

Daily routine continued: first showing my face at my mother's bedside in the morning, entering the studio at noon for work. Returning to the hospital before evening visiting hours ended, then back to the studio until early morning. Such days continued.

Eventually in the early hours of a day in early June, my mother passed away. I took just two days off for wake and funeral, then continued with this theatrical version's color direction and inspection. For better or worse, there was no replacement for

me in this theatrical production. That's this job. Because of this, I remember working quite matter-of-factly.

Every work has memories associated with its production, but memories of this

Dragon Ball Z: Extreme Battle! The Three Great Super Saiyans

overlap with those final days with my mother, making them somehow poignant.

There was another sad event. The night after finishing my mother's funeral, one message reached me. The news of art director Mukuo Takashi's death.

I knew Mukuo-san had been hospitalized for a long time, but he passed away during this same period. I attended the wake held the next day. The steadily falling June rain blurred that wake's scenes, making them quite memorable.

This was the first half of 1992, when I was 29. What awaited me was an even bigger theatrical work - a full two-hour feature.

■ Continued in Episode 69

(08.10.22)

Color Design Notes [Tsuji Kunitada]

Episode 69: A Little Bit of Promotion!

Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!

"The sky is high, and I'm getting fat," autumn (crying).

As soon as autumn arrived, my busyness accelerated and late-night work is becoming routine. When you sit and work for long periods, you naturally get hungry, and even if the number of daily meals and amounts don't change, the timing somehow makes one meal fall into late night.

"Late-night meals double the calories!"

These are the words of a certain junior color director. Ah, truly golden words!! Eating late at night is dangerous!

...While thinking this, I somehow end up eating one meal (crying).

Well, I try to reduce the amount as much as possible at night, but when you sit and work continuously, your brain inevitably craves sugar, and you unconsciously reach for sweets...

Such are these long autumn nights (sobbing).

Well then.

Just recently, a certain producer I know (Producer I) called me...

"Tsuji Kunitada-san, are you busy right now?"

"Yeah. I'm working on

Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro

for December release"

"Huh!? There's such a thing?"

He treated it like "such a thing"! (sobbing)

Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro

isn't widely known, apparently.

Even though it's almost released...

So out of frustration, I'll do a little promotion this time...

Once again,

Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!

. Nationwide release Saturday, December 20th. Original by Mizuki Shigeru, supervision by Kyogoku Natsuhiko, script by Sanji Riku, director Koga Goro, character design by Ueno Ken, animation director Asanuma Akihiro, art director Honma Sadaaki, and color design by me - that's the lineup.

This work and one other job have me extremely busy currently. That's why I've been missing serialization lately... (deeply reflecting).

The currently airing

Kitaro

TV series is the fourth remake, and apparently this year marks the 40th anniversary since the first series began. That means it gets remade and appears on TV about once every 10 years. Despite everything, it's quite a popular work.

The very first original

Kitaro

was still black and white. I wasn't allowed to watch the original broadcast (I was about 5), but later - I think when I was in middle school? - they reran that original

Kitaro

Sunday mornings at 6 AM during summer, and I remember watching it intently in my darkened room.

A few years before that, I remember watching the second

Kitaro

in evening rerun slots or something. This second series was already in color, but both the first and second were quite scary.

Then came the 1980s and the third

Kitaro

. Around this time it became more "hero Kitaro" feeling. During this third series, I participated in the theatrical

GeGeGe no Kitaro: The Great Yokai War

(← I wrote about this before, right? (laugh)).

"Never imagined I'd end up working on

Kitaro

that I watched as a child, especially theatrical work" - it was quite a mysterious feeling.

This

GeGeGe no Kitaro: The Great Yokai War

was a story where Yumeko-chan didn't appear. Just between us, I actually disliked Yumeko-chan's existence (explosion). Because the

Kitaro

I'd watched wasn't a justice hero who fought to protect Yumeko-chan (bitter laugh). So when I received the script and storyboard and read through them, I remember feeling somewhat relieved (laugh).

Time flowed further, and the 1990s brought the fourth

Kitaro

. Yes, digital coloring started from this fourth series. While I hardly watched the actual broadcasts, being the first digital coloring work, it was apparently quite difficult. The color designer then was Itasaka-san, who's also handling the currently acclaimed fifth series.

So the fifth series. And its theatrical feature.

While

Kitaro

has been made into theatrical works many times, they were all about 40-minute short or medium-length films, making this the first 90-minute feature-length anime film adaptation. That was somewhat surprising.

Well, for story details, please check the official website, but this theatrical version is in a way a festival (laugh). What kind of festival? Japan is divided into six regions, with different versions screening in each region - that's the "gimmick."

What's different? When Neko-musume gets blown far away by the demon mirror Kagami-jijii and runs around Japan to return to Kitaro, regional "local specialties" appear for each area.

As reported recently, Higashikokubaru, Governor of Miyazaki, appears as a "local specialty" for the Kyushu-Okinawa region. We properly asked him to do the voice acting (laugh). Also, for the Kanto-Koshinetsu region, Fuji TV's morning information program "Mezamashi TV" appears. Again, we had Otsuka announcer, Takashima announcer, and weather presenter Kaito Aiko-san voice themselves!

I created colors for all these "local specialty" characters. Especially Kaito-san's colors were the most energetically created color direction, and I'm quite pleased with my self-praise of "Really well done! Perfect!" She's my top pick among this theatrical version's characters! The person herself was apparently very pleased too (joy). Ah, I really wanted to meet Kaito-san in person (sobbing).

For

The Great Yokai War

, I stubbornly insisted on "absolutely something different from TV" and worked hard, but for this

Japan Explodes!!

, I'm making it thinking "so people who always watch TV can enjoy it even more." The feeling is to upgrade the TV taste that everyone knows further in the theatrical version.

Well, in that way (← what way?), we're making

Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!

. It should be completed soon (probably). Please look forward to it!

Producer I should definitely go see it properly at the theater!

And the story about that other job next time.

■ Continued in Episode 70

(08.11.04)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 6: Once Upon a Time... (5) People Fighting from 11 PM

"I want to see *Odin: Photon Sailer Starlight*," I said, and thanks to Editor-in-Chief Oguro I was able to see it (Thank you, Editor-in-Chief Oguro!).

So recently we held a mini-screening in the color design room at Oizumi Studio. Several of us who were involved in finishing at the time watched it together.

"Ah, so this is what it was like," everyone said with distant stares (laughs).

Based on

Yamato

-like elements, it tried to cram in all the trends of the time - animation, music, everything - but it was all half-hearted. That kind of feeling. "It was tough though (bitter laugh)" was everyone's impression (bitter laugh).

Well then.

The collaborative work *Robotex* story.

The animation and finishing work requested from Korean production companies came back about a week later on the final flight from Seoul.

At that time, the collaborative works being produced included *G.I. Joe*, *Transformer*, *Muppet Babies*, and several other lines.

Packages from Korea arrived almost every night. Tonight Japanese staff, tomorrow night some Korean staff - someone's hand luggage, several duralumin trunks delivered to the studio.

20-30 kilograms each.

Usually 2-3 pieces, sometimes 7-8 pieces. Those trunks and bags had traveled the Tokyo-Seoul route countless times, and like battle-scarred veterans, they were battered, wobbly, reinforced with duct tape everywhere, and used until they literally fell apart.

They'd paint until just before departure from Seoul production companies, hastily pack it, and give it to staff traveling to Tokyo.

Even the carriers didn't know how many pieces of luggage there would be until the last minute. So the carrying staff had it tough too. Occasionally, they'd miscount the pieces carried back from Narita Airport, leaving trunks abandoned at the

baggage claim, causing great commotion (bitter laugh). Or sometimes luggage would be stopped by airport customs for some reason and couldn't be brought back - again, great commotion.

The final flights departing Seoul in the evening arrived at Narita Airport around 8:30-9:00 PM.

After the long journey from there, they'd arrive at Oizumi Studio in Nerima around 11 PM.

And from there, it was war.

Most of the arrived luggage was painted cels.

The number of sheets coming back in one flight varied, but at peak times, all works combined could be over 3,000 sheets at once. We'd tackle them in order of schedule priority. Since it was so late, we'd want to say "Well, let's check tomorrow morning..." Works and episodes that could wait until the next day were worked on during the day. But works without schedule room would immediately unpack and start delivery checking (cel inspection and retake processing) to finish checking and retake processing by morning.

At that time, Toei Doga's [inspection] members totaled 10 people including me.

Everyone had their own assigned works, but within their capacity for their own work, they participated in this late-night cel inspection as helpers.

For example, with *Robotex*, first I, as the person in charge, would quickly look through each cut and note any major mistakes like color errors.

Then several available helpers would divide up the cel inspection work.

As inspection progressed, we'd find all kinds of finishing-related retakes

- color mismatches, paint unevenness, more color errors, mask creation mistakes, etc. Simple things we'd fix quickly while inspecting, but time-consuming ones got noted and passed to the retake processing team.

Late-night retake processing was handled by production companies specializing in finishing retakes.

On nights with cel inspection, teams from those companies would come in around 11 PM when flights arrived, set up in the painting rooms. They'd eat sushi and such prepared by the finishing department while waiting for our inspection results, then process the mountain of retake cuts one after another.

So *Robotex* Episode 1 came back painted this way.

The luggage arrived, progress staff skillfully took out cut bags from trunks and sorted them by work. Matching shipping slips with luggage, finally the mountain of

Robotex

painted work was piled in front of me.

Now, checking begins.

"Aggh!"

Opening the first cut, I was immediately stunned.

There should have been a white-bodied robot with black surface shadows in white-black two-tone color, but the cel I held had just a solid white mass painted uniformly white. The shadow areas that should have been painted separately had been omitted and painted "shadowless." "Oh no," an immediate baptism.

Also, several characters running toward the background, who should have been different colors, were all painted the same color (naturally shadowless),

or painted in completely unspecified colors...

This was common with Korean deliveries at the time

- when there was no schedule room and they absolutely had to make the final flight that day, sometimes this kind of "work simplification" or "work time reduction" would be imposed.

Some cuts even had paint that wasn't properly dry, sticking to the animation paper - "half-dry" cels... (cries).

"Ah, ah, ah... (sweat)"

I panicked. But I couldn't OK this as-is, so retakes it was. I added processing instructions and sent them to the retake team. Various time-consuming cuts and cuts with complex retake instructions I decided to handle myself, while requesting help from assisting seniors for other OK-looking cuts or cuts without major retakes.

In the "tissue paper" (white protective paper on cels) covering the floor like clouds, cel inspection proceeded silently.

As expected from battle-tested seniors. The large pile soon disappeared. When the assisted portions were finished, the seniors went home.

What remained were me, the work's person in charge, and the retake team fighting the mountain of retakes.

While checking remaining cuts, I reflected.

"See, this is why mistakes happen when you specify like this."

F-san, the senior who helped with inspection, had pointed out several problems with my color direction method.

Thinking about it, these shadow-skipped cuts might have happened because I hadn't properly written "BL" instructions for the BL shadow parts, and everyone being painted the same color might have been problems with my color direction method.

Being painted random colors might have been because when inquiries came, my response was delayed, so they couldn't make it in time... The more I thought, the more I concluded, "Ah, maybe it was the fault of me, the rookie?" If proper, clear, accurate specifications had been given, they might have painted it properly, and we might not have had to process retakes until this hour...

While reflecting on various things like this, cuts flowed to photography like a raging torrent.

This continued for about 3 days. The final retake processing finished at 6 AM on the last day. 12 hours later, all the rushes were completed, and all staff watched that connected film together. There we found several major retakes, rushed to fix those too and re-shot. Thus

Robotex

Episode 1 was somehow shipped to America.

Finally taking a breath... but there was no time for that, as Episode 2's cuts waiting for color direction were already piled like a mountain on my desk.

##

■Continues to Episode 7

(07.02.13)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 70: Side Story - More Promotion!

Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!

November means "Tori no Ichi" (Rooster Market). This year there seem to be three rooster days.

Oh. I learned just 2-3 years ago that "Tori no Ichi" and "O-Tori-sama" aren't nationwide customs/festivals. What a surprise - they're Tokyo local. Native Tokyo people tend to unconsciously assume things done in Tokyo must be nationwide (laugh).

Every November on "Rooster Days," markets are held at shrines. At those market stalls you buy lucky bamboo rakes for business prosperity and offer rakes bought the previous year to the shrine. Tokyo has such events.

Somehow, Tori no Ichi makes my heart race. Memories of being taken to Shinjuku Hanazono Shrine's Tori no Ichi as a child resurface from deep in my body, and even at this age I get excited and restless.

There's a shrine near my house where Tori no Ichi is held, but my "O-Tori-sama roots" are definitely Hanazono Shrine. That crowded night market is irresistibly good. I don't actually buy rakes, but the clapping between sellers and customers that happens each time a rake sells makes me so happy.

However, last year and the year before, I was constantly chased by work during this period and couldn't go out, which was quite lonely. Same this year - "Ni no Tori" (second rooster day) has already ended.

"San no Tori" (third rooster day) is at month's end.

Will I be able to go to Tori no Ichi this year? (laugh)

Well then.

Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!

releasing next month (December 20th) is finally in production's last spurt!

"Huh? It's still not finished? (sweat)" - such comments are prohibited (laugh).

Being swamped by that work's final push, I dropped last week's serialization manuscript again. Sorry to all readers.

Well...

Since I'm dropping manuscripts at last week's situation level, being even busier this week, I naturally can't concentrate on writing other topics (explosion), so this week is also promotional special part 2 for

Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!

that I'm currently battling.

My work on this

Theatrical GeGeGe no Kitaro: Japan Explodes!!

is color design, color direction, and inspection for the main story of about 80+ minutes plus the roughly 3-minute short

GeGeGe Festival! The Five Great Kitaros

that plays briefly before the main story begins.

As you all know, the

GeGeGe no Kitaro

TV series is currently airing with great acclaim, and color design for that is handled by Itasaka Yasue-san. While colors for Kitaro, Neko-musume, and many demons are already established in the TV series, do we use those as-is for the theatrical version? Actually, no.

TV series colors are made somewhat brighter for TV screens. TV screens and theatrical film screenings have different color (or brightness) expression ranges, so theatrical works need screens made with appropriate colors.

Also, TV series has flexible design to handle various episodes unfolding weekly with maximum common denominator adaptability, but theatrical versions can specialize for just that one episode, requiring color design focused only on that story's content.

So my first job was converting each character's TV series colors for this theatrical use.

First, deciding the protagonist Kitaro's colors.

For any work, I set key characters and create the [basic][foundation] centered on those characters. For Kitaro, color combinations were already decided, so I adjusted brightness and color saturation while maintaining that balance. First lowering brightness and saturation somewhat uniformly, then raising sunken colors and restraining excessive colors through trial and error. Just like a balance scale.

The result was somewhat lower saturation and brightness compared to TV color direction, with added depth to shadow colors. I also restrained the yellowish tones

in skin color compared to the TV series.

"White" brightness is also a major key. For characters, white of eyes and teeth become the brightest, closest to "White," and how to set those values becomes a major factor.

Kitaro's eye whites in the TV series appear to be [RGB:244.244.244], but for this theatrical version I set them to [228.228.228]. This [RGB:228.228.228] looks quite gray when viewed alone, but it just needs to look white in balance with skin. I adjusted overall balance with that sense.

Incidentally, for this time's guest character Kazamatsuri Hana, to make her skin look fair, conversely from that skin color balance, her eye whites are brighter than Kitaro's at [233.233.233].

Oh, Medama-oyaji's "eye whites" are handled separately (laugh).

So after first deciding Kitaro, I next created Hana-chan's colors. Then using those two as the axis, I adjusted other regular characters' colors while creating original theatrical characters' colors.

Whether creating new colors or converting from TV versions, I first consider individual character personalities while being conscious of character distinctiveness balance to create colors for each character individually. Then I adjust balance considering combinations with other characters in appearance scenes. I endlessly repeat such processes.

So the color directions I created for this theatrical version totaled over 200! (laugh)

Too many demons! (bitter laugh)

Who exactly thought up "47 Demon Warriors"? (bitter laugh)

When I handled color design for

Ojamajo Doremi

previously, main character color directions created in the first two years didn't reach 200, showing how many this number is. Moreover, I also create special coloring color directions for individual scenes, so adding those approaches 400? Or more? This was definitely my theatrical work record for most color directions (laugh).

This is still just the first part of my work. The real battle is color direction and inspection of completed coloring. The battle finally enters the front lines.

To be continued next time!

■ Continued in Episode 71

(08.11.18)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 71: Extra Edition - Finally Complete!

GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!

How many floors up do you use the elevator?

I live on the 4th floor of a 6-story apartment building, and when going up and down from the 1st floor to my home, I end up taking the elevator. Well, having the elevator right by my apartment door is a big reason I keep taking it (laughs).

Somehow I seem to have a rule in my head that goes "stairs for up to 3 floors, elevator for 4 floors and above." I wonder why?

The elementary and junior high schools I attended as a child were 3-story buildings. The school I went to every day naturally had stairs up to the 3rd floor, so I unknowingly developed this "stairs up to 3 floors" rule, I suppose?

What do you think?

Wait... my high school was 4 stories (sweat).

Incidentally, Toei Animation's (■■■■■■■■■■) Oizumi Studio is basically a 3-story building. It feels more like a school than a company, you know? My desk is on the 2nd floor, and every time I need to check rushes, I go up to the screening room on the 3rd floor... I'd kind of like an escalator (laughs).

Now then.

This is the third promotional extra edition for the theatrical work

GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!

(■■■■ ■■■■■■■■■■ ■■■■■■■■) opening this month (December 20th) (laughs).

As I wrote last time, after creating the colors for the regular characters by modifying the existing TV version character colors, and the theatrical original characters, we now move on to matching these with the background art for each scene and confirming the color scheme for each scene.

When I get worked up thinking "theatrical work," I tend to overdo things, but this time there was an agreement with Director Koga (■■■■■) and the producer to "not stray too far from the TV series." With that in mind, I started organizing the scenes, so I aimed for relatively normal-looking screens. Even so, since it's a theatrical version, we also aimed for dynamic screens worthy of that, which was the tricky part.

Roughly speaking, I placed the so-called "normal" color direction (■■■■) - the most basic standard - on the daytime outdoor scenes.

For the several sunset scenes, I created a total of 8 different sunset color directions to match the depth of each sunset.

Similarly, I made 4 types of night color direction. Additionally, I created quite a few color schemes for special locations and time periods like the Yokai Yokochō, a certain cave interior, the hell realm where Enma-sama resides, and various flashback image scenes.

As for the light effects during battle scenes and reflection effects, those colors were handled almost entirely on a cut-by-cut basis. Oh, and the familiar BANK cuts from the TV version were naturally adjusted in color to match their use in this theatrical production.

Since the climax scene took place at night, I created night-like colors for the cels, but here too there was an order from the director to "not make it too dark, use colors that still convey the characters' normal color feel," so I created quite clean night colors.

For daytime scenes inside Kitarō's house and Hana's mansion, I had them colored with the "normal" color direction first, then made adjustments during cel inspection. I placed the cels on the backgrounds for those cuts and slightly adjusted the brightness.

That's right, this time I handled both the color direction and final cel inspection alone for the entire production (for the coloring inspection, several staff members did rough inspections of the overseas coloring before I checked them), so I worked on adjusting cel colors by matching them with backgrounds before sending them to photography.

Based on predetermined scene color directions, we specify colors for each accordingly, but even then, depending on the cut, there are various elements like the amount of shadows in the drawings, the brightness or darkness expression of the backgrounds, the particular performance content we want to achieve in that cut, so it often doesn't work to simply say "this scene's colors are OK if painted with this color direction."

So I actually place the cels on the backgrounds and make small adjustments to brightness and color tone so each cut achieves the intended screen balance.

Some productions have separate specialized staff who handle such adjustment work using After Effects, but for this

Kitarō

, I was allowed to create quite a lot of the screens myself.

And we mustn't forget the work of the special effects department. Most texture processing and effects are the work of the special effects team. For hand-drawn animation, their section's work is indispensable! This time too, they thought through various processing techniques and completed an enormous amount of work. Even during the aforementioned fine-tuning adjustments, they properly handled my selfish orders like "ah, actually here, add some brush work..." (laughs).

Animation production workflow is an assembly line process. After the key animation is finished and the animation director's work is done, the final 7 days from when the last cut reaches me becomes the final battle. Everything must be finished in these 7 days. We accelerate all at once toward completion. How many cuts can get rush approval before entering these "7 days of fire" (■) becomes one major key in the final push of theatrical production (laughs).

This time the coordination between sections went well, and we managed to get through without major confusion. Phew, that was good! If these gears had gotten out of sync, we might have faced a situation where we'd have to tearfully give up on major retakes that remained at the end. But this time we were able to finish with results that satisfied the staff.

So anyway, I managed to give final approval to all cuts about 12 hours before writing this manuscript. Now we just wait for the first screening at the lab.

The short film

GeGeGe Festival! The Five Great Kitaros

and

GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!

- just over 2 weeks until everyone can see them (oh, there seems to be an advance screening next weekend). Please look forward to it!

■ Continued in Episode 72

(08.12.02)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 72: Another Extra Edition! About

Casshern Sins

Actually, today (December 9th), there's the staff first screening of

GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!

in the screening room at Toei Studios (■■■■■) Oizumi Studio. And I'm writing this manuscript during the break until that first screening, and during the break until the wrap party (sweat).

Looking back, it feels like this year was all about

Kitaro

. Around this time last year, I was working on launching

Hakaba Kitaro

(■■■■■). Ah, has it really been a year since then... it makes me gaze into the distance. And just as the production period for

Hakaba Kitaro

was ending, the talk for this

Kitaro

theatrical feature came up...

Well, that's what kind of year this was. I wonder what kind of year next year will be. I still can't see anything yet, so while staying alert, I think I'll take a relaxed approach.

What kind of year was this for everyone?

Now then.

During this year of my personal "

Kitaro

Year," there was actually a work that was quietly, secretly moving in parallel. The currently airing

Casshern Sins

(■■■■■Sins).

...I wrote "currently airing," but it's actually not a national broadcast - it's mainly late-night broadcasts in the Kanto, Chubu, and Osaka areas. Moreover, even though there's broadcasting in Kanto, it's not on Tokyo stations, which is a subtle situation (laughs). So some of you might not know about it... which brings us to another promotional piece! (laughs)

Original creator: Tatsunoko Production (■■■■■■■■■■), Series composition: Kobayashi Yasuko (■■■■), Character design: Umakoshi Yoshihiko (■■■■), Director: Yamauchi Shigeyasu (■■■■). Yes, it's a work by Director Yamauchi.

"Director Yamauchi is apparently doing

Casshern

with Umakoshi characters" - I heard that rumor from certain sources at the end of the year before last. At that time, I was overwhelmed with my father's final days and had no spare capacity, but after things settled down, one day I resolved to call Director Yamauchi.

"I hear you're doing

Casshern

?"

"Yes, I am (laughs)"

"Um, could I join too? (sweat)"

And so, I ended up participating in

Casshern

by half-forcing my way in (!). As color design (■■■■), I'm in charge of the basic character colors and scene-by-scene design. Sometimes I also do color direction for individual episodes.

Actually, I haven't seen the original

New Human Casshern

(■■■■■■■■■■). Nor the OVA that came after. Despite being right in the strike zone generationally, I somehow hadn't watched it. I could enthusiastically sing the theme song at karaoke (laughs), but somehow I hadn't seen the main story. I still haven't watched beyond the reference materials for the main story (sorry).

So rather than doing

Casshern

, I simply wanted to work with Director Yamauchi. That's all there was to it.

The production site is Madhouse (■■■■■■■■). I first met the production producer around summer before last year, I think. By autumn, I had brought my work Mac into the staff room and my "nest" was complete, and I gradually entered the work phase.

24 episodes across 2 cours. It's just the right amount to work on thoroughly. The director seemed to be thinking about a small elite team for both direction and animation.

"For episodes directed by the director, Umakoshi-san will be animation director, and Tsujita-san will handle color direction and inspection" - somehow it became arranged like that (laughs). That was fine, but looking at the schedule, the director's own directed episodes were lined up right from the start: episodes 1, 2, 4, and 7 in the first half.

"Th-this is! (sweat)"

Won't this become quite difficult? I was momentarily daunted, but since the broadcast start was still far off, I figured it would probably be okay somehow. That was my feeling at the time.

Meanwhile, voice actor auditions began. I was secretly thinking "I wonder if Furuya Toru-san will come." I didn't know about the original Casshern, but I had a feeling he might actually suit this new Casshern character. And then, it was indeed Furuya-san! What a surprise! I was so happy about this.

Various things were decided bit by bit like this, the year changed, and we entered this year. By last year, production had already started on the main episodes, and screens were gradually becoming visible. We've been creating it quite steadily, aiming for broadcast this autumn.

Screen-wise, first and foremost is the excellence of the animation! With Umakoshi-san at the center, they're drawing really good animation every episode - it's wonderful. As an animation note, we've abandoned the thin lines popular nowadays and are finishing the in-betweens with clear, bold lines throughout. We're taking care to ensure the powerful nature of the animation comes through more strongly on screen.

We're using a technique of adding "bleeding" to the entire screen during photography. By applying this processing to all cuts, strong unity is born across scenes without screen variation.

This "bleeding filter processing" drastically affects both cel and background saturation and contrast, so we're controlling the saturation and brightness of both cel colors and backgrounds by reverse-calculating from the intended final screen. In a way, it's the complete opposite of

Hakaba Kitaro

(laughs).

From the start, we've been quite conscious of how the screen looks on digital terrestrial and high-definition broadcasting, so honestly, even for the same broadcast, I'd recommend viewing on digital terrestrial rather than analog broadcast.

Well, episode 1 was completed with quite luxurious time investment, and while there were some cuts that looked a bit dark and hard to see, it turned out quite well overall, I must say!

And of course, the "Yamauchi style" explodes. Exquisite layouts and sharp animation direction, atmosphere and timing, and music.

Really, rather than writing about it here, I just want people to watch it (laughs).

The "savings" we built up before broadcast have finally run out (laughs), so every week continues to be a daily battle! The broadcast will finish the first half of the series this month. From here on, various mysteries will be revealed and the story will move forward rapidly.

The production site is getting tough, but I'm having so much fun I can't help it (laughs).

While it's a work with limited broadcast areas, you can also watch it through online distribution, so please give it a try. Of course, there will be both regular DVD and Blu-ray versions for home video!

■ Continued in Episode 73

(08.12.09)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 73: Year-End Extra Edition - What I Thought After Going to Osaka

Huh? (sweat)

Christmas is over already, isn't it? (sweat)

Which means next week is already next year, right? (sweat)

This work I'm doing color direction for now, this episode number, wasn't this supposed to be delivered by year-end? (sweat)

What's going on?? (heavy sweat)

Anyway, this is the last installment of the year, so I'm writing this manuscript, but out of 52 weeks in a year, how many manuscripts did I end up writing?

Hmm...

Anyway, next year, I really need to... not drop any manuscripts... as much as possible.

...I'll do my best (sobbing).

Now then.

Last weekend, I went to Osaka to see Oda Kazumasa's concert at Kyocera Dome.

Actually, I'm a big fan of Oda Kazumasa, and I follow his concert tours every few years, watching not only Tokyo performances but also quite a few performances outside Tokyo. I get tickets for concerts held on weekends in regional areas and use the concerts as an excuse to tour those regions - that's my pattern for domestic travel. This year alone, I went to Takamatsu, Sapporo, Hakata, and Nagoya (laughs).

So, Osaka. It's been a while since I've been to Osaka.

Every time I go to Osaka, I think "Ah, it's different from Tokyo. It's like a foreign country."

Well, of course, since they're speaking a different language, it's natural. For example, on station escalators. In Tokyo, you stand on the left and leave the right side open, but in Osaka this is reversed. It's the same not just in Osaka, but also in Kyushu and Fukuoka. Incidentally, it's the same in Seoul, Korea (laughs). Somehow it makes me think "Ah! Asia!" (laughs).

What struck me as "interesting" this time were the subway car advertisements. The so-called Tokyo-originated ads from major national companies weren't particularly

different from those in Tokyo, but what was interesting were the local corporate and regional ads. Local Osaka eyeglass stores, pachinko parlors, "debt consultation" law offices - various ads were there, and their color usage was interesting. There were tons of combinations like "there's no way you'd use this text color with this background color!" (laughs). Looking around, I could see that such color schemes actually formed a trend. Which means these are "acceptable" in Osaka, I suppose.

Starting from such observations, when I looked at the downtown areas and station crowds, the atmosphere of the city and the aura carried by the people passing by were definitely somehow different from the Tokyo where I live. This isn't limited to Osaka - it's the same in other regional cities too, though to varying degrees. But you know, places like Sapporo don't seem to have such big differences, and ah, maybe that's because my mother was born in Hokkaido?

I was born and raised in Tokyo. I'm still living in Tokyo now, but we people born and raised in Tokyo tend to have the illusion that Tokyo things are standard wherever you go in the country. We live in the country called Japan, speak roughly the same Japanese, watch the same nationally broadcast network programs on TV as Tokyo, and see the same nationwide corporate advertisements as Tokyo. But you know, everything else has surprisingly big differences.

So I thought: "How do dramas and anime made in Tokyo appear to people living outside Tokyo?" Those of us living normally in Tokyo watch Tokyo-set dramas with no sense of incongruity, just thinking "hmm, okay," but how do people in regional areas watching these feel?

For example, TV dramas set in Tokyo streets, right? And there are escalator scenes where people stand on the left and leave the right open because it's Tokyo - that's normal, right? But what do people in Osaka and Hakata think when they watch this? Does this slight difference from their daily life create a sense of incongruity when compared to their reality? Or is it just "the world inside TV"?

In anime's case, when it becomes stories about other worlds, it probably doesn't matter much, but for example, school stories and contemporary dramas often have settings in Tokyo or its suburbs. So those "little things" that we casually treat as "well, this is how it is, right?" based on Tokyo standards in our visuals - in reality, might not be that way outside Tokyo.

The

Ojamajo Doremi

(■■■■■■■■■■) series was also made with a "roughly Tokyo suburbs, maybe Kanagawa-ish?" feeling. While thinking about creating an atmosphere that viewers could easily and naturally accept, we aimed for something "relatively

standard-looking nationally," but I wonder how it appeared to all those who watched it nationwide?

Well, such were the various things I thought about vaguely while eating delicious food in Osaka (laughs).

Oh, speaking of which, back during

Doremi

, when Nagamine-kun was going to direct Ai-chan's hometown story, he actually went on "self-funded research" to Tennoji in Osaka. I remembered such things while eating kushikatsu under Tsutenkaku (laughs).

■ Continued in Episode 74

(08.12.26)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 74: Happy New Year! New Year's Greetings and This Year's Aspirations

Happy New Year.

Did everyone have "first dreams" (■■)?

The dream you have from New Year's night to the morning of the 2nd is called the first dream, apparently, and wow, I had quite a vivid one.

Amazingly, I was jogging (burst of laughter).

I was running on roads near my house, and even ran on the jogging track at a nearby park (laughs). That was my first dream.

The me in the dream looked pretty serious about it too (laughs). Ah, does this mean "Go jogging!"? Recently, my weight - or rather, my waistline - has been getting concerning.

Hmm, maybe I should put some spirit into it and start running.

First, let me get some new workout wear... Oh, and new shoes too...

Right! The first step in everything is getting the right look! (←misunderstanding)

Please look forward to this year's me! (mysterious)

Now then.

New Year's ended so quickly, didn't it (laughs).

Every year, on the 1st and 2nd, we make New Year's visits to my and my wife's respective family homes. Usually by the night of the 2nd, I get drunk at my wife's family home and end up staying over. By the 3rd, I'm already working. That's how it goes every year. I'd really like to go to a hot spring for a few nights starting around the 3rd and relax (... distant gaze).

Actually, when you're working in TV, you always have weekly deliveries, so the New Year's break always creates backlogs either before New Year's or after. Speaking of which, last New Year's I was frantic with

Hakaba Kitaro

(... distant gaze).

Well, anyway, here we are in the new year.

As for this year's aspirations, well, there are various things, but first about work.

This year, I want to do lots of TV work.

Previously, from

Neighborhood Story

(■■■■■■) to

Tomorrow's Nadja

(■■■■■■■■■■), until I was pushed out by

PreCure

(■■■■■■) (burst of laughter), I participated continuously in the Sunday morning slot TV series, and during that entire period, I was in "input mode."

"Input mode." What I mean is, new things kept flowing into me, and lots of "drawers" kept accumulating inside me. When you continue making about 50 episodes a year of one work, you get to experience that many things continuously.

You see and read lots of different materials, create lots of character colors, think about lots of different scene treatments, and meet lots of different people. Each of these things remains inside you. Then when you do something next, those "drawers" become useful. And by using those "drawers," their contents become even more substantial. That's "input mode."

Conversely, big jobs like movies are "output." You use what you've stored up inside yourself in "carry-out" fashion, fighting essentially with "sliced portions."

Certainly, there is "input" while taking on and completing big jobs too, but it doesn't reach the scale you can get from TV series, and I feel the nature is different too.

So now I definitely want to do TV work - I want lots of "input" at this stage.

I want to enjoy lots of different experiences and encounters, and I want to push myself harder (laughs). I'm full of such feelings.

Well, I don't seem to be built for really large-scale work anyway (laughs).

Related to work, this year I absolutely want to master Adobe's "After Effects," the standard visual effects software!

I resolved to buy "After Effects" about 3 years ago. Spent a lot of money on it. But apparently my resolve wasn't strong enough, because I've only learned the very basics and stopped there (laughs). I want to be able to direct myself, decide colors, create screens, and even handle photography. So this year is practical study.

For private matters - or rather, hobbies - I want to take lots of photographs.

Recently, wherever I go, I always carry a good camera and take tons of shots. Yeah, I'm in love with digital cameras. If this were film cameras, the developing and printing costs would be enormous. Plus, with the attitude of "it's okay if I fail!" I can shoot aggressively, so I can try lots of different things. That's wonderful.

After all, the foundation of image-making is lenses! Cutting screens with pleasant framing, creating different screen expressions with various lenses. This is really fun (laughs).

So I want to shoot tons of daily life and go to various places to photograph everything.

Right! I want to travel! Travel, travel, trips!

Landscapes, cityscapes, little interesting objects that catch my eye, and delicious foods. I want to take tons of different photos in various places, both domestically and overseas.

Ah, speaking of overseas, I really need to do something about my English...

...When I think about it, far from leisurely hot springs, it looks like this year will be busy for me too (laughs). If I'm doing lots of TV work, I won't be able to go on trips anyway (tears).

But well, in this short life, I want to live this year to the fullest too, yes (laughs).

So please treat me well this year too! (^_^)

■ Continued in Episode 75

(09.01.06)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 75: Once Upon a Time... (46) - My First Theatrical Feature Film Begins!

The other day, I bought a pair of jeans...

I usually wear Uniqlo's stone-washed-style ones that cost about 3000 yen, but they had gotten quite worn out. Then my wife said, "Wear something more age-appropriate!"

So I went to a jeans specialty store and bought a certain famous brand's "503" or something like that. 8500 yen (tax included). Nearly three times the price of what I used to wear. Well, whether expensive means better - it certainly is different. Though of course, there are plenty of jeans that cost twice as much as these, so I settled on these "503s" as my version of "age-appropriate."

I'm a 45-year-old with an "almost" standard Japanese body type, so naturally I need alterations - hemming the length, the leg length.

It's just heartbreakingly sad (tears). I'd like a discount for the amount they cut off (tears).

Just the other day, I saw my jeans hanging on the balcony next to my wife's jeans, and you know, mine were clearly shorter in the legs (tears). More than frustrating, it was just sad.

So this time I asked them to hem it "a bit long" with some consideration. Then apparently the store's hemming person also added some "consideration," because they're long!

I mean, they're not ridiculously long, but you know how young people wear them long? Like that. But I've never worn them long like that, and since I have short legs, the way the jeans bunch up around my ankles feels really uncomfortable.

Ah, the sadness of middle age (tears). The sadness of being a 45-year-old Japanese man (sobbing).

I'm wearing those jeans as I write this manuscript.

Now then.

Let me write a bit more about old stories.

This is about late summer 1990, while production of
Space Prince Tenjū-hen

(■■■■■ ■■■■) was continuing.

Next to Toei Animation's (■■■■■) Oizumi Studio was a shopping center called "Oz," and on its 4th floor next to a bookstore was a small cafe-like establishment. It's gone now, but back then it was often used by Toei Animation staff. I too ate there once or twice a week.

One day, when I went to that shop for lunch during break time, Director Imazawa (■■■), who directed

Space Prince Tenj■■-hen

, was having his meal there. After greeting him, I sat at a table some distance away, and after ordering, I was reading a paperback I'd brought along. Then Director Imazawa came over to sit next to me after finishing his meal.

"Actually, there's a job I'd like to ask you to do"

"Yes" - I closed my paperback and focused on Director Imazawa's words.

"We're going to do a theatrical work. I'd like to ask you to handle the colors."

"Yes!"

"Do you know

COO: From a Far Sea

?"

That was the first time I heard about the theatrical feature

Coo: Far From Home

(Coo ■■■■■■■■■■).

"

COO: From a Far Sea

" - a novel by Kageyama Tamio (■■■■■), winner of the Naoki Prize.

Marine biologist Tetsuro and his son Yosuke were living in the Fiji Islands of the South Pacific for Tetsuro's research. One day, while Yosuke was heading to school on the main island by jet ski, he encountered a baby of a mysterious creature resembling a seal washed up on the beach. He brought it home to show his father. Amazingly, it was a baby plesiosaur - a dinosaur that should have been extinct since ancient times. They began life with this baby, named "COO," but danger approached Yosuke and his father from those targeting COO...

Far from not knowing it, I was actually a huge fan of the author Kageyama Tamio and had read almost all of his works. Particularly this "

COO: From a Far Sea

" was one of my favorite books, and I properly owned the first edition.

That it was from the same Kadokawa Shoten (■■■■) as

Space Prince Tenj■■-hen

, that it was planned to be a theatrical work of over 90 minutes, that the characters would be by Okura Masahiko (■■■■), that the art director hadn't been decided yet (later decided to be Yamamoto Nizo), that production would start immediately after

Space Prince Tenj■■-hen

finished - as Director Imazawa spoke these details quietly, gently, and slowly, I was listening with tremendous internal excitement.

I myself had never done anything but minor assistance on feature theatrical works, but being able to participate as a main staff member in "movies" like

Galaxy Express 999

(■■■■) or

Space Battleship Yamato

(■■■■) was exciting just by itself, and that it was "

COO

" - I couldn't help but be excited.

"Yes! I definitely want to do it!"

I felt that Director Imazawa had evaluated my work during these two years of working hard on

Space Prince Tenj■■-hen

and was giving me this opportunity. No matter what kind of work, if you continue trying to do good work and produce results, there will always be people properly watching. I've continued to believe this and still do today, and this was one such instance.

Then, when

Space Prince Tenj■■-hen

ended, the staff room was finally set up. This was at the end of 1991.

Around that time, I had

Dragon Ball Z

theatrical work coming up (

Dragon Ball Z: Clash! 10 Billion Power Warriors

, directed by Nishio Daisuke), and I joined

COO

overlapping with the final push of that work.

My first job was creating image stills for the work. The task was to create 2-3 stills from famous scenes around the beginning of the novel for some kind of presentation.

In a studio room, first we had a meeting with just Director Imazawa, Okura-san, and myself. In front of us were key frames drawn by Okura-san - dynamic artwork showing the protagonist boy kicking up waves as he rides a water bike across the ocean.

However, what was drawn there wasn't the Japanese boy Yosuke, but a foreign boy - clearly a white boy.

■ Continued in Episode 76

(09.01.13)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 76: Once Upon a Time... (47) - White Protagonist!? The Launch of COO

As always, when it comes time to replace my computer, I agonize tremendously. It's kind of like... breaking up with a girlfriend you've been with for a long time, and the future with a new girlfriend...

"I thought we could be together forever..."

"I knew this from the beginning. No one can win against the flow of time..."

It resembles the ephemeral nature of love's end.

Ever since I started using computers for work, I've been using Mac. Windows just doesn't suit me, so it's been Mac all along. I'm using three desktop machines (Mac Pro) between home and work, and connecting them, the one I carry everywhere and use constantly is a Mac notebook computer, the PowerBook G4.

The PowerBook I'm currently using is my fourth generation. Purchased in December 2005. Actually, the keyboard and various other parts are already quite worn out, and last year I dropped it on the floor at Hong Kong airport, causing the case to warp... Even so, I've been struggling to keep using it, but with technology advancing daily and the data I handle getting bigger and bigger, the specs have finally reached their limit (tears). I decided to buy a new MacBook Pro.

If I endure and persevere, I could manage a bit longer. But I can't escape the inevitable farewell that's surely coming... You could call it lingering attachment, but my love for this "girlfriend" who's shared so much time with me is immense. The keyboard feel my fingers remember won't be forgotten immediately even when I get a new "girlfriend" (laughs).

If it were death by separation (breaking down and becoming unusable), I could give up more easily (←hey now).

I've been writing this entire series on that PowerBook, but from next time I'll probably be writing with my new "girlfriend."

Now then.

We were supposed to create advance image stills for

Coo: Far From Home

(Coo ■■■■■■■■■■■■), but I was surprised when I saw the key frames Okura-san had drawn. What was depicted there wasn't the Japanese boy Yosuke, but a

foreigner - clearly a white boy.

"Ah, this... actually there's talk of making the protagonist not Japanese, but a foreigner," said Imazawa-san.

When I asked about it, apparently this came from Kadokawa's side. Actually, this
COO

was intended for production not just for domestic Japanese release, but with North American and worldwide release in mind. For that purpose, it seemed they thought that having white parent and child as protagonists would be more acceptable in North America and globally than having Japanese parent and child.

So Yosuke had become a white boy.

Nowadays, having a Japanese protagonist would probably be totally fine, but back then there was this big barrier of language between Japan and overseas, and there were indeed such "barriers" in terms of racial visuals as well.

"Whaaaaat!? Hmm..."

Well, it wasn't incomprehensible, but as a fan of the original work, I felt somewhat unconvinced. But anyway, it was work. I created a refreshing blonde boy with clear blue eyes. And delivered it.

Around that time, production of

COO

was progressing at a relaxed pace... or rather, stagnating. There were things like the producer, director, animation director, and art director going on location scouting to the South Pacific, but in any case, without clarifying this "racial issue," they couldn't work on character settings, or even the scenario itself.

Then after a while, word came from Kadokawa.

"Please proceed according to the original work. Japanese parent and child."

And so various things finally got started. This was the beginning of my long relationship with

COO

.

■ Continued in Episode 77

(09.01.20)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 77: Once Upon a Time... (48) - First, I Bought "Lonely Planet Fiji"

The other day, I went to Seoul to meet some friends.

I occasionally meet up like this with Korean friends I used to work with. Incidentally, they're two young women (laughs). With their escort, I always get to enjoy a Seoul that's different from regular tourist travel - going to art museums, strolling through fashionable districts, eating delicious food at local restaurants.

Really though, Korea and Seoul are so close. The flight time is about 2 hours. You arrive with roughly the same sense of distance as going to Fukuoka or somewhere. And when you arrive, the scenery isn't that different from Japan. The skin color of people passing by is the same as Japanese people, and it doesn't feel that different from places like Osaka or Hakata that I visited recently. Oh yes, they stand on the right side of escalators too (laughs).

But what's definitely different are the characters overflowing on signs throughout the city. Wow, I can't read them at all > Hangul (laughs). I took the subway alone from the airport, but you know, I couldn't understand anything at all. Seoul's subway also has "serial numbers" for stations like Tokyo's, so I managed to reach my destination relying on those.

Ah! I see!

Foreigners coming to Tokyo must feel exactly the same way. I realized for the first time the importance of those subway station "serial numbers."

Now then.

Coo: Far From Home

was restarted with "protagonist = Japanese" according to the original work. The staff room we had set up was still far from being busy. The crucial scenario itself was still in progress, and various settings were barely getting started. I myself was actually busier with other works (like theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

, etc.).

In terms of color direction (color design), ultimately there's no way to work until character settings come out, so I could only wait for settings to start appearing. Even so, to be proactive, I reread the original work... well, that was about it (laughs).

Meanwhile, the director and main staff (planning producer Tamiya-san, animation director, art director) went on location scouting to Fiji and Tahiti, where the story takes place.

As expected, I wasn't taken along for color direction (tears). Too bad. According to what I heard from the director later, it was an extremely tight and demanding location scout, but even so, the beautiful ocean and coral reefs seen from above in the airplane were absolutely wonderful.

Lucky them.

Actually, at that time I had never gone overseas yet. I didn't even have a passport. I'm sure if it were now, I would have said "I'll pay my own way to go on the location scout!" (laughs).

Ah, no, I think I actually said something like that back then too... (laughs).

But anyway, in the end I wasn't taken along (actually, I couldn't go even if I wanted to because of work on Director Nishio's theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

), so I reluctantly started gathering materials about Fiji and Tahiti bit by bit.

First, visuals. When you think about gathering overseas materials, you start with bookstores. You dig through photo books and such publications. But they're expensive! Proper photo books certainly have good prices attached. So expensive you can't easily afford them. Back then, there wasn't the convenient thing called the Internet like today.

Since I wasn't taken on the location scout, I was getting impatient, but when I thought about what materials I actually needed, "...(sweat)" I didn't really understand it myself (laughs).

Then one day, I encountered a book. It was

Lonely Planet Fiji

().

The travel guidebook contained exactly the information I (probably) wanted, packed tight. The regional divisions might have changed now, but I'm sure this book contained information about the Fiji Islands and Tahiti.

As you probably know, this

Lonely Planet

series - honestly, the photos aren't that beautiful, and even when included, they're quite small. Even so, I felt I could somehow sense the local atmosphere, so I

absorbed all the information into my head.

I've never read a travel guide so thoroughly from corner to corner, before or since. How thoroughly did I read it? Well, I could accurately draw the main area map of Papeete in Tahiti without looking at anything! Even the locations of recommended Chinese restaurants were firmly in my head (laughs).

A very useful guidebook. It became the first overseas travel guidebook I ever bought in my life. However, I still haven't been able to visit the places introduced in this book.

■ Continued in Episode 77

(09.01.28)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 78: Once Upon a Time... (49) - Location Scouting!

Lately I've been approached by young people in the industry at various places saying things like "I'm reading your Anime Style series!" or "I'm watching

Casshern

!"

Oh my (sweat).

Despite how I look, I'm actually quite shy (laughs). While I can have perfectly relaxed, normal, enthusiastic, and enjoyable conversations with people I've met several times before, when young people, especially young women, approach me at studios or other places, I get quite surprised and flustered.

Just recently someone spoke to me at a certain studio, but I got so flustered that I don't think I gave proper responses...

At that time (and pretty much always), I was walking around lost in thought, completely defenseless when someone spoke to me, so I was surprised and flustered (sweat).

Since someone took the trouble to speak to me, I wish I could have given at least one witty response. Sorry about that > you at that time

Oh well...

But you know, I'm actually quite happy about it (laughs). Thank you everyone. Getting such reactions is tremendously encouraging (laughs).

So I'll do my best not to drop manuscripts...

cough cough

...as much as possible (heavy sweat).

Now then.

Coo: Far From Home

had begun, but we were in days of waiting for the scenario, then waiting for storyboards. I think at this point the planned theatrical release was summer of the following year (1993), so it was still over a year away.

One year later!

I had never worked on a production with such a long schedule until completion. It was always "No time!" or "One month until delivery!" - that kind of thing. TV series end up taking about a year, but that's making one episode per week for a year, and each individual episode was always about how to fight and win with limited time each week. It was that kind of repetition.

"

Coo: Far From Home

will take proper production time and be made using Toei's original method for theatrical features!" These were the words of Kaburaki-san, who was commanding

COO

's production at the time.

Hearing that and reflecting, the first theatrical work I was involved with at Toei Animation (■■■■■) was the legendary

Odin

, which was made by somehow finishing it with absolutely no time, and the theatrical

Fist of the North Star

(■■■■■) and

TRANSFORMERS THE MOVIE

(American co-production) that I helped with were also large in scale but created relatively quickly in a rush, and the

Saint Seiya

theatrical versions and

GeGeGe no Kitaro

that I handled as main staff were ultimately only on the production scale of extensions of "Toei Manga Festival."

Since we didn't even know about the era of

Galaxy Express 999

and such, I remember being a bit moved by the words "make it using Toei's original method for theatrical features."

So the stance was to first take proper time on storyboards and settings, and do solid foundation work.

Therefore, character design worked on character designs, art director worked on art settings - everyone was steadily advancing their basic setting work. Meanwhile, I was starting to create color samples from the character designs that came up, while fighting with that year's second

Dragon Ball Z

theatrical version, and losing my mother to cancer (tears).

"Let's go on location scouting!"

It was around the time the calendar was about to turn to July when this talk suddenly arose.

"Huh? Location scouting? The South Pacific? (hopeful)"

"Mm, Aburatsubo."

"...Ah, Aburatsubo? (sweat)"

"Cruisers and such, you really need to see proper ones once, in person. It's hard to draw storyboards without really understanding them," said Director Imazawa. The storyboard work and setting work were still in progress, but he seemed to be stuck.

Furthermore... "Dolphins and such, you really need to see proper ones once, in person. It's hard to draw storyboards without really understanding them," so considering various things together, we decided to go location scouting to Aburatsubo on the Miura Peninsula in Kanagawa Prefecture, not far from Tokyo.

Location scouting! What a fun-sounding word (laughs). I think this was my first location scouting. I'll confess - at this time, I was honestly half in field trip mode (laughs). While we were heading to Aburatsubo in two cars from Tokyo, I was just feeling "fun" for no particular reason, all floaty.

I didn't yet understand the significance of location scouting. If we just wanted to see cruisers or dolphins, each of us could have gone separately. But you know, having all the staff look at the same things while talking, exchanging opinions about settings and visuals - sharing such occasions and time is important for everyone working together to create one work.

"Ah, this is what location scouting is about"

On the deck of a large cruiser moored at Aburatsubo Marina, talking with Director Imazawa, Yamamoto Nizo-san, Okura-san and others while imagining actual scenes from the main story, I thought "I see, this is what location scouting is."

After that we moved to Aburatsubo Marine Park to observe dolphins and other marine life. There too, while watching the dolphins swim, everyone's opinions flew around. It was really nice. Location scouting really is important!

And the end of that Aburatsubo location scouting was extending our trip to Misaki Port for everyone to eat together. Misaki Port means tuna! We had delicious tuna at a restaurant run by the local fishermen's cooperative. Ending with everyone eating delicious food together - this too is an important point of location scouting (laughs).

■ Continued in Episode 79

(09.02.10)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 79: Once Upon a Time... (50) - JMSDF Yokosuka Base Destroyer Location Scouting Chronicles!

Right now I'm working on the new program

Marie & Gali

(■■■■■■■■■) starting in April (or more precisely, broadcasting from March 31st).

The script is by Yamada-san, Umakoshi-san's character design with Masuda-san's art, character colors by me - the same crew from that pilot version. The direction team will be centered on the promising young directors Tsuchida-kun, Kureta-kun, and Komaki-san, who were active in

GeGeGe no Kitaro

. The voice actors are also the same crew from the pilot version.

A 5-minute program on NHK Educational TV, and a science anime at that? It's a somewhat unusual format, but with the feeling of "if we can make something weird, we win," we're progressing enjoyably and steadily. Please look forward to it!

Now then.

Following up on the location scouting I wrote about last time, here's the story of COO

's second location scouting expedition. Six months after the "Aburatsubo location scouting" in early summer 1992, we went out on location scouting again.

"Huh? Location scouting? This time surely the South Pacific? (hopeful)"

"Mm, Yokosuka."

"...Ah, Yokosuka? (sweat)"

Actually, in the latter half of the story, a fleet of the French Navy (I think it was French?) appears in the production. If it were just the exterior appearance, we might have managed somehow with photo references, but there were scenes of Yosuke and others being confined inside the ship, with various interior ship scenes appearing.

Not a passenger ship, but a warship.

We hadn't even been on many passenger ships, let alone warships. Unlike passenger ships designed for comfortable living, warships designed for combat with all waste eliminated would be completely different, you'd think.

So...

"Warships and such, you really need to see proper ones once, in person. It's hard to draw storyboards without really understanding them," said Director Imazawa. And animation director Okura, who loves mechanical warships. The director's storyboard work was almost finished, but he seemed stuck on this warship-related section along with the settings.

Nowadays, if you search the internet, there's an incredible amount of reference photos and footage overflowing on the web, but in 1992, such convenient things weren't available yet. But you can't just say "let's go see them" because they're military secrets, so naturally they wouldn't show them to us.

However, Kadokawa Shoten (■■■■) and Toei Animation applied for coverage to the Japan Maritime Self-Defense Force public relations department, and amazingly, we were able to cover active JMSDF vessels stationed at Yokosuka Base. Wow! That's what big companies can do. Individuals could never make this happen, I'm sure.

So we main staff gathered at Keikyu Taura Station on the Keihin Kyuko line. It was a certain day in December 1992. A day of harsh cold winds... no, it was actually a relatively warm, pleasant Indian summer day.

We walked from the station to the Japan Maritime Self-Defense Force Yokosuka District Funakoshi Base. After passing through the guardhouse, we waited in a small office-like place for the public relations people. Eventually about three people in uniform arrived. Led by them, we walked along the pier to where the vessels we could tour were moored.

While slightly nervous, we were all boys at heart, already gripping our cameras tightly, unable to hide our inner excitement (laughs). As we walked, everyone was already taking tons of photos of the naval port scenery (laughs). I was fully prepared with both an SLR camera and a compact camera.

The vessel we were allowed to tour was the destroyer "Teshio." Among the Self-Defense Force's ships, it was a medium-sized vessel. We were shown the destroyer's deck, the command post on the bridge, corridors inside the ship, mess hall, officers' quarters, and so on.

As usual, we were covering with the theatrical scenes in mind. Since the performances would be inside the ship with low ceilings and many watertight bulkheads, we used assistant director Hiroshima-san as a model and carefully photographed size comparisons with ceilings, walls, chairs, and tables.

French Navy vessels referenced by Japan Maritime Self-Defense Force vessels - well, the basics of warships probably aren't that different, right? (laughs)

Since it was docked, naturally the gun barrels were properly plugged with stoppers, and the missile pods were empty. While it's a warship of exclusive defense that basically doesn't engage in combat, there was still a kind of cold tension emanating from the bridge instruments and even the deck hatches and handrails. Ah, this is the kind of thing you only get from seeing the real thing.

When you see the real thing, there are various combat ship-specific innovations in all sorts of places - it was incredibly educational. For example, even something like a mess hall table was designed so dishes wouldn't fall off during ocean swells. The hatch opening and closing mechanisms - actually touching them, operating them, each thing was moving.

Before I knew it, I had used up all six rolls of 36-exposure film I'd brought (laughs).

At the end, perhaps as "service," they spun the latest anti-aircraft gun around at high speed for us! Everyone was excited!

And that was the end of

COO

's location scouting. Now we would finally enter the main production work.

■ Continued in Episode 80

(09.02.18)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 7: Surely *Space Battleship Yamato* Was the Beginning

Due to my work, our house was piled with VHS videotapes.

Various program recordings from TV, work reference footage, even white boxes (completed video dubbed to VHS tapes for staff use). They were all necessary, but they just took up space and were bothersome. In recent years, DVD recorders appeared on the market, and our house dutifully purchased one. We converted all the VHS tapes to DVD at once. We were able to clear them out beautifully.

The other day, when I returned to my parents' house, I looked up at my room's shelves for over ten minutes.

There was a massive mountain of tapes. VHS plus 8mm video and beta tapes (laughs). And they're all treasure troves you can't easily throw away! Hmm... The road ahead is still long (bitter laugh).

Well then.

Let me take a break from collaborative work stories this time.

An even older story.

Since buying that plastic model "1/350 Space Battleship Yamato" I mentioned, I've gotten fired up about *Space Battleship Yamato* again (laughs).

I impulsively bought the first TV series DVD box set (well, I had it on laser disc), and I've been watching it obsessively lately. It's a bit of a "festival" state.

I was an elementary school student who liked anime at a normal kid level, but yes, in the fall of fifth grade, I encountered a certain anime.

That was

Space Battleship Yamato

.

Everything about it was different from the anime I'd watched before, and man, I was hooked as a kid (laughs).

Looking back, I think quite a lot of who I am today began with this encounter with Space Battleship Yamato

. Starting to read lots of manga, getting interested in SF novels, buying and building plastic models, first wanting a telescope after getting interested in astronomy - it all began when I was obsessed with

Space Battleship Yamato

around this time.

So this time, I'd like to write about *Space Battleship Yamato* from a "color" perspective, fitting for "Color Design Notes."

First, my favorite scenes (laughs).

Episode 1

- Nothing beats Captain Okita's monochrome-style color change scene. The scene where he decides to retreat in the bridge of the damaged Okita ship under attack from the Gamilas fleet. In the alert-like red-toned background, the blue-gray feeling of Captain Okita calmly trying to make decisions really got to me. The designs and colors of the Gamilas battleship and assault ship

Yukikaze (■■■■■)

that appeared in this episode are my No.1 favorites among

Space Battleship Yamato

's design groups.

Episode 2

-

Yamato

appearing after shaking off the old battleship

Yamato

's remains. The heavy colors of Yamato appearing against the dim ground surface background after sunset are great. As a child, I thought "Whoa!" at the colors and animation of the light reflection the ship body receives when firing the

Shock Cannon

(main gun).

Episode 3

- Yamato flying with the explosion smoke and flames of a super-large missile as background. This is probably cel book or harmony processing, but man, it's cool. For these "decisive!" cuts, you really want to put effort into showing them, and in

my own work, I think I want to add an extra touch to cuts like this - that became my foundation.

Episode 4

- The footlight-style reflection color changes in the strategy room explaining warp principles are cool. I still get excited by Yuki Mori's nude cut during warp (laughs).

Episode 5

- The wave cannon's high-contrast colors. "Strong light high-contrast can be just two-color painting," I think, and this might be the root of such thoughts.

Episodes 7 & 8

- The light from Pluto's reflection satellite cannon and its reflection colors are nice. Yamato's main gun is green while Gamilas light weapons are pink-based. I really understood the necessity of this distinction after I started working. The processing of Pluto's indigenous life forms, probably cel doubling processing, has a blue-black transparency that feels like a planet far from the sun.

Episode 10

-

Dr. Sado's beloved cat Mii-kun

appearing in the final communication with Earth. I was really drawn to this very Matsumoto

-style cat. Maybe this is the root of my cat-loving.

Episode 11

- Actually, from this episode,

Gamilas people's skin becomes blue.

Even the main character

Desler

has his skin and hair colors boldly changed! In previous episodes, they were the same as Earth people. This was probably to make them more alien-like and distinguish them from Earth people, but as a child I really thought "I wish it had been like that from Episode 1." Still, this major change mid-series was quite a bold decision, I think. We also make minor adjustments and minor changes in our own work, but we're too scared to do such bold full model changes (bitter laugh).

Episode 16

- The story where

Yuki Mori

and

Analyzer

are captured by

Beemera

people while investigating to gather vegetables. This episode uses special coloring throughout, but especially the color change of Analyzer standing alone against the burning Beemera planet city background is impressive. With overall dark shadow-like colors and only the instruments appearing to glow, that figure is full of melancholy, and Analyzer's sadness comes through in the colors.

Episode 25

-

Starsha

's hair is color trace finishing, right... or so I thought, but looking closely this time, ah, Starsha's eyes and face contours and other skin main lines themselves are basically color trace? Or brown carbon trace processing! This kind of processing takes a lot of effort! But thanks to this processing, she becomes a somehow mystical character. Probably because Starsha appeared in few episodes, they could manage such time-consuming processing.

Episode 26

- The final episode begins immediately without the usual opening, making me keenly feel "Ah, it's the final episode!" - that memory remains vividly today. Having the opening or ending spill into the main episode gives a real "special episode" feeling. I experienced this as a creator with

Ojamajo Doremi

and

Gaiking

endings, but this is quite troublesome in various ways - money (production costs) issues, problems with stations and agencies (laughs).

When I watch this *Yamato* after starting animation finishing work, I can't help noticing finishing retake cuts.

Back then it was cel finishing, and probably there wasn't enough time to process retakes.

In space and other dark backgrounds, cel scratches, dust, and dirt inevitably stand out,

and countless cuts with surface painting for color error corrections and color mismatches are visible. Well, that probably also became part of

Yamato

's "flavor."

About Space Battleship Yamato itself's colors.

Actually, the colors in the three theatrical versions produced by Toei Doga -

Farewell Space Battleship Yamato: Warriors of Love

,

Yamato Forever

,

Space Battleship Yamato: Final Chapter

- are different from this first TV series. Both are grayish colors, but the TV series Yamato has heavy, low-saturation, subdued gray-tone coloring. The Toei Doga-produced

Space Battleship Yamato

is overall blue-tinted gray. What circumstances led to this? I really don't know the truth, but I think one factor might be differences in paint manufacturers used.

The *Space Battleship Yamato* TV series was made with

Taiyo Shikisai (■■■■■)

company paints.

Meanwhile, Toei Doga was using

Stack

company paints by this time. These two major paint manufacturers' colors actually have no compatibility. Against Taiyo Shikisai's many colors with overall low-saturation matte tones, Stack colors had overall vivid tones with fewer colors. If you painted the TV

Yamato

's colors with the closest atmospheric Stack colors, that probably became the theatrical version's blue-tinted Yamato. That's what I think.

In the booklet included with this DVD box set, the original coloring settings from that time were published as reference material.

So for the first time, I learned the original

Yamato

color direction and paint numbers. The basic ship body was

Z-4

, the ship bottom and smokestack red parts' basic was

Zm-1

. From the paint numbering system, I think these were probably colors created specifically for

Yamato

. Man, I was moved! In plastic model paint terms, that's "Japanese Navy warship color" and "ship bottom color" (laughs). After all,

Yamato

is imprinted with these colors in my mind, so I just can't like Toei Doga's "blue-tinted Yamato."

After the so-called *Space Battleship Yamato* boom, the three Toei Doga theatrical versions I mentioned earlier were made, and TV series *2* and *3* were also made,

but for me,

Space Battleship Yamato

means the first TV series. There was a time when I thought "If new ones are made again, I want to participate too!" but now I want to cherish it as just one fan.

##

■Continues to Episode 8

(07.02.20)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 80: DVD & Blu-Ray Release Commemorative!

Casshern Sins

Color Design Notes (Part 1)

The TV broadcast of

GeGeGe no Kitaro

(5th series) will end at the end of March. The final episode will be exactly episode 100.

100 episodes.

I remembered the producer saying that the

GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!

that I was involved in making last year would "connect to an episode around the 100th episode of the series." What will they do with the remaining "47 Yokai Warriors" (sweat)? Hmm... Though it's not my concern, it's somewhat bothering me these days.

Now then.

Casshern Sins

(■■■■■■■■Sins), currently airing magnificently in late-night slots on MBS and other stations - its DVD & Blu-Ray release has finally begun. For this work where I participated as color design (■■■■■), "Everyone please buy them! Especially the Blu-Ray versions!" So for the next four weeks, I'll be delivering "

Casshern Sins

Color Design Notes"!

First this week, episodes 1-6 included in BOX 1.

I joined

Casshern Sins

in late summer 2007. Actually, at that point the production site was working toward "broadcast start April 2008!" Just six months later, aiming for broadcast start, there was talk of "somehow getting 4-5 episodes in stock."

However, the situation changed. Before we knew it, the "April 2008" broadcast start disappeared and became "Autumn 2008!"

"Well, somehow we'll get 12-13 episodes in stock..." I often discussed this with the production producer, but... it's not so easy to build up stock in today's TV anime production situation. As much time as you have, you end up using it all until the last minute - that's the way of the world (laughs). Ha ha ha (laughs).

So ultimately, it ended up being a last-minute start after all (laughs).

Between Director Yamauchi (■■■■) and me, from some point it had become an implicit understanding, our normal way of working, that "everything would be decided scene by scene with art board matching."

Casshern Sins

uses this method too.

Well, for various convenience reasons (like animation reference and promotional materials), I made basic normal character color samples and color direction, but those were just samples - they would almost never appear as-is on the actual screens.

I attend art board commission meetings with the art staff and listen to the director explain the scene atmosphere. Then I receive the art boards completed by the art staff and approved by the director, and matching those boards, I compose character color schemes while imagining the performance flow. Then I have the episode director check those color samples + art board combinations and get approval, using that as a "blueprint" to request individual cuts from the color direction staff assigned to each episode.

That's the flow for individual episodes. Furthermore, I think about the color composition, flow, and balance throughout the entire series. How to construct the character color world throughout all 24 episodes - I consider this an important job in series color design.

When entering episode 1, scripts for quite a few episodes were ready except for the latter half to climax, so I could grasp the overall picture and enter design after thinking about the composition myself.

Episode 1: "In a World Coming to an End"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu /
Animation Director: Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Color Direction: Kunioto Kunio

In episode 1, the story begins with absolutely no explanation. Casshern fights furiously, then a mysterious little girl appears and they interact, he saves her from crisis, and finally an even more mysterious woman appears and picks a fight with Casshern. Such is episode 1 (laughs).

I thought if we could somehow show "this kind of world" feeling in about the first 3 episodes, that would be good. So in episode 1, I just worked steadily on creating screens matched to backgrounds.

This is what kind of visual and what kind of taste this work has. It's fine if viewers end up feeling "what? what?" after watching. That's episode 1.

Being episode 1 above all, both art and color were initially working by feel. Working with atmosphere emphasis, it ended up with a nice heavy finish, but...

Actually this work has "bleeding" processing added via photography work throughout. This is tricky (laughs). When photography "bleeding" is applied to the screen, overall contrast becomes stronger. Especially dark parts are emphasized, creating dramatically dark screens.

Background and cel matching was decided based on HD master monitor standards, so in the "raw" state it had quite a finished, settled balance. When "bleeding" was applied on top of that, watching the all-rush, everyone said "Oh no... dark, or rather black (sweat)."

We certainly couldn't remake it (←didn't want to (laughs)), so we pushed through saying "Well, it'll be fine! Surely... probably (sweat)" (burst).

So the first half of episode 1 ended up with the darkest screen throughout the series (laughs).

However, from the latter half when the large robot appears, we're using "normal" color direction. Since it was episode 1, I somehow wanted to end episode 1 with "normal" color tone. The backgrounds happened to be bright scenes too, so they're raw normal colors.

Episode 2: "The World is Full of Doomsday Voices"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu /
Animation Director: Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Color Direction: Kunioto Kunio

Episode 2 explains "Actually this world has been hit by something called 'ruin.'" In episode 2, I'm doing something like a miniature, compressed version of the overall color design composition for the entire

Casshern Sins

series.

Basically, the first half does scene-by-scene decisions matched to backgrounds, the middle creates scenes with special color usage matched to what the characters are talking about, and the latter half adds mysterious color tones to character shadow colors riding on the characters' emotional ups and downs. This flow is actually what I was trying to do throughout the entire series.

Episode 2's climax, where Casshern massacres the community's civilian robots in madness mode, and the buildup of cuts and color tones leading to that point - I'm quite proud of how well that turned out! (laughs)

The special coloring used in this madness mode, adding mysterious colors to shadow colors, I mostly sealed away until the latter half of the series, especially until Luna appears.

Episodes 1 and 2 anyway were made using plenty of time. Naturally the animation frame count also reached wonderful heights (laughs). The quality is supreme. But the production producer's face was blue (laughs).

Episode 3: "At the End of Suffering"

Script: Yamato-ya Akira / Storyboard & Direction: Minatsu Tatsuya / Animation Director: Nishii Terumi / Color Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Episode 3: "Actually, humans are still barely surviving too."

Casshern still can't grasp the situation well. Moreover, guilt from "doing something terrible (sweat)" in the previous episode weighs on him. Then comes a certain reconciliation or understanding with Friender.

Series composition that doesn't follow the main plot too much but sprinkles episodic complete stories - but this is important, building up the characters' emotional movements and flow through such stories.

Episode 3 doesn't do anything particularly special color-wise, just working carefully and steadily to create the distance, atmosphere, and feeling between Casshern and Akoz.

Episode 3's color direction was by Akimoto Yuki-san. She and Kohinata Tomoko-san, who appears from episode 5 onward, are two people we always rely on for Toei (■■■) productions. Since I could sync up with these two, I asked their company president "Please!" and had them participate.

As a result, they each handled color direction for 1/3 of all 24 episodes, and two endings completely from color design, respectively. My gratitude! So grateful!

Episode 4: "Angel of Destruction"

Script: Takahashi Natsuko / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Animation Director: Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Color Direction: Kunioto Kunio

Somehow a flow developed where "episodes directed by the director have Tsujita-san also handle color direction," so I also handled color direction for episode 4.

Episode 4 is also a "this is the world Casshern exists in" type story. For this story, I created scene colors with "beauty" as the theme.

In

Casshern Sins

, I basically design character colors from scratch with nothing to start from. While Casshern, Friender, and Braiking Boss are based on the "original work" colors, everything else was my original... Though I haven't actually watched the "original work" (laughs). The flow was: receive character line art from Umakoshi-san → I create colors first → show to director and Umakoshi-san and get approval.

For this story's guest character Sophita, from when I first received the character design, I had somehow decided on "brown skin." I wonder why? I heard later that the director apparently had a somewhat "pale" image.

I was surprised when I heard Sophita's voice in the all-rush. It was Akitani Tomoko-san, the voice of Hazuki-chan from

Ojamajo Doremi

(■■■■■■■■■■). And the brown-skinned Sophita was just perfect for that voice! This must also be Yamauchi magic (laughs).

Just when episode 4's production peak coincided with the final push of

Dragon Ball Z

production for Shueisha Jump Tours, I was fighting a 24-hour system - Toei (■■■) during the day, Madhouse (■■■■■■■■) at night, no time to sleep. On top of that, the

Casshern Sins

opening overlapped... Ah, good memories (distant gaze).

Oh yes, the animation rule that "bangs don't show through in

Casshern Sins

!" was established starting from this episode. Until then it was all over the place - sometimes transparent, sometimes not. Actually there are several cuts in this episode we couldn't fix completely (laughs).

Episode 5: "The Man Who Killed the Sun Named Moon"

Script: Kamishiro Tsutomu / Storyboard: Ohira Naoki / Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Animation Director: Okuda Yoshiko / Color Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

"Stalker Ryuze" and Casshern constantly worrying. The 'Luna murder' avant-title that appears for several cuts at the beginning of each main episode, connected

flashback scenes of Lyuze and Casshern appear, revealing why Ryuze is pursuing Casshern. And finally "Black Casshern" Dio appears. The story that finally starts moving toward the main plot... maybe? Episode 5.

This story also had color design steadily matched scene by scene. Episode 5 had the fewest scene color changes of any episode.

The "Luna murder" scene shown in the avant-title was created with red-purple as the image color, but what about the area before that, where she confronts Lyuze? After much thought, I made it "normally" darkish, but hmm, maybe I should have added one more touch?

Episodes 5 and 6 are connected stories. And this following episode 6 was actually made almost parallel with episode 1 schedule-wise. So I asked Kohinata-san, who handled episode 6's color direction, to also do episode 5 later. Actually, the evening scene in the B-part uses exactly what was created for episode 6.

Episode 6: "Reunion With Destiny"

Script: Kamishiro Tsutomu / Storyboard & Direction: Ito Naoyuki / Animation Director: Okuda Yoshiko / Color Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

So episode 6, made almost parallel with episode 1. Naturally, the screen is dark (laughs). But since it's almost all evening throughout, the bright parts look quite bright.

Also, the bangs are totally transparent (laughs). This was also because it was animation from before the rule was established.

The key point of episode 6 is definitely Dio. This Dio was quite a difficult "troublemaker."

Because Dio basically has a "black" bodysuit. A black suit with bright highlight-like parts - that kind of design. However, that area was unorganized when animation progressed, and I overthought it and made him too "black." Maybe I should have made him a bit brighter, calling in the evening light around him to reflect back? > Dio

However, in terms of the balance of mysteriousness, this level of darkness was totally OK for me. I thought it was fine if the dark parts got crushed, and since the master was made based on digital terrestrial and HD screens, it looked properly visible on the master monitor so it was good! But the world was still mainly analog viewing, so voices came from various directions saying "It's too dark to see!" (laughs).

So there was that, and from the point of the overall "flow" of the series and color design composition, episodes after this gradually have more bright screens.

Even so, I earnestly think I want people to watch on digital terrestrial rather than analog terrestrial broadcast, and on Blu-Ray rather than regular DVD (laughs).

■ Continued in Episode 81

(09.02.24)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 81: DVD & Blu-Ray Release Commemorative!

Casshern Sins

Color Design Notes (Part 2)

The other day, when I casually turned on the TV, there was a program about 50 years of news history for Fuji TV's 50th anniversary. In it, footage of the tsunami disaster at Okushiri Island was shown, and among the debris left after the tsunami receded, there was a family's photo album that had been destroyed and was all messed up.

A family album.

Beyond the loss of life, I thought it would be painful to lose memories with family. While houses and belongings can somehow be managed, once you lose an album filled with family memories, it never comes back.

And then I suddenly thought: ah, we don't have albums at our house.

Our household has gone all digital photography now, and while the photos are stored on everyone's computer hard drives, we don't bother printing them out and putting them together in albums.

Really, photos should be made into albums you can hold in your hands and look at.

Work is also becoming increasingly digital with paperless progress. That's better for work, but I think memories should still be something you can hold in your hands.

Well, if we had children, we probably would have taken lots of photos (nowadays it would be video?) and made lots of "growth albums."

Ah, come to think of it, we barely have any photos of the two of us together...

This is something I really need to think about in the future...

Now then.

Have you purchased them, everyone?

Casshern Sins

DVD & Blu-Ray. This week I'm delivering part 2 of "

Casshern Sins

Color Design Notes."

Episode 7: "The Woman in the High Tower"

Script: Yoshida Reiko / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Animation Director: Tominaga Mari / Color Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

This episode 7 was actually made as episode 8 in production. Originally there was one episode before this, production episode 7, but due to various circumstances it was moved to the back as production episode 18 (broadcast episode 17). So from here on, production episode numbers and broadcast episode numbers were misaligned. We on the production side naturally talked in terms of production episode numbers, so when someone occasionally talked in broadcast episode numbers, it got confusing (laughs).

So broadcast episode 7. This is also a complete story in one episode. Lyzbel, alone in some factory, making bells. She mysteriously entices the visiting Casshern, plotting to use him as material for the bells she creates.

This story also progresses quietly, but Lyzbel being nicely "sick" and somewhat mysteriously sensual - I remember getting a bit excited reading the storyboard (laughs).

In

Casshern Sins

, we do things throughout not just reflecting spatial colors, but expressing the characters' emotional movements and states by adding strange colors to the characters themselves, and we intentionally do this in several places in episode 7. Like the scene where Lyzbel snuggles up to Casshern at the top of the tower.

The scene near the end of the first half where she tries to put Casshern to sleep was directed by assistant director Nakayama-san, and the mysterious green lamp coloring came from Nakayama-san's image.

Casshern Sins

tends to have a lot of purple-based special coloring (←the director's preference), but ah, green tones work well too! It turned out to be a good scene.

For me, the robots playing cards at the beginning and those cards are my favorite parts (laughs).

Episode 8: "A Hymn of Hope"

Script: Yamato-ya Akira / Storyboard: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Direction & Animation Director: Ito Tatsufumi / Color Direction: Akimoto Yuki

The episode where songstress Janis appears. This episode also builds up colors scene by scene steadily.

The Janis I first conceived had light brown hair, but with "she's a strong woman, right?" (director), we arrived at red hair to bring out her inner strength. Ah, that overlaps with Lyuze (laughs).

The climax is still spectacular - Janis's singing scene and Casshern's big battle set to her singing voice. Perhaps due to coincidence, from episode 8 onward, episodes with Akimoto-san as color direction tend to have "tight schedules + intense battles"...

Actually, the battle scene outside this music hall - both the robots and backgrounds had colors that were a bit too deep, and when we filmed it, it became too dark and you couldn't tell what was what. So we had the photography department adjust the screen brightness.

Episode 9: "Flowers Blooming in the Valley of Death"

Script: Kamishiro Tsutomu / Storyboard & Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Animation Director: Aoki Tetsuro / Color Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

In this story, rumors are heard that Luna might be alive, and Casshern's group's travel purpose is determined for now. It's a very touching story about Niko and Bolton.

Right around episodes 7-11, I was in the thick of

GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie

, and partly because of that, I left Niko and the doll's color settings half-finished (sweat). I got the director's approval at quite the last minute.

For episode 9, I deliberately reduced scene-by-scene color changes and made it a structure that carefully follows the performances of Niko, the apple, and Bolton.

In return, the finishing was tough with all the flowers (laughs). The flower fields, petals, and flower decorations worn on heads were quite challenging apparently, and quite a few cuts had to be redone in finishing inspection. During rush checking, color direction Kohinata-san watched the cut where Bolton tears off and throws away the flower decorations and said "...after all that hard work (tears)" and was crying (laughs).

From this episode, Matsumoto Kenji-san joined the art staff. Matsumoto-san's uniquely deep artistic style really hit the spot with Niko's poignancy.

Episode 10: "A Man Imprisoned by the Past"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard: Ito Naoyuki / Animation Director: Hayama Jun'ichi / Color Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Setting aside Casshern and the others for a bit, this is Dio and Leda's story. With Leda pulling strings in the background, the "Dio Corps" is launched. And Down makes his appearance.

I was thinking I'd decide on this "tattered Down" together with the "cool Down" setting that appears in flashback scenes. But the "cool Down" setting came up after key animation work had already progressed (animation proceeded with rough settings). So I left the colors undecided until quite the last minute (sorry (sweat)).

And that "tattered Down" - in the character setting that was first submitted and approved, he was a clean-faced character, but when it came time to decide colors, painting according to the settings and creating the color scheme gave an "hmm, something's lacking" impression. Apparently Umakoshi-san thought so too: "Would it be bad to add some color divisions?" So it became an urgent setting revision, resulting in that kabuki-style? wrestler-style? kumadori color-divided face.

Meanwhile, the "cool Down" appearing in flashback scenes is a solidly built handsome man (laughs). Being Luna's guardian, I tried matching the color scheme of his clothing with Lyuze's. This episode also avoided extreme color changes and kept to natural colors matched to the background art. However, what the director told me later was about the Luna and Down flashback scene.

Actually, I had made this scene to look normal colored like other scenes, but the director said "Let's use colors to give meaning that flashback scenes are flashback scenes." "If we're making normal scenes look ordinary, we should give some variation to flashback scenes."

Episode 11: "Under His Own Mission"

Script: Kamishiro Tsutomu / Storyboard: Sendo-ji Takuma / Direction: Hatano Kohei / Animation Director: Hayama Kenji / Color Direction: Nakano Tomoaki

Episode 11 was produced by Tatsunoko Production (■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■). The first outsourced production episode of the

Casshern Sins

series. From direction to animation to photography, all handled by Tatsunoko Production.

I had worked with director Hatano since

Hakaba Kitaro

(■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■). However, he apparently didn't know I was doing color design until the color direction meeting, so when I walked into the meeting room, as soon as he saw my face he shouted "Whaaaat!? No way?" (laughs).

This episode is also a "this is the world Casshern exists in" type story. Casshern trapped in crystal and Friender trying bravely to save him encounter a group of humans and robots traveling in search of Luna's location. Friender opens his heart to their leader, Jin.

On his 10th appearance, the dog who's already often forgotten (burst) plays a big role.

Every time I make scene-by-scene color direction, I tend to forget to make Friender (laughs). But this time I certainly didn't forget (or rather, I started with Friender).

This story also used almost no special coloring. I made it naturally matched to the background art.

In the latter half, there's a scene where companions pressure Jin to "kill Casshern." It's a rather heavy, tense scene, but Jin persuades everyone against it. From the cut where Jin declares "I won't kill Casshern" (right around when the insert song starts playing), I changed from the low-saturation color direction used until then to normal color direction. From this point where the atmosphere of the situation changes, I wanted to restore "brightness" and "vitality" to the character colors.

You probably can't tell unless you watch really carefully, but I tried to create the screen atmosphere including such small details.

Episode 12: "Coloring the Time I Lived"

Script: Takahashi Natsuko / Storyboard & Direction: Minatsu Tatsuya / Animation Director: Nishii Terumi / Color Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Exactly halfway through all 24 episodes, the turning point episode.

A poignant, beautiful story about Margo, a man (robot) trying to repaint his town silver as proof of his existence.

The Margo drawn in the storyboard seemed like some old guy character, but the setting that came up from Umakoshi-san was a character that looked like "a girl?" at first glance. So I made the character's color image "French artist" - white skin like a Caucasian + clear blue eyes. Incidentally, if it had been the old guy Margo from the storyboard, the image would have been a rather rough-haired red-haired Dutch artist.

"Silver" is quite difficult. One step wrong and it just looks like gray, and if you push it too far it becomes white solid color. And then snow piles on top of that...

Applause to the art staff who exquisitely distinguished such "silver."

Actually, this episode hit quite a spot for me personally. I suddenly thought "maybe I'm the same as Margo."

The episodic complete stories mostly ended with episode 12. Finally, in the latter half, the story would head toward the main plot.

■ Continued in Episode 82

(09.03.05)

Color Design Notes [Tsuji Kunitada]

Episode 82: DVD & Blu-Ray Release Commemorative!

Casshern Sins

Color Design Notes (Part 3)

The WBC (World Baseball Classic) is really exciting! I'm also a huge baseball fan, so I can't help but be tremendously concerned about how the games turn out. Sports really should be enjoyed via live broadcast. Just knowing the results afterward is somehow unbearable for me.

But unfortunately, the preliminary game times coincided with travel between studios, or working in environments without TV or radio. Meetings can't be helped, but during travel and such, couldn't something be done? Following game progress on mobile phone news sites is also not quite right...

So I deployed it! A transistor radio!

I put a tiny AM radio in my pocket and listened to broadcasts through earphones while traveling. Well, this was quite something! I'm totally in love with radio now.

But visually, I definitely give off that unmistakable old guy vibe... (laughs).

Oh yes, I tried watching the TV broadcast on one-seg while listening to audio on radio, but one-seg arrives with incredible delay, doesn't it? Like, one play behind, one pitch behind.

"I see! People listening to radio are getting 'early access' compared to those watching on one-seg!"

I feel a bit superior somehow (laughs).

Now then.

Before entering the second half, today I'll delve into the mysteries of the opening and two endings.

First, the ending stories.

Ending 1 (Song: KANA "reason")

Storyboard & Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Key Animation: Okuda Yoshiko / Art: Kajiyama Nariyo / Color Design & Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

Ending 2 (Song: Kuno Shinji "Light and Shadow")

Storyboard & Direction: Nakayama Naomi / Key Animation: Tominaga Mari / Art: Gyoshin Mitsu / Color Design & Direction: Akimoto Yuki

I had heard from early on that the ending songs would change between first and second halves, so I decided from the beginning to have Kohinata-san and Akimoto-san, the two main color direction staff, each handle everything for their respective endings.

So basically I was hands-off on the endings. I had them each meet with their respective directors and proceed however they wanted. I just waited excitedly for the finished products (laughs). So I don't have much to say about the endings from my perspective.

We originally planned for 12 episodes each for broadcast, but due to certain promotional relationships and main episode circumstances, the second one ended up with fewer broadcasts.

In the first ending, the "glass pendant" appears. That's the one Ringo gave to Lyuze in the main episode. I hadn't thought deeply about it, but the main episode with the pendant ended up being Kohinata-san's assigned episode by good coincidence (laughs).

In the second ending, Friender isn't on screen. So I asked director Nakayama-san: "Hey, where's Friender?"

"Ah! (heavy sweat)"

"...C-can I interpret this as an ending from Friender's perspective?"

"...Y-yes. That's right!"

...Apparently that's what it is.

And now, the opening story.

Opening (Song: Color Bottle "Blue Flower")

Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Key Animation: Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Art: Kono Rei / Color Direction & Coloring: Kunioto Kunio

"Right, we need to make an opening," said the director. Late summer last year, when the broadcast start was becoming somewhat visible. But after that, I hadn't really pursued the opening topic much. Because I myself was too busy with the final push for Jump Tours'

Dragon Ball Z

and the theatrical

New Savior Legend Fist of the North Star: Kenshiro's Story

, so I was trying not to touch on that topic (laughs).

Then one evening, a call from production: "We're having an opening meeting."

Due to the art staff's schedule, the meeting was set for 1 AM. I was pretty exhausted, but I chugged coffee and attended the meeting.

"Basically, I want to show everyone as still images."

The idea was that since the main episodes moved incredibly densely, the opening should be solidly composed of accumulated still images. Of course, the animation would be by Umakoshi Yoshihiko. We'd mix in some cuts with movement as accents, but basically everything would be single drawings of Umakoshi's bold-lined animation.

"The problem is finding a method that properly utilizes these animation lines," said the director.

"Ah..." said I.

"Can't we make it like a poster?"

I think the greatest charm of Umakoshi's animation is the "rough feel" of those lines. I love the power of the lines he draws, and when he draws posters or stills, I try to utilize the "rough feel" of the lines, their textured quality.

You know, in old animation made with cels, the roughness of pencil lines would appear directly on the cels through carbon tracing, right? I wanted to somehow achieve that atmosphere, so I would deliberately roughly binarize the line art and reproduce somewhat rough, coarse, violent-feeling lines without too much line correction.

So, well, ultimately I ended up painting everything myself (laughs).

"For the moving parts, it doesn't need to be so precise."

Since my workload looked a bit tough, we had the finishing company handle coloring orders for cuts with movement, but I would paint everything else.

The meeting with the art staff centered on the color direction for each cut. Like "up to this cut, make it bluish. From the next one, BAM! BAM! BAM! to orange." The background drawing style referenced the main episode art boards to some extent, then the director said "I leave the rest to you (laughs)."

So from the next day, I was doing coloring work all night long.

While the size was small, it was like painting licensed stills in a way, and since I'm not really doing heavy coloring work normally, my hands are slow (laughs).

There's specialized software called PaintMan for digital coloring, and normally everyone does main episode coloring with PaintMan, but I can't quite master PaintMan (laughs). So I painted using Photoshop. I always use Photoshop for posters and magazine stills.

And the battle with lines. Painting each section divided by rough lines properly would be incredibly difficult and deadly (laughs), so I separated the line parts into layers and placed them overlaid on top, saving that, then used the "eraser" tool on the original drawing underneath to boldly erase and paint over the lines themselves. This way I could paint quickly instead of fussily, and the lines themselves were saved in layers so it was fine. After finishing painting, I'd merge with the line layer above to complete it.

The flow of cut colors is more important in openings than in main episodes. Based on the color flow decided in the meeting, I decided colors cut by cut, matching the musical tone and the art style. For example, riding the song's crescendo, gradually making colors stronger in a building fashion, or gently changing colors through overlap within a single cut.

That's how the opening was made. Unfortunately there wasn't enough time, so for the first several episodes the title cut "blue flower" ended up as a still image, but otherwise maybe I just fine-tuned the eye cut colors?

Such was the opening. I've done openings for various works, but this

Casshern Sins

opening is quite a favorite of mine.

■ Continued in Episode 83

(09.03.10)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 83: DVD & Blu-Ray Release Commemorative!

Casshern Sins

Color Design Notes (Part 4)

I somehow managed to complete

Casshern Sins

last Friday. Looking back on about a year and a half, it feels like it was over in a flash once finished... With that sense of accomplishment mixed with the physical damage from almost three straight days and nights of all-nighters during the final push, I've been rather "spacey" since last weekend.

Ah, I need to rejoin society soon or the next job will...

Even while saying this, I'm in full WBC (World Baseball Classic) festival mode (laughs).

The Japan vs Cuba game that started early morning on the 16th (Japan time) in the San Diego round - I finished my tax filing all-nighter and watched the TV at home with that momentum. Wow, Japan's complete victory! Wonderful! Boom! Boom! Boom! Whoosh!

brass band sounds

(←apparently whistles and drums)

While watching the broadcast, the stadium stands where they were playing were totally empty. Huh? If I went there, could I maybe watch the game?

"Should I just go now? To San Diego. Wouldn't I make it in time for Japan's next game?"

The thought crossed my mind for a moment, but ah, work...

Anyway, until the WBC ends, I'm a useless person (laughs) > To all concerned parties

Now then.

Casshern Sins

Color Design Notes - this week covers episodes 13-18 of the main story. Ah, it became 5 installments total for this series. According to the original plan, this time would go all the way to the final episode. But then, depending on the region, the final episode hasn't aired yet... So I did the OP & ED edition last time, making it 5

installments total.

So please bear with me a little longer.

Episode 13: "The Past Fills Before My Eyes"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard & Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Animation
Director: Okuda Yoshiko / Color Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

The first episode of the second half was the last broadcast of the year. Braiking Boss casually appears and, surprisingly, immediately spills various plot details to Casshern and the others before leaving. The remaining characters are all stunned! This sudden development combined with the long gap until the next broadcast over New Year's really kept viewers who had been watching the original broadcast on edge.

The key point for this episode's color creation was the cave interior scenes. Since Casshern Sins

screens tend to become dark easily, I had been consciously creating brighter colors for the past several episodes, but in episode 13 I wanted the cave's darkness, especially around the campfire where Braiking Boss speaks, to be dark. That's what creates atmosphere. So I created it darker with the mindset of "it's okay if it gets crushed, if it's not visible!"

When we color designers work on character color design, we dim or block the lighting around our monitors to make the environment dark so we can see the monitor's color output correctly. Especially when creating colors for dark scenes, it needs to be dark. In bright ambient light situations, the monitor - or rather, your eyes - get overwhelmed by the surrounding brightness and you can't see the deep color portions.

Since we create screens this way, when viewing, if you turn off the lighting around the TV and watch in a dark environment, you can actually see the colors within the dark areas to some degree. While "when watching TV, keep the room bright..." often plays during TV broadcasts, for

Casshern Sins

that's forbidden (laughs).

Oh yes, episode 13 had an irregular ending change just for this episode. "Blue Shadow" (■■■■), which was used as an insert song in the episode, was part of the CD sales promotion. Come to think of it, around this time Sera-san was passionately talking about

Casshern

on TV quite a bit.

This song was apparently one Sera-san put his heart into creating... but just between us, as my personal opinion, it didn't really fit the atmosphere of

Casshern Sins

. It was probably created from the image of the original

Casshern

. The guitar just doesn't suit

Casshern Sins

(laughs). ...Ah, that was unnecessary commentary (laughs).

Episode 14: "Truth Illuminates the Darkness"

Script: Kamishiro Tsutomu / Storyboard: Miyashita Shinpei / Direction: Ito Tatsufumi / Animation Director: Ito Tatsufumi / Color Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Groups of ordinary robots and humans heading toward Luna's city seeking Luna's healing, and Dio's army also moving in search of Luna. Meanwhile, Casshern has recovered part of his memory and is troubled again. But he resolves to fight to protect small children, and has a rematch with Dio.

This was newlywed Ito-san's direction and animation director episode. Until the very last minute of the animation director crunch, the couple (!) were pulling all-nighters in the staff room. Actually, around this time the animation schedule was starting to get suspicious...

From around these episodes, crowds appear frequently, but I left the work mostly to the color direction staff. The crowd colors created a nice atmosphere. I had the color direction staff create samples by creating the atmosphere with main episode cuts and rough coloring, then checked those. Almost all were approved in one go. They understood the color world of

Casshern Sins

perfectly - wonderful.

Episode 15: "Death God Down"

Script: Takahashi Natsuko / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Animation Director: Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Color Direction: Kunioto Kunio

Down, who was Luna's guardian, reappears. The battle between Casshern and Down.

And this was our final battle of 2008 too. With the year-end/New Year schedule, December had an incredible 5 episode delivery schedule. Particularly, episode 14 was due on the 23rd and this episode 15 was due on the 29th at year-end, and well, we didn't finish (burst), ultimately crossing into the new year (laughs). On New Year's Eve morning after an all-nighter, I gazed vacantly at the sunrise from the staff room.

Episode 15's art was by Yuki Yukie-san.

She had been away from animation production sites for a while, but responded to Director Yamauchi's passionate request and took up the brush again after quite some time. Probably since

Tomorrow's Nadja

? Not only the art boards, but almost all the actual backgrounds were drawn by Yukie-san.

Yukie-san's backgrounds aren't digital backgrounds drawn on computer, but actually painted with paints on watercolor paper. These were scanned and digitized by a scanning company. Yukie-san's unique watercolor bleeding quality worked incredibly well with the photography processing bleeding, and the subtle color mixing in the sky (clouds) and the blue of the glass tile backgrounds were particularly beautiful - the feeling of colors gently emerging on screen was exquisite.

The animation was supervised by Umakoshi too, the art was wonderful, and though it was continuous all-nighter work, I was somehow very happy and grinning throughout.

The New Year's card that arrived later from Yukie-san had one comment: "My first anime in 4 years was tough (laughs)." But she seemed to enjoy it (laughs).

Episode 16: "For the Power to Believe"

Script: Yamada Takashi / Storyboard & Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Animation Director: Yamamuro Naoyoshi, Watanabe Natsuki / Color Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

Episode 16 hit peak animation work right across the year-end/New Year period.

The storyboard had already taken quite a bit of time, and then during year-end/New Year, animation just wouldn't come up. So it was essentially color direction from New Year onward. The original broadcast was the third week of January. So really, we powered through by sheer force.

Usually previews are made according to the previous episode's key frame schedule and delivered together with that episode's main story, but when

animation doesn't come up to this extent, you can't assemble a preview. Actually, in previous episodes there had been times when preview cuts couldn't be completed in time and we used cuts with temporary coloring in "normal" colors not used in the main episode, but even so, the animation itself was for main episode use. But for episode 16, even that was impossible, so director Kimura ended up assembling it using art boards and character color samples (laughs).

From episode 7 onward, we had a system where different art designers handled art boards for each episode, and for episode 16 we asked Honma Sadayuki-san, who had helped us with

GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!

. Actually, I had persuaded him at the

Kitaro

wrap party (laughs).

Episode 17: "Glass Cradle"

Script: Takahashi Natsuko / Storyboard & Direction: Ito Naoyuki / Animation

Director: Hayama Jun'ichi, Hamada Kunihiro, Kitao Masaru, Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Color Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Episode 17 should have entered animation earlier than episode 16, but somehow ended up with even less schedule than episode 16 (laughs).

Episode 17 begins with the shocking avant-title of maternity Leda. The laboratory where Luna was created appears, which was also a place of Leda's memories. In that place, three child-type robots were living while protecting something... Leda's main story. The episode where Leda's "female" aspects began to emerge strongly.

Horto, Hoty, Holter - robots who seem to be Luna's siblings. From that concept, when creating colors I thought to make them "a bit soft, with a thin sense of physicality." So I made their hair color traced.

Normal character hair has solid outlines, and photography processing creates bleeding shadows around those solid lines, but with color tracing, those solid line bleeding shadows don't appear, so I thought it would look softer. I originally thought about making eyebrows color traced too, but there was opinion that facial expressions might dissolve and become hard to see, so I gave up. But that seemed to work out just right.

The climax, something extracted from Holter's chest - in the original storyboard it wasn't like that but something more SF-like, but the director drew a doodle-like memo sketch, and Umakoshi-kun who was watching said "ah, that might be good," so it became the setting. I created colors based on that and made a sample for the

special effects staff to work from, but... hmm, it became unexpectedly flashy and was a bit of a failure (sorry).

From episode 17, the "complete version" of ending 2 was attached (episodes 14-16 were provisional versions).

Episode 18: "The Time I Lived, The Time to Come"

Script: Yamato-ya Akira / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Animation Director: Maru Kanako / Color Direction: Kunioto Kunio

From episode 13 onward, the story had been following the main plot, and in episode 17 Casshern's party's immediate clear destination was established. This deals with Lyuze's internal turmoil.

Casshern, the very person who brought ruin to her sister Lyuze - Lyuze had been pursuing Casshern with the goal of killing him, but she ends up falling in love with Casshern and falls into a dilemma. Moreover, ruin is creeping up on her too, and that fear also torments Lyuze.

Episode 18 consists almost entirely of Lyuze's dreams. At the end, Lyuze's feelings are liberated by Lyuze who appears in her dream.

This was an episode where animation director Maru-san did solo key animation, progressing with relative ease. So I feel I could work relatively leisurely. There were few characters too (laughs).

By the way, episode 18's "live-action part" became a topic of conversation in various places (laughs).

That part originally had various ideas like moving dolls with CG, but ultimately it was decided to "shoot it with humans." We used Director's single-lens digital camera EOS-1D's continuous shooting function to continuously photograph the character (model's) performance, then imported that into After Effects for processing.

The shooting was early morning the day before delivery, at Zenpukuji Park not far from the studio. At 6 AM after finishing the main episode cut photography, participants were Director Yamauchi, assistant director Nakayama-san, director Kimura-kun, and me. A photo shoot in extremely light clothing during the coldest time right after dawn. Kimura-kun was the script supervisor, I was the general helper. Ladies jogging around the park pond passed by saying "Oh my, how hard, in this cold."

We rehearsed based on the storyboard to match the timing, then immediately shot for real. We finished shooting in about an hour, then warmed up for about an hour and a half at a nearby family restaurant (laughs). Then we returned to the studio, handed the data to the photography staff and had a meeting.

That's how it turned out (laughs).

I didn't think it would be blurred that much, so I was a bit surprised seeing the finished product. Well, I suppose so - showing faces clearly would be problematic. Ah, the tree stump nearby really looked like a "well" (laughs).

So now you know who was in that footage, right? (laughs)

■ Continued in Episode 84

(09.03.18)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 84: DVD & Blu-Ray Release Commemorative!

Casshern Sins

Color Design Notes (Part 5 and 1/2)

From last week through this week, the WBC (World Baseball Classic) has been at the center of my life - everything in my day was decided according to game broadcast times. I ended up skipping preview screenings and having meeting times shifted, so my apologies > To all concerned parties

Thanks to everyone's cooperation (laughs), Japan magnificently won the championship! (←I hate the expression "Samurai JAPAN" - it's lame (laughs))

But you know, that final game - no matter who won or lost, it was such a good game that it didn't matter! Truly the game of the century! When we got tied in the bottom of the 9th, I was actually a bit happy. Partly thinking "ah, this is the real thrill of baseball," and "ah, I can watch this battle a little longer!"

I feel like I was shown something I'll probably never forget for the rest of my life.

Oh, and also...

"I'm so glad I bought a big TV! Long live digital terrestrial!"

Now then.

Casshern Sins

Color Design Notes - this week covers episodes 19-21 of the main story (←It still won't end (laughs)).

Episode 19: "Believing in the Flower That Lives in the Heart"

Script: Yoshida Reiko / Storyboard & Direction: Nakayama Naomi / Animation Director: Okuda Yoshiko / Color Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

After finding one answer to her inner conflict in episode 18, Lyuze lost the mission she had been given to "kill Casshern," and having lost her emotional support, she returns to reality and faces her own "ruin" and its terror. Casshern who lives eternally, Lyuze whose ruin progresses. The words of female warrior Helene pursue such feelings.

In my mind, episode 19 was the beginning of the final sprint - I approached it with that feeling.

Director Nakayama said "I want to color according to Lyuze's feelings," so in addition to scene-by-scene color changes, I tried adding purple to character shadows during battles and according to emotional dominance, and for scenes inside caves where she suppresses her heart and speaks matter-of-factly, I created monochromatic colors with as little variation as possible.

From the pre-dawn rain battle, Helen's death marks dawn breaking all at once, and simultaneously doubt disappears from Lyuze's heart. I thought if we could beautifully create that series of scenes, we'd win - with that thinking, I give myself 100% full marks (laughs).

Incidentally, the cut where Helene dies was wonderful work by color direction Kohinata-san. I just conveyed a rough image and let Kohinata-san create the colors - it was a special cut.

Episode 20: "For Whom Do Flowers Bloom"

Script: Takahashi Natsuko / Storyboard & Direction: eunyoung CHOI / Animation Director: eunyoung CHOI / Color Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Finally reaching Luna's clinic. Reunion with Down. And Luna. However, the actual Luna was a cold existence far from the "healing" image. Yet Down still serves such a Luna.

Director and key animator/animation director Eunyoung-san.

Actually I didn't know her at all. I hadn't seen her previous work either. However, during the art board meeting with Yukie-san and the three of us, I became a huge fan of hers mid-meeting (laughs). It had been a long time since I was so excited about meeting content. Furthermore, at the color direction meeting, leaving color direction Akimoto-san behind, Eunyoung-san and I got carried away together, and the product of that was episode 20's edgy coloring (laughs).

I thought to make daytime not much different from usual Casshern-like coloring, but nights with mysterious expression that might make you think "unrealistic?"

When I read the scenario, I had thought "In episode 20, couldn't we achieve a feeling like 'it's very realistic but goes beyond that and reality flies away'?" and that exactly matched Eunyoung-san's sensibility - it "clicked!" and fit perfectly in my mind.

The flow was: first Eunyoung-san, Yukie-san and I met about art boards. From the images conveyed there, Yukie-san drew art boards, and I created scene-by-scene colors on top of those boards. When roughly complete, Eunyoung-san and I worked out details with samples in front of us. Based on the color design approved there, we then built up detailed cut-by-cut meetings with the color direction staff.

Eunyoung-san would critique my scene design where I assembled color samples on art boards, and I'd respond by bringing up new ideas - that kind of exchange. Basically that's the process for any episode, but somehow the exchange with Eunyoung-san was instantaneous and incredibly dense, and that exchange itself was, wow, fun!

Was it the director's decision to assign Eunyoung-san to episode 20? Production PD Fujio-san's decision? Either way, it was a perfect match. I want to work with Eunyoung-san again! (laughs)

Episode 21: "Paradise of Disappointment"

Script: Yoshida Reiko / Storyboard: Miyashita Shinpei / Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Animation Director: Kiyomaru Satoru, Saito Tadashi, Takanya, Tsuchikawa Norika, Sakurai Masaaki, Kitao Masaru / Color Direction: Komada Noriko

Casshern and others who have lost faith in Luna. There they're joined by Ouji, who tells them "Luna once gave 'healing' called 'lifespan (death)' to immortal robots." Meanwhile, Luna is now spreading "immortality (eternal life)" under the name of "healing." A city of robots living hedonistically after being granted immortality. Down who died for Luna. Lyuze who refuses Luna's "healing" while carrying ruin. Various things weigh on Casshern, and from his conflict he gets destroyed by Dio's forces without resistance...

Episode 21 was the series' second outsourced production episode. Studio Fantasia handled animation through finishing.

As a contrast to episode 20, I kept this episode to designing scenes relatively simply by matching scene backgrounds. Actually, I was planning to do lots of various things in the following episode 22.

For the hedonistic city scenes where they live after gaining immortality, director Kimura's explanation was "It's riot of color!" However,

Casshern Sins

had been killing colors and creating low-saturation screens all along, so I couldn't quite get the balance of "riot of color" right - "So how much color am I allowed to use? (sweat)" The art staff seemed to have the same issue (laughs).

During rush checking, incredibly flashy stones appeared on screen, and seeing that made me jump! (laughs) Looking back now, maybe it could have been even more flashy and explosive? (laughs)

The nighttime lakeside stone-skipping love scene colors actually use the "rainy flower field" color direction from episode 19. When I happened to try the color sample on this scene's art board, it fit perfectly, so we adopted it. There was

almost no reuse (←unpleasant way to put it (laughs)) like this - maybe 1-2 times in other episodes.

The final cut of Casshern being trampled. We created Casshern's rough feeling by compositing diagonal line materials that Kimura-kun roughly sketched with pencil over the finished coloring. It's not an expression method you can use for everything, but I feel it really suits Casshern's style, and I quite like it.

...That was episodes 19, 20, and 21.

And about episode 22...

"I'll do the final three episodes 22, 23, 24 myself!" Director Yamauchi's bombshell declaration! Despite the production schedule being so tight already, having Director Yamauchi handle storyboard + direction for all of the last three episodes himself - in a way reckless and extremely dangerous, such thrilling developments were secretly in progress...

■ Continued in Episode 85

(09.03.26)

Color Design Notes [Tsuji Kunitada]

Episode 85: DVD & Blu-Ray Release Commemorative!

Casshern Sins

Color Design Notes (Final Episode!)

The Web Anime Style editorial department strictly ordered me: "It would be unseemly to spill over into April, so definitely upload and finish "

Casshern Sins

Color Design Notes' on the regular posting day of March 31st," and it's true that I thought "well, the last one is just 3 episodes so it'll be easy."

But as expected, I struggled tremendously (sweat). As befits the final 3 episodes (laughs).

Actually, I'm supposed to be at a certain anime-related event at Loft Plus One in Shinjuku's Kabukicho today, and the assembly time was said to be 6 PM, but I'm actually still writing at Madhouse (■■■■■■■) (heavy sweat).

Hang in there, me! Don't lose, me!

Now then.

Episodes 22, 23, and 24 were ultimately a battle against time. Director Yamauchi properly wrote storyboards for all 3 consecutive episodes, and while he delegated direction to Nakayama-san and Kimura-kun, he decisively handled the final episode himself!

But time passed mercilessly, and we proceeded with animation meetings as soon as storyboards were completed, with art meetings the week before delivery. Art boards were handled by Matsumoto-san, and background work had everyone who had handled individual episodes until then - Koyama-san, Matsuda-san, See Through Studio, Studio Rufus, and Yuki Yuki-san - all participating in battle. Large meetings with everyone, then dividing the work to complete everything in one week - total warfare. The animation staff were the same. The direction team too. And we color staff also went to total war.

Episode 22: "A Drop Called Eternity"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Direction: Nakayama Naomi / Animation Director: Tominaga Mari / Color Direction: Kohinata Tomoko

Having seized control of "Luna's City," Leda appeared to have gained eternal life through Luna's healing, but further ruin spread across her face. In fury, Leda received more healing, but amazingly half her body transformed into an ugly form. Dio, parting ways with Leda, took the captive Casshern outside the castle and waited endlessly for his body to regenerate. Then he entered the final duel with the revived Casshern.

Episode 22: Leda vs Luna's "battle of women" and Dio vs Casshern's "battle of men."

In this episode, "Luna's healing" appears on screen for the first time. For this series of "healing" scenes, director Nakayama and I had agreed to "create maximum color performance." We wanted to create colors for "Luna's room" that were realistic but all like image space.

So especially in the second healing scene in the latter half, I changed coloring cut by cut, overlapped backgrounds and cuts to change colors, and added all sorts of dramatic variations.

Luna is great (laughs). That facial expression and performance showing "So Luna was a woman after all!" The exchange with Leda gives me chills every time I watch it!

Meanwhile, Dio's scenes use contrasting "quiet" coloring, carefully and quietly building up colors to match the background art that changes moment by moment over time.

The scenes connecting these two axes, especially the Ringo, Lyuze, and Ouji scenes, are created with suppressed saturation and heavier colors. This was so the key scenes would stand out. It's the same in episode 23.

Episode 23: "Those Who Return"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Direction: Kimura Nobukage / Animation Director: Nishii Terumi / Color Direction: Akimoto Yuki

Dio and Casshern engage in one-on-one mortal combat. Meanwhile, Leda, abandoned in the robot graveyard, heads to Luna for revenge but gets stabbed by Luna's sword. Casshern arrives there. Understanding everything, Leda heads to Dio. And Casshern confronts Luna.

A story where you can see one conclusion point for each character's fate and way of life as they bear their karma. In a sense, episode 23 was probably one "final episode" - that's how I approached making it.

This episode had two key points. One was the scene where Luna and Casshern confront each other and speak.

So that the conversation between the two could properly reach viewers, I deliberately did nothing special color-wise. I designed it quietly with so-called normal color usage. Even so, matching the story's tension, I made some difference between the first half (scene 50 in the storyboard) and latter half (scene 52), shifting toward cooler colors, and additionally asked color direction Akimoto-san to "read the animation and dialogue content of each cut and vary the shadow depth intensity" to create depth in the characters' expressions.

The other point was Dio's final moments.

Dio, who withdrew saying "I won..." after the final blow in his death battle with Casshern. "I want to make his death scene fitting for Dio's end," "Let's show Dio's death beautifully," "Naturally at sunset" - the director, director Kimura, and I all thought so. So for the scene where Leda snuggles close and they both breathe their last, Umakoshi-san did the animation himself, using the opening's "still image" technique.

Both episode 22 and this episode 23 turned out to be screens that made me think "How did we manage to complete this in such a short schedule!" It's probably an absolutely forbidden way of working schedule-wise, but everyone had the tension and teamwork of "This is the final stretch of what we've built up to - let's get through it!"

And finally episode 24. Even higher hurdles awaited there.

Episode 24: "To the Flower That Blooms in Cycles"

Script: Kobayashi Yasuko / Storyboard & Direction: Yamauchi Shigeyasu / Animation Director: Umakoshi Yoshihiko / Color Direction: Kunioto Kunio

Complete storyboard package 10 days before delivery. Then editing and voice recording, with art meetings the day after episode 23's delivery. Naturally all-hands-on-deck mode. Art staff had just 5 days. Such a wonderfully impossible schedule to begin work.

The world several decades after parting with Luna. Braiking Boss had joined with Luna and revived the empire, but he too continued to doubt this world and Luna. Meanwhile, Ringo, Ouji, Friender, Lyuze, and Casshern were living quietly like a family in a remote place. But ruin progressed, and Ouji, then Lyuze faced death. Dejected Casshern. Eventually resolving himself, Casshern heads toward Luna...

Laugh or cry, this was the end. I handled color direction for the final episode.

Anyway, with "several decades later...", Braiking Boss's cape and other design elements were changed. Luna's clinic also had the lake dry up and rise, changing even its shape. Casshern and the others were the same, but Ouji's truck had decayed into an art object.

"This, a hat? Why?" asked the director.

"Umakoshi-kun said 'In the end it's definitely the hat!'" said I.

A conversation while looking at the suddenly submitted character design. Yes, Braiking Boss's hat. He'd been saying this for quite a while. The director said "Hmm. I see" and approved it.

And naturally the colors matched the original work. But I hadn't properly watched the original. I hurriedly did image searches on the Internet (burst). That's how I decided it.

The first scene I decided for episode 24 was Boss and Casshern's one-on-one battle scene. Colors with weight that still brought out proper color tones. I decided this core scene's balance first, then worked backwards to decide each previous scene.

Next I decided Lyuze's final scene. "Ouji in evening, Lyuze in morning" - before discussing death scenes, both the director and I separately thought this way, and particularly for Lyuze we both thought "not sharply vivid, but a somewhat hazy morning," which is how it turned out. In episode 24, to show the "near death feeling," I deliberately drained saturation from Lyuze's complexion to make it whitish. My initial idea for the sequence of Lyuze breathing her last in Casshern's arms was to leave only the main lines and make everything white, with just the "C" on Casshern's chest red, but it felt too excessive so I scrapped it (laughs).

The other scenes were built up individually following the

Casshern Sins

worldview we'd established.

The color idea for the final "Luna's hall" came from the director. Initially I had tried making it reddish monochrome, but during director checking he said "You can put in some weird color. Like light blue?" That's how that scene was completed. It fit that scene so perfectly it was shocking (laughs).

And the ending.

This was also decided quite early to be "with Yukie-san's art" and "still images like the opening." And I would do the coloring. But with this terrifying schedule, I had no time to handle coloring myself. So I had Akimoto-san, who was helping with the final episode, handle all the coloring.

I thought grown-up Ringo should wear a cream-colored dress, but I forgot to convey that. But telepathy? Wonderful! She properly colored it with a cream-colored dress! So the ending is mostly Akimoto-san's colors as-is.

Atmosphere-wise it was set several decades after the main story ended, so actually Friender had become quite an old dog. I was preparing to properly show that old dog depiction in the ending, but amazingly that ending cut got dropped (laughs). Poor Friender, loyally unlucky until the very end...

This final episode 24 was actually a bit unsatisfactory. We couldn't broadcast with the screens everyone was trying to create and deliver.

Casshern Sins

is a TV work, and normally what was broadcast on TV should be the completed, final form, but our abilities were insufficient and it aired in an "incomplete" form. I shouldn't make excuses here, but episodes 22-24 in the DVD version have been touched up a bit to become the visuals we originally aimed for.

Though unsatisfactory, please watch on DVD or Blu-Ray once more if possible.

Anyway,

Casshern Sins

is complete. It feels like a big typhoon passed, the sky is clear beautiful weather, the mood is refreshing, but now we have to clean up the scattered house debris - that kind of feeling.

But you know, this feeling is wonderful. So once again, without learning my lesson, I want to create works together with Director Yamauchi.

■ Continued in Episode 86

(09.03.31)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 86: Excuse Me Extra Edition -

Casshern Sins

Flashback and New Programs

In Tokyo, the cherry blossoms have passed their peak, and petals are fluttering in the refreshing wind like a blizzard. How is everyone doing?

Recently, a grand wrap party for

Casshern Sins

was held, and I was able to reunite with familiar faces. Naturally, it continued to a second party, third party, and we got excited and talked until morning. Particularly with the director, we talked deeply about the "behind-the-scenes stories" of the final episode's Casshern and Luna scenes that didn't make it into the footage.

(I wonder if that topic came up in the recent Anime Style interview? I wasn't there so I don't know)

Then, quite the "backlash" hit me, both physically and mentally - wham! (laughs). My condition dropped all at once, and I couldn't get my hands on this column manuscript or even other work... So I'm writing this apology and excuse (tears).

I'll try to recover starting from next week's installment.

Now then.

April means new program season. This season, I'm participating in two programs.

The first is

Marie & Gali

(■■■■■■■■).

It broadcasts within the program "Sue Ensa" on NHK Educational every Tuesday at 7:25 PM. Each episode is 5 minutes long, but recklessly it's a continuous story (laughs). I handled the color design (■■■■■) for the main characters.

For

Marie & Gali

, apparently due to NHK policy, they can't put all the individual episode staff credits on air. Moreover, the credits for "Sue Ensa" overall are also included. So those concerned about staff should pay attention.

(09.04.10)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 87: Once Upon a Time... (51) Creating Colors!

COO

's Special New Paint Colors Appear!

Since last weekend, a friend has been traveling overseas - she went to New York! Before her departure, I was helping her with travel arrangements, camera matters, various Manhattan things, and wow, how convenient! Long live the Internet!

"Well, let's take a look, shall we?"

We connected to Google Maps. We could see New York, Manhattan's cityscape in real satellite photos.

"Here's Times Square, and this is Broadway. Going all the way down, look, here's Wall Street, and this is 'Ground Zero.' And going a bit offshore, look, there's the 'Statue of Liberty,'" - that sort of thing.

And then there's that "Street View"! Manhattan is almost entirely covered, and clicking along the streets as you proceed feels like you're actually there.

I've been to New York about three times, but that was over 10 years ago. Back then, the Internet was just starting to spread, and it was the era of finally managing to connect to the net using hotel room phone lines with great difficulty.

Come to think of it, back then there was a fixed camera in Times Square that showed Times Square in real time, and I used to enjoy watching that footage (laughs).

Now, even modest New York hotels have broadband connections in each room, plus wireless LAN. Man, ten years makes a decade. I'd like to go take some photos soon too, with distant eyes...

Now then.

Resuming the long-interrupted

Coo: Far From Home

(Coo ■■■■■■■■■■) old stories (laughs).

Storyboard work progressed, and character final designs kept appearing one after another. Which meant it was finally time for "colors." As I wrote before, I was a huge fan of the original novel, and I had my own images of protagonist Yosuke and Tetsuro father and son, as well as Cathy and Tony. I applied these vague, formless images in my head to the characters Okura-san had drawn.

And it was perfect!

As a fan of the original work, what I had been hoping was "I hope it's not too childish artwork." But the Yosuke that Okura-san drew was not a "child" but a "boy." Tetsuro and Cathy were also solid-lined, proper "adult" characters.

"This is it!" I remember joyfully doing the first color direction for color samples.

The human characters seemed like they'd translate fairly smoothly into forms (colors), but the color of the true protagonist "Coo" wouldn't be decided. Or rather, "what color would a baby plesiosaur be in the first place?" We had reached that fundamental question.

Enter the so-called "dinosaur picture books." While dinosaur figures were drawn with wonderful brushwork and vivid life, frankly speaking, these were only imaginary colors. So they weren't very helpful as reference. "Well, anyway, let's try painting something," I decided, and started making several color samples as I thought of them.

However, there was one problem here. Yes, the paint problem.

As I've written several times before, Toei Animation (■■■■■) at the time used STAC paints to make works, and with very few colors.

COO

was a theatrical work, so in addition to TV series paint (about 120 colors), theatrical "X paints" (about 70 colors) could be used, but honestly that wasn't nearly enough.

So I had the company negotiate, and as a "special exception," we got permission to also use "A-number paints" (about 80 colors) that were made for American co-productions.

However, these "X" paints and "A" paints were actually problematic - they were paints that had been added haphazardly during

Yamato

-era theatrical works and co-productions, so they weren't proper color gradations. But you can't make something from nothing. I struggled with color charts anyway and somehow assembled color tones close to my image.

I managed to get through human characters with color balance, creating atmospheric results, but "Coo" remained difficult and I hit a wall.

"I wonder? My impression is that it should be a bit brighter, but not this whitish, and not gray either, something more slippery feeling," said Director Imazawa. I'd made color samples in countless subtle combinations - I'd lost count - but ah, it was still a bit different from the director's impression. I wasn't satisfied either, naturally. But

we were out of paints, out of colors.

"Then let's make them."

That was a comment from production staff member Kaburaki-san.

"If we absolutely don't have them, let's have the paint company make them. This is such a big work, let's have them made."

If we don't have sleeves, let's first make those sleeves. Thus we reached the groundbreaking development of ordering special new paint colors exclusively for

COO

from STAC.

■ Continued in Episode 88

(09.04.14)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 88: Once Upon a Time... (52) - Colors Created! The Secret of BG-2A, BG-3A, and CR-1A, CR-2A

From last week through this week, there was a big move in the color design room at Toei Animation's (■■■■■■■■■■) Oizumi Studio. Since I became freelance, the room was divided into a room for freelance people and others. And with that came the big move. And personal organization, major cleanup.

What I thought was just recently turned out to be over 15 years since I moved into the current room. In that time, I accumulated so much stuff that I reset everything and disposed of a tremendous variety of things.

I kept only commemorative works' storyboards and setting materials from old works, discarding the rest. I discarded old reference magazines and books including manga that had become outdated. I discarded all MO disks (!) containing early digital work data (←the data had been converted to CDs long ago). Personal music recordings on cassette tapes and MD disks were also discarded.

I was amazed at the sheer volume of items that had been placed around this desk area (laughs).

At the same time, various things were "excavated"!

There were mountains of main production materials related to

Coo: Far From Home

that I'm writing about now. And looking at such things made me lose track of time, so cleanup wouldn't progress, wouldn't progress (laughs).

Still, I somehow forced myself to clean up and successfully created a "new nest" (laughs).

"From now on, I'm going to live as lightly as possible!" - so I vowed (laughs).

Now then.

"Then let's make them."

"Huh? Is that okay?" said I.

"You can't do it with existing paints, right? Then let's have the paint company make them. This is such a big theatrical work."

The color of the crucial protagonist Coo in the theatrical work

Coo: Far From Home

absolutely wouldn't be decided. With the paints available at Toei Animation, the color tone was impossible. Then this surprising development occurred suddenly.

This development honestly surprised me. Actually, I had been thinking "that's the only method, isn't it?" but I thought "well, it's probably impossible."

I had tried searching for suitable paints among Taiyo Shikisai paints that Toei Animation didn't basically use, but even with Taiyo Shikisai's extensive color range, the colors usable for Coo's body were also subtle. But I was thinking that maybe in the end I'd have to have the director compromise somewhere around there.

The fundamental reason for being cautious about making new paints was that ultimately, increasing colors meant extra money.

At that time, professional cel coloring paints in large business bottles (called "kilo bottles") cost 2000 yen per bottle for STAC (incidentally, Taiyo Shikisai was about 1600 yen). These had to be stocked at studios handling coloring work. Since the character requiring these new colors was the "protagonist" Coo, naturally he appeared most frequently, so it wouldn't end with one or two bottles - large quantities had to be prepared. If this increased to 3 colors, 4 colors and beyond, costs would increase accordingly.

Coloring work was a per-piece world. Even for theatrical works, Toei work's contract rates were probably around 300 yen per piece (maybe a bit higher?). Paint costs and such were included in that amount. So when the paints used (prepared) increased, production became that much more difficult.

"Then why not supply the needed new colors in kind as needed?" - I would think, but "material costs are included in the unit price," and somehow the company side wouldn't budge on that point (laughs).

Also, at that time, the center of Toei works' coloring operations was gradually shifting to a studio in Manila, Philippines. At that time, all cels and paints for Manila studios were sent from Japan by sea mail - a time-consuming system (though industrial products that could be made locally like cut bags were made locally). So if paint ran short during production, it would be terrible, so large quantities had to be sent anticipating surpluses.

The new colors made this time would only be usable for

COO

production, and these colors wouldn't remain on Toei Animation's color chart for use in any work in the future. For such reasons, "increasing new 'colors'" was in a sense a production taboo.

But we decided to make them anyway. While the aforementioned issues certainly existed, from the position of deciding colors, this was an unprecedented great

opportunity.

"List up how many you'll need."

When told that, naturally "necessary colors" transform into "desired colors" (laughs). So the colors I listed, even after cutting down, were about 10 colors. I submitted this to the company... but as generally expected, things got cloudy (laughs). Apparently there was indeed various debate among higher-ups in the production department, and the result was "10 colors is too many!" - the list was returned (laughs). But it wasn't completely rejected - with the condition "minimum," it became possible.

"Well, I suppose so," said I. I had honestly anticipated such a situation (laughs). So I resubmitted a list of 4 colors that were absolutely essential new colors, and somehow got the go-ahead.

Those 4 colors were: first, 2 colors for "Coo's" body color. Coo's body would be painted in two colors - upper and lower surfaces - the upper surface normal color and regular shadow color. I mixed existing BG-series paints to make sample amounts and painted color samples, getting the director's approval. These were given to the paint company for production. They were named BG-2A and BG-3A respectively.

And 2 more colors. These were "Cathy's" skin colors.

Cathy was a white woman tanned brown, but Toei's paints didn't have suitable paints. The limited variety of skin color variations in Toei's paints was truly fatal. So, I'll confess here for the first time, I plotted something a bit sneaky.

The newly made colors were CR-1A and CR-2A. Actually, these 2 colors were Taiyo Shikisai paint colors 56N (←probably) and 45M. I made color samples using these 2 Taiyo Shikisai paint colors I personally owned and had STAC make them.

While the new colors were supposedly "only for

COO

production," I thought:

"Since we'll probably make too many and have leftovers anyway, and if there are leftovers it's wasteful, so it's better to use them for other works too, right? (grin)"

Regardless of Coo's body colors, these brownish skin-tone intermediate colors were colors I definitely wanted to use for works other than

COO

, especially video works. Even if I couldn't use them openly, if I used them secretly to an unnoticed degree, it would be fine - I had such calculations. And if they ran

short by any chance, I could just use Taiyo Shikisai paints directly.

Actually, from

COO

onward, these 2 colors continued to be used "secretly" in quite a few works I participated in (laughs).

Also, there were production systems like the theatrical

Dragon Ball Z

I had participated in before entering

COO

, where during crunch time we'd do color direction with Taiyo Shikisai colors and have Korean studios do the coloring - I thought these could be used in such cases too!

So we could use 4 new colors.

While there were only these 4 colors for heavy use as new colors, I thought that probably during color direction work, there would be colors I'd want to use like "just here! just this cut!" depending on the cut. In such cases, I could either add paint I made myself to coloring orders cut by cut, or have it ordered from coloring studios that had Taiyo Shikisai paints - I was determined to use every possible means.

Thus

Coo: Far From Home

was able to establish a system for creating "colors" using the highest number of colors in Toei Animation work history.

And finally we'd enter the real production of main episode screens.

■ Continued in Episode 89

(09.04.21)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 89: Once Upon a Time... (53) - The Story of Creating Colors That Convince Viewers with a Limited Number of Available Colors

The world is in Golden Week. I myself am actually in Italy. My fifth visit to Italy in five years, and I'm immediately hit with heavy rain day and night... Hmm, someone's conspiracy?

While I'm in Italy, the Tokyo production sites are working through Golden Week. Unable to finish scheduled work before departure, I'm traveling through Italy with a laptop and pen tablet. Connecting to the internet through hotel lines, I'm exchanging and checking setting data with Tokyo. While the world has become convenient, work chases you wherever you go (laughs).

And as generally expected, I couldn't finish this series manuscript in time either, so I'm currently writing at my hotel (sweat). Moreover, with the 7-hour time difference, whether I can make the update deadline... Ah, sorry...

Now then.

Finally the new paint problem was settled. Coo's basic body color was also decided. Work on character color samples progressed using the new colors that arrived.

Coo... His carefully considered body color was cleared with new colors.

Yosuke and Tetsuro... This father-son pair was decided relatively smoothly. They're alike, after all. Simple clothing too. I was careful with skin color - the balance of tanning. Which color (which paint) to use to express "tanned East Asian" feel was key. If too dark, the balance with hair would be bad, and differentiation from Polynesians would be difficult. So it became relatively bright. Naturally, the child got a darker tan to look more energetic.

Tony... With the atmosphere of "Australian guy," I made him white-skinned with slightly pinkish skin color. However, I decided not to tan him much.

Cathy... Her carefully considered skin color was also cleared with new colors. However, to "still make her skin look bright and feminine," I made her shirt blackish so her skin would look brighter by contrast. The "rain shower scene" had the perfect balance between underwear and skin (laughs).

Among her belongings a camera bag appears, and wanting it to look like professional photographer equipment, I made it a yellow and black NIKON bag instead of a regular duralumin bag.

Blue and White Tip... These two dolphins were quite challenging. "White Tip" was easy - white spots made it immediately recognizable - but why "Blue" was blue meant it was probably more bluish than other dolphins. But how blue is blue? After various trials, I landed on "ah, this is probably fine." Ultimately, "don't overthink it" (burst).

Also, the dolphin body upper/lower surface color division problem. Real dolphins don't have sharply divided colors - the boundary lines are gradated - but animation can't easily do that, so the balance was difficult. But ultimately, rather than aiming for something too subtle, it would be better to be clear within the presentation, so that's how the colors turned out.

That was roughly how the main appearing characters went.

While deciding colors this way, a new issue arose among everyone: "Should character brightness and appearance be the same for outdoor and indoor scenes?"

For outdoor scenes, if the sun is shining brightly, you can create a strong sunlight impression by making shadow areas smaller and shadows slightly darker, and even if not so sunny, normally colored with regular shadow artwork would probably be okay.

But what about indoors? "Probably a bit darker, right?" However, "would simply making everything slightly darker really work?"

Outdoors, strong tropical sunlight pours down. But indoors, even in tropical simple buildings, they're not hermetically sealed spaces with complete light blocking - windows and doors everywhere with outside brightness constantly entering.

Nizo-san's interior art boards were drawn relatively soft and bright. While outdoors were blindingly bright, interiors might be shadowy, but they had the softness of brightness your eyes adjust to indoors.

"How about adding highlights along character outlines in the artwork?" Such a proposal was made. Not highlights that strongly suggest light reflection with sharp clarity, but soft color differences not much different from normal parts.

Okura-san submitted character settings with added highlight artwork, and I made several color sample patterns based on those.

First, the basic "normal" color direction sample with highlights slightly brighter than "normal" color. This became too bright. Depending on how you looked at it, it could appear brighter than outdoor cases.

Next, making the basic colors one shade darker overall with shadow coloring, and painting highlights with "normal" colors. This was subtly good as expected. The bottleneck was paint variations.

With today's digital tools, you could easily do "lower brightness by X%..." with a few clicks in Photoshop, but in those cel paint days, to make colors one shade darker meant "painting with paint that looks darker." The paint variations we had made things too dark, causing characters to float (or sink) against backgrounds.

Hmm...

After much consideration, I created a "partially darken colors to utilize highlights" approach. For example, leave hair and skin at basic "normal color" without darkening, and add soft highlights. Only bright colored parts like shirts get one shade darker colors, with highlight areas painted in that part's original "normal color" - a "hybrid method" in today's terms.

Looking at character balance when lined up, I carefully decided colors person by person using available paints. This balanced nicely on screen.

With today's digital coloring, you can really easily modify and adjust color tones and brightness, so you can create things to some extent without much thinking, but looking back, in those days we really used our heads to squeeze out solutions.

Not just cases like "making things slightly darker," but in every situation - depicting image space scenes, realistic depictions like flame reflections - we constantly faced "ah, we don't have paint colors between this color and that color..."

Each time, we'd rack our brains, try countless combinations of available paints, and create convincing combinations to get through.

While today certainly has today's struggles and considerations, "devising ways to create convincing colors for viewers with limited available colors" wasn't just my battle - it was the fight of all color direction staff in the anime industry at that time.

■ Continued in Episode 90

(09.05.01)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 8: Once Upon a Time... (6) Cel Paints Have a Sweet Fragrance That's Wonderful

The other day I went to see the movie "Bubble he GO!! Time Machine wa Drum-shiki."

A story about time-traveling from 2007 to the bubble peak year 1990 to prevent the bubble's collapse and save Japan's near-bankrupt economy.

Hirosue Ryoko

love!

Abe Hiroshi

the best! It was quite an enjoyable movie and I was very satisfied.

Come to think of it, the stories I've been writing about from around 1985 are exactly bubble period stories.

But personally, I don't really remember receiving any particular bubble benefits (bitter laugh).

Well then.

This week I'll return to the main story.

About paints.

When I started finishing work at that Ikebukuro production company, since the finishing production I belonged to mainly took Toei work, the paints used there were naturally mostly

Stack

(STAC: I think it was Saito Tele Animation Color) paints.

But occasionally, we'd take rush jobs from production companies other than Toei Doga, and most of those jobs used different paints from Toei's.

Taiyo Shikisai (■■■■■)

paints.

Before entering the industry, I never imagined there were two paint manufacturers

(actually there were many more companies making cel paints, but I learned this much later). Moreover, the colors and numbering were different with subtle incompatibility. But thinking about it, the anime programs I watched on TV back then - Toei works and works from other companies clearly had different screen brilliance and color atmospheres, which I'd noticed even as an amateur. One major factor was the paint issue itself.

As I wrote about *Yamato* last time, Stack colors with overall vivid tones versus Taiyo Shikisai paints with matte tones.

Stack colors that could appear transparent when painted thin versus Taiyo colors that were uniform in any color and dried quickly. Stack colors with high transparency but prone to spoiling with rotten egg-like odors versus Taiyo colors that would quickly harden if you weren't careful. Stack colors that sometimes had fluffy white mold growing on the surface when you opened them versus Taiyo colors that could cause white clouding in finished painting if not well stirred.

As color design or color direction, which I preferred depends entirely on the case.

When wanting vivid colors, Stack colors were good, and for subdued intermediate tones, definitely Taiyo Shikisai. Most of all, Taiyo colors had many colors and were easy to create gradations, but the numbering system was complex, often leading to specification and painting mistakes... (bitter laugh).

But for us doing finishing painting work on site, more than paint color development, it was first about ease of painting and drying speed.

Paint spread and brush movement favored Stack colors, while drying speed favored Taiyo Shikisai. Ah, color trace work ease was definitely Stack colors. Especially Stack's "

Trace Black

" used for line corrections had very fine, smooth material quality and was the best paint for hand tracing.

(I think Taiyo Shikisai also had "Trace Black," but trace lines drawn with these paints had an enamel-like glossy reflection, and unfortunately they stuck easily to the protective "tissue paper" on cels and animation paper, making them hard to use back then...)

And the individual "quirks" of paints themselves were problematic.

You had to know each paint's individual "quirks," or when you dried and collected the carefully painted cels and flipped them over, you'd end up going "Aggh!"

Following dim memories, Stack paint large bottles, called "kilo bottles," cost about 1,600 yen each back then,

PB series (vivid pink colors) were slightly more expensive, and "Trace Black" was nearly 2,000 yen. I've forgotten the unit cost of raw cels. Incidentally, carbon for machine tracing was each subcontracting production company's burden. I think black carbon was about 20 yen per sheet. Brown and other colored carbons were about 25 yen.

When I started work at the finishing production company, all materials for Toei works were supplied by Toei.

Raw cels, paints - everything was provided by Toei. Finishing subcontractors only handled finishing work. For paints, when you ran out, you'd tell the finishing progress staff the color number and they'd prepare it in advance so you could take it back with cuts (back then, shelves for each production company were set up in the finishing department for cut exchanges).

However, that "material supply" was suddenly discontinued one month, and while there was some upcharge to finishing unit costs as "material costs," everything else became each finishing production's burden.

It was effectively a unit cost reduction. This was a big blow to finishing subcontractors back then. Well, other companies' works normally used this system. My production company and similar companies that mainly did Toei works increased the weight of non-Toei works from that point. This coincided with when animation production volume was starting to increase.

Even when Taiyo Shikisai paint jobs came in, they weren't constantly high volume, so naturally we couldn't afford to stock a complete set of Taiyo Shikisai paints.

So what did we do? We used "conversion charts" to convert Taiyo color specifications to Stack colors for painting.

"Conversion charts"!

Every finishing production company used them back then. Sometimes each finishing production made and used their own, sometimes production companies brought them.

As I wrote earlier, Taiyo colors and Stack colors have basically no compatibility.

Even gray paints have subtly different colors. So we very forcibly and roughly "converted" them for painting (laughs). It's unthinkable now, but back then it was OK even if colors were somewhat different.

For absolutely unavailable colors, we'd ask production progress staff to bring the necessary number of small bottles along with cuts.

The Taiyo paints brought this way gradually increased as inventory. So when taking rush jobs, we'd start by rewriting color specifications with our Taiyo paint

inventory list in hand and calling to identify missing colors.

##

■Continues to Episode 9

(07.02.27)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 90: Golden Week Extra Edition -

Tomorrow's Nadja

Memory City and That Person's City from

Doremi

(laughs)

Golden Week is over. Once it ended, it immediately got hot (tears). The humidity especially...

During Golden Week, I was away from Japan. While I was away, various things happened. A certain famous rock singer passed away, a certain famous actor got married...

Various things happened among my acquaintances too. A certain color direction person who got married in a lightning engagement (laughs). Or my Seoul friend's mother who passed away suddenly at a young age. Happy and sad events crowded together during this year's Golden Week.

Now then.

This year's Golden Week, I took a somewhat long break and traveled around northern Italy. From Milan to Parma, Bologna, Venice, Verona, and back to Milan. I saw various things in each city and ate lots (laughs).

Whether domestic or international, whenever I travel anywhere, I'm always curious about places related to works I've been involved with that appeared in the main episodes. And speaking of Europe, there's

Tomorrow's Nadja

(■■■■■■■■).

In

Tomorrow's Nadja

, we "traveled" across Europe from England to Austria for about a year. Italy also appeared - Milan, Venice, and Rome - but the place I love most that appeared across 2 full episodes (episodes 18-19) was Venice.

Actually, this was my third visit to Venice! My previous visit was 11 years ago. So this was my first time since

Nadja

. In the main episodes, famous places like canals, St. Mark's Square, and Rialto Bridge appeared, but naturally they were all major spots I'd been to before. So during main episode work at the time, I knew the atmosphere of every place perfectly and could create perfect colors and ambiance.

However, one place I'd never been to appeared in the main episodes: the Contarini del Bovolo Palace and its spiral staircase. I should have seen most major points, but I'd never been there at all. When I looked it up, it was properly listed in guidebooks, but probably honestly not with very good photos, so I'd unconsciously passed by that building.

Episode 19. Carnival night. In the scene chasing the "Black Rose" fleeing from St. Mark's Square, that place appeared just briefly, just a few cuts. The "Black Rose" performing against the full moon on rooftops - Nadja and Harvey watch that scene from this spiral staircase.

The art board Yuki Yukie-san drew for that scene. The palace appearing in the night scene looked white, beautiful, and fantastic in Venice's deep blue night, with the spiral staircase also floating up white and soft.

This time, I absolutely wanted to see that palace, that spiral staircase, so I went to visit it.

That day in Venice was refreshing weather with occasional showers, but it was pleasant, truly perfect sightseeing weather in Venice style.

From morning I toured various churches, immersing myself in religious paintings. When the sun tilted a bit, I finally aimed for the "spiral staircase" and walked endlessly through alleyways. Walking through the maze-like city's winding paths, I finally reached my destination.

"Ah, here it is!"

The palace stood quietly, as if protected within Venice's labyrinth.

But unfortunately, this building was already a "dead" building.

Venice is the "city that stopped time." Buildings that have existed there for centuries have their interiors renovated to suit modern life while maintaining their external appearance, using them as they are. So even if they look like old buildings from the past, most are "living" buildings.

However, this palace was a "dead" building. It was already ruins with no one living there, and even repairs to broken parts weren't being done. Naturally, tourists like us were prohibited from entering. We could only look from afar, from our side of the iron fence.

"Ah, I see..." I sighed.

Until seeing the real thing here, I had assumed it was still a "living" building.

"Ah, maybe when Nadja ran up these stairs, maybe it was already dead? No, that couldn't be, surely"

Looking up at the spiral staircase, I was alone in my sentimentality (laughs). While I shouldn't mix up anime and reality, I momentarily immersed myself in an imaginary world around 1900 from the story.

The palace and stairs surrounded by cold iron fencing stood there quietly yet beautifully in the slightly darkening evening shadows. Needless to say, Yukie-san's art board images seemed to softly overlay on top (laughs).

By the way, the next day I went to Murano Island. The island famous as the birthplace of Venetian glass. I went to that island to search for Mirai-san and her workshop (!), but unfortunately I couldn't find them (laughs).

■ Continued in Episode 91

(09.05.12)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 91: Once Upon a Time... (54) -

COO

Above Water, Below Water

Two weeks' absence (sweat).

Work has been piling up lately and I'm in quite a fluster.

In the midst of this, today I attended a certain awards ceremony.

Hakaba Kitaro

(■■■■■■), which was produced at Toei Animation last year with my participation, received:

The Japan Society of Motion Picture and Television Engineers' 2008 "Video Technology Excellence Award"

This is an award for video technology, and this time we won for the "Hakaba Filter" used in the main production. As individuals involved in developing and operating this filter, five of us received the award jointly: CG director Morita-san, photography director Iribe-san, art directors Kurahashi-san and Honma-san, and myself.

Since "this might be the first and last awards ceremony of my life" (laughs)... or rather, "well, it seems interesting and I should probably experience something like this," I decided to attend. Incidentally, Kurahashi-san and Honma-san were absent from the start. Iribe-san, who was supposed to attend, also became absent at the last minute saying "work..." (sweat). Sadly, only Morita-san and I attended.

I actually went with a relatively light heart, but this was quite impressive and surprising. It seemed to be a pretty major award. Various film and TV works and technologies were literally receiving awards. Looking at the distributed list of winners, Morita-san and I were a bit intimidated.

Our presentation was relatively early, so that tension ended quickly once we received the award on stage (laughs). After that we could leisurely enjoy watching the other award presentations.

Setting aside our award, looking at the content of other awards made me excited. Video and the technology supporting it are deep and enjoyable.

Now then.

Coo: Far From Home

means "ocean."

"I want to capture above and below the ocean surface together in one screen like this."

One day, Director Imazawa brought a photo book.

The photo book featured southern seas, with many photos taken with the camera lens half-submerged underwater, creating compositions where above and below water were divided right at the screen center. Beautiful (presumably) South Pacific waters with high transparency. Clear footage was captured and featured where above and below water were indistinguishable.

"Like this, I'm wondering if we can create underwater, submarine footage that doesn't look different from above water or in air," said the director.

Normally, underwater processing involves first changing character colors with color direction to look appropriate, then adding water undulation through photography processing like wave glass effects, creating enough effects to clearly indicate "this is underwater!" But the idea was to deliberately not do that and aim for surprisingly transparent water.

We ran various tests using actual production animation for processing tests.

In cuts where above and below sea surface fit simultaneously in the screen like those photo books, indeed, it seemed fine to paint above and below water with the same colors (actually, we painted underwater areas slightly darker). We achieved the intended transparent feeling as aimed.

However, in cuts where the camera was above water (sea surface) showing underwater parts through water, we found it felt better to properly differentiate above and below water colors. Ultimately, it was case-by-case. The important thing was not that "water doesn't exist" but that it "appears as if water doesn't exist." However, we decided to minimize wave glass processing in photography.

Underwater seemed workable this way, but the problem was indoor aquariums. In the story, a large aquarium for raising Coo was newly installed in the separate research room. Coo swims around inside it.

The big difference between ocean and aquarium is that aquariums have glass walls and are located indoors.

We expressed the "glass wall" feeling by reflecting Coo's body on the glass when swimming Coo approached the glass.

The problem was indeed the "aquarium placed indoors" aspect. With underwater ocean scenes, you just see endless underwater extending into the distance, so maintaining water transparency was sufficient, but with indoor aquariums, you see

various indoor elements through water and glass, so rather than transparency, we needed to express "there's water there" to avoid busy, cluttered screens.

This was quite a dilemma. As mentioned earlier, the director's theme was "transparency," but that transparency could work against the screen. We tried various test photography approaches: a version doing nothing like underwater scenes, a version with cel color changes plus wave glass photography processing, and others.

Among these, what we settled on as "ah, this might be it" was a technique of layering thin light blue color film over everything below the waterline where water existed. Honestly, transparency was somewhat reduced, but here we prioritized expressing that "water exists." So coloring was basically normal color tones. In terms of animation, we created thickness with paint at the waterline to make film placement easier. Film was laid underneath and photographed. This technique cleared the aquarium issue.

However...

"Hmm, we need some more flavoring..." While watching test photography rushes of underwater cuts, the director and animation director began pondering.

■ Continued in Episode 92

(09.06.02)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 92: Once Upon a Time... (55) -

COO

What to Do About Shallow Waters? Flickering Light

The

Coo: Far From Home

memories I'm continuing to ramble about - actually, this work still hasn't been released on DVD. When it was originally released, Laserdisc (!) and VHS video were released during their heyday, but it still hasn't reached DVD release.

While writing these memories, sometimes I need to check the main episode screens. I have an old LD player at home, but checking the Laserdisc every time I need verification is troublesome. Moreover, I write manuscripts more often outside my home.

"Maybe I should burn this to DVD?"

I connected the LD player to an HD-DVD recorder and tried dubbing. Since it's such an old LD player, naturally it's analog connection. I managed to dub it somehow, but ah, the noise... the color... Apparently it's due to the old LD player. It's about 20 years old now...

I put that data on the laptop I carry daily, occasionally checking main episode screens while writing manuscripts. Then I end up getting absorbed watching and eventually watch the whole thing (laughs).

This movie is really good, well-made (laughs).

I wish it could somehow be re-released on DVD.

I wonder if I should petition somewhere? Hmm.

Now then.

Coo: Far From Home

- watching test rushes of underwater footage, cuts of dolphins swimming in shallow waters, the director and animation director spoke up: "Something's missing."

What that was: "flickering light."

During daytime in oceans and rivers when water moves with waves and currents, the surface undulations create lens-like effects, casting net-like light patterns on the water bottom. While it doesn't reach deep areas, this "flickering light" should

reflect on shallow sea floors and dolphins swimming in shallow waters.

"We definitely want this," said Director Imazawa.

So we decided to add this "flickering" to things swimming in relatively shallow underwater areas. We added "net pattern" animation for "flickering" to dolphins' upper body surfaces.

Now, what to do with this? The base animation was completed. But how to effectively show this on screen?

Several methods existed. First, during coloring, composite this animation and paint with "light-hitting" colors. Second, color this "net pattern" as separate cel material in white, then photograph it with multiple exposure overexposure to create bright, blown-out colors (super). Third, create a transmitted light mask from this animation and apply transmitted light to literally add light, among others.

First, the coloring method was rejected because "it inevitably looks like 'net-patterned dolphins' swimming." The second photography super method also wasn't much different from coloring in the end, and we couldn't control brightness, darkness, and color tone as desired, so it was rejected.

The third transmitted light method was the technique of applying "flickering light" directly, allowing various transmitted materials for the transmitted light applied, and from test results, it seemed quite promising.

However...

The ocean water itself, emphasizing transparency, sought transparency that appeared completely absent (as if even seawater didn't exist), but for overhead shots looking down at the sea surface, we were adding transmitted light reflections to the sea surface so it was clearly recognizable as existing there. Without clear sea surface recognition, depending on cut continuity, it might look strange (like incorrect cuts).

This "sea surface reflection light" and "flickering light" conflicted. "Flickering light" should exist gently and faintly below that sea surface. But it subtly asserted itself, unfortunately creating busy, unclear screens.

"Well then, let's make it shadows instead."

Until now we'd been struggling to show "net patterns" brightly on screen as "flickering light," but we reversed the concept - use the "net patterns" themselves as shadows rather than light. So we colored the "net pattern" black and used it with semi-exposure masking.

Test photography results: While honestly different from realistic appearance, it somehow conveyed the atmosphere and, more importantly, made underwater

character performances stand out.

"Let's go with this," the director decided. Incidentally, seabed "net patterns" became "case-by-case," basically optional.

Today, various methods and techniques might express realistic shallow underwater scenes, and even then, pursuing it further might have achieved much more realistic shallow water depictions. But I think making it too realistic would somehow differ from what this work aimed for. The director and main staff all seemed to somehow share such feelings.

■ Continued in Episode 93

(09.06.11)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 93: Once Upon a Time... (56) -

COO

How to Make Color Direction Sheets Part 1

The other day I received the Blu-ray version of

GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!

and watched it at home immediately.

Wow, Blu-ray is too clear... or rather, shows too much (sweat).

The colors and textures were reproduced very vividly, which was perfectly fine in that regard, but everything was visible so clearly down to the smallest details that parts I secretly wanted to gloss over were clearly exposed (heavy sweat).

Blu-ray is dangerous.

While

Casshern Sins

was a TV work, it was broadcast on digital terrestrial, and we approached screen creation from the beginning assuming Blu-ray release, but this

Japan Explodes!!

was originally created with theatrical film projection in mind. While it's a movie shown on large screens, given the film projection format and conditions, the image naturally appears somewhat softer, so considering that, I thought "this should be fine" when creating various scenes (←not cutting corners!).

But showing it on screens that are too crystal clear - honestly, it was heavy sweat material.

Recently TVs themselves are gradually becoming liquid crystal high-definition, plus Blu-ray, so we really need to be careful and consider what final format things will take!

Now then.

I think I wrote this before (←did I write it? (sweat)), but the "color" work flow is roughly like this:

1. Listen to the director about the overall work concept and keep "roughly like this" in mind.

2. Make trial color samples for cels based on character settings from the character designer.
3. Check color samples with director and main staff. Decide basic character colors for the work.
4. Create coloring settings (called "color direction sheets," "color direction tables," various names) based on decided colors.
5. Based on storyboards, meet with director and art staff about entire content.
6. Create (modify) color samples matching art boards for each scene like evening, night, etc., deciding scene-by-scene character colors.
7. Also create coloring settings for scene-specific color direction (special coloring).
8. Do color direction for each cut (in-betweens, key animation) in the main episode.
9. Inspect finished coloring, hand over to photography.
10. Rush check of photography results. Issue retakes.
11. Handle retake cuts and continue rush checking. Attend almost to the end.
12. Completion, delivery, happily ever after (sometimes wrap parties).

Most works follow roughly this flow. Between these steps, meetings about individual cut processing and test work + checking for decisions repeat, gradually making various cuts concrete into screens.

Coo: Far From Home

work began moving seriously. Key animation gradually started coming up, in-between work, and cuts finally started going to finishing. Which meant soon we needed to do color direction and send to coloring, but for that we needed to create something first. Yes, creating settings for coloring work, the blueprint for coloring work - "color direction sheets."

Creating "colors" and "deciding colors" is important work, but creating these "color direction sheets" is also an important point in "color" work.

The cuts we color direct are painted by finishing coloring staff, but specifying paint numbers for every detail in actual cut artwork is impossible. It's time-consuming and becomes very hard to read. So for characters appearing in many cuts with setting artwork, we create coloring settings called "color direction sheets" in advance and give them to coloring staff to paint based on those. Creating these is also our job as color design and color direction staff.

Even today with digital coloring, we create this work as digital data. Since coloring work is done on computers, colors can be picked from color direction data with

tools and placed directly on screen - that's it. Moving images are completed with exactly the color direction data colors.

But during cel coloring back then, we instructed this only with paint color numbers on paper settings, and coloring staff would keep these settings in mind or constantly reference them while applying paint to cels.

How we created such coloring settings "color direction sheets."

First, prepare copies of character setting artwork. At Toei, most works had character masters drawn in B4 size, so we made color direction sheets in the same 100% copy B4 size.

We'd write paint numbers on these setting sheets, but depending on the setting, there might be parts not drawn from certain angles, or detail explanations in close-up sizes might be separated into different settings, often split across several sheets. If we made color direction sheets using original settings as-is, coloring one character would require checking 2-3 color direction sheets. That would be very inconvenient for colorists.

During coloring work, one hand holds a brush, the other a small paint bottle - both hands are basically always occupied, so flipping through color direction sheet pages in that situation is very troublesome. Usually they'd post current character color direction sheets around their coloring desk for reference while painting, but space for posting 2-3 sheets is limited, and needing to check 2-3 sheets is inherently troublesome - too much trouble increases accidents like painting mistakes.

So we considered making color direction sheets as readable as possible on one sheet.

We'd cut apart copies of multi-sheet settings, separating each drawn character and part. Then select angles and parts that fulfilled necessary information for color direction.

For human character settings, we typically needed: full body front, full body back, sometimes side view, close-up face, and close-up eyes.

We'd re-layout these to fit on B4 size. We'd use copy machine functions to reduce or enlarge parts as needed. This way, we'd recreate one sheet where you could understand that character's color overview at a glance.

Naturally, case-by-case, sometimes it's more readable not to force everything onto one sheet, so in such cases it's important to organize without forcing it too much.

We'd take clean copies of the cut-and-pasted re-layouts. Finally, we'd add paint numbers and painting division instructions.

■ Continued in Episode 94

(09.06.18)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 94: Once Upon a Time... (57) -

COO

How to Make Color Direction Sheets Part 2

This year Tokyo also seems to be having a "dry rainy season." Every morning, weather forecasts often predict "it's going to rain! it's going to rain!" but in reality it's often just "sprinkling" and "drizzling" before stopping.

It's "probability of precipitation."

For example, let's say the probability of precipitation for a certain time period on a certain day is 70%. When we hear 70%, our instinct is to interpret it as:

"A tremendous amount of rain will fall"

But actually, this number means:

"The probability that rain will fall in such weather conditions is 7 out of 10"

It's only about the probability of "whether it will rain or not." Whether it's a heavy downpour or just sprinkling, rain is rain. If rain falls at all, "the forecast was correct!"

Don't you think that's kind of unfair? What do you think? (laughs)

Now then.

Continuing how to make color direction sheets.

As I wrote last time, the base for color direction sheet settings was organized by cutting and pasting from animation setting sheets. We write paint numbers on this.

There are long-established "conventions for writing paint numbers" in the industry. Whether this was started by whoever made Japan's first color direction sheet, or came from overseas - I haven't researched it so I don't know the true origin, but the rule for expressing paint numbers in color direction sheets is "darker goes below."

Long ago, when I was working at a finishing production company, I was teaching a newcomer how to read color direction. After hearing my explanation, they said "Ah, so shadows become the 'denominator'?" which made me think "Oh, I see, exactly." It's just like fraction notation. The denominator is darker than the numerator.

Where and how to write numbers on color direction sheets:

First, draw lines from the parts you want to color direct to empty space outside the artwork. At the end of those lines, add paint number instructions. Write the "normal color" number, draw a line below it, and write the "shadow color" number below the

line. If there's a "second shadow" (shadow of the "shadow color," also called "two-level shadow"), draw another line below the "shadow color" and write the number. Incidentally, "highlight colors" are written diagonally above the "normal color" number with symbols like [Hi.].

Not just Toei Animation (■■■■) works, but other companies' works also generally used the same notation. This is actually important.

Finishing work often involves multiple finishing production companies working in parallel like a human wave, and finishing production companies themselves often handle multiple production companies' works simultaneously. For example, one finishing production company might be simultaneously working on Company A's Work A and Company B's Work B. If color direction sheets are made with unique notation methods for each work, workers can get confused. The result: silly mistakes occur → redo work.

To prevent this, notation specifications should follow the same rules. Many people in charge of color direction and color design were finishing company alumni (I was too), having experienced such struggles and problems firsthand. So they naturally converged toward "industry standard" color direction notation. Easy-to-read, mistake-resistant direction sheets became one theme.

These rules remain basically the same even with today's digital coloring.

■ Continued in Episode 95

(09.07.09)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 96: The Sea and Sky I Realized Through Solar Eclipse Broadcasting, and Once Upon a Time... (58) -

Coo: Far From Home

During the total solar eclipse on the 22nd, Tokyo's weather was completely overcast. I couldn't even see the partial eclipse with the naked eye. Unfortunately I was working, so I was glued to NHK General's eclipse broadcast on TV the whole time. Of course, digital terrestrial with HD LCD TV combination. Perfectly recorded on Blu-ray (laughs).

The southern islands in the eclipse path that had been talked about early on apparently had bad weather, and commercial stations seemed to suffer complete defeats. NHK, however, achieved complete victory with solid dual broadcasts from the eclipse observation ship in the Pacific and Iwo Jima!

While I'd been an astronomy boy since childhood, I actually wasn't deeply interested in eclipses, and even for this eclipse, I didn't go out for observations, having a casual attitude of "TV is fine."

But watching NHK's broadcast, I was completely hooked. Ah, I should have gone to see the eclipse (tears). Especially the observation ship tour in the Pacific.

NHK's broadcast footage was incredible! Well, the eclipse images themselves were still whatever (burst), but what was amazing was the surrounding scenery and landscape just before, during, and after totality.

The "moon's shadow" approached from the western horizon, gradually enveloping the surroundings. The sky, sea, and floating clouds that had been shining beautifully and vividly gradually lost their color, changing to gray with a hint of purple. In response, outside the shadow, near the horizon, the sky became tinged yellow to orange by the same principle as sunset, with clouds floating against that sky becoming silhouettes.

That footage was incredible.

Mystical or rather, the sheer scale of that scene was overwhelmingly massive. I watched TV with bated breath as the landscape changed moment by moment. I could only groan while watching TV. Since it was an eclipse broadcast, naturally they showed diamond rings, the pitch-black sun, corona, and prominences, but I was thinking "don't bother showing the sun during totality, keep showing the landscape!" (laughs).

Whether the observation ship or Iwo Jima, they were surrounded 360 degrees by ocean. I think that location made the footage even more spectacular.

Particularly the Iwo Jima broadcast had an NHK commentator with a microphone providing live commentary while immersed in the changing scenery, but he was so overwhelmed by the landscape that he was at a loss for words.

While I knew intellectually what it would be like inside the shadow during a total eclipse, ah, this is it. You really have to experience the real thing. Why didn't I apply? Well, applications closed a year in advance, so it would have been impossible anyway.

Total solar eclipses occur somewhere in the world almost every year. So with some (considerable) effort, it's not impossible to travel overseas to see eclipses. So in the not-too-distant future, I want to experience a total solar eclipse over the ocean. That's how deeply it moved me.

Now then.

Such southern sea landscapes.

Coo: Far From Home

. Of course, there was no eclipse in the story (laughs), but the beautiful scenery I saw in the broadcast was being painted by art director Yamamoto Nizo-san.

The

Coo: Far From Home

staff room was then located on the 3rd floor of the building facing the main entrance of Oizumi Studio, in what was called the "theatrical room."

Yamamoto-san had his desk in that room, steadily painting art boards and beautiful background paintings for the main production every day.

Having everyone including the director work in one place is the ideal setup. Having the director, animation director, and art director all together was a very reassuring environment. Well, that's how it should be originally, but it's hard to achieve. Now with digital dominance, art staff can work with just computers, but back then they painted normally with watercolors, needing paints, brushes, and numerous other supplies. Since they used water, they needed nearby water access too. So art staff mostly worked at their respective art studios except during meetings.

Both backgrounds and animation finishing gradually progressed, and cuts (in-betweens) for evening and night scenes started coming to color direction. When a certain number of cuts accumulated in my hands, I'd decide special scene colors while watching the situation with art boards for those scenes.

I created and decided various colors in sequence - not just daytime, but several evening colors for different time progressions, early morning colors, etc. And finally came the first half's climax: "night" scenes.

■ Continued in Episode 97

(09.07.24)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 97: Once Upon a Time... (59) -

COO

The Darkness of Southern Island Nights is...

It's August! August. Soon it'll be "late summer greetings," but how is everyone doing?

Thanks to everyone, I'm spending a summer so busy it brings tears to my eyes. Ah, I love work. Goodbye, summer days (sobbing).

My work this summer includes first the currently broadcasting

Ultimate!! Mecha-Mote Chairman

(■■■■ ■■■■■■■■■■) on TV Tokyo network. This one's tough. I'm constantly battling with all the fashionable elements appearing every week.

Several other TV works are in motion, but they're still secret. I can't write about them, sorry.

And theatrical works. The current big project is a pirate movie opening this winter - the theatrical

ONE PIECE

:

STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM

Advance tickets just went on sale recently, with various information being released.

This year is the commemorative 10th movie, so original creator Oda Eiichiro serves as executive producer. He wrote an original story and created a massive amount of character concepts. The staff working hard to turn these into even more wonderful visuals includes animation director and character designer Sato Masayuki, art director Waki Takeshi from Studio Green, art setting Sato Masahiro, color design by me, and directing all this staff is Chief Director Sakai Munehisa from the TV series.

Actually, Sakai-kun served as production manager on the movie

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that I'm rambling about in these "Color Design Notes." I'm making this exciting masterpiece with such a Sakai-kun. Please look forward to it!

Now then.

"Since they're attacking on a moonless night, wouldn't darkness be more atmospheric? So dark you can't see (laughs)," said I. This is about the climactic scene in the first half of

Coo: Far From Home

where special forces attack Yosuke and the others to kidnap Coo.

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has several night scenes. Since island scenes basically aimed for a "heartwarming" relaxed feeling, night scenes were also made quietly and peacefully, but from this "attack scene" onward we decided to aim for tension. My comment in that meeting was the above.

The darkest scene is around the infiltration from midnight jungle to Yosuke and the others' house. Then Cathy and Yosuke waiting inside the house. They successfully repel the attackers once. Around that area.

"Night" expression probably varies tremendously by work, but it's often made relatively bright. Why? Because if it's too pitch black, you can't tell what's happening on screen (laughs). So when creating so-called "night colors," we decide color tones considering such things along with brightness balance and screen atmosphere.

But in this case, I thought it might be better if it was unclear enough. Special forces are attacking under cover of darkness, and waiting Cathy and others would be in trouble if seen. I thought from the perspective and feelings of Yosuke and others holding their breath in that place, or the special force members, rather than us watching the screen. It was one attempt to somehow bring moviegoers into feeling like they're inside that screen.

Therefore, this "attack scene" became the darkest scene in the main story for both backgrounds and cels. The actual scene was short, and with night vision goggle green screens interspersed, the series of action performances were clearly understandable, and I calculated that with 35mm film screen depth, we could make it quite dark and be fine.

The scenes following this "attack scene" were the same. I created screens following the brightness and visibility from the perspective of Yosuke and others in that location.

The blinding brightness of combat helicopter lights. The dark figures of special forces trying to take Coo away against the gradually dawning subtle blue sky. In pre-dawn darkness, Tony's Cessna attacking from above is already in dawn brightness, with aerial combat there. Following that, Yosuke and the dolphins

pursuing the special forces boat are already in pre-sunrise brightness. And Blue's tragedy.

I think we created a good feeling for the rapid series of scenes riding on Yosuke and others' subjective perspective.

As a postscript, considerably after the release, when

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was broadcast on Nippon Television, this "attack scene" was beautifully pitch black (laughs). It really wasn't visible on TV.

■ Continued in Episode 98

(09.08.04)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 98: Once Upon a Time... (60) -

COO

The Warship Stage

After saying "Summer!" it's already passed the traditional Tanabata and even crossed "Beginning of Autumn."

Everyone, late summer greetings.

...But Tokyo this summer hasn't gotten as hot as expected. Cool summer trend? El Niño effects after all?

Still, this week is Obon, so it's the week when working adults across Japan simultaneously have their short summer vacation called "Obon break."

However, unfortunately, I have no break and am working straight through this week. Weekly broadcast TV work naturally won't wait, and theatrical work is also pushing toward editing at the end of this month and voice recording early next month, with everyone forgoing Obon break for work.

My enjoyment during this period is summer Koshien high school baseball broadcasts.

High school baseball cheering brass bands are amazing every year. Mixed with old popular songs like "Nerawareta Otoko" and "Southpaw," anime theme songs are doing quite well.

Triton of the Sea

,

Space Battleship Yamato

,

Lupin III

theme,

Gundam

too. How many years ago was

Triton

? About 30 years now? (laughs)

Old anime theme songs have clear themes, energy, and that "cheering" feeling. They're also not musically difficult and suited for brass bands.

Every year some high school uses them for cheering, passed down continuously. In music or anything, good things really do remain!

Now then.

Coo: Far From Home

- the story rushes toward the ending with rapid developments. Pursuing kidnapped Coo, the story moves to Tahiti, Papeete. From peaceful island scenes, the story shifts to the "city."

COO

, which we'd been carefully making in storyboard order from the beginning, took about a year to reach this point.

I think we were working on this area around spring 1993. Ah, since we visited the Maritime Self-Defense Force for research in late 1992, maybe a bit later? Around when Yamamoto Nizo-san's work was nearing completion, which is why I remember having a big drinking party.

Assistant director Hiroshima-san, production manager Sakai-kun, and I were taken by Nizo-san to get completely drunk in Oizumi, then drank more at Sayama City station, then tumbled into Nizo-san's studio "Eieisha" then in Sayama City, where the still-strong Nizo-san made us drink more beer (laughs). Though he was also totally drunk, in that condition he still pulled out Moriya Suji-san's art book or something to explain to us (laughs). ...Such memories too (laughs).

The next morning, still reeking of alcohol, I swayed home on the train. The scenery from that train showed beautifully blooming cherry blossoms - so spring, early April maybe? (laughs)

Recently it's rare to spend so much time making theatrical works, but this

COO

ultimately took about a year and a half of actual work. Initially, the production aimed for summer 1993 release, but later moved back six months to winter 1993, December release. Delayed release naturally stretched the schedule (laughs), finally completing in October I think.

So from this Papeete section to the ending's nuclear test prevention ~ parting with Coo took about half a year to create.

And the story from Papeete onward:

In crowded Papeete, underwear-like T-shirts & shorts with sandals wouldn't work. Tetsuro father and son appear in somewhat "city-appropriate" clothes (ultimately Tetsuro wore "slightly better shorts" (laughs)).

Yosuke boyishly wears T-shirt + shorts, but we decided to dress adult Tetsuro properly in a collared shirt. Cathy wears a white dress. While Yosuke was fine, Tetsuro, uncomfortable in his usual collar-less shirt, keeps fussing with his neckline. I dressed the tanned characters in whitish clothes to emphasize their tan. Locals mostly wear colored shirts. Incidentally, at the airport scene, the contrast with the group of young Japanese tourist women who just arrived, still with their untanned white skin, looked good.

Such white clothes only for Papeete. Soon they change into different outfits. The group pursues the warship holding Coo to Mangareva Island. From here, cruisers and warships become the stage, so the screen atmosphere becomes considerably harder.

The earlier location scouting and Maritime Self-Defense Force destroyer research proved very helpful. Having seen the real thing and having that sense within yourself makes all the difference. Director Imazawa's storyboards and Yamamoto-san's art properly created the stage. The high-density closed space, ship interior atmosphere naturally meant suppressing color tones and lowering brightness. The basic approach was the same as night interior island colors, but considering the enclosed space colors, screens including characters appeared somewhat harder.

Since performances here also had characters' expressions drawn with sharp distinctions, I think we successfully conveyed the tension of the warship setting throughout the screen.

For this warship, close-ups of interiors and deck were background paintings, but somewhat pulled-back shots and cuts showing the entire warship were all animation. However, even carefully painting cels and building up with special effects couldn't quite convey the warship's size. So what we did was have art staff retouch cel-painted work with paint brushes. So-called BOOK technique. There were quite a few, but precise animation + background texture successfully expressed the warship's size and coldness.

After somehow rescuing Coo from such warships, when humans fire at him, Coo separates from Yosuke and others, departing into the ocean. And Yosuke and others develop protest actions to prevent nuclear testing in waters where Coo's tribe is thought to live. The story heads toward its finale.

■ Continued in Episode 99

(09.08.11)

Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]

Episode 99: Once Upon a Time... (61) -

COO

And Into the Distance...

Just recently, cicadas were noisily crying even at night, but last night I suddenly noticed the cicada voices had disappeared and somehow changed to autumn insects' voices. Tokyo nights have become quite cool.

Still, daytime remains hot. On such a hot Sunday,

Ultimate!! Mecha-Mote Chairman

staff went on "fashionable location scouting" to Harajuku-Shibuya. Led by Director Kosaka, with producer, two character designers, art director and others - 9 people total wandering around. While I buy magazines regularly, actually going out to experience "live samples (laughs)" is important.

Right in the middle of summer clearance sales. Not "mecha-mote" but "mecha-komi (crowded) (tears)" - we energetically covered Takeshita Street, Shibuya 109, etc. Having women along definitely makes fashionable shops easier to enter (laughs). "109" would be absolutely impossible for me alone (laughs).

But the crowds were probably correct. While seeing shops and products was one purpose, most importantly, the customers gathering in those areas were the best samples. Some people were cool, others not, but both were exactly "live samples."

So I was staring quite intently at customers and shop staff. Shop staff usually wear their store's clothes, so their styling was also educational. When I made eye contact, I'd smile nicely (laughs). ←Ah, suspicious...

Oh my... (sweat).

Such "fashionable location scouting" needs to happen seasonally. When's next? Around late October maybe?

The sheer number of people was overwhelming though (laughs).

Now then.

Coo: Far From Home

production faced its second summer. This was 1993. Main episode work was mostly complete, with parallel retake work beginning. Release was officially decided for that winter, December. Delivery schedule decided for autumn. Finally the final phase.

On a certain day near summer's end, a terrible incident occurred. Kadokawa Haruki arrested! For narcotics violations among other charges - the very head of film production was arrested.

"What will happen? To

COO

?" An unpleasant feeling swirled among us production staff. "Surely not a release delay, right?"

While

COO

wasn't directly at fault, so it probably wouldn't come to that, still the rising mood and publicity felt dampened - or rather doused - leaving us very unsettled.

Come to think of it, the previous spring, we suddenly had a staff introduction for Kadokawa Haruki regarding

COO

, with us main staff gathered in Oizumi Studio's 3rd floor large conference room. Kadokawa Haruki appeared there. He had overwhelming presence, a powerful aura that brightened the room. He gave us staff an inspiring speech, and I was quite moved at the time.

Even in such circumstances, production continued.

I've forgotten exact dates by now, but once sound-related work finished, we decided to watch through everything once. The so-called "with sound" screening. While we issue detailed retakes as rushes come up, watching everything from start to finish sometimes reveals hidden retakes. So it's like final retake identification. We approached the "with sound" screening quite nervously.

No, we were more excited than nervous.

"What will those screens look like with dialogue and sound added?"

That day from morning, I was strangely high-energy.

Toei Animation Oizumi Studio's 3rd floor screening room gathered all staff, screening by reel (about 10+ minutes each) in order. Main episode about 2 hours. We were in the screening room about 4 hours total. While some screens still had retake work remaining, what had color throughout was mostly complete.

It was quite moving!

A 2-hour feature film was my first experience. About a year and a bit with various difficulties. The results were here. Ah, good. While the director and other staff

discussed various additional retakes, I was alone in a storm of emotion.

Then October. At Toei Chemical's Chofu screening room,

Coo: Far From Home

's first screening was held. I remember it was quite early morning. Sitting front row center (I always watch first screenings from this seat), I checked the first print. Secretly, several retakes remained with "oops" moments (laughs), but it was still magnificent. When I confirmed "Color Design: Tsujita Kunio" in the ending credits, my emotions swelled even larger. I felt a rush of having accomplished something.

Several days later, the completion premiere was held at Oizumi Toei Studios' screening room. Kadokawa Haruki couldn't attend (laughs), but original author Kageyama Tamio came.

After the screening, at the wrap party in the studio cafeteria, I actually got to talk with Kageyama-san! "Kageyama-san, when this

COO

was published, I properly bought and read the book, and being a huge fan of this story, for someone like me to be involved in this movie..." I was extremely excited (burst). Kageyama-san listened happily to my story. And then I realized:

"Ah! I should have gotten my first edition signed!"

A lifelong regret.

When I told Kageyama-san this, he said "Then send it to my office. I'll sign it (laughs)" and gave me his office business card. But I couldn't be so bold as to request a signature. That became another good memory.

Coo: Far From Home

had its nationwide release that winter. Unfortunately it didn't become a big hit and still hasn't become a DVD (laughs).

Even so, for me it was probably a work that became a huge treasure.

As a side note, among promotional goods distributed to staff during production was a memo pad, which I actually still treasure and use. Using it, or rather too precious to use (laughs). It's still firmly placed on my Oizumi Studio desk. Maybe it's like a good luck charm now? (laughs)

■ Continued in Episode 100

(09.08.25)

****Color Design Notes [Tsujita Kunio]****

##

Episode 9: Once Upon a Time... (7) The Forbidden "X" Paints

It's warm. It's spring.

Tokyo is already warm enough that the cherry blossoms seem ready to bloom. The cherry trees in Shakujii Park also seem to be showing a pinkish tint overall.

The problem is what clothes to wear.

During the day it's so warm that I actually spend time in studios wearing T-shirts, but temperatures still drop considerably after evening, so if you're not careful you'll catch cold (laughs). But once you've spent the day in a T-shirt, putting on another layer becomes bothersome (bitter laugh). Hmm.

Incidentally, I don't have hay fever, so I'm saved in that regard (laughs).

Well then.

Having joined Toei Doga, I inevitably had to deal with Stack color paints whether I liked it or not.

Toei Doga divided paints into three groups.

First, about 120 colors for regular TV works.

Next, about 70 special colors for theatrical works called

"X (Ekkusu) colors."

And about 70-plus special colors for American "collaborative works" called

"A colors"

(numbered like "A-1").

TV work basic colors had about 5 gradation levels for each color,

organized as a super-average, well-balanced chart that could be used for any work. I once heard that Toei Doga's art department decided this chart saying "Like this..." and Stack made paints according to it, but I'm not sure about that since I never confirmed it (laughs).

"X colors" were gradually added as needed when making theatrical works, since TV basic colors alone weren't sufficient.

Incidentally, several colors numbered "X-51" and above were exceptions - when we took over collaborative works that other companies had been handling, these

were colors formulated to match Taiyo Shikisai paints, so these exceptionally had compatibility with Taiyo colors. For example, "X-54" was like Taiyo Shikisai's "200G."

"A colors" were made to match model paints when color models (color sample cels) sent from America had colors not available in Toei's paints.

For example, "A-7" was

Spider-Man

's bodysuit color, something like that.

Back then, Toei Doga was constantly making several lines of TV series, but regardless of content direction, all works decided colors based on this basic TV color chart.

It certainly was a well-balanced color chart, but inevitably everything ended up with similar atmospheres. Since the basics were all vivid, strong colors, even things that should have been intermediate color schemes were forcibly assigned and arranged. "Bandai colors" was well said - all clear colors like those used for toys. For example, red (B-3), blue (CB-4), yellow (Y-3) were standard.

Ideally, rather than every work using the same color chart, we'd arrange usage colors according to each work's tendencies

- like making this work's chart heavy in earth colors, or preparing lots of blue color variations for this work.

Anyway, for TV works we could only use colors from this basic chart of about 120 colors.

But naturally, we wanted to use "X" and other paints too (laughs). However, using "X" or especially "A" would get you severely scolded by company superiors. Finishing productions would also complain.

Certainly, from work or color direction perspectives, using "X" at key points would definitely look better,

but that meant increasing the number of colors used for painting. Increasing paint colors meant finishing productions had to prepare those colors, costing extra materials. With finishing work unit costs that weren't high, there were harsh realities.

So for example, in character color decision meetings, spreading color sample cels and color chart sheets to decide things, directors and we color directors wanted to use "X" colors.

But we weren't allowed. If we could use this "X color" here, it would be perfect... such conflicts unfolded.

Toei Doga TV works back then included some categorized as "shadowless works," where even if animation had shadows, finishing didn't need to add shadows by agreement. With cel finishing, adding shadows meant painting required double work - shadow tracing, shadow painting - taking double time. But unit costs were naturally TV rates, burdening finishing productions. So by agreement, "shadowless was OK."

This continued even for *Sailor Moon*.

However, with the flow of time, more works requiring "shadows" even for TV anime increased.

Not just adding shadows to raise visual grade, but many characters arranged different colors in shadow colors from normal color gradations to create atmosphere when deciding character colors. In this context, "X colors" came to be used normally on TV.

Also, the shift of finishing work sites from domestic productions to overseas studios was significant.

##

■Continues to Episode 10

(07.03.06)